

English Skills with Readings

SEVENTH EDITION



JOHN LANGAN

Front Matter

[Praise for *English Skills with Readings*, 7th Edition and *English Skills*, 9th Edition](#)

[Readings Listed by Rhetorical Mode](#)

[To the Instructor](#)

[About the Author](#)

Praise for *English Skills with Readings*, 7th Edition and *English Skills*, 9th Edition

“I would describe English Skills with Readings as the ‘complete package.’ It is a text that will foster better student writing—one of the best texts for teaching English that I have seen in a long time!”

—Cedric Burden, Lawson State Community College

“English Skills with Readings captures the perfect balance of technique and practice, example and exercise, modeling and prompting. The student can digest and integrate the focused, essential principles of writing for clear, effective, and error-free written communication.”

—Spencer Belgarian, Fashion Institute of Design & Merchandising

“An excellent book for students who need plenty of practice in the basics of writing.”

—Su Senapati, Abraham Baldwin Agricultural College

“The best developmental writing text around.”

—Mib Garrard, Grayson County College

“Changing to this textbook is the single factor which has renewed my desire to teach this course.”

—Anneliese Homan, State Fair Community College

“There can be no legitimate comparison between John Langan’s McGraw-Hill developmental composition text series and any other texts available. Other texts are simply not as clear, precise, interesting, or comprehensive as English Skills.”

—Candace C. Mesa, Dixie College

“I love Langan’s tone and style—direct and not condescending.”

—Jeanne Grandchamp, Bristol Community College

“It is an outstanding text, good for discussion, individual work, or collaborative activities.”

—Patsy Krech, University of Memphis

Readings Listed by Rhetorical Mode

Note: Some selections are listed more than once because they illustrate more than one rhetorical method of development.

EXEMPLIFICATION

All the Good Things *Sister Helen Mrosla* [628](#)

Joe Davis: A Cool Man *Beth Johnson* [649](#)

What Good Families Are Doing Right *Delores Curran* [662](#)

Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name *James Lincoln Collier* [686](#)

“Extra Large,” Please *Diane Urbina* [718](#)

How They Get You to Do That *Janny Scott* [701](#)

Dealing with Feelings *Rudolph F. Verderber* [711](#)

Rudeness at the Movies *Bill Wine* [740](#)

The Most Hateful Words *Amy Tan* [726](#)

The Storyteller *H. H. Munro (“Saki”)* [732](#)

PROCESS

Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name *James Lincoln Collier* [686](#)

Let’s Really Reform Our Schools *Anita Garland* [693](#)

COMPARISON OR CONTRAST

Rowing the Bus *Paul Logan* [634](#)

Joe Davis: A Cool Man *Beth Johnson* [649](#)

The Fist, the Clay, and the Rock *Donald Holland* [657](#)

“Extra Large,” Please *Diane Urbina* [718](#)

The Most Hateful Words *Amy Tan* [726](#)

xii

DEFINITION

xiii

What Good Families Are Doing Right *Delores Curran* [662](#)

Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name *James Lincoln Collier* [686](#)

The Storyteller *H. H. Munro (“Saki”)* [732](#)

The Fist, the Clay, and the Rock *Donald Holland* [657](#)

DIVISION-CLASSIFICATION

Dealing with Feelings *Rudolph F. Verderber* 711

The Fist, the Clay, and the Rock *Donald Holland* [657](#)

DESCRIPTION

Rowing the Bus *Paul Logan* [634](#)

Joe Davis: A Cool Man *Beth Johnson* [649](#)

Rudeness at the Movies *Bill Wine* [740](#)

From Father to Son, Last Words to Live by *Dana Canedy* [747](#)

CAUSE AND EFFECT

The Scholarship Jacket *Marta Salinas* [642](#)

Joe Davis: A Cool Man *Beth Johnson* [649](#)

“Extra Large,” Please *Diane Urbina* [718](#)

Do It Better! *Ben Carson, M.D., with Cecil Murphey* [676](#)

Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name *James Lincoln Collier* [686](#)

Let’s Really Reform Our Schools *Anita Garland* [693](#)

How They Get You to Do That *Janny Scott* [701](#)

Dealing with Feelings *Rudolph F. Verderber* [711](#)

The Most Hateful Words *Amy Tan* [726](#)

Rudeness at the Movies *Bill Wine* [740](#)

A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath *Theresa Conroy and Christine M. Johnson* [753](#)

xiii

xiv

NARRATION

All the Good Things *Sister Helen Mroska* [628](#)

Rowing the Bus *Paul Logan* [634](#)

The Scholarship Jacket *Marta Salinas* [642](#)

From Father to Son, Last Words to Live by *Dana Canedy* [747](#)

Do It Better! *Ben Carson, M.D., with Cecil Murphey* [676](#)

The Most Hateful Words *Amy Tan* [726](#)

The Storyteller *H. H. Munro (“Saki”)* [732](#)

A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath *Theresa Conroy and Christine M. Johnson* [753](#)

ARGUMENT

The Scholarship Jacket *Marta Salinas* [642](#)

Joe Davis: A Cool Man *Beth Johnson* [649](#)

Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name *James Lincoln Collier* [686](#)

Let’s Really Reform Our Schools *Anita Garland* [693](#)

Rudeness at the Movies *Bill Wine* [740](#)

“Extra Large,” Please *Diane Urbina* [718](#)

To the Instructor

Key Features of the Book

English Skills with Readings will help students learn and apply the basic principles of effective composition. It will also help them master essential reading skills. It is a nuts-and-bolts book based on a number of assumptions or beliefs about the writing process:

- ***First of all, English Skills with Readings assumes that four principles in particular are keys to effective writing: unity, support, coherence, and sentence skills.*** These four principles are highlighted on the inside back cover and reinforced throughout the book.
 - Part One focuses on the first three principles and to some extent on sentence skills; Part Five serves as a concise handbook of sentence skills.
 - The four principles are applied in different types of paragraph development (Part Two) and in several-paragraph essays (Part Three).
 - Part Four discusses research skills.
 - Part Six presents seventeen reading selections.

The ongoing success of *English Skills with Readings* is evidence that the four principles are easily grasped, remembered, and followed by students.

- ***The book also reflects a belief that, in addition to these four principles, there are other important factors in writing effectively.*** The second chapter discusses *prewriting, rewriting, and editing*. Besides encouraging students to see *writing as a process*, the chapter asks students to examine their *attitude toward writing*, to *write on what they know* about or can learn about, to consider keeping a *writing journal*, and to make *outlining* a part of the writing process.
 - ***English Skills with Readings assumes that the best way to begin writing is with personal experience.*** After students have learned to support a point by providing material from their own experience, they are ready to develop an idea by drawing on their own reasoning abilities and on information in reports, articles, and books. In Parts Two and Three, students are asked to write on *both experiential and objective topics*.
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xv

xvi

- ***The book also assumes that beginning writers are more likely to learn composition skills through lively, engaging, and realistic models than through materials remote from the common experiences that are part of everyday life.*** For example, when a writer argues that proms should be banned, or catalogs ways to harass an instructor, or talks about why some teenagers take drugs, students will be more apt to remember and follow the writing principles that are involved.
- ***A related assumption is that students are especially interested in and challenged by the writing of their peers.*** After reading vigorous papers composed by other students and understanding the power

that good writing can have, students will be more encouraged to aim for similar honesty, realism, and detail in their own work.

- ***Another premise of English Skills with Readings is that mastery of the paragraph should precede work on the several-paragraph essay.*** Thus Part One illustrates the basic principles of composition writing using paragraph models, and the assignments in Part Two aim at developing the ability to support ideas within a variety of paragraph forms. The essential principles of paragraph writing are then applied to the several-paragraph essays in Part Three.
- ***The grammar, punctuation, and usage skills that make up Part Five are explained clearly and directly, without unnecessary technical terms.*** Here, as elsewhere, *abundant exercise material* is provided, especially for the mistakes that are most likely to interfere with clear communication.
- ***A final assumption is that, since no two people will use an English text in exactly the same way, the material should be organized in a highly accessible manner.*** Because each of the six parts of the book deals with a distinct area of writing, instructors can turn quickly and easily to the skills they want to present. At the same time, ideas for sequencing material are provided in a section titled “Using This Text” at the end of [Chapter 1](#). And a detailed syllabus is provided in the Instructor’s Manual.

I am very grateful for the ongoing popularity of *English Skills with Readings*. Instructors continue to say that the four bases really do help students learn to write effectively. And they continue to comment that students find the activities, assignments, model passages, and reading selections especially interesting and worthwhile.

xvi

xvii

The Readings

- The seventeen selections in Part Six have been chosen for their content as much as for rhetorical mode. They are organized thematically into three groups: “Goals and Values,” “Education and Self-Improvement,” and “Human Groups and Society.” Some selections reflect important contemporary concerns: for instance, “Let’s Really Reform Our Schools,” “‘Extra Large,’ Please,” and “What Good Families Are Doing Right.” Some provide information many students may find helpful: examples are “Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name,” “How They Get You to Do That,” and “Dealing with Feelings.” Some recount profoundly human experiences: “All the Good Things,” “From Father to Son, Last Words to Live by,” “Joe Davis: A Cool Man,” and “A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath.” (A list on [pages xii–xiv](#) presents the readings by rhetorical mode.)
- Each reading begins with a preview that supplies background information where needed and stimulates interest in the piece.
- The ten reading comprehension questions that follow each selection give students practice in five key skills: understanding vocabulary in context, summarizing (by choosing an alternative title), determining the main idea, recognizing key supporting details, and making inferences. Reading educators agree that these are among the most crucial comprehension skills. A special chart in [Appendix A](#) enables students to track their progress as they practice these skills.

- Discussion questions following the reading comprehension questions deal with matters of content as well as aspects of structure, style, and tone. Through the questions on structure in particular, students will see that professional authors practice some of the same basic composing techniques (such as the use of transitions and emphatic order to achieve coherence) that they have been asked to practice in their own writing.
- Finally, two paragraph writing assignments and one essay writing assignment follow the discussion questions. The assignments range from personal narratives to expository and persuasive essays about issues in the world at large. Many assignments provide guidelines on how to proceed, including sample topic sentences or thesis statements and appropriate methods of development. In addition, five of the selections feature a fourth writing assignment requiring some simple online research.

When assigning a selection, instructors may find it helpful to ask students to read the preview as well as to answer the reading comprehension and discussion questions that follow the selection. Answers can then be gone over quickly in class. Through these activities, a writing instructor can contribute to the improvement of students' reading skills.

xvii

Changes in the Seventh Edition

xviii

Here is a list of what is new in the seventh edition of *English Skills with Readings*:

- *Among several changes in this seventh edition is its new, more contemporary design.* The enhanced four-color design adds visual appeal for students while highlighting key material for them and helping them make connections and find the information they need.
- *More than seventy images have been added throughout the text.* Because today's students respond so readily to visual images, and must learn to evaluate such images critically, this edition features more than seventy new images, each chosen and used for a pedagogical purpose.
 - ✍ Every part now opens with an image (or images) accompanied by a writing prompt that introduces students to the lessons that section of the text will cover.
 - ✍ Every chapter in Parts One through Four opens with a compelling visual or visuals, all of which are accompanied by a writing prompt related to the particular chapter. In addition, every section in Part Five features a visual opener with accompanying writing prompt.
 - ✍ Part Six, "Readings for Writers," now includes writing prompts for featured images, which are linked thematically to the readings.
- *Research coverage has been expanded.* The new edition returns to previous editions' tradition of extensive research coverage. The former [Chapter 19](#), "A Quick Guide to Research," has been replaced with two new chapters: [Chapter 19](#), "Using the Library and the Internet" and [Chapter 20](#), "Writing a Research Paper."
- *Key features have been added to make the book easier to use for instructors and students.*

- ✍ Every part and chapter now opens with an outline of its contents, preparing students for the lessons to follow.
- ✍ Practice exercises and activities are now numbered consecutively in each chapter, allowing students to quickly find the activities they need to complete.
- ✍ Tip, Hint, and Explanation Boxes throughout the text offer advice about grammar rules, hints for students on how to complete selected activities, and explanations of why the answers to sample activities are correct.
- ✍ Technology icons have been simplified to include just one easily recognizable icon directing students to the Online Learning Center, where they can find expanded coverage of a particular topic or hone their skills through completing additional exercises.



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xviii

xix

- ✍ A new Collaborative Learning icon highlights all student activities that can be assigned as collaborative activities, either in or outside of class.
- ✍ Teaching Tips are available in the margins throughout the *Annotated Instructor's Edition*.
- ✍ ESL Tips, which offer specific advice for instructing multilingual writers, are also featured in the margins of the *Annotated Instructor's Edition*.
- *New checklists reinforce the importance of the four bases during revision.* Every chapter in Part Two, “Paragraph Development,” now features a specialized checklist of the four bases that students can use when revising paragraphs written in the different patterns of development. Each checklist is tailored to the particular pattern of writing the students are working on in that chapter.
- *The book features three new reading selections in Part Six, “Readings for Writers.”* Chosen for their appeal and relevance to today’s students, these new essays address the growing number of American children who are dangerously overweight; an American soldier in Iraq who prepared his newborn son for life without him; and one teacher’s lesson on becoming strong and resilient learners.
- *A new appendix, “A Writer’s Journal,”* has been added to encourage students to keep a writing journal and to give them room to start recording ideas.



Learning Aids Accompanying the Book

Supplements for Instructors



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- An *Annotated Instructor's Edition* (ISBN 0-07-335014-1) consists of the student text complete with answers to all activities and tests, followed by an Instructor's Guide featuring teaching suggestions and a model syllabus.
- An *Online Learning Center* (www.mhhe.com/langan) offers a host of instructional aids and additional resources for instructors, including a comprehensive computerized test bank, the downloadable *Instructor's Manual and Test Bank*, online resources for writing instructors, and more.
- *The McGraw-Hill Virtual Workbook* offers interactive activities and exercises that reinforce the skills students learn in Part Five of *English Skills with Readings*. Authored by Donna Matsumoto, Leeward Community College, and powered by Quia, each interactive, Web-based activity corresponds to a key section or chapter in Part Five, giving students additional opportunities for practice in grammar, punctuation, and mechanics. This online workbook is supported by a powerful array of Web-based instructor's tools, including an automated online grade book.
- The *Classroom Performance System* (CPS by eInstruction) is an easy-to-use, wireless response system that allows instructors to conduct quizzes and polls in class and provide students with immediate feedback. McGraw-Hill provides a database of questions compatible with *English Skills* and *English Skills with Readings*. To download the database, go to the *English Skills* OLC at www.mhhe.com/langan. For further details on CPS, go to www.mhhe.com/einstruction.
- *PageOut!* helps instructors create graphically pleasing and professional Web pages for their courses, in addition to providing classroom management, collaborative learning, and content management tools. *PageOut!* is **FREE** to adopters of McGraw-Hill textbooks and learning materials. Learn more at www.mhhe.com/pageout.
- Partners in Teaching is an online community of composition and basic writing instructors. Two associated listservs, Teaching Composition and Teaching Basic Writing, address issues of pedagogy in theory and in practice. Their goal is to bring together senior members of the college composition community with newer members—junior faculty and teaching assistants—as well as adjuncts. Each month, major figures in the fields of composition and basic writing take turns leading discussions on issues of importance to people in the profession.
- We enthusiastically invite you to submit your own ideas for topics and potential contributions to these listservs. Please check out Teaching Composition at www.mhhe.com/tcomp and Teaching Basic Writing at www.mhhe.com/tbw and join the discussion.

xix

xx

Supplements for Students



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- An *Online Learning Center* (www.mhhe.com/langan) offers a host of instructional aids and additional resources for students, including self-correcting exercises, writing activities for additional practice, guides to doing research on the Internet and avoiding plagiarism, useful Web links, and more. The site is powered by Catalyst, McGraw-Hill's innovative writing and research resource.
- *The McGraw-Hill Virtual Workbook* offers interactive activities and exercises that reinforce the skills students learn in Part Five of *English Skills with Readings*. Authored by Donna Matsumoto, Leeward Community College, and powered by Quia, each interactive, Web-based activity corresponds to a key section or chapter in Part Five, giving students additional opportunities for practice in grammar, punctuation, and mechanics.

xx

Dictionary and Vocabulary Resources

xxi

- *Random House Webster's College Dictionary* (0-07-240011-0): This authoritative dictionary includes over 160,000 entries and 175,000 definitions. The most commonly used definitions are always listed first, so students can find what they need quickly.
- *The Merriam-Webster's Dictionary* (0-07-310057-9), based on the best-selling Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary, contains over 70,000 definitions.
- *The Merriam-Webster's Thesaurus* (0-07-310067-6): This handy paperback thesaurus contains over 157,000 synonyms, antonyms, related and contrasted words, and idioms.
- *Merriam-Webster's Vocabulary Builder* (0-07-310069-2) introduces 3,000 words and includes quizzes to test progress.
- *Merriam-Webster's Notebook Dictionary* (0-07-299091-0): An extremely concise reference to the words that form the core of the English vocabulary, this popular dictionary, conveniently designed for three-ring binders, provides words and information at students' fingertips.
- *Merriam-Webster's Notebook Thesaurus* (0-07-310068-4) is designed for three-ring binders and helps students search for words they might need today. It provides concise, clear guidance for over 157,000 word choices.
- *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary and Thesaurus, Electronic Edition* (0-07-310070-6): Available on CD-ROM, this online dictionary contains thousands of new words and meanings from all areas of human endeavor, including electronic technology, the sciences, and popular culture.

You can contact your local McGraw-Hill representative or consult McGraw-Hill’s Web site at www.mhhe.com/english for more information on the supplements that accompany *English Skills with Readings, 7th Edition*.

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xxi

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xxii

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Joyce Stern, Assistant Professor at Nassau Community College, contributed the ESL Tips to the *Annotated Instructor's Edition* of *English Skills with Readings*. Professor Stern is also Assistant to the Chair in the Department of Reading and Basic Education. An educator for over thirty years, she holds an advanced degree in TESOL from Hunter College, as well as a New York State Teaching Certificate in TESOL. She is currently coordinating the design, implementation, and recruitment of learning communities for both ESL and developmental students at Nassau Community College and has been recognized by the college's Center for Students with Disabilities for her dedication to student learning.

Donna T. Matsumoto, Assistant Professor of English and the Writing Discipline Coordinator at Leeward Community College in Hawaii (Pearl City), wrote the Teaching Tips for the *Annotated Instructor's Edition* of *English Skills with Readings*. Professor Matsumoto has taught writing, women's studies, and American studies for a number of years through the University of Hawaii system, at Hawaii Pacific University, and in community schools for adults. She received a 2005 WebCT Exemplary Course Project award for her online writing course and is the author of McGraw-Hill's *The Virtual Workbook*, an online workbook featuring interactive activities and exercises.

John Langan

About the Author



John Langan has taught reading and writing at Atlantic Cape Community College near Atlantic City, New Jersey, for more than twenty-five years. The author of a popular series of college textbooks on both writing and reading, John enjoys the challenge of developing materials that teach skills in an especially clear and lively way. Before teaching, he earned advanced degrees in writing at Rutgers University and in reading at Rowan University. He also spent a year writing fiction that, he says, “is now at the back of a drawer waiting to be discovered and acclaimed posthumously.” While in school, he supported himself by working as a truck driver, a machinist, a battery assembler, a hospital attendant, and an apple packer. John now lives with his wife, Judith Nadell, near Philadelphia. In addition to his wife and Philly sports teams, his passions include reading and turning on nonreaders to the pleasure and power of books. Through Townsend Press, his educational publishing company, he has developed the nonprofit “Townsend Library”—a collection of more than fifty new and classic stories that appeal to readers of any age.

PART 1: Basic Principles of Effective Writing

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College offers many different challenges for students. In order to be a successful student, it can be helpful to know your individual strengths and weaknesses. Take a few minutes to think about your strengths and weaknesses as a student. How can you use this information to be a better student?

[1: An Introduction to Writing](#)

[2: The Writing Process](#)

[3: The First and Second Steps in Writing](#)

[4: The Third Step in Writing](#)

[5: The Fourth Step in Writing](#)

[6: Four Bases for Revising Writing](#)

1: An Introduction to Writing



Though some of us may stumble upon the job of our dreams, many of us have also had a job that seemed more like a nightmare. In this chapter you will read a student's paragraph about his worst job. Think about the best or worst job you have ever had. Later in the chapter you will be asked to write a paragraph of your own on this topic.

This chapter will

- introduce you to the basic principles of effective writing
- ask you to write a simple paragraph
- present writing as both a skill and a process of discovery
- suggest keeping a journal
- suggest a sequence for using this book

4

This book grows out of experiences I had when learning how to write. My early memories of writing in school are not pleasant. In middle school, I remember getting back paper after paper on which the only comment was “Handwriting very poor.” In high school, the night before a book report was due, I would work anxiously at a card table in my bedroom. I was nervous and sweaty because I felt out of my element, like a person who knows only how to open a can of soup being asked to cook a five-course meal. The act of writing was hard enough, and my feeling that I wasn’t any good at it made me hate the process all the more.

5

Luckily, in college I had an instructor who changed my negative attitude about writing. During my first semester in composition, I realized that my instructor repeatedly asked two questions about any paper I wrote: “What is your point?” and “What is your support for that point?” I learned that sound writing consists basically of making a point and then providing evidence to support or develop that point. As I understood, practiced, and mastered these and other principles, I began to write effective papers. By the end of the semester, much of my uneasiness and bad feelings about writing had disappeared. I knew that competent writing is a skill that I or anyone can learn with practice. It is a nuts-and-bolts process consisting of a number of principles and techniques that can be studied and mastered. Further, I learned that while there is no alternative to the work required for competent writing, there is satisfaction to be gained through such work. I no longer feared or hated writing, for I knew I could work at it and be good at it.

English Skills explains in a clear and direct way the four basic principles you must learn to write effectively:

1. Start with a clearly stated point.
2. Provide logical, detailed support for your point.
3. Organize and connect your supporting material.
4. Revise and edit so that your sentences are effective and error-free.

Part One of this book explains each of these steps in detail and provides many practice materials to help you master them.

Understanding Point and Support

An Important Difference between Writing and Talking

In everyday conversation, you make all kinds of points, or assertions. You say, for example, “I hate my job”; “Sue’s a really generous person”; or “That exam was unfair.” The points that you make concern such personal matters as well as, at times, larger issues: “A lot of doctors are arrogant”; “The death penalty should exist for certain crimes”; “Tobacco and marijuana are equally dangerous.”

5

The people you are talking with do not always challenge you to give reasons for your statements. They may know why you feel as you do, or they may already agree with you, or they simply may not want to put you on the spot; and so they do not always ask “Why?” But the people who *read* what you write may not know you, agree with you, or feel in any way obliged to you. If you want to communicate effectively with readers, you must provide solid evidence for any point you make. An important difference, then, between writing and talking is this: *In writing, any idea that you advance must be supported with specific reasons or details.*

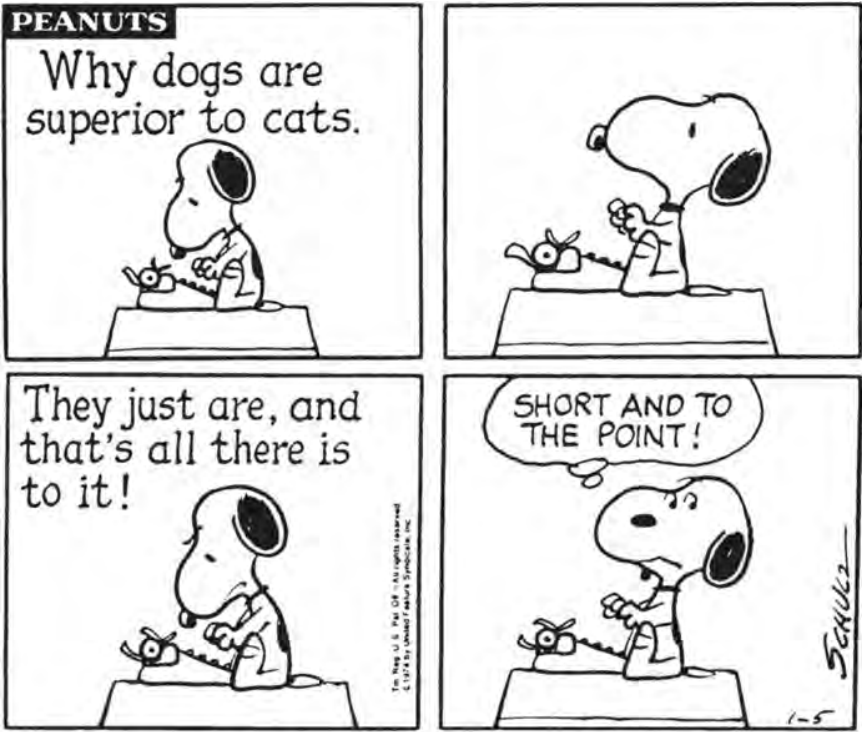
6

Think of your readers as reasonable people. They will not take your views on faith, but they *are* willing to consider what you say as long as you support it. There fore, remember to support with specific evidence any statement that you make.

Point and Support in Two Cartoons

The following two *Peanuts* cartoons will show you quickly and clearly what you need to write effectively. You need to know how to (1) make a point and (2) support the point.

Look for a moment at the following cartoon:



Peanuts © United Feature Syndicate, Inc.

See if you can answer the following questions:

- What is Snoopy’s point in his paper?

Your answer: His point is that_____

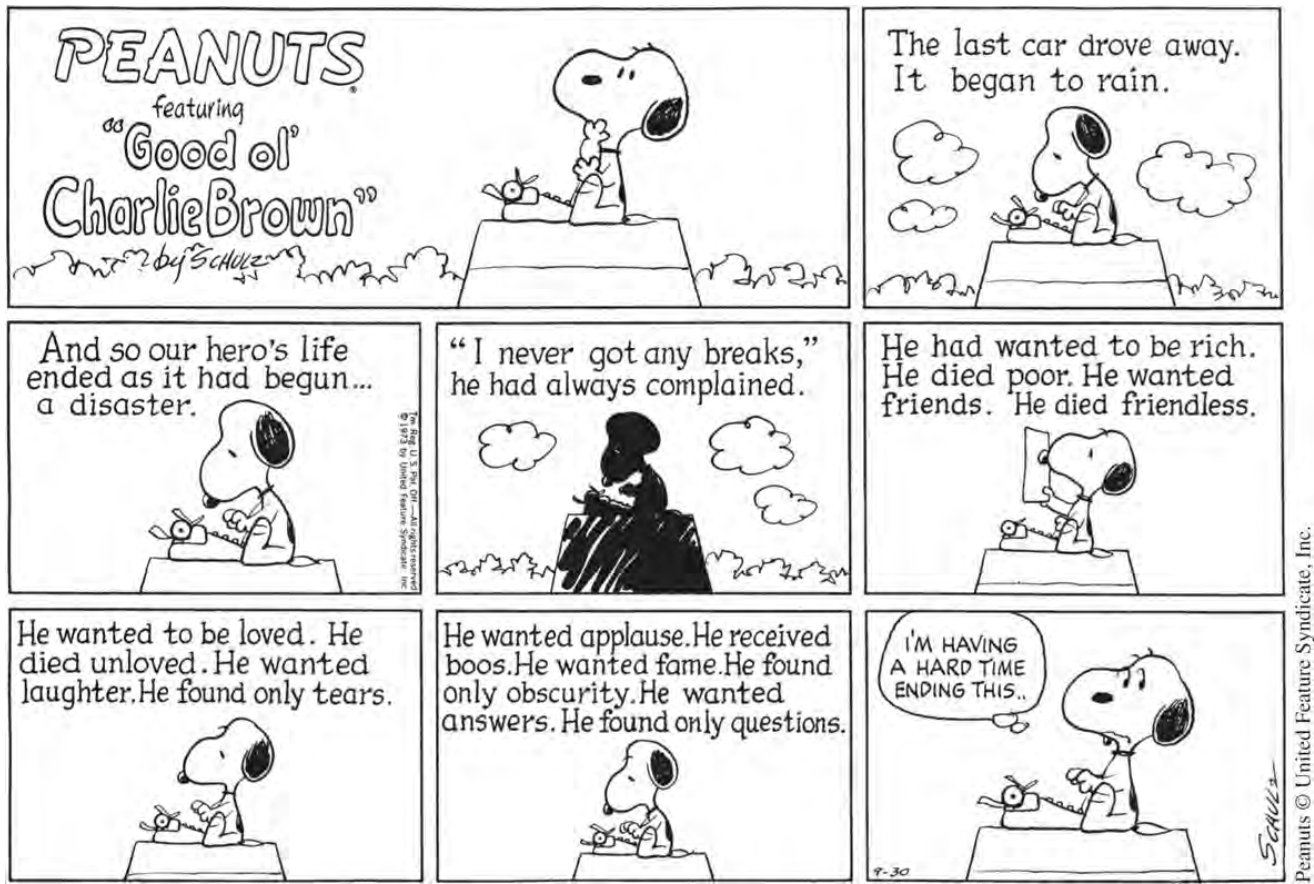
- What is his support for his point?

Your answer:_____

6
7

Snoopy’s point, of course, is that dogs are superior to cats. But he offers no support whatsoever to back up his point. There are two jokes here. First, he is a dog, so he is naturally going to believe that dogs are superior. The other joke is that his evidence (“They just are, and that’s all there is to it!”) is no more than empty words. His somewhat guilty look in the last panel suggests that he knows he has not proved his point. To write effectively, you must provide *real* support for your points and opinions.

Now look at this other cartoon about Snoopy as a writer.



See if you can answer the following questions:

- What is Snoopy’s point about the hero in his writing?

Your answer: His point is that_____

- What is his support for his point?

Your answer: _____

Snoopy’s point is that the hero’s life has been a disaster. This time, Snoopy has an abundance of support for his point: the hapless hero never had any luck, money, friends, love, laughter, applause, fame, or answers. 7
But the flaw in Snoopy’s composition is that he does not use enough supporting *details* to really prove his 8
point. Instead, he plays the opposites game with his support (“He wanted to be loved. He died unloved.”)
As readers, we wonder who the hero wanted to be loved by: his mother? a heroine? a beagle? To
sympathize with the hero and understand the nature of his disastrous life, we need more specifics. In the
final panel of the cartoon, Snoopy has that guilty expression again. Why might he have a hard time ending
this paragraph?

Point and Support in a Paragraph



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Suppose you and a friend are talking about jobs you have had. You might say about a particular job, “That was the worst one I ever had. A lot of hard work and not much money.” For your friend, that might be enough to make your point, and you would not really have to explain your statement. But in writing, your point would have to be backed up with specific reasons and details.

Below is a paragraph, written by a student named Gene Hert, about his worst job. A *paragraph* is a short paper of 150 to 200 words. It usually consists of an opening point called a *topic sentence* followed by a series of sentences supporting that point.

My Job in an Apple Plant

Working in an apple plant was the worst job I ever had. First of all, the work was physically hard. For ten hours a night, I took cartons that rolled down a metal track and stacked them onto wooden skids in a tractor trailer. Each carton contained twenty-five pounds of bottled apple juice, and they came down the track almost nonstop. The second bad feature of the job was the pay. I was getting the minimum wage at that time, \$3.65 an hour, plus a quarter extra for working the night shift. I had to work over sixty hours a week to get decent take-home pay. Finally, I hated the working conditions. We were limited to two ten-minute breaks and an unpaid half hour for lunch. Most of my time was spent outside on the loading dock in near-zero-degree temperatures. I was very lonely on the job because I had no interests in common with the other truck loaders. I felt this isolation especially when the production line shut down for the night, and I spent two hours by myself cleaning the apple vats. The vats were an ugly place to be on a cold morning, and the job was a bitter one to have.

Notice what the details in this paragraph do. They provide you, the reader, with a basis for understanding *why* the writer makes the point that is made. Through this specific evidence, the writer has explained and successfully communicated the idea that this job was his worst one.

8
9

The evidence that supports the point in a paragraph often consists of a series of reasons followed by examples and details that support the reasons. That is true of the paragraph above: three reasons are provided, with examples and details that back up those reasons. Supporting evidence in a paper can also consist of anecdotes, personal experiences, facts, studies, statistics, and the opinions of experts.

Activity 1

The paragraph on the apple plant, like almost any piece of effective writing, has two essential parts: (1) a point is advanced, and (2) that point is then supported. Taking a minute to outline the paragraph will help you understand these basic parts clearly. Add the words needed to complete the outline.

Point: Working in an apple plant is the worst job I ever had.

Reason 1: _____

- a. Loaded cartons onto skids for ten hours a night
- b. _____

Reason 2: _____

- a. _____
- b. Had to work sixty hours for decent take-home pay

Reason 3: _____

- a. Two ten-minute breaks and an unpaid lunch
- b. _____
- c. Loneliness on job
 - (1) No interests in common with other workers
 - (2) By myself for two hours cleaning the apple vats

Activity 2

See if you can complete the statements below.

- 1. An important difference between writing and talking is that in writing we absolutely must _____ any statement we make.

2. A _____ is made up of a point and a collection of specifics that support the point.

Activity 3

An excellent way to get a feel for the paragraph is to write one. Your instructor may ask you to do that now. The only guidelines you need to follow are the ones described here. There is an advantage to writing a paragraph right away, at a point where you have had almost no instruction. This first paragraph will give a quick sense of your needs as a writer and will provide a baseline—a standard of comparison that you and your instructor can use to measure your writing progress during the semester.

Here, then, is your topic: Write a paragraph on the best or worst job you have ever had. Provide three reasons why your job was the best or the worst, and give plenty of details to develop each of your three reasons.

Notice that the sample paragraph, “My Job in an Apple Plant,” has the same format your paragraph should have. You should do what this author has done:

- State a point in the first sentence.
- Give three reasons to support the point.
- Introduce each reason clearly with signal words (such as *First of all*, *Second*, and *Finally*).
- Provide details that develop each of the three reasons.

Write your paragraph on a separate sheet of paper. After completing the paragraph, hand it in to your instructor.

Benefits of Paragraph Writing

Paragraph writing offers at least three benefits. First of all, mastering the structure of the paragraph will help make you a better writer. For other courses, you’ll often do writing that will be variations on the paragraph form—for example, exam answers, summaries, response papers, and brief reports. In addition, paragraphs serve as the basic building blocks of essays, the most common form of writing in college. The basic structure of the traditional paragraph, with its emphasis on a clear point and well-organized, logical support, will help you write effective essays and almost every kind of paper that you will have to do.

Second, the discipline of writing a paragraph will strengthen your skills as a reader and listener. You’ll become more critically aware of other writers’ and speakers’ ideas and the evidence they provide—or fail to provide—to support those ideas.

Most important, paragraph writing will make you a stronger thinker. Writing a solidly reasoned paragraph requires mental discipline and close attention to a set of logical rules. Creating a paragraph in which there is an overall topic sentence supported by well-reasoned, convincing evidence is more challenging than writing a free-form or expressive paper. Such a paragraph obliges you to carefully sort out, think through, and organize

your ideas. You'll learn to discover and express just what your ideas are and to develop those ideas in a sound and logical way. Traditional paragraph writing, in short, will train your mind to think clearly, and that ability will prove to be of value in every phase of your life.

10
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Writing as a Skill

A sure way to wreck your chances of learning how to write competently is to believe that writing is a “natural gift” rather than a learned skill. People with such an attitude think that they are the only ones for whom writing is unbearably difficult. They feel that everyone else finds writing easy or at least tolerable. Such people typically say, “I’m not any good at writing” or “English was not one of my good subjects.” They imply that they simply do not have a talent for writing, while others do. The result of this attitude is that people try to avoid writing, and when they do write, they don’t try their best. Their attitude becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy: Their writing fails chiefly because they have brainwashed themselves into thinking that they don’t have the “natural talent” needed to write. Unless their attitude changes, they probably will not learn how to write effectively.

A realistic attitude about writing must build on the idea that *writing is a skill*. It is a skill like driving, typing, or cooking, and like any skill, it can be learned. If you have the determination to learn, this book will give you the extensive practice needed to develop your writing skills.

Many people find it difficult to do the intense, active thinking that clear writing demands. (Perhaps television has made us all so passive that the active thinking necessary in both writing and reading now seems harder than ever.) It is frightening to sit down before a blank sheet of paper or a computer screen and know that an hour later, nothing on it may be worth keeping. It is frustrating to discover how much of a challenge it is to transfer thoughts and feelings from one’s head into words. It is upsetting to find that an apparently simple writing subject often turns out to be complicated. But writing is not an automatic process: we will not get something for nothing—and we should not expect to. For almost everyone, competent writing comes from plain hard work—from determination, sweat, and head-on battle. The good news is that the skill of writing can be mastered, and if you are ready to work, you will learn what you need to know.

Activity 4

To get a sense of just how you regard writing, read the following statements. Put a check (✓) beside those statements with which you agree. This activity is not a test, so try to be as honest as possible.

- _____ 1. A good writer should be able to sit down and write a paper straight through without stopping.
- _____ 2. Writing is a skill that anyone can learn with practice.
- _____ 3. I’ll never be good at writing because I make too many mistakes in spelling, grammar, and punctuation.
- _____ 4. Because I dislike writing, I always start a paper at the last possible minute.
- _____ 5. I’ve always done poorly in English, and I don’t expect that to change.

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12

Now read the following comments about the five statements. The comments will help you see if your attitude is hurting or helping your efforts to become a better writer.

Comments

- Statement 1: *“A good writer should be able to sit down and write a paper straight through without stopping.”*

Statement 1 is not true. Writing is, in fact, a process. It is done not in one easy step but in a series of steps, and seldom at one sitting. If you cannot do a paper all at once, that simply means you are like most of the other people on the planet. It is harmful to carry around the false idea that writing should be easy.

- Statement 2: *“Writing is a skill that anyone can learn with practice.”*

Statement 2 is absolutely true. Writing is a skill, like driving or word processing, that you can master with hard work. If you want to learn to write, you can. It is as simple as that. If you believe this, you are ready to learn how to become a competent writer.

Some people hold the false belief that writing is a natural gift, which some have and others do not. Because of this belief, they never make a truly honest effort to learn to write—and so they never learn.

- Statement 3: *“I’ll never be good at writing because I make too many mistakes in spelling, grammar, and punctuation.”*

The first concern in good writing should be content—what you have to say. Your ideas and feelings are what matter most. You should not worry about spelling, grammar, or punctuation while working on content.

Unfortunately, some people are so self-conscious about making mistakes that they do not focus on what they want to say. They need to realize that a paper is best done in stages, and that applying the rules can and should wait until a later stage in the writing process. Through review and practice, you will eventually learn how to follow the rules with confidence.

- Statement 4: *“Because I dislike writing, I always start a paper at the last possible minute.”*

This habit is all too common. You feel you are going to do poorly, and then behave in a way that ensures you *will* do poorly! Your attitude is so negative that you defeat yourself—not even allowing enough time to really try.

Again, what you need to realize is that writing is a process. Because it is done in steps, you don’t have to get it right all at once. If you allow yourself enough time, you’ll find a way to make a paper come together.

- Statement 5: *“I’ve always done poorly in English, and I don’t expect that to change.”*

How you may have performed in the *past* does not control how you can perform in the *present*. Even if you did poorly in English in high school, it is in your power to make English one of your best subjects in college. If you believe writing can be learned and then work hard at it, you *will* become a better writer.

In conclusion, your attitude is crucial. If you believe you are a poor writer and always will be, chances are you will not improve. If you realize you can become a better writer, chances are you *will* improve. Depending on how you allow yourself to think, you can be your own best friend or your own worst enemy.

Writing as a Process of Discovery

In addition to believing that writing is a natural gift, many people believe, mistakenly, that writing should flow in a simple, straight line from the writer’s head onto the page. But writing is seldom an easy, one-step journey in which a finished paper comes out in a first draft. The truth is that *writing is a process of discovery* which involves a series of steps, and those steps are very often a zigzag journey. Look at the following illustrations of the writing process:



Very often, writers do not discover just what they want to write about until they explore their thoughts in writing. For example, Gene Hert had been asked to write about a best or worst job. Only after he did some freewriting on good and bad jobs did he realize that the most interesting details centered on his job at an apple plant. He discovered his subject in the course of writing.

Another student, Rhonda, talking afterward about a paper she wrote, explained that at first her topic was how she relaxed with her children. But as she accumulated details, she realized after a page of writing that the words *relax* and *children* simply did not go together. Her details were really examples of how she *enjoyed* her children, not how she *relaxed* with them. She sensed that the real focus of her writing should be what she did by herself to relax, and then she thought suddenly that the best time of her week was Thursday after school. “A light clicked on in my head,” she explained. “I knew I had my paper.” Then it was a matter of detailing exactly what she did to relax on Thursday evenings. Her paper, “How I Relax,” is on [page 84](#).

The point is that writing is often a process of continuing discovery. As you write, you may suddenly switch direction or double back. You may be working on a topic sentence and realize suddenly that it could be your concluding thought. Or you may be developing a supporting idea and then decide that it should be the main point of your paper. [Chapter 2](#) will treat the writing process directly. What is important to remember here is that writers frequently do not know their exact destination as they begin to write. Very often they discover the direction and shape of a paper during the process of writing.

Keeping a Journal

Because writing is a skill, it makes sense that the more you practice writing, the better you will write. One excellent way to get practice in writing, even before you begin composing formal paragraphs, is to keep a daily or almost daily journal. Writing a journal will help you develop the habit of thinking on paper and will show you how ideas can be discovered in the process of writing. A journal can make writing a familiar part of your life and can serve as a continuing source of ideas for papers.

At some point during the day—perhaps during a study period after your last class of the day, or right before dinner, or right before going to bed—spend fifteen minutes or so writing in your journal. Keep in mind that you do not have to plan what to write about, or be in the mood to write, or worry about making mistakes as you write; just write down whatever words come out. You should write at least one page in each session.

You may want to use a notebook that you can easily carry with you for on-the-spot writing. Or you may decide to write on loose-leaf paper that can be transferred later to a journal folder on your desk. Many students choose to keep electronic journals on their computers or online through livejournal.com or a similar Web site. No matter how you proceed, be sure to date all entries.

Your instructor may ask you to make journal entries a specific number of times a week, for a specific number of weeks. He or she may have you turn in your journal every so often for review and feedback. If you are keeping the journal on your own, try to make entries three to five times a week every week of the semester. Your journal can serve as a sourcebook of ideas for possible papers. More important, keeping a journal will help you develop the habit of thinking on paper, and it can help you make writing a familiar part of your life.



Activity 5

Following is an excerpt from one student's journal. (Sentence-skills mistakes have been corrected to improve readability.) As you read, look for a general point and supporting material that could be the basis for an interesting paper.

October 6

Today a woman came into our department at the store and wanted to know if we had any scrap lumber ten feet long. Ten feet! "Lady," I said, "anything we have that's ten feet long sure as heck isn't scrap." When the boss heard me say that, he almost canned me. My boss is a company man, down to his toe tips. He wants to make a big impression on his bosses, and he'll run us around like mad all night to make himself look good. He's the most ambitious man I've ever met. If I don't transfer out of Hardware soon, I'm going to go crazy on this job. I'm not ready to quit, though. The time is not right. I want to be here for a year and have another job lined up and have other things right before I quit. It's good the boss wasn't around tonight when another customer wanted me to carry a bookcase he had bought out to his car. He didn't ask me to help him—he expected me to help him. I hate that kind of "You're my servant" attitude, and I told him that carrying stuff out to cars wasn't my job. Ordinarily I go out of my way to give people a hand, but not guys like him. . . .

- If the writer of this journal is looking for an idea for a paper, he can probably find several in this single entry. For example, he might write a narrative support ing the point that "In my sales job I have to deal with some irritating customers." See if you can find another idea in this entry that might be the basis for an interesting paragraph. Write your point in the space below.

- Take fifteen minutes to prepare a journal entry right now on this day in your life. On a separate sheet of paper, just start writing about anything that you have said, heard, thought, or felt, and let your thoughts take you where they may.

15

16

Using This Text

Here is a suggested sequence for using this book if you are working on your own.

1. After completing this introduction, read the remaining five chapters in Part One and work through as many of the activities as you need to master the ideas in these chapters. By the end of Part One, you will have covered all the basic theory needed to write effective papers.
2. Turn to Part Five and take the diagnostic test. The test will help you determine what sentence skills you need to review. Study those skills one or two at a time while you continue to work on other parts of the book. These skills will help you write effective, error-free sentences.
3. What you do next depends on course requirements, individual needs, or both. You will want to practice at least several different kinds of paragraph development in Part Two. If your time is limited, be sure to include “Exemplification,” “Process,” “Comparison or Contrast,” and “Argument.”
4. After you develop skill in writing effective paragraphs, go on to practice writing one or more of the several-paragraph essays described in Part Three.
5. Turn to Part Four as needed for help with projects that involve research.
6. If you are using the alternate version of this book—*English Skills with Readings*—read at least one of the seventeen selections in Part Six every week, always being sure to work through the two sets of questions that follow each reading.

Remember that, for your convenience, the book includes the following:

- On the inside back cover, there is a checklist of the four basic steps in effective writing.
- On [page 621](#), there is a list of commonly used correction symbols.

Get into the habit of referring to these guides on a regular basis; they’ll help you produce clearly thought-out, well-written papers.

English Skills will help you learn, practice, and apply the thinking and writing skills you need to communicate effectively. But the starting point must be your determination to do the work needed to become a strong writer. The ability to express yourself clearly and logically can open doors of opportunity for you, both in school and in your career. If you decide—and *only you can decide*—that you want such language power, this book will help you reach that goal.

2: The Writing Process



Getting started is often the hardest part of writing. You may have looked and felt like the student pictured above many times when working on a writing assignment. What could this student do to help get ideas flowing? As you will learn in this chapter, using various prewriting techniques can help make the writing process a lot easier.

This chapter will explain and illustrate

- the sequence of steps in writing an effective paragraph
- prewriting
- revising
- editing



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[Chapter 1](#) introduced you to the paragraph form and some basics of writing. This chapter will explain and illustrate the sequence of steps in writing an effective paragraph. In particular, the chapter will focus on prewriting and revising— strategies that can help with every paragraph that you write.

For many people, writing is a process that involves the following steps:

- 1. **Discovering a point—often through prewriting.**
- 2. **Developing solid support for the point—often through more prewriting.**
- 3. **Organizing the supporting material and writing it out in a first draft.**
- 4. **Revising and then editing carefully to ensure an effective, error-free paper.**

Learning this sequence will help give you confidence when the time comes to write. You’ll know that you can use prewriting as a way to think on paper (or at the keyboard) and to discover gradually just what ideas you want to develop. You’ll understand that there are four clear-cut goals to aim for in your writing—unity, support, organization, and error-free sentences. You’ll realize that you can use revising to rework a paragraph until it is strong and effective. And you’ll be able to edit a paragraph so that your sentences are clear and error-free.

Prewriting

If you are like many people, you may have trouble getting started writing. A mental block may develop when you sit down before a blank sheet of paper or a blank screen. You may not be able to think of an interesting topic or a point to make about your topic. Or you may have trouble coming up with specific details to support your point. And even after starting a paragraph, you may hit snags—moments when you wonder “What else can I say?” or “Where do I go next?”

The following pages describe five techniques that will help you think about and develop a topic and get words on paper: (1) freewriting, (2) questioning, (3) making a list, (4) clustering, and (5) preparing a scratch outline. These prewriting techniques help you think about and create material, and they are a central part of the writing process.

Technique 1: Freewriting



When you do not know what to write about a subject or when you are blocked in writing, freewriting sometimes helps. In *freewriting*, you write on your topic for ten minutes. You do not worry about spelling or punctuating correctly, about erasing mistakes, about organizing material, or about finding exact words. You just write without stopping. If you get stuck for words, you write “I am looking for something to say” or repeat words until something comes. There is no need to feel inhibited, since mistakes *do not count* and you do not have to hand in your paper.

Freewriting will limber up your writing muscles and make you familiar with the act of writing. It is a way to break through mental blocks about writing. Since you do not have to worry about mistakes, you can focus on discovering what you want to say about a subject. Your initial ideas and impressions will often become clearer after you have gotten them down on paper, and they may lead to other impressions and ideas. Through continued practice in freewriting, you will develop the habit of thinking as you write. And you will learn a technique that is a helpful way to get started on almost any paragraph.

Freewriting: A Student Model

Gene Hert’s paragraph “My Job in an Apple Plant” on [page 8](#) was written in response to an assignment to write a paragraph on the best or worst job he ever had. Gene began by doing some general freewriting and thinking about his jobs. Here is his freewriting:

I have had good and bad jobs, that's for sure. It was great earning money for the first time. I shoveled snow for my neighbor, a friend of mine and I did the work and had snowball fights along the way. I remember my neighbor reaching into his pocket and pulling out several dollars and handing us the money, it was like magic. Then there was the lawnmowing, which was also a good job. I mowed my aunts lawn while she was away at work. Then I'd go sit by myself in her cool living room and have a coke she left in the refrigarator for me. And look through all her magazines. Then there was the apple plant job I had after high school. That was a worst job that left me totaly wiped out at the end of my shift. Lifting cartons and cartons of apple juice for bosses that treated us like slaves. The cartons coming and coming all night long. I started early in the evening and finished the next morning. I still remember how tired I was. Driving back home the first time. That was a lonely job and a hard job and I don't eat apples anymore.

At this point, Gene read over his notes, and as he later commented, “I realized that I had several potential topics. I said to myself, ‘What point can I make that I can cover in a paragraph? What do I have the most information about?’ I decided to narrow my topic down to my awful job at the apple plant. I figured I would have lots of interesting details for that topic.” Gene then did a more focused freewriting to accumulate details for a paragraph on his bad job:

The job I remember most is the worst job I ever had. I worked in an apple plant, I put in very long hours and would be totally beat after ten hours of work. All the time lifting cartons of apple juice which would come racing down a metal track. The guy with me was a bit lazy at times, and I would be one man doing a two-man job. The cartons would go into a tractor trailer, we would have to throw down wooden skids to put the cartons on, then we'd have to move the metal track as we filled up the truck. There is no other job I have had that even compares to this job, it was a lot worse than it seems. The bosses treated us like slaves and the company paid us like slaves. I would work all night from 7 P.M. and drive home in the morning at 5 A.M. and be bone tired. I remember my arms and shoulders were so tired after the first night. I had trouble turning the steering wheel of my father's car.

Notice that there are problems with spelling, grammar, and punctuation in Gene's freewriting. Gene was not worried about such matters, nor should he have been. At this stage, he just wanted to do some thinking on paper and get some material down on the page. He knew that this was a good first step, a good way of getting started, and that he would then be able to go on and shape that material.

20

You should take the same approach when freewriting: explore your topic without worrying at all about being “correct.” Figuring out what you want to say and getting raw material down on the page should have all of your attention at this early stage of the writing process.

21

Activity 1

To get a sense of the freewriting process, take a sheet of paper and freewrite about different jobs you have had and what you liked or did not like about them. See how much material you can accumulate in ten minutes. And remember not to worry about “mistakes”; you’re just thinking on paper.

Technique 2: Questioning

In *questioning*, you generate ideas and details by asking as many questions as you can think of about your subject. Such questions include *Why? When? Where? Who? How? In what ways?*

Here are questions that Gene Hert asked while further developing his paragraph:

Questioning: A Student Model



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Questions	Answers
<u>What did I hate about the job?</u>	Very hard work. Poor pay. Mean bosses.
<u>How was the work hard?</u>	Nonstop cartons of apple juice. Cartons became very heavy.
<u>Why was pay poor?</u>	\$3.65 an hour (minimum wage at the time). Only a quarter more for working the second shift. Only good money was in overtime—where you got time-and-a-half. No double time.
<u>How were the bosses mean?</u>	Yelled at some workers. Showed no appreciation. Created bad working conditions.
<u>In what ways were working conditions bad?</u>	Unheated truck in zero-degree weather. Floor of tractor trailer was cold steel. Breaks were limited—only two of them. Lonely job.

Asking questions can be an effective way of getting yourself to think about a topic from different angles. The questions can help you generate details about a topic and get ideas on how to organize those details. Notice how asking questions gives Gene a better sense of the different reasons why he hated the job.

Activity 2

To get a feel for the questioning process, use a sheet of paper to ask yourself a series of questions about your best and worst jobs. See how many details you can accumulate in ten minutes. And remember again not to be concerned about “mistakes,” because you are just thinking on paper.

Technique 3: Making a List



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In *making a list*, also known as *brainstorming*, you create a list of ideas and details that relate to your subject. Pile these items up, one after another, without trying to sort out major details from minor ones, or trying to put the details in any special order, or even trying to spell words correctly. Your goal is to accumulate raw material by making up a list of everything about your subject that occurs to you.

After freewriting and questioning, Gene made up the following list of details.

Making a List: A Student Model

Apple factory job—worst one I ever had

Bosses were mean

Working conditions were poor

Went to work at 5 P.M., got back at 7 A.M.

Lifted cartons of apple juice for ten hours

Cartons were heavy

Only two ten-minute breaks a night

Pay was only \$3.65 an hour

Just quarter extra for night shift

Cost of gas money to and from work

No pay for lunch break

Had to work 60 hours for good take-home pay

Loaded onto wooden skids in a truck

Bosses yelled at some workers

Temperature zero outside

Floors of trucks ice-cold metal

Nonstop pace

Had to clean apple vats after work

Slept, ate, and worked—no social life

No real friends at work

One detail led to another as Gene expanded his list. Slowly but surely, more details emerged, some of which he could use in developing his paragraph. By the time he had finished his list, he was ready to plan an outline of his paragraph and then to write his first draft.

Activity 3

To get a sense of making a list, use a sheet of paper to list a series of details about one of the best or worst jobs you ever had. Don't worry about deciding whether the details are major or minor; instead, just get down as many details as you can think of in five or ten minutes.

Technique 4: Clustering



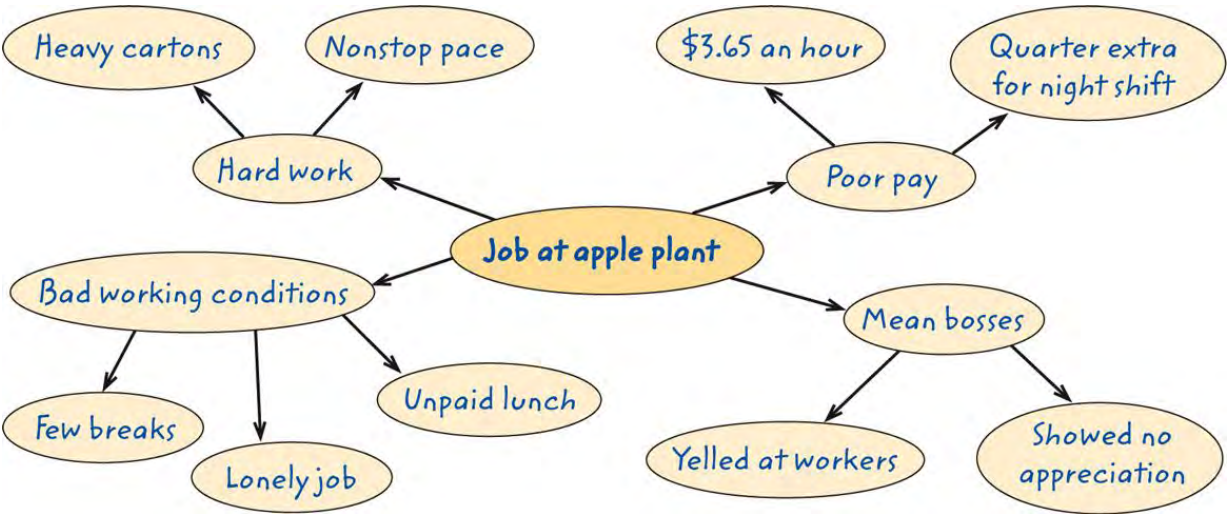
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Clustering, also known as *diagramming* or *mapping*, is another strategy that can be used to generate material for a paragraph. This method is helpful for people who like to think in a visual way. In clustering, you use lines, boxes, arrows, and circles to show relationships among the ideas and details that occur to you.

Begin by stating your subject in a few words in the center of a blank sheet of paper. Then, as ideas and details occur to you, put them in boxes or circles around the subject and draw lines to connect them to each other and to the subject. Put minor ideas or details in smaller boxes or circles, and use connecting lines to show how they relate as well.

Keep in mind that there is no right or wrong way of clustering. It is a way to think on paper about how various ideas and details relate to one another. Below is an example of what Gene might have done to develop his ideas:

Clustering: A Student Model



TIP

In addition to helping generate material, clustering often suggests ways to organize ideas and details.

Activity 4

Use clustering or diagramming to organize the details about a best or worst job that you created for the previous activity ([page 23](#)).

Technique 5: Preparing a Scratch Outline

A scratch outline can be the *single most helpful technique* for writing a good paragraph. A scratch outline often follows freewriting, questioning, making a list, or clustering, but it may also gradually emerge in the midst of these strategies. In fact, trying to make a scratch outline is a good way to see if you need to do more prewriting. If you cannot come up with a solid outline, then you know you need to do more prewriting to clarify your main point and its several kinds of support.

In a scratch outline, you think carefully about the point you are making, the supporting items for that point, and the order in which you will arrange those items. The scratch outline is a plan or blueprint to help you achieve a unified, supported, and well-organized paragraph.



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24

25

Scratch Outline: A Student Model

In Gene’s case, as he was working on his list of details, he suddenly realized what the plan of his paragraph could be. He could organize many of his details into one of three supporting groups: (1) the job itself, (2) the pay, and (3) the working conditions. He then went back to the list, crossed out items that he now saw did not fit, and numbered the items according to the group where they fit. Here is what Gene did with his list:

Apple factory job—worst one I ever had

~~Bosses were mean~~

3 Working conditions were poor

~~Went to work at 5 P.M., got back at 7 A.M.~~

1 Lifted cartons of apple juice for ten hours

1 Cartons were heavy

3 Only two ten-minute breaks a night

2 Pay was only \$3.65 an hour

2 Just quarter extra for night shift

~~Cost of gas money to and from work~~

3 No pay for lunch break

2 Had to work 60 hours for good take-home pay

1 Loaded onto wooden skids in a truck

~~Bosses yelled at some workers~~

3 Temperature zero outside

~~Floors of trucks ice cold metal~~

1 Nonstop pace

3 Had to clean apple vats after work

~~Slept, ate, and worked—no social life~~

3 No real friends at work

Under the list, Gene was now able to prepare his scratch outline:

25

The apple plant was my worst job.

- 1. Hard work*
- 2. Poor pay*
- 3. Poor working conditions*

After all his prewriting, Gene was pleased. He knew that he had a promising paragraph—one with a clear point and solid support. He saw that he could organize the material into a paragraph with a topic sentence, supporting points, and vivid details. He was now ready to write the first draft of his paragraph, using his outline as a guide.

TIP

Chances are that if you do enough prewriting and thinking on paper, you will eventually discover the point and support of your paragraph.

Activity 5

Create a scratch outline that could serve as a guide if you were to write a paragraph on your best or worst job experience.

Writing a First Draft

When you write a first draft, be prepared to put in additional thoughts and details that did not emerge during prewriting. And don't worry if you hit a snag. Just leave a blank space or add a comment such as "Do later" and press on to finish the paper. Also, don't worry yet about grammar, punctuation, or spelling. You don't want to take time correcting words or sentences that you may decide to remove later. Instead, make it your goal to state your main idea clearly and develop the content of your paragraph with plenty of specific details.

Writing a First Draft: A Student Model

Here is Gene's first draft, done in longhand:

~~The apple plant job was my worst.~~ Working in an apple plant was the worst job I ever had. The work was physically hard. For ~~a long time~~ ten hours a night, I stacked cartons that rolled down a metal track in a tractor trailer. Each carton had cans or bottles of apple juice, and they were heavy. At the same time, I had to keep a mental count of all the cartons I had loaded. The pay for the job was a bad feature. I was getting the minamum wage at that time plus a quarter extra for night shift. I had to work a lot to get a decent take-home pay. Working conditions were poor at the apple plant, we were limited to ~~short breaks~~ two ten-minute breaks. The truck-loading dock where I was most of the time was a cold and lonely place. Then by myself cleaning up. DETAILS!

26

27

TIP

After Gene finished the first draft, he was able to put it aside until the next day. You will benefit as well if you can allow some time between finishing a draft and starting to revise.

Activity 6

See if you can fill in the missing words in the following explanation of Gene's first draft.

1. Gene presents his _____ in the first sentence and then crosses it out and revises it right away to make it read smoothly and clearly.
2. Notice that he continues to accumulate specific supporting details as he writes the draft. For example, he crosses out and replaces "a long time" with the more specific _____; he crosses out and replaces "short breaks" with the more specific _____.
3. There are various misspellings—for example, _____. Gene doesn't worry about spelling at this point. He just wants to get down as much of the substance of his paragraph as possible.

4. There are various punctuation errors, especially the run-on and the fragment near the (*beginning, middle, end*)_____ of the paragraph.
5. Near the close of his paragraph, Gene can't think of added details to insert, so he simply prints "_____" as a reminder to himself for the next draft.

27

Revising

28



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Revising is as much a stage in the writing process as prewriting, outlining, and doing the first draft. *Revising* means that you rewrite a paragraph, building upon what has already been done, in order to make it stronger. One writer has said about revision, “It’s like cleaning house—getting rid of all the junk and putting things in the right order.” It is not just “straightening up”; instead, you must be ready to roll up your sleeves and do whatever is needed to create an effective paragraph. Too many students think that a first draft *is* the paragraph. They start to become writers when they realize that revising a rough draft three or four times is often at the heart of the writing process.

Here are some quick tips that can help make revision easier. First, set your first draft aside for a while. You can then come back to it with a fresher, more objective point of view. Second, work from typed or printed text, preferably double-spaced so you’ll have room to handwrite changes later. You’ll be able to see the paragraph more impartially if it is typed than if you were just looking at your own familiar handwriting. Next, read your draft aloud. Hearing how your writing sounds will help you pick up problems with meaning as well as with style. Finally, as you do all these things, write additional thoughts and changes above the lines or in the margins of your paragraph. Your written comments can serve as a guide when you work on the next draft.

There are two stages to the revision process:

- Revising content
- Revising sentences

Revising Content

To revise the content of your paragraph, ask the following questions:

1. Is my paragraph unified?
 - Do I have a main idea that is clearly stated at the beginning of my paragraph?
 - Do all my supporting points truly support and back up my main idea?
2. Is my paragraph supported?

• Are there separate supporting points for the main idea? • Do I have <i>specific</i> evidence for each supporting point? • Is there <i>plenty of</i> specific evidence for the supporting points?	28
3. Is my paragraph organized? • Do I have a clear method of organizing my paper? • Do I use transitions and other connecting words?	29

The next two chapters (Chapters 3 and 4) will give you practice in achieving **unity**, **support**, and **organization** in your writing.

Revising Sentences

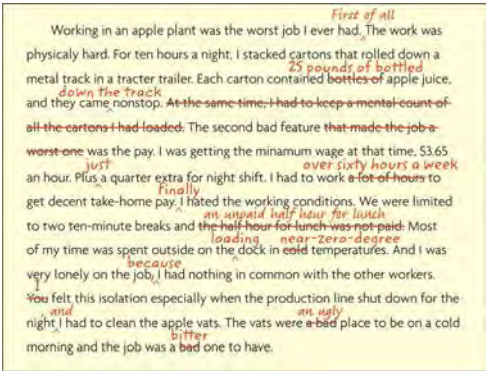
To revise individual sentences in your paragraph, ask the following questions:

1. Do I use parallelism to balance my words and ideas?
 2. Do I have a consistent point of view?
 3. Do I use specific words?
 4. Do I use active verbs?
 5. Do I use words effectively by avoiding slang, clichés, pretentious language, and wordiness?
 6. Do I vary my sentences in length and structure?

[Chapter 5](#) will give you practice in revising sentences.

Revising: A Student Model

For his second draft, Gene used a word-processing program on a computer. He then printed out a double-spaced version of his paragraph, leaving himself plenty of room for handwritten revisions. Here is Gene’s second draft plus the handwritten changes and additions that became his third draft:



Gene made his changes in longhand as he worked on the second draft. As you will see when you complete the activity below, his revision serves to make the paragraph more unified, supported, and organized.

Activity 7

Fill in the missing words.

- 1. To clarify the organization, Gene adds at the beginning of the first supporting point the transitional phrase “_____,” and he sets off the third supporting point with the word “_____.”
- 2. In the interest of (*unity, support, organization*) _____, he crosses out the sentence “_____.” He realizes that this sentence is not a relevant detail to support the idea that the work was physically hard.
- 3. To add more (*unity, support, organization*) _____, he changes “a lot of hours” to “_____”; he changes “on the dock” to “_____”; he changes “cold temperatures” to “_____.”
- 4. In the interest of eliminating wordiness, he removes the words “_____” from the sixth sentence.
- 5. To achieve parallelism, Gene changes “the half hour for lunch was not paid” to “_____.”
- 6. For greater sentence variety, Gene combines two short sentences, beginning the second part of the sentence with the subordinating word “_____.”
- 7. To create a consistent point of view, Gene changes “You felt this isolation” to “_____.”
- 8. Finally, Gene replaces the somewhat vague “bad” in “The vats were a bad place to be on a cold morning, and the job was a bad one to have” with two more precise words: “_____” and “_____.”

Editing



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The last major stage in the writing process is editing—checking a paragraph for mistakes in grammar, punctuation, usage, and spelling. Editing as well as proofreading (checking a paragraph for typos and other careless errors) is explained in detail on [pages 122–123](#).

Editing: A Student Model

After typing into his word-processing file all the revisions in his paragraph, Gene printed out another clean draft of the paragraph. He now turned his attention to editing changes, as shown below:

My Job in an Apple Plant

Working in an apple plant was the worst job I ever had. First of all the work was ~~physically~~ ^{physically} hard. For ten hours a night, I took cartons that rolled down a metal track and stacked them onto wooden skids in a ~~tractor~~ ^{tractor} trailer. Each carton contained ~~25~~ ^{twenty-five} pounds of bottled apple juice, and they came down the track almost nonstop. The second bad feature of the job was the pay. I was getting the ~~minamum~~ ^{minimum} wage at that time, \$3.65 an hour, ^P Plus just a quarter extra for working the night shift. I had to work over sixty hours a week to get a decent take-home pay. Finally, I hated the working conditions. We were limited to two ten-minute breaks and an unpaid half hour for lunch. Most of my time was spent outside on the loading dock in near-zero-degree temperatures. And I was very lonely on the job because I had no interests in common with the other workers. I felt this isolation especially when the production line shut down for the night, and I ~~had to clean~~ ^{spent two hours by myself cleaning} the apple vats. The vats were an ugly place to be on a cold morning, and the job was a bitter one to have.

Once again, Gene made his changes in longhand right on the printout of his paragraph. To note these changes, complete the activity below.

31

32

Activity 8

Fill in the missing words.

- As part of his editing, Gene checked and corrected _____ the of three words, *physically*, *tractor*, and *minimum*.
- He added _____ to set off an introductory phrase ("First of all") and an introductory word ("Finally") and also to connect the two complete thoughts in the final sentence.

3. He corrected a fragment (“_____”) by using a comma to attach it to the preceding sentence.

4. He realized that a number like “25” should be _____ as “twenty-five.”

5. And since revision can occur at any stage of the writing process, including editing, Gene makes one of his details more vivid by adding the descriptive words “_____.”

All that remained for Gene to do was to enter his corrections, print out the final draft of the paragraph, and proofread it for any typos or other careless errors. He was then ready to hand it in to his instructor.

Review Activities



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You now have a good overview of the writing process, from prewriting to first draft to revising to editing. The remaining chapters in Part One will deepen your sense of the four goals of effective writing: unity, support, organization or coherence, and sentence skills.

32
33

To reinforce much of the information about the writing process that you have learned in this chapter, you can now work through the following activities:

1. Taking a writing inventory

2. Prewriting

3. Outlining

4. Revising

1: Taking a Writing Inventory

Activity 9

To evaluate your approach to the writing process, answer the questions below. This activity is not a test, so try to be as honest as possible. Becoming aware of your writing habits can help you make helpful changes in your writing.

1. When you start work on a paper, do you typically do any prewriting?

_____ Yes _____ Sometimes _____ No

2. If so, which of the prewriting techniques do you use?

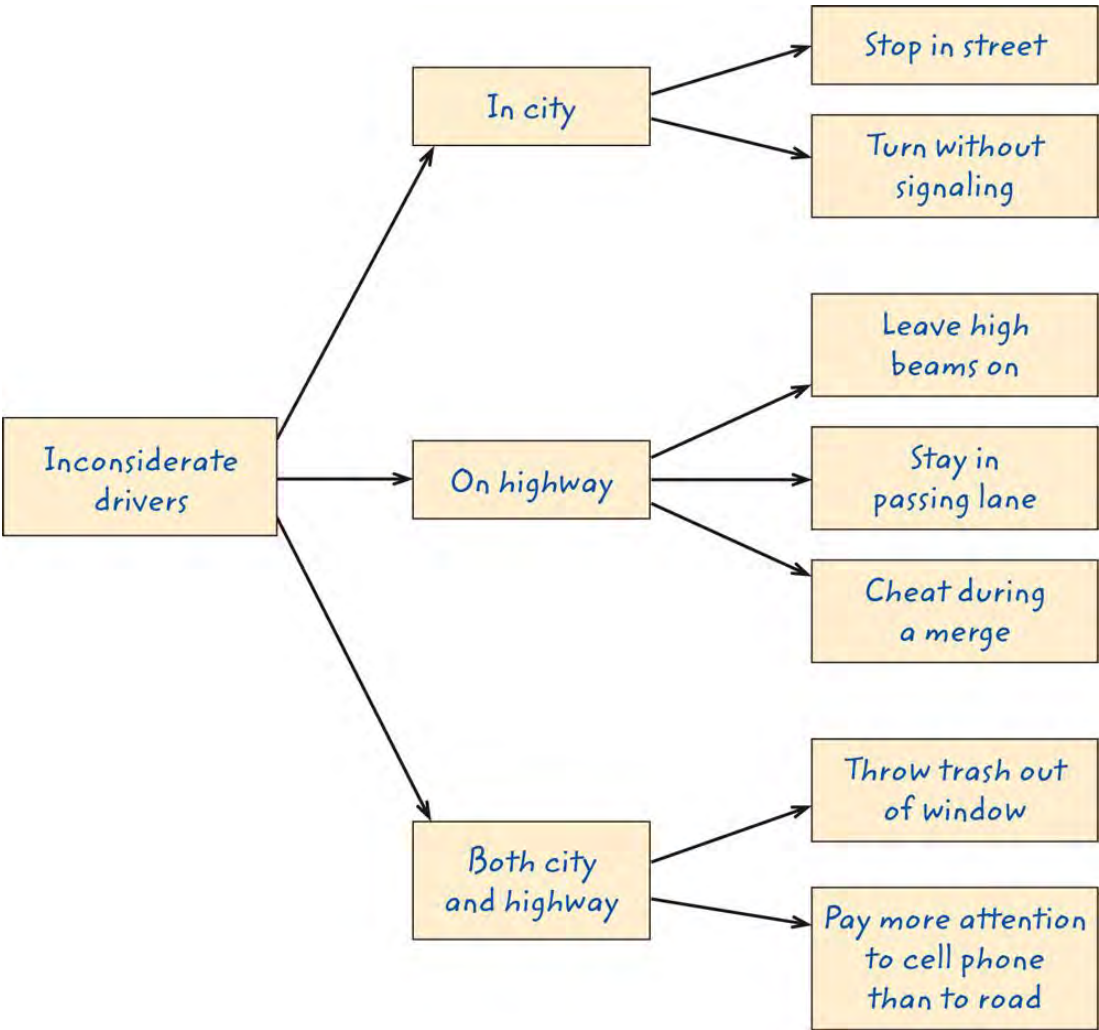
_____ Freewriting _____ Clustering _____ Questioning _____ Scratch outline _____ List making _____ Other (please describe) 3. Which prewriting technique or techniques work best for you or do you think will work best for you? 4. Many students have said they find it helpful to handwrite a first draft and then type that draft on a computer. They then print the draft out and revise it by hand. Describe your own way of drafting and revising a paper. 5. After you write the first draft of a paper, do you have time to set it aside for a while so that you can come back to it with a fresh eye? 6. How many drafts do you typically write when doing a paper?	33
7. When you revise, are you aware that you should be working toward a paper that is unified, solidly supported, and clearly organized? Has this chapter given you a better sense that unity, support, and organization are goals to aim for? 8. Do you revise a paper for the effectiveness of its sentences as well as for its content? 9. What (if any) information has this chapter given you about prewriting that you will try to apply in your writing? 10. What (if any) information has this chapter given you about revising that you will try to apply in your writing?	34

2: Prewriting

Activity 10

Below are examples of how the five prewriting techniques could be used to develop the topic “Inconsiderate Drivers.” Identify each technique by writing F (for free-writing), Q (for questioning), L (for listing), C (for clustering), or SO (for the scratch outline) in the answer space.

	_____ High beams on Weave in and out at high speeds Treat street like a trash can Open car door onto street without looking Stop on street looking for an address Don't use turn signals High speeds in low-speed zones Don't take turns merging Use horn when they don't need to Don't give walkers the right of way More attention to cell phone than the road		
	_____ What is one example of an inconsiderate driver? Where does this happen?	A person who turns suddenly without signaling. At city intersections or on smaller country roads.	34
	Why is this dangerous? What is another example of inconsideration on the road? _____ Some people are inconsiderate drivers. 1. In city: a. Stop in middle of street b. Turn without signaling 2. On highway: a. Leave high beams on b. Stay in passing lane c. Cheat during a merge 3. Both in city and on highway: a. Throw trash out of window b. Pay more attention to cell phone than to road	You have to be alert and slow down yourself to avoid rear-ending the car in front. Drivers who come toward you at night with their high beams on.	35



35

I was driving home last night after class and had three people try to blind me by coming at me with their high beams on. I had to zap them all with my high beams. Rude drivers make me crazy. The worst are the ones that use the road as a trash can. People who throw butts and cups and hamburger wrappings and other stuff out the car windows should be tossed into a trash dumpster. If word got around that this was the punishment maybe they would wise up. Other drivers do dumb things as well. I hate the person who will just stop in the middle of the street and try to figure out directions or look for a house address. Why don't they pull over to the side of the street? That hardly seems like too much to ask. Instead, they stop all traffic while doing their own thing. Then there are the people who keep what they want to do a secret. They're not going to tell you they plan to make a right- or left-hand turn. You've got to figure it out yourself when they suddenly slow down in front of you. Then there are all the people on their cell phones yakking away and not paying attention to their driving.

36

3: Outlining



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As already mentioned (see [page 24](#)), outlining is central to writing a good paragraph. An outline lets you see, and work on, the bare bones of a paragraph, without the distraction of cluttered words and sentences. It develops your ability to think clearly and logically. Outlining provides a quick check on whether your paragraph will be *unified*. It also suggests right at the start whether your paragraph will be adequately *supported*. And it shows you how to plan a paragraph that is *well organized*.

The following series of exercises will help you develop the outlining skills so important to planning and writing a solid paragraph.

Activity 11

One key to effective outlining is the ability to distinguish between general ideas and specific details that fit under those ideas. Read each group of specific ideas below. Then circle the letter of the general idea that tells what the specific ideas have in common. Note that the general idea should not be too broad or too narrow. Begin by trying the example item, and then read the explanation that follows.

EXAMPLE

specific ideas: runny nose, coughing, sneezing, sore throat

The general idea is:



- b. symptoms.
- c. throat problems.

EXPLANATION

It is true that the specific ideas are all symptoms, but they have in common something even more specific—they are all symptoms of the common cold. Therefore, answer *b* is too broad; the correct answer is *a*. Answer *c* is too narrow because it doesn’t cover all the specific ideas; it covers only the final item in the list (“sore throat”).

1. *Specific ideas:* leaking toilet, no hot water, broken window, roaches The general idea is:
a. problems.

36
37

- b. kitchen problems.
 - c. apartment problems.
- 2. *specific ideas*: count to ten, take a deep breath, go for a walk The general idea is:
 - a. actions.
 - b. ways to calm down.
 - c. ways to calm down just before a test.
- 3. *Specific ideas*: putting sticky tape on someone’s chair, putting a “kick me” sign on someone’s back, putting hot pepper in someone’s cereal The general idea is:
 - a. jokes.
 - b. practical jokes.
 - c. practical jokes played on teachers.
- 4. *Specific ideas*: going to bed earlier, eating healthier foods, reading for half an hour each day, trying to be kinder The general idea is:
 - a. resolutions.
 - b. problems.
 - c. solutions.
- 5. *specific ideas*: money problems, family problems, relationship problems, health problems The general idea is:
 - a. poor grades.
 - b. causes of poor grades.
 - c. effects of poor grades.

37
38

Activity 12

In the following items, the specific ideas are given but the general ideas are unstated. Fill in each blank with a general heading that accurately describes the list provided.

EXAMPLE

General idea: Household Chores
Specific ideas: washing dishes
preparing meals
taking out
trash dusting

1. General idea: _____
Specific ideas: convenient work hours
short travel time to job
good pay
considerate boss

2. General idea: _____
Specific ideas: greed
cowardice
selfishness
dishonesty

3. General idea: _____
specific ideas: order the invitations
get the bride’s gown
rent the tuxedos
hire a photographer

4. General idea: _____
Specific ideas: “Your mother stinks. ”
“Your father’s a bum.”
“You look like an ape.”
“Your car is a real piece of junk.”

5. *General idea:* _____
- Specific ideas:* “I like your dress.”
- “You look great in red.”
- “Your new haircut looks terrific.”
- “You did very well on the exam.”

38

39

Activity 13

Major and minor ideas are mixed together in the two paragraphs outlined below. Put the ideas in logical order by filling in the outlines.

1. *Topic sentence:* People can be classified by how they treat their cars.

Seldom wax or vacuum car

Keep every mechanical item in top shape

Protective owners

Deliberately ignore needed maintenance

Indifferent owners

Wash and polish car every week

Never wash, wax, or vacuum car

Abusive owners

Inspect and service car only when required by state law

- a. _____
- (1) _____
- (2) _____
- b. _____
- (1) _____
- (2) _____
- c. _____
- (1) _____

(2) _____

2. *Topic sentence:* Living with an elderly parent has many benefits.

Advantages for elderly person

Live-in baby-sitter

Learn about the past

Advantages for adult children

Serve useful role in family

Help with household tasks

Advantages for grandchildren

Stay active and interested in young people

More attention from adults

a. _____

(1) _____

(2) _____

39

b. _____

(1) _____

(2) _____

40

c. _____

(1) _____

(2) _____

Activity 14

Again, major and minor ideas are mixed together. In addition, in each outline one of the three major ideas is missing and must be added. Put the ideas in logical order by filling in the outlines that follow (summarizing as needed) and adding a third major idea.

1. *Topic sentence:* Extending the school day would have several advantages.

Help children academically

	Parents know children are safe at the school More time to spend on basics Less pressure to cover subjects quickly More time for extras like art, music, and sports Help working parents More convenient to pick up children at 4 or 5 P.M. Teachers' salaries would be raised a. _____ (1) _____ (2) _____ b. _____ (1) _____ (2) _____ c. _____ (1) _____ (2) _____ 2. <i>Topic sentence:</i> By following certain hints about food, exercise, and smoking, you can increase your chances of dying young. Don't ever walk if you can ride instead. Choose foods such as bacon and lunch meats that are laced with nitrites and other preservatives. Be very selective about what you eat. If you begin to cough or feel short of breath, keep smoking.	
	If a friend invites you to play an outdoor sport, open a beer instead and head for your La-Z-Boy recliner. Resist the urge to exercise. Choose foods from one of four essential groups: fat, starch, sugar, and grease. Smoke on a regular basis.	40 41

- a.

(1)

(2)
- b.

(1)

(2)
- c.

(1)

(2)

Activity 15

Read the following two paragraphs. Then outline each one in the space provided. Write out the topic sentence in each case and summarize in a few words the primary and secondary supporting material that fits under the topic sentence.

1. Why I’m a Stay-at-Home Baseball Fan

I’d much rather stay at home and watch ball games on television than go to the ballpark. First, it’s cheaper to watch a game at home. I don’t have to spend fifteen dollars for a ticket and another ten dollars for a parking space. If I want some refreshments, I can have what’s already in the refrigerator instead of shelling out another six dollars for a limp, lukewarm hot dog and a watery Coke. Also, it’s more comfortable at home. I avoid a bumper-tobumper drive to the ballpark and pushy crowds who want to go through the same gate I do. I can lie quietly on my living-room sofa instead of sitting on a hard stadium seat with noisy people all around me. Most of all, watching a game on television is more informative. Not only do I see all the plays that I might miss from my fifteen-dollar seat, but I see some of them two and three times in instant replay. In addition, I get each play explained to me in glorious detail. If I were at the ballpark, I wouldn’t know that the pitch our third baseman hit was a high and inside slider or that his grand-slam home run was a record-setting seventh in his career. The other fans can spend their money; put up with traffic, crowds, and hard seats; and guess at the plays. I’ll take my baseball lying down—at home.

Topic sentence: _____

- a.

(1)

- (2) _____
- b. _____
- (1) _____
- (2) _____
- c. _____
- (1) _____
- (2) _____

2. Why Teenagers Take Drugs

There are several reasons why teenagers take drugs. First of all, it is easy for young people to get drugs. Drugs are available almost anywhere, from aschool cafeteria to a movie line to a football game. Teens don’t have to risk traveling to the slums or dealing with shady types on street corners. It is also easy to get drugs because today’s teens have spending money, which comes from allowances or earnings from part-time jobs. Teens can use their money to buy the luxuries they want—music, makeup, clothes, or drugs. Second, teens take drugs because the adolescent years are filled with psychological problems. For a teenager, one of these problems is the pressure of making important life decisions, such as choosing a career path. Another problem is establishing a sense of self. The teen years are the time when young people must become more independent from their parents and form their own values. The enormous mental pressures of these years can make some people turn to drugs. A final, and perhaps most important, reason why teenagers take drugs is peer pressure to conform. Teens often become very close to special friends, for one thing, and they will share a friend’s interests, even if one interest is drugs. Teenagers also attend parties and other social events where it’s all-important to be one of the crowd, to be “cool.” Even the most mature teenager might be tempted to use drugs rather than risk being an outcast. For all these reasons, drugs are a major problem facing teenagers.

Topic sentence: _____

- a. _____
- (1) _____
- (2) _____
- b. _____
- (1) _____
- (2) _____

42
43

- c. _____
- (1) _____
- (2) _____

4: Revising

Activity 16

Listed in the box below are five stages in the process of composing a paragraph titled “Dangerous Places.”

1. Prewriting (list)
2. Prewriting (freewriting, questioning, list, and scratch outline)
3. First draft
4. Revising (second draft)
5. Revising (final draft)

The five stages appear in scrambled order below and on the next page. Write the number 1 in the blank space in front of the first stage of development and number the remaining stages in sequence.

	_____ There are some places where I never feel safe. For example, public rest rooms. The dirt and graffiti dirt on the floors and the graffiti scrawled on the walls make the room seem dangerous create a sense of danger. I'm also afraid in parking lots. Late at night, I don't like walking in the lot After class, I don't like the parking lot. When I leave my night class or the shopping mall late the walk to the car is scary. Most parking lots have large lights which make me feel at least a little better. I feel least safe in our laundry room. . . . It is a depressing place . . . Bars on the windows, . . . pipes making noises, . . . cement steps the only way out. . . .	43
	_____ <u>Dangerous Places</u> Highways Cars—especially parking lots Feel frightened in our laundry room Big crowds—concerts, movies Closed-in places Bus and train stations Airplane Elevators and escalators _____ Dangerous Places	44

	There are some places where I never feel completely safe. For example, I seldom feel safe in public rest rooms. I worry that I'll suddenly be alone there and that someone will come in to mug me. The ugly graffiti often scrawled on the walls, along with the grime and dirt in the room and crumpled tissues and paper towels on the floor, add to my sense of unease and danger. I also feel unsafe in large, dark, parking lots. When I leave my night class a little late, or I am one of the few leaving the mall at 10 P.M., I dread the walk to my car. I am afraid that someone may be lurking behind another car, ready to mug me. And I fear that my car will not start, leaving me stuck in the dark parking lot. The place where I feel least safe is the basement laundry room in our apartment building. No matter what time I do my laundry, I seem to be the only person there. The windows are barred, and the only exit is a steep flight of cement steps. While I'm folding the clothes, I feel trapped. If anyone unfriendly came down those steps, I would have nowhere to go. The pipes in the room make sudden gurgles, clanks, and hisses, adding to my unsettledness. Places like public rest rooms, dark parking lots, and the basement laundry room give me the shivers. _____ There are some places where I never feel completely safe. For example, I never feel safe in public rest rooms. If I'm alone there, I worry that someone will come in to rob and mug me. The dirt on the floors and the graffiti scrawled on the walls create a sense of danger. I feel unsafe in large, dark parking lots. When I leave my night class a little late or I leave the mall at 10 P.M., the walk to the car is scary. I'm afraid that someone may be behind a car. Also that my car won't start. Another place I don't feel safe is the basement laundry room in our apartment building. No matter when I do the laundry, I'm the only person there. The windows are barred and there are steep steps. I feel trapped when I fold the clothes. The pipes in the room make frightening noises such as hisses and clanks. Our laundry room and other places give me the shivers.	44				
	_____ Some places seem dangerous and unsafe to me. For example, last night I stayed till 10:15 after night class and walked out to parking lot alone. Very scary. Also, other places I go to every day, such as places in my apartment building. Also frightened by big crowds and public rest rooms. <u>Why was the parking lot scary?</u> <u>What places in my building scare me?</u> <table><tr><td>Dark</td><td>Laundry room (especially)</td></tr><tr><td>Only a few cars</td><td>Elevators</td></tr></table>	Dark	Laundry room (especially)	Only a few cars	Elevators	45
Dark	Laundry room (especially)					
Only a few cars	Elevators					

No one else in lot Lobby at night sometimes
Could be someone behind a car Outside walkway at night
Cold

- 2 Parking lots
- 3 Laundry room
- 1 Public rest rooms

Activity 17

The author of “Dangerous Places” in [Activity 16](#) made a number of editing changes between the second draft and the final draft. Compare the two drafts and, in the spaces provided below, identify five of the changes.

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____
- 4. _____
- 5. _____

3: The First and Second Steps in Writing



There are many different reasons for going to college. Perhaps you are studying fashion like the student pictured here. The following chapter contains two student paragraphs detailing each of the writer's reasons for being in college. Think about your own reasons for attending college. You may want to make a list of these reasons. At the end of this chapter you will be asked to write your own paragraph on why you are in college.

This chapter will show you how to

- begin a paragraph by making a point of some kind
- provide specific evidence to support that point
- write a simple paragraph

46

[Chapter 2](#) emphasized how prewriting and revising can help you become an effective writer. This chapter will focus on the first two steps in writing an effective paragraph:

47



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1. Begin with a point.
2. Support the point with specific evidence.

[Chapters 4](#) and [5](#) will then look at the third and fourth steps in writing:

3. Organize and connect the specific evidence ([pages 84–104](#)).
4. Write clear, error-free sentences ([pages 106–136](#)).

Step 1: Begin with a Point

Your first step in writing is to decide what point you want to make and to write that point in a single sentence. The point is commonly known as a *topic sentence*. As a guide to yourself and to the reader, put that point in the first sentence of your paragraph. Everything else in the paragraph should then develop and support in specific ways the single point given in the first sentence.

Activity 1

Read the two student paragraphs below about families today. Which paragraph clearly supports a single point? Which paragraph rambles on in many directions, introducing a number of ideas but developing none of them?

[Paragraph A](#)

Changes in the Family

Changes in our society in recent years have weakened family life. First of all, today's mothers spend much less time with their children. A generation or two ago, most households got by on Dad's paycheck, and Mom stayed home. Now many mothers work, and their children attend an after-school program, stay with a neighbor, or go home to an empty house. Another change is that families no longer eat together. In the past, Mom would be home and fix a full dinner—salad, pot roast, potatoes, and vegetables, with homemade cake or pie to top it off. Dinner today is more likely to be takeout food or frozen dinners eaten at home, or fast food eaten out, with different members of the family eating at different times. Finally, television has taken the place of family conversation and togetherness. Back when there were traditional meals, family members would have a chance to eat together, talk with each other, and share events of the day in a leisurely manner. But now families are more likely to be looking at the TV set than talking to one another. Most homes even have several TV sets, which people watch in separate rooms. Clearly, modern life is a challenge to family life.

47

Paragraph B

48

The Family

Family togetherness is very important. However, today's mothers spend much less time at home than their mothers did, for several reasons. Most fathers are also home much less than they used to be. In previous times, families had to work together running a farm. Now children are left at other places or are home alone much of the time. Some families do find ways to spend more time together despite the demands of work. Another problem is that with parents gone so much of the day, nobody is at home to prepare wholesome meals for the family to eat together. The meals Grandma used to make would include pot roast and fried chicken, mashed potatoes, salad, vegetables, and delicious homemade desserts. Today's takeout foods and frozen meals can provide good nutrition. Some menu choices offer nothing but high-fat and high-sodium choices. People can supplement prepared foods by eating sufficient vegetables and fruit. Finally, television is also a big obstacle to togetherness. It sometimes seems that people are constantly watching TV and never talking to each other. Even when parents have friends over, it is often to watch something on TV. TV must be used wisely to achieve family togetherness.

<i>Complete the following statement:</i> Paragraph _____ is effective because it makes a clear, single point in the first sentence and goes on in the remaining sentences to support that single point. Paragraph A starts with a point—that changes in our society in recent years have weakened family life—and then supports that idea with examples about mothers’ working, families’ eating habits, and television. Paragraph B, on the other hand, does not make and support a single point. At first we think the point of the paragraph may be that “family togetherness is very important.” But there is no supporting evidence showing how important family togetherness is. Instead, the line of thought in paragraph B swerves about like a car without a steering wheel. In the second sentence, we read that “today’s mothers spend much less time at home than their mothers did, for several reasons.” Now we think for a moment that this may be the main point and that the author will go on to list and explain some of those reasons. But the paragraph then goes on to comment on fathers, families in previous times, and families who find ways to spend time together. Any one of those ideas could be the focus of the paragraph, but none is. By now we are not really surprised at what happens in the rest of the paragraph. We are told about the absence of anyone “to prepare wholesome meals for the family,” about what “the meals Grandma used to make” would be like, and about nutrition. The author then goes on to make a couple of points about how much people watch TV. The paragraph ends with yet another idea that does not support any previous point and that itself could be the point of a paragraph: “TV must be used wisely to achieve family togetherness.” No single idea in this paragraph is developed, and the result for the reader is confusion. In summary, while paragraph A is unified, paragraph B shows a complete lack of unity.	48 49
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Step 2: Support the Point with specific Evidence

The first essential step in writing effectively is to start with a clearly stated point. The second basic step is to support that point with specific evidence. Consider the supported point that you just read:

Point

Changes in our society in recent years have weakened family life.

Support

- (1) Mothers
 - (a) Most stayed home a generation ago
 - (b) Most work now, leaving children at an after-school program, or with a neighbor, or in an empty house
- (2) Eating habits
 - (a) Formerly full homemade meals, eaten together
 - (b) Now prepared foods at home or fast food out, eaten separately

(3) Television

- (a) Watching TV instead of conversing
- (b) Watching in separate rooms instead of being together

The supporting evidence is needed so that we can *see and understand for ourselves* that the writer’s point is sound. The author of “Changes in the Family” has supplied specific supporting examples of how changes in our society have weakened family life. The paragraph has provided the evidence that is needed for us to understand and agree with the writer’s point.

49

Now consider the following paragraph:

50

Good-Bye, Tony

I have decided not to go out with Tony anymore. First of all, he was late for our first date. He said that he would be at my house by 8:30, but he did not arrive until 9:30. Second, he was bossy. He told me that it would be too late to go to the new Chris Rock comedy that I wanted to see, and that we would go instead to a new action film with the Rock. I told him that I didn’t like violent movies, but he said that I could shut my eyes during the bloody parts. Only because it was a first date did I let him have his way. Finally, he was abrupt. After the movie, rather than suggesting a hamburger or a drink, he drove right out to a back road near Oakcrest High School and started making out with me. What he did a half hour later angered me most of all. He cut his finger on my earring and immediately said we had to go right home. He was afraid the scratch would get infected if he didn’t put Bactine and a Band-Aid on it. When he dropped me off, I said, “Good-bye, Tony,” in a friendly enough way, but in my head I thought, “Good-bye forever, Tony.”

The author’s point is that she has decided not to go out with Tony anymore. See if you can summarize in the spaces below the three reasons she gives to support her decision:

Reason 1: _____

Reason 2: _____

Reason 3:_____

Notice what the supporting details in this paragraph do. They provide you, the reader, with a basis for understanding why the writer made the decision she did. Through specific evidence, the writer has explained and communicated her point successfully. The evidence that supports the point in a paragraph often consists of a series of reasons introduced by signal words (the author here uses *First of all*, *Second*, and *Finally*) and followed by examples and details that support the reasons. That is true of the sample paragraph above: three reasons are provided, followed by examples and details that back up those reasons.

50

51

The Point as an “Umbrella” Idea

You may find it helpful to think of the point as an “umbrella” idea. Under the writer’s point fits all of the other material of the paragraph. That other material is made up of specific supporting details— evidence such as examples, reasons, or facts. The diagram to the right shows the relationship for the paragraph “Good-Bye, Tony”:



Activity 2

Both of the paragraphs that follow resulted from an assignment to “Write a paragraph that details your reasons for being in college.” Both writers make the point that they have various reasons for attending college. Which paragraph then goes on to provide plenty of specific evidence to back up its point? Which paragraph is vague and repetitive and lacks the concrete details needed to show us exactly why the author decided to attend college?

HINT

Imagine that you’ve been asked to make a short film based on each paragraph. Which one suggests specific pictures, locations, words, and scenes you could shoot? This is the one that uses concrete details.

Paragraph A

Reasons for Going to College

I decided to attend college for various reasons. One reason is self-respect. For a long time now, I have had little self-respect. I spent a lot of time doing nothing, just hanging around or getting into trouble, and eventually I began to feel bad about it. Going to college is a way to start feeling better about myself. By accomplishing things, I will improve my self-image. Another reason for going to college is that things happened in my life that made me think about a change. For one thing, I lost the part-time job I had. When I lost the job, I realized I would have to do something in life, so I thought about school. I was in a rut and needed to get out of it but did not know how. But when something happens that is out of your control, then you have to make some kind of decision. The most important reason for college, though, is to fulfill my dream. I know I need an education, and I want to take the courses I need to reach the position that I think I can handle. Only by qualifying yourself can you get what you want. Going to college will help me fulfill this goal. These are the main reasons why I am attending college.

Paragraph B

51
52

Why I’m in School

There are several reasons I’m in school. First of all, my father’s attitude made me want to succeed in school. One night last year, after I had come in at 3 A.M., my father said, “Mickey, you’re a bum. When I look at my son, all I see is a good-for-nothing bum.” I was angry, but I knew my father was right in a way. I had spent the last two years working at odd jobs at a pizza parlor and luncheonette, trying all kinds of drugs with my friends. That night, though, I decided I would prove my father wrong. I would go to college and be a success. Another reason I’m in college is my girlfriend’s encouragement. Marie has already been in school for a year, and she is doing well in her computer courses. Marie helped me fill out my application and register for courses. She even lent me sixty-five dollars for textbooks. On her day off, she lets me use her car so I don’t have to take the college bus. The main reason I am in college is to fulfill a personal goal: for the first time in my life, I want to finish something. For example, I quit high school in the eleventh grade. Then I enrolled in a government job-training program, but I dropped out after six months. I tried to get a high school equivalency diploma, but I started missing classes and eventually gave up. Now I am in a special program where I will earn my high school degree by completing a series of five courses. I am determined to accomplish this goal and to then go on and work for a degree in hotel management.

52
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Complete the following statement: Paragraph _____ provides clear, vividly detailed reasons why the writer decided to attend college.

Paragraph B is the one that solidly backs up its point. The writer gives us specific reasons he is in school. On the basis of such evidence, we can clearly understand his opening point. The writer of paragraph A offers only vague, general reasons for being in school. We do not get specific examples of how the writer was “getting into trouble,” what events occurred that forced the decision, or even what kind of job he or she wants to qualify for. We sense that the feeling expressed is sincere; but without particular examples we cannot really see why the writer decided to attend college.

Reinforcing Point and Support

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You have now learned the two most important steps in writing effectively: making a point and supporting that point. Take a few minutes now to do the following activity. It will strengthen your ability to recognize a *point* and the *support* for that point.

Activity 3

In the following groups, one statement is the general point and the other statements are specific support for the point. Identify each point with a P and each statement of support with an S.

EXAMPLE

- S My mother has cancer.
- S My fourteen-year-old sister is pregnant.
- S I lost my job.
- P My family has real problems.

53
54

EXPLANATION

The point—that the family has real problems—is strongly supported by the three specific problems stated.

- _____The kitchen is so small that only one person can be there.

_____A nearby bus station fills the apartment with exhaust fumes every morning.

_____The apartment has some real drawbacks.

_____There are no closets.
- _____Some people skip breakfast.

3. _____ Some people have poor eating habits.
_____ Some people always order supersize portions.
_____ Some people eat almost no fruits or vegetables.

- _____ Children are at risk at the school.
_____ There are two active gangs in the school.
_____ Knives and guns have been found in lockers.
_____ Drug busts have been made at the school.

4. _____ Cats are clean and do not require much attention.
_____ Cats like living indoors and are safe to have around children.
_____ Cats are inexpensive to feed and easy to keep healthy.
_____ There are definite advantages to having a cat as a pet.

5. _____ Ron feels short of breath.
_____ Ron is getting dizzy and sweaty.
_____ Ron might be having a heart attack.
_____ Ron has pain in his chest.

6. _____ The couple had different goals.
_____ The couple disliked each other's friends.
_____ The couple shared few interests in common.
_____ The couple had good reasons to break up.

7. _____ The bread the waiter brought us is stale.

	_____ We’ve been waiting for our main course for over an hour. _____ It is time to speak to the restaurant manager. _____ The people next to us are awfully loud.	54
8.	_____ Carla asks you questions about yourself. _____ Carla is a pleasure to be around. _____ Carla has a great smile. _____ Carla really listens when you talk.	55
9.	_____ My boss is hard to work for. _____ She lacks a sense of humor. _____ She never gives praise. _____ She times all our breaks to the second.	
10.	_____ The man doesn’t use his turn signals. _____ The man drives too fast down narrow residential streets. _____ The man doesn’t come to a complete stop at stop signs. _____ The man is an unsafe driver.	
11.	_____ Though a mosquito is small, it has power. _____ A mosquito can find you in the dark. _____ A mosquito can keep you awake all night. _____ A mosquito can make you scratch yourself until you bleed.	
12.		

	_____Because sending e-mail is so simple, family and friends may use it to stay in close touch. _____When people are upset, they may send off an angry e-mail before they consider the consequences. _____The jokes, petitions, and other e-mails that friends so easily forward can become a real nuisance. _____The ease of using e-mail can be both a blessing and a curse. 13. _____When some people answer the phone, their first words are “Who’s this?” _____Some people never bother to identify themselves when calling someone. _____Some people have terrible telephone manners. _____Some people hang up without even saying good-bye. 14. _____One mother created what she called the homework zone—the kitchen table after dinner—where she and her young children did their assignments. _____Some adult students have taken classes at a nearby community college during their lunch hour. _____Adult students often find creative ways to balance school, employment, and family responsibilities.	55
15.	_____By listening to recorded lectures in the car, working students turn travel time into learning time. _____Moviegoers can take several simple steps to save money at the movie theater. _____Bringing homemade popcorn to the movies is cheaper than buying expensive theater popcorn. _____Buying candy at a grocery store, not a theater, cuts candy costs in half. _____Going to movies early in the day reduces ticket prices by as much as \$3 each.	56

The Importance of *Specific* Details

The point that opens a paragraph is a general statement. The evidence that supports a point is made up of specific details, reasons, examples, and facts.

Specific details have two key functions. First of all, details *excite the reader’s interest*. They make writing a pleasure to read, for we all enjoy learning particulars about other people—what they do and think and feel. Second, details *support and explain a writer’s point*; they give the evidence needed for us to see and understand a general idea. For example, the writer of “Good-Bye, Tony” provides details that make vividly clear her decision not to see Tony anymore. She specifies the exact time Tony was supposed to arrive (8:30) and when he actually arrived (9:30). She mentions the kind of film she wanted to see (a new Chris Rock movie) and the one that Tony took her to instead (a violent movie). She tells us what she may have wanted to do after the movie (have a hamburger or a drink) and what they did instead (making out); she even specifies the exact location of the place Tony took her (a back road near Oakcrest High School). She explains precisely what happened next (Tony “cut his finger on my earring”) and even mentions by name (Bactine and a Band-Aid) the treatments he planned to use.

The writer of “Why I’m in School” provides equally vivid details. He gives clear reasons for being in school (his father’s attitude, his girlfriend’s encouragement, and his wish to fulfill a personal goal) and backs up each reason with specific details. His details give us many sharp pictures. For instance, we hear the exact words his father spoke: “Mickey, you’re a bum.” He tells us exactly how he was spending his time (“working at odd jobs at a pizza parlor and luncheonette, trying all kinds of drugs with my friends”). He describes how his girlfriend helped him (filling out the college application, lending money and her car). Finally, instead of stating generally that “you have to make some kind of decision,” as the writer of “Reasons for Going to College” does, he specifies that he has a strong desire to finish college because he dropped out of many schools and programs in the past: high school, a job-training program, and a high school equivalency course.

In both “Good-Bye, Tony” and “Why I’m in School,” then, the vivid, exact details capture our interest and enable us to share in the writer’s experience. We see people’s actions and hear their words; the details provide pictures that make each of us feel “I am there.” The particulars also allow us to understand each writer’s point clearly. We are shown exactly why the first writer has decided not to see Tony anymore and exactly why the second writer is attending college.

56
57

Activity 4

Each of the five points below is followed by two attempts at support (*a* and *b*). Write S (for *specific*) in the space next to the one that succeeds in providing specific support for the point. Write X in the space next to the one that lacks supporting details.

1. My two-year-old son was in a stubborn mood today.

a. When I asked him to do something, he gave me nothing but trouble. He seemed determined to make things difficult for me, for he had his mind made up.

b. When I asked him to stop playing in the yard and come indoors, he looked me square in the eye and shouted “No!” and then spelled it out, “N . . . O!”

2. The prices in the amusement park were outrageously high.
- ___ a. The food seemed to cost twice as much as it would in a supermarket and was sometimes of poor quality. The rides also cost a lot, and so I had to tell the children that they were limited to a certain number of them.
 - ___ b. The cost of the log flume, a ride that lasts roughly three minutes, was ten dollars a person. Then I had to pay four dollars for an eight-ounce cup of Coke and six dollars for a hot dog.
3. My brother-in-law is accident-prone.
- ___ a. Once he tried to open a tube of Krazy Glue with his teeth. When the cap came loose, glue squirted out and sealed his lips shut. They had to be pried open in a hospital emergency room.
 - ___ b. Even when he does seemingly simple jobs, he seems to get into trouble. This can lead to hilarious, but sometimes dangerous, results. Things never seem to go right for him, and he often needs the help of others to get out of one predicament or another.
4. The so-called “bargains” at the yard sale were junk.
- ___ a. The tables were filled with useless stuff no one could possibly want. They were the kinds of things that should be thrown away, not sold.
 - ___ b. The “bargains” included two headless dolls, blankets filled with holes, scorched potholders, and a plastic Christmas tree with several branches missing.

57
58

5. The key to success in college is organization.
- ___ a. Knowing what you’re doing, when you have to do it, and so on is a big help for a student. A system is crucial in achieving an ordered approach to study. Otherwise, things become very disorganized, and it is not long before grades will begin to drop.
 - ___ b. Organized students never forget paper or exam dates, which are marked on a calendar above their desks. And instead of having to cram for exams, they study their clear, neat classroom and textbook notes on a daily basis.

EXPLANATION

The specific support for point 1 is answer b. The writer does not just tell us that the little boy was stubborn but provides an example that shows us. In particular, the detail of the son’s spelling out “N . . . O!” makes his stubbornness vividly real for the reader. For point 2, answer b gives specific prices (ten dollars for a ride, four dollars for a Coke, and six dollars for a hot dog) to support the idea that the amusement park was expensive. For point 3, answer a vividly backs up the idea that the brother-in-law is accidentprone by detailing an accident with Krazy Glue. Point 4 is supported

by answer b, which lists specific examples of useless items that were offered for sale—from headless dolls to a broken plastic Christmas tree. We cannot help agreeing with the writer’s point that the items were not bargains but junk. Point 5 is backed up by answer b, which identifies two specific strategies of organized students: they mark important dates on calendars above their desks, and they take careful notes and study them on a daily basis.

In each of the five cases, the specific evidence enables us to see for ourselves that the writer’s point is valid.

Activity 5

Follow the directions for [Activity 4](#).

1. The house has been neglected by its owners.

a. As soon as you look at the house from the outside, you can tell that repairs need to be made. The roof is badly in need of attention. But it is very obvious that other outside parts of the house also are badly in need of care.

b. The roof is missing a number of shingles. The house’s paint is peeling and spotted with mold. Two windows have been covered with plywood.
2. Students have practical uses for computers.

a. Students stay in touch with friends by e-mail. They often shop over the Internet. They do all their research online.

b. Students have an easier way now to communicate with their friends. They can also save time now: they have no need to go out and buy things but can do it at home. Also, getting information they need for papers no longer requires spending time in the library.
3. Rico knew very little about cooking when he got his first apartment.

a. He had to live on whatever he had in the freezer for a while. He was not any good in the kitchen and had to learn very slowly. More often than not, he would learn how to cook something only by making mistakes first.

b. He lived on macaroni and cheese TV dinners for three weeks. His idea of cooking an egg was to put a whole egg in the microwave, where it exploded. Then he tried to make a grilled cheese sandwich by putting slices of cheese and bread in a toaster.
4. Speaking before a group is a problem for many people.

a. They become uncomfortable even at the thought of speaking in public. They will go to almost any length to avoid speaking to a group. If they are forced to do it, they can feel so anxious that they actually develop physical symptoms.

58

59

- _____b. Stage fright, stammering, and blushing are frequent reactions. Some people will pretend to be ill to avoid speaking publicly. When asked to rank their worst fears, people often list public speaking as even worse than death.
- 5. Small children can have as much fun with ordinary household items as with costly toys.
 - _____a. A large sheet thrown over a card table makes a great hideout or playhouse. Banging pot covers together makes a tremendous crash that kids love. Also, kids like to make long, winding fences out of wooden clothespins.
 - _____b. Kids can make musical instruments out of practically anything. The result is a lot of noise and fun. They can easily create their own play areas as well by using a little imagination. There is simply no need to have to spend a lot of money on playthings.

59



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60

The Importance of *Adequate* Details

One of the most common and most serious problems in students’ writing is inadequate development. You must provide *enough* specific details to support fully the point you are making. You could not, for example, submit a paragraph about your brother-in-law being rude and provide only a single short example. You would have to add several other examples or provide an extended example of your brother-in-law’s rudeness. Without such additional support, your paragraph would be underdeveloped.

At times, students try to disguise an undersupported point by using repetition and wordy generalities. You saw this, for example, in paragraph A (“Reasons for Going to College”) on [page 51](#). Be prepared to do the plain hard work needed to ensure that each of your paragraphs has full, solid support.

Activity 6

The following paragraphs were written on the same topic, and each has a clear opening point. Which one is adequately developed? Which one has few particulars and uses mostly vague, general, wordy sentences to conceal the fact that it is starved for specific details?

Paragraph A

Abuse of Public Parks

Some people abuse public parks. Instead of using the park for recreation, they go there, for instance, to clean their cars. Park caretakers regularly have to pick up the contents of dumped ashtrays and car litter bags. Certain juveniles visit parks with cans of spray paint to deface buildings, fences, fountains, and statues. Other offenders are those who dig up and cart away park flowers, shrubs, and trees. One couple were even arrested for stealing park sod, which they were using to fill in their lawn. Perhaps the most widespread offenders are the people who use park tables and benches and fireplaces but do not clean up afterward. Picnic tables are littered with trash, including crumpled bags, paper plates smeared with ketchup, and paper cups half-filled with stale soda. On the ground are empty beer bottles, dented soda cans, and sharp metal pop-tops. Parks are made for people, and yet—ironically—their worst enemy is “people pollution.”

60

Paragraph B

Mistreatment of Public Parks

Some people mistreat public parks. Their behavior is evident in many ways, and the catalog of abuses could go on almost without stopping. Different kinds of debris are left by people who have used the park as a place for attending to their automobiles. They are not the only individuals who mistreat public parks, which should be used with respect for the common good of all. Many young people come to the park and abuse it, and their offenses can occur in any season of the year. The reason for their inconsiderate behavior is known only to themselves. Other visitors lack personal cleanliness in their personal habits when they come to the park, and the park suffers because of it. Such people seem to have the attitude that someone else should clean up after them. It is an undeniable fact that people are the most dangerous thing that parks must contend with.

Complete the following statement: Paragraph _____ provides an adequate number of specific details to support its point.

Paragraph A offers a series of detailed examples of how people abuse parks. Paragraph B, on the other hand, is underdeveloped. Paragraph B speaks only of “different kinds of debris,” while paragraph A refers specifically to “dumped ashtrays and car litter bags”; paragraph B talks in a general way of young people abusing the park, while paragraph A supplies such particulars as “cans of spray paint” and defacing “buildings, fences, fountains, and statues.” And there is no equivalent in paragraph B for the specifics in paragraph A about people who steal park property and litter park grounds. In summary, paragraph B lacks the full, detailed support needed to develop its opening point convincingly.

To check your understanding of the chapter so far, see if you can answer the following questions.

1. It has been observed: “To write well, the first thing that you must do is decide what nail you want to drive home.” What is meant by *nail*?

2. How do you drive home the nail in the paragraph?
3. What are the two reasons for using specific details in your writing?

- a. _____
- b. _____

Practice in Making and Supporting a Point

You now know the two most important steps in competent writing: (1) making a point and (2) supporting that point with specific evidence. The purpose of this section is to expand and strengthen your understanding of these two basic steps.

You will first work through a series of activities on *making* a point:

1. Identifying Common Errors in Topic Sentences
2. Understanding the Two Parts of a Topic Sentence
3. Selecting a Topic Sentence
4. Writing a Topic Sentence: I
5. Writing a Topic Sentence: II

You will then sharpen your understanding of specific details by working through a series of activities on *supporting* a point:

6. Recognizing Specific Details: I
7. Recognizing Specific Details: II
8. Providing Supporting Evidence
9. Identifying Adequate Supporting Evidence
10. Adding Details to Complete a Paragraph
11. Writing a Simple Paragraph

1: Identifying Common Errors in Topic Sentences

When writing a point, or topic sentence, people sometimes make mistakes that undermine their chances of producing an effective paper. One mistake is to substitute an announcement of the topic for a true topic sentence. Other mistakes include writing statements that are too broad or too narrow. Following are examples of all three errors, along with contrasting examples of effective topic sentences.

Announcement

My car is the concern of this paragraph.

The statement above is a simple announcement of a subject, rather than a topic sentence expressing an idea about the subject.

Statement That Is Too Broad

Many people have problems with their cars.

The statement is too broad to be supported adequately with specific details in a single paragraph.

Statement That Is Too Narrow

My car is a Ford Focus.

The statement above is too narrow to be expanded into a paragraph. Such a narrow statement is sometimes called a *dead-end statement* because there is no place to go with it. It is a simple fact that does not need or call for any support.

Effective Topic Sentence

I hate my car.

The statement above expresses an opinion that could be supported in a paragraph. The writer could offer a series of specific supporting reasons, examples, and details to make it clear why he or she hates the car.

Here are additional examples:

Announcements

The subject of this paper will be my apartment.

I want to talk about increases in the divorce rate.

Statements That Are Too Broad

The places where people live have definite effects on their lives.

Many people have trouble getting along with others.

Statements That Are Too Narrow

I have no hot water in my apartment at night.

Almost one of every two marriages ends in divorce.

Effective Topic Sentences

My apartment is a terrible place to live.

The divorce rate is increasing for several reasons.

63

64

Activity 7

For each pair of sentences below, write A beside the sentence that only *announces* a topic. Write OK beside the sentence that *advances an idea* about the topic.

1.

_____ a. This paper will deal with flunking math.

_____ b. I flunked math last semester for several reasons.

2.

_____ a. I am going to write about my job as a gas station attendant.

_____ b. Working as a gas station attendant was the worst job I ever had.

3.

_____ a. Obscene phone calls are the subject of this paragraph.

_____ b. People should know what to do when they receive an obscene phone call.

4.

_____ a. In several ways, my college library is inconvenient to use.

_____ b. This paragraph will deal with the college library.

5.

_____ a. My paper will discuss the topic of procrastinating.

_____ b. The following steps will help you stop procrastinating.

Activity 8

For each pair of sentences below, write TN beside the statement that is *too narrow* to be developed into a paragraph. Write OK beside the statement in each pair that could be developed into a paragraph.

1.

_____a. I do push-ups and sit-ups each morning.

_____b. Exercising every morning has had positive effects on my health.
2.

_____a. José works nine hours a day and then goes to school three hours a night.

_____b. José is an ambitious man.
3.

_____a. I started college after being away from school for seven years.

_____b. Several of my fears about returning to school have proved to be groundless.
4.

_____a. Parts of Walt Disney’s *Bambi* make the movie frightening for children.

_____b. Last summer I visited Disneyland in Anaheim, California.
5.

_____a. My brother was depressed yesterday for several reasons.

_____b. Yesterday my brother had to pay fifty-two dollars for a motor tune-up.

Activity 9

For each pair of sentences below, write TB beside the statement that is *too broad* to be supported adequately in a short paper. Write OK beside the statement that makes a limited point.

1.

_____a. Professional football is a dangerous sport.

_____b. Professional sports are violent.
2.

_____a. Married life is the best way of living.

_____b. Teenage marriages often end in divorce for several reasons.
3.

_____a. Aspirin can have several harmful side effects.

_____b. Drugs are dangerous.

64

65

4.

- _____ a. I've always done poorly in school.
- _____ b. I flunked math last semester for several reasons.

5.

- _____ a. Computers are changing our society.
- _____ b. Using computers to teach schoolchildren is a mistake.

2: Understanding the Two Parts of a Topic Sentence

As stated earlier, the point that opens a paragraph is often called a *topic sentence*. When you look closely at a point, or topic sentence, you can see that it is made up of two parts:

1. The *limited topic*
2. The writer's *attitude* toward or idea about the limited topic

The writer's attitude, point of view, or idea is usually expressed in one or more *key words*. All the details in a paragraph should support the idea expressed in the key words. In each of the topic sentences below, a single line appears under the topic and a double line under the idea about the topic (expressed in a key word or key words):

My girlfriend is very aggressive.

Highway accidents are often caused by absentmindedness.

The kitchen is the most widely used room in my house.

Voting should be required by law in the United States.

My pickup truck is the most reliable vehicle I have ever owned.

In the first sentence, the topic is *girlfriend*, and the key word that expresses the writer's idea about his topic is that his girlfriend is *aggressive*. In the second sentence, the topic is *highway accidents*, and the key word that determines the focus of the paragraph is that such accidents are often caused by *absentmindedness*. Notice each topic and key word or key words in the other three sentences as well.

Activity 10

For each point below, draw a single line under the topic and a double line under the idea about the topic.

1. Billboards should be abolished.

2. My boss is an ambitious man.	65
3. Politicians are often self-serving.	66
4. The apartment needed repairs.	
5. Television commercials are often insulting.	
6. My parents have rigid racial attitudes.	
7. The middle child is often a neglected member of the family.	
8. The language in many movies today is offensive.	
9. Doctors are often insensitive.	
10. Homeowners today are more energy-conscious than ever before.	
11. My car is a temperamental machine.	
12. My friend Debbie, who is only nineteen, is extremely old-fashioned.	
13. Looking for a job can be a degrading experience.	
14. The daily life of students is filled with conflicts.	
15. Regulations in the school cafeteria should be strictly enforced.	
16. The national speed limit should be raised.	
17. Our vacation turned out to be a disaster.	
18. The city’s traffic-light system has both values and drawbacks.	
19. Insects serve many useful purposes.	
20. Serious depression often has several warning signs.	

3: Selecting a Topic Sentence

Remember that a paragraph is made up of a topic sentence and a group of related sentences developing the topic sentence. It is also helpful to remember that the topic sentence is a *general* statement. The other sentences provide specific support for the general statement.

Activity 11

Each group of sentences below could be written as a short paragraph. Circle the letter of the topic sentence in each case. To find the topic sentence, ask yourself, “Which is a general statement supported by the specific details in the other three statements?”

Begin by trying the example item below. First circle the letter of the sentence you think expresses the main idea. Then read the explanation.

EXAMPLE

- a. If you stop carrying matches or a lighter, you can cut down on impulse smoking.
- b. If you sit in no-smoking areas, you will smoke less.
- c. You can behave in ways that will help you smoke less.
- d. By keeping a record of when and where you smoke, you can identify the most tempting situations and then avoid them.

EXPLANATION

Sentence a explains one way to smoke less. Sentences b and d also provide specific ways to smoke less. In sentence c, however, no one specific way is explained. The words ways that will help you smoke less refer only generally to such methods. Therefore, sentence c is the topic sentence; it expresses the author’s main idea. The other sentences support that idea by providing examples.

- 1.
 - a. “I couldn’t study because I forgot to bring my textbook home.”
 - b. “I couldn’t take the final because my grandmother died.”
 - c. Students give instructors some common excuses.
 - d. “I couldn’t come to class because I had a migraine headache.”
- 2.
 - a. Its brakes are badly worn.
 - b. My old car is ready for the junk pile.
 - c. Its floor has rusted through, and water splashes on my feet when the highway is wet.
 - d. My mechanic says its engine is too old to be repaired, and the car isn’t worth the cost of a new engine.
- 3.
 - a. The last time I ate at the diner, I got food poisoning and was sick for two days.
 - b. The city inspector found roaches and mice in the diner’s kitchen.

66
67

- c. Our town diner is a health hazard and ought to be closed down.
- d. The toilets in the diner often back up, and the sinks have only a trickle of water.

4.

- a. Part-time workers can be easily laid off.
- b. Most part-time workers get no fringe benefits.
- c. The average part-timer earns three dollars less an hour than a full-timer.
- d. Part-time workers have second-class status.

5.

- a. In early colleges, students were mostly white males.
- b. Colleges of two centuries ago were quite different from today’s schools.
- c. All students in early colleges had to take the same courses.
- d. The entire student body at early schools would be only a few dozen people.

4: Writing a Topic Sentence: I

Activity 12

The following activity will give you practice in writing an accurate point, or topic sentence—one that is neither too broad nor too narrow for the supporting material in a paragraph. Sometimes you will construct your topic sentence after you have decided which details you want to discuss. An added value of this activity is that it shows you how to write a topic sentence that will exactly match the details you have developed.

67
68

- 1. *Topic sentence:* _____
 - a. When we brought a “welcome to the neighborhood” present, the family next door didn’t even say thank you.
 - b. The family never attends the annual block party.
 - c. The family’s children aren’t allowed to play with other neighborhood kids.
 - d. Our neighbors keep their curtains closed and never sit out in their yard.
- 2. *Topic sentence:* _____
 - a. Only about thirty people came to the dance, instead of the expected two hundred.
 - b. The band arrived late and spent an hour setting up.

- c. There were at least three males at the dance to every female.
- d. An hour after the dance started, it ended because of a power failure.

3. *Topic sentence:*_____:

- a. We had to wait half an hour even though we had reserved a table.
- b. Our appetizer and main course arrived at the same time.
- c. The busboy ignored our requests for more water.
- d. The wrong desserts were served to us.

4. *Topic sentence:*_____

- a. In early grades we had spelling bees, and I would be among the first to sit down.
- b. In sixth-grade English, my teacher kept me busy diagramming sentences on the board.
- c. In tenth grade we had to recite poems, and I always forgot my lines.
- d. In my senior year, my compositions had more red correction marks than anyone else’s.

5. *Topic sentence:*_____

- a. The crowd scenes were crudely spliced from another film.
- b. Mountains and other background scenery were just painted cardboard cutouts.
- c. The “sync” was off, so that you heard voices even when the actors’ lips were not moving.
- d. The so-called “monster” was just a spider that had been filmed through a magnifying lens.

68
69

5: Writing a Topic Sentence: II

Often you will start with a general topic or a general idea of what you want to write about. You may, for example, want to write a paragraph about some aspect of school life. To come up with a point about school life, begin by limiting your topic. One way to do this is to make a list of all the limited topics you can think of that fit under the general topic.

Activity 13

Following are five general topics and a series of limited topics that fit under them. Make a point out of *one* of the limited topics in each group.

HINT

To create a topic sentence, ask yourself, “What point do I want to make about _____
(my limited topic)?”

EXAMPLE

Recreation

- Movies
- Dancing
- TV shows
- Reading
- Sports parks

Your point: _____

1. Your school

- Instructor
- Cafeteria
- specific course
- Particular room or building
- Particular policy (attendance, grading, etc.)
- Classmate

Your point: _____

2. Job

- Pay
- Boss
- Working conditions
- Duties
- Coworkers

- Customers or clients

Your point: _____

3. Money

- Budgets
- Credit cards
- Dealing with a bank
- School expenses
- Ways to get it
- Ways to save it

Your point: _____

4. Cars

- First car
- Driver's test
- Road conditions
- Accident
- Mandatory speed limit
- Safety problems

Your point: _____

5. Sports

- A team's chances
- At your school
- Women's team
- Recreational versus spectator
- Favorite team

- Outstanding athlete

Your point: _____

70

71

6: Recognizing Specific Details: I

specific details are examples, reasons, particulars, and facts. Such details are needed to support and explain a topic sentence effectively. They provide the evidence needed for readers to understand, as well as to feel and experience, a writer’s point.

Here is a topic sentence followed by two sets of supporting sentences. Which set provides sharp, specific details?

Topic Sentence

Some poor people must struggle to make meals for themselves.

Set A

They gather up whatever free food they can find in fast-food restaurants and take it home to use however they can. Instead of planning well-balanced meals, they base their diet on anything they can buy that is cheap and filling.

Set B

Some make tomato soup by adding hot water to the free packets of ketchup they get at McDonald’s. Others buy cans of cheap dog food and fry it like hamburger.

Set B provides specific details: instead of a general statement about “free food they find in fast-food restaurants and take . . . home to use however they can,” we get a vivid detail we can see and picture clearly: “make tomato soup [from] free packets of ketchup.” Instead of a general statement about how the poor will “base their diet on anything they can buy that is cheap and filling,” we get exact and vivid details: “Others buy cans of cheap dog food and fry it like hamburger.”

Specific details are often like the information we might find in a movie script. They provide us with such clear pictures that we could make a film of them if we wanted to. You would know just how to film the information given in set B. You would show a poor person breaking open a packet of ketchup from McDonald’s and mixing it with water to make a kind of tomato soup. You would show someone opening a can of dog food and frying its contents like hamburger.

In contrast, the writer of set A fails to provide the specific information needed. If you were asked to make a film based on set A, you would have to figure out for yourself just what particulars you were going to show.

When you are working to provide specific supporting information in a paper, it might help to ask yourself, “Could someone easily film this information?” If the answer is “yes,” you probably have good details.

71

72

Activity 14

Each topic sentence below is followed by two sets of supporting details (*a* and *b*). Write S (for *specific*) in the space next to the set that provides specific support for the point. Write G (for *general*) next to the set that offers only vague, general support.

1. *Topic sentence:* My roommate is messy.

_____ a. He doesn't seem to mind that he can't find any clean clothes or dishes. He never puts anything back in its proper place; he just drops it wherever he happens to be. His side of the room looks as if a hurricane has gone through.

_____ b. His coffee cup is covered inside with a thick layer of green mold. I can't tell you what color his easy chair is; it has disappeared under a pile of dirty laundry. When he turns over in bed, I can hear the crunch of cracker crumbs beneath his body.

2. *Topic sentence:* Roberta is very aggressive.

_____ a. Her aggressiveness is apparent in both her personal and her professional life. She is never shy about extending social invitations. And while some people are turned off by her aggressive attitude, others are impressed by it and enjoy doing business with her.

_____ b. When she meets a man she likes, she is quick to say, “Let's go out sometime. What's your phone number?” In her job as a furniture salesperson, she will follow potential customers out onto the sidewalk as she tries to persuade them to buy.

3. *Topic sentence:* Our new kitten causes us lots of trouble.

_____ a. He has shredded the curtains in my bedroom with his claws. He nearly drowned when he crawled into the washing machine. And my hands look like raw hamburger from his playful bites and scratches.

_____ b. He seems to destroy everything he touches. He's always getting into places where he doesn't belong. Sometimes he plays too roughly, and that can be painful.

4. *Topic sentence:* My landlord is softhearted.

_____ a. Even though he wrote them himself, he sometimes ignores the official apartment rules in order to make his tenants happy.

_____ b. Although the lease states “No pets,” he brought my daughter a puppy after she told him how much she missed having one.

5. *Topic sentence:* The library is a distracting place to try to study.

_____ a. It's hard to concentrate when a noisy eight-person poker game is going on on the floor beside you. It's also distracting to overhear remarks like, "Hey, Baby, what's your mother's address? I want to send her a thank-you card for having such a beautiful daughter."	72
_____ b. Many students meet in the library to do group activities and socialize with one another. Others go there to flirt. It's easy to get more interested in all that activity than in paying attention to your studies.	73

7: Recognizing Specific Details: II

Activity 15

At several points in the following paragraphs, you are given a choice of two sets of supporting details. Write S (for *specific*) in the space next to the set that provides specific support for the point. Write G (for *general*) next to the set that offers only vague, general support.

Paragraph 1

My daughter's boyfriend is a good-for-nothing young man. After knowing him for just three months, everyone in our family is opposed to the relationship. For one thing, Russell is lazy.

- _____ a. He is always finding an excuse to avoid putting in an honest day's work. He never pitches in and helps with chores around our house, even when he's asked directly to do so. And his attitude about his job isn't any better. To hear him tell it, he deserves special treatment in the workplace. He thinks he's gone out of his way if he just shows up on time.
- _____ b. After starting a new job last week, he announced this Monday that he wasn't going to work because it was his *birthday* —as if he were somebody special. And when my husband asked Russell to help put storm windows on the house next Saturday, Russell answered that he uses his weekends to catch up on sleep.

Another quality of Russell's which no one likes is that he is cheap.

- _____ c. When my daughter's birthday came around, Russell said he would take her out to Baldoni's, a fancy Italian restaurant. Then he changed his mind. Instead of spending a lot of money on a meal, he said, he wanted to buy her a really nice pair of earrings. So my daughter cooked dinner for him at her apartment. But there was no present, not even a little one. He claims he's waiting for a jewelry sale at Macy's. I don't think my daughter will ever see that "really nice" gift.
- _____ d. He makes big promises about all the nice things he's going to do for my daughter, but he never comes through. His words are cheap, and so is he. He's all talk and no action. My daughter isn't greedy, but it hurts her when Russell says he's going to take her someplace nice or give her something special and then nothing happens.

	Worst of all, Russell is mean.	73
	_____e. Russell seems to get special pleasure from hurting people when he feels they have a weak point. I have heard him make remarks that to him were funny but were really very insensitive. You’ve got to wonder about someone who needs to be ugly to other people just for the sake of being powerful. Sometimes I want to let him know how I feel. _____f. When my husband was out of work, Russell said to him, “Well, you’ve got it made now, living off your wife.” After my husband glared at him, he said, “Why’re you getting sore? I’m just kidding.” Sometimes he snaps at my daughter, saying things like “Don’t make me wait—there are plenty of other babes who would like to take your place.” At such times I want to toss him out to the curb. Everyone in the family is waiting anxiously for the day when my daughter will see Russell the way the rest of us see him. Paragraph 2 Many adult children move back in with their parents for some period of time. Although living with Mom and Dad again has some advantages, there are certain problems that are likely to arise. One common problem is that children may expect their parents to do all the household chores. _____a. They never think that they should take on their share of work around the house. Not only do they not help with their parents’ chores; they don’t even take responsibility for the extra work that their presence creates. Like babies, they go through the house making a mess that the parents are supposed to clean up. It’s as if they think their parents are their servants. _____b. They expect meals to appear on the table as if by magic. After they’ve eaten, they go off to work or play, never thinking about who’s going to do the dishes. They drop their dirty laundry beside the washing machine, assuming that Mom or Dad will attend to it and return clean, folded clothes to their bedroom door. And speaking of their bedrooms: every day they await the arrival of Mom’s Maid Service to make the bed, pick up the floor, and dust the furniture. Another frequent problem is that parents forget their adult children are no longer adolescents. _____c. Parents like this want to know everything about their adult children’s lives. They don’t think their kids, even though they are adults, should have any privacy. Whenever they see their children doing anything, they want to know all the details. It’s as though their children are still teenagers who are expected to report all their activities. Naturally, adult children get irritated when they are treated as if they were little kids.	74
	_____d. They may insist upon knowing far more about their children’s comings and goings than the children want to share. For example, if such parents see their adult son heading out the door, they demand to know: “Where are you going? Who will you be with? What will you be doing? What time will you be back?” In addition, they may not let their adult child have any privacy. If their daughter and a date are sitting in the living room, for instance, they may	75

join them there and start peppering the young man with questions about his family and his job, as if they were interviewing him for the position of son-in-law.

Finally, there may be financial problems when an adult child returns to live at home.

- _____ e. Having an extra adult in the household creates extra expenses. But many adult children don't offer to help deal with those extra costs. Adult children often eat at home, causing the grocery bill to climb. They may stay in a formerly unused room, which now needs to be heated and lit. They produce extra laundry to be washed. They use the telephone, adding to the long-distance bill. For all these reasons, adult children should expect to pay a reasonable fee to their parents for room and board.
- _____ f. It's expensive to have another adult living in the household. Adult children would be paying a lot of bills on their own if they weren't staying with their parents. It's only fair that they share the expenses at their parents' house. They should consider all the ways that their living at home is increasing their parents' expenses. Then they should insist on covering their share of the costs.

8: Providing Supporting Evidence

Activity 16

Provide three details that logically support each of the following points, or topic sentences. Your details can be drawn from your own experience, or they can be invented. In each case, the details should show in a specific way what the point expresses in only a general way. You may state your details briefly in phrases, or as complete sentences.

EXAMPLE

The student had several ways of passing time during the dull lecture.

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75
76

1. I could tell I was coming down with the flu.

2. The food at the cafeteria was terrible yesterday.

3. I had car problems recently.
4. When your money gets tight, there are several ways to economize.
5. Some people have dangerous driving habits.

9: Identifying Adequate Supporting Evidence

Activity 17

Two of the following paragraphs provide sufficient details to support their topic sentences convincingly. Write AD, for *adequate development*, beside those paragraphs. There are also three paragraphs that, for the most part, use vague, general, or wordy sentences as a substitute for concrete details. Write U, for *under developed*, beside those paragraphs.

_____ 1. My Husband’s Stubbornness

My husband’s worst problem is his stubbornness. He simply will not let any kind of weakness show. If he isn’t feeling well, he refuses to admit it. He will keep on doing whatever he is doing and will wait until the symptoms get almost unbearable before he will even hint that anything is the matter with him. Then things are so far along that he has to spend more time recovering than he would if he had a different attitude. He also hates to be wrong. If he is wrong, he will be the last to admit it. This happened once when we went shopping, and he spent an endless amount of time going from one place to the next. He insisted that one of them had a fantastic sale on things he wanted. We never found a sale, but the fact that this situation happened will not change his attitude. Finally, he never listens to anyone else’s suggestions on a car trip. He always knows he’s on the right road, and the

76
77

results have led to a lot of time wasted getting back in the right direction. Every time one of these incidents happens, it only means that it is going to happen again in the future.

_____2. **Dangerous Games**

Because they feel compelled to show off in front of their friends, some teenagers play dangerous games. In one incident, police found a group of boys performing a dangerous stunt with their cars. The boys would perch on the hoods of cars going thirty-five or forty miles an hour. Then the driver would brake sharply, and the boy who flew the farthest off the car would win. Teenagers also drive their cars with the lights off and pass each other on hills or curves as ways of challenging each other. In addition to cars, water seems to tempt young people to invent dangerous contests. Some students dared each other to swim through a narrow pipe under a four-lane highway. The pipe carried water from a stream to a pond, and the swimmer would have to hold his or her breath for several minutes before coming out on the other side. Another contest involved diving off the rocky sides of a quarry. Because large stones sat under the water in certain places, any dive could result in a broken neck. But the students would egg each other on to go “rock diving.” Playing deadly games like these is a horrifying phase of growing up for some teenagers.

_____3. **Attitudes toward Food**

As children, we form attitudes toward food that are not easily changed. In some families, food is love. Not all families are like this, but some children grow up with this attitude. Some families think of food as something precious and not to be wasted. The attitudes children pick up about food are hard to change in adulthood. Some families celebrate with food. If a child learns an attitude, it is hard to break this later. Someone once said: “As the twig is bent, so grows the tree.” Children are very impressionable, and they can’t really think for themselves when they are small. Children learn from the parent figures in their lives, and later from their peers. Some families have healthy attitudes about food. It is important for adults to teach their children these healthy attitudes. Otherwise, the children may have weight problems when they are adults.

77

_____4. **Qualities in a Friend**

There are several qualities I look for in a friend. A friend should give support and security. A friend should also be fun to be around. Friends can have faults, like anyone else, and sometimes it is hard to overlook them. But a friend can’t be dropped because he or she has faults. A friend should stick to you, even in bad times. There is a saying that “a friend in need is a friend indeed.” I believe this means that there are good friends and fair-weather friends. The second type is not a true friend. He or she is the kind of person who runs when there’s trouble. Friends don’t always last a lifetime. Some-one you believed to be your best friend may lose contact with you if you move to a different area or go around with a different group of people. A friend should be generous and understanding. A friend does not have to be exactly like you. Sometimes friends are opposites, but they still like each other and get along. Since I am a very quiet person, I can’t say that I have many friends. But these are the qualities I believe a friend should have.

78

_____ 5. An Unsafe Place

We play touch football on an unsafe field. First of all, the grass on the field is seldom mowed. The result is that we have to run through tangled weeds that wrap around our ankles like trip wires. The tall grass also hides some gaping holes lurking beneath. The best players know the exact positions of all the holes and manage to detour around them like soldiers zigzagging across a minefield. Most of us, though, endure at least one sprained ankle per game. Another danger is the old baseball infield that we use as the last twenty yards of our gridiron. This area is covered with stones and broken glass. No matter how often we clean it up, we can never keep pace with the broken bottles hurled on the field by the teenagers we call the “night shift.” These people apparently hold drinking parties every night in the abandoned dugout and enjoy throwing the empties out on the field. During every game, we try to avoid falling on especially big chunks of Budweiser bottles. Finally, encircling the entire field is an old, rusty chain-link fence full of tears and holes. Being slammed into the fence during the play can mean a painful stabbing by the jagged wires. All these dangers have made us less afraid of opposing teams than of the field where we play.

10: Adding Details to Complete a Paragraph

Activity 18

Each of the following paragraphs needs specific details to back up its supporting points. In the spaces provided, add a sentence or two of realistic details for each supporting point. The more specific you are, the more convincing your details are likely to be.

78
79

_____ 1. A Pushover Instructor

We knew after the first few classes that the instructor was a pushover. First of all, he didn’t seem able to control the class.

In addition, he made some course requirements easier when a few students complained.

Finally, he gave the easiest quiz we had ever taken.

2. Helping a Parent in College

There are several ways a family can help a parent who is attending college. First, family members can take over some of the household chores that the parent usually does.

Also, family members can make sure that the student has some quiet study time.

Last, families can take an interest in the student’s problems and accomplishments.

79
80

11: Writing a Simple Paragraph

You know now that an effective paragraph does two essential things: (1) it makes a point, and (2) it provides specific details to support that point. You have considered a number of paragraphs that are effective because they follow these two basic steps or ineffective because they fail to follow them.

You are ready, then, to write a simple paragraph of your own. Choose one of the three assignments below, and follow carefully the guidelines provided.

Writing Assignment 1

Turn back to the activity on [page 76](#) and select the point for which you have the best supporting details. Develop that point into a paragraph by following these steps:

- a. If necessary, rewrite the point so that the first sentence is more specific or suits your purpose more exactly. For example, you might want to rewrite the second point so that it includes a specific time and place: “Dinner at the Union Building Cafeteria was terrible yesterday.”

- b. Provide several sentences of information to develop each of your three supporting details fully. Make sure that all the information in your paragraph truly supports your point.
- c. Use the words *First of all*, *Second*, and *Finally* to introduce your three supporting details.
- d. Conclude your paragraph with a sentence that refers to your opening point. This last sentence “rounds off” the paragraph and lets the reader know that your discussion is complete. For example, the paragraph “Changes in the Family” on [page 47](#) begins with “Changes in our society in recent years have weakened family life.” It closes with a statement that refers to, and echoes, the opening point: “Clearly, modern life is a challenge to family life.”
- e. Supply a title based on your point. For instance, point 4 on [page 76](#) might have the title “Ways to Economize.”

Use the following list to check your paragraph for each of the above items:

YES	NO	
_____	_____	Do you begin with a point?
_____	_____	Do you provide relevant, specific details that support the point?
_____	_____	Do you use the words <i>First of all</i> , <i>Second</i> , and <i>Finally</i> to introduce your three supporting details?
_____	_____	Do you have a closing sentence?

80

YES	NO	
_____	_____	Do you have a title based on your point?
_____	_____	Are your sentences clear and free of obvious errors?

81

Writing Assignment 2

In this chapter you have read two paragraphs ([pages 51–53](#)) on reasons for being in college. For this assignment, write a paragraph describing your own reasons for being in college. You might want to look first at the following list of common reasons students give for going to school. Write a check mark next to each reason that applies to you. If you have different reasons for being in college that are not listed here, add them to the list. Then select your three most important reasons for being in school and generate specific supporting details for each reason.

Before starting, reread paragraph A on [page 60](#). *You must provide comparable specific details of your own.* Make your paragraph truly personal; do not fall back on vague generalities like those in paragraph B on [page 61](#). As you work on your paragraph, use the checklist for [Writing Assignment 1](#) as a guide.

APPLY IN MY CASE **Reasons Students Go to College**

- _____ To have some fun before getting a job
- _____ To prepare for a specific career
- _____ To please their families
- _____ To educate and enrich themselves
- _____ To be with friends who are going to college
- _____ To take advantage of an opportunity they didn't have before
- _____ To find a husband or wife
- _____ To see if college has anything to offer them
- _____ To do more with their lives than they've done so far
- _____ To take advantage of Veterans Administration benefits or other special funding
- _____ To earn the status that they feel comes with a college degree
- _____ To get a new start in life
- _____ Other: _____

81

82

Writing Assignment 3

Write a paragraph about stress in your life. Choose three of the following stressful areas and provide specific examples and details to develop each area.

- Stress at school
- Stress at work
- Stress at home
- Stress with a friend or friends



Use the checklist for [Writing Assignment 1](#) as a guide while you are working on the paragraph.

4: The Third Step in Writing



Look at this photograph and write a paragraph in which you tell a new college student how to study for an important exam. Once you have read through [Chapter 4](#), read your paragraph again. Did you use time order, emphatic order, or a combination of both to organize your paragraph?

This chapter will show you how to

- organize specific evidence in a paper by using a clear method of organization
- connect the specific evidence by using transitions and other connecting words

You know from [Chapter 3](#) that the first two steps in writing an effective paragraph are making a point and supporting the point with specific evidence. This chapter will deal with the third step. You'll learn the chief ways to organize and connect the supporting information in a paper.

Step 3: Organize and Connect the specific Evidence



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At the same time that you are generating the specific details needed to support a point, you should be thinking about ways to organize and connect those details. All the details in your paper must *cohere*, or stick together; when they do, your reader will be able to move smoothly from one bit of supporting information to the next. This chapter will discuss the following ways to organize and connect supporting details: (1) common methods of organization, (2) transition words, and (3) other connecting words.

Common Methods of Organization: Time Order and Emphatic Order

Time order and emphatic order are common methods used to organize the supporting material in a paper. (You will learn more specialized methods of development in Part Two of the book.)

Time order simply means that details are listed as they occur in time. *First* this is done; *next* this; *then* this; *after* that, this; and so on. Here is a paragraph that organizes its details through time order.

How I Relax

The way I relax when I get home from school on Thursday night is, first of all, to put my three children to bed. Next, I run hot water in the tub and put in lots of scented bubble bath. As the bubbles rise, I undress and get into the tub. The water is relaxing to my tired muscles, and the bubbles are tingly on my skin. I lie back and put my feet on the water spigots, with everything but my head under the water. I like to stick my big toe up the spigot and spray water over the tub. After about ten minutes of soaking, I wash myself with scented soap, get out and dry myself off, and put on my nightgown. Then I go downstairs and make myself a ham, lettuce, and tomato sandwich on rye bread and pour myself a tall glass of iced tea with plenty of sugar and ice cubes. I carry these into the living room and turn on the television. To get comfortable, I sit on the couch with a pillow behind me and my legs under me. I enjoy watching The Daily Show or a late movie. The time is very peaceful after a long, hard day of housecleaning, cooking, washing, and attending night class.

Fill in the missing words: “How I relax” uses the following words to help show time order:
_____, _____, _____, _____, and _____.

Emphatic order is sometimes described as “save-the-best-’til-last” order. It means that the most interesting or important detail is placed in the last part of a paper. (In cases where all details seem equal in importance, the writer should impose a personal order that seems logical or appropriate to the details.) The last position in a paper is the most emphatic position because the reader is most likely to remember the last thing read. *Finally*, *last of all*, and *most important* are typical words and phrases showing emphasis. The following paragraph organizes its details through emphatic order.

The National Enquirer

There are several reasons why the National Enquirer is so popular. First of all, the paper is advertised on television. In the ads, attractive-looking people say, with a smile, “I want to know!” as they scan the pages of the Enquirer. The ads reassure people that it’s all right to want to read stories such as “Heartbreak for Jennifer Lopez” or “Prince’s Fiancée in New Royal Topless Scandal.” In addition, the paper is easily available. In supermarkets, convenience stores, and drugstores, the Enquirer is always displayed in racks close to the cash register. As customers wait in line, they can’t help being attracted to the paper’s glaring headlines. Then, on impulse, customers will add the paper to their other purchases. Most of all, people read the Enquirer because they love gossip. We find other people’s lives fascinating, especially if those people are rich and famous. We want to see and read about their homes, their clothes, and their friends, lovers, and families. We also take a kind of mean delight in their unflattering photos and problems and mistakes, perhaps because we envy them. Even though we may be ashamed of our interest, it’s hard to resist buying a paper that promises “The Forbidden Love of Paris Hilton” or “Film Star Who Now Looks Like a Cadaver” or even “Hollywood Star Wars: Who Hates Whom and Why.” The Enquirer knows how to get us interested and make us buy.

Fill in the missing words: The paragraph lists a total of _____ different reasons people read the *National Enquirer*. The writer of the paragraph feels that the most important reason is _____. He or she signals this reason by using the emphasis words _____.

Some paragraphs use a *combination of time order and emphatic order*. For example, “Good-Bye, Tony” on [page 50](#) includes time order: it moves from the time Tony arrived to the end of the evening. In addition, the writer uses emphatic order, ending with her most important reason (signaled by the words *most of all*) for not wanting to date Tony anymore.

Transitions



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Look at the following items. Then check (✓) the one that is easier to read and understand.

- _____ Our landlord repainted our apartment. He replaced the dishwasher.
- _____ Our landlord repainted our apartment. Also, he replaced the dishwasher.

You probably found the second item easier to understand. The word *also* makes it clear that the writer is adding a second way the landlord has been of help. *Transitions*, or *transition words*, are signal words that help readers follow the direction of the writer’s thoughts. They show the relationship between ideas, connecting thoughts. They are “bridge” words, carrying the reader across from one idea to the next.



Two major types of transitions are of particular help when you write: words that show *addition* and words that show *time*.

Words That Show Addition

Check (✓) the item that is easier to read and understand.

- 1.
 - _____ a. A drinking problem can destroy a person’s life. It can tear a family apart.
 - _____ b. A drinking problem can destroy a person’s life. In addition, it can tear a family apart.
- 2.
 - _____ a. One way to lose friends is always to talk and never to listen. A way to end friendships is to borrow money and never pay it back.
 - _____ b. One way to lose friends is always to talk and never to listen. Another way to end friendships is to borrow money and never pay it back.

In the pair of sentences about a drinking problem, the words *In addition* help make the relationship between the two sentences clear. The author is describing two effects of a drinking problem: it can destroy a life and a family. *In addition*, *another*, and words like these are known as **addition words**. In

the pair of sentences about losing friends, you probably found the second item easier to understand. The word *Another* makes it clear that the writer is describing a second way to lose friends.

Addition words signal added ideas. They help writers organize information and present it clearly to readers. Some common words that show addition are listed in the following box:

Addition Words		
one	to begin with	in addition
first	another	next
first of all	second	last (of all)
for one thing	also	finally

Words That Show Time

Check (✓) the item that is easier to read and understand.

1.

- _____ a. I had blood work done. I went to the doctor.
- _____ b. I had blood work done. Then I went to the doctor.

The word *Then* in the second item makes clear the relationship between the sentences. After having blood work done, the writer goes to the doctor. *Then* and words like it are **time words**, which carry the reader from one idea to the next.



Here are some more pairs of sentences. Check (✓) the item in each pair that contains a time word and so is easier to read and understand.

2.

- _____ a. Every week my uncle studies the food ads to see which stores have the best specials. He clips all the coupons.
- _____ b. Every week my uncle studies the food ads to see which stores have the best specials. Next, he clips all the coupons.

87

3.

- _____ a. Carmen took a very long shower. There was no hot water left for anyone else in the house.

88

_____ b. Carmen took a very long shower. After that, there was no hot water left for anyone else in the house.

In the pair of sentences about the uncle, the word *Next* helps make the relationship between the two sentences clear. The uncle studies ads, and then he clips coupons. In the second pair of sentences, the word *after* makes the relationship clear: after Carmen’s long shower, there was no hot water left for anyone else.

Time words tell us *when* something happened in relation to when something else happened. They help writers organize and make clear the order of events, stages, and steps in a process. Below are some common words that show time.

Time Words		
before	next	later
first	as	after
second	when	finally
third	while	then

Activity 1

1. Fill in each blank with the appropriate addition transition from the list that follows. Use each transition once.

another finally one



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There are some widely popular but inappropriate methods that people have to combat stress. _____ common strategy is to consume massive quantities of junk food, which is easily done thanks to all the ever-present convenience stores and fast-food restaurants. _____ way to deal with stress is to doze or sleep for hours and hours, even during the day. _____, watching hours of nonstop TV can put people in a stupor that helps them forget the problems of everyday life.

2. Fill in each blank with the appropriate time transition from the list that follows. Use each transition once.

then	next	before
first	after	

88
89

I do not like to write. In fact, I dislike writing so much that I have developed a series of steps for postponing the agony of doing writing assignments. _____ I tell myself that to proceed without the proper equipment would be unwise. So I go out to buy a new pen, and this kills at least an hour. _____, I begin to stare at the blank page. _____ long, however, I realize that writing may also require thought, so I begin to think deeply about my subject. Soon I feel drowsy. This naturally leads to the conclusion that I need a nap because I can't throw myself into my writing until I am at my very best. _____ a refreshing nap, I again face the blank page. It is usually at this stage that I actually write a sentence or two—disappointing ones. I _____ wisely decide that I need inspiration, perhaps from an interesting magazine or my new Xbox game. If I feel a bit guilty, I comfort myself with the knowledge that, as any artist knows, you can't rush these things.

3. Underline the three *addition* signals in the following paragraph:

I am opposed to state-supported lotteries for a number of reasons. First of all, by supporting lotteries, states are supporting gambling. I don't see anything morally wrong with gambling, but it is a known cause of suffering for many people who do it to excess. The state should be concerned with relieving suffering, not causing it. Another objection I have to state lotteries is the kind of advertising they do on television. The commercials promote the lotteries as an easy way to get rich. In fact, the odds against getting rich are astronomical. Last, the lotteries take advantage of the people who can least afford them. Studies have shown that people with lower incomes are more likely to play the lottery than people with higher incomes. This is the harshest reality of the lotteries: the state is encouraging people of limited means not to save their money but to throw it away on a state-supported pipe dream.

4. Underline the four *time* signals in the following paragraph:

It is often easy to spot bad drivers on the road because they usually make more than one mistake: they make their mistakes in series. First, for example, you may notice that a man is tailgating you. Then, almost as soon as you notice, he has passed you in a no-passing zone. That's two mistakes already in a matter of seconds. Next, almost invariably, you see him speed down the road and pass someone else. Finally, as you watch in disbelief, glad that he's out of your way, he speeds through a red light or cuts across oncoming traffic in a wild left turn.

89
90

Other Kinds of Transitions

In the following box are other common transitional words, grouped according to the kind of signal they give readers. In the paragraphs you write, you will most often use addition words (like *first*, *also*, *another*, and *finally*), but all of the following signals are helpful to know as well.

Other Common Transitional Words

Space signals: next to, across, on the opposite side, to the left, to the right, in front, in back, above, below, behind, nearby

Change-of-direction signals: but, however, yet, in contrast, otherwise, still, on the contrary, on the other hand

Illustration signals: for example, for instance, specifically, as an illustration, once, such as

Conclusion signals: therefore, consequently, thus, then, as a result, in summary, to conclude, last of all, finally

Activity 2

- 1. Underline the three *space signals* in the following paragraph:

Standing in the burned-out shell of my living room was a shocking experience. Above my head were charred beams, all that remained of our ceiling. In front of me, where our television and stereo had once stood, were twisted pieces of metal and chunks of blackened glass. Strangely, some items seemed little damaged by the fire. For example, I could see the remote control and a dusty DVD under the rubble. I walked through the gritty ashes until I came to what was left of our sofa. Behind the sofa had been a wall of family photographs. Now, the wall and the pictures were gone. I found only a waterlogged scrap of our framed wedding picture.

90

2. Underline the four *change-of-direction signals* in the following paragraph:

In some ways, train travel is superior to air travel. People always marvel at the speed with which airplanes can zip from one end of the country to another. Trains, on the other hand, definitely take longer. But sometimes longer can be better. Traveling across the country by train allows you to experience the trip more completely. You get to see the cities and towns, mountains and prairies that too often pass by unnoticed when you fly. Another advantage of train travel is comfort. Traveling by plane means wedging yourself into a narrow seat with your knees bumping the back of the seat in front of you and, if you're lucky, being handed a "snack" consisting of a bag of pretzels. In contrast, the seats on most trains are spacious and comfortable, permitting even the longest-legged traveler to stretch out and watch the scenery just outside the window. And when train travelers grow hungry, they can get up and stroll to the dining car, where they can order anything from a simple snack to a full meal. There's no question that train travel is definitely slow and old-fashioned compared with air travel. However, in many ways it is much more civilized.

3. Underline the three *illustration signals* in the following selection:

Status symbols are all around us. The cars we drive, for instance, say something about who we are and how successful we have been. The auto makers depend on this perception of automobiles, designing their commercials to show older, well-established people driving luxury sedans and young, fun-loving people driving to the beach in sports cars. Clothing, too, has always been a status symbol. Specifically, schoolchildren are often rated by their classmates according to the brand names of their clothing. Another example of a status symbol is the cell phone. This device, not so long ago considered a novelty, is now used by almost everyone. Being without a cell phone in the twenty-first century is like being without a regular phone in the 1990s.

4. Underline the *conclusion signal* in the following paragraph:

A hundred years ago, miners used to bring caged canaries down into the mines with them to act as warning signals. If the bird died, the miners knew that the oxygen was running out. The smaller animal would be affected much more quickly than the miners. In the same way, animals are acting as warning signals to us today. Baby birds die before they can hatch because pesticides in the environment cause the adults to lay eggs with paper-thin shells. Fish die when lakes are contaminated with acid rain or poisonous mercury. The dangers in our environment will eventually affect all life on earth, including humans. Therefore, we must pay attention to these early warning signals. If we don't, we will be as foolish as a miner who ignored a dead canary—and we will die.

Other Connecting Words



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In addition to transitions, there are three other kinds of connecting words that help tie together the specific evidence in a paper: *repeated words*, *pronouns*, and *synonyms*.

Repeated Words

Many of us have been taught by English instructors—correctly so—not to repeat ourselves in our writing. On the other hand, repeating key words can help tie ideas together. In the paragraph that follows, the word *retirement* is repeated to remind readers of the key idea on which the discussion is centered. Underline the word the five times it appears.

Oddly enough, retirement can pose more problems for a homemaker than for his or her retiring spouse. For a person who has been accustomed to a demanding job, retirement can mean frustration and a feeling of uselessness. This feeling will put pressure on the stay-at-home spouse to provide challenges equal to those of the workplace. Often, these tasks will disrupt the homemaker’s well-established routine. Another problem arising from retirement is filling up all those empty hours. The spouse of a retired person may find himself or herself in the role of social director or tour guide, expected to come up with a new form of amusement every day. Without sufficient challenges or leisure activities, a person can become irritable and take out the resulting boredom and frustration of retirement on the homemaker. It is no wonder that many of these partners wish their spouses would come out of retirement and do something—anything—just to get out of the house.

92

Pronouns

93

Pronouns (*he, she, it, you, they, this, that*, and others) are another way to connect ideas as you develop a paper. Using pronouns to take the place of other words or ideas can help you avoid needless repetition. (Be sure, though, to use pronouns with care in order to avoid the unclear or inconsistent pronoun references described in [Chapters 28](#) and [29](#) of this book.) Underline the eight pronouns in the passage that follows, noting at the same time the words that the pronouns refer to.

A professor of nutrition at a major university recently advised his students that they could do better on their examinations by eating lots of sweets. He told them that the sugar in cakes and candy would stimulate their brains to work more efficiently, and that if the sugar was eaten for only a month or two, it would not do them any harm.

Synonyms

Using *synonyms*— words that are alike in meaning—can also help move the reader from one thought to the next. In addition, the use of synonyms increases variety and interest by avoiding needless repetition of the same words. Underline the three words used as synonyms for *false ideas* in the following passage.

There are many false ideas about suicide. One wrong idea is that a person who talks about suicide never follows through. The truth is that about three out of every four people who commit suicide notify one or more other persons ahead of time. Another misconception is that a person who commits suicide is poor or downtrodden. Actually, poverty appears to be a deterrent to suicide rather than a predisposing factor. A third myth about suicide is that people bent on suicide will eventually take their lives one way or another, whether or not the most obvious means of suicide is removed from their reach. In fact, since an attempt at suicide is often a kind of cry for help, removing a convenient means of taking one's life, such as a gun, shows people bent on suicide that someone cares enough about them to try to prevent it.

Activity 3

Read the selection below and then answer the questions about it that follow.

My Worst Experience of the Week

¹The registration process at State College was a nightmare. ²The night before registration officially began, I went to bed anxious about the whole matter, and nothing that happened the next day served to ease my tension. ³First, even though I had paid my registration fee early last spring, the people at the bursar's office had no record of my payment. ⁴And for some bizarre reason, they wouldn't accept the receipt I had. ⁵Consequently, I had to stand in line for two hours, waiting for someone to give me a slip of paper which stated that I had, in fact, paid my registration fee. ⁶The need for this new receipt seemed ludicrous to me, since all along I had proof that I had paid. ⁷I was next told that I had to see my adviser in the Law and Justice Department and that the department was in Corridor C of the Triad Building. ⁸I had no idea what or where the Triad was. ⁹But, finally, I found my way to the ugly gray-white building. ¹⁰Then I began looking for Corridor C. ¹¹When I found it, everyone there was a member of the Communications Department. ¹²No one seemed to know where Law and Justice had gone. ¹³Finally, one instructor said she thought Law and Justice was in Corridor A. ¹⁴"And where is Corridor A?" I asked. ¹⁵"I don't know," the teacher answered. ¹⁶"I'm new here." ¹⁷She saw the bewildered look on my face and said sympathetically, "You're not the only one who's confused." ¹⁸I nodded and walked numbly away. ¹⁹I felt as if I were fated to spend the rest of the semester trying to complete the registration process, and I wondered if I would ever become an official college student.

Questions

- 1. How many times is the key word *registration* used?
- 2. Write here the pronoun that is used for *people at the bursar’s office* (sentence 4):_____ ; *Corridor C* (sentence 11):_____ ; *instructor* (sentence 17): _____.
- 3. Write here the words that are used as a synonym for *receipt* (sentence 5):

the words that are used as a synonym for *Triad* (sentence 9):

the word that is used as a synonym for *instructor* (sentence 15):

94

94

95

Complete the following statements.

- 1. Time order means
- 2. Emphatic order means
- 3. _____are signal words that help readers follow the direction of a writer’s thought.
- 4. In addition to transitions, three other kinds of connecting words that help link sentences and ideas are repeated words, _____, and _____.

Practice in Organizing and Connecting Specific Evidence

You now know the third step in effective writing: organizing and connecting the specific evidence used to support the main point of a paper. This closing section will expand and strengthen your understanding of the third step in writing.

You will work through the following series of activities:

- Organizing through Time Order
- Organizing through Emphatic Order
- Organizing through a Combination of Time Order and Emphatic Order
- Identifying Transitions
- Identifying Transitions and Other Connecting Words

Organizing through Time Order

Activity 4

Use time order to organize the scrambled list of sentences below. Write the number 1 beside the point that all the other sentences support. Then number each supporting sentence as it occurs in time.

- _____ The table is right near the garbage can.
- _____ So you reluctantly select a glue-like tuna-fish sandwich, a crushed apple pie, and watery, lukewarm coffee.
- _____ You sit at the edge of the table, away from the garbage can, and gulp down your meal. Trying to eat in the cafeteria is an unpleasant experience.
- _____ Suddenly you spot a free table in the center.
- _____ With a last swallow of the lukewarm coffee, you get up and leave the cafeteria as rapidly as possible.
- _____ Flies are flitting into and out of the trash.
- _____ By the time it is your turn, the few things that are almost good are gone.
- _____ There does not seem to be a free table anywhere.
- _____ Unfortunately, there is a line in the cafeteria.
- _____ The hoagies, coconut-custard pie, and iced tea have all disappeared.
- _____ You hold your tray and look for a place to sit down.
- _____ You have a class in a few minutes, and so you run in to grab something to eat quickly.

95

96

Organizing through Emphatic Order

Activity 5

Use emphatic order (order of importance) to arrange the following scrambled list of sentences. Write the number 1 beside the point that all the other sentences support. Then number each supporting sentence, starting with what seems to be the least important detail and ending with the most important detail.

- _____ The people here are all around my age and seem to be genuinely friendly and interested in me.
- _____ The place where I live has several important advantages.

_____ The schools in this neighborhood have a good reputation, so I feel that my daughter is getting a good education. _____ The best thing of all about this area, though, is the school system. _____ Therefore, I don't have to put up with public transportation or worry about how much it's going to cost to park each day. _____ The school also has an extended day-care program, so I know my daughter is in good hands until I come home from work. _____ First of all, I like the people who live in the other apartments near mine. _____ Another positive aspect of this area is that it's close to where I work. _____ That's more than I can say for the last place I lived, where people stayed behind locked doors.	96
_____ The office where I'm a receptionist is only a six-block walk from my house. _____ In addition, I save a lot of wear and tear on my car.	97

Organizing through a Combination of Time Order and Emphatic Order

Activity 6

Use a combination of time and emphatic order to arrange the scrambled list of sentences below. Write the number 1 beside the point that all the other sentences support. Then number each supporting sentence. Paying close attention to transitional words and phrases will help you organize and connect the supporting sentences.

- _____ I did not see the spider but visited my friend in the hospital, where he suffered through a week of nausea and dizziness because of the poison.
- _____ We were listening to the radio when we discovered that nature was calling.
- _____ As I got back into the car, I sensed, rather than felt or saw, a presence on my left hand.
- _____ After these two experiences, I suspect that my fear of spiders will be with me until I die.
- _____ The first experience was the time when my best friend received a bite from a black widow spider.
- _____ I looked down at my hand, but I could not see anything because it was so dark.
- _____ I had two experiences when I was sixteen that are the cause of my *arachnophobia*, a terrible and uncontrollable fear of spiders.
- _____ We stopped the car at the side of the road, walked into the woods a few feet, and watered the leaves.

_____ My friend then entered the car, putting on the dashboard light, and I almost passed out with horror. _____ I saw the bandage on his hand and the puffy swelling when the bandage was removed. _____ Then it flew off my hand and into the dark bushes nearby. _____ I sat in the car for an hour afterward, shaking and sweating and constantly rubbing the fingers of my hand to reassure myself that the spider was no longer there. _____ But my more dramatic experience with spiders happened one evening when another friend and I were driving around in his car.	97
_____ Almost completely covering my fingers was a monstrous brown spider, with white stripes running down each of a seemingly endless number of long, furry legs. _____ Most of all, I saw the ugly red scab on his hand and the yellow pus that continued oozing from under the scab for several weeks. _____ I imagined my entire hand soon disappearing as the behemoth relentlessly devoured it. _____ At the same time, I cried out “Arghh!” and flicked my hand violently back and forth to shake off the spider. _____ For a long, horrible second it clung stickily, as if intertwined for good among the fingers of my hand.	98

Identifying Transitions

Activity 7

Fill in each blank with the appropriate addition transition from the following list. Use each transition once.

also second for one thing last of all

Why School May Frighten a Young Child

School may be frightening to young children for a number of reasons. _____, the regimented environment may be a new and disturbing experience. At home, children may have been able to do what they wanted when they wanted to do it. In school, however, they are given set times for talking, working, playing, eating, and even using the rest room. A _____ source of anxiety may be the public method of discipline that some teachers use. Whereas at home children are scolded in private, in school they may be held up to embarrassment and ridicule in front of their peers. "Bonnie," the teacher may say, "why are you the only one in class who didn't do your homework?" Or, "David, why are you the only one who can't work quietly at your seat?" Children may _____ be frightened by the loss of personal attention. Their little discomforts or mishaps, such as tripping on the stairs, may bring instant sympathy from a parent; in school, there is often no one to notice, or the teacher is frequently too busy to care and just says, "Go do your work. You'll be all right." _____, a child may be scared by the competitive environment of the school. At home, one hopes, such competition for attention is minimal. But in school, children may vie for the teacher's approving glance or tone, or for stars on a paper, or for favored seats in the front row. For these and other reasons, it is not surprising that children may have difficulty adjusting to school.

Activity 8

Fill in each blank with the appropriate time transition from the list that follows. Use each transition once.

then first after as later

A Victory for Big Brother

In one of the most terrifying scenes in all of literature, George Orwell in his classic novel *1984* describes how a government known as Big Brother destroys a couple's love. The couple, Winston and Julia, fall in love and meet secretly, knowing the government would not approve. _____ informers turn them in, a government agent named O'Brien takes steps to end their love. _____ he straps Winston down and explains that he has discovered Winston's worst fear. _____ he sets a cage with two giant, starving sewer rats on the table next to Winston. He says that when he presses a lever, the door of the cage will slide up, and the rats will shoot out like bullets and bore straight into Winston's face. _____ Winston's eyes dart back and forth, revealing his terror, O'Brien places his hand on the lever. Winston knows that the only way out is for Julia to take his place. Suddenly, he hears his own voice screaming, "Do it to Julia! Not me! Julia!" Orwell does not describe Julia's interrogation, but when Julia and Winston see each other _____, they realize that each has betrayed the other. Their love is gone. Big Brother has won.

Activity 9

Fill in each blank with the appropriate addition or change-of-direction transition from the list that follows. Use each transition once.

however also next finally but first

Watching TV Football

Watching a football game on television may seem like the easiest thing in the world. _____, like the game of football itself, watching a game correctly is far more complicated than it appears. _____ is the matter of what company you invite. The ideal number of people depends on the size of your living room. You should _____ invite at least one person who will be rooting for the opposite team. There's nothing like a little rivalry to increase the enjoyment of a football game. _____, you must attend to the refreshments. Make sure to have on hand plenty of everyone's favorite drinks, along with the essential chips, dips, and pretzels. You may even want something more substantial on hand, like sandwiches or pizza. If you do, make everyone wait until the moment of kickoff before eating. Waiting will make everything taste much better. _____, there is one bit of sports equipment you should have on hand: a football. In the spirit of the occasion, it is good to have a football to toss around outside during halftime. _____ if your team happens to be getting trounced, you may decide not to wait until halftime.

Activity 10

Fill in each blank with the appropriate addition or change-of-direction transitions from the list that follows. Use each transition once.

- fourth
- but
- yet
- another
- for one thing
- second
- however
- last

Avoidance Tactics

Getting down to studying for an exam or writing a paper is hard, and so it is tempting for students to use one of the following five avoidance tactics in order to put the work aside. _____ students may say to themselves, "I can't do it!" They adopt a defeatist attitude at the start and give up without a struggle. They could get help with their work by using such college services as tutoring programs and skill labs. _____ they refuse even to try. A _____ avoidance technique is to say, "I'm too busy." Students may take on an extra job, become heavily involved in social activities, or allow family problems to become so time-consuming that they cannot concentrate on their studies. _____ if college really matters to a student, he or she will make sure that there is enough time to do the required work. _____ avoidance technique is expressed by the phrase "I'm too tired." Typically, sleepiness occurs when it is time to study or go to class and then vanishes when the pressure of school is off. This sleepiness is a sign of work avoidance. A _____ excuse is to say "I'll do it later." Putting things off until the last minute is practically a guarantee of poor grades on tests and papers. When everything else—watching TV, calling a friend, or even cleaning the oven—seems more urgent than studying, a student may simply be escaping academic work. _____ some students avoid work by saying to themselves, "I'm here and that's what counts." Some students live under the dangerous delusion that, since they possess a college ID, a parking sticker, and textbooks, the course work will somehow take care of itself. _____ once a student has a college ID, he or she has only just begun. Doing the necessary studying, writing, and reading will bring real results: good grades, genuine learning, and a sense of accomplishment.

Activity 11

Fill in each blank with the appropriate transition from the following list. Use each transition once.

Addition transitions: first of all, second, finally

Time transition: when

Illustration transition: once

Change-of-direction transition: however

Conclusion transition: as a result

Joining a Multicultural Club

One of the best things I've done in college is joining a multicultural club. _____, the club has helped me become friendly with a diverse group of people. At any time in my apartment, I can have someone from Pakistan or Sweden chatting about music, or someone from Russia or Uganda talking about politics. _____, I watched a Spanish student serve *chocolate con churros* to three students from China. They had never tasted such a thing before, but they liked it. A _____ benefit of the club is that it's helped me realize how similar people are. _____ the whole club first assembled, we wound up having a conversation about dating and sex that included the perspectives of people from fifteen countries and six continents! It was clear we all shared the feeling that sex was fascinating. The talk lasted for hours, with many different people describing the wildest or funniest dating experience they had had. Only a few students, particularly those from the United States and Japan, seemed bashful. _____, the club has reminded me about the dangers of stereotyping. Before I joined the club, my only direct experience with people from China was ordering meals in the local Chinese restaurant. _____, I believed that most Chinese people ate lots of rice and worked in restaurants. In the club, _____ I met Chinese people who were soccer players, English majors, and math tutors. I've also seen Jewish and Muslim students—people who I thought would never get along—drop their preconceived notions and become friends. Even more than my classes, the club has been an educational experience for me.

Identifying Transitions and Other Connecting Words

Activity 12

This activity will give you practice in identifying transitions and other connecting words that are used to help tie ideas together.

Section A—Transitions

Locate the transitional word in each sentence and write it in the space provided.

1. I decided to pick up a drop-add form from the registrar’s office. However, I changed my mind when I saw the long line of students waiting there.

2. In England, drivers use the left-hand side of the road. Consequently, in a car the steering wheel is on the right side.

3. Crawling babies will often investigate new objects by putting them in their mouths. Therefore, parents should be alert for any pins, tacks, or other dangerous items on floors and carpets.

102

4. One technique that advertisers use is to have a celebrity endorse a product. The consumer then associates that product with the star qualities of the celebrity.

103

Section B—Repeated Words

In the space provided, write the repeated words.

5. We absorb radiation from many sources in our environment. Our cell phones and microwave ovens, among other things, give off low-level radiation.

6. Many researchers believe that people have weight set-points their bodies try to maintain. This may explain why many dieters return to their original weight.

7. At the end of the concert, thousands of fans held up lighters in the darkened stadium. The sea of lighters signaled that the fans wanted an encore.

8. Establishing credit is important for everyone. A good credit history is often necessary when applying for a loan or credit card.
- _____

Section C—Synonyms

In the space provided, write the synonym for the underlined word.

9. I checked my car's tires, oil, water, and belts before the trip. But the ungrateful machine sputtered and died about fifty miles from home.
- _____
10. Women's clothes, in general, use less material than men's clothes. Yet women's garments usually cost more than men's.
- _____
11. The temperance movement in this country sought to ban alcohol. Drinking liquor, movement leaders said, led to violence, poverty, prostitution, and insanity.
- _____
12. For me, apathy quickly sets in when the weather becomes hot and sticky. This listlessness disappears when the humidity decreases.
- _____

103

Section D—Pronouns

In the space provided, write the word referred to by the underlined pronoun.

13. At the beginning of the twentieth century, bananas were still an oddity in the United States. Some people even attempted to eat them with the skin on.
- _____
14. Canning vegetables is easy and economical. It can also be very dangerous.
- _____
15. There are a number of signs that appear when students are under stress. For example, they start to have trouble studying, eating, and even sleeping.
- _____

104

5: The Fourth Step in Writing



Write a paragraph about your initial reaction to this photograph. Do you feel the farmer is doing something wrong or unethical by injecting plant hormones into the tomato to bring about ripening?

This chapter will show you how to

- revise so that your sentences flow smoothly and clearly
- edit so that your sentences are error-free

105

Step 4: Write Clear, Error-Free Sentences

106

Up to now this book has emphasized the first three steps in writing an effective paragraph: making a point ([Chapter 3](#)), supporting the point ([Chapter 3](#)), and organizing and connecting the evidence ([Chapter 4](#)). This chapter will focus on the fourth step: writing clear, error-free sentences. You'll learn how to revise a paragraph so that your sentences flow smoothly and clearly. Then you'll review how to edit a paragraph for mistakes in grammar, punctuation, and spelling.

Revising Sentences

The following strategies will help you to revise your sentences effectively.

- Use parallelism.
- Use a consistent point of view.
- Use specific words.
- Use concise wording.
- Vary your sentences.

Use Parallelism



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Words in a pair or a series should have a parallel structure. By balancing the items in a pair or a series so that they have the same kind of structure, you will make a sentence clearer and easier to read. Notice how the parallel sentences that follow read more smoothly than the nonparallel ones.

Nonparallel (Not Balanced)

I resolved to lose weight, to study more, and *watching* less TV.

A consumer group rates my car as noisy, expensive, and *not having much safety*.

Lola likes wearing soft sweaters, eating exotic foods, and *to bathe* inscented bath oil.

Single life offers more freedom of choice; *more security is offered by marriage*.

Parallel (Balanced)

I resolved to lose weight, to study more, and to watch less TV. (A balanced series of *to* verbs: *to lose, to study, to watch*)

A consumer group rates my car as noisy, expensive, and unsafe. (A balanced series of descriptive words: *noisy, expensive, unsafe*)

Lola likes wearing soft sweaters, eating exotic foods, and bathing inscented bath oil.

(A balanced series of *-ing* words: *wearing, eating, bathing*)

Single life offers more freedom of choice; marriage offers more security. (Balanced verbs and word order: *single life offers . . . ; marriage offers . . .*)

106

107

TIP

You need not worry about balanced sentences when writing first drafts. But when you rewrite, try to put matching words and ideas into matching structures. Such parallelism will improve your writing style.

Activity 1

Cross out and revise the unbalanced part of each of the following sentences.

EXAMPLE

When Gail doesn't have class, she uses her time to clean house, ~~to get~~ her laundry done, and to buy groceries.

- 1. Lola plans to become a model, a lawyer, or to go into nursing.
- 2. Filling out an income tax form is worse than wrestling a bear or to walk on hot coals.
- 3. The study-skills course taught me how to take more effective notes, to read a textbook chapter, and preparing for exams.
- 4. Home Depot has huge sections devoted to plumbing equipment, electrical supplies, and tools needed for carpentry.
- 5. Martha Grencher likes to water her garden, walking her pug, and arguing with her husband.
- 6. Filled with talent and ambitious, Eduardo worked hard at his sales job.
- 7. When I saw my roommate with my girlfriend, I felt worried, angry, and embarrassment.
- 8. Cindy's cat likes sleeping in the dryer, lying in the bathtub, and to chase squirrels.
- 9. The bacon was fatty, grease was on the potatoes, and the eggs were cold.
- 10. People in the lobby munched popcorn, sipped sodas, and were shuffling their feet impatiently.

107

Use a Consistent Point of View

108

Consistency with Verbs

Do not shift verb tenses unnecessarily. If you begin writing a paper in the present tense, don't shift suddenly to the past. If you begin in the past, don't shift without reason to the present. Notice the inconsistent verb tenses in the following example:

Incorrect The shoplifter *walked* quickly toward the front of the store. When a clerk *shouts* at him, he *started* to run.

The verbs must be consistently in the present tense:

Correct The shoplifter *walks* quickly toward the front of the store. When a clerk *shouts* at him, he *starts* to run.

Or the verbs must be consistently in the past tense:

Correct The shoplifter *walked* quickly toward the front of the store. When a clerk *shouted* at him, he *started* to run.

Activity 2

In each passage, one verb must be changed so that it agrees in tense with the other verbs. Cross out the incorrect verb and write the correct form above each crossed-out verb.

EXAMPLE

Kareem wanted to be someplace else when the dentist ~~waited~~ in a long needle.

- 1. I listened to music and surfed the Internet before I decide to do some homework.
- 2. The hitchhiker stopped me as I walks from the turnpike rest station and said, “Are you on your way to San Jose?”
- 3. Some students attend all their classes in school and listen carefully during lectures, but they don’t take notes. As a result, they often failed tests.
- 4. His parents stayed together for his sake; only after he graduates from college did they get divorced.
- 5. In the movie, artillery shells exploded on the hide of the reptile monster. The creature just grinned, tosses off the shells, and kept eating people.

108

- 6. Several months a year, monarch butterflies come to live in a spot along the California coast. Thousands and thousands of them hang from the trees and fluttered through the air in large groups.
- 7. After waking up each morning, Harry stays in bed for a while. First he stretches and yawned loudly, and then he plans his day.
- 8. The salespeople at Biggs’s Department Store are very helpful. When people asked for a product the store doesn’t carry or is out of, the salesperson recommends another store.
- 9. Part-time workers at the company are the first to be laid off. They are also paid less, and they received no union representation.
- 10. Smashed cars, ambulances, and police cars blocked traffic on one side of the highway. On the other side, traffic slows down as drivers looked to see what had happened.

109

Consistency with Pronouns

Pronouns should not shift point of view unnecessarily. When writing a paper, be consistent in your use of first-, second-, or third-person pronouns.

Type of Pronoun	Singular	Plural
First-person pronouns	I (my, mine, me)	we (our, us)
Second-person pronouns	you (your)	you (your)
Third-person pronouns	he (his, him) she (her) it (its)	they (their, them)

TIP

Any person, place, or thing, as well as any indefinite pronoun like *one*, *anyone*, *someone*, and so on, is a third-person word.

If you start writing in the third person *she*, don't jump suddenly to the second person *you* . Or if you are writing in the first person *I*, don't shift unexpectedly to *one*. Look at the examples that follow:

Inconsistent

I enjoy movies like *The Return of the Vampire* that frighten *you*. (A very common mistake people make is to let *you* slip into their writing after they start with another pronoun.)
As soon as a person walks into Helen's apartment, *you* can tell that Helen owns a cat.
(Again, *you* is a shift in point of view.)

Consistent

I enjoy movies like *The Return of the Vampire* that frighten me.

As soon as a person walks into Helen's apartment, *he or she* can tell that Helen owns a cat.
(See also the coverage of his or her references on [pages 472–473](#).)

Activity 3

Cross out inconsistent pronouns in the following sentences and write the correct form of the pronoun above each crossed-out word. You may have to change the form of the verb as well.

EXAMPLE

My dreams are always the kind that haunt ~~you~~ the next day.

- Whenever we take our children on a trip, *you* have to remember to bring snacks, tissues, and toys.

2. In our society, we often need a diploma before you can be hired for a job. 3. I work at a company where the owners don't provide you with health insurance. 4. If a student organizes time carefully, you can accomplish a great deal of work. 5. Although I know you should watch your cholesterol intake, I can never resist an ear of corn dripping with melted butter. 6. Good conversationalists have the ability to make the person they are talking to feel as if they are the only other person in the room. 7. We never go to the Salad Bowl anymore, because you wait so long to be seated and the waiters usually make mistakes with the order. 8. I'm careful about talking to people on the subway because one can get into some really weird situations.	110
9. We can't afford to move right now, because you need not only the first month's rent but also an extra month's security deposit. 10. In my job as store manager, I'm supposed to be nice to the customer even if they are being totally unreasonable.	111

Use Specific Words

To be an effective writer, you must use specific words rather than general words. Specific words create pictures in the reader's mind. They help capture interest and make your meaning clear. Compare the following general and specific sentences:

General

The boy came down the street.
A bird appeared on the grass.

She stopped the car.

Specific

Theo ran down Woodlawn Avenue.
A blue jay swooped down onto the frost-covered lawn.
Jackie slammed on the brakes of her Hummer.

The specific sentences create clear pictures in our minds. The details *show* us exactly what has happened. Here are four ways to make your sentences specific.

- 1. Use exact names.

She loves her *car*.

Renée loves her *Honda*.

- 2. Use lively verbs.

The garbage truck *went* down Front Street.

The garbage truck *rumbled* down Front Street.

3. Use descriptive words (modifiers) before nouns.

A girl peeked out the window.

A *chubby six-year-old* girl peeked out the *dirty kitchen* window.

4. Use words that relate to the five senses: sight, sound, taste, smell, and touch.

That woman is a karate expert.

That *tiny, silver-haired* woman is a karate expert. (*sight*)

When the dryer stopped, a signal sounded.

When the dryer stopped, a *loud buzzer* sounded. (*sound*)

111

Lola offered me an orange slice.

112

Lola offered me a *sweet, juicy* orange slice. (*taste*)

The real estate agent opened the door of the closet.

The real estate agent opened the door of the *cedar-scented* closet. (*smell*)

I pulled the blanket around me to fight off the wind.

I pulled the *fluffy* blanket around me to fight off the *chilling* wind. (*touch*)

Activity 4

This activity will give you practice in replacing vague, indefinite words with sharp, specific words. Add three or more specific words to replace the general word or words underlined in each sentence. Make changes in the wording of a sentence as necessary.

EXAMPLE

My bathroom cabinet contains many drugs.

My bathroom cabinet contains aspirin, antacids, tranquilizers, and
certain prescription drugs.

1. At the shopping center, we visited several stores.

2. Sunday is my day to take care of chores.

3. Lola enjoys various activities in her spare time.

4. I spent most of my afternoon doing homework.

5. We returned home from vacation to discover that several pests had invaded the house.

112

113

Activity 5

Again, you will practice changing vague, indefinite writing into lively, image-filled writing that helps capture the reader’s interest and makes your meaning clear. With the help of the methods described on [pages 49–62](#) and [71–82](#), add specific details to the sentences that follow. Note the examples.

EXAMPLE

The person got out of the car.

The elderly man carefully lifted himself out of the white Buick.
He got out.

The fans enjoyed the victory.

Many of the City cheered from their raised balconies and cheered wildly when Boston scored the winning touchdown.

1. The lunch was not very good.

2. The animal ran away.

3. An accident occurred.

4. The instructor came into the room.

5. The machine did not work.

Use Concise Wording

Wordiness—using more words than necessary to express a meaning—is often a sign of lazy or careless writing. Your readers may resent the extra time and energy they must spend when you have not done the work needed to make your writing direct and concise.

113

Here are examples of wordy sentences:

114

Anne is of the opinion that the death penalty should be allowed.

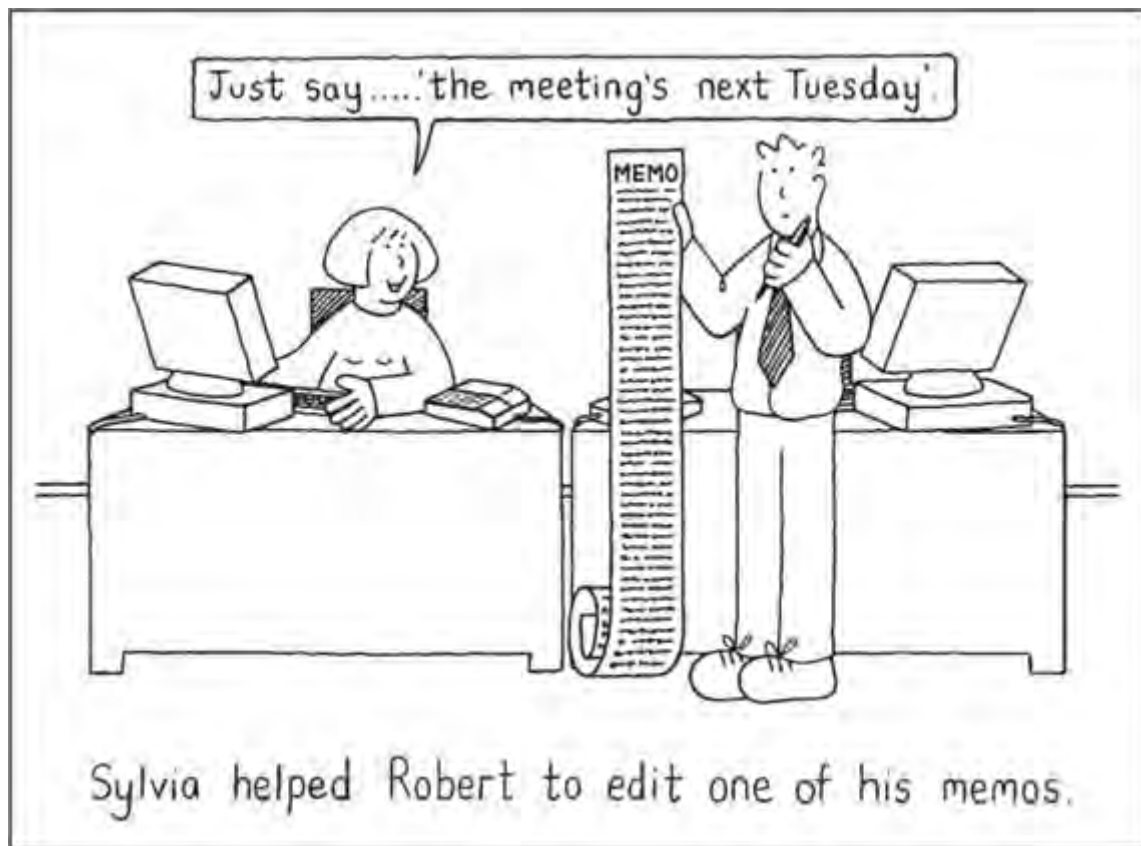
I would like to say that my subject in this paper will be the kind of generous person that my father was.

Omitting needless words improves the sentences:

Anne supports the death penalty.

My father was a generous person.

The following box lists some wordy expressions that could be reduced to single words.



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Wordy Form	Short Form
a large number of	many
a period of a week	a week
arrive at an agreement	agree
at an earlier point in time	before
at the present time	now
big in size	big
owing to the fact that	because
during the time that	while
five in number	five
for the reason that	because
good benefit	benefit
in every instance	always
in my own opinion	I think
in the event that	if
in the near future	soon
in this day and age	today
is able to	can
large in size	large
plan ahead for the future	plan
postponed until later	postponed
red in color	red
return back	return

114

115

Activity 6

Rewrite the following sentences, omitting needless words.

1. After a lot of careful thinking, I have arrived at the conclusion that drunken drivers should receive jail terms.
2. The movie that I went to last night, which was fairly interesting, I must say, was enjoyed by me and my girlfriend.
3. Ben finally made up his mind after a lot of indecisions and decided to look for a new job.

One aspect of effective writing is to vary your sentences. If every sentence follows the same pattern, writing may become monotonous. This chapter explains four ways you can create variety and interest in your writing style. The first two ways involve coordination and subordination—important techniques for achieving different kinds of emphasis.

- Add a second complete thought (coordination).
- Add a dependent thought (subordination).
- Begin with a special opening word or phrase.
- Place adjectives or verbs in a series.

116

When you add a second complete thought to a simple sentence, the result is a *compound* (or double) sentence. The two complete statements in a compound sentence are usually connected by a comma plus a joining, or *coordinating*, word (*and, but, for, or, nor, so, yet*).

Bill has stopped smoking cigarettes, but he is now addicted to chewing gum.

Page 12 of 35

Darrell turned all the lights off, and then he locked the office door.

Activity 7

Combine the following pairs of simple sentences into compound sentences. Use a comma and a logical joining word (*and*, *but*, *for*, *so*) to connect each pair.

HINT

If you are not sure what and, but, for, and so mean, see [pages 435–436](#).

EXAMPLE

- The cars crept along slowly.
- Visibility was poor in the heavy fog.

The most cost-effective way to visibility earnings is the [Amazon](#) fee.

- Lee thought she would never master the spreadsheet program.
- In two weeks she was using it comfortably.

- 2.
 - Vandal smashed the car's headlights.
 - They slashed the tires as well.

- 3.
 - I married at age seventeen.
 - I never got a chance to live on my own.

- 4.
 - Mold grew on my leather boots.
 - The closet was warm and humid.

5. • My father has a high cholesterol count.
- He continues to eat red meat almost every day.

Revise by Adding a Dependent Thought (Subordination)

When you add a dependent thought to a simple sentence, the result is a complex sentence.* A dependent thought begins with a word or phrase like one of the following:

Dependent Words

after	if, even if	when, whenever
although, though	in order that	where, wherever
as	since	whether
because	that, so that	which, whichever
before	unless	while
even though	until	who, whoever
how	what, whatever	whose

117

118

A *complex* sentence is used to emphasize one idea over another. Look at the following complex sentence:

Although I lowered the thermostat, my heating bill remained high.

The idea that the writer wants to emphasize here—*my heating bill remained high*—is expressed as a complete thought. The less important idea—*Although I lowered my thermostat*— is subordinated to this complete thought. The technique of giving one idea less emphasis than another is called *subordination*.

Following are other examples of complex sentences. In each case, the part starting with the dependent word is the less emphasized part of the sentence.

Even though I was tired, I stayed up to watch the horror movie.

Before I take a bath, I check for spiders in the tub.

When Vera feels nervous, she pulls on her earlobe.

Activity 8

Use logical subordinating words to combine the following pairs of simple sentences into sentences that contain a dependent thought. Place a comma after a dependent statement when it starts the sentence.

EXAMPLE

- Our team lost.
- We were not invited to the tournament.

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1. • I receive my degree in June.
- I will begin applying for jobs.

2. • Lola doesn't enjoy cooking.
- She often eats at restaurants.

3. • I sent several letters of complaint.
- The electric company never corrected my bill.

4. • Neil felt his car begin to skid.
- He took his foot off the gas pedal.

5. • The final exam covered sixteen chapters.

118

119

- The students complained.

Revise by Beginning with a Special Opening Word or Phrase

Among the special openers that can be used to start sentences are (1) *-ed* words, (2) *-ing* words, (3) *-ly* words, (4) *to* word groups, and (5) prepositional phrases. Here are examples of all five kinds of openers:

***-ed* word**

Tired from a long day of work, Sharon fell asleep on the sofa.

***-ing* word**

Using a thick towel, Mel dried his hair quickly.

***-ly* word**

Reluctantly, I agreed to rewrite the paper.

***to* word group**

To get to the church on time, you must leave now.

prepositional phrase

With Fred’s help, Martha planted the evergreen shrubs.

Activity 9

Combine each pair of simple sentences into one sentence by using the opener shown at the left and omitting repeated words. Use a comma to set off the opener from the rest of the sentence.

EXAMPLE *-ing* word • The toaster refused to pop up.

- It buzzed like an angry hornet.

Setting like an angry hornet, the toaster refused to pop up.

***-ed* word** 1. • Nate dreaded the coming holidays.

	• He was depressed by his recent divorce.	
-ing word	2. • The star player glided down the court. • He dribbled the basketball like a pro.	
-ly word	3. • I waited in the packed emergency room. • I was impatient.	
to word group	4. • The little boy likes to annoy his parents. • He pretends not to hear them.	
prepositional phrase	5. • People must wear rubber-soled shoes. • They must do this in the gym.	

Revise by Placing Adjectives or Verbs in a Series

Various parts of a sentence may be placed in a series. Among these parts are adjectives (descriptive words) and verbs. Here are examples of both in a series.

Adjectives

The *black, smeary* newsprint rubbed off on my *new butcher-block* table.

Verbs

The quarterback *fumbled* the ball, *recovered* it, and *sighed* with relief.

Activity 10

In each group, combine the simple sentences into one sentence by using adjectives or verbs in a series and by omitting repeated words. In most cases, use a comma between the adjectives or verbs in a series.

EXAMPLE

- Before Christmas, I made fruitcakes.
- I decorated the house.
- I wrapped dozens of toys.

Before Christmas, I made fruitcakes, decorated the house and wrapped dozens of toys.

1. • My lumpy mattress was giving me a cramp in my neck.
- It was causing pains in my back.
 - It was making me lose sleep.

2. • Lights appeared in the fog.
- The lights were flashing.
 - The lights were red.
 - The fog was soupy.
 - The fog was gray.

3. • Before going to bed, I locked all the doors.
- I activated the burglar alarm.
 - I slipped a kitchen knife under my mattress.

	4. • Lola picked sweater hairs off her coat. • The hairs were fuzzy. • The hairs were white. • The coat was brown. • The coat was suede.	121
	5. • The contact lens fell onto the floor. • The contact lens was thin. • The contact lens was slippery. • The floor was dirty. • The floor was tiled.	122

Editing Sentences

After revising sentences in a paragraph so that they flow smoothly and clearly, you need to edit the paragraph for mistakes in grammar, punctuation, mechanics, usage, and spelling. Even if a paragraph is otherwise well-written, it will make an unfavorable impression on readers if it contains such mistakes. To edit a paragraph, check it against the agreed-upon rules or conventions of written English—simply called *sentence skills* in this book. Here are the most common of these conventions:



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- Write complete sentences rather than fragments.
- Do not write run-ons.
- Use verb forms correctly.
- Make sure that subject, verbs, and pronouns agree.

- Eliminate faulty modifiers.
- Use pronoun forms correctly.
- Use capital letters where needed.
- Use the following marks of punctuation correctly: apostrophe, quotation marks, comma, semicolon, colon, hyphen, dash, parentheses.
- Use correct manuscript form.
- Eliminate slang, clichés, and pretentious words.
- Check for possible spelling errors.
- Eliminate careless errors.

These sentence skills are treated in detail in Part Five of this book, and they can be referred to easily as needed. Both the list of sentence skills on the inside back cover and the correction symbols on [page 621](#) include page references so that you can turn quickly to any skill you want to check.

122

Tips for Editing

123

Here are four tips that can help you edit the next-to-final draft of a paragraph for sentence-skills mistakes:

1. Have at hand two essential tools: a good dictionary (see [page 546](#)) and a grammar handbook (you can use the one in this book on [pages 398–621](#)).
2. Use a sheet of paper to cover your paragraph so that you will expose only one sentence at a time. Look for errors in grammar, spelling, and typing. It may help to read each sentence out loud. If a sentence does not read clearly and smoothly, chances are something is wrong.
3. Pay special attention to the kinds of errors you tend to make. For example, if you tend to write run-ons or fragments, be on the lookout for those errors.
4. Try to work on a printed draft, where you'll be able to see your writing more objectively than you can on a handwritten page; use a pen with colored ink so that your corrections will stand out.

A Note on Proofreading

Proofreading means checking the final, edited draft of your paragraph closely for typos and other careless errors. A helpful strategy is to read your paper backward, from the last sentence to the first. This helps keep you from getting caught up in the flow of the paper and missing small mistakes. Here are six helpful proofing symbols:

Proofing Symbol	Meaning	Example
^	insert missing letter or word	beleve ^
g	omit	in the the meantime g
5	reverse order of words or letters	once a upon time 5
#	add space	alltogether #
=	close up space	foot ball =
cap, lc	Add a capital (or a lowercase) letter	My persian Cat cap lc

If you have to make a lot of corrections, type in the corrections and reprint the page.

123

124

Activity 11

In the spaces below this paragraph, write the numbers of the ten word groups that contain fragments or run-ons. Then, in the spaces between the lines, edit by making the necessary corrections. One is done for you as an example.

¹Two groups of researchers have concluded that “getting cold” has little to do with “catching a cold.” ²When the experiment was done for the first time, ³Researchers exposed more than four hundred people to the cold virus. ⁴Then divided those people into three groups. ⁵One group, wearing winter coats, sat around in ten-degree temperatures the second group was placed in sixty-degree temperatures. ⁶With the third group staying in a room. ⁷Where it was eighty degrees. ⁸The number of people who actually caught colds was the same. ⁹In each group. ¹⁰Other researchers repeated this experiment ten years later. ¹¹This time they kept some subjects cozy and warm they submerged others in a tank filled with water. ¹²Whose temperature had been lowered to seventy-five degrees. ¹³They made others sit around in their underwear in forty-degree temperatures. ¹⁴The results were the same, the subjects got sick at the same rate. ¹⁵Proving that people who get cold do not always get colds.

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____
- 4. _____
- 5. _____
- 6. _____
- 7. _____
- 8. _____
- 9. _____
- 10. _____

HINT

A series of editing tests appears on [pages 603–615](#). You will probably find it most helpful to take these tests after reviewing the sentence-skills handbook in Part Five.

Practice in Revising Sentences

You now know the fourth step in effective writing: revising and editing sentences. You also know that practice in *editing* sentences is best undertaken after you have worked through the sentence skills in Part Five. The focus in this closing section, then, will be on *revising* your work—using a variety of methods to ensure that your sentences flow smoothly and are clear and interesting. You will work through review tests that cover the following topics:

124

125

- Using parallelism
- Using a consistent point of view
- Using specific words
- Using concise wording
- Varying your sentences

Using Parallelism

Review Test 1

Cross out the unbalanced part of each sentence. In the space provided, revise the unbalanced part so that it matches the other item or items in the sentence. The first one is done for you as an example.

1. Our professor warned us that he would give surprise tests, ~~the assignment of term papers~~, and allow no makeup exams.

[Assign Term papers](#)

2. Making a big dinner is a lot more fun than to clean up after it.

3. The street-corner preacher stopped people walking by, was asking them questions, and handed them pamphlets.

4. My teenage daughter enjoys shopping for new clothes, to try different cosmetics, and reading fashion magazines.

5. Many of today's action movies have attractive actors, fantastic special effects, and dialogue that is silly.

6. While you're downtown, please pick up the dry cleaning, return the library books, and the car needs washing, too.

7. I want a job that pays high wages, provides a complete benefits package, and offering opportunities for promotion.

125

8. As the elderly woman climbed the long staircase, she breathed hard and was grabbing the railing tightly.

126

9. I fell into bed at the end of the hard day, grateful for the sheets that were clean, soft pillow, and cozy blanket.

10. Ray’s wide smile, clear blue eyes, and expressing himself earnestly all make him seem honest, even though he is not.
- _____

Review Test 2

Cross out the unbalanced part of each sentence. In the space provided, revise the unbalanced part so that it matches the other item or items in the sentence.

1. The neighborhood group asked the town council to repair the potholes and that a traffic light be installed.
- _____
2. Pesky mosquitoes, humidity that is high, and sweltering heat make summer an unpleasant time for me.
- _____
3. The afternoon mail brought advertisements that were unwanted, bills I couldn’t pay, and magazines I didn’t like.
- _____
4. Our house has a broken garage door, shutters that are peeling, and a crumbling chimney.
- _____
5. My car needed the brakes replaced, the front wheels aligned, and recharging of the battery.
- _____
6. I had to correct my paper for fragments, misplaced modifiers, and there were apostrophe mistakes.
- _____
7. We do not want to stay home during our vacation, but a trip is not something we can afford.
- _____

8. Stumbling out of bed, a cup of coffee that he drinks, and watching the weather report make up Roy’s early-morning routine.

126
127

-
9. Having a headache, my stomach being upset, and a bad case of sunburn did not put me in a good mood for the evening.
-
10. The Gray Panthers is an organization that not only aids older citizens but also providing information for their families.
-

Using a Consistent Point of View

Review Test 3

In the following passage, change verbs as needed so that they are consistently in the past tense. Cross out each incorrect verb and write the correct form above it, as shown in the example. You will need to make nine corrections.

Late one rainy night, Mei Ling woke to the sound of steady dripping. When she got out of bed to investigate, a drop of cold water ~~splashes~~ ^{splashed} onto her arm. She looks up just in time to see another drop form on the ceiling, hang suspended for a moment, and fall to the carpet. Stumbling to the kitchen, Mei Ling reaches deep into one of the cabinets and lifts out a large roasting pan. As she did so, pot lids and baking tins clattered out and crash onto the counter. Mei Ling ignored them, stumbled back to the bedroom, and places the pan on the floor under the drip. But a minute after sliding her icy feet under the covers, Mei Ling realized she is in trouble. The sound of each drop hitting the metal pan echoed like a gunshot in the quiet room. Mei Ling feels like crying, but she finally thought of a solution. She got out of bed and returns a minute later with a thick bath towel. She lined the pan with the towel and crawls back into bed.

Review 4

Cross out the inconsistent pronouns in the following sentences and revise by writing the correct form of the pronoun above each crossed-out word.

EXAMPLE

I dislike waitressing, for ~~she~~ can never count on a fair tip.

- 1. My kitchen is so narrow that one can't open the refrigerator without turning sidewise first.
- 2. Wanting relief from her headaches, Carla asked her doctor if acupuncture could really do you any good.
- 3. I drink coffee at work because you need a regular jolt of energy.
- 4. As we entered the house, you could hear someone giggling in the hallway.
- 5. I hate going to the supermarket because you always have trouble finding a parking space there.
- 6. In this company, a worker can take a break only after a relief person comes to take your place.
- 7. Sometimes the Bradleys take the turnpike route, but it costs you five dollars in tolls.
- 8. As we sat in class waiting for the test results, you could feel the tension.
- 9. My brother doesn't get enough regular exercise, even though he knows exercise is good for you.
- 10. My favorite subject is abnormal psychology because the case studies make one seem so normal by comparison.

Using specific Words

Review Test 5

Revise the following sentences, replacing vague, indefinite words with sharp, specific ones.

- 1. When I woke up this morning, I had *several signs of a cold*.

- 2. Lin brought *lots of reading materials* to keep her busy in the hospital waiting room.

3. To do well in school, a student needs *certain qualities*.

4. The table at the wedding reception was full of *a variety of appetizers*.

5. As I grew older and less stupid, I realized that money cannot buy *certain things*.

Review Test 6

With the help of the methods described on [pages 111–112](#) and summarized below, add specific details to the sentences that follow.

- 1. Use exact names.
- 2. Use lively verbs.
- 3. Use descriptive words (modifiers) before nouns.
- 4. Use words that relate to the senses—sight, hearing, taste, smell, touch.

1. The crowd grew restless.

2. I relaxed.

3. The room was cluttered.

4. The child threw the object.

5. The driver was angry.

Using Concise Wording

Review Test 7

Rewrite the following sentences, omitting needless words.

1. There was this one girl in my class who rarely, if ever, did her homework.

2. Judging by the looks of things, it seems to me that it will probably rain very soon.

3. Seeing as how the refrigerator is empty of food, I will go to the supermarket in the very near future.

4. In this day and age it is almost a certainty that someone you know will be an innocent victim of criminal activity.

130

131

5. In my personal opinion it is correct to say that the spring season is the most beautiful period of time in the year.

Review Test 8

Rewrite the following sentences, omitting needless words.

1. Workers who are employed on a part-time basis are attractive to a business because they do not have to be paid as much as full-time workers for a business.

2. During the time that I was sick and out of school, I missed a total of three math tests.

3. The game, which was scheduled for later today, has been canceled by the officials because of the rainy weather.

4. At this point in time, I am quite undecided and unsure about just which classes I will take during this coming semester.

-
5. An inconsiderate person located in the apartment next to mine keeps her radio on too loud a good deal of the time, with the result being that it is disturbing to everyone in the neighboring apartments.
-
-

131

Varying Your Sentences

132

Review Test 9

Using coordination, subordination, or both, combine each of the following groups of simple sentences into one longer sentence. Omit repeated words. Various combinations are possible, so for each group, try to find the combination that flows most smoothly and clearly.

1. • My grandmother is eighty-six.
- She drives to Florida alone every year.
 - She believes in being self-reliant.
-
-

2. • They left twenty minutes early for class.
- They were late anyway.
 - The car overheated.
-
-

3. • John failed the midterm exam.
- He studied harder for the final.
 - He passed it.
-
-

4. • A volcano erupts.

- It sends tons of ash into the air.
- This creates flaming orange sunsets.

5. • A telephone rings late at night.
- We answer it fearfully.
 - It could bring tragic news.

132
133

Review Test 10

Using coordination, subordination, or both, combine each of the following groups of simple sentences into two longer sentences. Omit repeated words. Various combinations are possible, so for each group, try to find the combination that flows most smoothly and clearly.

1. • Wendy pretended not to overhear her coworkers.
- She couldn't stop listening.
 - She felt deeply embarrassed.
 - They were criticizing her work.

2. • Tony got home from the shopping mall.
- He discovered that his rented tuxedo did not fit.
 - The jacket sleeves covered his hands.
 - The pants cuffs hung over his shoes.

3. • The boys waited for the bus.
- The wind shook the flimsy shelter.
- They shivered with cold.
- They were wearing thin jackets.

133

4. • The engine almost started.
- Then it died.
- I realized no help would come.
- I was on a lonely road.
- It was very late.

134

5. • Gary was leaving the store.
- The shoplifting alarm went off.
- He had not stolen anything.
- The clerk had forgotten to remove the magnetic tag.
- The tag was on a shirt Gary had bought.

Review Test 11

Part A

Combine the simple sentences into one sentence by using the opener shown in the margin and omitting repeated words. Use a comma to set off the opener from the rest of the sentence.

- edword** 1. • We were exhausted from four hours of hiking.
- We decided to stop for the day.

- ingword** 2. • Gus was staring out the window.
- He didn't hear the instructor call on him.

134

- ly word** 3. • Nobody saw the thieves steal our bikes.
- This was unfortunate.

135

- to word group** 4. • Wayne rented a limousine for the night. **toword**
- He wanted to make a good impression.

- prepositional phrase** 5. • Joanne goes online to e-mail her friends.
- She does this during her lunch breaks.

Part B

Combine the simple sentences in each group into one sentence by using adjectives or verbs in a series and by omitting repeated words. In most cases, use a comma between the adjectives or verbs in a series.

6. The photographer waved a teddy bear at the baby.

He made a funny face.

He quacked like a duck.

7. The bucket held a bunch of daisies.

The bucket was shiny.

The bucket was aluminum.

The daisies were fresh.

The daisies were white.

8. Amy poured herself a cup of coffee.

She pulled her hair back into a ponytail.

She opened her textbook.

She sat down at her desk.

She fell asleep.

9. The box in the dresser drawer was stuffed with letters.

The box was cardboard.

The dresser drawer was locked.

The letters were faded.

The letters were about love.

135

136

10. The boy asked the girl to dance.

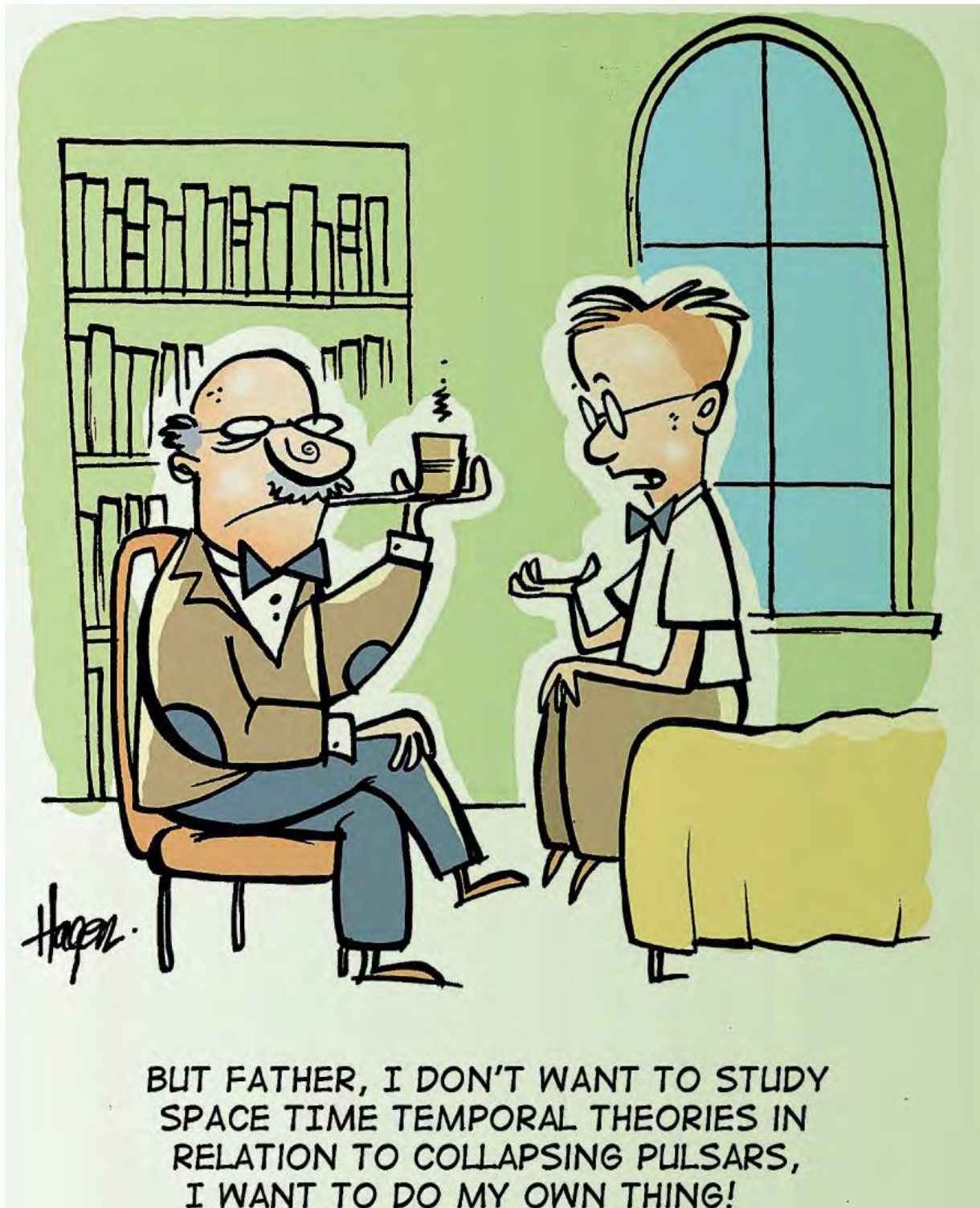
The boy was short.

The boy was self-confident.

The girl was tall. The girl was shy.

*The two parts of a complex sentence are sometimes called an *independent clause* and a *dependent clause*. A *clause* is simply a word group that contains a subject and a verb. An independent clause expresses a complete thought and can stand alone. A dependent clause does not express a complete thought in itself and “depends on” the independent clause to complete its meaning. Dependent clauses always begin with a dependent, or subordinating, word.

6: Four Bases for Revising Writing



Very often, our own interests and goals are different from those our parents hoped for us. Look at the cartoon above and write a paragraph about a time you “did your own thing” instead of following the wishes of a parent or someone else important to you. Why did you make the decision you did? How did the other person react? Looking back, do you still feel you made the right decision?

This chapter will show you how to evaluate a paragraph for

- unity
- support
- coherence
- sentence skills

137

In the preceding chapters, you learned four essential steps in writing an effective paragraph. The box below shows how these steps lead to four standards, or bases, you can use in revising your writing.

138



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Four Steps **Four Bases**

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. If you make one point and stick to that point, | your writing will have <i>unity</i> . |
| 2. If you back up the point with specific evidence, | your writing will have <i>support</i> . |
| 3. If you organize and connect the specific evidence, | your writing will have <i>coherence</i> . |
| 4. If you write clear, error-free sentence, | your writing will demonstrate effective <i>sentence skills</i> . |

This chapter will discuss the four bases—unity, support, coherence, and sentence skills—and will show how these four bases can be used to evaluate and revise a paragraph.

Base 1: Unity

Understanding Unity

The following two paragraphs were written by students on the topic “Why Students Drop Out of College.” Read them and decide which one makes its point more clearly and effectively, and why.

Paragraph A

Why Students Drop Out

Students drop out of college for many reasons. First of all, some students are bored in school. These students may enter college expecting nonstop fun or a series of fascinating courses. When they find out that college is often routine, they quickly lose interest. They do not want to take dull required courses or spend their nights studying, and so they drop out. Students also drop out of college because the work is harder than they thought it would be. These students may have made decent grades in high school simply by showing up for class. In college, however, they may have to prepare for two-hour exams, write fifteen-page term papers, or make detailed presentations to a class. The hard work comes as a shock, and students give up. Perhaps the most common reason students drop out is that they are having personal or emotional problems. Younger students, especially, may be attending college at an age when they are also feeling confused, lonely, or depressed. These students may have problems with roommates, family, boyfriends, or girlfriends. They become too unhappy to deal with both hard academic work and emotional troubles. For many types of students, dropping out seems to be the only solution they can imagine.

138

Paragraph B

Student Dropouts

There are three main reasons students drop out of college. Some students, for one thing, are not really sure they want to be in school and lack the desire to do the work. When exams come up, or when a course requires a difficult project or term paper, these students will not do the required studying or research. Eventually, they may drop out because their grades are so poor they are about to flunk out anyway. Such students sometimes come back to school later with a completely different attitude about school. Other students drop out for financial reasons. The pressures of paying tuition, buying textbooks, and possibly having to support themselves can be overwhelming. These students can often be helped by the school because financial aid is available, and some schools offer work-study programs. Finally, students drop out because they have personal problems. They cannot concentrate on their courses because they are unhappy at home, they are lonely, or they are having trouble with boyfriends or girlfriends. Instructors should suggest that such troubled students see counselors or join support groups. If instructors would take a more personal interest in their students, more students would make it through troubled times.

139

Activity 1

Fill in the blanks: Paragraph_____makes its point more clearly and effectively because_____

139

Paragraph A is more effective because it is *unified*. All the details in paragraph A are *on target*; they support and develop the single point expressed in the first sentence—that there are many reasons students drop out of college.

140

On the other hand, paragraph B contains some details irrelevant to the opening point—that there are three main reasons students drop out. These details should be omitted in the interest of paragraph unity. Go back to paragraph B and cross out the sections that are off target—the sections that do not support the opening idea.

You should have crossed out the following sections: “Such students sometimes . . . attitude about school”; “These students can often . . . work-study programs”; and “Instructors should suggest . . . through troubled times.”

The difference between these two paragraphs leads us to the first base, or standard, of effective writing: *unity*. To achieve unity is to have all the details in your paragraph related to the single point expressed in the topic sentence, the first sentence. Each time you think of something to put in, ask yourself whether it relates to your main point. If it does not, leave it out. For example, if you were writing about a certain job as the worst job you ever had and then spent a couple of sentences talking about the interesting people that you met there, you would be missing the first and most essential base of good writing.

Checking for Unity

To check a paragraph for unity, ask yourself these questions:

- 1. Is there a clear opening statement of the point of the paragraph?
- 2. Is all the material on target in support of the opening point?



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Base 2: Support

Understanding Support

The following student paragraphs were written on the topic “A Quality of Some Person You Know.” Both are unified, but one communicates more clearly and effectively. Which one, and why?

140

141

Paragraph A

My Quick-Tempered Father

My father is easily angered by normal everyday mistakes. One day my father told me to wash the car and cut the grass. I did not hear exactly what he said, and so I asked him to repeat it. Then he went into a hysterical mood and shouted, “Can’t you hear?” Another time he asked my mother to go to the store and buy groceries with a fifty-dollar bill, and he told her to spend no more than twenty dollars. She spent twenty-two dollars. As soon as he found out, he immediately took the change from her and told her not to go anywhere else for him; he did not speak to her the rest of the day. My father even gives my older brothers a hard time with his irritable moods. One day he told them to be home from their dates by midnight; they came home at 12:15. He informed them that they were grounded for three weeks. To my father, making a simple mistake is like committing a crime.

Paragraph B

My Generous Grandfather

My grandfather is the most generous person I know. He gave up a life of his own in order to give his children everything they wanted. Not only did he give up many years of his life to raise his children properly, but he is now sacrificing many more years to his grandchildren. His generosity is also evident in his relationship with his neighbors, his friends, and the members of his church. He has been responsible for many good deeds and has always been there to help all the people around him in times of trouble. Everyone knows that he will gladly lend a helping hand. He is so generous that you almost have to feel sorry for him. If one day he suddenly became selfish, it would be earthshaking. That’s my grandfather.

Activity 2

Fill in the blanks: Paragraph_____makes its point more clearly and effectively because_____

Paragraph A is more effective, for it offers specific examples that show us the father in action. We see for ourselves why the writer describes the father as quick-tempered.

Paragraph B, on the other hand, gives us no specific evidence. The writer of paragraph B tells us repeatedly that the grandfather is generous but never shows us examples of that generosity. Just how, for instance, did the grandfather sacrifice his life for his children and grandchildren? Did he hold two jobs so that his son could go to college, or so that his daughter could have her own car? Does he give up time with his wife and friends to travel every day to his daughter’s house to baby-sit, go to the store, and help with the dishes? Does he wear threadbare suits and coats and eat frozen dinners and other inexpensive meals (with no desserts) so that he can give money to his children and toys to his grandchildren? We want to see and judge for ourselves whether the writer is making a valid point about the grandfather, but without specific details we cannot do so. In fact, we have almost no picture of him at all.

Consideration of these two paragraphs leads us to the second base of effective writing: *support*. After realizing the importance of specific supporting details, one student writer revised a paragraph she had done on a restaurant job as the worst job she ever had. In the revised paragraph, instead of talking about “unsanitary conditions in the kitchen,” she referred to such specifics as “green mold on the bacon” and “ants in the potato salad.” All your paragraphs should include many vivid details!

Checking for Support

To check a paragraph for support, ask yourself these questions:

- 1. Is there *specific* evidence to support the opening point?
- 2. Is there *enough* specific evidence?



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141

142

Base 3: Coherence

Understanding Coherence

The following two paragraphs were written on the topic “The Best or Worst Job You Ever Had.” Both are unified and both are supported. However, one communicates more clearly and effectively. Which one, and why?

142

143

Paragraph A

Pantry Helper

My worst job was as a pantry helper in one of San Diego’s well-known restaurants. I had an assistant from three to six in the afternoon who did little but stand around and eat the whole time she was there. She would listen for the sound of the back door opening, which was a sure sign the boss was coming in. The boss would testily say to me, “You’ve got a lot of things to do here, Alice. Try to get a move on.” I would come in at two o’clock to relieve the woman on the morning shift. If her day was busy, that meant I would have to prepare salads, slice meat and cheese, and so on. Orders for sandwiches and cold platters would come in and have to be prepared. The worst thing about the job was that the heat in the kitchen, combined with my nerves, would give me an upset stomach by seven o’clock almost every night. I might be going to the storeroom to get some supplies, and one of the waitresses would tell me she wanted a bacon, lettuce, and tomato sandwich on white toast. I would put the toast in and head for the supply room, and a waitress would holler out that her customer was in a hurry. Green flies would come in through the torn screen in the kitchen window and sting me. I was getting paid only \$7.05 an hour. At five o’clock, when the dinner rush began, I would be dead tired. Roaches scurried in all directions whenever I moved a box or picked up a head of lettuce to cut.

Paragraph B

My Worst Job

The worst job I ever had was as a waiter at the Westside Inn. First of all, many of the people I waited on were rude. When a baked potato was hard inside or a salad was flat or their steak wasn't just the way they wanted it, they blamed me, rather than the kitchen. Or they would ask me to light their cigarettes, or chase flies from their tables, or even take their children to the bathroom. Also, I had to contend not only with the customers but with the kitchen staff as well. The cooks and busboys were often undependable and surly. If I didn't treat them just right, I would wind up having to apologize to customers because their meals came late or their water glasses weren't filled. Another reason I didn't like the job was that I was always moving. Because of the constant line at the door, as soon as one group left, another would take its place. I usually had only a twenty-minute lunch break and a ten-minute break in almost nine hours of work. I think I could have put up with the job if I had been able to pause and rest more often. The last and most important reason I hated the job was my boss. She played favorites, giving some of the waiters and waitresses the best-tipping repeat customers and preferences on holidays. She would hover around during my break to make sure I didn't take a second more than the allotted time. And even when I helped out by working through a break, she never had an appreciative word but would just tell me not to be late for work the next day.

143

144

Activity 3

Fill in the blanks: Paragraph _____ makes its point more clearly and effectively because _____

Paragraph B is more effective because the material is organized clearly and logically. Using emphatic order, the writer gives us a list of four reasons why the job was so bad: rude customers, an unreliable kitchen staff, constant motion, and—most of all—an unfair boss. Further, the writer includes transitional words that act as signposts, making movement from one idea to the next easy to follow. The major transitions are *First of all*, *Also*, *Another reason*, and *The last and most important reason*.

While paragraph A is unified and supported, the writer does not have any clear and consistent way of organizing the material. Partly, emphatic order is used, but this is not made clear by transitions or by saving the most important reason for last. Partly, time order is used, but it moves inconsistently from two to seven to five o'clock.

These two paragraphs lead us to the third base of effective writing: *coherence*. The supporting ideas and sentences in a composition must be organized so that they cohere, or “stick together.” As has already been mentioned, key techniques for tying material together are a clear method of organization (such as time order or emphatic order), transitions, and other connecting words.

Checking for Coherence

To check a paragraph for coherence, ask yourself these questions:

- 1 Does the paragraph have a clear method of organization?
- 2 Are transitions and other connecting words used to tie the material together?



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144
145

Base 4: Sentence Skills

Understanding Sentence Skills

Two versions of a paragraph are given below. Both are unified, supported, and organized, but one version communicates more clearly and effectively. Which one, and why?

Paragraph A

Falling Asleep Anywhere

¹There are times when people are so tired that they fall asleep almost anywhere. ²For example, there is a lot of sleeping on the bus or train on the way home from work in the evenings. ³A man will be reading the newspaper, and seconds later it appears as if he is trying to eat it. ⁴Or he will fall asleep on the shoulder of the stranger sitting next to him. ⁵Another place where unplanned naps go on is the lecture hall. ⁶In some classes, a student will start snoring so loudly that the professor has to ask another student to shake the sleeper awake. ⁷A more embarrassing situation occurs when a student leans on one elbow and starts drifting off to sleep. ⁸The weight of the head pushes the elbow off the desk, and this momentum carries the rest of the body along. ⁹The student wakes up on the floor with no memory of getting there. ¹⁰The worst place to fall asleep is at the wheel of a car. ¹¹Police reports are full of accidents that occur when people lose consciousness and go off the road. ¹²If the drivers are lucky, they are not seriously hurt. ¹³One woman's car, for instance, went into a river. ¹⁴She woke up in four feet of water and thought it was raining. ¹⁵When people are really tired, nothing will stop them from falling asleep—no matter where they are.

Paragraph B

“Falling Asleep Anywhere”

¹There are times when people are so tired that they fall asleep almost anywhere. ²For example, on the bus or train on the way home from work. ³A man will be reading the newspaper, seconds later it appears as if he is trying to eat it. ⁴Or he will fall asleep on the shoulder of the stranger sitting next to him. ⁵Another place where unplanned naps go on are in the lecture hall. ⁶In some classes, a student will start snoring so loudly that the professor has to ask another student to shake the sleeper awake. ⁷A more embarrassing situation occurs when a student leans on one elbow and starting to drift off to sleep. ⁸The weight of the head push the elbow off the desk, and this momentum carries the rest of the body along. ⁹The student wakes up on the floor with no memory of getting there. ¹⁰The worst time to fall asleep is when driving a car. ¹¹Police reports are full of accidents that occur when people conk out and go off the road. ¹²If the drivers are lucky they are not seriously hurt. ¹³One womans car, for instance, went into a river. ¹⁴She woke up in four feet of water. ¹⁵And thought it was raining. ¹⁶When people are really tired, nothing will stop them from falling asleep—no matter where they are.

145

146

Activity 4

Fill in the blanks: Paragraph_____makes its point more clearly and effectively because_____

Paragraph A is more effective because it incorporates sentence skills, the fourth base of competent writing.

Activity 5

See if you can identify the ten sentence-skills mistakes in paragraph B. Do this, first of all, by going back and underlining the ten spots in paragraph B that differ in wording or punctuation from paragraph A. Then try to identify the ten sentence-skills mistakes by circling what you feel is the correct answer in each of the ten statements below.

HINT

Comparing paragraph B with the correct version may help you guess correct answers even if you are not familiar with the names of certain skills.

- 1. The title should not be set off with
 - a. capital letters.
 - b. quotation marks.
- 2. In word group 2, there is a
 - a. missing comma.
 - b. missing apostrophe.
 - c. sentence fragment.
 - d. dangling modifier.
- 3. In word group 3, there is a
 - a. run-on.
 - b. sentence fragment.
 - c. mistake in subject-verb agreement.
 - d. mistake involving an irregular verb.

146

- 4. In word group 5, there is a 8. In word group 12, there is a
 - a. sentence fragment.
 - b. spelling error.
 - c. run-on.
 - d. mistake in subject-verb verb agreement.
- 5. In word group 7, there is a
 - a. misplaced modifier.
 - b. dangling modifier.
 - c. mistake in parallelism. verb.
 - d. run-on.
- 6. In word group 8, there is a

147

- a. nonstandard English verb.
- b. run-on.
- c. comma mistake.
- d. missing capital letter. verb.

7. In word group 11, there is a

- a. mistake involving an irregular verb.
- b. sentence fragment.
- c. slang phrase.
- d. mistake in subject-verb agreement.

8. In word group 12, there is a

- a. missing apostrophe.
- b. missing comma.
- c. mistake involving an irregular verb.
- d. sentence fragment.

9. In word group 13, there is a

- a. missing quotation mark.
- b. mistake involving an irregular
- c. missing apostrophe.
- d. missing capital letter.

10. In word group 15, there is a

- a. mistake in parallelism.
- b. mistake involving an irregular
- c. sentence fragment.
- d. mistake in pronoun point of view.

You should have chosen the following answers:

- 1. b
- 2. c

- 3. a
- 4. d
- 5. c
- 6. a
- 7. c
- 8. b
- 9. c
- 10. c

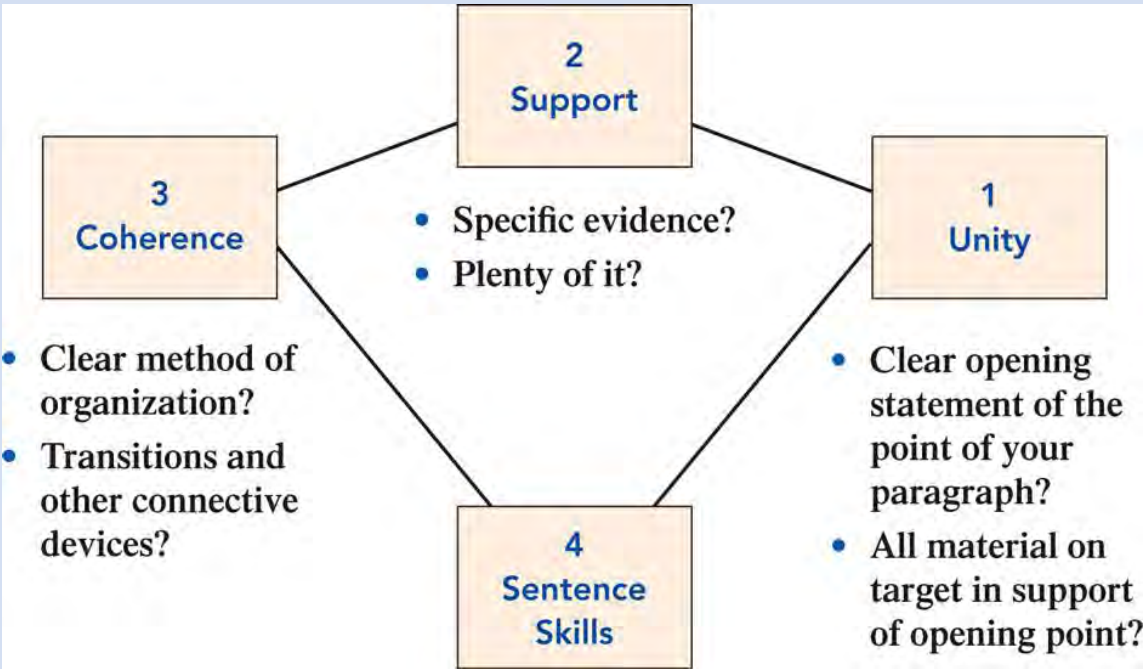
Part Five of this book explains these and other sentence skills. You should review all the skills carefully. Doing so will ensure that you know the most important rules of grammar, punctuation, and usage—rules needed to write clear, error-free sentences.



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Checking for Sentence Skills

Sentence skills and the other bases of effective writing are summarized in the following chart and on the inside back cover of the book.



- Fragments eliminated? ([page 414](#))
- Run-ons eliminated? ([430](#))
- Correct verb forms? ([445](#))
- Subject and verb agreement? ([463](#))
- Faulty modifiers eliminated? ([488](#))
- Faulty pronouns eliminated? ([470](#))
- Capital letters used correctly? ([501](#))
- Punctuation marks where needed?
 - (a) Apostrophes ([514](#))
 - (b) Quotation marks ([523](#))
 - (c) Commas ([531](#))
 - (d) Semicolons; colons ([541](#))
 - (e) Hyphens; dashes ([542](#))
 - (f) Parentheses ([543](#))
- Correct paper format? ([496](#))
- Needless words eliminated? ([113](#))
- Effective word choices? ([575](#))
- Possible spelling errors checked? ([555](#))
- Careless errors eliminated through proofreading? ([106](#))
- Sentences varied? ([116](#))

148

149

Practice in Using the Four Bases



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You are now familiar with four bases, or standards, of effective writing: unity, support, coherence, and sentence skills. In this closing section, you will expand and strengthen your understanding of the four bases as you work through the following activities:

- 1. Evaluating Scratch Outlines for Unity
- 2. Evaluating Paragraphs for Unity
- 3. Evaluating Paragraphs for Support
- 4. Evaluating Paragraphs for Coherence
- 5. Revising Paragraphs for Coherence
- 6. Evaluating Paragraphs for All Four Bases: Unity, Support, Coherence, and Sentence Skills

1: Evaluating Scratch Outlines for Unity

The best time to check a paragraph for unity is at the outline stage. A scratch outline, as explained on [page 24](#), is one of the best techniques for getting started with a paragraph.

Look at the following scratch outline that one student prepared and then corrected for unity:

I had a depressing weekend.

- 1. Hay fever bothered me*
- 2. Had to pay seventy-seven-dollar car bill*
- ~~*3. Felt bad*~~
- 4. Boyfriend and I had a fight*
- ~~*5. Did poorly in my math test today as a result*~~
- 6. My mother yelled at me unfairly*

Four reasons support the opening statement that the writer was depressed over the weekend. The writer crossed out “Felt bad” because it was not a reason for her depression. (Saying that she felt bad is only another way of saying that she was depressed.) She also crossed out the item about the math test because the point she is supporting is that she was depressed over the weekend.

149
150

Activity 6

In each outline, cross out the items that do not support the opening point. These items must be omitted in order to achieve paragraph unity.

- 1. The cost of raising a child keeps increasing.
 - a. School taxes get higher every year.

- b. A pair of children's sneakers can now cost over \$100.
 - c. Overpopulation is a worldwide problem.
 - d. Providing nutritious food is more costly because of inflated prices.
 - e. Children should work at age sixteen.
2. My father's compulsive gambling hurt our family life.
- a. We were always short of money for bills.
 - b. Luckily, my father didn't drink.
 - c. My father ignored his children to spend time at the racetrack.
 - d. Gamblers' Anonymous can help compulsive gamblers.
 - e. My mother and father argued constantly.
3. There are several ways to get better mileage in your car.
- a. Check air pressure in tires regularly.
 - b. Drive at no more than fifty-five miles per hour.
 - c. Orange and yellow cars are the most visible.
 - d. Avoid jackrabbit starts at stop signs and traffic lights.
 - e. Always have duplicate ignition and trunk keys.
4. My swimming instructor helped me overcome my terror of the water.
- a. He talked with me about my fears.
 - b. I was never good at sports.
 - c. He showed me how to hold my head under water and not panic.
 - d. I held on to a floating board until I was confident enough to give it up.
 - e. My instructor was on the swimming team at his college.
5. Fred Wilkes is the best candidate for state governor.
- a. He has fifteen years' experience in the state senate.
 - b. His son is a professional football player.
 - c. He has helped stop air and water pollution in the state.
 - d. His opponent has been divorced.

e. He has brought new industries and jobs to the state.

2: Evaluating Paragraphs for Unity

Activity 7

Each of the following five paragraphs contains sentences that are off target—sentences that do not support the opening point—and so the paragraphs are not unified. In the interest of paragraph unity, such sentences must be omitted.

150

Cross out the irrelevant sentences and write the numbers of those sentences in the spaces provided. The number of spaces will tell you the number of irrelevant sentences in each paragraph.

151

1. A Kindergarten Failure

¹In kindergarten I experienced the fear of failure that haunts many schoolchildren. ²My moment of panic occurred on my last day in kindergarten at Charles Foos Public School in Riverside, California. ³My family lived in California for three years before we moved to Omaha, Nebraska, where my father was a personnel manager for Mutual of Omaha. ⁴Our teacher began reading a list of names of all those students who were to line up at the door in order to visit the first-grade classroom. ⁵Our teacher was a pleasant-faced woman who had resumed her career after raising her own children. ⁶She called off every name but mine, and I was left sitting alone in the class while everyone else left, the teacher included. ⁷I sat there in absolute horror. ⁸I imagined that I was the first kid in human history who had flunked things like crayons, sandbox, and sliding board. ⁹Without getting the teacher’s permission, I got up and walked to the bathroom and threw up into a sink. ¹⁰Only when I ran home in tears to my mother did I get an explanation of what had happened. ¹¹Since I was to go to a parochial school in the fall, I had not been taken with the other children to meet the first-grade teacher at the public school. ¹²My moment of terror and shame had been only a misunderstanding.

The numbers of the irrelevant sentences: _____

2. How to Prevent Cheating

¹Instructors should take steps to prevent students from cheating on exams. ²To begin with, instructors should stop reusing old tests. ³A test that has been used even once is soon known on the student grapevine. ⁴Students will check with their friends to find out, for example, what was on Dr. Thompson’s biology final last term. ⁵They may even manage to find a copy of the test itself, “accidentally” not turned in by a former student of Dr. Thompson’s. ⁶Instructors should also take some commonsense precautions at test time. ⁷They should make students separate

	themselves—by at least one seat—during an exam, and they should watch the class closely. ⁸The best place for the instructor to sit is in the rear of the room, so that a student is never sure if the instructor is looking at him or her. ⁹Last of all, instructors must make it clear to students that there will be stiff penalties for cheating. ¹⁰One of the problems with our school systems is a lack of discipline. ¹¹Instructors never used to give in to students’ demands or put up with bad behavior, as they do today. ¹²Anyone caught cheating should immediately receive a zero for the exam. ¹³A person even suspected of cheating should be forced to take an alternative exam in the instructor’s office. ¹⁴Because cheating is unfair to honest students, it should not be tolerated. The numbers of the irrelevant sentences: _____	151 152
	3. Other Uses for Cars ¹Many people who own a car manage to turn the vehicle into a trash can, a clothes closet, or a storage room. ²People who use their cars as trash cans are easily recognized. ³Empty snack bags, hamburger wrappers, pizza cartons, soda cans, and doughnut boxes litter the floor. ⁴On the seats are old scratched CDs, blackened fruit skins, crumpled receipts, crushed cigarette packs, and used tissues. ⁵At least the trash stays in the car, instead of adding to the litter on our highways. ⁶Other people use a car as a clothes closet. ⁷The car contains several pairs of shoes, pants, or shorts, along with a suit or dress that’s been hanging on the car’s clothes hanger for over a year. ⁸Sweaty, smelly gym clothes will also find a place in the car, a fact passengers quickly discover. ⁹The world would be better off if people showed more consideration of others. ¹⁰Finally, some people use a car as a spare garage or basement. ¹¹In the backseats or trunks of these cars are bags of fertilizer, beach chairs, old textbooks, chainsaws, or window screens that have been there for months. ¹²The trunk may also contain an extra spare tire, a dented hubcap, a gallon container of window washer fluid, and old stereo equipment. ¹³If apartments offered more storage space, probably fewer people would resort to using their cars for such storage purposes. ¹⁴All in all, people get a lot more use out of their cars than simply the miles they travel on the road. The numbers of the irrelevant sentences: _____	
	4. Why Adults Visit Amusement Parks ¹Adults visit amusement parks for several reasons. ²For one thing, an amusement park is a place where it is acceptable to “pig out” on junk food. ³At the park, everyone is drinking soda and eating popcorn, ice cream, or hot dogs. ⁴No one seems to be on a diet, and so buying all the junk food you can eat is a guilt-free experience. ⁵Parks should provide stands where healthier food,	

such as salads or cold chicken, would be sold. ⁶ Another reason people visit amusement parks is to prove themselves. ⁷ They want to visit the park that has the newest, scariest ride in order to say that they went on the Parachute Drop, the seven-story Elevator, the Water Chute, or the Death Slide. ⁸ Going on a scary ride is a way to feel courageous and adventurous without taking much of a risk. ⁹ Some rides, however, can be dangerous.	152
¹⁰ Rides that are not properly inspected or maintained have killed people all over the country. ¹¹ A final reason people visit amusement parks is to escape from everyday pressures. ¹² When people are poised at the top of a gigantic roller coaster, they are not thinking of bills, work, or personal problems. ¹³ A scary ride empties the mind of all worries—except making it to the bottom alive. ¹⁴ Adults at an amusement park may claim they have come for their children, but they are there for themselves as well. The numbers of the irrelevant sentences: _____ 5. A Dangerous Cook ¹ When my friend Tom sets to work in the kitchen, disaster often results. ² Once he tried to make toasted cheese sandwiches for us by putting slices of cheese in the toaster along with the bread; he ruined the toaster. ³ Unfortunately, the toaster was a fairly new one that I had just bought for him three weeks before, on his birthday. ⁴ On another occasion, he had cut up some fresh beans and put them in a pot to steam. ⁵ I was really looking forward to the beans, for I eat nothing but canned vegetables in my dormitory. ⁶ I, frankly, am not much of a cook either. ⁷ The water in the Teflon pan steamed away while Tom was on the telephone, and both the beans and the Teflon coating in the pan were ruined. ⁸ Finally, another time Tom made spaghetti for us, and the noodles stuck so tightly together that we had to cut off slices with a knife and fork. ⁹ In addition, the meatballs were burned on the outside but almost raw inside. ¹⁰ The tomato sauce, on the other hand, turned out well. ¹¹ For some reason, Tom is very good at making meat and vegetable sauces. ¹² Because of Tom’s kitchen mishaps, I never eat at his place without an Alka-Seltzer in my pocket, or without money in case we have to go out to eat. The numbers of the irrelevant sentences: _____	153

3 Evaluating Paragraphs for Support

Activity 8

The five paragraphs that follow lack sufficient supporting details. In each paragraph, identify the spot or spots where more specific details are needed.

1. Chicken: Our Best Friend

¹Chicken is the best-selling meat today for a number of good reasons. ²First of all, its reasonable cost puts it within everyone’s reach. ³Chicken is popular, too, because it can be prepared in so many different ways. ⁴It can, for example, be cooked by itself, in spaghetti sauce, or with noodles and gravy. ⁵It can be baked, boiled, broiled, or fried. ⁶Chicken is also convenient. ⁷Last and most important, chicken has a high nutritional value. ⁸Four ounces of chicken contain twenty-eight grams of protein, which is almost half the recommended daily dietary allowance.

Fill in the blanks: The first spot where supporting details are needed occurs after sentence number _____. The second spot occurs after sentence number _____.

2. A Car Accident

¹I was on my way home from work when my terrible car accident took place. ²As I drove my car around the curve of the expressway exit, I saw a number of cars ahead of me. ³They were backed up because of a red light at the main road. ⁴I slowly came to a stop behind a dozen or more cars. ⁵In my rearview mirror, I then noticed a car coming up behind me that did not slow down or stop. ⁶I had a horrible, helpless feeling as I realized the car would hit me. ⁷I knew there was nothing I could do to signal the driver in time, nor was there any way I could get away from the car. ⁸Minutes after the collision, I picked up my glasses, which were on the seat beside me. ⁹My lip was bleeding, and I got out a tissue to wipe it. ¹⁰The police arrived quickly, along with an ambulance for the driver of the car that hit me. ¹¹My car was so damaged that it had to be towed away. ¹²Today, eight years after the accident, I still relive the details of the experience whenever a car gets too close behind me.

Fill in the blank: The point where details are needed occurs after sentence number _____.

3. Tips on Bringing Up Children

¹In some ways, children should be treated as mature people. ²For one thing, adults should not use baby talk with children. ³Using real words with children helps them develop language skills more quickly. ⁴Baby talk makes children feel patronized, frustrated, and confused, for they want to understand and communicate with adults by learning their speech. ⁵So animals should be called cows and dogs, not “moo-moos” and “bowwows.” ⁶Second, parents should be consistent when disciplining children. ⁷For example, if a parent tells a child, “You cannot have dessert unless you put away your toys,” it is important that the parent follow through on the warning.

153

154

	⁸By being consistent, parents will teach children responsibility and give them a stable center around which to grow. ⁹Finally, and most important, children should be allowed and encouraged to make simple decisions. ¹⁰Parents will thus be helping their children prepare for the complex decisions that they will have to deal with in later life.	154
	<i>Fill in the blank:</i> The spot where supporting details are needed occurs after sentence number_____. 4. Being on TV ¹People act a little strangely when a television camera comes their way. ²Some people behave as if a crazy puppeteer were pulling their strings. ³Their arms jerk wildly about, and they begin jumping up and down for no apparent reason. ⁴Often they accompany their body movements with loud screams, squeals, and yelps. ⁵Another group of people engage in an activity known as the cover-up. ⁶They will be calmly watching a sports game or other televised event when they realize the camera is focused on them. ⁷The camera operator can't resist zooming in for a close-up of these people. ⁸Then there are those who practice their funny faces on the unsuspecting public. ⁹They take advantage of the television time to show off their talents, hoping to get that big break that will carry them to stardom. ¹⁰Finally, there are those who pretend they are above reacting for the camera. ¹¹They wipe an expression from their faces and appear to be interested in something else. ¹²Yet if the camera stays on them long enough, they will slyly check to see if they are still being watched. ¹³Everybody's behavior seems to be slightly strange in front of a TV camera. <i>Fill in the blanks:</i> The first spot where supporting details are needed occurs after sentence number_____. The second spot occurs after sentence number_____. 5. Culture Conflict ¹I am in a constant tug-of-war with my parents over conflicts between their Vietnamese culture and American culture. ²To begin with, my parents do not like me to have American friends. ³They think that I should spend all my time with other Vietnamese people and speak English only when necessary. ⁴I get into an argument whenever I want to go to a fast-food restaurant or a movie at night with my American friends. ⁵The conflict with my parents is even worse when it comes to plans for a career. ⁶My parents want me to get a degree in science and then go on to medical school. ⁷On the other hand, I think I want to become a teacher. ⁸So far I have been taking both science and education courses, but soon I will have to concentrate on one or the other. ⁹The other night my father made his attitude about what I should do very clear. ¹⁰The	155

	most difficult aspect of our cultural differences is the way our family is structured. ¹¹ My father is the center of our family, and he expects that I will always listen to him. ¹² Although I am twenty-one years old, I still have a nightly curfew at an hour which I consider insulting. ¹³ Also, I am expected to help my mother perform certain household chores that I've really come to hate.	155
	¹⁴ My father expects me to live at home until I am married to a Vietnamese man. ¹⁵ When that happens, he assumes I will obey my husband just as I obey him. ¹⁶ I do not want to be a bad daughter, but I want to live like my American female friends.	156
	<i>Fill in the blanks:</i> The first spot where supporting details are needed occurs after sentence number _____. The second spot occurs after sentence number _____. The third spot occurs after sentence number _____.	

4: Evaluating Paragraphs for Coherence

Activity 9

Answer the questions about coherence that follow each of the two paragraphs below.

1. Why I Bought a Handgun

¹I bought a handgun to keep in my house for several reasons. ²Most important, I have had a frightening experience with an obscene phone caller. ³For several weeks, a man has called me once or twice a day, sometimes as late as three in the morning. ⁴As soon as I pick up the phone, he whispers something obscene or threatens me by saying, "I'll get you." ⁵I decided to buy a gun because crime is increasing in my neighborhood. ⁶One neighbor's house was burglarized while she was at work; the thieves not only stole her appliances but also threw paint around her living room and slashed her furniture. ⁷Not long after this incident, an elderly woman from the apartment house on the corner was mugged on her way to the supermarket. ⁸The man grabbed her purse and threw her to the ground, breaking her hip. ⁹Buying a gun was my response to listening to the nightly news. ¹⁰It seemed that every news story involved violence of some kind—rapes, murders, muggings, and robberies. ¹¹I wondered if some of the victims in the stories would still be alive if they had been able to frighten the criminal off with a gun. ¹²As time passed, I became more convinced that I should keep a gun in the house.

- a. The paragraph should use emphatic order. Write 1 before the reason that seems slightly less important than the other two, 2 before the second-most-important reason, and 3 before the most important reason.

_____Obscene phone caller

_____Crime increase in neighborhood _____News stories about crime b. Before which of the three reasons should the transitional words <i>First of all</i> be added? _____	156
c. Before which of the three reasons could the transition <i>In addition</i> be added? _____ d. Which words show emphasis in sentence 2?_____ e. In sentence 8, to whom does the pronoun <i>her</i> refer?_____ f. How often does the key word <i>gun</i> appear in the paragraph?_____ g. What is a synonym for <i>burglarized</i> in sentence 6?_____ 2. Apartment Hunting ¹Apartment hunting is a several-step process. ²Visit and carefully inspect the most promising apartments. ³Check each place for signs of unwanted guests such as roaches or mice. ⁴Make sure that light switches and appliances work and that there are enough electrical outlets. ⁵Turn faucets on and off and flush the toilet to be sure that the plumbing works smoothly. ⁶Talk to the landlord for a bit to get a sense of him or her as a person. ⁷If a problem develops after you move in, you want to know that a decent and capable person will be there to handle the matter. ⁸Find out what’s available that matches your interests. ⁹Your town newspaper and local real estate offices can provide you with a list of apartments for rent. ¹⁰Family and friends may be able to give you leads. ¹¹And your school may have a housing office that keeps a list of approved apartments for rent. ¹²Decide just what you need. ¹³If you can afford no more than \$400 a month, you need to find a place that will cost no more than that. ¹⁴If you want a location that’s close to work or school, you must take that factor into account. ¹⁵If you plan to cook, you want a place with a workable kitchen. ¹⁶By taking these steps, you should be ready to select the apartment that is best for you. a. The paragraph should use time order. Write 1 before the step that should come first, 2 before the intermediate step, and 3 before the final step. _____Visit and carefully inspect the most promising apartments. _____Decide just what you need.	157

	_____ Find out what's available that matches your interests. b. Before which of three steps could the transitional words <i>The first step is to</i> be added? _____ c. Before which step could the transitional words <i>After you have decided what you are looking for, the next step is to</i> be added? _____ d. Before which step could the transitional words <i>The final step</i> be added? _____	157
	e. To whom does the pronoun <i>him or her</i> in sentence 6 refer to? _____ f. What is a synonym for <i>landlord</i> in sentence 7? _____ g. What is a synonym for <i>apartment</i> in sentence 13? _____	158

5 Revising Paragraphs for Coherence

The two paragraphs in this section begin with a clear point, but in each case the supporting material that follows the point is not coherent. Read each paragraph and the comments that follow it on how to organize and connect the supporting material. Then do the activity for the paragraph.

Paragraph 1

A Difficult Period

Since I arrived in the Bay Area in midsummer, I have had the most difficult period of my life. I had to look for an apartment. I found only one place that I could afford, but the landlord said I could not move in until it was painted. When I first arrived in San Francisco, my thoughts were to stay with my father and stepmother. I had to set out looking for a job so that I could afford my own place, for I soon realized that my stepmother was not at all happy having me live with them. A three-week search led to a job shampooing rugs for a housecleaning company. I painted the apartment myself, and at least that problem was ended. I was in a hurry to get settled because I was starting school at the University of San Francisco in September. A transportation problem developed because my stepmother insisted that I return my father's bike, which I was using at first to get to school. I had to rely on a bus that often arrived late, with the result that I missed some classes and was late for others. I had already had a problem with registration in early September. My counselor had made a mistake with my classes, and I had to register all over again. This meant that I was one week late for class. Now I'm riding to school with a classmate and no longer have to depend on the bus. My life is starting to order itself, but I must admit that at first I thought it was hopeless to stay here.

EXPLANATION

The writer of this paragraph has provided a good deal of specific evidence to support the opening point. The evidence, however, needs to be organized. Before starting the paragraph, the writer should have decided to arrange the details by using time order. He or she could then have listed in a scratch outline the exact sequence of events that made for such a difficult period.

Activity 10

Here is a list of the various events described by the writer of paragraph 1. Number the events in the correct time sequence by writing 1 in front of the first event that occurred, 2 in front of the second event, and so on.

Since I arrived in the Bay Area in midsummer, I have had the most difficult period of my life.

- _____ I had to search for an apartment I could afford.
- _____ I had to find a job so that I could afford my own place.
- _____ My stepmother objected to my living with her and my father.
- _____ I had to paint the apartment before I could move in.
- _____ I had to find an alternative to unreliable bus transportation.
- _____ I had to register again for my college courses because of a counselor’s mistake.

Your instructor may now have you rewrite the paragraph on separate paper. If so, be sure to use time signals such as *first*, *next*, *then*, *during*, *when*, *after*, and *now* to help guide your reader from one event to the next.

Paragraph 2

Childhood Cruelty

When I was in grade school, my classmates and I found a number of excuses for being cruel to a boy named Andy Poppovian. Sometimes Andy gave off a strong body odor, and we knew that several days had passed since he had taken a bath. Andy was very slow in speaking, as well as very careless in personal hygiene. The teacher would call on him during a math or grammar drill. He would sit there silently for so long before answering that she sometimes said, "Are you awake, Andy?" Andy had long fingernails that he never seemed to cut, with black dirt caked under them. We called him "Poppy," or we accented the first syllable in his name and mispronounced the rest of it and said to him, "How are you today, POP-o-van?" His name was funny. Other times we called him "Popeye," and we would shout at him, "Where's your spinach today, Popeye?" Andy always had sand in the corners of his eyes. When we played tag at recess, Andy was always "it" or the first one who was caught. He was so physically slow that five guys could dance around him and he wouldn't be able to touch any of them. Even when we tried to hold a regular conversation with him about sports or a teacher, he was so slow in responding to a question that we got bored talking with him. Andy's hair was always uncombed, and it was often full of white flakes of dandruff. Only when Andy died suddenly of spinal meningitis in seventh grade did some of us begin to realize and regret our cruelty toward him.

EXPLANATION

The writer of this paragraph provides a number of specifics that support the opening point. However, the supporting material has not been organized clearly. Before writing this paragraph, the author should have (1) decided to arrange the supporting evidence by using emphatic order and (2) listed in a scratch outline the reasons for the cruelty to Andy Poppovian and the supporting details for each reason. The writer could also have determined which reason to use in the emphatic final position of the paper.

Activity 11

Create a clear outline for paragraph 2 by filling in the scheme below. The outline is partially completed.

When I was in grade school, my classmates and I found a number of excuses for being cruel to a boy named Andy Poppovian.

Reason 1. Because

- Details a. _____
b. _____
c. _____

Reason 2. Partly due

- Details a. _____
b. I might not know any of them

Reason 3. _____

- Details a. _____
b. I might not remember

Reason 4. _____

- Details a. _____
b. Used to argue
c. _____
d. _____

Your instructor may have you rewrite the paragraph on separate paper. If so, be sure to introduce each of the four reasons with transitions such as *First*, *Second*, *Another reason*, and *Finally*. You may also want to use repeated words, pronouns, and synonyms to help tie your sentences together.

6 Evaluating Paragraphs for All Four Bases: Unity, Support, Coherence, and Sentence Skills

Activity 12

In this activity, you will evaluate paragraphs in terms of all four bases: unity, support, coherence, and sentence skills. Evaluative comments follow each paragraph below. Circle the letter of the statement that best applies in each case.

1. Drunk Drivers

People caught driving while drunk—even first offenders—should be jailed. Drunk driving, first of all, is more dangerous than carrying around a loaded gun. In addition, a jail term would show drivers that society will no longer tolerate such careless and dangerous behavior. Finally, severe penalties might encourage solutions to the problem of drinking and driving. People who go out for a good time and intend to have several drinks would always designate one person, who would stay completely sober, as the driver.

- a. The paragraph is not unified.
- b. The paragraph is not adequately supported.
- c. The paragraph is not well organized.
- d. The paragraph does not show a command of sentence skills.
- e. The paragraph is well written in terms of the four bases.

2. A Frustrating Moment

A frustrating moment happened to me several days ago. When I was shopping. I had picked up a tube of crest toothpaste and a jar of noxema skincream. After the cashier rang up the purchases, which came to \$12.15. I handed her \$20. Then got back my change, which was only \$0.85. I told the cashier that she had made a mistake. Giving me change for \$13 instead of \$20. But she insist that I had only gave her \$13, I became very upset and demand that she return the rest of my change. She refused to do so instead she asked me to step aside so she could wait on the next customer. I stood very rigid, trying not to lose my temper. I simply said to her, I'm not going to leave here, Miss, without my change for \$20. Giving in at this point a bell was rung and the manager was summoned. After the situation was explain to him, he ask the cashier to ring off her register to check for the change. After doing so, the cashier was \$7 over her sale receipts. Only then did the manager return my change and apologize for the cashier mistake.

161

162

- a. The paragraph is not unified.
- b. The paragraph is not adequately supported.
- c. The paragraph is not well organized.
- d. The paragraph does not show a command of sentence skills.
- e. The paragraph is well written in terms of the four bases.

3. Asking Girls Out

There are several reasons I have trouble asking girls to go out with me. I have asked some girls out and have been turned down. This is one reason that I can't talk to them. At one time I was very shy and quiet, and people sometimes didn't even know I was present. I can talk to girls now as friends, but as soon as I want to ask them out, I usually start to become quiet, and a little bit of shyness comes out. When I finally get the nerve up, the girl will turn me down, and I swear that I will never ask another one out again. I feel sure I will get a refusal, and I have no confidence in myself. Also, my friends mock me, though they aren't any better than I am. It can become discouraging when your friends get on you. Sometimes I just stand there and wait to hear what line the girl will use. The one they use a lot is "We like you as a friend, Ted, and it's better that way." All my past experiences with girls have been just as bad. One girl used me to make her old boyfriend jealous. Then when she succeeded, she started going out with him again. I had a bad experience when I took a girl to the prom. I spent a lot of money on her. Two days later, she told me that she was getting serious with another guy. I feel that when I meet a girl I have to be sure I can trust her. I don't want her to turn on me.

- a. The paragraph is not unified.
- b. The paragraph is not adequately supported.
- c. The paragraph is not well organized.
- d. The paragraph does not show a command of sentence skills.
- e. The paragraph is well written in terms of the four bases.

162

4. A Change in My Writing

A technique of my present English instructor has corrected a writing problem that I've always had. In past English courses, I had major problems with commas in the wrong places, bad spelling, capitalizing the wrong words, sentence fragments, and run-on sentences. I never had any big problems with unity, support, or coherence, but the sentence skills were another matter. They were like little bugs that always appeared to infest my writing. My present instructor asked me to rewrite papers, just concentrating on sentence skills. I thought that the instructor was crazy because I didn't feel that rewriting would do any good. I soon became certain that my instructor was out of his mind, for he made me rewrite my first paper four times. It was very

163

frustrating, for I became tired of doing the same paper over and over. I wanted to belt my instructor against the wall when I'd show him each new draft and he'd find skills mistakes and say, "Rewrite." Finally, my papers began to improve and the sentence skills began to fall into place. I was able to see them and correct them before turning in a paper, whereas I couldn't before. Why or how this happened I don't know, but I think that rewriting helped a lot. It took me most of the semester, but I stuck it out and the work paid off.

- a. The paragraph is not unified.
- b. The paragraph is not adequately supported.
- c. The paragraph is not well organized.
- d. The paragraph does not show a command of sentence skills.
- e. The paragraph is well written in terms of the four bases.

5. **Luck and Me**

I am a very lucky man, though the rest of my family has not always been lucky. Sometimes when I get depressed, which is too frequently, it's hard to see just how lucky I am. I'm lucky that I'm living in a country that is free. I'm allowed to worship the way I want to, and that is very important to me. Without a belief in God a person cannot live with any real certainty in life. My relationship with my wife is a source of good fortune for me. She gives me security, and that's something I need a lot. Even with these positive realities in my life, I still seem to find time for insecurity, worry, and, worst of all, depression. At times in my life I have had bouts of terrible luck. But overall, I'm a very lucky guy. I plan to further develop the positive aspects of my life and try to eliminate the negative ones.

- a. The paragraph is not unified.
- b. The paragraph is not adequately supported.
- c. The paragraph is not well organized.
- d. The paragraph does not show a command of sentence skills.
- e. The paragraph is well written in terms of the four bases.

PART 2: Paragraph Development



This photograph is clearly making a statement. Write a paragraph about what you think that statement is and why you came to that conclusion. You may want to use personal experience to strengthen the support in your paragraph.

[7: Introduction to Paragraph Development](#)

[8: Exemplification](#)

[9: Process](#)

[10: Cause and Effect](#)

[11: Comparison or Contrast](#)

[12: Definition](#)

[13: Division-Classification](#)

[14: Description](#)

[15: Narration](#)

[16: Argument](#)

[17: Additional Paragraph Assignments](#)

7: Introduction to Paragraph Development



The kimono, pictured on the women in the photograph above, is the traditional garment of Japan. Its form and use have been refined to play an appropriate role in Japan's modern life, and it is often worn on special occasions. Can you think of a special tradition that you share with your family, friends, or your culture? Write a paragraph about this special tradition.

This chapter will

- explain the importance of knowing your subject
- explain the importance of knowing your purpose and audience
- offer tips on using a computer at each stage of the writing process
- show you how to conduct a peer review and personal review
- introduce you to nine patterns of paragraph development

166

167

Important Considerations in Paragraph Development

Before you begin work on particular types of paragraphs, there are several general considerations about writing to keep in mind: knowing your subject, knowing your purpose, and knowing your audience.

Knowing Your Subject

Whenever possible, write on a subject that interests you. You will then find it easier to put more time into your work. Even more important, try to write on a subject that you already know something about. If you do not have direct experience with the subject, you should at least have indirect experience—knowledge gained through thinking, prewriting, reading, or talking about the subject.

If you are asked to write on a topic about which you have no experience or knowledge, you should do whatever research is required to gain the information you need. [Chapters 19 and 20](#) will show you how to look up relevant information at the library and online, and how to write a research paper. Without direct or indirect experience, or the information you gain through research, you may not be able to provide the specific evidence needed to develop whatever point you are trying to make. Your writing will be starved for specifics.

Knowing Your Purpose and Audience

The three most common purposes of writing are *to inform*, *to persuade*, and *to entertain*. Each is described briefly below.

- To **inform**—to give information about a subject. Authors who are writing to inform want to provide facts that will explain or teach something to readers. For example, an informative paragraph about sandwiches might begin, “Eating food between two slices of bread—a sandwich—is a practice that has its origins in eighteenth-century England.”
- To **persuade**—to convince the reader to agree with the author’s point of view on a subject. Authors who are writing to persuade may give facts, but their main goal is to argue or prove a point to readers. A persuasive paragraph about sandwiches might begin, “There are good reasons why every sandwich should be made with whole grain bread.”

- To **entertain**—to amuse and delight; to appeal to the reader’s senses and imagination. Authors write to entertain in various ways, through fiction and nonfiction. An entertaining paragraph about sandwiches might begin, “What I wanted was a midnight snack, but what I got was better—the biggest, most magical sandwich in the entire world.”

167

Much of the writing assigned in this book will involve some form of argumentation or persuasion. You will advance a point or thesis and then support it in a variety of ways. To some extent, also, you will write papers to inform—to provide readers with information about a particular subject. And since, in practice, writing often combines purposes, you might also find yourself providing vivid or humorous details in order to entertain your readers.

168

Your audience will be primarily your instructor and sometimes other students. Your instructor is really a symbol of the larger audience you should see yourself writing for—an audience of educated adults who expect you to present your ideas in a clear, direct, organized way. If you can learn to write to persuade or inform such a general audience, you will have accomplished a great deal.

A Note on Tone

It will also be helpful for you to write some papers for a more specific audience. By so doing, you will develop an ability to choose words and adopt a tone of voice that is just right for a given purpose and a given group of people. *Tone* reveals the attitude that a writer has toward a subject. It is expressed through the words and details the writer selects. Just as a speaker’s voice can project a range of feelings, a writer’s voice can project one or more tones, or feelings: anger, sympathy, hopefulness, sadness, respect, dislike, and so on.

Activity 1

To appreciate differences in tone, look at the six statements below, which express different attitudes about a shabby apartment. Six different tones are used. Label each statement with the tone you think is present.

a. bitter	c. matter-of-fact	e. tolerant and accepting
b. sentimental	d. humorous	f. optimistic and hopeful

- _____ 1. This place may be shabby, but since both of my children were born while we lived here, it has a special place in my heart.
- _____ 2. This isn’t the greatest apartment in the world, but it’s not really that bad.
- _____ 3. If only there were some decent jobs out there, I wouldn’t be reduced to living in this miserable dump.
- _____ 4. This place does need some repairs, but I’m sure the landlord will be making improvements sometime soon.

168

- ____ 5. When we move away, we’re planning to release three hundred cockroaches and two mice so we can leave the place exactly as we found it.
- ____ 6. It’s a small two-bedroom apartment that needs to be repainted and have the kitchen plumbing repaired.

EXPLANATION

The tone of item 1 is sentimental. “It has a special place in my heart” expresses tender emotions. In item 2, the words “not really that bad” show that the writer is tolerant, accepting the situation while recognizing that it could be better. We could describe the tone of item 3 as bitter. The writer resents a situation that forces him or her to live in a “miserable dump.” Item 4 is optimistic and hopeful, since the writer is expecting the apartment to be improved soon. The tone of item 5 is humorous. Its writer claims to be planning a comic revenge on the landlord. The tone of item 6 is matter-of-fact and objective, simply describing what needs to be done.

The “Purpose and Audience” Assignment in Each Chapter

In this part of the book, there is an assignment at the end of each chapter that asks you to write with a very specific purpose in mind and for a very specific audience. You will be asked, for example, to imagine yourself as an employee writing a description of a new job opening at your workplace, as a graduate of a local high school advising a counselor there about a drug problem, as an aide at a day-care center preparing instructions for children, as an apartment tenant complaining to a landlord about neighbors, or as a travel agent providing suggestions for different kinds of family vacations. Through these and other assignments, you will learn how to adjust your style and tone of voice to a given writing situation.

Tips on Using a Computer

- If you are using your school’s computer center, allow yourself enough time. You may have to wait for a computer or printer to be free. In addition, you may need several sessions at the computer and printer to complete your paper.
- Every word-processing program allows you to save your writing by hitting one or more keys. Save your work file frequently as you write your draft. A saved file is stored safely on the computer or network. Work that is not saved may be lost if the computer crashes or if the power is turned off.
- Keep your work in two places—the hard drive or network you are working on and, if you have one, a backup USB drive. At the end of each session with the computer, copy your work onto the USB drive or e-mail a copy to yourself. Then if the hard drive or network becomes damaged, you’ll have the backup copy.

- Print out your work at least at the end of every session. Then not only will you have your most recent draft to work on away from the computer, you'll also have a copy in case something should happen to your electronic file.
- Work in single spacing so that you can see as much of your writing on the screen at one time as possible. Just before you print out your work, change to double spacing.
- Before making major changes in a paper, create a copy of your file. For example, if your file is titled "Worst Job," create a file called "Worst Job 2." Then make all your changes in that file. If the changes don't work out, you can always go back to the original file.

Using a Computer at Each Stage of the Writing Process

Following are some ways to make word processing a part of your writing. Note that the sections that follow correspond to the stages of the writing process described in [Chapter 2, pages 17–45](#).

Prewriting

If you're a fast typist, many kinds of prewriting will work well on the computer. With freewriting in particular, you can get ideas onto the screen almost as quickly as they occur to you. A passing thought that could be productive is not likely to get lost. You may even find it helpful, when freewriting, to dim the screen of your monitor so that you can't see what you're typing. If you temporarily can't see the screen, you won't have to worry about grammar or spelling or typing errors (all of which do not matter in prewriting); instead, you can concentrate on getting down as many ideas and details as possible about your subject.

After any initial freewriting, questioning, and list-making on a computer, it's often very helpful to print out a hard copy of what you've done. With a clean printout in front of you, you'll be able to see everything at once and revise and expand your work with handwritten comments in the margins of the paper.

Word processing also makes it easy for you to experiment with the wording of the point of your paper. You can try a number of versions in a short time. After you have decided on the version that works best, you can easily delete the other versions—or simply move them to a temporary "leftover" section at the end of the paper.

If you have prepared a list of items, you may be able to turn that list into an outline right on the screen. Delete the ideas you feel should not be in your paper (saving them at the end of the file in case you change your mind), and add any new ideas that occur to you. Then use the cut and paste functions to shuffle the supporting ideas around until you find the best order for your paper.

Writing Your First Draft

Like many writers, you may want to write out a first draft by hand and then type it into the computer for revision. Even as you type your handwritten draft, you may find yourself making some changes and

170

171

improvements. And once you have a draft on the screen, or printed out, you will find it much easier to revise than a handwritten one.

If you feel comfortable composing directly on the screen, you can benefit from the computer's special features. For example, if you have written an anecdote in your freewriting that you plan to use in your paper, simply copy the story from your freewriting file and insert it where it fits in your paper. You can refine it then or later. Or if you discover while typing that a sentence is out of place, cut it out from where it is and paste it wherever you wish. And if while writing you realize that an earlier sentence can be expanded, just move your cursor back to that point and type in the added material.

Revising

It is during revision that the virtues of word processing really shine. All substituting, adding, deleting, and rearranging can be done easily within an existing file. All changes instantly take their proper places within the paper, not scribbled above the line or squeezed into the margin. You can concentrate on each change you want to make, because you never have to type from scratch or work on a messy draft. You can carefully go through your paper to check that all your supporting evidence is relevant and to add new support as needed here and there. Anything you decide to eliminate can be deleted in a keystroke. Anything you add can be inserted precisely where you choose. If you change your mind, all you have to do is delete or cut and paste. Then you can sweep through the paper focusing on other changes: improving word choice, increasing sentence variety, eliminating wordiness, and so on.

TIP

If you are like some students, you will find it convenient to print out a hard copy of your file at various points throughout the revision. You can then revise in longhand—adding, crossing out, and indicating changes—and later quickly make those changes in the document.

Editing and Proofreading

Editing and proofreading also benefit richly from word processing. Instead of crossing or whiting out mistakes, or rewriting an entire paper to correct numerous errors, you can make all necessary changes within the most recent draft. If you find editing or proofreading on the screen hard on your eyes, print out a copy. Mark any corrections on that copy, and then transfer them to the final draft.

If the word-processing program you're using includes spelling and grammar checks, by all means use them. The spell-check function tells you when a word is not in the computer's dictionary. Keep in mind, however, that the spell-check cannot tell you how to spell a name correctly or when you have mistakenly used, for example, *their* instead of *there*. To a spell-check, *Thank ewe four the complement* is as correct as *Thank you for the compliment*. Also use the grammar check with caution. Any errors it doesn't uncover are still your responsibility, and it sometimes points out mistakes where there are none.

A word-processed paper, with its clean appearance and attractive formatting, looks so good that you may think it is in better shape than it really is. Do not be fooled by your paper's appearance. Take sufficient time to review your grammar, punctuation, and spelling carefully.

TIP

Even after you hand in your paper, save the computer file. Your teacher may ask you to do some revising, and then the file will save you from having to type the paper from scratch.

Using Peer Review

Often, it is a good idea to have another student respond to your writing before you hand it in to the instructor. On the day a composition is due, or on a day when you are writing paragraphs or essays in class, your instructor may ask you to pair up with another student. That student will read your composition, and you will read his or hers.



Ideally, read the other paragraph or essay aloud while your partner listens. If that is not practical, read it in a whisper while he or she looks on. As you read, both you and your partner should look and listen for spots where the composition does not read smoothly and clearly. Check or circle the trouble spots where your reading snags.

Your partner should then read your work, marking possible trouble spots while doing so. Then each of you should do three things:

1: Identification

On a separate sheet of paper, write at the top the title and author of the composition you have read. Under it, put your name as the reader of the paragraph or essay.

2: Scratch Outline

“X-ray” the paper for its inner logic by making up a scratch outline. The scratch outline need be no more than twenty words or so, but it should show clearly the logical foundation on which the paragraph or essay is built. It should identify and summarize the overall point of the paper and the three areas of support for the point.

Your outline should be organized like this:

Point: _____

Support:

- 1. _____
- 2. _____
- 3. _____

172
173

For example, here is a scratch outline of the paper on [page 208](#) about a new puppy in the house:

Point: A new puppy can have dramatic effects on a house.

Support:

- 1. Keep family away of other
- 2. Deny roomers
- 3. Change roomers

3: Comments

Under the outline, write the heading “Comments.” Here is what you should comment on:

- Look at the spots where your reading of the composition snagged: Are words missing or misspelled? Is there a lack of parallel structure? Are there mistakes with punctuation? Is the meaning of a sentence confusing? Try to figure out what the problems are and suggest ways of fixing them.
- Are there spots in the paragraph or essay where you see problems with *unity*, *support*, or *organization*? (You’ll find it helpful to refer to the checklist on the inside back cover of this book.) If so, offer comments. For example, for an essay, you might say, “More details are needed in the first supporting paragraph,” or “Some of the details in the last supporting paragraph don’t really back up your point.”
- Finally, make note of something you really liked about the composition, such as good use of transitions or an especially realistic or vivid specific detail.

After you have completed your evaluation of the paragraph or essay, give it to your partner. Your instructor may provide you with the option of rewriting your composition in light of this feedback. Whether or not you rewrite, be sure to hand in the peer evaluation form with your paragraph or essay.

173
174

Doing a Personal Review

- 1. While you’re writing and revising a paragraph or essay, you should be constantly evaluating it in terms of *unity*, *support*, and *organization*. Use as a guide the detailed checklist on the inside back cover of this book.
- 2. After you’ve finished the next-to-final draft of a composition, check it for the *sentence skills* listed on the inside back cover. It may also help to read your work out loud. If a given sentence does not sound right—that is, if it does not read clearly and smoothly—chances are something is wrong. In that case, revise or edit as necessary until your composition is complete.

Nine Patterns of Paragraph Development



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Traditionally, writing has been divided into the following patterns of development:

- **Exposition**
 - Examples
 - Process
 - Cause and effect
- **Description**
- **Narration**
- **Argumentation**

- **Comparison and contrast**
- **Definition**
- **Division and classification**

In *exposition*, the writer provides information about and explains a particular subject. Patterns of development within exposition include giving *examples*, detailing a *process* of doing or making something, analyzing *causes and effects*, *comparing* and *contrasting*, *defining* a term or concept, and *dividing* something into parts or *classifying* it into categories.

In addition to exposition, three other patterns of development are common: *description*, *narration*, and *argumentation*. A *description* is a verbal picture of a person, place, or thing. In *narration*, a writer tells the story of something that happened. Finally, in *argumentation*, a writer attempts to support a controversial point or defend a position on which there is a difference of opinion.

The pages ahead present individual chapters on each pattern. You will have a chance, then, to learn nine different patterns or methods for organizing material in your papers. Each pattern has its own internal logic and provides its own special strategies for imposing order on your ideas.

As you practice each pattern, you should remember the following:

174
175

TIP

While each paragraph that you write will involve one predominant pattern, very often one or more additional patterns may be involved as well. For instance, the paragraph “Good-Bye, Tony” ([page 50](#)) presents a series of causes leading to an effect—that the writer will not go out with Tony again. But the writer also presents examples to explain each of the causes (Tony was late, he was bossy, he was abrupt). And there is an element of narration, as the writer presents examples that occur from the beginning to the end of the date.

No matter which pattern or patterns you use, each paragraph will probably involve some form of argumentation. You will advance a point and then go on to support your point. To convince the reader that your point is valid, you may use exemplification, narration, description, or some other pattern of organization. Among the paragraphs you will read in Part Two, one writer supports the point that a certain pet shop is depressing by providing a number of descriptive details. Another writer labels a certain experience in his life as heartbreaking and then uses a narrative to demonstrate the truth of his statement. A third writer advances the opinion that good horror movies can be easily distinguished from bad horror movies and then supplies comparative information about both to support her claim. Much of your writing, in short, will have the purpose of persuading your reader that the idea you have advanced is valid.

The Progression in Each Chapter

After each type of paragraph development is explained, student papers illustrating that type are presented, followed by questions about the paragraphs. The questions relate to unity, support, and coherence—the four bases of effective writing. You are then asked to write your own paragraph. In most cases, the first assignment is fairly structured and provides a good deal of guidance for the writing process. The other assignments offer a wide choice of writing topics. The fourth assignment always requires some simple research, and the fifth assignment requires writing with a specific purpose and for a specific audience.

8: Exemplification



Is the United States a health-conscious nation? Look at the photograph above and write a paragraph in which you answer this question. Use examples found in the media, in this photograph, or in your own daily observations to support your point.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop an exemplification paragraph
- write an exemplification paragraph
- revise an exemplification paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student paragraphs

176

In our daily conversations, we often provide *examples*—that is, details, particulars, specific instances—to explain statements that we make. Consider the several statements and supporting examples in the box below:

177



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Statement	Examples
Wal-Mart was crowded today.	There were at least four carts waiting at each of the checkout counters, and it took me forty-five minutes to get through a line.
The corduroy shirt I bought is poorly made.	When I washed it, the colors began to fade, one button cracked and another fell off, a shoulder seam opened, and the sleeves shrank almost two inches.
My son Peter is unreliable.	If I depend on him to turn off a pot of beans in ten minutes, the family is likely to eat burned beans. If I ask him to turn down the thermostat before he goes to bed, the heat is likely to stay on all night.

In each case, the examples help us *see for ourselves* the truth of the statement that has been made. In paragraphs, too, explanatory examples help the audience fully understand a point. Lively, specific examples also add interest to a paragraph.

In this chapter, you will be asked to provide a series of examples to support a topic sentence. Providing examples to support a point is one of the most common and simplest methods of paragraph development. First read the paragraphs ahead; they all use examples to develop their points. Then answer the questions that follow.

Paragraphs to Consider

Inconsiderate Drivers

¹Some people are inconsiderate drivers. ²In the city, they will at times stop right in the middle of the street while looking for a certain home or landmark. ³If they had any consideration for the cars behind them, they would pull over to the curb first. ⁴Other drivers will be chatting on their cell phones and then slow down unexpectedly at a city intersection to make a right or left turn. ⁵The least they could do is use their turn signals to let those behind them know in advance of their intention. ⁶On the highway, a common example of inconsiderateness is night drivers who fail to turn off their high beams, creating glare for cars approaching in the other direction. ⁷Other rude highway drivers move to the second or passing lane and then stay there, making it impossible for cars behind to go around them. ⁸Yet other drivers who act as if they have special privileges are those who do not wait their turn in bottleneck situations where the cars in two lanes must merge alternately into one lane. ⁹Perhaps the most inconsiderate drivers are those who throw trash out their windows, creating litter that takes away some of the pleasure of driving and that must be paid for with everyone's tax dollars.

177

178

Office Politics

¹Office politics is a destructive game played by several types of people. ²For instance, two supervisors may get into a conflict over how to do a certain job. ³Instead of working out an agreement like adults, they carry on a power struggle that turns the poor employees under them into human Ping-Pong balls being swatted between two angry players. ⁴Another common example of office politics is the ambitious worker who takes credit for other people's ideas. ⁵He or she will chat in a "friendly" fashion with inexperienced employees, getting their ideas about how to run the office more smoothly. ⁶Next thing you know, Mr. or Ms. Idea-Stealer is having a closed-door session with the boss and getting promotion points for his or her "wonderful creativity." ⁷Yet another illustration of office politics is the spy. ⁸This employee acts very buddy-buddy with other workers, often dropping little comments about things he or she doesn't like in the workplace. ⁹The spy encourages people to talk about their problems at work, how they don't like their boss, the pay, and the working conditions. ¹⁰Then the spy goes straight back and repeats all he or she has heard to the boss, and the employees get blamed for their "poor attitude." ¹¹A final example of office politics is people who gossip. ¹²Too often, office politics can turn a perfectly fine work situation into a stressful one.

178

An Egotistical Neighbor

¹I have an egotistical neighbor named Alice. ²If I tell Alice how beautiful her dress is, she will take the time to tell me the name of the store where she bought it, the type of material that was used in making it, and the price. ³Alice is also egotistical when it comes to her children. ⁴Because they are hers, she thinks they just have to be the best children on the block. ⁵I am wasting my time by trying to tell her I have seen her kids expose themselves on the street or take things from parked cars. ⁶I do not think parents should praise their children too much. ⁷Kids have learned how to be good at home and simply awful when they are not at home. ⁸Finally, Alice is quick to describe the furnishings of her home for someone who is meeting her for the first time. ⁹She tells how much she paid for the paneling in her dining room. ¹⁰She mentions that she has three flat-screen television sets and that they were bought at an expensive electronics store. ¹¹She lets the person know that the entertainment system in her living room cost more than two thousand dollars, and that she has such a large collection of DVDs, she would not be able to watch them all in one week. ¹²Poor Alice is so self-centered that she never realizes how boring she can be.

Question

About Unity

- 1 Which two sentences in “An Egotistical Neighbor” are irrelevant to the point that Alice is egotistical? (*Write the sentence numbers here.*)

About Support

- 2 In “Inconsiderate Drivers,” how many examples are given of inconsiderate drivers?

_____two _____four _____six _____seven

- 3 After which sentence in “Office Politics” are specific details needed?

About Coherence

4	What are the four transition words or phrases that are used to introduce each new example in “Office Politics”?	179
5	What two transition words are used to introduce examples in “An Egotistical Neighbor”?	180
6	Which paragraph clearly uses emphatic order to organize its details, saving for last what the writer regards as the most important example?	

Developing an Exemplification Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

Backing up your statements with clear, specific illustrations is the key to a successful examples paragraph. When Charlene, the writer of “Office Politics,” was assigned an examples paragraph, she at first did not know what to write about.

Then her teacher made a suggestion. “Imagine yourself having lunch with some friends,” the teacher said. “You’re telling them *how* you feel about something and *why*. Maybe you’re saying, ‘I am so mad at my boyfriend!’ or ‘My new apartment is really great.’ You wouldn’t stop there—you’d continue by saying what your boyfriend does that is annoying, or in what way your apartment is nice. In other words, you’d be making a general point and backing it up with examples. That’s what you need to do in this paragraph.”

That night, Charlene was on the telephone with her brother. She was complaining about the office where she worked. “Suddenly I realized what I was doing,” Charlene said. “I was making a statement—I hate the politics in my office—and giving examples of those politics. I knew what I could write about!”

Charlene began preparing to write her paragraph by freewriting. She gave herself ten minutes to write down everything she could think of on the subject of politics in her office. This is what she wrote:

Of all the places I've ever worked this one is the worst that way.
Can't trust anybody there—everybody's playing some sort of game.
Worst one of all is Bradley and the way he pretends to be friendly with
people. Gets them to complain about Ms. Bennett and Mr. Hawkins
and then runs back to them and reports everything. He should realize
that people are catching on to his game and figuring out what a jerk
he is. Melissa steals people's ideas and then takes credit for them.
Anything to get brownie points. She's always out for herself first, you
can tell. Then there's all the gossip that goes on. You think you're in a
soap opera or something, and it's kind of fun in a way but it also is
very distracting people always talking about each other and worrying
about what they say about you. And people talk about our bosses a lot.
Nobody knows why Mr. Bennett and Mr. Hawkins hate each other so
much but they each wins the workers on their side. You do something
one boss's way, but then the other boss appears and is angry that
you're not doing it another way. You don't know what to do at times to
keep people happy.

Charlene read over her freewriting and then spent some time asking questions about her paragraph. “Exactly what do I want my point to be?” she asked. “And exactly how am I going to support that point?” Keeping those points in mind, she worked on several scratch outlines and wound up with the following:

Office politics are ruining the office.

1. Bradley reports people's complaints.

2. Melissa steals ideas.

3. People gossip.

4. Ms. Bennett and Mr. Hankins make workers choose sides.

Working from this outline, she then wrote the following first draft:

My office is being ruined by office politics. It seems like everybody is trying to play some sort of game to get ahead and don't care what it does to anybody else. One example is Bradley. Although he pretends to be friendly with people he isn't sincere. What he is trying to do is get them to complain about their bosses. Once they do, he goes back to the bosses and tells them what's been said and gets the worker in trouble. I've seen the same kind of thing happen at two other offices where I've worked. Melissa is another example of someone who plays office politics games. She steals other people's ideas and takes the credit for them. I had a good idea once on how to reduce office memos. I told her we ought to use e-mail to send office memos instead of typing them on paper. She went to Ms. Bennett and pretended the idea was hers. I guess I was partly to blame for not acting on the idea myself. And Ms. Bennett and Mr. Hankins hate each other and try to get us to take sides in their conflict. Then there is all the gossip that goes on. People do a lot of backbiting, and you have to be very careful about your behavior or people will start talking about you. All in all, office politics is really a problem where I work.

Development through Revising

After completing her first draft, Charlene put it aside until the next day. When she reread it, this was her response:

"I think the paragraph would be stronger if I made it about office politics in general instead of just politics in my office. The things I was writing about happen in many offices, not just in mine. And our instructor wants us to try some third-person writing. Also, I need to make better use of transitions to help the reader follow as I move from one example to another."

With these thoughts in mind, Charlene began revising her paragraph, and after several drafts she produced the paragraph that appears on [page 178](#).

Writing an Exemplification Paragraph

Writing Assignment 1

The assignment here is to complete an unfinished paragraph (in the box), which has as its topic sentence, "My husband Roger is a selfish person." Provide the supporting details needed to develop the examples of Roger's selfishness. The first example has been done for you.

A Selfish Person

My husband Roger is a selfish person. For one thing, he refuses to move out of the city, even though it is a bad place to raise the children.

We inherited some money when my parents died, and it might be enough for a down payment on a small house in a nearby town.

But Roger says he would miss his buddies in the neighborhood.

Also, when we go on vacation, we always go where Roger wants to go.

Another example of Roger's selfishness is that he always spends any budget money that is left over. _____

Finally, Roger leaves all the work of caring for the children to me.

Prewriting

- a. On a separate piece of paper, jot down a couple of answers for each of the following questions:
- What specific vacations did the family go on because Roger wanted to go? Write down particular places, length of stay, time of year. What vacations has the family never gone on (for example, to visit the wife’s relatives), even though the wife wanted to?
 - What specific items has Roger bought for himself (rather than for the whole family’s use) with leftover budget money?
 - What chores and duties involved in the everyday caring for the children has Roger never done?

Your instructor may ask you to work with one or two other students in generating the details needed to develop the three examples in the paragraph. The groups may then be asked to read their details aloud, with the class deciding which details are the most effective for each example.



Here and in general in your writing, try to generate *more* supporting material than you need. You are then in a position to choose the most convincing details for your paragraph.

- b. Read over the details you have generated and decide which sound most effective. Jot down additional details as they occur to you.
- c. Take your best details, reshape them as needed, and use them to complete the paragraph about Roger.

Revising

Read over the paragraph you have written. Ask yourself these questions:

FOUR BASES Checklist for Exemplification

About *Unity*

- ❏ Do all of the examples I provide support the central idea that Roger is selfish?

About *Support*

- ❏ Are there enough examples to make my point about Roger and convince others to agree with me?
- ❏ Do I appeal to my readers’ senses with vivid, specific examples?

About *Coherence*

- Have I presented the examples in my paragraph in the most effective order?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I used specific rather than general words?
- Are my sentences varied in length and structure?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.

Writing Assignment 2

Write an examples paragraph about one quality of a person you know well. The person might be a member of your family, a friend, a roommate, a boss or supervisor, a neighbor, an instructor, or someone else. Here is a list of descriptions that you might consider choosing from. Feel free to choose another description that does not appear here.

Honest	Hardworking	Jealous
Bad-tempered	Supportive	Materialistic
Ambitious	Suspicious	Sarcastic
Prejudiced	Open-minded	Self-centered
Considerate	Lazy	Spineless
Argumentative	Independent	Good-humored
Softhearted	Stubborn	Cooperative
Energetic	Flirtatious	Self-disciplined
Patient	Irresponsible	Sentimental
Reliable	Stingy	Defensive
Generous	Trustworthy	Dishonest
Persistent	Aggressive	Insensitive
Shy	Courageous	Unpretentious
Sloppy	Compulsive	Tidy

185

186



	Prewriting a. Select the individual you will write about and the quality of this person that you will focus on. For example, you might choose a self-disciplined cousin. Her quality of self-discipline will then be the point of your paper. b. Make a list of examples that will support your point. A list for the self-disciplined cousin might look like this: Exercises every day for forty-five minutes	186
	Never lets herself watch TV until homework is done Keeps herself on a strict budget Organizes her school papers in color-coordinated notebooks Eats no more than one dessert every week Balances her checkbook the day her statement arrives c. Read over your list and see how you might group the items into categories. The list above, for example, could be broken into three categories: schoolwork, fitness, and money. Exercises every day for forty-five minutes (fitness) Never lets herself watch TV until homework is done (schoolwork) Keeps herself on a strict budget (money) Organizes her school papers in color-coordinated notebooks (schoolwork) Eats no more than one dessert every week (fitness) Balances her checkbook the day her bank statement arrives (money) d. Prepare a scratch outline made up of the details you've generated, with those details grouped into appropriate categories. 1. <u>Self-disciplined about fitness</u> A. Exercises every day for forty-five minutes B. Eats no more than one dessert every week	187

2. Self-disciplined about schoolwork

- A. Never lets herself watch TV until homework is done
- B. Organizes her school papers in color-coordinated notebooks

3. Self-disciplined about money

- A. Keeps herself on a strict budget
- B. Balances her checkbook the day her bank statement arrives

e. Write the topic sentence of your paragraph. You should include the name of the person you’re writing about, your relationship to that person, and the specific quality you are focusing on. For example, you might write, “Keisha, a school mate of mine, is very flirtatious,” or “Stubbornness is Uncle Carl’s outstanding characteristic.” And a topic sentence for the paragraph about the self-disciplined cousin might be “My cousin Mari is extremely self-disciplined.”

Remember to focus on only *one* characteristic. Also remember to focus on a *specific* quality, not a vague, general quality. For instance, “My English instructor is a nice person” is too general.

f. Now you have a topic sentence and an outline and are ready to write the first draft of your paragraph. Remember, as you flesh out the examples, that your goal is not just to *tell* us about the person but to *show* us the person by detailing his or her words, actions, or both. In preparation for this writing assignment, you might want to go back and reread the examples provided in “An Egotistical Neighbor.”

187
188

Revising



It’s hard to criticize your own work honestly, especially just after you’ve finished writing. If at all possible, put your paragraph away for a day or so and then return to it. Better yet, wait a day and then read it aloud to a friend whose judgment you trust.

Read the paragraph with these questions in mind:

FOUR BASES Checklist for Exemplification

About *Unity*

- Does my topic sentence clearly state whom I am writing about, what that person’s relationship is to me, and what quality of that person I am going to focus on?
- Do the examples I provide truly show that my subject has the quality I am writing about?

About *Support*

- Have I provided enough specific details to solidly support my point that my subject has a certain quality?

About *Coherence*

- Have I organized the details in my paragraph into several clearly defined categories?
- Have I used transitional words such as *also*, *in addition*, *for example*, and *for instance* to help the reader follow my train of thought?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph?
- Have I used specific rather than general words?
- Have I used concise wording?
- Are my sentences varied?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you and your reader can answer “yes” to all these questions.

188

189

Writing Assignment 3

Write a paragraph that uses examples to develop one of the following statements or a related statement of your own.

1. _____ is a distracting place to try to study.
2. _____ The daily life of a student is filled with conflicts.
3. Abundant evidence exists that the United States has become a health-conscious nation.
4. Despite modern appliances, many household chores are still drudgery.
5. One of my instructors, _____, has some good (*or* unusual) teaching techniques.
6. Wasted electricity is all around us.
7. Life in the United States is faster-paced today than ever before.
8. Violence on television is widespread.

9. Today, some people are wearing ridiculous fashions.
10. Some students here at _____ do not care about learning (*or* are overly concerned about grades).

Be sure to choose examples that truly support your topic sentence. They should be relevant facts, statistics, personal experiences, or incidents you have heard or read about. Organize your paragraph by listing several examples that support your point. Save the most vivid, most convincing, or most important example for last.

Writing Assignment 4

As this cartoon suggests, the diet of many Americans is not healthy. We eat too much junk food and far too much cholesterol. Write a paragraph with a topic sentence like one of the following on [page 190](#):



The diet of the average American is unhealthy.

The diet of many American families is unhealthy.

189
190

Many schoolchildren in America do not have a healthy diet.

Using strategies described in [Chapter 19 \(pages 358–373\)](#), research the topic with keywords such as “unhealthy American diets.” Combine information you find with your own observations to provide a series of examples that support your point.

Writing Assignment 5

Considering Purpose and Audience

In this examples paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Imagine that you are a television critic for a daily newspaper. Your job is to recommend to viewers, every day, the programs most worth watching. You’ve decided that there is nothing particularly good on TV today. Therefore, your plan is to write a one-paragraph article about TV commercials, supporting this point: “Television advertisements are more entertaining than the programs they interrupt.” To prepare for this article, spend some time watching television, taking detailed notes on several ads. Decide on two or three ways in which the ads are entertaining; these ways will be the main supporting points in your outline. Then choose at least one ad to use as a specific example to illustrate each of those points. Here are some entertaining qualities that may be seen in ads:

Humor	Drama	Suspense
Cleverness	Emotion	Beauty
Music		

9: Process



Write a paragraph that informs a particular reader how to “surf the Web.” For instance, you might tell film buffs how to find out about their favorite directors, or budding astronomers where to find help online, or students where to find help in one or more of their courses. Be sure to imagine a specific audience with specific interests and take them through the process of surfing the Web step by step.

Google, Inc.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop a process paragraph
- write a process paragraph
- revise a process paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student process paragraphs



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Every day we perform many activities that are *processes*— that is, series of steps carried out in a definite order. Many of these processes are familiar and automatic: for example, tying shoelaces, changing sheets,

using a vending machine, and starting a car. We are thus seldom aware of the sequence of steps making up each activity. In other cases, such as when we are asked for directions to a particular place, or when we try to read and follow the directions for a new game, we may be painfully conscious of the whole series of steps involved in the process.

In this section, you will be asked to write a process paragraph—one that explains clearly how to do or make something. To prepare for this assignment, you should first read the student process papers below and then respond to the questions that follow.

TIP

In process writing, you are often giving instructions to the reader, and so the pronoun *you* can appropriately be used. Two of the model paragraphs that follow use *you*—as indeed does much of this book, which gives instruction on how to write effectively. As a general rule, though, do not use *you* in your writing.



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Paragraphs to Consider

Sneaking into the House at Night

¹The first step I take is bringing my key along with me. ²Obviously, I don't want to have to knock on the door at 1:30 in the morning and rouse my parents out of bed. ³Second, I make it a point to stay out past midnight. ⁴If I come in before then, my father is still up, and I'll have to face his disapproving look. ⁵All I need in my life is for him to make me feel guilty. ⁶Trying to make it as a college student is as much as I'm ready to handle. ⁷Next, I am careful to be very quiet upon entering the house. ⁸This involves lifting the front door up slightly as I open it, so that it does not creak. ⁹It also means treating the floor and steps to the second floor like a minefield, stepping carefully over the spots that squeak. ¹⁰When I'm upstairs, I stop briefly in the bathroom without turning on the light. ¹¹Finally, I tiptoe to my room, put my clothes in a pile on a chair, and slip quietly into bed. ¹²With my careful method of sneaking into the house at night, I have avoided some major hassles with my parents.

How to Harass an Instructor

¹There are several steps you can take to harass an instructor during a class. ²First of all, show up late, so that you can interrupt the beginning of the instructor's presentation. ³Saunter in nonchalantly and try to find a seat next to a friend. ⁴In a normal tone of voice, speak some words of greeting to your friends as you sit down, and scrape your chair as loudly as possible while you make yourself comfortable in it. ⁵Then just sit there and do anything but pay attention. ⁶When the instructor sees that you are not involved in the class, he or she may pop a quick question, probably hoping to embarrass you. ⁷You should then say, in a loud voice, "I DON'T KNOW THE ANSWER." ⁸This declaration of ignorance will throw the instructor off guard. ⁹If the instructor then asks you why you don't know the answer, say, "I don't even know what page we're on" or "I thought the assignment was boring, so I didn't do it." ¹⁰After the instructor calls on someone else, get up loudly from your seat, walk to the front of the classroom, and demand to be excused for an emergency visit to the washroom. ¹¹Stay there at least fifteen minutes and take your time coming back. ¹²If the instructor asks you where you've been when you reenter the room, simply ignore the question and go to your seat. ¹³Flop into your chair, slouching back and extending your legs as far out as possible. ¹⁴When the instructor informs you of the assignment that the class is working on, heave an exaggerated sigh and very slowly open up your book and start turning the pages. ¹⁵About a half hour before class is over, begin to look at the clock every few minutes. ¹⁶Ten minutes before dismissal time, start noisily packing up your books and papers. ¹⁷Then get up and begin walking to the door a couple of minutes before the class is supposed to end. ¹⁸The instructor will look at you and wonder whether it wouldn't have been better to go into business instead of education.

192

193

Dealing with Verbal Abuse

¹If you are living with someone who abuses you verbally with criticism, complaints, and insults, you should take steps to change your situation. ²First, realize that you are not to blame for his or her abusive behavior. ³This may be difficult for you to believe. ⁴Years of verbal abuse have probably convinced you that you're responsible for everything that's wrong with your relationship. ⁵But that is a lie. ⁶If your partner is verbally abusive, it is that person's responsibility to learn why he or she chooses to deal with problems by saying nasty things. ⁷Perhaps he observed his father treating his mother that same way. ⁸Maybe she never learned any more positive ways to deal with negative emotions, like anger, fear, or disappointment. ⁹Steps two and three need to be done one right after the other. ¹⁰Step two is for you to announce that you will no longer tolerate being verbally abused. ¹¹State that you are a person who deserves respect and civil behavior, and that you will accept no less. ¹²Next, offer to go with him or her to talk to a counselor who will help both of you learn new ways to communicate. ¹³While your partner learns to express his or her feelings without attacking you, you can learn to stand up for yourself and express your feelings clearly. ¹⁴If he or she refuses to take responsibility for changing abusive behavior, then you must consider step four: to leave that person. ¹⁵You were not put here on earth to have your self-concept demolished by serving as someone else's verbal punching bag.

193

Questions

About Unity

- 1. Which paragraph lacks an opening topic sentence?

- 2. Which two sentences in “Sneaking into the House at Night” should be eliminated in the interest of paragraph unity? (*Write the sentence numbers here.*)

About Support

- 3. After which sentence in “How to Harass an Instructor” are supporting details (examples) needed?

- 4. Summarize the four steps in the process of dealing with verbal abuse.
 - a. _____
 - b. _____
 - c. _____
 - d. _____

About Coherence

- 5. Do these paragraphs use time order or emphatic order?

- 6. Which transition words introduce the first, second, and third steps in “Sneaking into the House at Night”?

Developing a Process Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

To be successful, a process essay must explain clearly each step of an activity. The key to preparing to write such an essay is thinking through the activity as though you’re doing it for the first time. Selma is the author of “Dealing with Verbal Abuse.” As she considered possible topics for her paper, she soon focused on a situation in her own life: living with an abusive man. Selma had not known how to change her situation. But with the help of a counselor, she realized there were steps she could take—a process she

could follow. She carried out that process and finally left her abusive partner. Remembering this, Selma decided to write about how to deal with abuse.

She began by making a list of the steps she followed in coping with her own abusive relationship. This is what she wrote:

Tell him you won't accept any more abuse.

Open your own checking account.

Apply for credit cards in your own name.

Offer to go with him to counseling.

Realize you're not to blame.

Learn to stand up for yourself.

Go into counseling yourself if he won't do it.

Call the police if he ever becomes violent.

Leave him if he refuses to change.

Next, she numbered the steps in the order in which she had performed them. She crossed out some items she realized weren't really part of the process of dealing with verbal abuse.

2 Tell him you won't accept any more abuse.

~~*Open your own checking account.*~~

~~*Apply for credit cards in your own name.*~~

3 Offer to go with him to counseling.

1 Realize you're not to blame.

5 Learn to stand up for yourself.

4 Go into counseling yourself if he won't do it.

~~*Call the police if he ever becomes violent.*~~

6 Leave him if he refuses to change.

195

196

Then Selma grouped her items into four steps. Those steps were (1) realize you're not to blame; (2) tell the abuser you won't accept more abuse; (3) get into counseling, preferably with him; and (4) if necessary, leave him.

Selma was ready to write her first draft. Here it is:

Some people think that "abuse" has to mean getting punched and kicked, but that's not so. Verbal abuse can be as painful inside as physical abuse is on the outside. It can make you feel worthless and sad. I know because I lived with a verbally abusive man for years. Finally I found the courage to deal with the situation. Here is what I did. With the help of friends, I finally figured out that I wasn't to blame. I thought it was my fault because that's what he always told me—that if I wasn't so stupid, he wouldn't criticize and insult me. When I told him I wanted him to stop insulting and criticizing me, he just laughed at me and told me I was a crybaby. One of my friends suggested a counselor, and I asked Harry to go talk to him with me. We went together once but Harry wouldn't go back. He said he didn't need anyone to tell him how to treat his woman. I wasn't that surprised because Harry grew up with a father who treated his mother like dirt and his mom just accepts it to this day. Even after Harry refused to go see the counselor, though, I kept going. The counselor helped me see that I couldn't make Harry change, but I was still free to make my own choices. If I didn't want to live my life being Harry's verbal punching bag, and if he didn't want to change, then I would have to. I told Harry that I wasn't going to live that way anymore. I told him if he wanted to work together on better ways to communicate, I'd work with him. But otherwise, I would leave. He gave me his usual talk about "Oh, you know I don't really mean half the stuff I say when I'm mad." I said that wasn't a good enough excuse, and that I did mean what I was saying. He got mad all over again and called me every name in the book. I stuck around for a little while after that but then realized "This is it. I can stay here and take this or I can do what I know is right for me." So I left. It was a really hard decision but it was the right one. Harry may be angry at me forever but I know now that his anger and his verbal abuse are his problem, not mine.

Development through Revising

After Selma had written her first draft, she showed it to a classmate for her comments. Here is what the classmate wrote in response:

In order for this to be a good process essay, I think you need to do a couple of things.

First, although the essay is based on what you went through, I think it's too much about your own experience. I'd suggest you take yourself out of it and just write about how any person could deal with any verbally abusive situation. Otherwise this paper is about you and Harry, not the process.

Second, you need a clear topic sentence that tells the reader what process you're going to explain.

Third, I'd use transitions like "first" and "next" to make the steps in the process clearer. I think the steps are all there, but they get lost in all the details about you and Harry.

197

When Selma reread her first draft, she agreed with her classmate's suggestions. She then wrote the version of "Dealing with Verbal Abuse" that appears on [page 193](#).

198

Writing a Process Paragraph

Writing Assignment 1

Choose one of the topics below to write about in a process paragraph.



How to feed a family on a budget	
How to break up with a boyfriend or girlfriend	
How to balance a checkbook	
How to change a car or bike tire	
How to get rid of house or garden pests, such as mice, roaches, or wasps	
How to play a simple game like checkers, tic-tac-toe, or an easy card game	
How to shorten a skirt or pants	
How to meet new people, for either dating or friendship	
How to plant a garden	
How to deal with a nosy person	
How to fix a leaky faucet, a clogged drain, or the like	
How to build a campfire or start a fire in a fireplace	
How to study for an important exam	
How to conduct a yard or garage sale	
How to wash dishes efficiently, clean a bathroom, or do laundry	198
Prewriting	199
a. Begin by freewriting on your topic for ten minutes. Do not worry about spelling, grammar, organization, or other matters of form. Just write whatever comes into your head regarding the topic. Keep writing for more than ten minutes if ideas keep coming to you. This freewriting will give you a base of raw material to draw from during the next phase of your work on the paragraph. After freewriting, you should have a sense of whether there is enough material available for you to write a process paragraph about the topic. If so, continue as explained below. If there is not enough material, choose another topic and freewrite about <i>it</i> for ten minutes. b. Write a clear, direct topic sentence stating the process you are going to describe. For instance, if you are going to describe a way to study for major exams, your topic sentence might be “My study-skills instructor has suggested a good way to study for major exams.” Or you can state in your topic sentence the process and the number of steps involved: “My technique for building a campfire involves four main steps.” c. List all the steps you can think of that may be included in the process. Don’t worry, at this point, about how each step fits or whether two steps overlap. Here, for example, is the list prepared by the author of “Sneaking into the House at Night”:	



Quiet on stairs
Come in after Dad's asleep
House is freezing at night
Bring key
Know which steps to avoid
Lift up front door
Late dances on Saturday night
Don't turn on bathroom light
Avoid squeaky spots on floor
Get into bed quietly

d. Number your items in the order in which they occur; strike out items that do not fit in the list; add others that come to mind. The author of “Sneaking into the House at Night” did this step as follows:

~~Quiet on stairs~~

2 Come in after Dad's asleep

~~House is freezing at night~~

1 Bring key

5 Know which steps to avoid

3 Lift up front door

~~Late dances on Saturday night~~

6 Don't turn on bathroom light

4 Avoid squeaky spots on floor

8 Get into bed quietly

7 Undress quietly

e. Use your list as a guide to write the first draft of your paragraph. As you write, try to think of additional details that will support your opening sentence. Do not expect to finish your composition in one draft. After you complete your first rough draft, in fact, you should be ready to write a series of drafts as you work toward the goals of unity, support, and coherence.

Revising

After you have written the first draft of your paragraph, set it aside for a while if you can. Then read it out loud, either to yourself or (better yet) to a friend or classmate who will be honest with you about how it sounds. You (or you and your friend) should keep these points in mind:



FOUR BASES Checklist for Process

About Unity

- An effective process composition describes a series of events in a way that is clear and easy to follow. Are the steps in your paragraph described in a clear, logical way?

About *Support*

- Does your paragraph explain every necessary step so that a reader could perform the task described?

About *Coherence*

- Have you used transitions such as *first, next, also, then, after, now, during, and finally* to make the paper move smoothly from one step to another?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Is the point of view consistent? For example, if you begin by writing “This is how I got rid of mice” (first person), do not switch to “You must buy the right traps” (second person). Write this paragraph either from the first-person point of view (using *I* and *we*) or from the second-person point of view (*you*)—do not jump back and forth between the two.
- Have you corrected any sentence-skills mistakes that you noticed while reading the paragraph out loud? Have you checked the composition for sentence skills, including spelling, as listed on the inside back cover of this book?

Continue revising your work until you and your reader can answer “yes” to all these questions.

Writing Assignment 2

Write a paragraph about one of the following processes. For this assignment, you will be working with more general topics than those in [Writing Assignment 1](#). In fact, many of the topics are so broad that entire books have been written about them. A big part of your task, then, will be to narrow the topic down enough so that it can be covered in one paragraph. Then you’ll have to invent your own steps for the process. In addition, you’ll need to make decisions about how many steps to include and the order in which to present them.

- How to break a bad habit such as smoking, overeating, or excess drinking
- How to improve a course you have taken
- How to make someone you know happy
- How to discipline a child

201
202

How to improve the place where you work

How to show appreciation to others

How to make someone forgive you

How to make yourself depressed

How to get over a broken relationship

How to procrastinate

How to flirt

Prewriting

- a. Choose a topic that appeals to you. Then ask yourself, “How can I make this broad, general topic narrow enough to be covered in a paragraph?” A logical way to proceed would be to think of a particular time you have gone through this process. For instance, if the general topic is “How to decorate economically,” you might think about a time you decorated your own apartment.
- b. Write a topic sentence about the process you are going to describe. Your topic sentence should clearly reflect the narrowed-down topic you have chosen. If you chose the topic described in step *a*, for example, your topic sentence could be “I made my first apartment look nice without spending a fortune.”
- c. Make a list of as many different items as you can think of that concern your topic. Don’t worry about repeating yourself, about putting the items in order, about whether details are major or minor, or about spelling. Simply make a list of everything about your topic that occurs to you. Here, for instance, is a list of items generated by the student writing about decorating her apartment on a budget:

*Bought pretty towels and used them as wall hangings
Trimmed overgrown shrubs in front yard
Used old mayonnaise jars for vases to hold flowers picked in
the yard
Found an old oriental rug at a yard sale
Painted mismatched kitchen chairs in bright colors
Kept dishes washed and put away
Bought a slipcover for a battered couch
Used pink lightbulbs
Hung pretty colored sheets over the windows*

d. Next, decide what order you will present your items in and number them. (As in the example of “decorating an apartment,” there may not be an order that the steps *must* be done in. If that is the case, you’ll need to make a decision about a sequence that makes sense, or that you followed yourself.) As you number your items, strike out items that do not fit in the list and add others that you think of, like this:

6

Bought pretty towels and used them as wall hangings

~~Trimmed overgrown shrubs in front yard~~

7

Used old mayonnaise jars for vases to hold flowers picked in the yard

4

Found an old oriental rug at a yard sale

2

Painted mismatched kitchen chairs in bright colors

~~Kept dishes washed and put away~~

1

Bought a slipcover for a battered couch

8

Used pink lightbulbs

5

Hung pretty colored sheets over the windows

3

Built bookshelves out of cinder blocks and boards

e. Referring to your list of steps, write the first draft of your paper. Add additional steps as they occur to you.

Revising

If you can, put your first draft away for a day or so and then return to it. Read it out loud to yourself or, better yet, to a friend who will give you honest feedback.

Here are questions to ask yourself as you read over your first draft and the drafts to follow:



FOUR BASES Checklist for Process

About Unity

- Have I included a clear topic sentence that tells what process I will be describing?
- Is the rest of my paragraph on target support of my topic sentence?

About *Support*

- Have I included all the essential information so that anyone reading my paper could follow the same process?

About *Coherence*

- Have I made the sequence of steps easy to follow by using transitions like first, second, then, next, during, and finally?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph?
- Have I used specific rather than general words?
- Have I used concise wording?
- Are my sentences varied?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.

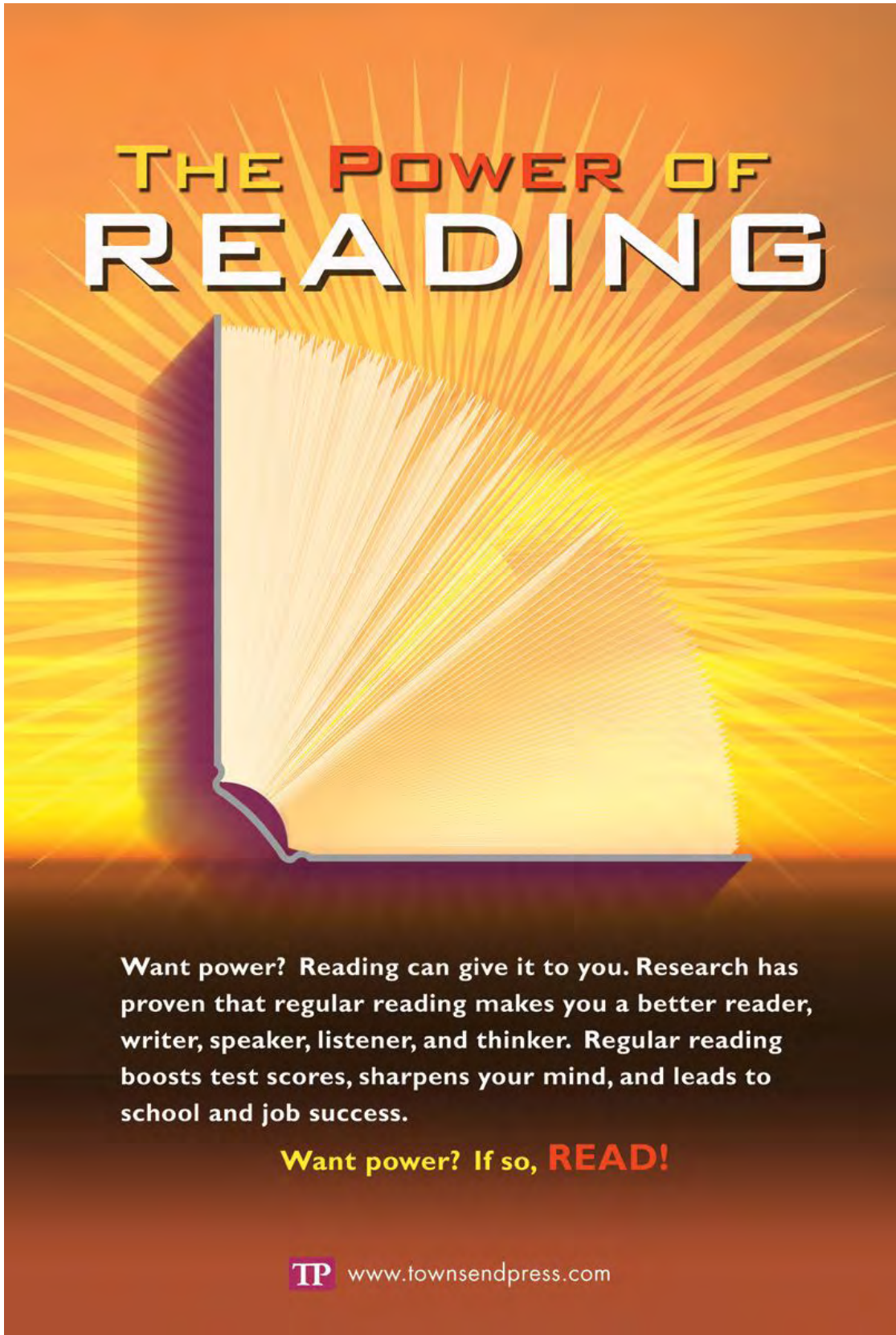
Writing Assignment 3

Look at the poster headed “The Awesome Power of Reading” on [page 205](#). It lists ways that regular reading can improve a person’s life.

What are some steps that a person could take in order to make himself or herself a regular reader? Alternatively, what steps could a person take to encourage a child to read more? Write a process paragraph in which you describe a sequence of steps. If you write about how an adult might become a regular reader, for instance, you might talk about the first action to take, then a second, then a third. If you write about encouraging a child to read more, your goal here, too, should be to present a series of steps to follow to promote a child’s love of reading.

204

205



THE POWER OF READING

Want power? Reading can give it to you. Research has proven that regular reading makes you a better reader, writer, speaker, listener, and thinker. Regular reading boosts test scores, sharpens your mind, and leads to school and job success.

Want power? If so, READ!

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Writing Assignment 4

Write a process paragraph on how to succeed at a job interview. Using strategies described in [Chapter 19 \(pages 358–373\)](#), do some research on the topic. Your reading will help you think about how to proceed with the paragraph.

Condense the material you have found into three, four, or five basic steps. Choose the steps, tips, and pointers that seem most important to you or that recur most often in the material. Remember that you are reading only to obtain background information for your paragraph. Do not copy material or repeat someone else's words or phrases in your own work. See [pages 380–381](#) for important information about plagiarism.

Writing Assignment 5

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this process paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. You have two options.

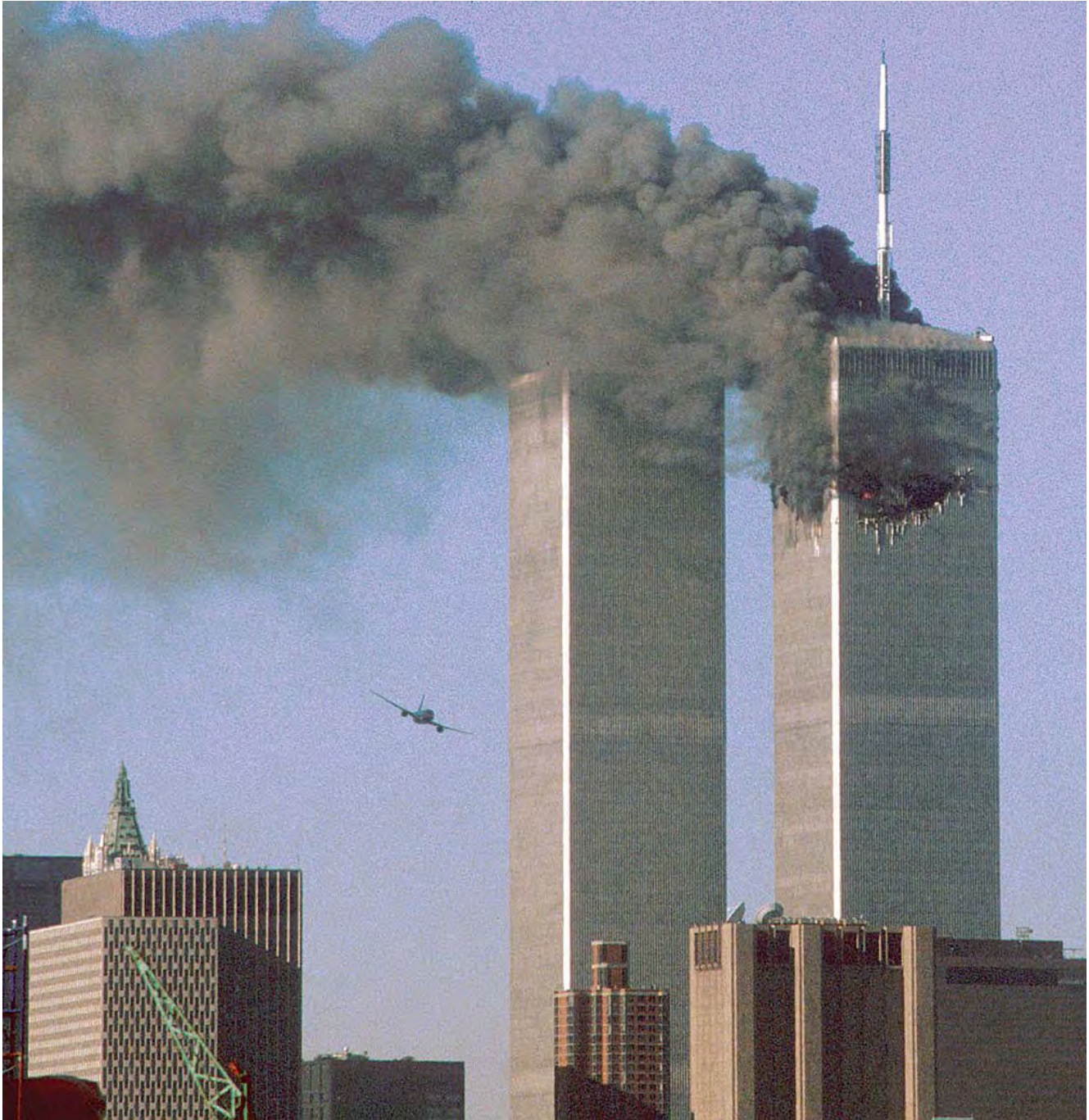
Option 1

Imagine that you have a part-time job helping out in a day-care center. The director, who is pleased with your work and wants to give you more responsibility, has put you in charge of a group activity (for example, an exercise session, an alphabet lesson, or a valentine-making project). But before you actually begin the activity, the director wants to see a summary of how you would go about it. What advance preparation would be needed, and what exactly would you be doing throughout the time of the project? Write a paragraph explaining the steps you would follow in conducting the activity.

Option 2

Write an explanation you might give to one of the children of how to do a simple classroom task—serving juice and cookies, getting ready for nap time, watering a plant, putting toys or other classroom materials away, or any other task you choose. Explain each step of the task in a way that a child would understand.

10: Cause and Effect



Write a paragraph in which you describe the effects of the events that took place on September 11, 2001. Think about the impact that day has had on you and others close to you, as well as how the United States as a country has been affected.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop a cause-and-effect paragraph

- write a cause-and-effect paragraph
- revise a cause-and-effect paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student cause-and-effect paragraphs

207

208

What caused Will to drop out of school? Why are reality TV shows so popular? Why does our football team do so poorly each year? How has retirement affected Mom? What effects does divorce have on children? Every day we ask such questions and look for answers. We realize that situations have causes and also effects—good or bad. By examining causes and effects, we seek to understand and explain things.



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In this section, you will be asked to do some detective work by examining the causes or the effects of something. First read the three paragraphs that follow and answer the questions about them. All three paragraphs support their opening points by explaining a series of causes or a series of effects.

Paragraphs to Consider

New Puppy in the House

¹Buying a new puppy can have significant effects on a household. ²For one thing, the puppy keeps the entire family awake for at least two solid weeks. ³Every night when the puppy is placed in its box, it begins to howl, yip, and whine. ⁴Even after the lights go out and the house quiets down, the puppy continues to moan. ⁵A second effect is that the puppy tortures the family by destroying material possessions. ⁶Every day something different is damaged. ⁷Family members find chewed belts and shoes, gnawed table legs, and ripped sofa cushions leaking stuffing. ⁸In addition, the puppy often misses the paper during the paper-training stage of life, thus making the house smell like the public rest room at a city bus station. ⁹Maybe the most serious problem, though, is that the puppy causes family arguments. ¹⁰Parents argue with children about who is supposed to feed and walk the dog. ¹¹Children argue about who gets to play with the puppy first. ¹²Everyone argues about who left socks and shoes around for the puppy to find. ¹³These continual arguments, along with the effects of sleeplessness and the loss of valued possessions, can really disrupt a household. ¹⁴Only when the puppy gets a bit older does the household settle back to normal.

My Car Accident

¹Several factors caused my recent car accident. ²First of all, because a heavy snow and freezing rain had fallen the day before, the road that I was driving on was hazardous. ³The road had been plowed but was dangerously icy in spots where dense clusters of trees kept the early-morning sun from hitting the road and melting the ice. ⁴Second, despite the slick patches, I was stupidly going along at about fifty miles an hour instead of driving more cautiously. ⁵I have a daredevil streak in my nature and sometimes feel I want to become a stock-car racer after I finish school, rather than an accountant as my parents want me to be. ⁶A third factor contributing to my accident was a dirty green Chevy van that suddenly pulled onto the road from a small intersecting street about fifty yards ahead of me. ⁷The road was a sheet of ice at that point, but I was forced to apply my brake and also swing my car into the next lane. ⁸Unfortunately, the fourth and final cause of my accident now came into play. ⁹The rear of my Honda Civic was heavy because I had a set of barbells in the backseat. ¹⁰I was selling this fairly new weight-lifting set to someone at school, since the weights had failed to build up my muscles immediately and I had gotten tired of practicing with them. ¹¹The result of all the weight in the rear was that after I passed the van, my car spun completely around on the slick road. ¹²For a few horrifying, helpless moments, I was sliding down the highway backward at fifty miles an hour, with no control whatsoever over the car. ¹³Then, abruptly, I slid off the road, thumping into a huge snowbank. ¹⁴I felt stunned for a moment but then also relieved. ¹⁵I saw a telephone pole about six feet to the right of me and realized that my accident could have been disastrous.

208

209

Why I Stopped Smoking

¹For one thing, I realized that my cigarette smoke bothered others, irritating people's eyes and causing them to cough and sneeze. ²They also had to put up with my stinking smoker's breath. ³Also, cigarettes are a messy habit. ⁴Our house was littered with ashtrays piled high with butts, matchsticks, and ashes, and the children were always knocking them over. ⁵Cigarettes are expensive, and I estimated that the carton a week that I was smoking cost me about \$2,000 a year. ⁶Another reason I stopped was that the message about cigarettes being harmful to health finally got through to me. ⁷I'd known they could hurt the smoker—in fact, a heavy smoker I know from work is in Eagleville Hospital now with lung cancer. ⁸But when I realized what secondhand smoke could do to my wife and children, causing them bronchial problems and even increasing their risk of cancer, it really bothered me. ⁹Cigarettes were also inconvenient. ¹⁰Whenever I smoked, I would have to drink something to wet my dry throat, and that meant I had to keep going to the bathroom all the time. ¹¹I sometimes seemed to spend whole weekends doing nothing but smoking, drinking, and going to the bathroom. ¹²Most of all, I resolved to stop smoking because I felt exploited. ¹³I hated the thought of wealthy, greedy corporations making money off my sweat and blood. ¹⁴The rich may keep getting richer, but—at least as regards cigarettes—with no thanks to me.

209

Questions

About Unity

- 1. Which two sentences in “My Car Accident” do not support the opening idea and so should be omitted? (*Write the sentence numbers here.*)

- 2. Which of the above paragraphs lacks a topic sentence?

About Support

- 3. How many separate causes are given in “Why I Stopped Smoking”?

_____ four _____ six _____ seven _____ eight
- 4. How many effects of bringing a new puppy into the house are given in “New Puppy in the House”?

_____ one _____ two _____ three _____ four

About Coherence

- 5. What transition words or phrases are used to introduce the four reasons listed in “My Car Accident”?

- 6. In “New Puppy in the House,” what words signal the effect that the author feels may be the most important?

Developing a Cause-and-Effect Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

In order to write a good cause-and-effect paragraph, you must clearly define an effect (*what* happened) and the contributing causes (*why* it happened). In addition, you will need to provide details that support the causes and effects you’re writing about.

Jerome is the student author of “Why I Stopped Smoking.” As soon as the topic occurred to him, he knew he had his *effect* (he had stopped smoking). His next task was to come up with a list of *causes* (reasons he had stopped). He decided to make a list of all the reasons for his quitting smoking that he could think of. This is what he came up with:

210

211

Annoyed others

Messy

Bad for health

Expensive

Taking his list, Jerome then jotted down details that supported each of those reasons:

Annoyed others

Bad breath

Irritates eyes

Makes other people cough

People hate the smell

Messy

Ashtrays, ashes, butts everywhere

Messes up my car interior

Bad for health

Marco in hospital with lung cancer

Secondhand smoke dangerous to family

My morning cough

Expensive

Carton a week costs more than \$2,000 a year

Tobacco companies getting rich off me

Jerome then had an effect and four causes with details to support them. On the basis of this list, he wrote a first draft:

211

212

My smoking annoyed other people, making them cough and burning their eyes. I bothered them with my smoker's breath. Nonsmokers usually hate the smell of cigarettes and I got embarrassed when nonsmokers visited my house. I saw them wrinkle their noses in disgust at the smell. It is a messy habit. My house was full of loaded ashtrays that the kids were always knocking over. My car was messy too. A guy from work, Marco, who has smoked for years, is in the hospital now with lung cancer. It doesn't look as though he's going to make it. Secondhand smoke is bad for people too and I worried it would hurt my wife and kids. Also I realized I was coughing once in a while. The price of cigarettes keeps going up and I was spending too much on smokes. When I see things in the paper about tobacco companies and their huge profits it made me mad.

Development through Revising

The next day, Jerome traded first drafts with his classmate Roger. This is what Roger had to say about Jerome's work:

The biggest criticism I have is that you haven't used many transitions to tie your sentences together. Without them, the paragraph sounds like a list, not a unified piece of writing.

Is one of your reasons more important than the others? If so, it would be good if you indicated that.

You could add a little more detail in several places. For instance, how could secondhand smoke hurt your family? And how much were you spending on cigarettes?

As Jerome read his own paper, he realized he wanted to add one more reason to his paragraph: the inconvenience to himself. “Maybe it sounds silly to write about always getting drinks and going to the bathroom, but that’s one of the ways that smoking takes over your life that you never think about when you start,” he said. Using Roger’s comments and his own new idea, he produced the paragraph that appears on [page 209](#).

212

213

Writing a Cause-and-Effect Paragraph

Writing Assignment 1

Choose one of the three topic sentences and brief outlines below. Each is made up of three supporting points (causes or effects). Your task is to turn the topic sentence and outline into a cause or effect paragraph.

Option 1

Topic sentence: There are several reasons why some high school graduates are unable to read.

- (1) Failure of parents (*cause*)
- (2) Failure of schools (*cause*)
- (3) Failure of students themselves (*cause*)

Option 2

Topic sentence: Living with roommates (or family) makes attending college difficult.



213

- (1) Late-night hours (*cause*)
- (2) More temptations to cut class (*cause*)
- (3) More distractions from studying (*cause*)

Option 3

Topic sentence: Attending college has changed my personality in positive ways.

- (1) More confident (*effect*)
- (2) More knowledgeable (*effect*)
- (3) More adventurous (*effect*)

Prewriting

- a. After you've chosen the option that appeals to you most, jot down all the details you can think of that might go under each of the supporting points. Use a separate piece of paper for your lists. Don't worry yet about whether you can use all the items—your goal is to generate more material than you need. Here, for example, are some of the details generated by the author of “New Puppy in the House” to back up her supporting points:

Topic sentence: Having a new puppy disrupts a household.

- 1. *Keeps family awake*
 - a. *Whines at night*
 - b. *Howls*
 - c. *Loss of sleep*
- 2. *Destroys possessions*
 - a. *Chews belts and shoes*
 - b. *Chews furniture*
 - c. *Tears up toys it's supposed to fetch*
- 3. *Has accidents in house*
 - a. *Misses paper*
 - b. *Disgusting cleanup*
 - c. *Makes house smell bad*
- 4. *Causes arguments*
 - a. *Arguments about walking dog*
 - b. *Arguments about feeding dog*
 - c. *Arguments about who gets to play with dog*
 - d. *Arguments about vet bills*

- b. Now go through the details you have generated and decide which are most effective. Strike out the ones you decide are not worth using. Do other details occur to you? If so, jot them down as well.
- c. Now you are ready to write your paragraph. Begin the paragraph with the topic sentence you chose. Make sure to develop each of the supporting points from the outline into a complete sentence, and then back it up with the best of the details you have generated.

Revising

Review your paragraph with these questions in mind:

FOUR BASES Checklist for Cause and Effect
About *Unity*

- Have I begun the paragraph with the topic sentence provided?
- Are any sentences in my paragraph not directly relevant to this topic sentence?

About *Support*

- Is each supporting point stated in a complete sentence?
- Have I provided effective details to back up each supporting point?

About *Coherence*

- Have I used transitions such as in addition, another thing, and also to make relationships between the sentences clear?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I avoided wordiness?
- Have I proofread the paragraph for sentence-skills errors, including spelling, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Revise your paragraph until you are sure the answer to each question is “yes.”

Writing Assignment 2

Most of us find it easy to criticize other people, but we may find it harder to give compliments. In this assignment, you will be asked to write a one-paragraph letter praising someone. The letter may be to a person you know (for instance, a parent, relative, or friend); to a public figure (an actor, politician,

religious leader, sports star, and so on); or to a company or an organization (for example, a newspaper, a government agency, a store where you shop, or the manufacturer of a product you own).

Prewriting

- a. The fact that you are writing this letter indicates that its recipient has had an *effect* on you: you like, admire, or appreciate the person or organization. Your job will be to put into words the *causes*, or reasons, for this good feeling. Begin by making a list of reasons for your admiration. Here, for example, are a few reasons a person might praise an automobile manufacturer:

My car is dependable.

The price was reasonable.

I received prompt action on a complaint.

The car is well-designed.

The car dealer was honest and friendly.

The car has needed little maintenance.

Reasons for admiring a parent might include these:

You are patient with me.

You are fair.

You have a great sense of humor.

You encourage me in several ways.

I know you have made sacrifices for me.

Develop your own list of reasons for admiring the person or organization you’ve chosen.

- b. Now that you have a list of reasons, you need details to back up each reason. Jot down as many supporting details as you can for each reason. Here is what the writer of a letter to the car manufacturer might do:

216

217

My car is dependable.

Started during last winter's coldest days when neighbors' cars
wouldn't start

Has never stranded me anywhere

The price was reasonable.

Costs less than other cars in its class

Came standard with more options than other cars of the
same price

I received prompt action on a complaint.

When I complained about rattle in door, manufacturer arranged
for a part to be replaced at no charge

The car is well-designed.

Controls are easy to reach

Dashboard gauges are easy to read

The car dealer was honest and friendly.

No pressure, no fake "special deal only today"

The car has needed little maintenance.

Haven't done anything but regular tune-ups and oil changes

- c. Next, select from your list the three or four reasons that you can best support with effective details. These will make up the body of your letter.
- d. For your topic sentence, make the positive statement you wish to support. For example, the writer of the letter to the car manufacturer might begin like this: "I am a very satisfied owner of a 2008 Camry."
- e. Now combine your topic sentence, reasons, and supporting details, and write a draft of your letter.

Revising

If possible, put your letter aside for a day. Then read it aloud to a friend. As you and he or she listen to your words, you should both keep these questions in mind:

**FOUR BASES Checklist for Cause and Effect****About *Unity***

- Is the topic sentence a positive statement that is supported by the details?
- Is the rest of my letter on target in support of my topic sentence?

About *Support*

- Does the letter clearly state several different reasons for liking and admiring the person or organization?
- Is each of those reasons supported with specific evidence?

About *Coherence*

- Are the sentences linked with transitional words and phrases?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I avoided wordiness?
- Are my sentences varied?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you and your reader can answer “yes” to all these questions.

Writing Assignment 3

Look at the poster pictured here. What does it seem to suggest? How do the woman’s expression and clenched fists help you better understand the meaning of the poster?



Write a paragraph about a particular addiction. You might write about someone you know who is addicted to smoking, drinking, shopping, watching TV, or surfing the Internet. In your paragraph, discuss several possible reasons for this addiction, or several effects on the person's life. Here are some sample topic sentences for such a paragraph:

218

219

My cousin is addicted to overeating, and her addiction is harming her in a number of ways.

There were at least three reasons why I became addicted to cigarettes.

Although shopping can be a pleasant activity, addictive shopping can be destructive for several reasons.

Writing Assignment 4

Investigate the reasons behind a current news event. For example, you may want to discover the causes of one of the following:

A labor strike or some other protest

A military action by our or some other government

A murder or some other act of violence

A tax increase

A traffic accident, a fire, a plane crash, or some other disaster

Research the reasons for the event by reading current newspapers (especially bigcity dailies that are covering the story in detail), reading weekly newsmagazines (such as *Time* and *Newsweek*), watching television shows and specials, or consulting an Internet news source.

Decide on the major cause or causes of the event and their specific effects. Then write a paragraph explaining in detail the causes and effects. Below is a sample topic sentence for this assignment.

The rape and murder that occurred recently on X Street have caused much fear and caution throughout the neighborhood.

Note how this topic sentence uses general words (*fear*, *caution*) that can summarize specific supporting details. Support for the word *caution*, for example, might include specific ways in which people in the neighborhood are doing a better job of protecting themselves.

219

220

Writing Assignment 5

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this process paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Choose one of the following options:

Option 1

Assume that there has been an alarming increase in drug abuse among the students at the high school you attended. What might be the causes of this increase? Spend some time thinking and freewriting about several possible causes. Then, as a concerned member of the community, write a letter to the high school guidance counselor explaining the reasons for the increased drug abuse. Your purpose is to provide information the counselor may be able to use in dealing with the problem.

Option 2

Your roommate has been complaining that it's impossible to succeed in Mr. X's class because the class is too stressful. You volunteer to attend the class and see for yourself. Afterward, you decide to write a letter to the instructor calling attention to the stressful conditions and suggesting concrete ways to deal with them. Write this letter, explaining in detail the causes and effects of stress in the class.

11: Comparison or Contrast



Look at this photograph and write a paragraph in which you compare or contrast online classes versus traditional classes that meet in person. Be sure to look at each student pictured here and make note of his or her actions. Use one or more examples from this photo to support your point.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop a comparison or contrast paragraph
- write a comparison or contrast paragraph
- revise a comparison or contrast paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student comparison or contrast paragraphs
- two common methods of development in a comparison or contrast paragraph



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Comparison and contrast are two everyday thought processes. When we *compare* two things, we show how they are similar; when we *contrast* two things, we show how they are different. We might compare or contrast two brand-name products (for example, Nike versus New Balance running shoes), two television shows, two instructors, two jobs, two friends, or two courses of action we could take in a given situation. The purpose of comparing or contrasting is to understand each of the two things more clearly and, at times, to make judgments about them.

In this chapter, you will be asked to write a comparison or contrast composition. First, however, you must learn the two common methods of developing a comparison or contrast paragraph. Read the two paragraphs that follow and try to explain the difference in the two methods of development.

Paragraphs to Consider



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My Senior Prom

¹My senior prom was nothing like what I expected it to be. ²From the start of my senior year, I had pictured putting on a sleek silvery slip dress that my aunt would make and that would cost \$300 in any store. ³No one else would have a gown as attractive as mine. ⁴I imagined my boyfriend coming to the door with a lovely deep-red corsage, and I pictured myself happily inhaling its perfume all evening long. ⁵I saw us setting off for the evening in his brother's BMW convertible. ⁶We would make a flourish as we swept in and out of a series of parties before the prom. ⁷Our evening would be capped by a delicious shrimp dinner at the prom and by dancing close together into the early morning hours. ⁸The prom was held on May 15, 2007, at the Pony Club on Black Horse Pike. ⁹However, because of sickness in her family, my aunt had no time to finish my gown and I had to buy an ugly pink one off the discount rack at the last minute. ¹⁰My corsage of red roses looked terrible on my pink gown, and I do not remember its having any scent. ¹¹My boyfriend's brother was out of town, and I stepped outside and saw the stripped-down Chevy that he used at the races on weekends. ¹²We went to one party where I drank a lot of wine that made me sleepy and upset my stomach. ¹³After we arrived at the prom, I did not have much more to eat than a roll and some celery sticks. ¹⁴Worst of all, we left early without dancing because my boyfriend and I had had a fight several days before, and at the time we did not really want to be with each other.

Day versus Evening Students

¹As a part-time college student who has taken both day and evening courses, I have observed notable differences between day and evening students.

²First of all, day and evening students differ greatly in age, styles, and interests.

³The students in my daytime classes are all about the same age, with similar clothing styles and similar interests. ⁴Most are in their late teens to early twenties, and whether male or female, they pretty much dress alike. ⁵Their uniform consists of jeans, a T-shirt, running shoes, a baseball cap, and maybe a gold earring or two. ⁶They use the same popular slang, talk about the same movies and TV shows, and know the same musical artists. ⁷But students in my evening courses are much more diverse. ⁸Some are in their late teens, but most range from young married people in their twenties and thirties to people my grandparents' age. ⁹Generally, their clothing is more formal than the day students'. ¹⁰They are dressed for the workplace, not for a typical college classroom. ¹¹Many of the women wear skirts or dresses; the men often wear dress shirts or sweaters. ¹²And they are more comfortable talking about mortgages or work schedules or child care than about what was on TV last night. ¹³Day and evening students also have very different responsibilities. ¹⁴For day students, college and a part-time job are generally the only major responsibilities. ¹⁵They have plenty of time to study and get assignments done. ¹⁶However, evening students lead much more complicated lives than most day students. ¹⁷They may come to campus after putting in a nine-to-five day at work. ¹⁸Most have children to raise or grandchildren to babysit for. ¹⁹When they miss a class or hand in an assignment late, it's usually because of a real problem, such as a sick child or an important deadline at work. ²⁰Finally, day and evening students definitely have different attitudes toward school. ²¹Day students often seem more interested in the view out the window or the cute classmate in the next row than in what the instructor is saying. ²²They doze, draw cartoons, whisper, and write notes instead of paying attention. ²³In contrast, evening students sit up straight, listen hard, and ask the instructor lots of questions. ²⁴They obviously are there to learn, and they don't want their time wasted. ²⁵In short, day students and night students are as different as . . . day and night.



The student writer of “Day versus Evening Students” uses the different appearances of day and evening students to support his or her argument. Looking at the woman pictured here, would you say she is a day or evening student, or not a student at all? What generalizations do we often make about people based on their appearance? Are these generalizations fair? Write a paragraph in which you explore this topic.

223

Complete this comment: The difference in the methods of contrast in the two paragraphs is that

224

Compare your answer with the following explanation of the two methods of development used in comparison or contrast paragraphs.

Methods of Development

There are two common methods, or formats, of development in a comparison or contrast paper. One format presents the details *one side at a time*. The other presents the details *point by point*. Each format is explained below.

One Side at a Time

Look at the outline of “My Senior Prom”:

Topic sentence: *My senior prom was nothing like what I had expected it to be.*

A. Expectations (first half of paper)

1. Dress (expensive, silver)
2. Corsage (deep red, fragrant)
3. Car (BMW convertible)
4. Parties (many)
5. Dinner (shrimp)
6. Dancing (all night)

B. Reality (second half of paper)

1. Dress (cheap, pink)
2. Corsage (wrong color, no scent)
3. Car (stripped-down Chevy)
4. Parties (only one)
5. Dinner (roll and celery)
6. Dancing (none because of quarrel)

When you use the one-side-at-a-time method, follow the same order of points of contrast or comparison for each side, as in the outline above. For example, both the first half of the paper and the second half begin with the same idea: what dress would be worn. Then both sides go on to the corsage, the car, and so on.

Point by Point

Now look at the outline of “Day versus Evening Students”:

Topic sentence: There are notable differences between day and night students.

A. Age and related interests and tastes in clothing

- 1. Youthful nature of day students*
- 2. Older nature of evening students*

B. Amount of responsibilities

- 1. Lighter responsibilities of day students*
- 2. Heavier responsibilities of evening students*

C. Attitude toward school

- 1. Casual attitude of day students*
- 2. Serious attitude of evening students*

The outline shows how the two kinds of students are contrasted point by point. First, the writer contrasts the ages, clothing styles, and interests of daytime students and evening students. Next, the writer contrasts the limited responsibilities of the daytime students with the heavier responsibilities of the evening students. Finally, the writer contrasts the casual attitude toward school of the daytime students and the serious attitude of the evening students.

When you begin a comparison or contrast paper, you should decide right away which format you are going to use: one side at a time or point by point. An outline is an essential step in helping you decide which format will be more workable for your topic. Keep in mind, however, that an outline is just a guide, not a permanent commitment. If you later feel that you’ve chosen the wrong format, you can reshape your outline to the other format.

Activity 1

Complete the partial outlines provided for the two paragraphs that follow.

1. **How My Parents’ Divorce Changed Me**

In the three years since my parents’ divorce, I have changed from a spoiled brat to a reasonably normal college student. Before the divorce, I expected my mother to wait on me. She did my laundry, cooked and cleaned up after meals, and even straightened up my room. My only response was to complain if the meat was too well done or if the sweater I wanted to wear was not clean. In addition, I expected money for anything I wanted. Whether it was a digital music player or my own cell phone, I expected Mom to hand over the money. If she refused, I would get it from Dad. However, he left when I was fifteen, and things changed. When Mom got a full-time job to support us, I was the one with the free time to do housework. Now, I did the laundry, started the dinner, and cleaned not only my own room but also the rest of the house. Also, I no longer asked her for money, since I knew there was none to spare. Instead, I got a part-time job on weekends to earn my own spending money. Today, I have my own car that I am paying for, and I am putting myself through college. Things have been hard sometimes, but I am glad not to be that spoiled kid any more.

Topic sentence: In the three years since my parents’ divorce, I have changed from a spoiled brat to a reasonably normal college student.

a. Before the divorce

(1) _____

(2) _____

b. After the divorce

(1) _____

(2) _____

Complete the following statement: Paragraph 1 uses the _____ method of development.

2. **Good and Bad Horror Movies**

A good horror movie is easily distinguishable from a bad one. A good horror movie, first of all, has both male and female victims. Both sexes suffer terrible fates at the hands of monsters and maniacs. Therefore, everyone in the audience has a chance to identify with the victim. Bad horror movies, on [Chapter 11](#) Comparison or Contrast the other hand, tend to concentrate on women, especially half-dressed ones. These movies are obviously prejudiced against half the human race. Second, a good horror movie inspires compassion for its characters. For example, the audience will feel sympathy for the victims in the horror classics about the Wolfman, played by Lon Chaney, Jr., and also for the Wolfman himself, who is shown to be a sad victim of fate. In contrast, a bad horror movie encourages feelings of aggression and violence in viewers. For instance, in the Halloween films, the murders are seen from the murderer’s point of view. The effect is that the audience stalks the victims along with the killer and feels the same thrill he does. Finally, every good horror movie has a sense of humor. In Alien, as a crew member is coughing and choking just before the horrible thing bursts out of his chest, a colleague chides him, “The food ain’t that bad, man.” Humor provides relief from the horror and makes the

226

227

characters more human. A bad horror movie, though, is humorless and boring. One murder is piled on top of another, and the characters are just cardboard figures. Bad horror movies may provide cheap thrills, but the good ones touch our emotions and live forever.

Topic sentence: A good horror movie is easily distinguished from a bad one.

a. Kinds of victims

(1) _____

(2) _____

b. Effect on audience

(1) _____

(2) _____

c. Tone

(1) _____

(2) _____

Complete the following statement: Paragraph 1 uses the _____ method of development.

227

Additional Paragraphs to Consider

228

Read these additional paragraphs of comparison or contrast and then answer the questions that follow.

My Broken Dream

¹When I became a police officer in my town, the job was not as I had dreamed it would be. ²I began to dream about being a police officer at about age ten. ³I could picture myself wearing a handsome blue uniform with an impressive-looking badge on my chest. ⁴I could also picture myself driving a powerful patrol car through town and seeing everyone stare at me with envy. ⁵But most of all, I dreamed of wearing a gun and using all the equipment that “TV cops” use. ⁶I knew everyone would be proud of me. ⁷I could almost hear the guys on the block saying, “Boy, Steve made it big. ⁸Did you hear he’s a cop?” ⁹I dreamed of leading an exciting life, solving big crimes, and meeting lots of people. ¹⁰I knew that if I became a cop, everyone in town would look up to me. ¹¹However, when I actually did become a police officer, I soon found out that the reality was different. ¹²My first disappointment came when I was sworn in and handed a well-used, baggy uniform. ¹³My disappointment continued when I was given a badge that looked like something pulled out of a cereal box. ¹⁴I was assigned a beat-up old junker and told that it would be my patrol car. ¹⁵It had a striking resemblance to a car that had lost in a demolition derby at a stock-car raceway. ¹⁶Disappointment seemed to continue. ¹⁷I soon found out that I was not the envy of all my friends. ¹⁸When I drove through town, they acted as if they had not seen me, despite the gun and nightstick at my side. ¹⁹I was told I was crazy doing this kind of job by people I thought would look up to me. ²⁰My job was not as exciting as I had dreamed it would be, either. ²¹Instead of solving robberies and murders every day, I found that I spent a great deal of time comforting a local resident because a neighborhood dog had watered his favorite bush.

Two Views on Toys

¹Children and adults have very different preferences. ²First, there is the matter of taste. ³Adults pride themselves on taste, while children ignore the matter of taste in favor of things that are fun. ⁴Adults, especially grandparents, pick out tasteful toys that go unused, while children love the cheap playthings advertised on television. ⁵Second, of course, there is the matter of money. ⁶The new games on the market today are a case in point. ⁷Have you ever tried to lure a child away from some expensive game in order to get him or her to play with an old-fashioned game or toy? ⁸Finally, there is a difference between an adult's and a child's idea of what is educational. ⁹Adults, filled with memories of their own childhood, tend to be fond of the written word. ¹⁰Today's children, on the other hand, concentrate on anything electronic. ¹¹These things mean much more to them than to adults. ¹²Next holiday season, examine the toys that adults choose for children. ¹³Then look at the toys the children prefer. ¹⁴You will see the difference.

228

229

Mike and Helen

¹Like his wife, Helen, Mike has a good sense of humor. ²Also, they are both short, dark-haired, and slightly pudgy. ³Unlike Helen, Mike tends to hold a grudge. ⁴He is slow to forget a cruel remark, a careless joke, or an unfriendly slight. ⁵Mike enjoys swimming, camping, and tennis, but Helen is an indoor type. ⁶Both Mike and Helen can be charming when they want to be, and they seem to handle small crises in a calm, cool way. ⁷A problem such as an overflowing washer, a stalled car, or a sick child is not a cause for panic; they seem to take such events in stride. ⁸In contrast to Helen, though, Mike tends to be disorganized. ⁹He is late for appointments and unable to keep important documents—bank records, receipts, and insurance papers—where he can find them.

Questions

About Unity

1. Which paragraph lacks a topic sentence?

	2. Which paragraph has a topic sentence that is too broad?	
	About Support	
	3. Which paragraph contains almost no specific details?	
	4. Which paragraph provides the most complete support?	
		229
	About Coherence	230
	5. What method of development (one side at a time or point by point) is used in “My Broken Dream”?	
	In “Two Views in Toys”?	
	6. Which paragraph offers specific details but lacks a clear, consistent method of development?	

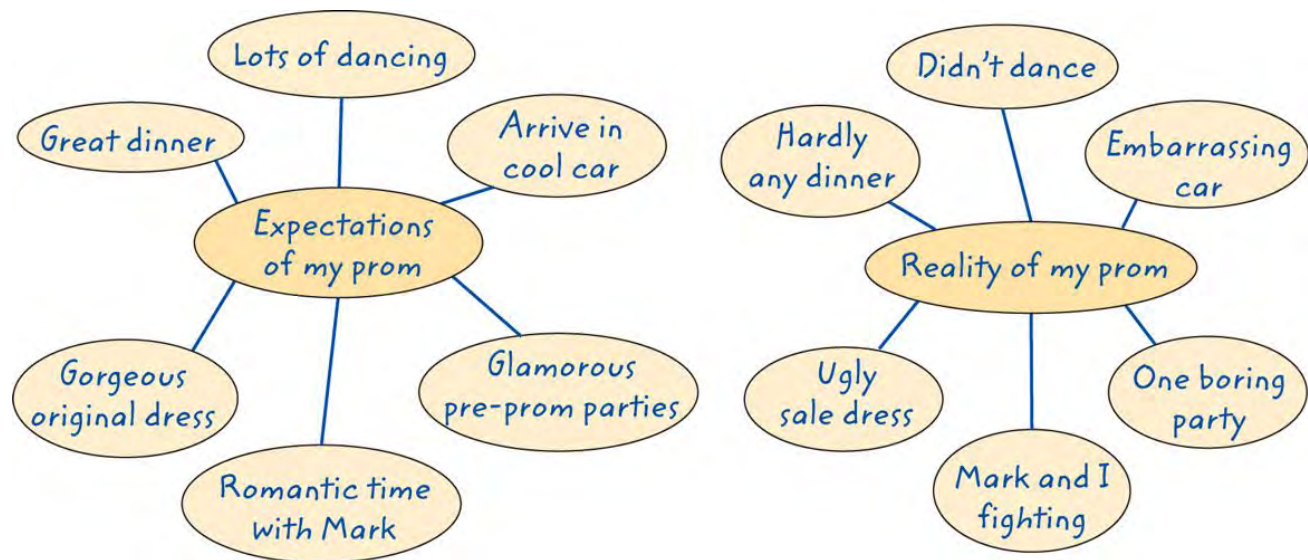
Developing a Comparison or Contrast Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

Gayle, the author of “My Senior Prom,” had little trouble thinking of a topic for her comparison or contrast paragraph.

“My instructor said, ‘You might compare or contrast two individuals, jobs you’ve had, or places you’ve lived,’” Gayle said. “Then he added, ‘Or you might compare or contrast your expectations of a situation with the reality.’ I immediately thought of my prom—boy, were my expectations different from the reality! I had thought it would be the high point of my senior year, but instead it was a total disaster.”

Because she is a person who likes to think visually, Gayle started her preparations for her paragraph by clustering. She found this a helpful way to “see” the relationships between the points she was developing. Her diagram is shown here:



230

231

Taking a detail first from the “Expectations” part of the diagram, then one from the “Reality” portion, then another from “Expectations,” and so on, Gayle began to write her paragraph using a point-by-point format:

My senior prom was nothing like what I expected. First of all, I expected to be wearing a beautiful dress that my aunt would make for me. But because she couldn't finish it in time, I had to buy an ugly one at the last minute. Second, I thought I'd have a wonderful romantic evening with my boyfriend. But we'd been fighting that week and by the time the prom came around we were barely speaking. I thought we'd have a great time stopping in at lots of parties before the prom, but we went to only one and I left with an upset stomach.

Gayle stopped here, because she wasn't satisfied with the way the paragraph was developing. “I wanted the reader to picture the way I had imagined my prom, and I didn't like interrupting that picture with the reality of the evening. So I decided to try the one-side-at-a-time approach instead.” Here is Gayle's first draft:

My senior prom was nothing like what I expected. I imagined myself wearing a beautiful, expensive-looking dress that my aunt would make. I thought my boyfriend and I would have a wonderful romantic evening together. We'd dance all through the night and we would cruise around in my boyfriend's brother's hot car. We would stop in at a lot of fun pre-prom parties, I thought, and we'd have a delicious shrimp dinner at the prom itself. But instead my uncle had a gallbladder attack that the doctor thought might be a heart attack and my aunt went to the hospital with him instead of finishing my dress. I had to go to the mall at the last minute and buy an ugly dress that nobody else had wanted off the sale rack. Mark and I had been fighting all week. Because he's in track and has a part-time job too we don't have much time together and still he wants to go out on Saturdays with his guy friends. So by the night of the prom we were hardly speaking to each other. We went to only one party before the prom and I left it feeling sick. And the restaurant was so crowded and noisy that I hardly got anything to eat. Because we were angry at each other, we didn't dance at all. And instead of his brother's luxury car, we had to use a stripped-down racing car.

231

232

Development through Revising

Gayle's instructor reviewed her first draft. Here are his comments:

All this is very promising, but some of your details are out of order—for example, you mention the pre-prom parties after the dance itself. Be sure to follow the evening's sequence of events.

More descriptive details are needed! For instance, what was your "beautiful" dress supposed to look like, and what did the "ugly" one you ended up with look like?

You include some unnecessary information: for example, the details of your uncle's illness. Everything in your paragraph should support your topic sentence.

Following her instructor's suggestions (and remembering a few more details she wanted to include), Gayle wrote the version of her paragraph that appears on [page 222](#).

232

Writing a Comparison or Contrast Paragraph

233

Writing Assignment 1

Write a comparison or contrast paragraph on one of the topics below:

Two holidays

Two instructors

Two children

Two kinds of eaters

Two drivers

Two coworkers

Two members of a team (or two teams)

Two singers or groups

Two pets

Two parties

Two jobs

Two characters in the same movie or TV show

Two homes

Two neighborhoods

Two cartoon strips

Two cars

Two friends

Two crises

Two bosses or supervisors

Two magazines

Two types of computers



Prewriting

- Choose your topic, the two subjects you will write about.
- Decide whether your paragraph will *compare* the two subjects (discuss their similarities) or *contrast* them (discuss their differences). Students most often choose to write about differences. For example, you might write about how a musical group you enjoy differs from a musical group you dislike. You might discuss important differences between two employers you have had or between two neighborhoods you've lived in. You might contrast a job you've had in a car factory with a job you've had as a receptionist.

233

- c. Write a direct topic sentence for your paragraph. Here's an example: "My job in a car-parts factory was very different from my job as a receptionist."
- d. Come up with at least three strong points to support your topic sentence. If you are contrasting two jobs, for example, your points might be that they differed greatly (1) in their physical setting, (2) in the skills they required, and (3) in the people they brought you into contact with.
- e. Use your topic sentence and supporting points to create a scratch outline for your paragraph. For the paragraph about jobs, the outline would look like this:

Topic sentence: *My job in a car-parts factory was very different from my job as a receptionist.*

1. *The jobs differed in physical setting.*
2. *The jobs differed in the skills they required.*
3. *The jobs differed in the people they brought me into contact with.*

- f. Under each of your supporting points, jot down as many details as occur to you. Don't worry yet about whether the details all fit perfectly or whether you will be able to use them all. Your goal is to generate a wealth of material to draw on. An example:

Topic sentence: *My job in a car-parts factory was very different from my job as a receptionist.*

1. The jobs differed in physical setting.

Factory loud and dirty
Office clean and quiet
Factory full of machines, hunks of metal, tools
Office full of desks, files, computers
Factory smelled of motor oil
Office smelled of new carpet
Windows in factory too high and grimy to look out of
Office had clean windows onto street

2. The jobs differed in the skills and behavior they required.

Factory required physical strength
Office required mental activity
Didn't need to be polite in factory
Had to be polite in office
Didn't need to think much for self in factory
Constantly had to make decisions in office

3. The jobs differed in the people they brought me into contact with.

In factory, worked with same crew every day
In office, saw constant stream of new customers
Most coworkers in factory had high-school education or less
Many coworkers and clients in office well educated
Coworkers in factory spoke variety of languages
Rarely heard anything but English in office

g. Decide which format you will use to develop your paragraph: one side at a time or point by point. Either is acceptable; it is up to you to decide which you prefer. The important thing is to be consistent: whichever format you choose, be sure to use it throughout the entire paragraph. h. Write the first draft of your paragraph. Revising Put your writing away for a day or so. You will return to it with a fresh perspective and a better ability to critique what you have done.	235
Reread your work with these questions in mind: FOUR BASES Checklist for Comparison or Contrast About <i>Unity</i> - Does my topic sentence make it clear what two things I am comparing or contrasting? - Do all sentences in the paragraph stay on-topic? About <i>Support</i> - Have I compared or contrasted the subjects in at least three important ways? - Have I provided specific details that effectively back up my supporting points? About <i>Coherence</i> - If I have chosen the point-by-point format, have I consistently discussed a point about one subject, then immediately discussed the same point about the other subject before moving on to the next point? - If I have chosen the one-side-at-a-time format, have I discussed every point about one of my subjects, then discussed the same points in the same order about the second subject? - Have I used appropriate transitions, such as <i>first</i>, <i>in addition</i>, <i>also</i>, and <i>another way</i>, to help readers follow my train of thought? About <i>Sentence Skills</i> - Have I carefully proofread my paragraph, using the list on the inside back cover of the book, and corrected all sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling? Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.	236

Writing Assignment 2

Write a paragraph in which you compare or contrast your life in the real world with your life in an imagined “perfect world.” Your paragraph may be humorous or serious.

Prewriting

- a. As your “real life” and “ideal life” are too broad for a paragraph, choose three specific areas to focus on. You might select any of the areas below, or think of a specific area yourself.

work friends
money possessions
romance housing
physical location talents
personal appearance
- b. Write the name of one of your three areas (for example, “work”) across the top of a page. Divide the page into two columns. Label one column “real world” and the other “perfect world.” Under “real world,” write down as many details as you can think of describing your real-life work situation. Under “perfect world,” write down details describing what your perfect work life would be like. Repeat the process on separate pages for your other two major areas.
- c. Write a topic sentence for your paragraph. Here’s an example: “In my perfect world, my life would be quite different in the areas of work, money, and housing.”
- d. Decide which approach you will take: one side at a time or point by point.
- e. Write a scratch outline that reflects the format you have selected. The outline for a point-by-point format would look like this:

Topic sentence: In my perfect world, my life would be quite different in the areas of work, money, and housing.

1. Work

- a. Real-life work*
- b. Perfect-world work*

2. Money

- a. Real-life money*
- b. Perfect-world money*

3. Housing

- a. Real-life housing*
- b. Perfect-world housing*

The outline for a one-side-at-a-time format would look like this:

Topic sentence: *In my perfect world, my life would be quite different in the areas of work, money, and housing.*

- 1. Real life*
 - a. Work*
 - b. Money*
 - c. Housing*
- 2. Perfect world*
 - a. Work*
 - b. Money*
 - c. Housing*

- f. Drawing from the three pages of details you generated in step *b*, complete your outline by jotting down your strongest supporting details for each point.
- g. Write the first draft of your paragraph.

Revising

Reread your paragraph, and then show it to a friend who will give you honest feedback. You should both review it with these questions in mind:



FOUR BASES Checklist for Comparison or Contrast

About *Unity*

- Does the topic sentence make it clear what three areas of life are being compared or contrasted?
- Is the rest of my paragraph on target in support of my topic sentence?

About *Support*

- Does the paragraph provide specific details that describe both the “real-life” situation and the “perfect-world” situation?

About *Coherence*

- Does the paragraph follow a consistent format: point by point or one side at a time?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph?
- Have I used specific rather than general words?
- Have I avoided wordiness?
- Are my sentences varied?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you and your reader can answer “yes” to all these questions.

Writing Assignment 3

Write a contrast paragraph on one of the topics below.

Neighborhood stores versus a shopping mall

Driving on an expressway versus driving on country roads

People versus *Us Weekly* (or any other two popular magazines)

Camping in a tent versus camping in a recreational vehicle

Working parents versus stay-at-home parents

Shopping at a department store versus shopping online

A used car versus a new one

239

240

Recorded music versus live music

PG-rated movies versus R-rated movies

News in a newspaper versus news on television or the Internet

Yesterday's toys versus today's toys

Fresh food versus canned or frozen food

The locker room of a winning team after a game versus the locker room of a losing team

An ad on television or online versus an ad for the same product in a magazine

Amateur sports teams versus professional teams

Follow the directions for prewriting and rewriting given in [Writing Assignment 2](#).

Writing Assignment 4

Use the cartoon shown here as the basis for a comparison and contrast paragraph. Assume that your audience has not seen the cartoon. It is your job, then, to compare *and* contrast elements in the cartoon so effectively that your readers will clearly understand both what the cartoon looks like and what it means. Before writing your paragraph, you might make a list for yourself of exactly how the two characters in the cartoon are the same and how they are different. When comparing, you may want to use transitions such as *just as*, *alike*, *likewise*, and *similarly*. When contrasting, you may want to use transitions such as *in contrast*, *on the other hand*, *differs from*, *unlike*, or *however*.



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Writing Assignment 5

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this comparison and contrast paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Imagine that you are living in an apartment building in which new tenants are making life unpleasant for you. Write a letter of complaint to your landlord comparing *and* contrasting life before and after the tenants arrived. You might want to focus on one or more of the following:

Noise

Trash

Safety hazards

Parking situation

12: Definition



What are some words that come to mind as you look at this photograph? Write a paragraph in which you define one of these terms. For example, you may look at the photograph and think challenge, frustration, obstacle, or courage.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop a definition paragraph
- write a definition paragraph
- revise a definition paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student definition paragraphs

242

243

In talking with other people, we sometimes offer informal definitions to explain just what we mean by a particular term. Suppose, for example, we say to a friend, “Karen can be so clingy.” We might then expand on our idea of “clingy” by saying, “You know, a clingy person needs to be with someone every single minute. If Karen’s best friend makes plans that don’t include her, she becomes hurt. And when she dates someone, she calls him several times a day and gets upset if he even goes to the grocery store without her. She hangs on to people too tightly.” In a written definition, we make clear in a more complete and formal way our own personal understanding of a term. Such a definition typically starts with one meaning of a term. The meaning is then illustrated with a series of examples or a story.



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In this section, you will be asked to write a paragraph that begins with a one-sentence definition; that sentence will be the topic sentence. The three student papers below are all examples of definition paragraphs. Read them and then answer the questions that follow.

Paragraphs to Consider



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Luck

¹Luck is putting \$1.75 into a vending machine and getting the money back with your snack. ²It is an instructor's decision to give a retest on a test on which you first scored thirty. ³Luck refers to moments of good fortune that happen in everyday life. ⁴It is not going to the dentist for two years and then going and finding out that you do not have any cavities. ⁵It is calling up a plumber to fix a leak on a day when the plumber has no other work to do. ⁶Luck is finding a used car for sale at a good price at exactly the time when your car rolls its last mile. ⁷Luck is driving into a traffic bottleneck and choosing the lane that winds up moving most rapidly. ⁸Luck is being late for work on a day when your boss arrives later than you do. ⁹It is having a new checkout aisle at the supermarket open up just as your cart arrives. ¹⁰The best kind of luck is winning a new wide-screen TV on a chance for which you paid only a quarter.

Disillusionment

¹Disillusionment is the feeling we have when one of our most cherished beliefs is stolen from us. ²I learned about disillusionment firsthand the day Mr. Keller, our eighth-grade teacher, handed out the grades for our class biology projects. ³I had worked hard to assemble what I thought was the best insect collection any school had ever seen. ⁴For weeks, I had set up homemade traps around our house, in the woods, and in vacant lots. ⁵At night, I would stretch a white sheet between two trees, shine a lantern on it, and collect the night-flying insects that gathered there. ⁶With my own money, I had bought killing jars, insect pins, gummed labels, and display boxes. ⁷I carefully arranged related insects together, with labels listing each scientific name and the place and date of capture. ⁸Slowly and painfully, I wrote and typed the report that accompanied my project at the school science fair. ⁹In contrast, my friend Eddie did almost nothing for his project. ¹⁰He had his father, a psychologist, build an impressive maze complete with live rats and a sign that read, "You are the trainer." ¹¹A person could lift a little plastic door, send a rat running through the maze, and then hit a button to release a pellet of rat food as a reward. ¹²This exhibit turned out to be the most popular one at the fair. ¹³I felt sure that our teacher would know that Eddie could not have built it, and I was certain that my hard work would be recognized and rewarded. ¹⁴Then the grades were finally handed out, and I was crushed. ¹⁵Eddie had gotten an A-plus, but my grade was a B. ¹⁶I suddenly realized that honesty and hard work don't always pay off in the end. ¹⁷The idea that life is not fair, that sometimes it pays to cheat, hit me with such force that I felt sick. ¹⁸I will never forget that moment.

243

244

A Mickey Mouse Course

¹A Mickey Mouse course is any college course that is so easy that even Mickey Mouse could achieve an A. ²A student who is taking a heavy schedule, or who does not want four or five especially difficult courses, will try to sandwich in a Mickey Mouse course. ³A student can find out about such a course by consulting other students, since word of a genuine Mickey Mouse course spreads like wildfire. ⁴Or a student can study the college course schedule for telltale class titles like *The Art of Pressing Wildflowers*, *History of the Comic Book*, or *Watching Television Creatively*. ⁵In an advanced course such as microbiology, though, a student had better be prepared to spend a good deal of time during the semester on the course. ⁶Students in a Mickey Mouse course can attend classes while half-asleep, hungover, or wearing iPod earphones or a blindfold; they will still pass. ⁷The course exams (if there are any) would not challenge a five-year-old. ⁸The course lectures usually consist of information that anyone with common sense knows anyway. ⁹Attendance may be required, but participation or involvement in the class is not. ¹⁰The main requirement for passing is that a student's body is there, warming a seat in the classroom. ¹¹There are no difficult labs or special projects, and term papers are never mentioned. ¹²Once safely registered for such a course, all the students have to do is sit back and watch the credits accumulate on their transcripts.

244

Questions

About Unity

- 1. Which paragraph places its topic sentence within the paragraph rather than, more appropriately, at the beginning?

- 2. Which sentence in “A Mickey Mouse Course” should be omitted in the interest of paragraph unity? (*Write the sentence number here.*) _____

About Support

- 3. Which two paragraphs develop their definitions through a series of short examples?

- 4. Which paragraph develops its definition through a single extended example?

About Coherence

- 5. Which paragraph uses emphatic order, saving its best detail for last?

- 6. Which paragraph uses time order to organize its details?

Developing a Definition Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

When Harry, the author of “Disillusionment,” started working on his assignment, he did not know what he wanted to write about. He looked around the house for inspiration. His two-year-old twins racing around the room made him think about defining “energy.” The fat cat asleep on a sunny windowsill suggested that he might write about “laziness” or “relaxation.” Still not sure of a topic, he looked over his notes from that day’s class. His instructor had jotted a list of terms on the blackboard, saying, “Maybe you could focus on what one of these words has meant in your own life.” Harry looked over the words he had copied down: *honesty, willpower, faith, betrayal, disillusionment*—“When I got to the word ‘disillusionment,’ the eighth-grade science fair flashed into my mind,” Harry said. “That was a bitter experience that definitely taught me what disillusionment was all about.”

245

246

Because the science fair had occurred many years before, Harry had to work to remember it well. He decided to try the technique of questioning himself to come up with the details of what had happened. Here are the questions Harry asked himself and the answers he wrote:

When did I learn about disillusionment?

When I was in eighth grade

Where did it happen?

At the school science fair

Who was involved?

Me, Eddie Loomis and his father, and Mr. Keller

What happened?

I had worked very hard on my insect collection. Eddie had done almost nothing but he had a rat maze that his father had built. I got a B on my project while Eddie got an A+.

Why was the experience so disillusioning?

I thought my hard work would be rewarded. I was sure Mr. Keller would recognize that I had put far more effort into my project than Eddie had. When Eddie won, I learned that cheating can pay off and that honest work isn't always rewarded.

How did I react?

I felt sick to my stomach. I wanted to confront Mr. Keller and Eddie and make them see how unfair the grades were. But I knew I'd just look like a poor loser, so I didn't do anything.

On the basis of this experience, how would I define disillusionment?

It's finding out that something you really believed in isn't true.

Drawing from the ideas generated by his self-questioning, Harry wrote the following draft of his paragraph:

Disillusionment is finding out that one of your most important beliefs isn't true. I learned about disillusionment at my eighth-grade science fair. I had worked very hard on my project, an insect collection. I was sure it would get an A. I had worked so hard on it, even spending nights outside making sure it was very good. My friend Eddie also did a project, but he barely worked on his at all. Instead, he had his father build a maze for a rat to run through. The trainer lifted a little plastic door to let the rat into the maze, and if it completed the maze, the trainer could release a pellet of food for it to eat. It was a nice project, but the point is that Eddie hadn't made it. He just made things like the banner that hung over it. Mr. Keller was our science teacher. He gave Eddie an A+ and me just a B. So that really taught me about disillusionment.

Development through Revising

The next day, Harry's instructor divided the class into groups of three. The groups reviewed each member's paragraph. Harry was grouped with Curtis and Jocelyn. After reading through Harry's paper several times, the group had the following discussion:

"My first reaction is that I want to know more about your project," said Jocelyn. "You give details about Eddie's, but not many about your own. What was so good about it? You need to show us, not just tell us. Also, you said that you worked very hard, but you didn't show us how hard."

"Yeah," said Harry. "I remember my project clearly, but I guess the reader has to know what it was like and how much effort went into it."

Curtis said, "I like your topic sentence, but when I finished the paragraph I wasn't sure what 'important belief' you'd learned wasn't true. What would you say that belief was?"

Harry thought a minute. "I'd believed that honest hard work would always be rewarded. I found out that it doesn't always happen that way, and that cheating can actually win."

Curtis nodded. “I think you need to include that in your paper.” Jocelyn added, “I’d like to read how you felt or reacted after you saw your grade, too. If you don’t explain that, the paragraph ends sort of abruptly.”

Harry agreed with his classmates’ suggestions. After he had gone through several revisions, he produced the version that appears on [page 243](#).

Writing a Definition Paragraph

Writing Assignment 1

Write a paragraph that defines the term *TV addict*. Base your paragraph on the topic sentence and three supporting points provided below.



Topic sentence: Television addicts are people who will watch all the programs they can, for as long as they can, without doing anything else.

- (1) TV addicts, first of all, will watch anything on the tube, no matter how bad it is. . . .
- (2) In addition, addicts watch more hours of TV than normal people do. . . .
- (3) Finally, addicts feel that TV is more important than other people or any other activities that might be going on. . . .

Prewriting a. Generate as many examples as you can for each of the three qualities of a TV addict. You can do this by asking yourself the following questions: • What are some truly awful shows that I (or TV addicts I know) watch just because the television is turned on? • What are some examples of the large amounts of time that I (or TV addicts I know) watch television? • What are some examples of ways that I (or TV addicts I know) neglect people or give up activities in order to watch TV? Write down every answer you can think of for each question. At this point, don't worry about writing full sentences or even about grammar or spelling. Just get your thoughts down on paper.	248
b. Look over the list of examples you have generated. Select the strongest examples you have thought of. You should have at least two or three for each quality. If not, ask yourself the questions in step <i>a</i> again. c. Write out the examples you will use, this time expressing them in full, grammatically correct sentences. d. Start with the topic sentence and three points provided in the assignment. Fill in the examples you've generated to support each point and write a first draft of your paragraph. Revising Put your first draft away for a day or so. When you come back to it, reread it critically, asking yourself these questions: FOUR BASES Checklist for Definition About <i>Unity</i> ☞ Have I used the topic sentence and the three supporting points that were provided? ☞ Does every sentence in my paragraph help define the term <i>TV addict</i>? About <i>Support</i> ☞ Have I backed up each supporting point with at least two examples? ☞ Does each of my examples truly illustrate the point that it backs up? About <i>Coherence</i>	249

- Have I used appropriate transitional language (*another, in addition, for example*) to tie my thoughts together?
- Are all the transitional words correctly used?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I carefully proofread my paragraph, using the list on the inside back cover of the book, and corrected all sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling?
- Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph?

Keep revising your paragraph until you can answer “yes” to each question.

249
250

Writing Assignment 2

Write a paragraph that defines one of the following terms. Each term refers to a certain kind of person.

Know-it-all	Fair-weather friend	Good neighbor	Control freak
Charmer	Good sport	Optimist	Player
Loser	Clown	Pessimist	Princess
Flake	Fool	Spaz	Traitor
Snob	Leader	Workaholic	Slob
Con	artist	Nerd	Showoff

Prewriting

- a. Write a topic sentence for your definition paragraph. This is a two-part process:
- First*, place the term in a class, or category. For example, if you are writing about a certain kind of person, the general category is *person*. If you are describing a type of friend, the general category is *friend*.
 - Second*, describe what you consider the special feature or features that set your term apart from other members of its class. For instance, say what *kind* of person you are writing about or what *type* of friend.

In the following topic sentence, try to identify three things: the term being defined, the class it belongs to, and the special feature that sets the term apart from other members of the class.

A chocoholic is a person who craves chocolate.

The term being defined is *chocoholic*. The category it belongs to is *person*. The words that set *chocoholic* apart from any other person are *craves chocolate*.

Below is another example of a topic sentence for this assignment. It is a definition of *whiner*. The class, or category, is underlined: A whiner is a type of person. The words that set the term *whiner* apart from other members of the class are double-underlined.

A whiner is a person who feels wronged by life.

In the following sample topic sentences, underline the class and doubleunderline the special features.

A shopaholic is a person who needs new clothes to be happy.

The class clown is a student who gets attention through silly behavior.

A worrywart is a person who sees danger everywhere.

- b. Develop your definition by using one of the following methods:

Examples. Give several examples that support your topic sentence.

250

Extended example. Use one longer example to support your topic sentence. *Contrast.* Support your topic sentence by contrasting what your term *is* with what it is *not* . For instance, you may want to define a *fair-weather friend* by contrasting his or her actions with those of a true friend.

251

- c. Once you have created a topic sentence and decided how to develop your paragraph, make a scratch outline. If you are using a contrast method of development, remember to present the details one side at a time or point by point (see [pages 224–225](#)).
- d. Write a first draft of your paragraph.

Revising

As you revise your paragraph, keep these questions in mind:

FOUR BASES Checklist for Definition

About *Unity*

- Does my topic sentence (1) place my term in a class and (2) name some special features that set it apart from its class?
- Is the rest of my paragraph on target in support of my topic sentence?

About *Support*

- Have I made a clear choice to develop my topic sentence through several examples, or one extended example, or contrast?

About *Coherence*

- If I have chosen to illustrate my topic through contrast, have I consistently followed either a point-by-point or a one-side-at-a-time format?
- Have I used appropriate transitions (*another, in addition, in contrast, for example*) to tie my thoughts together?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph?
- Have I used specific rather than general words?
- Have I avoided wordiness?
- Are my sentences varied?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.

251

252

Writing Assignment 3

Write a paragraph that defines one of the abstract terms below.

Arrogance	Family	Persistence
Assertiveness	Fear	Practicality
Class	Freedom	Rebellion
Common sense	Gentleness	Responsibility
Conscience	Innocence	Self-control
Curiosity	Insecurity	Sense of humor
Danger	Jealousy	Shyness
Depression	Nostalgia	Violence
Escape	Obsession	

As a guide in writing your paper, use the suggestions for prewriting and rewriting in [Writing Assignment 2](#). Remember to place your term in a class or category and to describe what *you* feel are the distinguishing features of that term.

After writing your topic sentence, check that it is complete and correct by doing the following:

- Single-underline the category of the term you’re defining.
- Double-underline the term’s distinguishing characteristic or characteristics.

Here are three sample topic sentences:

Laziness is the trait of resisting all worthwhile work as much as possible.

Jealousy is the feeling of wanting a possession or quality that someone else has.

A family is a group whose members are related to one another in some way.

Writing Assignment 4

Since stress affects all of us to some degree—in the workplace, in school (as shown in the photograph on the next page), in our families, and in our everyday lives—it is a useful term to explore. Write a paragraph defining *stress*. Organize your paragraph in one of these ways:

- Use a series of examples (see [pages 177–190](#)) of stress.
- Use narration (see [pages 284–297](#)) to provide one longer example of stress: Create a hypothetical person (or use a real person) and show how this person’s typical day illustrates your definition of *stress*.

252

Using strategies described in [Chapter 19](#) ([pages 358–373](#)), do some research on stress. Your reading will help you think about how to proceed with the paper.

253

HINT

Do not simply write a series of general, abstract sentences that repeat and reword your definition. If you concentrate on providing specific support, you will avoid the common trap of getting lost in a maze of generalities.

Make sure your paper is set firmly on the four bases: unity, support, coherence, and sentence skills. Edit the next-to-final draft of the paragraph carefully for sentence-skills errors, including spelling.



Writing Assignment 5

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this definition paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Choose one of the following options.

Option 1

Imagine that at the place where you work, one employee has just quit, creating a new job opening. Since you have been working there for a while, your boss has asked you to write a description of the position. That description, a detailed definition of the job, will be sent to employment agencies. These agencies will be responsible for interviewing candidates. Choose any position you know about, and write a paragraph defining it. First state the purpose of the job, and then list its duties and responsibilities. Finally, describe the qualifications for the position. Below is a sample topic sentence for this assignment.

Purchasing-department secretary is a position in which someone provides a variety of services to the purchasing-department managers.

In a paragraph with the above topic sentence, the writer would go on to list and explain the various services the secretary must provide.

Option 2

Alternatively, imagine that a new worker has been hired, and your boss has asked you to explain “team spirit” to him or her. The purpose of your explanation will be to give the newcomer an idea of the kind of teamwork that is expected in this workplace. Write a paragraph that defines in detail what your boss means by *team spirit*. Use examples or one extended example to illustrate each of your general points about team spirit.

13: Division-Classification



Music comes in many forms. Write a paragraph in which you discuss three different styles of music and what makes each one unique and different.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop a division-classification paragraph
- write a division-classification paragraph
- revise a division-classification paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student division classification paragraphs

254

255

If you were doing the laundry, you might begin by separating the clothing into piles. You would then put all the whites in one pile and all the colors in another. Or you might classify the laundry, not according to color, but according to fabric—putting all cottons in one pile, polyesters in another, and so on. *Classifying* is the process of taking many things and separating them into categories. We generally classify to better manage or understand many things. Librarians classify books into groups (fiction, travel, health, etc.) to make them easier to find. A scientist sheds light on the world by classifying all living things into two main groups: animals and plants.



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Dividing, in contrast, is taking one thing and breaking it down into parts. We often divide, or analyze, to better understand, teach, or evaluate something. For instance, a tinkerer might take apart a clock to see how it works; a science text might divide a tree into its parts to explain their functions. A music reviewer may analyze the elements of a band’s performance—for example, the skill of the various players, rapport with the audience, selections, and so on.

In short, if you are classifying, you are sorting *numbers of things* into categories. If you are dividing, you are breaking *one thing* into parts. It all depends on your purpose—you might classify flowers into various types or divide a single flower into its parts.

In this section, you will be asked to write a paragraph in which you classify a group of things into categories according to a single principle. To prepare for this assignment, first read the paragraphs below, and then work through the questions and the activity that follow.

Paragraphs to Consider



Types of E-Mail

¹As more and more people take advantage of e-mailing, three categories of e-mail have emerged. ²One category of e-mail is junk mail, or spam. ³When most people sign on to their computers, they are greeted with a flood of get-rich quick schemes, invitations to pornographic Web sites, and ads for a variety of unwanted products. ⁴E-mail users quickly become good at hitting the “delete” button to get rid of this garbage. ⁵The second category that clogs most people’s electronic mailbox is forwarded mail, most of which also gets deleted without being read. ⁶The third and best category of e-mail is genuine personal e-mail from genuine personal friends or colleagues. ⁷Getting such real, thoughtful e-mail can almost make up for the irritation of the other two categories.

255

256

Studying for a Test

¹Phase 1 of studying for a test, often called the “no problem” phase, runs from the day the test is announced to approximately forty-eight hours before the dreaded exam is passed out. ²During phase 1, the student is carefree, smiling, and kind to helpless animals and small children. ³When asked by classmates if he or she has studied for the test yet, the reply will be an assured “No problem.” ⁴During phase 1, no actual studying takes place. ⁵Phase 2 is entered two days before the test. ⁶For example, if the test is scheduled for 9 A.M. Friday, phase 2 begins at 9 A.M. Wednesday. ⁷During phase 2, again, no actual studying takes place. ⁸Phase 3, the final phase, is entered twelve hours before “zero hour.” ⁹This is the cram phase, characterized by sweaty palms, nervous twitches, and confused mental patterns. ¹⁰For a test at nine o’clock on Friday morning, a student begins exhibiting these symptoms at approximately nine o’clock on Thursday night. ¹¹Phase 3 is also termed the “shock” phase, since the student is shocked to discover the imminence of the exam and the amount of material to be studied. ¹²During this phase, the student will probably be unable to sleep and will mumble meaningless phrases like “ $a^2 + c^2$.” ¹³This phase will not end until the exam is over. ¹⁴If the cram session has worked, the student will fall gratefully asleep that night. ¹⁵On waking up, he or she will be ready to go through the whole cycle again with the next test.

Three Kinds of Dogs

¹A city walker will notice that most dogs fall into one of three categories. ²First there are the big dogs, which are generally harmless and often downright friendly. ³They walk along peacefully with their masters, their tongues hanging out and big goofy grins on their faces. ⁴Apparently they know they're too big to have anything to worry about, so why not be nice? ⁵Second are the spunky medium-sized dogs. ⁶When they see a stranger approaching, they go on alert. ⁷They prick up their ears, they raise their hackles, and they may growl a little deep in their throats. ⁸"I could tear you up," they seem to be saying, "but I won't if you behave yourself." ⁹Unless the walker leaps for their master's throat, these dogs usually won't do anything more than threaten. ¹⁰The third category is made up of the shivering neurotic little yappers whose shrill barks could shatter glass and whose needle-like little teeth are eager to sink into a friendly outstretched hand. ¹¹Walkers always wonder about these dogs—don't they know that people who really wanted to could squash them under their feet like bugs? ¹²Apparently not, because of all the dogs a walker meets, these provide the most irritation. ¹³Such dogs are only one of the potential hazards that the city walker encounters.

256
257

Questions

About Unity

- 1. Which paragraph lacks a topic sentence?

- 2. Which sentence in "Three Kinds of Dogs" should be eliminated in the interest of paragraph unity? (*Write the sentence number here.*) _____

About Support

- 3. Which of the three phases in "Studying for a Test" lacks specific details?

- 4. After which sentence in "Types of E-Mail" are supporting details needed? (*Write the sentence number here.*) _____

About Coherence

- 5. Which paragraph uses emphatic order to organize its details?

6. Which words in the emphatic-order paragraph signal the most important detail?

Activity 1

This activity will sharpen your sense of the classifying process. In each of the ten groups, cross out the one item that has not been classified on the same basis as the other three. Also, indicate in the space provided the single principle of classification used for the remaining three items. Note the examples.

EXAMPLES

- Water
- a. Cold
 - b. ~~Lake~~
 - c. Hot
 - d. Lukewarm

Unifying principle:

Temperature

- Household pests
- a. ~~Mice~~
 - b. Ants
 - c. Roaches
 - d. Flies

Unifying principle:

Insects

1. Eyes
- a. Blue
 - b. Nearsighted
 - c. Brown
 - d. Hazel

Unifying principle:

2. Mattresses
- a. Double
 - b. Twin
 - c. Queen
 - d. Firm

Unifying principle:

257
258

3. Zoo animals

- a. Flamingo
- b. Peacock
- c. Polar bear
- d. Ostrich

Unifying principle:

4. Vacation

- a. Summer
- b. Holiday
- c. Seashore
- d. Weekend

Unifying principle:

5. Books

- a. Novels
- b. Biographies
- c. Boring
- d. Short stories

Unifying principle:

6. Wallets

- a. Leather
- b. Plastic
- c. Stolen
- d. Fabric

Unifying principle:

7. Newspaper

- a. Wrapping garbage
- b. Editorials
- c. Making paper planes
- d. Covering floor while painting

Unifying principle:

8. Students

- a. First-year
- b. Transfer
- c. Junior
- d. Sophomore

Unifying principle:

9. Exercise

- a. Running
- b. Swimming
- c. Gymnastics
- d. Fatigue

Unifying principle:

10. Leftovers

- a. Cold chicken
- b. Feed to dog
- c. Reheat

- d. Use in a stew
- Unifying principle:

258

Developing a Division-Classification Paragraph

259

Development through Prewriting

Marcus walked home from campus to his apartment, thinking about the assignment to write a division-classification paragraph. As he strolled along his familiar route, his observations made him think of several possibilities. “First I thought of writing about the businesses in my neighborhood, dividing them into the ones run by Hispanics, Asians, and African-Americans,” he said. “When I stopped in at my favorite coffee shop, I thought about dividing the people who hang out there. There is a group of old men who meet to drink coffee and play cards, and there are students like me, but there didn’t seem to be a third category and I wasn’t sure two was enough. As I continued walking home, though, I saw Mr. Enriquez and his big golden retriever, and a woman with two nervous little dogs that acted as if they wanted to eat me, and the newsstand guy with his mutt that’s always guarding the place, and I thought ‘Dogs! I can classify types of dogs.’”

But how would he classify them? Thinking further, Marcus realized that he thought of dogs as having certain personalities depending on their size. “I know there are exceptions, of course, but since this was going to be a lighthearted, even comical paragraph, I thought it would be OK if I exaggerated a bit.” He wrote down his three categories:

Big dogs

Medium-sized dogs

Small dogs

Under each division, then, he wrote down as many characteristics as he could think of:

<u>Big dogs</u>	<u>Medium-sized dogs</u>	<u>Small dogs</u>
calm	spunky	nervous
friendly	energetic	trembling
good-natured	ready to fight	noisy
dumb	protective	yappy
lazy	friendly if they know you	snappy
		annoying

259

Marcus then wrote a topic sentence: “Dogs seem to fall into three categories.” Using that topic sentence and the scratch outline he’d just produced, he wrote the following paragraph:

Most dogs seem to fall into one of three categories. First there are the big dumb friendly dogs. They give the impression of being sweet but not real bright. One example of this kind of dog is Lucy. She’s a golden retriever belonging to a man in my neighborhood. Lucy goes everywhere with Mr. Enriquez. She doesn’t even need a leash but just follows him. Dogs like Lucy never bother anybody. She just lies at Mr. Enriquez’s feet when he stops to talk to anyone. The guy who runs the corner newsstand I pass every day has a spunky medium-sized dog. Once the dog knows you he’s friendly and even playful. But he’s always on the lookout for a stranger who might mean trouble. For a dog who’s not very big he can make himself look pretty fierce if he wants to. Then there are my least favorite kind of dogs. Little nervous yappy ones. My aunt used to have a Chihuahua like that. It knew me for nine years and still went crazy shaking and yipping at me every time we met. She loved that dog but I can’t imagine why. If I had a dog it would definitely come from category 1 or 2.

Development through Revising

Marcus traded his first draft with a fellow student, Rachel, and asked her to give him feedback. Here are the comments Rachel wrote on his paper:

This is a change in point of view—you haven't been using "you" before.

Is this the beginning of a second category? That's not clear.

Not a complete sentence.

Another change in point of view—you've gone from writing in the third person to "you" to "me."

Most dogs seem to fall into three categories. First there are the big dumb friendly dogs. They give the impression of being sweet but not real bright. One example of this kind of dog is Lucy, a golden retriever belonging to a man in my neighborhood. Lucy goes everywhere with Mr. Enriquez. She doesn't even need a leash but just follows him everywhere. Lucy never bothers you. She just lies at Mr. Enriquez's feet when he stops to talk to anyone. The guy who runs the corner newsstand I pass every day has a spunky medium-sized dog. Once the dog knows you he's friendly and even playful. But he's always on the lookout for a stranger who might mean trouble. For a dog who's not very big he can make himself look pretty fierce if he wants to scare you. Then there are my least favorite kind of dogs. Little nervous yappy ones. My aunt used to have a Chihuahua like that. It knew me for nine years and still went crazy shaking and yipping at me every time we met. She loved that dog but I can't imagine why. If I had a dog it would definitely come from category 1 or 2.

Marcus—I think you need to make your three categories clearer. Your first one is OK—"big dogs," which you say are friendly—but categories 2 and 3 aren't stated as clearly. It's distracting to have your point of view change from third person to "you" to "me." Since you're trying to divide and classify all dogs, I'm not sure it's a good idea to talk only about three individual dogs. This way it sounds as if you're just describing those three dogs instead of putting them into three groups.

When Marcus considered Rachel’s comments and reread his paragraph, he agreed with what she had written. “I realized it was too much about three particular dogs and not enough about the categories of dogs,” he said. “I decided to revise it and focus on the three classes of dogs.”

Marcus then wrote the version that appears on [page 256](#).

261

262

Writing Assignment 1

Below are four options to develop into a classification paragraph. Each one presents a topic to classify into three categories. Choose one option to develop into a paragraph.

OPTION 1

Supermarket shoppers

- (1) Slow, careful shoppers
- (2) Average shoppers
- (3) Hurried shoppers

OPTION 2

Eaters

- (1) Very conservative eaters
- (2) Typical eaters
- (3) Adventurous eaters

OPTION 3

Types of housekeepers

- (1) Never clean
- (2) Clean on a regular basis
- (3) Clean constantly

OPTION 4

Attitudes toward money

- (1) Cheap
- (2) Reasonable
- (3) Extravagant

Prewriting

- a. Begin by doing some freewriting on the topic you have chosen. For five or ten minutes, simply write down everything that comes into your head when you think about “types of housekeepers,” “attitudes toward money,” or whichever option you choose. Don’t worry about grammar, spelling, or organization—just write.
- b. Now that you’ve “loosened up your brain” a little, try asking yourself questions about the topic and writing down your answers. If you are writing about supermarket shoppers, for instance, you might ask questions like these:

How do the three kinds of shoppers prepare for their shopping trip?

How many aisles will each kind of shopper visit?

What do the different kinds of shoppers bring along with them—lists, calculators, coupons, etc.?

How long does each type of shopper spend in the store?

Write down whatever answers occur to you for these and other questions. Again, do not worry at this stage about writing correctly. Instead, concentrate on getting down all the information you can think of that supports your three points.

- c. Reread the material you have accumulated. If some of the details you have written make you think of even better ones, add them. Select the details that best support your three points. Number them in the order you will present them.
- d. Restate your topic as a grammatically complete topic sentence. For example, if you’re writing about eaters, your topic sentence might be “Eaters can be divided into three categories.” Turn each of your three supporting points into a full sentence as well.
- e. Using your topic sentence and three supporting sentences and adding the details you have generated, write the first draft of your paragraph.

Revising

Put away your work for a day or so. Then reread it with a critical eye, asking yourself or a peer reviewer these questions:



262
263

FOUR BASES Checklist for Division-Classification

About *Unity*

- Does my paragraph include a complete topic sentence and three supporting points?
- While classifying the various types of my chosen topic, have I also kept that subject unified?

About *Support*

- Have I backed up each supporting point with strong, specific details?
- Have I given examples of each type of shopper, housekeeper, eater, or attitude toward money?

About *Coherence*

- Does the paragraph successfully classify types of shoppers, housekeepers, eaters, or attitudes toward money?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I carefully proofread my paragraph, using the list on the inside back cover of the book, and corrected all sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling?
- Have I used specific rather than general words?

Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.

263

264

Writing Assignment 2

Write a classification paragraph on one of the following topics:



First dates

Drivers

Mothers or fathers

Cars

Instructors

Sports fans

Restaurants

Attitudes toward life

Commercials

Employers

Jobs

Bars

Women's or men's magazines

Rock, pop, rap, or country singers

Family get-togethers

Presents

Neighbors

Houseguests

Baseball, basketball, football, or hockey players

Prewriting

- a. Classify members of the group you are considering writing about into three categories. Remember: *You must use a single principle of division when you create your three categories.* For example, if your topic is “school courses” and you classify them into easy, moderate, and challenging, your basis for classification is “degree of difficulty.” It would not make sense to have as a fourth type “foreign language” (the basis of such a categorization would be “subject matter”) or “early morning” (the basis of that classification would be “time of day the classes meet”). You *could* categorize school courses on the basis of subject matter or time of day they meet, for almost any subject can be classified in more than one way. In a single paper, however, you must choose *one* basis for classification and stick to it.

b. Once you have a satisfactory three-part division, spend at least five minutes freewriting about each of your three points. Don't be concerned yet with grammar, spelling, or organization. Just write whatever comes into your mind about each of the three points.	264
c. Expand your topic into a fully stated topic sentence. d. At this point, you have all three elements of your paragraph: the topic sentence, the three main points, and the details needed to support each point. Now weave them all together in one paragraph. Revising Do not attempt to revise your paragraph right away. Put it away for a while, if possible until the next day. When you reread it, try to be as critical of it as you would be if someone else had written it. As you go over the work, ask yourself these questions: FOUR BASES Checklist for Division-Classification About <i>Unity</i> ➤ Have I divided my topic into three distinct parts? ➤ Is each of those parts based on the same principle of division? About <i>Support</i> ➤ Have I provided effective details to back up each of my three points? ➤ Have I given each of the three parts approximately equal weight, devoting the same amount of time to each part? About <i>Coherence</i> ➤ Have I used appropriate transitions and other connective devices to weave my paragraph together? About <i>Sentence Skills</i> ➤ Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph? ➤ Have I used specific rather than general words? ➤ Have I avoided wordiness and used concise wording? ➤ Are my sentences varied?	265

- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising until you are sure the answer to each question is “yes.”

265

266

Writing Assignment 3

There are many ways you could classify your fellow students. Pick out one of your courses and write a paragraph in which you classify the students in that class according to one underlying principle. You may wish to choose one of the classification principles below.

- | | |
|--|---------------------|
| Attitude toward the class | Punctuality |
| Participation in the class | Attendance |
| Method of taking notes in class | Level of confidence |
| Performance during oral reports, speeches, presentations, lab sessions | |

If you decide, for instance, to classify students according to their attitude toward class, you might come up with these three categories:

- Students actually interested in learning the material
- Students who know they need to learn the material, but don’t want to overdo it
- Students who find the class a good opportunity to catch up with lost sleep

Of course, you may use any other principle of classification that seems appropriate. Follow the steps listed under “Prewriting” and “Revising” for [Writing Assignment 2](#).

Writing Assignment 4

When we go to a restaurant, we probably hope that the service will be helpful, the atmosphere will be pleasant, and the food will be tasty. But as the cartoon shown on the following page suggests, restaurants that are good in all three respects may be hard to find. Write a review of a restaurant, analyzing its (1) service, (2) atmosphere, and (3) food. Visit a restaurant for this assignment, or draw on an experience you have had recently. Freewrite or make a list of observations about such elements as

- | | |
|--|---|
| Quantity of food you receive | Attitude of the servers |
| Taste of the food | Efficiency of the servers |
| Temperature of the food | Decor (consider if it's a chain restaurant) |
| Freshness of the ingredients | Level of cleanliness |
| How the food is presented (garnishes, dishes, and so on) | Noise level and music, if any |

Feel free to write about details other than those listed above. Just be sure each detail fits into one of your three categories: food, service, or atmosphere.

266

267



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For your topic sentence, rate the restaurant by giving it from one to five stars, on the basis of your overall impression. Include the restaurant's name and location in your topic sentence. Here are some examples:

Guido's, an Italian restaurant downtown, deserves three stars.

The McDonald's on Route 70 merits a four-star rating.

The Circle Diner in Westfield barely earns a one-star rating.

Writing Assignment 5

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this division-classification paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Imagine that you are a travel agent and someone has asked you for suggestions about family vacations. Write a paragraph classifying vacations for families into three or more types—for example, vacations in theme parks, in national parks, in the city, or in the countryside. For each type, include an explanation with one or more examples (see [page 110](#)).

14: Description

Just as an artist uses paint to create a picture for viewers, writers use words to paint a picture in their readers' minds. Try to recreate this painting with words and write a paragraph in which you describe the painting to someone who has never seen it.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop a descriptive paragraph
- write a descriptive paragraph
- revise a descriptive paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student descriptive paragraphs

268

269

When you describe something or someone, you give your readers a picture in words. To make this “word picture” as vivid and real as possible, you must observe and record specific details that appeal to your readers’ senses (sight, hearing, taste, smell, and touch). More than any other type of writing, a descriptive paragraph needs sharp, colorful details.



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Here is a description in which only the sense of sight is used:

A rug covers the living-room floor.

In contrast, here is a description rich in sense impressions:

A thick, reddish-brown shag rug is laid wall to wall across the living-room floor. The long, curled fibers of the shag seem to whisper as you walk through them in your bare feet, and when you squeeze your toes into the deep covering, the soft fibers push back at you with a spongy resilience.

Sense impressions include sight (*thick, reddish-brown shag rug; laid wall to wall; walk through them in your bare feet; squeeze your toes into the deep covering; push back*), hearing (*whisper*), and touch (*bare feet, soft fibers, spongy resilience*). The sharp, vivid images provided by the sensory details give us a clear picture of the rug and enable us to share the writer’s experience.

In this chapter, you will be asked to describe a person, place, or thing for your readers by using words rich in sensory details. To prepare for the assignment, first read the three paragraphs ahead and then answer the questions that follow.

Paragraphs to Consider

My Teenage Son's Room

¹I push open the door with difficulty. ²The doorknob is loose and has to be jiggled just right before the catch releases from the doorjamb. ³Furthermore, as I push at the door, it runs into a basketball shoe lying on the floor. ⁴I manage to squeeze in through the narrow opening. I am immediately aware of a pungent odor in the room, most of which is coming from the closet, to my right. ⁵That's the location of a white wicker clothes hamper, heaped with grass-stained jeans, sweat-stained T-shirts, and smelly socks. ⁶But the half-eaten burrito, lying dried and unappetizing on the bedside table across the room, contributes a bit of aroma, as does the glass of curdled sour milk sitting on the sunny windowsill. ⁷To my left, the small wire cage on Greg's desk is also fragrant, but pleasantly. ⁸From its nest of sweet-smelling cedar chips, the gerbil peers out at me with its bright eyes, its tiny claws scratching against the cage wall. ⁹The floor around the wastebasket that is next to the desk is surrounded by what appears to be a sprinkling of snowballs. ¹⁰They're actually old wadded-up school papers, and I can picture Greg sitting on his bed, crushing them into balls and aiming them at the "basket"—the trash can. ¹¹I glance at the bed across from the desk and chuckle because pillows stuffed under the tangled nest of blankets make it look as if someone is still sleeping there, though I know Greg is in history class right now. ¹²I step carefully through the room, trying to walk through the obstacle course of science-fiction paperbacks, a wristwatch, sports magazines, and a dust-covered computer on which my son stacks empty soda cans. ¹³I leave everything as I find it, but tape a note to Greg's door saying, "Isn't it about time to clean up?"

269

A Depressing Place

¹The pet shop in the mall is a depressing place. ²A display window attracts passersby who stare at the prisoners penned inside. ³In the right-hand side of the window, two puppies press their forepaws against the glass and attempt to lick the human hands that press from the outside. ⁴A cardboard barrier separates the dogs from several black-and-white kittens piled together in the opposite end of the window. ⁵Inside the shop, rows of wire cages line one wall from top to bottom. ⁶At first, it is hard to tell whether a bird, hamster, gerbil, cat, or dog is locked inside each cage. ⁷Only an occasional movement or a clawing, shuffling sound tells visitors that living creatures are inside. ⁸Running down the center of the store is a line of large wooden perches that look like coat racks. ⁹When customers pass by, the parrots and mynahs chained to these perches flutter their clipped wings in a useless attempt to escape. ¹⁰At the end of this center aisle is a large plastic tub of dirty, stagnant-looking water containing a few motionless turtles. ¹¹The shelves against the left-hand wall are packed with all kinds of pet-related items. ¹²The smell inside the entire shop is an unpleasant mixture of strong chemical deodorizers, urine-soaked newspapers, and musty sawdust. ¹³Because so many animals are crammed together, the normally pleasant, slightly milky smell of the puppies and kittens is sour and strong. ¹⁴The droppings inside the uncleaned birdcages give off a dry, stinging odor. ¹⁵Visitors hurry out of the shop, anxious to feel fresh air and sunlight. ¹⁶The animals stay on.

270

271

Karla

¹Karla, my brother's new girlfriend, is a catlike creature. ²Framing her face is a layer of sleek black hair that always looks just-combed. ³Her face, with its wide forehead, sharp cheekbones, and narrow, pointed chin, resembles a triangle. ⁴Karla's skin is a soft, velvety brown. ⁵Her large brown eyes slant upward at the corners, and she emphasizes their angle with a sweep of maroon eye shadow. ⁶Karla's habit of looking sidelong out of the tail of her eye makes her appear cautious, as if she were expecting something to sneak up on her. ⁷Her nose is small and flat. ⁸The sharply outlined depression under it leads the observer's eye to a pair of red-tinted lips. ⁹With their slight upward tilt at the corners, Karla's lips make her seem self-satisfied and secretly pleased. ¹⁰One reason Karla may be happy is that she recently was asked to be in a local beauty contest. ¹¹Her long neck and slim body are perfectly in proportion with her face. ¹²Karla manages to look elegant and sleek no matter how she is standing or sitting, for her body seems to be made up of graceful angles. ¹³Her slender hands are tipped with long, polished nails. ¹⁴Her narrow feet are long, too, but they appear delicate even in flat-soled running shoes. ¹⁵Somehow, Karla would look perfect in a cat's jeweled collar.

Questions

About Unity

1. Which paragraph lacks a topic sentence?

2. Which sentence in the paragraph about Karla should be omitted in the interest of paragraph unity? (*Write the sentence number here.*) _____

About Support

3. Label as *sight*, *touch*, *hearing*, or *smell* all the sensory details in the following sentences taken from the three paragraphs. The first sentence is done for you as an example.

a. From a pile of mossy logs under steps, the pettiest cat came
and lit up, saw it, dug down, sniffed, and
was gone.

b. Because so many animals are crammed together, the normally pleasant, slightly milky smell of the puppies and kittens is sour and strong.

c. Her slender hands are tipped with long, polished nails.

d. That’s the location of a white wicker clothes hamper, heaped with grass-stained jeans, sweat-stained T-shirts, and smelly socks.
4. After which sentence in “A Depressing Place” are specific details needed?

271

272

About Coherence

5. Spatial signals (*above*, *next to*, *to the right*, and so on) are often used to help organize details in a descriptive paragraph. List four space signals that appear in “My Teenage Son’s Room”:

6. The writer of “Karla” organizes the details by observing Karla in an orderly way. Which of Karla’s features is described first? _____ Which is described last? _____ Check the method of spatial organization that best describes the paragraph:

____Interior to exterior

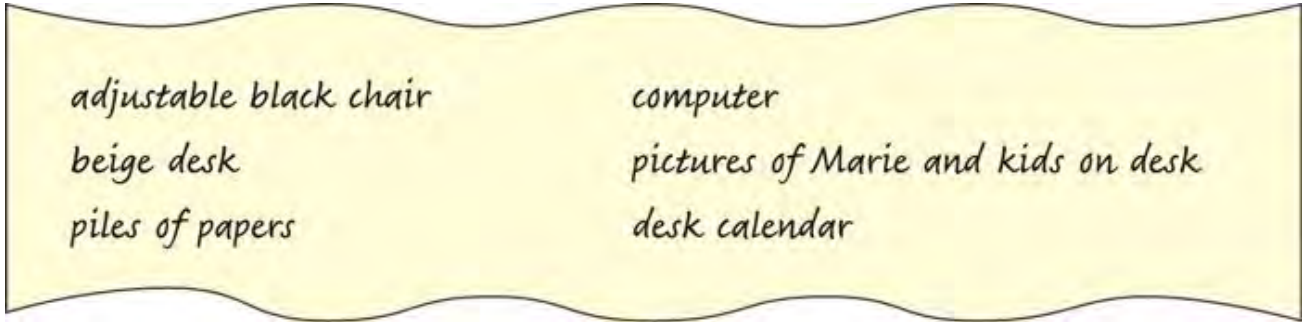
____Near to far

____Top to bottom

Developing a Descriptive Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

When Victor was assigned a descriptive paragraph, he thought at first of describing his own office at work. He began by making a list of details he noticed while looking around the office:



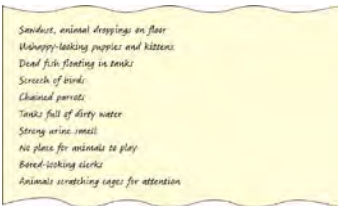
But Victor quickly became bored. Here is how he describes what happened next:

“As I wrote down what I saw in my office, I was thinking, ‘What a drag.’ I gave up and worked on something else. Later that evening I told my wife that I was going to write a boring paragraph about my boring office. She started laughing at me. I said, ‘What’s so funny?’ and she said, ‘You’re so certain that a writing assignment has to be boring that you deliberately chose a subject that bores you. How about writing about something you care about?’ At first I was annoyed, but then I realized she was right. When I hear ‘assignment’ I automatically think ‘pain in the neck’ and just want to get it over with.”

Victor’s attitude is not uncommon. Many students who are not experienced writers don’t take the time to find a topic that interests them. They grab the one closest at hand and force themselves to write about it just for the sake of completing the assignment. Like Victor, they ensure that they (and probably their instructors as well) will be bored with the task.

In Victor’s case, he decided that this assignment would be different. That evening as he talked with his son, Mikey, he remembered a visit the two had made to a mall a few days earlier. Mikey had asked Victor to take him to the pet store. Victor had found the store a very unpleasant place. “As I remembered the store, I recalled a lot of descriptive details—sounds, smells, sights,” Victor said. “I realized not only that it would be easier to describe a place like that than my bland, boring office, but that I would actually find it an interesting challenge to make a reader see it through my words. For me to realize writing could be enjoyable was a real shock!”

Now that Victor had his subject, he began making a list of details about the pet shop. Here is what he wrote:



As he looked over his list of details, the word that came to mind was “depressing.” He decided his topic sentence would be “The pet store in the mall is depressing.” He then wrote this first draft:

The pet store in the mall is depressing. There are sawdust and animal droppings all over the floor. Sad-looking puppies and kittens scratch on their cages for attention. Dead fish and motionless turtles float in tanks of stagnant water. The loud screeching of birds is everywhere, and parrots with clipped wings try to escape when customers walk too near. Everywhere there is the smell of animal urine that has soaked the sawdust and newspapers. The clerks, who should be cleaning the cages, stand around talking to each other and ignoring the animals.

Development through Revising

The next day Victor’s instructor asked to see the students’ first drafts. This is what she wrote in response to Victor’s:

This is a very good beginning. You have provided some strong details that appeal to the reader’s senses of smell, hearing, and sight.

In your next draft, organize your paragraph by using spatial order. In other words, describe the room in some logical physical order—maybe from left to right, or from the front of the store to its back. Such an organization mirrors the way a visitor might move through the store.

I encourage you to become even more specific in your details. For instance, in what way did the puppies and kittens seem sad? As you work on each sentence, ask yourself if you can add more descriptive details to paint a more vivid picture in words.

In response to his teacher’s suggestion about a spatial order method of organization, Victor rewrote the paragraph, beginning with the display window that attracts visitors, then going on to the store’s right-hand wall, the center aisle, and the left-hand wall. He ended the paragraph with a sentence that brought the reader back outside the shop. Thinking about the shop in this way enabled Victor to remember and add a

number of new specific details as well. He then wrote the version of “A Depressing Place” that appears on [page 270](#).

Writing a Descriptive Paragraph

Writing Assignment 1

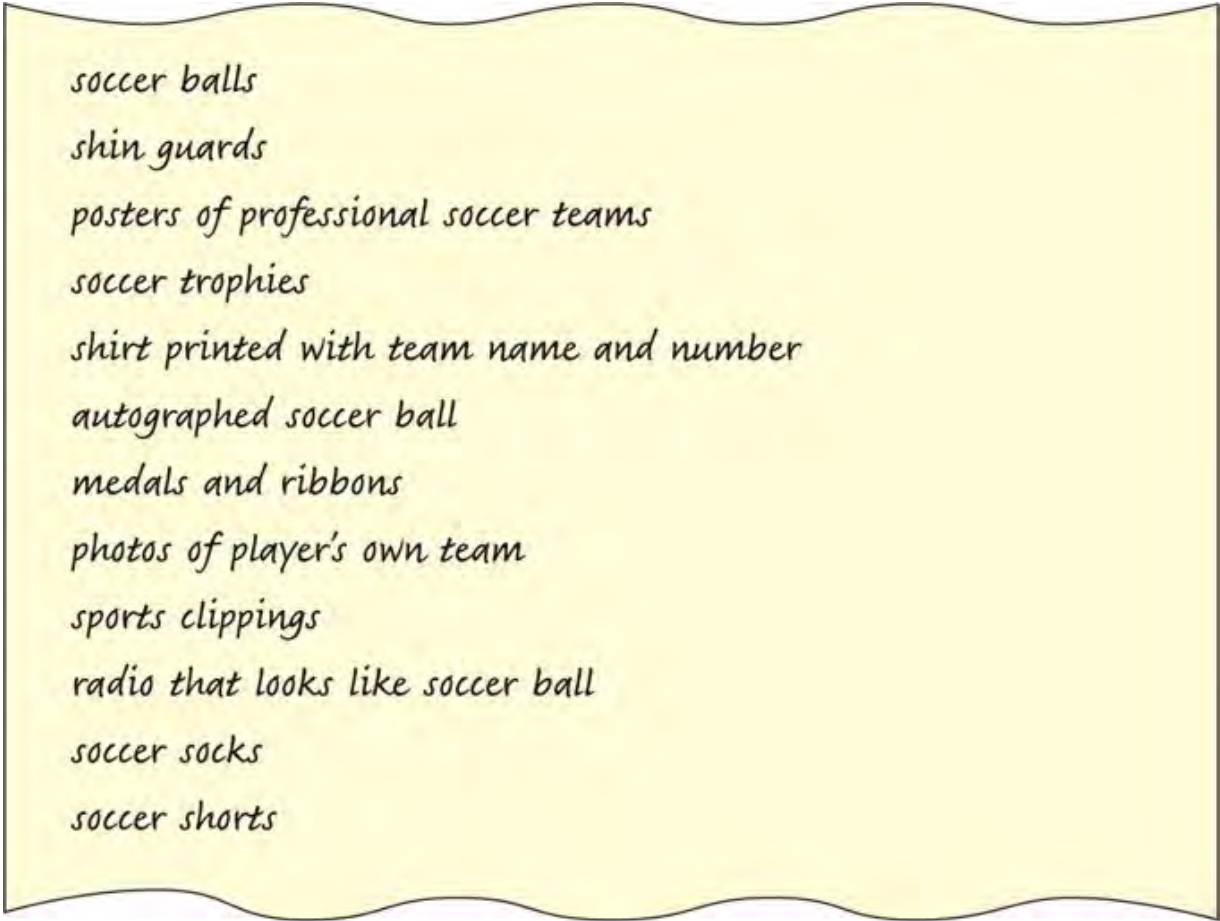
Write a paragraph describing a certain person’s room. Use as your topic sentence “I could tell by looking at the room that a _____ lived there.” There are many kinds of people who could be the focus for such a paragraph. You can select any one of the following, or think of another type of person.

- | | |
|-----------------|--------------------|
| Photographer | Cheerleader |
| Cook | Football player |
| Student | Actor |
| Musician | Dancer |
| Hunter | Carpenter |
| Slob | Baby |
| Outdoors person | Cat or dog lover |
| Doctor | World traveler |
| Music lover | Drug addict |
| TV addict | Little boy or girl |
| Camper | Alcoholic |
| Computer expert | In-line skater |



Prewriting

- a. After choosing a topic, spend a few minutes making sure it will work. Prepare a list of all the details you can think of that support the topic. For example, a student who planned to describe a soccer player’s room made this list:



HINT

If you don’t have enough details, choose another type of person. Check your new choice by listing details before committing yourself to the topic.

- b. You may want to use other prewriting techniques, such as freewriting or questioning, to develop more details for your topic. As you continue prewriting, keep the following in mind:
- Everything in the paragraph should support your point. For example, if you are writing about a soccer player’s room, every detail should serve to show that the person who lives in that room plays and loves soccer. Other details—for example, the person’s computer, tropical fish tank, or daily “to-do” list—should be omitted.
 - Description depends on the use of specific rather than general descriptive words. For example:

275

276

	General Mess on the floor	Specific The obstacle course of science-fiction paperbacks, a wristwatch, sports magazines, and a dust-covered computer on which my son stacks empty soda cans.	276
	Ugly turtle tub Bad smell Nice skin	Large plastic tub of dirty, stagnant-looking water containing a few motionless turtles Unpleasant mixture of strong chemical deodorizers, urine-soaked newspapers, and musty sawdust Soft, velvety brown skin	277
	Remember that you want your readers to experience the room vividly. Your words should be as detailed as a clear photograph, giving readers a real feel for the room. Appeal to as many senses as possible. Most of your description will involve the sense of sight, but you may be able to include details about touch, hearing, and smell as well. - Spatial order is a good way to organize a descriptive paragraph. Move as a visitor’s eye might move around the room, from right to left or from larger items to smaller ones. Here are a few transition words of the sort that show spatial relationships: to the left to the right next to across from above below on the opposite side nearby Such transitions will help prevent you—and your reader—from getting lost as the description proceeds. c. Before you write, see if you can make a scratch outline based on your list. Here is one possible outline of the paragraph about the soccer player’s room. Note that the details are organized according to spatial order—from the edges of the room in toward the center. <u>Topic sentence:</u> <i>I could tell by looking at the room that a soccer player lived there.</i> <i>Walls</i> <i>Bookcase</i> <i>Desk</i> <i>Chair</i> <i>Floor</i>		

d. Then proceed to write a first draft of your paragraph.	277
 Revising Read your descriptive paragraph slowly out loud to a friend. Ask the friend to close his or her eyes and try to picture the room as you read. Read it aloud a second time. Ask your friend to answer these questions: FOUR BASES Checklist for Description About <i>Unity</i> - Does every detail in the paragraph support the topic sentence? Here’s one way to find out: Ask your friend to imagine omitting the key word or words (in the case of our example, “soccer player”) in your topic sentence. Would readers know what word should fit in that empty space? About <i>Support</i> - Are the details specific and vivid rather than general? - Has the writer included details that appeal to as many senses as possible? About <i>Coherence</i> - Does the paragraph follow a logical spatial order? - Has the writer used transitions (such as <i>on top of</i>, <i>beside</i>, <i>to the left of</i>) to help the reader follow that order? About <i>Sentence Skills</i> - Has the writer carefully proofread his or her paragraph, using the list on the inside back cover of the book, and corrected all sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling? Continue revising your work until you and your reader can answer “yes” to all these questions.	278

Writing Assignment 2

Write a paragraph describing a specific person. Select a dominant impression of the person, and use only details that will convey that impression. You might want to write about someone who falls into one of these categories:



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278

279

- | | |
|-------------------------|--------------------------|
| TV or movie personality | Coworker |
| Instructor | Clergyman or clergywoman |
| Employer | Police officer |
| Child | Store owner or manager |
| Older person | Bartender |
| Close friend | Joker |
| Enemy | Neighbor |

Prewriting

- a. Reread the paragraph about Karla that appears earlier in this chapter. Note the dominant impression that the writer wanted to convey: that Karla is a catlike person. Having decided to focus on that impression, the writer included only details that contributed to her point. Similarly, you should focus on one dominant aspect of your subject’s appearance, personality, or behavior.
- Once you have chosen the person you will write about and the impression you plan to portray, put that information into a topic sentence. Here are some examples of topic sentences that mention a particular person and the dominant impression of that person:
- Kate gives the impression of being permanently nervous.
- The old man was as faded and brittle as a dying leaf.
- The child was an angelic little figure.
- Our high school principal resembled a cartoon drawing.
- The TV newscaster seems as synthetic as a piece of Styrofoam.
- Our neighbor is a fussy person.

The rock singer seemed to be plugged into some special kind of energy source.

The drug addict looked as lifeless as a corpse.

My friend Jeffrey is a slow, deliberate person.

The owner of that grocery store seems burdened with troubles.

- b. Make a list of the person’s qualities that support your topic sentence. Write quickly; don’t worry if you find yourself writing down something that doesn’t quite fit. You can always edit the list later. For now, just write down all the details that occur to you that support the dominant impression you want to convey. Include details that involve as many senses as possible (sight, sound, hearing, touch, smell). For instance, here’s a list one writer jotted down to support the sentence “The child was an angelic little figure”:



- c. Edit your list, striking out details that don’t support your topic sentence and adding others that do. The author of the paragraph on an angelic figure crossed out one detail from the original list and added a new one:



279

280

- d. Decide on a spatial order of organization. In the example above, the writer ultimately decided to describe the child from head to toe.
- e. Make a scratch outline for your paragraph, based on the organization you have chosen.
- f. Then proceed to write a first draft of your paragraph.

Revising

Put your paragraph away for a day or so if at all possible. Then ask yourself and a peer editor these questions:



280

281

FOUR BASES Checklist for Description

About *Unity*

- Does my topic sentence make a general point about the incident?

About *Support*

- Do descriptions of the appearance, tone of voice, and expressions of the people involved paint a clear picture of the incident?

About *Coherence*

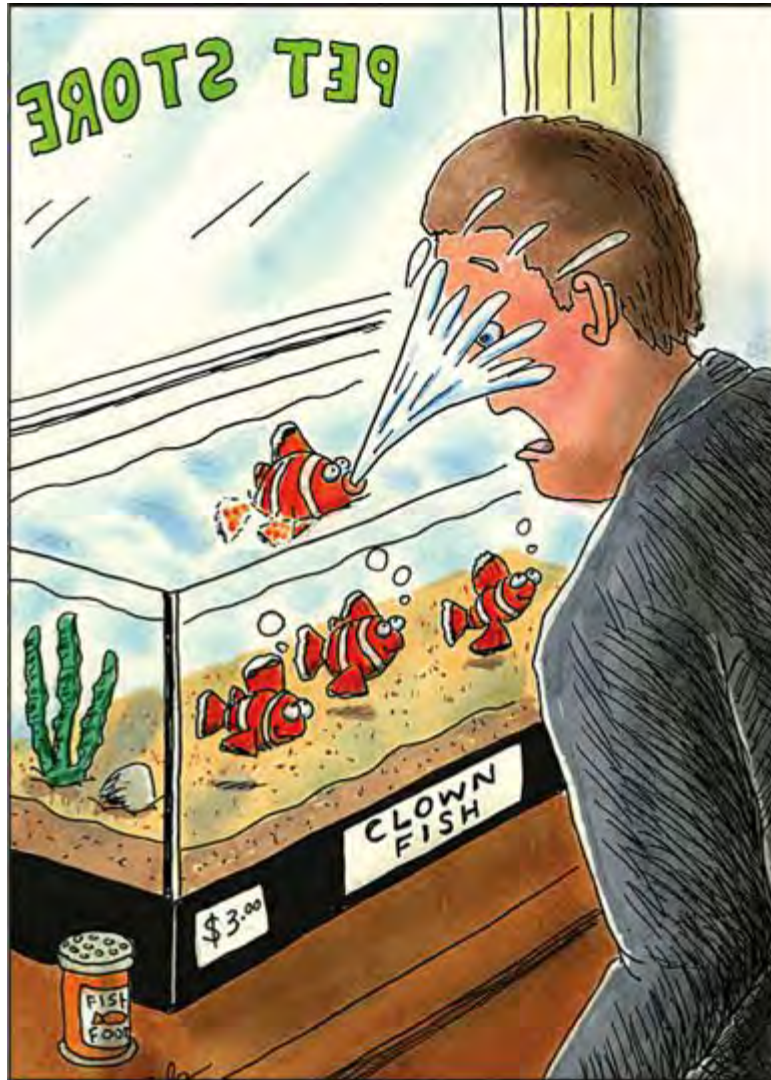
- Is the sequence of events made clear by transitional words, such as *first*, *later*, and *then*?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph?
- Have I used specific rather than general words?
- Have I avoided wordiness?
- Are my sentences varied?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.

Writing Assignment 3



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Write a paragraph describing the cartoon shown here so that a person who has never seen it will be able to visualize it and fully understand it.

In order to write such a complete description, you must notice and report *every detail* in the cartoon. The details include such things as the way the room is arranged; the objects present in the room; what the characters are doing with those objects; the expressions on the characters' faces; and any motions that are occurring. Remember as you are describing the cartoon to give special attention to the same elements that the cartoonist gives special attention to. Your goal should be this: someone who reads your description of the cartoon will understand it as fully as someone who saw the cartoon itself.

281

282

Writing Assignment 4

Write a paragraph describing an animal you have spent some time with—a pet, a friend’s pet, an animal you’ve seen in a park or zoo or even on television. Write a paragraph about how the animal looks and behaves. Select details that support a dominant impression of your subject. Once you decide on the impression you wish to convey, compose a topic sentence, such as either of those below, that summarizes the details you will use.

The appearance of a gorilla named Koko gives no hint of the animal’s intelligence and gentleness.

A cute squirrel who has taken up residence in my backyard exhibits surprising agility and energy.

Remember to provide colorful, detailed descriptions to help your readers picture the features and behavior you are writing about. Note the contrast in the two items below.

Lacks rich descriptive details: The squirrel was gray and enjoyed our deck. *Includes rich descriptive details:* On our deck, the young gray squirrel dug a hole in the dirt in a planter full of marigolds and then deposited an acorn in the hole, his fluffy tail bobbing enthusiastically all the while.

Writing Assignment 5

Visit a place you have never gone to before and write a paragraph describing it. You may want to visit

- A restaurant
- A classroom, a laboratory, an office, a workroom, or some other room in your school
- A kind of store you ordinarily don’t visit: for example, a hardware store, toy store, record shop, gun shop, or sports shop, or a particular men’s or women’s clothing store
- A bus terminal, train station, or airport
- A place of worship
- A park, vacant lot, or street corner

You may want to jot down details about the place while you are there or very soon after you leave. Again, decide on a dominant impression you want to convey of the place, and use only those details

282
283

which will support that impression. Follow the notes on prewriting, writing, and revising for [Writing Assignment 2](#).

Writing Assignment 6

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this descriptive paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Choose one of the following options.

Option 1

Imagine that you are an interior designer. A new dormitory is going to be built on campus, and you have been asked to create a sample dormitory room for two students. Write a paragraph describing your design of the room, telling what it would include and how it would be arranged. In your prewriting for this assignment, you might list all the relevant student needs you can think of, such as a good study space, storage space, and appropriate lighting and colors. Then put all the parts together so that they work well as a whole. Use a spatial order in your paragraph to help readers “see” your room. Begin with the following topic sentence or something like it:

My design for a dormitory room offers both efficiency and comfort for two students.

Feel free to use a less-than-serious tone.

Option 2

Alternatively, write a paragraph describing your design of another type of room, including any of the following:

- | | |
|-----------------|---------|
| Child’s bedroom | Kitchen |
| Schoolroom | Porch |
| Restaurant | Bakery |

15: Narration



A dults sentimentally think of childhood as a time of happy, carefree innocence, as depicted in this photograph. Yet, during childhood most of us witnessed events that began to make us aware that life was not always happy or fair. What such events do you remember? Select one and write a paragraph about it. What impression did it make on you?

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop a narrative paragraph
- write a narrative paragraph
- revise a narrative paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student narrative paragraphs

284

285

At times we make a statement clear by relating in detail something that has happened. In the story we tell, we present the details in the order in which they happened. A person might say, for example, “I was embarrassed yesterday,” and then go on to illustrate the statement with the following narrative:



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I was hurrying across campus to get to a class. It had rained heavily all morning, so I was hopscotching my way around puddles in the pathway. I called to two friends ahead to wait for me, and right before I caught up to them, I came to a large puddle that covered the entire path. I had to make a quick choice of either stepping into the puddle or trying to jump over it. I jumped, wanting to seem cool, since my friends were watching, but didn't clear the puddle. Water splashed everywhere, drenching my shoe, sock, and pants cuff, and spraying the pants of my friends as well. “Well done, Dave!” they said. My embarrassment was all the greater because I had tried to look so casual.

The speaker's details have made his moment of embarrassment vivid and real for us, and we can see and understand just why he felt as he did.

In this section, you will be asked to tell a story that illustrates or explains some point. The paragraphs below all present narrative experiences that support a point. Read them and then answer the questions that follow.

Paragraphs to Consider



Heartbreak

¹Bonnie and I had gotten engaged in August, just before she left for college at Penn State. ²A week before Thanksgiving, I drove up to see her as a surprise. ³When I knocked on the door of her dorm room, she was indeed surprised, but not in a pleasant way. ⁴She introduced me to her roommate, who looked uncomfortable and quickly left. ⁵I asked Bonnie how classes were going, and at the same time I tugged on the sleeve of my heavy sweater in order to pull it off. ⁶As I was slipping it over my head, I noticed a large photo on the wall—of Bonnie and a tall guy laughing together. ⁷It was decorated with paper flowers and a yellow ribbon, and on the ribbon was written “Bonnie and Blake.” ⁸“What’s going on?” I said. ⁹I stood there stunned and then felt anger that grew rapidly. ¹⁰“Who is Blake?” I asked. ¹¹Bonnie laughed nervously and said, “What do you want to hear about—my classes or Blake?” ¹²I don’t really remember what she then told me, except that Blake was a sophomore math major. ¹³I felt a terrible pain in the pit of my stomach, and I wanted to rest my head on someone’s shoulder and cry. ¹⁴I wanted to tear down the sign and run out, but I did nothing. ¹⁵Clumsily I pulled on my sweater again. ¹⁶My knees felt weak, and I barely had control of my body. ¹⁷I opened the room door, and suddenly more than anything I wanted to slam the door shut so hard that the dorm walls would collapse. ¹⁸Instead, I managed to close the door quietly. ¹⁹I walked away understanding what was meant by a broken heart.

285

286

Losing My Father

¹Although my father died ten years ago, I felt that he’d been lost to me four years earlier. ²Dad had been diagnosed with Alzheimer’s disease, an illness that destroys the memory. ³He couldn’t work any longer, but in his own home he got along pretty well. ⁴I lived hundreds of miles away and wasn’t able to see my parents often. ⁵So when my first child was a few weeks old, I flew home with the baby to visit them. ⁶After Mom met us at the airport, we picked up Dad and went to their favorite local restaurant. ⁷Dad was quiet, but kind and gentle as always, and he seemed glad to see me and his new little grandson. ⁸Everyone went to bed early. ⁹In the morning, Mom left for work. ¹⁰I pattered happily around in my old bedroom. ¹¹I heard Dad shuffling around in the kitchen, making coffee. ¹²Eventually I realized that he was pacing back and forth at the foot of the stairs as if he were uneasy. ¹³I called down to him, “Everything all right there?” ¹⁴“I’ll be down in a minute.” ¹⁵“Fine!” he called back, with forced-sounding cheerfulness. ¹⁶Then he stopped pacing and called up to me, “I must be getting old and forgetful. ¹⁷When did you get here?” ¹⁸I was surprised, but made myself answer calmly. ¹⁹“Yesterday afternoon.” ²⁰Remember, Mom met us at the airport, and then we went to The Skillet for dinner.” ²¹“Oh, yes,” he said. ²²“I had roast beef.” ²³I began to relax. ²⁴But then he continued, hesitantly, “And . . . who are you?” ²⁵My breath stopped as if I’d been punched in the stomach. ²⁶When I could steady my voice, I answered, “I’m Laura; I’m your daughter.” ²⁷I’m here with my baby son, Max.” ²⁸“Oh,” is all he said. ²⁹“Oh.” ³⁰And he wandered into the living room and sat down. ³¹In a few minutes I joined him and found him staring blankly out the window. ³²He was a polite host, asking if I wanted anything to eat, and if the room was too cold. ³³I answered with an aching heart, mourning for his loss and for mine.

286

A Frustrating Job

¹Working as a baby-sitter was the most frustrating job I ever had. ²I discovered this fact when my sister asked me to stay with her two sons for the evening. ³I figured I would get them dinner, let them watch a little TV, and then put them to bed early. ⁴The rest of the night I planned to watch TV and collect an easy twenty dollars. ⁵It turned out to be anything but easy. ⁶First, right before we were about to sit down for a pizza dinner, Rickie let the parakeet out of its cage. ⁷This bird is really intelligent and can repeat almost any phrase. ⁸The dog started chasing it around the house, so I decided to catch it before the dog did. ⁹Rickie and Jeff volunteered to help, following at my heels. ¹⁰We had the bird cornered by the fireplace when Rickie jumped for it and knocked over the hamster cage. ¹¹Then the bird escaped again, and the hamsters began scurrying around their cage like crazy creatures. ¹²The dog had disappeared by this point, so I decided to clean up the hamsters' cage and try to calm them down. ¹³While I was doing this, Rickie and Jeff caught the parakeet and put it back in its cage. ¹⁴It was time to return to the kitchen and eat cold pizza. ¹⁵But upon entering the kitchen, I discovered why the dog had lost interest in the bird chase. ¹⁶What was left of the pizza was lying on the floor, and tomato sauce was dripping from the dog's chin. ¹⁷I cleaned up the mess and then served chicken noodle soup and ice cream to the boys. ¹⁸Only at nine o'clock did I get the kids to bed. ¹⁹I then returned downstairs to find that the dog had thrown up pizza on the living-room rug. ²⁰When I finished cleaning the rug, my sister returned. ²¹I took the twenty dollars and told her that she should get someone else next time.

Questions

About Unity

- 1. Which paragraph lacks a topic sentence?

Write a topic sentence for the paragraph.

	2. Which sentence in “A Frustrating Job” should be omitted in the interest of paragraph unity? (Write the sentence number here.) _____	287
	About Support	288
	3. What is for you the best (most real and vivid) detail or image in the paragraph “Heartbreak”? _____ _____	
	What is the best detail or image in “Losing My Father”? _____ _____	
	What is the best detail or image in “A Frustrating Job”? _____ _____	
	4. Which two paragraphs include the actual words spoken by the participants? _____ _____	
	About Coherence	
	5. Do the three paragraphs use time order or emphatic order to organize details? _____	
	6. What are four transition words used in “A Frustrating Job”? _____	

Developing a Narrative Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

Gary’s instructor was helping her students think of topics for their narrative paragraphs. “A narrative is simply a story that illustrates a point,” she said. “That point is often about an emotion you felt. Looking at a list of emotions may help you think of a topic. Ask yourself what incident in your life has made you feel any of these emotions.”

The instructor then jotted these feelings on the board:

Anger	Thankfulness
Embarrassment	Loneliness
Jealousy	Sadness
Amusement	Terror
Confusion	Relief

288

289

As Gary looked over the list, he thought of several experiences in his life. “The word ‘angry’ made me think about a time when I was a kid. My brother took my skateboard without permission and left it in the park, where it got stolen. ‘Amused’ made me think of when I watched my roommate, who claimed he spoke Spanish, try to bargain with a street vendor in Mexico. He got so flustered that he ended up paying even more than the vendor had originally asked for. When I got to ‘sad,’ though, I thought about when I visited Bonnie and found out she was dating someone else. ‘Sad’ wasn’t a strong enough word, though—I was heartbroken. So I decided to write about heartbreak.”

Gary’s first step was to do some freewriting. Without worrying about spelling or grammar, he simply wrote down everything that came into his mind concerning his visit to Bonnie. Here is what he came up with:

I hadn't expected to see Bonnie until Christmas. We'd got engaged just before she went off to college. The drive to Penn State took ten hours each way and that seemed like too much driving for just a weekend visit. But I realized I had a long weekend over Thanksgiving I decided to surprise her. I think down deep I knew something was wrong. She had sounded sort of cool on the phone and she hadn't been writing as often. I guess I wanted to convince myself that everything was OK. We'd been dating since we were 16 and I couldn't imagine not being with her. When I knocked at her dorm door I remember how she was smiling when she opened the door. Her expression changed to one of surprise. Not happy surprise. I hugged her and she sort of hugged me back but like you'd hug your brother. Another girl was in the room. Bonnie said, "This is Pam," and Pam shot out of the room like I had a disease. Everything seemed wrong and confused. I started taking off my sweater and then I saw it. On a bulletin board was this photo of Bonnie with Blake, the guy she had been messing around with. They broke up about a year later, but by then I never wanted to see Bonnie again. I couldn't believe Bonnie would start seeing somebody else when we were planning to get married. It had even been her idea to get engaged. Before she left for college. Later on I realized that wasn't the first dishonest thing she'd done. I got out of there as quick as I could.

289

Development through Revising

Gary knew that the first, freewritten version of his paragraph needed work. Here are the comments he made after he reread it the following day:

"Although my point is supposed to be that my visit to Bonnie was heartbreaking, I didn't really get that across. I need to say more about how the experience felt.

"I've included some information that doesn't really support my point. For instance, what happened to Bonnie and Blake later isn't important here. Also, I think I spend too much time explaining the circumstances of the visit. I need to get more quickly to the point where I arrived at Bonnie's dorm.

"I think I should include more dialogue, too. That would make the reader feel more like a witness to what really happened."

With this self-critique in mind, Gary revised his paragraph until he had produced the version that appears on [page 285](#).

Writing a Narrative Paragraph

Writing Assignment 1

Write a paragraph about an experience in which a certain emotion was predominant. The emotion might be fear, pride, satisfaction, embarrassment, or any of these:

Frustration	Sympathy	Shyness
Love	Bitterness	Disappointment
Sadness	Violence	Happiness
Terror	Surprise	Jealousy
Shock	Nostalgia	Anger
Relief	Loss	Hate
Envy	Silliness	Nervousness

The experience you write about should be limited in time. Note that the three paragraphs presented in this chapter all detail experiences that occurred within relatively short periods. One writer describes a

heartbreaking surprise he received the day he visited his girlfriend; another describes the loss of her father; the third describes a frustrating night of baby-sitting.

A good way to bring an event to life for your readers is to include some dialogue, as the writers of two of the three paragraphs in this chapter have done. Words that you said, or that someone else said, help make a situation come alive. First, though, be sure to check the section on quotation marks on [pages 523–530](#).



Prewriting

- a. Begin by freewriting. Think of an experience or event that caused you to feel a certain emotion strongly. Then spend ten minutes writing freely about the experience. Do not worry at this point about such matters as spelling or grammar or putting things in the right order. Instead, just try to get down all the details you can think of that seem related to the experience.
- b. This preliminary writing will help you decide whether your topic is promising enough to develop further. If it is not, choose another emotion and repeat step *a*. If it does seem promising, do two things:
 - First, write your topic sentence, underlining the emotion you will focus on. For example, “My first day in kindergarten was one of the scariest days of my life.”
 - Second, make up a list of all the details involved in the experience. Then number these details according to the order in which they occurred.

	c. Referring to your list of details, write a rough draft of your paragraph. Use time signals such as <i>first, then, after, next, while, during</i>, and <i>finally</i> to help connect details as you move from the beginning to the middle to the end of your narrative. Be sure to include not only what happened but also how you felt about what was going on.	291
	Revising Put your first draft away for a day or so. When you return to it, read it over, asking yourself these questions: FOUR BASES Checklist for Narration About <i>Unity</i> - Does my topic sentence clearly state what emotion the experience made me feel? - Are there any off-topic sentences I should eliminate for the sake of paragraph unity? About <i>Support</i> - Have I included some dialogue to make the experience come alive? - Have I explained how I felt as the experience occurred? About <i>Coherence</i> - Have I used time order to narrate the experience from beginning to end? - Have I used time signals to connect one detail to the next? About <i>Sentence Skills</i> - Have I carefully proofread my paragraph, using the list on the inside back cover of the book, and corrected all sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling? - Is the first-person point of view in my paragraph consistent? - Did I use verb tenses consistently and correctly? (This is especially important when relaying a story.) Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.	292

Writing Assignment 2

Narrate a real-life event you have witnessed. Listed on the following page are some places where interesting personal interactions often happen. Think of an event that you saw happen at one of these places, or visit one of them and take notes on an incident to write about.

292
293

- The traffic court or small-claims court in your area
- The dinner table at your or someone else’s home
- A waiting line at a supermarket, unemployment office, ticket counter, movie theater, or cafeteria
- A doctor’s office
- An audience at a movie, concert, or sports event
- A classroom
- A restaurant
- A student lounge

Prewriting

- a. Decide what point you will make about the incident. What one word or phrase characterizes the scene you witnessed? Your narration of the incident will emphasize that characteristic.
- b. Write your topic sentence. The topic sentence should state where the incident happened as well as your point about it. Here are some possibilities:

I witnessed a *heartwarming* incident at Taco Bell yesterday.

Two fans at last week’s baseball game got into a *hilarious* argument.

The scene at our family dinner table Monday was one of complete *confusion*.

A *painful* dispute went on in Atlantic County small-claims court yesterday.

- c. Use the questioning technique to remind yourself of details that will make your narrative come alive. Ask yourself questions like these and write down your answers:

Whom was I observing?

How were they dressed?

What were their facial expressions like?

What tones of voice did they use?

What did I hear them say?

- d. Drawing details from the notes you have written, write the first draft of your paragraph. Remember to use time signals such as *then*, *after that*, *during*, *meanwhile*, and *finally* to connect one sentence to another.

293

Revising

294

After you have put your paragraph away for a day, read it to a friend who will give you honest feedback. You and your friend should consider these questions:



FOUR BASES Checklist for Narration

About *Unity*

- Does my topic sentence make a general point about the incident?

About *Support*

- Do descriptions of the appearance, tone of voice, and expressions of the people involved paint a clear picture of the incident?

About *Coherence*

- Is the sequence of events made clear by transitional words such as first, later, and then?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have I used a consistent point of view throughout my paragraph?
- Have I used specific rather than general words?
- Have I avoided wordiness?
- Are my sentences varied?
- Have I checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.

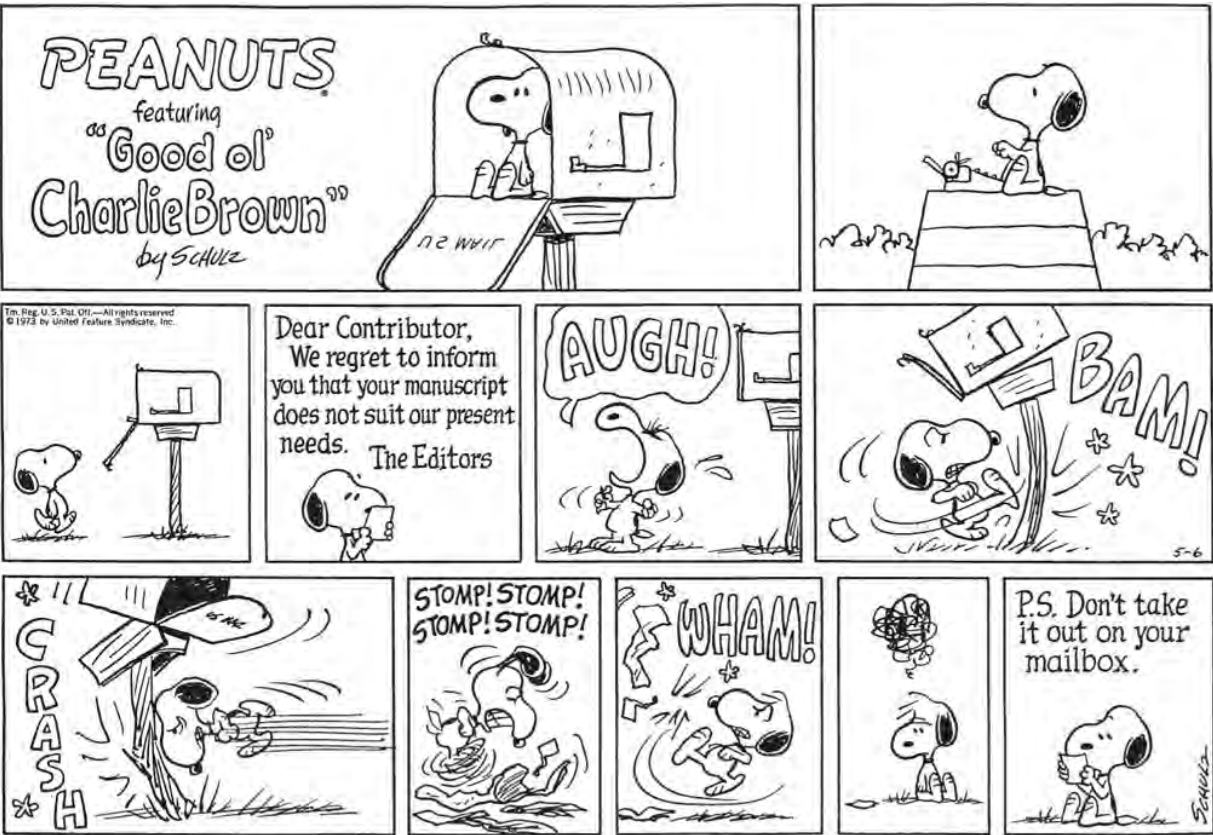
Writing Assignment 3

In a story, something happens. The *Peanuts* cartoon on the following page is a little story about the would-be writer, Snoopy, who gets a rejection letter and loses his temper. For this assignment, tell a story about something that happened to you.

Make sure that your story has a point, expressed in the first sentence of the paragraph. If necessary, tailor your narrative to fit your purpose. Use time order to organize your details (*first* this happened; *then* this; *after that*, this; *next*, this; and so on). Concentrate on providing as many specific details as possible so that the reader can really share your experience. Try to make it as vivid for the reader as it was for you when you first experienced it.

294

295



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Use one of the topics below or a topic of your own choosing. Whatever topic you choose, remember that your story must illustrate or support a point stated in the first sentence of your paper.

A time you lost your temper

- A moment of great happiness or sadness
- Your best or worst date
- A time you took a foolish risk
- An incident that changed your life
- A time when you did or did not do the right thing
- Your best or worst holiday or birthday, or some other day
- A time you learned a lesson or taught a lesson to someone else
- An occasion of triumph in sports or some other area

You may wish to refer to the suggestions for prewriting and revising in [Writing Assignments 1](#) and [2](#).

295

296

Writing Assignment 4

Write a paragraph that shows, through some experience you have had, the truth or falsity of a popular belief. You might write about any one of the following statements or some other popular saying.

- Every person has a price.
- Haste makes waste.
- Don't count your chickens before they're hatched.
- A bird in the hand is worth two in the bush.
- It isn't what you know, it's who you know.
- Borrowing can get you into trouble.
- What you don't know won't hurt you.
- A promise is easier made than kept.

You never really know people until you see them in an emergency.

If you don't help yourself, nobody will.

An ounce of prevention is worth a pound of cure.

Hope for the best but expect the worst.

Never give advice to a friend.

You get what you pay for.

A stitch in time saves nine.

A fool and his money are soon parted.

There is an exception to every rule.

Nice guys finish last.

Begin your narrative paragraph with a topic sentence that expresses your agreement or disagreement with a popular saying or belief, for example:

“Never give advice to a friend” is not always good advice, as I learned after helping a friend reunite with her boyfriend.

My sister learned recently that it is easier to make a promise than to keep one.

Remember that the purpose of your story is to support your topic sentence. Omit details that don't support your topic sentence. Also, feel free to use made-up details that will strengthen your support.

296

297

Writing Assignment 5

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this narrative paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Imagine that a younger brother or sister, or a young friend, has to make a difficult decision of some kind. Perhaps he or she must decide how to prepare for a job interview, whether or not to get help with a difficult class, or what to do about a coworker who is taking money from the cash register. Narrate a story from your own experience (or the experience of someone you know) that will teach a younger person something about the decision he or she must make. In your paragraph, include a comment or two about

the lesson your story teaches. Write about any decision young people often face, including any of those already mentioned or those listed below.

Should he or she save a little from a weekly paycheck?

Should he or she live at home or move to an apartment with some friends?

How should he or she deal with a group of friends who are involved with drugs, stealing, or both?

Refer to the suggestions for prewriting and revising in [Writing Assignments 1](#) and [2](#).

16: Argument



Do paparazzi have a right to follow a celebrity's every move, snapping photographs all along the way? Write a paragraph in which you argue for or against the outrageous tactics of the paparazzi.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to

- develop an argument paragraph
- write an argument paragraph
- revise an argument paragraph

In addition, you will read and consider

- three student argument paragraphs

298

299

Most of us know someone who enjoys a good argument. Such a person usually challenges any sweeping statement we might make. “Why do you say that?” he or she will ask. “Give your reasons.” Our questioner then listens carefully as we cite our reasons, waiting to see if we really do have solid evidence to support our point of view. In an argument such as the one going on in the cartoon, the two parties each present their supporting evidence. The goal is to determine who has the more solid evidence to support his or her point of view. A questioner may make us feel a bit nervous, but we may also appreciate the way he or she makes us think through our opinions.

The ability to advance sound, compelling arguments is an important skill in everyday life. We can use argument to get an extension on a term paper, obtain a favor from a friend, or convince an employer that we are the right person for a job. Understanding persuasion based on clear, logical reasoning can also help us see through the sometimes faulty arguments advanced by advertisers, editors, politicians, and others who try to bring us over to their side.



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In this chapter, you will be asked to argue a position and defend it with a series of solid reasons. In a general way, you are doing the same thing with all the paragraph assignments in the book: making a point and then supporting it. The difference here is that, in a more direct and formal manner, you will advance a point about which you feel strongly and seek to persuade others to agree with you.



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Paragraphs to Consider

Let's Ban Proms

¹While many students regard proms as peak events in high school life, I believe that high school proms should be banned. ²One reason is that even before the prom takes place, it causes problems. ³Teenagers are separated into “the ones who were asked” and “the ones who weren’t.” ⁴Being one of those who weren’t asked can be heartbreaking to a sensitive young person. ⁵Another pre-prom problem is money. ⁶The price of the various items needed can add up quickly to a lot of money. ⁷The prom itself can be unpleasant and frustrating, too. ⁸At the beginning of the evening, the girls enviously compare dresses while the boys sweat nervously inside their rented suits. ⁹During the dance, the couples who have gotten together only to go to the prom have split up into miserable singles. ¹⁰When the prom draws to a close, the popular teenagers drive off happily to other parties while the less popular ones head home, as usual. ¹¹Perhaps the main reason proms should be banned, however, is the drinking and driving that go on after the prom is over. ¹²Teenagers pile into their cars on their way to “after-proms” and pull out the bottles and cans stashed under the seat. ¹³By the time the big night is finally over, at 4 or 5 A.M., students are trying to weave home without encountering the police or a roadside tree. ¹⁴Some of them do not make it, and prom night turns into tragedy. ¹⁵For all these reasons, proms have no place in our schools.

299

300

Bashing Men

¹Our culture now puts down men in ways that would be considered very offensive if the targets were women. ²For instance, men are frequently portrayed in popular culture as bumbling fools. ³The popular TV show *The Simpsons*, for instance, shows the father, Homer, as a total idiot, dishonest and childish. ⁴His son, Bart, is equally foolish; but the mother, Marge, and the sister, Lisa, are levelheaded and responsible. ⁵Little children love the “*Berenstain Bears*” books, which are supposed to teach lessons about subjects including honesty, bad habits, and going to the doctor. ⁶In every book, while the mother bear gives her cubs good advice, the father bear acts stupidly and has to be taught a lesson along with the kids. ⁷In addition, society teaches us to think of men as having no value in a family other than to contribute money. ⁸Popular stars go on national TV and proclaim that because they are financially independent women, their babies don’t need a father. ⁹Families on welfare are denied benefits if the children’s father stays in the home—apparently if he isn’t bringing in money, the family is better off without him. ¹⁰The welfare system is deeply flawed in other ways as well. ¹¹And women tell each other men-bashing jokes that would be considered sexist and offensive if they were directed at women. ¹²Here’s one: “Question: A woman has a flat tire. ¹³Santa Claus, Oprah Winfrey, and a decent man all stop to help her. ¹⁴Who actually changes the tire?” ¹⁵The answer: “Oprah, of course. ¹⁶The other two are fictional characters.” ¹⁷Women deserve to be treated with respect, but that doesn’t mean men should be put down.

300

Living Alone

¹Living alone is quite an experience. ²People who live alone, for one thing, have to learn to do all kinds of tasks by themselves. ³They must learn—even if they have had no experience—to change fuses, put up curtains and shades, temporarily dam an overflowing toilet, cook a meal, and defrost a refrigerator. ⁴When there is no father, husband, mother, or wife to depend on, a person can't fall back on the excuse, "I don't know how to do that." ⁵Those who live alone also need the strength to deal with people. ⁶Alone, singles must face noisy neighbors, unresponsive landlords, dishonest repair people, and aggressive bill collectors. ⁷Because there are no buffers between themselves and the outside world, people living alone have to handle every visitor—friendly or unfriendly—alone. ⁸Finally, singles need a large dose of courage to cope with occasional panic and unavoidable loneliness. ⁹That weird thump in the night is even more terrifying when there is no one in the next bed or the next room. ¹⁰Frightening weather or unexpected bad news is doubly bad when the worry can't be shared. ¹¹Even when life is going well, little moments of sudden loneliness can send shivers through the heart. ¹²Struggling through such bad times taps into reserves of courage that people may not have known they possessed. ¹³Facing everyday tasks, confronting all types of people, and handling panic and loneliness can shape singles into brave, resourceful, and more independent people.

Questions

About Unity

1. The topic sentence in "Living Alone" is too broad. Circle the topic sentence below that states accurately what the paragraph is about.
 - a. Living alone can make one a better person.
 - b. Living alone can create feelings of loneliness.
 - c. Living alone should be avoided.
2. Which sentence in "Bashing Men" should be eliminated in the interest of paragraph unity? (*Write the sentence number here.*) _____
3. How many reasons are given to support the topic sentence in each paragraph?

	a. In “Let’s Ban Proms” _____one _____two _____three _____four b. In “Bashing Men” _____one _____two _____three _____four c. In “Living Alone” _____one _____two _____three _____four	301
	4. After which sentence in “Let’s Ban Proms” are more specific details needed? _____ About Coherence 5. Which paragraph uses a combination of time and emphatic order to organize its details? _____ 6. What are the three main transition words in “Living Alone”? _____	302

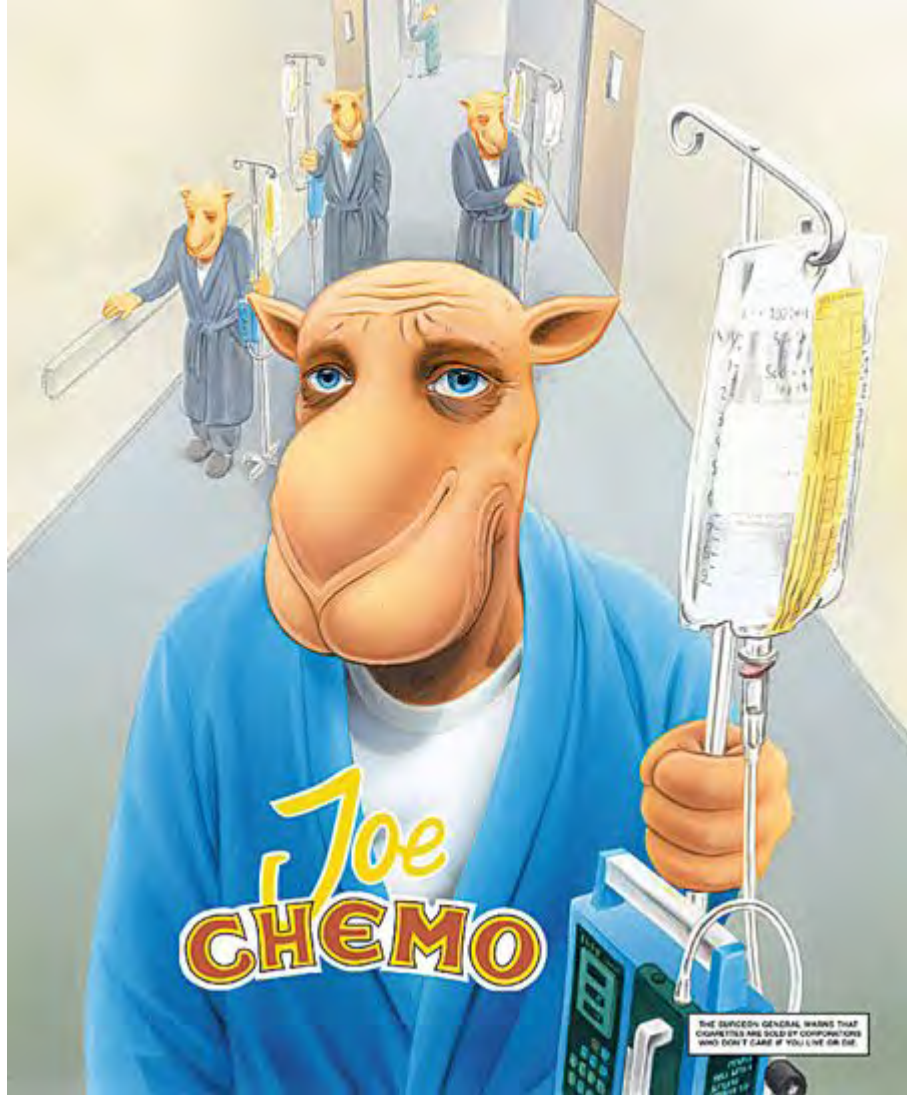
Activity 1

Complete the outline below of “Bashing Men.” Summarize in a few words the supporting material that fits under the topic sentence: After 1, 2, and 3, write in the three main points of support for the topic sentence. In the spaces after the numbers, write in the examples used to support those three main points. Two items have been done for you as examples.

Topic sentence: It’s become more and more acceptable to bash men, acting as though they are less deserving of respect than women.

1. _____
- _____
- a. _____
- _____
- b. Berenstain Bears
2. _____
- _____
- a. _____
- _____
- b. Welfare benefits cut off if father in home
3. _____

a. _____



Images can make visual arguments as well. What visual argument does this spoof-ad make? Is it effective? Why or why not?

302

303

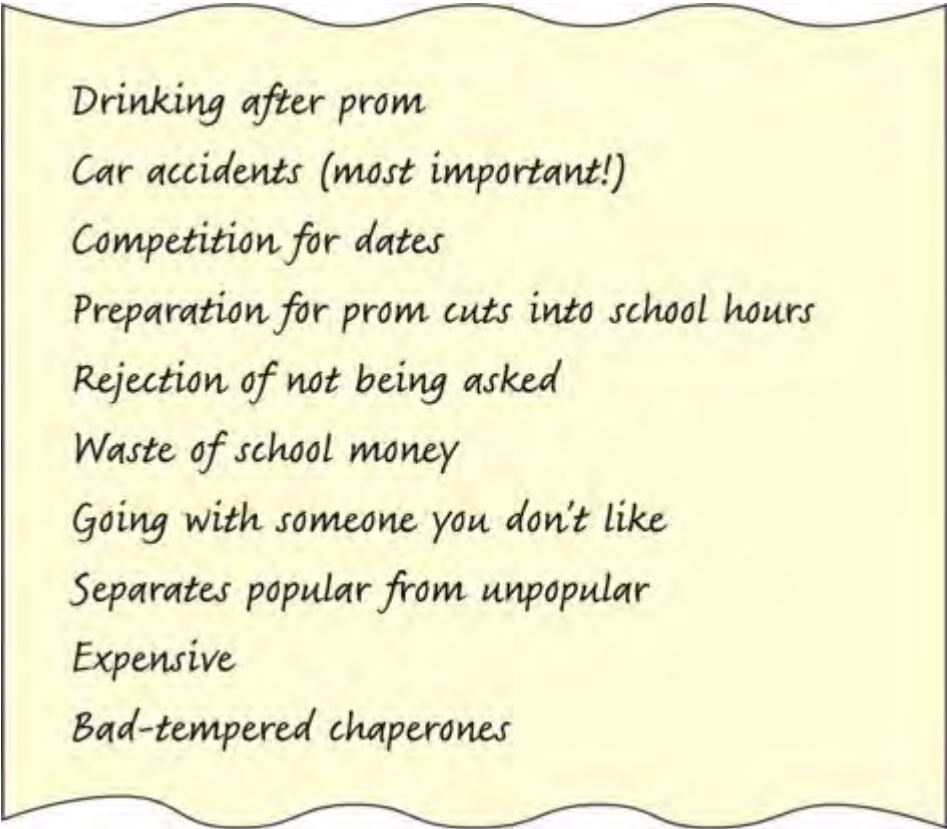
Developing an Argument Paragraph

Development through Prewriting

Yolanda is the student author of "Let's Ban Proms." She decided on her topic after visiting her parents' home one weekend and observing her younger brother's concern about his upcoming prom.

“I really felt bad for Martin as I saw what he was going through,” Yolanda said. “He’s usually a happy kid who enjoys school. But this weekend he wasn’t talking about his track meets or term papers or any of the things he’s usually chatting about. Instead he was all tied up in knots about his prom. The girl he’d really wanted to go with had already been asked, and so friends had fixed him up with a girl he barely knew who didn’t have a date either. Neither of them was excited about being together, but they felt that they just ‘had’ to go. And now he’s worried about how to afford renting a tux, and how will he get a cool car to go in, and all that stuff. It’s shaping up to be a really stressful, expensive evening. When I was in high school, I saw a lot of bad things associated with the prom, too. I hate to see young kids feeling pressured to attend an event that is fun for only a few.”

Yolanda began prewriting by making a list of all the negative aspects of proms. This is what she came up with:



Next, Yolanda numbered the details in the order she was going to present them. She also struck out details she decided not to use:



303

304

Drawing from these notes, Yolanda wrote the following first draft of her paragraph:

In my opinion, high school proms should be banned. First, they cause unhappiness by separating students into "the ones who were asked" and "the ones who weren't." Proms are also expensive, as anyone who has attended one knows. The competition for dates can damage previously strong friendships. Many couples get together only in order to have a date for the prom and do not enjoy each other's company. After the prom, too, the kids are separated into "more popular" and "less popular" groups, with the popular ones going to after-prom parties. The biggest reason to ban proms, though, is the prom-night drinking that commonly occurs. Teenagers hide liquor in their cars and then try to drive home drunk. Some of them do not make it. For all these reasons, proms should be banned.

Development through Revising

Yolanda's instructor reviewed her first draft and made these comments:

The order of your paragraph could be made stronger. Although you make good use of emphatic order (by ending with "the biggest reason to ban proms"), it's less clear that the paragraph is also organized according to time—in other words, you move from before the prom starts to during the prom to after it. Better use of transitional language will make the organization more clear.

Also, you could make the paragraph more alive by including concrete details and illustrations. Your main points would be stronger with such support.

304

305

With these comments in mind, Yolanda revised her paragraph until she produced the version that appears on [page 299](#).

Writing an Argument Paragraph

Writing Assignment 1

Develop an argument paragraph based on one of the following statements:

Condoms should (or should not) be made available in high schools.

_____ (*name a specific athlete*) is the athlete most worthy of admiration in his *or* her sport.

Television is one of the best (*or* worst) inventions of this century.

_____ make the best (*or* worst) pets.

Cigarette and alcohol advertising should (*or* should not) be banned.

Teenagers make poor parents.

_____ is one public figure today who can be considered a hero.

This college needs a better (cafeteria *or* library *or* student center *or* grading policy *or* attendance policy).



Prewriting

- a. Make up brief outlines for any three of the statements above. Make sure you have three separate and distinct reasons for each statement. Below is an example of a brief outline for a paragraph making another point.

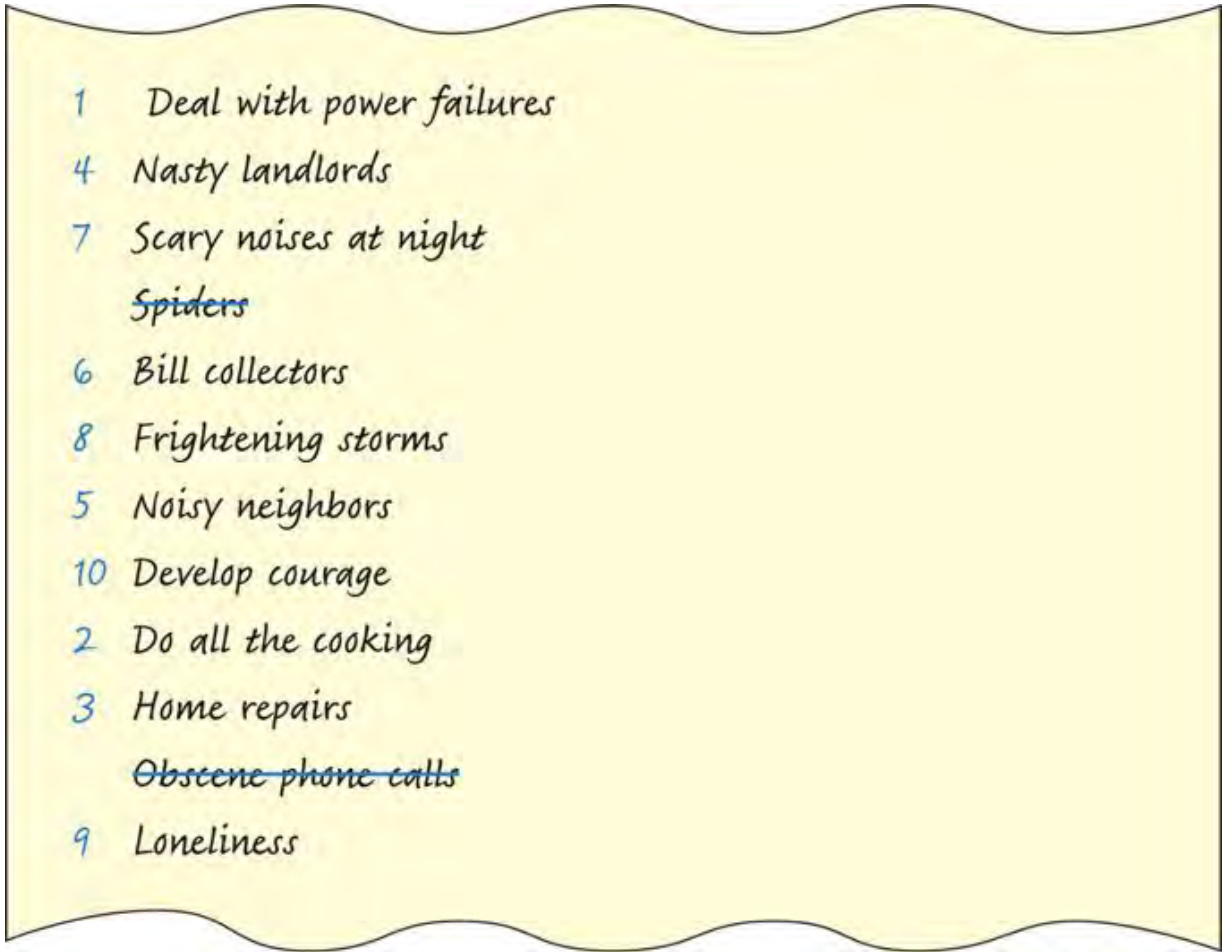
Large cities should outlaw passenger cars.

- 1. Cut down on smog and pollution*
- 2. Cut down on noise*
- 3. Make more room for pedestrians*

- b. Decide, perhaps through discussion with your instructor or classmates, which of your outlines is the most promising for development into a paragraph. Make sure your supporting points are logical by asking yourself in each case, “Does this item truly support my topic sentence?”
- c. Do some prewriting. Prepare a list of all the details you can think of that might actually support your point. Don’t limit yourself; include more details than you can actually use. Here, for example, are details generated by the writer of “Living Alone”:

<i>Deal with power failures</i>	<i>Noisy neighbors</i>
<i>Nasty landlords</i>	<i>Develop courage</i>
<i>Scary noises at night</i>	<i>Do all the cooking</i>
<i>Spiders</i>	<i>Home repairs</i>
<i>Bill collectors</i>	<i>Obscene phone calls</i>
<i>Frightening storms</i>	<i>Loneliness</i>

- d. Decide which details you will use to develop your paragraph. Number the details in the order in which you will present them. Because presenting the strongest reason last (emphatic order) is the most effective way to organize an argument paragraph, be sure to save your most powerful reason for last. Here is how the author of “Living Alone” made decisions about details:



- e. Write the first draft of your paragraph. As you write, develop each reason with specific details. For example, in “Living Alone,” notice how the writer makes the experience of living alone come alive with phrases like “That weird thump in the night” or “little moments of sudden loneliness can send shivers through the heart.”

Revising

Put your paragraph away for a day or so. Then look over the checklist that follows.

307
308

FOUR BASES Checklist for Argument

About *Unity*

- Imagine that your audience is a jury who will ultimately render a verdict on your argument. Have you presented a convincing case? If you were on the jury, would you both understand and be favorably impressed by this argument?
- Does every one of your supporting points help prove the argument stated in your topic sentence?

About *Support*

- Have you backed up your points of support with specific details?
- Have you appealed to your readers’ senses with these details?

About *Coherence*

- Have you used emphatic order in your paragraph, saving the most important, strongest detail for last?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Have you used strong verbs (rather than *is* and *to be*) throughout?
- Have you written your argument in the active, rather than passive, voice?
- Have you checked your paper for sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling? Use the checklist on the inside back cover of this book.

Continue revising your work until you can answer “yes” to all these questions.

Writing Assignment 2

Write a paragraph in which you take a stand on one of the controversial points below. Support the point with three reasons.

Students should not be required to attend high school.

All handguns should be banned.

The death penalty should exist for certain crimes.

Abortion should be legal.

Federal prisons should be coed, and prisoners should be allowed to marry.

308

The government should set up centers where sick or aged persons can go voluntarily to commit suicide.

309

Parents should never hit their children.

Prostitution should be legalized.

Prewriting

- a. As a useful exercise to help you begin developing your argument, your instructor might give class members a chance to “stand up” for what they believe in. One side of the front of the room should be designated *strong agreement* and the other side *strong disagreement*, with an imaginary line representing varying degrees of agreement or disagreement in between. The instructor will read one value statement at a time from the list above, and students will move to the appropriate spot, depending on their degree of agreement or disagreement. Some time will be allowed for students, first, to discuss with those near them the reasons they are standing where they are; and, second, to state to those at the other end of the scale the reasons for their position.
- b. Begin your paragraph by writing a sentence that expresses your attitude toward one of the value statements above, for example, “I feel that prostitution should be legalized.”
- c. Outline the reason or reasons you hold the opinion that you do. Your support may be based on your own experience, the experience of someone you know, or logic. For example, an outline of a paragraph based on one student’s logic looked like this:

I feel that prostitution should be legalized for the following reasons:

- 1. Prostitutes would then have to pay their fair share of income tax.*
- 2. Government health centers would administer regular checkups. This would help prevent the spread of AIDS and venereal disease.*
- 3. Prostitutes would be able to work openly and independently and would not be controlled by pimps and gangsters.*
- 4. Most of all, prostitutes would be less looked down on—an attitude that is psychologically damaging to those who may already have emotional problems.*

- d. Write a first draft of your paragraph, providing specific details to back up each point in your outline.

Revising

309

310

Put your paragraph away for at least a day. Ask a friend whose judgment you trust to read and critique it. Your friend should consider each of these questions:



FOUR BASES Checklist for Argument

About *Unity*

- Does the topic sentence clearly state the writer’s opinion on a controversial subject?

About *Support*

- Does the paragraph include at least three separate and distinct reasons that support the author’s argument?
- Is each of the three reasons backed up by specific, relevant evidence?

About *Coherence*

- Has the author saved the most powerful reason for last?

About *Sentence Skills*

- Has the author used a consistent point of view throughout the paragraph?
- Has the author used specific rather than general words?
- Has the author avoided wordiness?
- Has the author checked for spelling and other sentence skills, as listed on the inside back cover of the book?

Continue revising your work until you and your reader can answer “yes” to all these questions.

310

311

Writing Assignment 3

Where do you think it is best to bring up children—in the country, the suburbs, or the city? Write a paragraph in which you argue that one of those three environments is best for families with young children. Your argument should cover two types of reasons: (1) the advantages of living in the environment you’ve chosen and (2) the disadvantages of living in the other places. Use the following, or something much like it, for your topic sentence:

For families with young children, (*the country, a suburb, or the city*) _____ is the best place to live.

For each reason you advance, include at least one persuasive example. For instance, if you argue that the cultural life in the city is one important reason to live there, you should explain in detail just how going to a science museum is interesting and helpful to children. After deciding on your points of support, arrange them in a brief outline, saving your strongest point for last. In your paragraph, introduce each of your reasons with an addition transition, such as *first of all*, *another*, *also*, and *finally*.

Writing Assignment 4

Write a paper in which you use research findings to help support one of the following points:

Cigarettes should be illegal.

Mandatory retirement ages should be abolished.

Any person convicted of drunken driving should be required to spend time in jail.

Drivers should not be permitted to use cell phones.

Everyone should own a pet.

High schools should (or should not) pass out birth-control devices and information to students.

Homosexuals should (or should not) be allowed in the armed forces.

Schools should be open all year round.

Advertising should not be permitted on young children's TV shows.

[Chapter 19](#), "Using the Library and the Internet" ([pages 357–373](#)), will show you how to use keywords and search engines to think about your topic and do research. See if you can organize your paper in the form of three separate and distinct reasons that support the topic. Put these reasons into a scratch outline and use it as a guide in writing your paragraph.

Writing Assignment 5

Writing for a Specific Purpose and Audience

In this argument paragraph, you will write with a specific purpose and for a specific audience. Imagine that you have finally met Mr. or Ms. Right—but your parents don't approve of him or her. Specifically, they are against your doing one of the following:

Continuing to see this person

Seriously dating this person and no one else

Moving in together

Getting married at the end of the school year

Write a letter to your parents explaining in detail why you have made your choice. Do your best to convince them that it is a good choice.

17: Additional Paragraph Assignments

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We no longer live in a traditional marriage culture. Living together, commuter marriages, visiting marriages, polyamorous marriages, childless marriages, singlehood, bearing children out of wedlock, registered domestic partners, divorce, remarriage, step families: In short, we can no longer expect most people to spend most of their lives in one traditional style marriage. But are we happy? [Read more »](#)

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This chapter will provide

- additional writing assignments especially suited for practice at the beginning of the course
- additional writing assignments for measuring progress at the end of the course
- fifteen additional writing assignments in all

313

314

This chapter contains a variety of paragraph writing assignments. The earlier assignments are especially suited for writing practice at the beginning of a course; the later ones can be used to measure progress at the end of the course. In general, more detailed instructions are provided with the earlier assignments; fewer guidelines appear for the later ones, so that writers must make more individual decisions about exactly how to proceed. In short, the section provides a wide range of writing assignments. Many choices are possible, depending on the needs and interests of students and the purposes of the instructor.

Writing Assignment 1

Your instructor may pass out slips of paper and ask you to write, in the middle of the slip, your name; in the top left-hand corner, the best or worst job (or chore) you have ever had; in the top right-hand corner, the best or worst instructor you have ever had; in the lower left-hand corner, the best or worst place you have ever eaten in; in the lower right-hand corner, the best or worst thing that has happened to you in the past week. The instructor may also participate by writing on the board. Here is one student's paper.



Baby-sitting for my sister *B. O. Sullivan*
(tenth-grade history teacher)

Gail Battaglia

Fourth Street Diner *Trying to register*

You should then get together with any person in the room whom you do not know, exchange papers, and talk for a bit about what you wrote. Then the two of you should join another pair, with members of the resulting group of four doing two things:

- Mastering the first names of all the members of the group, so that, if asked, they could introduce the instructor to everyone in the group.

Giving a “mini” speech to the group in which they talk with <i>as much specific detail as possible</i> about any one of the four responses on their slips of paper. During or after this speech, other members of the group should ask questions to get as full a sense as possible of why the experience described was “best” or “worst.”	314
Finally, you should write a paragraph about any one of the best or worst experiences. The main purpose in writing this paragraph is to provide plenty of specific details that <i>show clearly</i> why your choice was “best” or “worst.” The paragraph on page 8 is an example of one students response to this assignment.	315

Writing Assignment 2

Interview someone in the class. Take notes as you ask the person a series of questions.

How to Proceed



a. Begin by asking a series of factual questions about the person. You might ask such questions as

- Where is the person from? Where does he or she live now?
- Does the person have brothers or sisters? Does the person live with other people, or alone?
- What kinds of jobs (if any) has the person had? Where does he or she work now?
- What are the person’s school or career plans? What courses is he or she taking?
- What are the person’s favorite leisure activities?

Work at getting specific details rather than general ones. You do not want your introduction to include lines such as “Regina graduated from high school and worked for a year.” You want to state specific places and dates: “Regina graduated from DeWitt Clinton High School in the Bronx in 2008. Within a week of graduation, she had gotten a job as a secretary for a branch of the Allstate Insurance Company located in Queens.” Or if you are writing about a person’s favorite activities, you do not want to simply say, “Regina enjoys watching TV in her few spare hours.” Instead, go on and add details such as “Her favorite shows are *60 Minutes*, *The Colbert Report*, and *C.S.I.*”

b. Then ask a series of questions about the person’s attitudes and thoughts on various matters. You might ask the person’s feeling about his or her

- Writing ability
- Parents

	Boss (if any)	315
	Courses	316
	Past schooling	
	Strengths and talents	
	Areas for self-improvement	
	You might also ask what things make the person angry or sad or happy, and why.	
	c. After collecting all this information, use it in two paragraphs. Begin your introduction to the person with a line like “This is a short introduction to _____. Here is some factual information about him (her).” Then begin your second paragraph with the line “Now let’s take a brief look at some of _____’s attitudes and beliefs.”	

Writing Assignment 3

Keep a journal for one week, or for whatever time period your instructor indicates. At some point during each day—perhaps right before going to bed—write for fifteen minutes or more about some of the specific happenings, thoughts, and feelings of your day. You do not have to prepare what to write or be in the mood or worry about making mistakes; just write down whatever words come out. As a minimum, you should complete at least one page in each writing session.

Keeping a journal will help you develop the habits of thinking on paper and writing in terms of specific details. Also, the journal can serve as a sourcebook of ideas for possible papers.

A sample journal entry was given on [page 15](#) in [Chapter 1](#). It includes general ideas that the writer might develop into paragraphs; for example:

Working at a department store means that you have to deal with some irritating customers.

Certain preparations are advisable before you quit a job.

See if you can construct another general point from this journal entry that might be the basis for a detailed and interesting paragraph. Write the point in the space below.

316

Writing Assignment 4

Make up and write a *realistic* dialogue between two or more people. Don’t have your characters talk like cardboard figures; have them talk the way people would in real life. Also, make sure their voices are consistent. (Do not have them suddenly talk out of character.)

317

The dialogue should deal with a lifelike situation. It may, for example, be a discussion or argument of some kind between two friends or acquaintances, a husband and wife, a parent and child, a brother and sister, a boyfriend and girlfriend, a clerk and customer, or other people. The conversation may or may not lead to a decision or action of some kind.

When writing dialogue, enclose your characters' exact words within quotation marks. (You should first review the material on quotation marks on [pages 523–530](#).) Begin a new paragraph to mark each change in speaker. Also, include brief descriptions of whether your characters smile, sit down or stand up, or make other facial gestures or movements during the conversation. And be sure to include a title for your dialogue. The example that follows can serve as a guide.

A Supermarket Conversation

The supermarket checker rang up the total and said to the young woman in line, "That'll be \$43.61."

The young woman fumbled with her pocketbook and then said in an embarrassed voice, "I don't think I have more than \$40. How much did you say it was again?"

"It's \$43.61," the checker said in a sharp, impatient tone.

As the young woman searched her pocketbook for the dollars she needed, the checker said loudly, "If you don't have enough money, you'll have to put something back."

A middle-aged man behind the young woman spoke up. "Look, Ma'am, I'll lend you a couple of dollars."

"No, I couldn't do that," said the young woman. "If . . . I don't think I need those sodas," she said hesitantly.

"Look, lady, make up your mind. You're holding up the line," the checker snapped.

The man turned to the checker and said coldly, "Why don't you try being a little more courteous to people? If we weren't here buying things, you'd be out of a job."

317

318

Writing Assignment 5

Make up a list of things that bother you in everyday life. One student's list of "pet peeves" included the following items:

*Drivers who suddenly slow down to turn without having signaled
The cold floor in my bathroom on a winter morning
Not having cable television to watch football and basketball games
The small napkin holder in my parents' home that is always running
out of napkins
Not being able to fall asleep at night when I know I have to get up at
6:30 the next morning*

Suggestions on How to Proceed

- Brainstorm a list of everyday annoyances by asking yourself questions: “What annoys me at home (or about my kitchen, bathroom, closets, and so on)?” “What annoys me about getting to school?” “What annoys me at school or work?” “What annoys me while I am driving or shopping?” You will probably be able to think of other questions.
- Decide which annoyances seem most promising to develop. Which are the most interesting or important? Which can be developed with specific, vivid details? Cross out the items you will not use. Next, number the annoyances you have listed in the order in which you will present them. You may want to group related items together (all those that are connected with shopping, for instance). Be sure to end with the item that annoys you the most.
- Now write a rough draft of the paragraph. Begin with a topic sentence that makes clear what your paragraph is about. Concentrate on providing plenty of details about each of the annoyances you are describing.
- In a second or third draft, add signal words (such as *one*, *also*, *another*, and *last*) to set off each annoyance.
- Use the checklist on the inside back cover to edit your paper for sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling.

318

319

Writing Assignment 6

Getting comfortable is a quiet pleasure in life that we all share. Write a paper about the special way you make yourself comfortable, providing plenty of specific details so that the reader can really see and understand your method. Use transition words such as *first*, *next*, *then*, *in addition*, *also*, *finally*, and so on to guide readers through your paper. Transitions act like signposts on an unfamiliar route—they prevent your readers from getting lost.

A student paragraph on getting comfortable (“How I Relax”) is on [page 84](#).

Writing Assignment 7

Write in detail about a person who provided help at an important time in your life. State in the first sentence who the person is and the person’s relationship to you (friend, father, cousin, etc.). For example, “My grandmother gave me a lot of direction during the difficult time when my parents were getting divorced.” Then show through specific examples (the person’s words and actions) why he or she was so special for you.

Writing Assignment 8

Describe a favorite childhood place that made you feel secure, safe, private, or in a world of your own. Here are some possibilities:

A closet

Under a piece of furniture

A grandparent’s room

A basement or attic

The woods

A shed or barn

A tree

A bunk bed

Begin with a topic sentence something like this: “_____ was a place that made me feel _____ when I was a child.” Keep the point of your topic sentence in mind as you describe this place. Include only details that will support the idea that your place was one of security, safety, privacy, or the like.



Writing Assignment 9

Write a paragraph providing examples of one quality or habit that helps make you unique. One student's response to this assignment follows:

Floor-Cleaning Freak

The one habit that makes me unique is that I am a floor-cleaning freak. I use my Dustbuster to snap up crumbs seconds after they fall. When a rubber heel mark appears on my vinyl floor, I run for the steel wool. As I work in my kitchen preparing meals, I constantly scan the tiles, looking for spots where some liquid has been spilled or for a crumb that has somehow miraculously escaped my vision. After I scrub and wax my floors, I stand to one side of the room and try to catch the light in such a way as to reveal spots that have gone unwaxed. As I travel from one room to the other, my experienced eye is faithfully searching for lint that may have invaded my domain since my last passing. If I discover an offender, I discreetly tuck it into my pocket. The amount of lint I have gathered in the course of the day is the ultimate test of how diligently I am performing my task. I give my vacuum cleaner quite a workout, and I spend an excessive amount on replacement bags. My expenses for floor-cleaners and wax are alarmingly high, but somehow this does not stop me. Where my floors are concerned, money is not a consideration!

Writing Assignment 10

Write about techniques you use to make it through a day of school or work. These may include

Caffeine

A system of rewards

Humor

Food

Fantasizing



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You might organize the paragraph by using time order. Show how you turn to your supports at various times during the day in order to cope with fatigue or boredom. For example, in the morning you might use coffee (with its dose of caffeine) to get started. Later in the day, you might go on to use other supports, such as a Red Bull.

320

Writing Assignment 11

Imagine that all the televisions in the United States go blank, starting tonight. What would you and your family or friends do on a typical night without television? You may want to write about

321

What each individual would be doing

What you could do together

Problems the lack of TV would cause

Benefits of quality time without TV

Choose any of these approaches, or some other single approach, in writing about your life without TV.

Writing Assignment 12

Write a paper on one of the following topics. Begin with a clear, direct sentence that states exactly what your paper will be about. For example, if you choose the first topic, your opening sentence might be, “There were several delightful childhood games I played that occupied many of my summer days.” An opening sentence for the second topic might be, “The work I had to do to secure my high school diploma is one of the special accomplishments of my life.” Be sure to follow your opening sentence with plenty of specific supporting details that develop your topic.

- A way you had fun as a child
- A special accomplishment
- A favorite holiday and why it is your favorite
- Some problems a family member or friend is having
- A superstition or fear
- A disagreement you have had with someone
- A debt you have repaid or have yet to repay
- The sickest you’ve ever been
- How your parents (or you and a special person in your life) met
- Your father’s or mother’s attitude toward you

Writing Assignment 13

Write a paper on one of the following topics. Follow the instructions given for Assignment 12.

- A wish or dream you have or had
- Everyday pleasures
- Ways you were punished by your parents as a child
- Ways you were rewarded by your parents as a child
- A difficult moment in your life
- An experience you or someone you know has had with drugs
- Your weaknesses as a student
- Your strengths as a student

321
322

A time a prayer or wish was answered

Something you would like to change

Writing Assignment 14

Write a paper on one of the following topics:

- | | | |
|-------------|----------------|----------------|
| Crime | Music | Books |
| Lies | Exercise | Transportation |
| Television | Debt | Exhaustion |
| Plants | Parking meters | Cell phones |
| Comic books | Hunger | Drugs |

Suggestions on How to Proceed

- a. You might begin by writing several statements about your general topic. For example, suppose that you choose to do a paper on the subject “Neighborhood.” Here are some statements you might write:

My neighborhood is fairly rural.

The neighborhood where I grew up was unique.

Many city neighborhoods have problems with crime.

My new neighborhood has no playgrounds for children.

Everyone in my neighborhood seems to mow the lawn almost daily.

My neighborhood became a community when it was faced with a hurricane last summer.

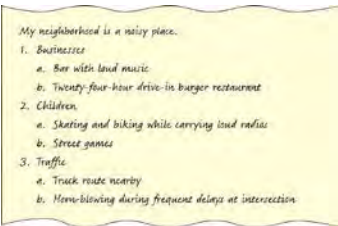
My neighborhood is a noisy place.

- b. Choose (or revise) one of the statements that you could go on to develop in a paragraph. You should not select a narrow statement like “My new neighborhood has no playgrounds for children,” for it is a simple factual sentence needing no support. Nor should you begin with a point such as “Many city neighborhoods have problems with crime,” which is too broad for you to develop adequately in a single paragraph. (See also the information on topic sentences on [pages 65–70](#).)

322

- c. After you have chosen a promising sentence, make a scratch outline of supporting details that will develop the point of that sentence. For example, one student provided the following outline:

323



- d. While writing your paper, use the checklist on the inside back cover to make sure you can answer “yes” to the questions about unity, support, and coherence. Also, refer to the checklist when you edit the next-to-final draft of your paper for sentence-skills mistakes, including spelling.

Writing Assignment 15

Write a paper on one of the topics below. Follow the instructions given for Assignment 14.

You Tube	Tryouts	Illness
Babies	Facebook	Success
Vacation	Hospital	Failure
Red tape	Parties	Wisdom teeth
Dependability	Criticism	Home

PART 3: Essay Development



Write two to three paragraphs about your plans after graduating college.

[18: Writing the Essay](#)

18: Writing the Essay



Global videoconferencing is just one form of technology that has changed the way people communicate. Write two or more paragraphs about a technology you use frequently that has changed the way you communicate with others.

This chapter will explain and illustrate

- the differences between a paragraph and an essay

This chapter will also show how to

- begin an essay
- tie its supporting paragraphs together
- conclude an essay
- plan an essay

What Is an Essay?

Differences between an Essay and a Paragraph



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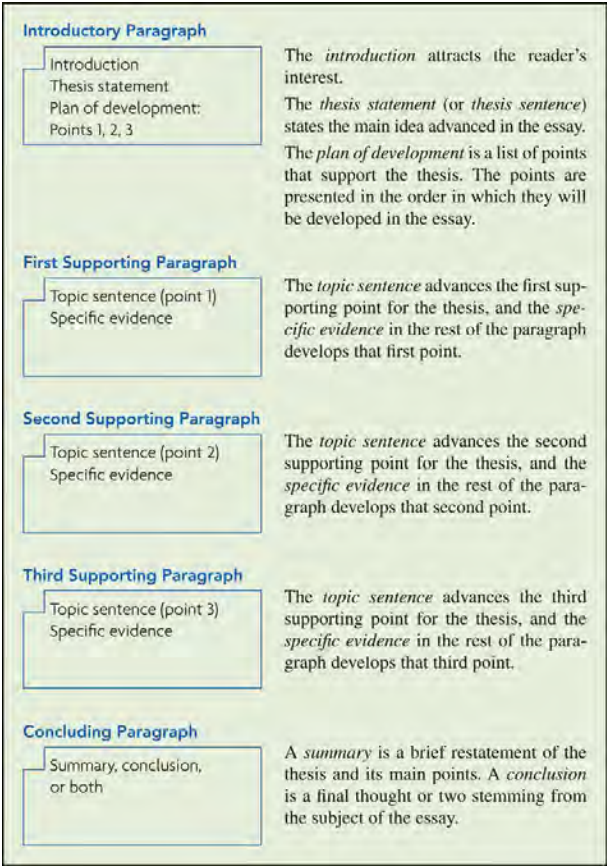
An essay is simply a paper of several paragraphs, rather than one paragraph, that supports a single point. In an essay, subjects can and should be treated more fully than they would be in a single-paragraph paper.

The main idea or point developed in an essay is called the *thesis statement* or *thesis sentence* (rather than, as in a paragraph, the *topic sentence*). The thesis statement appears in the introductory paragraph, and it is then developed in the supporting paragraphs that follow. A short concluding paragraph closes the essay.

The Form of an Essay

The diagram on the following page shows the form of an essay. You can refer to this as a guide while writing your own essays.

In some situations, you may need to include additional supporting paragraphs, but for this chapter’s purposes, we will be focusing on papers with three supporting paragraphs.



A Model Essay

Gene, the writer of the paragraph on working in an apple plant (page 8), later decided to develop his subject more fully. Here is the essay that resulted.

My Job in an Apple Plant

¹In the course of working my way through school, I have taken many jobs I would rather forget. ²I have spent nine hours a day lifting heavy automobile and truck batteries off the end of an assembly belt. ³I have risked the loss of eyes and fingers working a punch press in a textile factory. ⁴I have served as a ward aide in a mental hospital, helping care for brain-damaged men who would break into violent fits at unexpected moments. ⁵But none of these jobs was as dreadful as my job in an apple plant. ⁶The work was physically hard; the pay was poor; and, most of all, the working conditions were dismal.

Introductory paragraph

⁷First, the job made enormous demands on my strength and energy. ⁸For ten hours a night, I took cartons that rolled down a metal track and stacked them onto wooden skids in a tractor trailer. ⁹Each carton contained twelve heavy bottles of apple juice. ¹⁰A carton shot down the track about every fifteen seconds. ¹¹I once figured out that I was lifting an average of twelve tons of apple juice every night. ¹²When a truck was almost filled, I or my partner had to drag fourteen bulky wooden skids into the empty trailer nearby and then set up added sections of the heavy metal track so that we could start routing cartons to the back of the empty van. ¹³While one of us did that, the other performed the stacking work of two men.

First supporting paragraph

¹⁴I would not have minded the difficulty of the work so much if the pay had not been so poor. ¹⁵I was paid the minimum wage at that time, \$4.65 an hour, plus just a quarter extra for working the night shift. ¹⁶Because of the low salary, I felt compelled to get as much overtime pay as possible. ¹⁷Everything over eight hours a night was time-and-a-half, so I typically worked twelve hours a night. ¹⁸On Friday I would sometimes work straight through until Saturday at noon—eighteen hours. ¹⁹I averaged over sixty hours a week but did not take home much more than \$220.

Second supporting paragraph

²⁰But even more than the low pay, what upset me about my apple plant job was the working conditions. ²¹Our humorless supervisor cared only about his production record for each night and tried to keep the assembly line moving at breakneck pace. ²²During work I was limited to two ten-minute breaks and an unpaid half hour for lunch. ²³Most of my time was spent outside on the truck loading dock in near-zero-degree temperatures. ²⁴The steel floors of the trucks were like ice; the quickly penetrating cold made my feet feel like stone. ²⁵I had no shared interests with the man I loaded cartons with, and so I had to work without companionship on the job. ²⁶And after the production line shut down and most people left, I had to spend two hours alone scrubbing clean the apple vats, which were coated with a sticky residue.

Third supporting paragraph

²⁷I stayed on the job for five months, all the while hating the difficulty of the work, the poor money, and the conditions under which I worked. ²⁸By the time I quit, I was determined never to do such degrading work again.

Concluding paragraph

Important Points about the Essay

Introductory Paragraph

An introductory paragraph has certain purposes or functions and can be constructed using various methods.

Purposes of the Introduction

An introductory paragraph should do three things:

- 1. Attract the reader’s *interest*. Using one of the suggested methods of introduction described below can help draw the reader into your essay.
- 2. Present a *thesis sentence*—a clear, direct statement of the central idea that you will develop in your essay. The thesis statement, like a topic sentence, should have a keyword or keywords reflecting your attitude about the subject. For example, in the essay on the apple plant job, the keyword is *dreadful*.
- 3. Indicate a *plan of development*—a preview of the major points that will support your thesis statement, listed in the order in which they will be presented. In some cases, the thesis statement and plan of development may appear in the same sentence. In some cases, also, the plan of development may be omitted.

Activity 1

- 1. In “My Job in an Apple Plant,” which sentences are used to attract the reader’s interest?
_____ sentences 1 to 3 _____ 1 to 4 _____ 1 to 5
- 2. The thesis in “My Job in an Apple Plant” is presented in
_____ sentence 4 _____ sentence 5 _____ sentence 6
- 3. Is the thesis followed by a plan of development?
_____ Yes _____ No

330

- 4. Which words in the plan of development announce the three major supporting points in the essay? Write them below.
 - a. _____
 - b. _____
 - c. _____

331

Common Methods of Introduction

Here are some common methods of introduction. Use any one method, or a combination of methods, to introduce your subject in an interesting way.

- 1. **Broad statement.** Begin with a broad, general statement of your topic and narrow it down to your thesis statement. Broad, general statements ease the reader into your thesis statement by providing a background for it. In “My Job in an Apple Plant,” Gene writes generally on the topic of his worst jobs and then narrows down to a specific worst job.
- 2. **Contrast.** Start with an idea or situation that is the opposite of the one you will develop. This approach works because your readers will be surprised, and then intrigued, by the contrast between the opening idea and the thesis that follows it. Here is an example of a “contrast” introduction by a student writer:

When I was a girl, I never argued with my parents about differences between their attitudes and mine. My father would deliver his judgment on an issue, and that was usually the end of the matter. Discussion seldom changed his mind, and disagreement was not tolerated. But the situation is different with today’s parents and children. My husband and I have to contend with radical differences between what our children think about a given situation and what we think about it. We have had disagreements with all three of our daughters, Stephanie, Diana, and Giselle.

- 3. **Relevance.** Explain the importance of your topic. If you can convince your readers that the subject applies to them in some way, or is something they should know more about, they will want to continue reading. The introductory paragraph of “Sports-Crazy America” ([page 335](#)) provides an example of a “relevance” introduction.
- 4. **Anecdote.** Use an incident or brief story. Stories are naturally interesting. They appeal to a reader’s curiosity. In your introduction, an anecdote will grab the reader’s attention right away. The story should be brief and should be related to your central idea. The incident in the story can be something that happened to you, something that you may have heard about, or something that you have read about in a newspaper or magazine. Here is an example of a paragraph that begins with a story:

The husky man pushes open the door of the bedroom and grins as he pulls out a .38 revolver. An elderly man wearing thin pajamas looks at him and whimpers. In a feeble effort at escape, the old man slides out of his bed and moves to the door of the room. The husky man, still grinning, blocks his way. With the face of a small, frightened animal, the old man looks up and whispers, “Oh, God, please don’t hurt me.” The grinning man then fires four times. The television movie cuts now to a soap commercial, but the little boy who has been watching the set has begun to cry. Such scenes of direct violence on television must surely be harmful to children for a number of psychological reasons.

331
332

5. **Questions.** Ask your readers one or more questions. These questions catch the readers’ interest and make them want to read on. Here is an example of a paragraph that begins with questions:

What would happen if we were totally honest with ourselves? Would we be able to stand the pain of giving up self-deception? Would the complete truth be too much for us to bear? Such questions will probably never be answered, for in everyday life we protect ourselves from the onslaught of too much reality. All of us cultivate defense mechanisms that prevent us from seeing, hearing, or feeling too much. Included among such defense mechanisms are rationalization, reaction formation, and substitution.

Note, however, that the thesis itself must not be a question.

6. **Quotation.** A quotation can be something you have read in a book or an article. It can also be something that you have heard: a popular saying or proverb (“Never give advice to a friend”); a current or recent advertising slogan (“Just do it”); a favorite expression used by your friends or family (“My father always says . . .”). Using a quotation in your introductory paragraph lets you add someone else’s voice to your own. Here is an example of a paragraph that begins with a quotation:

“Evil,” wrote Martin Buber, “is lack of direction.” In my school days as a fatherless boy, with a mother too confused by her own life to really care for me, I strayed down a number of dangerous paths. Before my eighteenth birthday, I had been a car thief, a burglar, and a drug dealer.

332

333

Supporting Paragraphs

Most essays have three supporting points, developed in three separate paragraphs. (Some essays will have two supporting points; others, four or more.) Each of the supporting paragraphs should begin with a topic sentence that states the point to be detailed in that paragraph. Just as the thesis provides a focus for the entire essay, the topic sentence provides a focus for each supporting paragraph.

Activity 2

- 1. What is the topic sentence for the first supporting paragraph of “My Job in an Apple Plant”?
(Write the sentence number here.) _____
- 2. What is the topic sentence for the second supporting paragraph? _____
- 3. What is the topic sentence for the third supporting paragraph? _____

Transitional Sentences

In paragraphs, transitions and other connective devices ([pages 86–95](#)) are used to help link sentences. Similarly, in an essay *transitional sentences* are used to help tie the supporting paragraphs together. Such transitional sentences usually occur near the end of one paragraph or the beginning of the next.

In “My Job in an Apple Plant,” the first transitional sentence is

I would not have minded the difficulty of the work so much if the pay had not been so poor.

In this sentence, the keyword *difficulty* reminds us of the point of the first supporting paragraph, while *pay* tells us the point to be developed in the second supporting paragraph.

333

334

Activity 3

Here is the other transitional sentence in “My Job in an Apple Plant”:

But even more than the low pay, what upset me about my apple plant job was the working conditions.

Complete the following statement: In the sentence above, the keywords _____echo the point of the second supporting paragraph, and the keywords _____announce the topic of the third supporting paragraph.

Concluding Paragraph

The concluding paragraph often summarizes the essay by briefly restating the thesis and, at times, the main supporting points. Also, the conclusion brings the paper to a natural and graceful end, sometimes leaving the reader with a final thought on the subject.

Activity 4

- 1. Which sentence in the concluding paragraph of “My Job in an Apple Plant” restates the thesis and supporting points of the essay? _____
- 2. Which sentence contains the concluding thought of the essay? _____

Essays to Consider

Read the three student essays below and then answer the questions that follow.



www.mhhe.com/langan

Giving Up a Baby

¹As I awoke, I overheard a nurse say, "It's a lovely baby boy." ²How could a mother give him up?" ³"Be quiet," another voice said. ⁴"She's going to wake up soon." ⁵Then I heard the baby cry, but I never heard him again. ⁶Three years ago, I gave up my child to two strangers, people who wanted a baby but could not have one. ⁷I was in pain over my decision, and I can still hear the voices of people who said I was selfish or crazy. ⁸But the reasons I gave up my child were important ones, at least to me.

⁹I gave up my baby, first of all, because I was very young. ¹⁰I was only seventeen, and I was unmarried. ¹¹Because I was so young, I did not yet feel the desire to have and raise a baby. ¹²I knew that I would be a child raising a child and that, when I had to stay home to care for the baby, I would resent the loss of my freedom. ¹³I might also blame the baby for that loss. ¹⁴In addition, I had not had the experiences in life that would make me a responsible, giving parent. ¹⁵What could I teach my child, when I barely knew what life was all about myself?

¹⁶Besides my age, another factor in my decision was the problems my parents would have. ¹⁷I had dropped out of high school before graduation, and I did not have a job or even the chance of a job, at least for a while. ¹⁸My parents would have to support my child and me, possibly for years. ¹⁹My mom and dad had already struggled to raise their family and were not well off financially. ²⁰I knew I could not burden them with an unemployed teenager and her baby. ²¹Even if I eventually got a job, my parents would have to help raise my child. ²²They would have to be full-time babysitters while I tried to make a life of my own. ²³Because my parents are good people, they would have done all this for me. ²⁴But I felt I could not ask for such a big sacrifice from them.

²⁵The most important factor in my decision was, I suppose, a selfish one. ²⁶I was worried about my own future. ²⁷I didn't want to marry the baby's father. ²⁸I realized during the time I was pregnant that we didn't love each other. ²⁹My future as an unmarried mother with no education or skills would certainly have been limited. ³⁰I would be struggling to survive, and I would have to give up for years my dreams of getting a job and my own car and apartment. ³¹It is hard to admit, but I also considered the fact that, with a baby, I would not have the social life most young people have. ³²I would not be able to stay out late, go to parties, or feel carefree and irresponsible, for I would always have an enormous responsibility waiting for me at home. ³³With a baby, the future looked limited and insecure.

³⁴In summary, thinking about my age, my responsibility to my parents, and my own future made me decide to give up my baby. ³⁵As I look back today at my decision, I know that it was the right one for me at the time.

Sports-Crazy America

¹Almost all Americans are involved with sports in some way. ²They may play basketball or volleyball or go swimming or skiing. ³They may watch football or basketball games on the high school, college, or professional level. ⁴Sports may seem like an innocent pleasure, but it is important to look under the surface. ⁵In reality, sports have reached a point where they play too large a part in daily life. ⁶They take up too much media time, play too large a role in the raising of children, and give too much power and prestige to athletes.

⁷The overemphasis on sports can be seen most obviously in the vast media coverage of athletic events. ⁸It seems as if every bowl game play-off, tournament, trial, bout, race, meet, or match is shown on one television channel or another. ⁹On Saturday and Sunday, a check of TV Guide will show countless sports programs on network television alone, and countless more on cable stations. ¹⁰In addition, sports make up about 30 percent of local news at six and eleven o'clock, and network world news shows often devote several minutes to major American sports events. ¹¹Radio offers a full roster of games and a wide assortment of sports talk shows. ¹²Furthermore, many daily newspapers such as USA Today are devoting more and more space to sports coverage, often in an attempt to improve circulation. ¹³The newspaper with the biggest sports section is the one people will buy.

¹⁴The way we raise and educate our children also illustrates our sports mania. ¹⁵As early as age six or seven, kids are placed in little leagues, often to play under screaming coaches and pressuring parents. ¹⁶Later, in high school, students who are singled out by the school and by the community are not those who are best academically but those who are best athletically. ¹⁷And college sometimes seems to be more about sports than about learning. ¹⁸The United States may be the only country in the world where people often think of their colleges as teams first and schools second. ¹⁹The names Ohio State, Notre Dame, and Southern Cal mean "sports" to the public.

²⁰Our sports craziness is especially evident in the prestige given to athletes in the United States. ²¹For one thing, we reward them with enormous salaries.

²²In 2006, for example, baseball players averaged over \$2.8 million a year; the average annual salary in the United

States is \$44,389. ²³Besides their huge salaries, athletes receive the awe, the admiration, and sometimes the votes of the public. ²⁴Kids look up to someone like LeBron James or Tom Brady as a true hero; adults wear the jerseys and jackets of their favorite teams. ²⁵Former players become senators and congressmen. ²⁶And a famous athlete like Serena Williams or Tiger Woods needs to make only one commercial for advertisers to see the sales of a product boom.

²⁷Americans are truly mad about sports. ²⁸Perhaps we like to see the competitiveness we experience in our daily lives acted out on playing fields. ²⁹Perhaps we need heroes who can achieve clear-cut victories in a short time, of only an hour or two. ³⁰Whatever the reason, the sports scene in this country is more popular than ever.



An Interpretation of *Lord of the Flies*

¹Modern history has shown us the evil that exists in human beings.
²Assassinations are common, governments use torture to discourage dissent, and six million Jews were exterminated during World War II. ³In *Lord of the Flies*, William Golding describes a group of schoolboys shipwrecked on an island with no authority figures to control their behavior. ⁴One of the boys soon yields to dark forces within himself, and his corruption symbolizes the evil in all of us. ⁵First, Jack Merridew kills a living creature; then, he rebels against the group leader; and finally, he seizes power and sets up his own murderous society.
⁶The first stage in Jack's downfall is his killing of a living creature. ⁷In Chapter 1, Jack aims at a pig but is unable to kill. ⁸His upraised arm pauses "because of the enormity of the knife descending and cutting into living flesh, because of the unbearable blood," and the pig escapes. ⁹Three chapters later, however, Jack leads some boys on a successful hunt. ¹⁰He returns triumphantly with a freshly killed pig and reports excitedly to the others, "I cut the pig's throat." ¹¹Yet Jack twitches as he says this, and he wipes his bloody hands on his shorts as if eager to remove the stains. ¹²There is still some civilization left in him.
¹³After the initial act of killing the pig, Jack's refusal to cooperate with Ralph shows us that this civilized part is rapidly disappearing. ¹⁴With no adults around, Ralph has made some rules. ¹⁵One is that a signal fire must be kept burning. ¹⁶But Jack tempts the boys watching the fire to go hunting, and the fire goes out. ¹⁷Another rule is that at a meeting, only the person holding a special seashell has the right to speak. ¹⁸In Chapter 5, another boy is speaking when Jack rudely tells him to shut up. ¹⁹Ralph accuses Jack of breaking the rules. ²⁰Jack shouts: "Bollocks to the rules! We're strong—we hunt! If there's a beast, we'll hunt it down! We'll close in and beat and beat and beat—!" ²¹He gives a "wild whoop" and leaps off the platform, throwing the meeting into chaos. ²²Jack is now much more savage than civilized.
²³The most obvious proof of Jack's corruption comes in Chapter 8, when he establishes his own murderous society. ²⁴Insisting that Ralph is not a "proper chief" because he does not hunt, Jack asks for a new election. ²⁵After he again loses, Jack announces, "I'm going off by myself. . . . Anyone who wants to hunt when I do can come too." ²⁶Eventually, nearly all the boys join Jack's "tribe." ²⁷Following his example, they paint their faces like savages, sacrifice to "the beast," brutally murder two of their schoolmates, and nearly succeed in killing Ralph as well. ²⁸Jack has now become completely savage—and so have the others.
²⁹Through Jack Merridew, then, Golding shows how easily moral laws can be forgotten. ³⁰Freed from grown-ups and their rules, Jack learns to kill living things, defy authority, and lead a tribe of murdering savages. ³¹Jack's example is a frightening reminder of humanity's potential for evil. ³²The "beast" the boys try to hunt and kill is actually within every human being.

Questions

1. In which essay does the thesis statement appear in the last sentence of the introductory paragraph?

2. In the essay on *Lord of the Flies*, which sentence of the introductory paragraph contains the plan of development? _____
3. Which method of introduction is used in “Giving Up a Baby”?

a. General to narrow

b. Stating importance of topic

c. Incident or story

d. Questions
4. Complete the following brief outline of “Giving Up a Baby”: I gave up my baby for three reasons:

a. _____

b. _____

c. _____
5. Which *two* essays use a transitional sentence between the first and second supporting paragraphs?

6. *Complete the following statement:* Emphatic order is shown in the last supporting paragraph of “Giving Up a Baby” with the words

338

_____ ; in the last supporting paragraph of “Sports-Crazy America” with the words _____ ; and in the last supporting paragraph of “An Interpretation of *Lord of the Flies*” with the words _____ .

339

7. Which essay uses time order as well as emphatic order to organize its three supporting paragraphs? _____
8. List four major transitions used in the supporting paragraphs of “An Interpretation of *Lord of the Flies*.”

a. _____

b. _____

- c. _____
- d. _____

9. Which *two* essays include a sentence in the concluding paragraph that summarizes the three supporting points?

10. Which essay includes two final thoughts in its concluding paragraph?

Planning the Essay

Outlining the Essay

When you write an essay, planning is crucial for success. You should plan your essay by outlining in two ways:

- 1. Prepare a scratch outline. This should consist of a short statement of the thesis followed by the main supporting points for the thesis. Here is Gene’s scratch outline for his essay on the apple plant:

Working at an apple plant was my worst job.

- 1. Hard work*
- 2. Poor pay*
- 3. Bad working conditions*

339

Do not underestimate the value of this initial outline—or the work involved in achieving it. Be prepared to do a good deal of plain hard thinking at this first and most important stage of your essay.

340

- 2. Prepare a more detailed outline. The outline form that follows will serve as a guide. Your instructor may ask you to submit a copy of this form either before you actually write an essay or along with your finished essay.

Form for Planning an Essay

To write an effective essay, use a form like the one that follows.

Introduction

Opening remarks

Thesis statement _____

Plan of development

Body

Topic sentence 1 _____

Specific supporting evidence

Topic sentence 2 _____

Specific supporting evidence

Topic sentence 3 _____

Specific supporting evidence

Conclusion

Summary, closing remarks, or both

340

341

Practice in Writing the Essay

In this section, you will expand and strengthen your understanding of the essay form as you work through the following activities.

1 Understanding the Two Parts of a Thesis Statement

In this chapter, you have learned that effective essays center on a thesis, or main point, that a writer wishes to express. This central idea is usually presented as a *thesis statement* in an essay’s introductory paragraph.

A good thesis statement does two things. First, it tells readers an essay’s *topic*. Second, it presents the *writer’s attitude, opinion, idea, or point* about that topic. For example, look at the following thesis statement:

Celebrities are often poor role models.

In this thesis statement, the topic is *celebrities*; the writer’s main point is celebrities are *often poor role models*.

Activity 5

For each thesis statement below, single-underline the topic and double-underline the main point that the writer wishes to express about the topic.

1. Several teachers have played important roles in my life.

2. A period of loneliness in life can actually have certain benefits.

3. Owning an old car has its own special rewards.

4. Learning to write takes work, patience, and a sense of humor.

5. Advertisers use several clever sales techniques to promote their message.

6. Anger in everyday life often results from a lack of time, a frustration with technology, and a buildup of stress.

7. The sale of handguns in this country should be sharply limited for several reasons.

8. My study habits in college benefited greatly from a course on note-taking, textbook study, and test-taking skills.
9. Retired people must cope with the mental, emotional, and physical stresses of being “old.”

10. Parents should take certain steps to encourage their children to enjoy reading.

341

342

2 Supporting the Thesis with Specific Evidence

The first essential step in writing a successful essay is to form a clearly stated thesis. The second basic step is to support the thesis with specific reasons or details.

To ensure that your essay will have adequate support, you may find an informal outline very helpful. Write down a brief version of your thesis idea, and then work out and jot down the three points that will support your thesis.

Here is the scratch outline that was prepared for one essay:

The college cafeteria is poorly managed.

The checkout lines are always long.

The floor and tables are often dirty.

Food choices are often limited.

A scratch outline like the one above looks simple, but developing it often requires a good deal of careful thinking. The time spent on developing a logical outline is invaluable, though. Once you have planned the steps that logically support your thesis, you will be in an excellent position to go on to write an effective essay.

Activity 6

Following are five informal outlines in which two points (*a* and *b*) are already provided. Complete each outline by adding a third logical supporting point (*c*).

- 1. Poor grades in school can have various causes.
 - a. Family problems
 - b. Study problems
 - c. _____
- 2. My landlord adds to the stress in my life.
 - a. Keeps raising the rent
 - b. Expects me to help maintain the apartment
 - c. _____

342

- 3. My mother (*or some other adult*) has three qualities I admire.
 - a. Sense of humor
 - b. Patience
 - c. _____
- 4. The first day in college was nerve-racking.
 - a. Meeting new people
 - b. Dealing with the bookstore
 - c. _____
- 5. Getting married at nineteen was a mistake.
 - a. Not finished with my education
 - b. Not ready to have children
 - c. _____

343

3 Identifying Introductions

The box lists six common methods for introducing an essay; each is discussed in this chapter.

- 1. Broad statement
- 2. Contrast
- 3. Relevance
- 4. Incident or story
- 5. Question
- 6. Quotation

Activity 7

After reviewing the six methods of introduction on [pages 331–333](#), refer to the box above and read the following six introductory paragraphs. Then, in the space provided, write the number of the kind of introduction used in each paragraph. Each kind of introduction is used once.

Paragraph A

_____ Is bullying a natural, unavoidable part of growing up? Is it something that everyone has to endure as a victim, or practice as a bully, or tolerate as a bystander? Does bullying leave deep scars on its victims, or is it fairly harmless? Does being a bully indicate some deep-rooted problems, or is it not a big deal? These and other questions need to be looked at as we consider the three forms of bullying: physical, verbal, and social.

343

Paragraph B

_____ In a perfect school, students would treat each other with affection and respect. Differences would be tolerated, and even welcomed. Kids would become more popular by being kind and supportive. Students would go out of their way to make sure one another felt happy and comfortable. But most schools are not perfect. Instead of being places of respect and tolerance, they are places where the hateful act of bullying is widespread.

344

Paragraph C

_____ Students have to deal with all kinds of problems in schools. There are the problems created by difficult classes, by too much homework, or by personality conflicts with teachers. There are problems with scheduling the classes you need and still getting some of the ones you want. There are problems with bad cafeteria food, grouchy principals, or overcrowded classrooms. But one of the most difficult problems of all has to do with a terrible situation that exists in most schools: bullying.

Paragraph D

_____ Eric, a new boy at school, was shy and physically small. He quickly became a victim of bullies. Kids would wait after school, pull out his shirt, and punch and shove him around. He was called such names as “Mouse Boy” and “Jerk Boy.” When he sat down during lunch hour, others would leave his table. In gym games he was never thrown the ball, as if he didn’t exist. Then one day he came to school with a gun. When the police were called, he told them he just couldn’t take it anymore. Bullying had hurt him badly, just as it hurts many other students. Every member of a school community should be aware of bullying and the three hateful forms that it takes: physical, verbal, and social bullying.

Paragraph E

_____ A British prime minister once said, “Courage is fire, and bullying is smoke.” If that is true, there is a lot of “smoke” present in most schools today. Bullying in schools is a huge problem that hurts both its victims and the people who practice it. Physical, verbal, and social bullying are all harmful in their own ways.

Paragraph F

_____ A pair of students bring guns and homemade bombs to school, killing a number of their fellow students and teachers before taking their own lives. A young man hangs himself on Sunday evening rather than attend school the following morning. A junior high school girl is admitted to the emergency room after cutting her wrists. What do all these horrible reports have to do with each other? All were reportedly caused by a terrible practice that is common in schools: bullying.

344

345

4 Revising an Essay for All Four Bases: Unity, Support, Coherence, and Sentence Skills

You know from your work on paragraphs that there are four “bases” a paper must cover to be effective. In the following activity, you will evaluate and revise an essay in terms of all four bases: *unity*, *support*, *coherence*, and *sentence skills*.

Comments follow each supporting paragraph and the concluding paragraph. Circle the letter of the *one* statement that applies in each case.

Activity 8

A Hateful Activity: Bullying

Paragraph 1: Introduction

Eric, a new boy at school, was shy and physically small. He quickly became a victim of bullies. Kids would wait after school, pull out his shirt, and punch and shove him around. He was called such names as “Mouse Boy” and “Jerk Boy.” When he sat down during lunch hour, others would leave his

table. In gym games he was never thrown the ball, as if he didn't exist. Then one day he came to school with a gun. When the police were called, he told them he just couldn't take it anymore. Bullying had hurt him badly, just as it hurts many other students. Every member of a school community should be aware of bullying and the three hateful forms that it takes: physical, verbal, and social bullying. Paragraph 2: First Supporting Paragraph Bigger or meaner kids try to hurt kids who are smaller or unsure of themselves. They'll push kids into their lockers, knock books out of their hands, or shoulder them out of the cafeteria line. In gym class, a bully often likes to kick kids' legs out from under them while they are running. In the classroom, bullies might kick the back of the chair or step on the foot of the kids they want to intimidate. Bullies will corner a kid in a bathroom. There the victim will be slapped around, will have his or her clothes half pulled off, and might even be shoved into a trash can. Bullies will wait for kids after school and bump or wrestle them around, often while others are looking on. The goal is to frighten kids as much as possible and try to make them cry. Physical bullying is more common among boys, but it is not unknown for girls to be physical bullies as well. The victims are left bruised and hurting, but often in even more pain emotionally than bodily. a. Paragraph 2 contains an irrelevant sentence. b. Paragraph 2 lacks transition words. c. Paragraph 2 lacks supporting details at one key spot. d. Paragraph 2 contains a fragment and a run-on.	345 346
Paragraph 3: Second Supporting Paragraph Perhaps even worse than physical attack is verbal bullying, which uses words, rather than hands or fists, as weapons. We may be told that "sticks and stones may break my bones, but words can never harm me," but few of us are immune to the pain of a verbal attack. Like physical bullies, verbal bullies tend to single out certain targets. From that moment on, the victim is subject to a hail of insults and put-downs. These are usually delivered in public, so the victim's humiliation will be greatest: "Oh, no; here comes the nerd!" "Why don't you lose some weight, blubber boy?" "You smell as bad as you look!" "Weirdo." "Fairy." "Creep." "Dork." "Slut." "Loser." Verbal bullying is an equal-opportunity activity, with girls as likely to be verbal bullies as boys. If parents don't want their children to be bullies like this, they shouldn't be abusive themselves. Meanwhile, the victim retreats farther and farther into his or her shell, hoping to escape further notice. a. Paragraph 3 contains an irrelevant sentence. b. Paragraph 3 lacks transition words. c. Paragraph 3 lacks supporting details at one key spot. d. Paragraph 3 contains a fragment and a run-on.	

Paragraph 4: Third Supporting Paragraph As bad as verbal bullying is, many would agree that the most painful type of bullying of all is social bullying. Many students have a strong need for the comfort of being part of a group. For social bullies, the pleasure of belonging to a group is increased by the sight of someone who is refused entry into that group. So, like wolves targeting the weakest sheep in a herd, the bullies lead the pack in isolating people who they decide are different. Bullies do everything they can to make those people feel sad and lonely. In class and out of it, the bullies make it clear that the victims are ignored and unwanted. As the victims sink farther into isolation and depression, the social bullies—who seem to be female more often than male—feel all the more puffed up by their own popularity. a. Paragraph 4 contains an irrelevant sentence. b. Paragraph 4 lacks transition words. c. Paragraph 4 lacks supporting details at one key spot. d. Paragraph 4 contains a fragment and a run-on. Paragraph 5: Concluding Paragraph Whether bullying is physical, verbal, or social, it can leave deep and lasting scars. If parents, teachers, and other adults were more aware of the types of bullying, they might help by stepping in. Before the situation becomes too extreme. If students were more aware of the terrible pain that bullying causes, they might think twice about being bullies themselves, their awareness could make the world a kinder place. a. Paragraph 5 contains an irrelevant sentence. b. Paragraph 5 lacks transition words. c. Paragraph 5 lacks supporting details at one key spot. d. Paragraph 5 contains a fragment and a run-on.	346 347
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Essay Assignments

HINTS

- Keep the points below in mind when writing an essay on any of the topics that follow.
- 1. Your first step must be to plan your essay. Prepare both a scratch outline and a more detailed outline, as explained on the preceding pages.
 - 2. While writing your essay, use the checklist below to make sure that your essay touches all four bases of effective writing.

FOUR BASES Checklist for Essays

Base: *Unity*

- Clearly stated thesis in the introductory paragraph of your essay
- All the supporting paragraphs on target in backing up your thesis

Base: *Support*

- Three separate supporting points for your thesis
- specific evidence for each of the three supporting points
- Plenty of specific evidence for each supporting point

Base: *Coherence*

- Clear method of organization
- Transitions and other connecting words
- Effective introduction and conclusion

Base: *Sentence Skills*

- Clear, error-free sentences (use the checklist on the inside back cover of this book)

347

348

Writing Assignment 1

Your House or Apartment

Write an essay on the advantages *or* disadvantages (not both) of the house or apartment where you live. In your introductory paragraph, describe briefly the place you plan to write about. End the paragraph with your thesis statement and a plan of development. Here are some suggestions for thesis statements:

The best features of my apartment are its large windows, roomy closets, and great location.

The drawbacks of my house are its unreliable oil burner, tiny kitchen, and old-fashioned bathroom.

An inquisitive landlord, sloppy neighbors, and platoons of cockroaches came along with our rented house.

My apartment has several advantages, including friendly neighbors, lots of storage space, and a good security system.



Writing Assignment 2

A Big Mistake

Write an essay about the biggest mistake you made within the past year. Describe the mistake and show how its effects have convinced you that it was the wrong thing to do. For instance, if you write about “taking a full-time job while going to school” as your biggest mistake, show the problems it caused.

To get started, make a list of all the things you did last year that, with hindsight, now seem to be mistakes. Then pick out the action that has had the most serious consequences for you. Make a brief outline as in the following examples.

Thesis: Separating from my husband was the worst mistake I made last year.

- 1. Children have suffered
- 2. Financial troubles
- 3. Loneliness

348

Thesis: Buying a used car to commute to school was the worst mistake of last year.

- 1. Unreliable—late for class or missed class
- 2. Expenses for insurance, repairs
- 3. Led to an accident

349

Writing Assignment 3

A Valued Possession

Write an essay about a valued material possession. Here are some suggestions:

- | | |
|--------------------|-------------------------------|
| Car | Cell phone |
| Computer | Photograph album or scrapbook |
| Piece of furniture | Piece of clothing |
| Piece of jewelry | Stereo system or MP3 player |
| Camera | Musical instrument |

In your introductory paragraph, describe the possession: tell what it is, when and where you got it, and how long you have owned it. Your thesis statement should center on the idea that there are several reasons this possession is so important to you. In each of your supporting paragraphs, provide details to back up one of the reasons.

For example, here is a brief outline of an essay written about a leather jacket:

- 1. It is comfortable.
- 2. It wears well.
- 3. It makes me look and feel good.

Writing Assignment 4

Single Life

Write an essay on the advantages or drawbacks of single life. To get started, make a list of all the advantages and drawbacks you can think of. Advantages might include

- Fewer expenses
- More personal freedom
- Fewer responsibilities
- More opportunities to move or travel

349

Drawbacks might include

- Parental disapproval
- Being alone at social events
- No companion for shopping, movies, and so on
- Sadness at holiday time

350

After you make up two lists, select the thesis for which you feel you have more supporting material. Then organize your material into a scratch outline. Be sure to include an introduction, a clear topic sentence for each supporting paragraph, and a conclusion.

Alternatively, write an essay on the advantages or drawbacks of married life. Follow the directions given above.

Writing Assignment 5

Influences on Your Writing

Are you as good a writer as you want to be? Write an essay analyzing the reasons you have become a good writer or explaining why you are not as good as you'd like to be. Begin by considering some factors that may have influenced your writing ability.

- Your family background:* Did you see people writing at home? Did your parents respect and value the ability to write?
- Your school experience:* Did you have good writing teachers? Did you have a history of failure or success with writing? Was writing fun, or was it a chore? Did your school emphasize writing?
- Social Influences:* How did your school friends do at writing? What were your friends' attitudes toward writing? What feelings about writing did you pick up from TV or the movies?

You might want to organize your essay by describing the three greatest Influences on your skill (or your lack of skill) as a writer. Show how each of these has contributed to the present state of your writing.

Writing Assignment 6

A Major Decision

All of us come to various crossroads in our lives—times when we must make an important decision about which course of action to follow. Think about a major decision you had to make (or one you are planning to make). Then write an essay on the reasons for your decision. In your introduction, describe the decision you have reached. Each of the body paragraphs that follow should fully explain one of the reasons for your decision. Here are some examples of major decisions that often confront people:

- Enrolling in or dropping out of college
- Accepting or quitting a job
- Getting married or divorced
- Breaking up with a boyfriend or girlfriend
- Having a baby
- Moving away from home

Student papers on this topic include the essay on [page 334](#) and the paragraphs on [pages 50–53](#).

Writing Assignment 7

Reviewing a TV Show or Movie

Write an essay about a television show or movie you have seen very recently. The thesis of your essay will be that the show (or movie) has both good and bad features. (If you are writing about a TV series, be sure that you evaluate only one episode.)

In your first supporting paragraph, briefly summarize the show or movie. Don’t get bogged down in small details here; just describe the major characters briefly and give the highlights of the action.

In your second supporting paragraph, explain what you feel are the best features of the show or movie. Listed below are some examples of good features you might write about:



Suspenseful, ingenious, or
realistic plot

Good acting

Good scenery or special effects

Surprise ending

Good music

Believable characters

In your third supporting paragraph, explain what you feel are the worst features of the show or movie. Here are some possibilities:

Far-fetched, confusing, or dull plot

Poor special effects

Bad acting

351

352

- Cardboard characters
- Unrealistic dialogue

Remember to cover only a few features in each paragraph; do not try to include everything.

Writing Assignment 8

Your High School

Imagine that you are an outside consultant called in as a neutral observer to examine the high school you attended. After your visit, you must send the school board a five-paragraph letter in which you describe the most striking features (good, bad, or both) of the school and the evidence for each of these features.

In order to write the letter, you may want to think about the following features of your high school:

- Attitude of the teachers, student body, or administration
- Condition of the buildings, classrooms, recreational areas, and so on
- Curriculum
- How classes are conducted
- Extracurricular activities
- Crowded or uncrowded conditions

Be sure to include an introduction, a clear topic sentence for each supporting paragraph, and a conclusion.

Writing Assignment 9

Being One’s Own Worst Enemy

“A lot of people are their own worst enemies” is a familiar saying. We all know people who find ways to hurt themselves. Write an essay describing someone you know who is his or her own worst enemy. In your paper, introduce the person and explain his or her self-destructive behaviors. A useful way to gather ideas for this paper is to combine two prewriting techniques—outlining and listing. Begin with an outline of the general areas you expect to cover. Here’s an outline that may work:

- Introduce the person in the first paragraph.
- Describe the self-destructive behavior in two or more supporting paragraphs.
- Suggest changes in the concluding paragraph.

352
353

Once you have a workable outline, make a list to produce specific details for each point in the outline. Here is one sample outline:

Person

Just graduated from high school

Works at a department store

Wants to go to college, but needs money

Hurtful behaviors

Just moved into own apartment

Spends a lot of money on clothing

Makes no effort to find financial aid to continue her schooling

Changes

Stop spending so much and start saving

Get information from school financial aid offices

Writing Assignment 10

Parents and Children

The older we get, the more we see our parents in ourselves.

Write a paragraph in which you describe three characteristics you have “inherited” from a parent. Ask yourself a series of questions: “How am I like my mother (or father)?” “When and where am I like her (or him)?” “Why am I like her (or him)?”

One student used the following thesis statement: “Although I hate to admit it, I know that in several ways I’m just like my mom.” She then went on to describe how she works too hard, worries too much, and judges other people too harshly. Be sure to include examples for each characteristic you mention.

353

Writing Assignment 11

Influential People

Who are the three people who have been the most important influences in your life? Write an essay describing each of these people and explaining how each of them has helped you. For example:

354

It was my aunt who first impressed upon me the importance of a college education.

If it weren't for my father, I wouldn't be in college today.

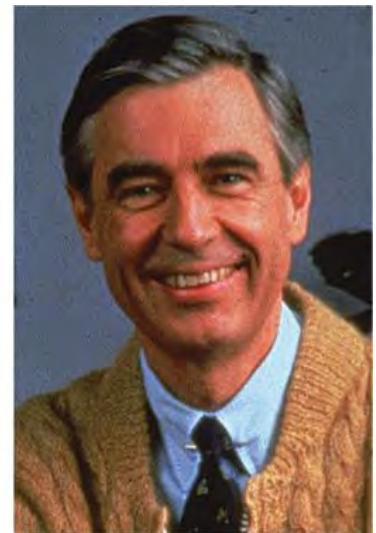
My best friend has helped me with my college education in several ways.

To develop support for this essay, make a list of all the ways each person helped you get your bearings and focus on a college path. Alternatively, you could do some freewriting about each person you're writing about. These prewriting techniques—listing and freewriting—are both helpful ways of getting started with an essay and thinking about it on paper.

Writing Assignment 12

Heroes for the Human Race

Many people would agree that three men who died in recent years were a credit to the human race. Christopher Reeve played Superman in the movies but became one in real life by fighting a spinal-cord injury. Charles Schultz was the creator of the world-famous comic strip *Peanuts*, whose characters dealt with anxieties we could all understand. Fred Rogers starred in the well-known television show *Mr. Rogers' Neighborhood*, which children and adults still watch today. Write an essay in which three separate supporting paragraphs explain in detail why each of these men can be regarded as a hero for humanity. [Chapter 20](#), “Writing a Research Paper” ([pages 374–397](#)), will show you how to do the necessary research.



PART 4: Research Skills

356

356

357



Choose a hobby or interest you might like to find out more about. Using the search engine of your choice, visit several Web sites that are related to your interest. Choose a site that you like and write a paragraph describing both the activity and the Web site to someone unfamiliar with both. What appeals to you about the activity? What makes the Web site fun, informative, and/ or amusing to people who share your interest?

[19: Using the Library and the Internet](#)

[20: Writing a Research Paper](#)

19: Using the Library and the Internet



Write an essay about using the Internet as a tool for research. To support your main point, provide examples of specific sites that you have found useful. What kinds of information has the Internet made available? Remember to be specific.

Google, Inc.

This chapter will explain and illustrate how to use the library and the Internet to

- find books on your topic
- find articles on your topic

This chapter will also show you how to

- evaluate Internet sources

358

This chapter provides the basic information you need to use your college library and the Internet with confidence. You will learn that for most research topics there are two basic steps you should take:

359

- 1. Find books on your topic.
- 2. Find articles on your topic.

You will learn, too, that while using the library is the traditional way of doing such research, a home computer with Internet access now enables you to investigate any topic.



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Using the Library

Most students know that libraries provide study space, computer workstations, and copying machines. They are also aware of a library’s reading area, which contains recent copies of magazines and newspapers. But the true heart of a library is the following: a *main desk*, the library’s *catalog or catalogs of holdings*, *book stacks*, and the *periodicals storage area*. Each of these will be discussed in the pages that follow.

Main Desk

The main desk is usually located in a central spot. Check at the main desk to see whether a brochure describes the layout and services of the library. You might also ask whether the library staff provides tours of the library. If not, explore your library to find each of the areas described below.

Activity 1

Make up a floor plan of your college library. Label the main desk, catalogs (in print or computerized), book stacks, and periodicals area.

Library Catalog

The *library catalog* will be your starting point for almost any research project. The *catalog* is a list of all the holdings of the library. It may still be an actual card catalog: a file of cards alphabetically arranged in drawers. More likely, however, the catalog is computerized and can be accessed on computer terminals located at different spots in the library. And increasingly, local and college library catalogs can be accessed online, so you may be able to check their book holdings on your home computer.

359
360

Finding a Book—Author, Title, and Subject

Whether you use an actual file of cards, use a computer terminal, or visit your library’s holdings online, it is important for you to know that there are three ways to look up a book. You can look it up according to *author*, *title*, or *subject*. For example, suppose you wanted to see if the library has the book *Amazing Grace*, by Jonathan Kozol. You could check for the book in any of three ways:

1. You could do an *author* search and look it up under *Kozol, Jonathan*. An author is always listed under his or her last name.
2. You could do a *title* search and look it up under *Amazing Grace*. Note that you always look up a book under the first word in the title, excluding the words *A*, *An*, or *The*.
3. If you know the subject that the book deals with—in this case, “poor children”—you could do a *subject search* and look it up under *Poor children*.

Here is the author entry in a computerized catalog for Kozol’s book *Amazing Grace*:

Author:	<u>Kozol, Jonathan</u>
Title:	Amazing Grace
Publisher:	New York: Crown, 1995
LC Subjects:	1. Poor children— New York (N.Y.) 2. Racism and racial segregation — New York (N.Y.) 3. Children of minorities— New York (N.Y.) 4. AIDS, asthma, illnesses of children.
Call Number:	362.709 Koz
Material:	Book
Location:	Cherry Hill
Status:	Available

Note that in addition to giving you the publisher (Crown) and year of publication (1995), the entry also tells you the *call number*—where to find the book in the library. If the computerized catalog is part of a network of libraries, you may also learn at what branch or location the book is available. If the book is not at your library, you can probably arrange for an interlibrary loan.

360
361

Using Subject Headings to Research a Topic

Generally, if you are looking for a particular book, it is easier to search by *author* or *title*. On the other hand, if you are researching a topic, then you should search by *subject*.

The subject section performs three valuable functions:

- It will give you a list of books on a given topic.
- It will often provide related topics that might have information on your subject.
- It will suggest to you more limited topics, helping you narrow your general topic.

Chances are you will be asked to do a research paper of about five to fifteen pages. You do not want to choose a topic so broad that it could be covered only by an entire book or more. Instead, you want to come up with a limited topic that can be adequately supported in a relatively short paper. As you search the subject section, take advantage of ideas that it might offer on how you can narrow your topic.

Activity 2

Part A Answer the following questions about your library’s catalog.

- 1. Is your library’s catalog an actual file of cards in drawers, or is it computerized?

- 2. Which type of catalog search will help you research and limit a topic?

Part B Use your library’s catalog to answer the following questions.

- 1. What is the title of one book by Alice Walker?

- 2. What is the title of one book by George Will?

- 3. Who is the author of *The Making of the President*? (Remember to look up the title under *Making*, not *The*.)

- 4. Who is the author of *Angela’s Ashes*? _____
- 5. List two books and their authors dealing with the subject of adoption:
 - a. _____

 - b. _____

- 6. Look up a book titled *The Road Less Traveled* or *Passages* or *The American Way of Death* and give the following information:
 - a. Author _____
 - b. Publisher _____
 - c. Date of publication _____
 - d. Call number _____
 - e. Subject headings _____

361
362

7. Look up a book written by Barbara Tuchman or Russell Baker or Bruce Catton and give the following information:

a. Title _____

b. Publisher _____

c. Date of publication _____

d. Call number _____

e. Subject headings _____

Book Stacks

The *book stacks* are the library shelves where books are arranged according to their call numbers. The *call number*, as distinctive as a social security number, always appears on the catalog entry for any book. It is also printed on the spine of every book in the library.

If your library has open stacks (ones that you are permitted to enter), here is how to find a book. Suppose you are looking for *Amazing Grace*, which has the call number HV[875] / N48 / K69 in the Library of Congress system. (Libraries using the Dewey decimal system have call letters made up entirely of numbers rather than letters and numbers. However, you use the same basic method to locate a book.) First, you go to the section of the stacks that holds the H’s. After you locate the H’s, you look for the HV’s. After that, you look for HV875. Finally, you look for HV875 / N48 /K69, and you have the book.

If your library has *closed stacks* (ones you are not permitted to enter), you will have to write down the title, author, and call number on a request form. (Such forms will be available near the card catalog or computer terminals.) You’ll then give the form to a library staff person, who will locate the book and bring it to you.

362
363

Activity 3

Use the book stacks to answer one of the following sets of questions. Choose the questions that relate to the system of classifying books used by your library.

Library of Congress system (letters and numbers)

1. Books in the BF21 to BF833 area deal with

a. philosophy.

b. sociology.

c. psychology.

d. history.
2. Books in the HV580 to HV5840 area deal with which type of social problem?

- a. Drugs
 - b. Suicide
 - c. White-collar crime
 - d. Domestic violence
3. Books in the PR4740 to PR4757 area deal with
- a. James Joyce.
 - b. Jane Austen.
 - c. George Eliot.
 - d. Thomas Hardy.

Dewey decimal system (numbers)

1. Books in the 320 area deal with
- a. self-help.
 - b. divorce.
 - c. science.
 - d. politics.
2. Books in the 636 area deal with
- a. animals.
 - b. computers.
 - c. marketing.
 - d. senior citizens.
3. Books in the 709 area deal with
- a. camping.
 - b. science fiction.
 - c. art.
 - d. poetry.

Periodicals

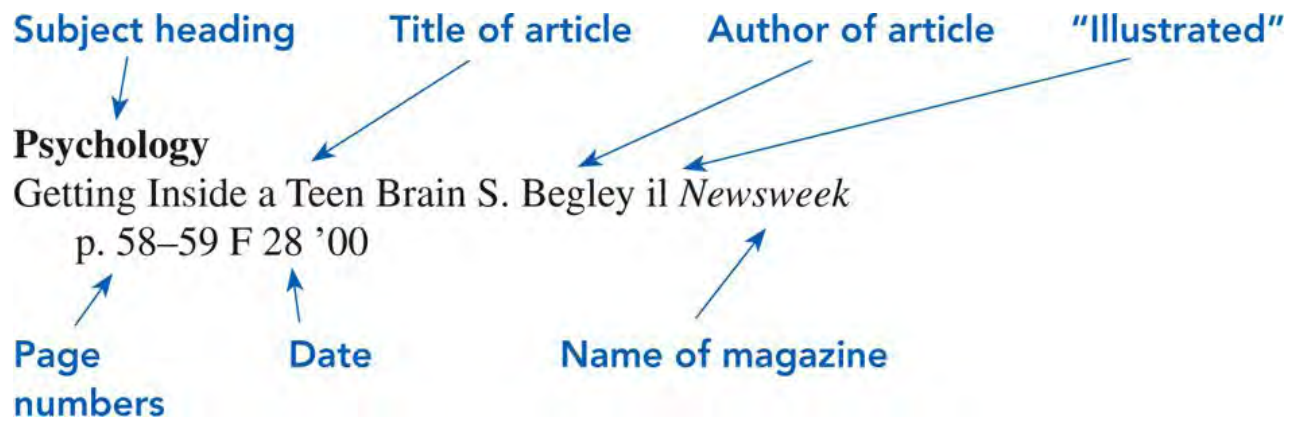
The first step in researching a topic is to check for relevant books; the second step is to locate relevant periodicals. *Periodicals* (from the word *periodic*, which means “at regular periods”) are magazines, journals, and newspapers. Periodicals often contain recent information about a given subject, or very specialized information about a subject, which may not be available in a book.

The library’s catalog lists the periodicals that it holds, just as it lists its book holdings. To find articles in these periodicals, however, you will need to consult a periodicals index. Two indexes widely used in libraries are *Readers’ Guide to Periodical Literature* and *EBSCOhost*.

Readers’ Guide to Periodical Literature

The old-fashioned way to do research is to use the familiar green volumes of the *Readers’ Guide*, found in just about every library. They list articles published in more than two hundred popular magazines, such as *Newsweek*, *Health*, *People*, *Ebony*, *Redbook*, and *Popular Science*. Articles appear alphabetically under both subject and author. For example, if you wanted to learn the names of articles published on the subject of child abuse within a certain time span, you would look under the heading “Child abuse.”

Here is a typical entry from the *Guide*:



Note the sequence in which information about the article is given:

1. Subject heading.
2. Title of the article. In some cases, bracketed words ([]) after the title help make clear just what the article is about.
3. Author (if it is a signed article). The author’s first name is always abbreviated.
4. Whether the article has a bibliography (*bibl*) or is illustrated with pictures (*il*). Other abbreviations sometimes used are shown in the front of the *Readers’ Guide*.

- 5. Name of the magazine. Before 1988, the *Reader’s Guide* used abbreviations for most of the magazines indexed. For example, the magazine *Popular Science* is abbreviated *Pop Sci*. If necessary, refer to the list of magazines in the front of the index to identify abbreviations.
- 6. Page numbers on which the article appears.
- 7. Date when the article appeared. Dates are abbreviated: for example, *Mr* stands for March, *Ag* for August, *O* for October. Other abbreviations are shown in the front of the *Guide*.

The *Readers’ Guide* is published in monthly supplements. At the end of a year, a volume is published covering the entire year. You will see in your library large green volumes that say, for instance, *Readers’ Guide 2000* or *Readers’ Guide 2008*. You will also see the small monthly supplements for the current year.

The drawback of *Readers’ Guide* is that it gives you only a list of articles; you must then go to your library’s catalog to see if the library actually has copies of the magazines that contain those articles. If you’re lucky and it does, you must take the time to locate the relevant issue, and then to read and take notes on the articles or make copies of them.

The *Reader’s Guide* may also be available at your library online. If so, you can quickly search for articles on a given subject simply by typing in a keyword or key phrase.

EBSCOhost

Many libraries now provide an online computer search service such as InfoTrac or EBSCOhost. Sitting at a terminal and using EBSCOhost, for instance, you will be able to use keywords to quickly search many hundreds of periodicals for full-text articles on your subject. When you find articles that are relevant for your purpose, you can either print them using a library printer (libraries may charge you about ten cents a page) or if possible e-mail to yourself to print elsewhere. Obviously, if an online resource is available, that is the way you should conduct your research.

Activity 4

At this point in the chapter, you now know the two basic steps in researching a topic in the library. What are the steps?

1. _____

2. _____

Activity 5

1. Look up a recent article on Internet shopping using one of your library’s periodicals indexes and fill in the following information:

a. Name of the index you used _____

- b. Article title _____
- c. Author (if given) _____
- d. Name of magazine _____
- e. Pages _____
- f. Date _____

2. Look up a recent article on violence in schools using one of your library's periodicals indexes and fill in the following information:

- a. Name of the index you used _____
- b. Article title _____
- c. Author (if given) _____
- d. Name of magazine _____
- e. Pages _____
- f. Date _____

365

Using the Internet

366



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The Internet is dramatic proof of the computer revolution that has occurred in our lives. It is a giant network that connects computers at tens of thousands of educational, scientific, government, and commercial agencies around the world. Within the Internet is the World Wide Web, a global information system that got its name because countless individual Web sites contain *links* to other sites, forming a kind of web.

To use the Internet, you need a personal computer with a *modem*—a device that sends and receives electronic data over a telephone or cable line. You also need to subscribe to a service provider such as America Online, Earthlink, or RoadRunner. If you have a printer, you can do a good deal of your research for a paper at home. As you would in a library, you should proceed by searching for books and articles on your topic.

Before you begin searching the Internet on your own, though, take the time to learn whether your local or school library is online. If it is, visit its online address to find out exactly what sources and databases it has available. You may be able to do all your research using the online resources available through your library.

If, on the other hand, your library's resources are limited, you can use the Internet on your own to search for material on any topic, as explained on the pages that follow.

Find Books on Your Topic

To find current books on your topic, go online and type in the address of one of the large commercial online booksellers:

Amazon at www.amazon.com

Barnes and Noble Books at www.bn.com



© Amazon.com or its affiliates. All rights reserved.

The easy-to-use search facilities of both Amazon and Barnes and Noble are free, and you are under no obligation to buy books from them.

Use the “Browse” Tab

After you arrive at the Amazon or Barnes and Noble Web site (or the online library site of your choice), go to the “Browse” tab of books. You’ll then get a list of categories where you might locate texts on your general subject. For example, if your assignment was to report on the development of the modern telescope, you would notice that one of the listings is “science and nature.” Upon choosing “science and nature,” you would get several subcategories, one of which is “astronomy.” Clicking on that will offer you still more subcategories, including one called “telescopes.” When you choose that, you would get a list of recent books on the topic of telescopes. You could then click on each title for information about each book. All this browsing and searching can be done very easily and will help you research your topic quickly.

Use the “Search” Box

If your assignment is to prepare a paper on some aspect of photography, type in the word “photography” in the search box. You’ll then get a list of books on that subject. Just looking at the list may help you

narrow your subject and decide on a specific topic you might want to develop. For instance, one student typed “photography” in the search box on Barnes and Noble’s site and got back a list of 13,000 books on the subject. Considering just part of that list helped her realize that she wanted to write on some aspect of photography during the U.S. Civil War. She typed “Civil War Photography” and got back a list of 200 titles. After looking at information about twenty of those books, she was able to decide on a limited topic for her paper.

A Note on the Library of Congress

The commercial bookstore sites described are especially quick and easy to use. But you should know that to find additional books on your topic, you can also visit the Library of Congress Web site (www.loc.gov). The Library of Congress, in Washington, D.C., has copies of all books published in the United States. Its online catalog contains about twelve million entries. You can browse this catalog by subject or search by keywords. The search form permits you to check just those books that interest you. Click on the “Full Record” option to view publication information about a book, as well as its call numbers. You can then try to obtain the book from your college library or through an interlibrary loan.

367

Other Points to Note

368

Remember that at any time you can use your printer to quickly print out information presented on the screen. (For example, the student planning a paper on photography in the Civil War could print out a list of the twenty books, along with sheets of information about individual books.) You could then go to your library knowing just what books you want to borrow. If your own local or school library is accessible online, you can visit in advance to find out whether it has the books you want. Also, if you have time and money, you may want to purchase them from a local bookshop or an online bookstore, such as Amazon. Used books are often available at greatly reduced prices, and they often ship out in just a couple of days.

Find Articles on Your Topic

There are many online sources that will help you find articles on your subject. Following are descriptions of some of them.

Online Magazines and Newspaper Articles

As already mentioned, your library may have an online search service such as EBSCOhost or InfoTrac that you can use to find and access relevant articles on your subject. Another online research service, one that you can subscribe to individually on a home computer, is eLibrary. You may be able to get a free seven-day trial subscription or pay for a monthly subscription at a limited cost. This service provides millions of newspaper and magazine articles as well as many thousands of book chapters and television and radio transcripts. After typing in one or more keywords, you’ll get long lists of articles that may relate to your subject. Click on a title to see the full text of the article. If it fits your needs, you can print it out right away. Very easily, then, you can research a full range of magazine and newspaper articles.

Search Engines



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An Internet search engine will help you quickly go through a vast amount of information on the Web to find articles about almost any topic. One extremely helpful search engine is Google; you can access it by typing www.google.com. A screen will then appear with a box in which you can type one or more keywords. For example, if you are thinking of doing a paper on Habitat for Humanity, you simply enter the words *Habitat for Humanity*. Within a second or so you will get a list of over one million articles and sites on the Web about Habitat for Humanity.

You should then try to narrow your topic by adding other keywords. For instance, if you typed “Habitat for Humanity’s hurricane relief efforts,” you would get a list of over 278,000 articles and sites. If you narrowed your potential topic further by typing “Habitat for Humanity’s hurricane relief effort in New Orleans,” you would get a list of 138,000 items. Google does a superior job of returning hits that are genuinely relevant to your search, so just scanning the early part of a list may be enough to provide you with the information you need.

Very often your challenge with searches will be getting too much information rather than too little. Try making your keywords more specific, or use different combinations of keywords. You might also try another search engine, such as www.yahoo.com. In addition, consult the search engine’s built-in “Advanced Search” feature for tips on successful searching.

Finally, remember while you search to save the addresses of relevant Web sites that you may want to visit again. The browser that you are using (for example, Internet Explorer or Safari) will probably have a “Bookmark” or “Favorite Places” option. With the click of a mouse, you can bookmark a site. You will then be able to return to it simply by clicking on its name in a list, rather than having to remember and type its address.



Results from a keyword search on Google using Habitat for Humanity’s hurricane relief effort in New Orleans.

Google, Inc.

Evaluating Internet Sources

Keep in mind that the quality and reliability of information you find on the Internet may vary widely. Anyone with a bit of computer know-how can create a Web site and post information there. That person may be a Nobel Prize winner, a leading authority in a specialized field, a high school student, or a crackpot. Be careful, then, to look closely at your source in the following ways:



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369

Evaluating Online Sources

- 1. **Internet address.** In a Web address, the three letters following the “dot” are the domain. The most common domains are .com, .edu, .gov., .net, and .org. A common misconception is that a Web site’s reliability can be determined by its domain type. This is not the case, as almost anyone can get a Web address ending in .com, .edu, .org, or any of the other domains. Therefore, it is important that you examine every Web site carefully, considering the three points (author, internal evidence, and date) that follow.
- 2. **Author.** What credentials does the author have (if any)? Has the author published other material on the topic?
- 3. **Internal evidence.** Does the author seem to proceed objectively— presenting all sides of a topic fairly before arguing his or her own views? Does the author produce solid, adequate support for his or her views?
- 4. **Date.** Is the information up-to-date? Check at the top or bottom of the document for copyright, publication, or revision dates. Knowing such dates will help you decide whether the material is current enough for your purposes.

370

Activity 6

Part A Go to www.google.com and search for the word “democracy.” Then complete the items below.

- 1. How many items did your search yield? _____
- 2. In the early listings, you will probably find each of the following domains: edu, gov, org, and com. Pick one site with each domain and write its full address.

370

371

- a. Address of one .com site you found: _____
- b. Address of one .gov site: _____
- c. Address of one .org site: _____
- d. Address of one .edu site: _____

Part B Circle *one* of the sites you identified above and use it to complete the following evaluation.

3. Name of site's author or authoring institution: _____
4. Is site's information current (within two years)? _____
5. Does the site serve obvious business purposes (with advertising or attempts to sell products)?

6. Does the site have an obvious connection to a governmental, commercial, business, or religious organization? If so, which one?

7. Does the site's information seem fair and objective?

8. Based on the information above, would you say the site appears reliable?

Practice in Using the Library and the Internet

Activity 7

Use your library or the Internet to research a subject that interests you. Select one of the following areas or (with your instructor's permission) an area of your own choice:

	Assisted suicide Interracial adoption Ritalin and children Sexual harassment	Same-sex marriage Global warming Nursing home costs Pro-choice movement today	371
	Pro-life movement today Health insurance reform Pollution of drinking water Problems of retirement Cremation Capital punishment Prenatal care Acid rain New aid for people with disabilities New remedies for allergies Censorship on the Internet Prison reform Drug treatment programs Sudden infant death syndrome New treatments for insomnia Organ donation Child abuse Voucher system in schools Food poisoning (salmonella) Alzheimer's disease Holistic healing Best job prospects today Heroes for today Computer use and carpal tunnel syndrome Noise control Animals nearing extinction Animal rights movement	Anti-gay violence Drug treatment programs for adolescents Fertility drugs Witchcraft today New treatments for AIDS Mind-body medicine Origins of Kwanzaa Hazardous substances in the home Airbags Gambling and youth Nongraded schools Forecasting earthquakes Ethical aspects of hunting Ethics of cloning Recent consumer frauds Stress reduction in the workplace Sex on television Everyday addictions Toxic waste disposal Self-help groups Telephone crimes Date rape Steroids Surrogate mothers Vegetarianism HPV immunizations	372
	Research the topic first through a subject search in your library's catalog or that of an online bookstore. Then research the topic through a periodicals index (print or online). On a separate sheet of paper, provide the following information.		
	1. Topic		
	2. Three books that either cover the topic directly or at least touch on the topic in some way. Include		
	Author		373

Title

Place of publication

Publisher

Date of publication

3. Three articles on the topic published in 2005 or later. Include

Title of article

Author (if given)

Title of magazine

Date

Page(s) (if given)

4. Finally, write a paragraph describing just how you went about researching your topic. In addition, include a photocopy or printout of one of the three articles.

20: Writing a Research Paper



If you were to write a research paper on college, what would you focus on? “College” itself is too broad a topic to cover in one paper. You would need to select a more limited topic. For example, you could focus on the first-class treatment received by many college star athletes or the benefits of attending smaller colleges over larger universities. Looking at the photos above, can you think of other college-themed topics you might cover in a research paper?

This chapter will explain and illustrate

- the six steps in writing a research paper:
STEP 1: Select a topic that you can readily research
STEP 2: Limit your topic and make the purpose of your paper clear
STEP 3: Gather information on your limited topic
STEP 4: Plan your paper and take notes on your limited topic
STEP 5: Write the paper
STEP 6: Use an acceptable format and method of documentation

This chapter also provides

- a model research paper

374

375

Step 1: Select a Topic That You Can Readily Research

Researching at a Local Library



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First of all, do a *subject* search of your library's catalog (as described on page 360) and see whether there are several books on your general topic. For example, if you initially choose the broad topic of "divorce," try to find at least three books on the topic of divorce. Make sure that the books are actually available on the library shelves.

Next, go to a *periodicals index* in your library (see [pages 363–365](#)) to see if there are a fair number of magazine, newspaper, or journal articles on your subject. You can use the *Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature* (described on page 364) to find articles that appear in the back issues of periodicals that your library may keep. But you may find that your library subscribes to an electronic database such as EBSCOhost, which will allow you access to articles published in a far greater range of publications. For instance, when Sara Hughes, author of the model research paper "Divorce Mediation," visited her local library, she typed the search term "divorce" into a computer that connected her to EBSCOhost. In seconds, EBSCOhost came back with hundreds of hits—titles, publication information, and the complete text of articles about divorce.

Researching on the Internet



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If you have access to the Internet on a home or library computer, you can use it to determine if resources are available for your topic.

The first step is to go to the *subjects* section of a large online bookseller or library catalog to find relevant books. (Don't worry—you don't have to buy the books; you're just browsing for information.) As mentioned in [Chapter 19](#), two of the largest online booksellers are Barnes and Noble and Amazon.

Sarah Hughes checked out both Barnes and Noble (www.bn.com) and Amazon (www.amazon.com). “Both sites were easy to use,” she reported. “All I had to do to get started was look at their ‘browse’ options and click on the subjects that seemed most relevant.

“At Barnes and Noble, the category I clicked on first was called ‘Parenting and Families.’ Under that was a bunch of subcategories, including one on ‘Divorce.’ I clicked on ‘Divorce’ and that brought up a list of 733 books! I spent some time scrolling through those titles and saw that there were lots of different themes: mostly ‘how to survive your own divorce’ books, but also books on all kinds of other topics, like ‘how to keep sane while your boyfriend is going through a divorce’ and ‘how to stay involved in your children’s lives when you’re not living with them.’ Others were about all kinds of emotional, legal, and financial aspects of divorce. There were clearly plenty of divorce-related books available, but I still didn’t know what my paper’s focus was going to be.” At this point Sarah was feeling frustrated. She would return to Barnes and Noble a little later, but first she decided to try something else: searching online for newspaper and magazine articles.

The simplest way is to use the Internet search engine Google (see [pages 368–369](#)), which allows you to search the Internet for information on any topic you like. Sarah relates her experience using Google in this way:

“First I typed in the word ‘divorce’ in the keyword box,” she said. “I got more than a hundred million hits! So I tried more specific search terms. I tried ‘divorce process’ first, but that was still too general. I got several hundred thousand hits and I didn’t know where to start reading. So I narrowed my topics even more: ‘divorce alternatives’ and ‘divorce costs.’ Those reduced the number of hits a lot. I was still getting thousands, but I could see that some of the very first ones looked really promising.

“In order to look just for magazine and newspaper articles, I went directly to the site of some popular publications, such as *Time* (time.com), *Newsweek* (newsweek.com), and *USA Today* (usatoday.com). I was able to search each one for recent articles about divorce. I saw that I would have to use a credit card and pay a fee of about two dollars to read each article online. So I noted down the date and page number of the articles I was interested in and looked up the ones that were available in the back-issue section of my library’s reading room. Between doing that and using EBSCOhost, I found plenty of recent material

related to my subject. I noticed the title of a *USA Today* article—‘A Kinder, Gentler Divorce?’—that really grabbed my attention. I read it carefully and came across a phrase I hadn’t heard before: ‘divorce mediation.’ In that article, I learned that divorce mediation helps people divorce without becoming bitter enemies in the process. To me, it definitely sounded like a topic worth exploring. So I went back to the Google search box and typed in ‘divorce mediation’. I began to read them and realized I had struck gold. I’d narrowed the huge topic of ‘divorce’ down to a much more specific one. Now I was beginning to have a focus.”

Encouraged, Sarah returned to Barnes and Noble and asked to see books on “divorce mediation.” That brought up a manageable list of just forty-one books. As Sarah clicked on their titles, she instantly saw on the screen information about those books—the titles and authors, reviews, sometimes even summaries and tables of contents. Reading about those books helped Sarah narrow her focus even further: she decided that her paper would be about the advantages of divorce mediation over traditional divorce. With that idea in mind, she was able to choose ten books that sounded most relevant to her paper. She went to her local library and found six of those books, then bought one more that was available in paperback at a nearby bookstore. (If you find relevant books in your online search that your local library does not own, ask your research librarian if he or she can obtain them from another library through an interlibrary loan program.)

376

However you choose to do your research, the outcome is the same: If books and articles are both available, pursue your topic. Otherwise, you may have to choose another topic. You cannot write a paper on a topic for which research materials are not readily available.

377

Step 2: Limit Your Topic and Make the Purpose of Your Paper Clear

A research paper should *thoroughly* develop a *limited* topic. It should be narrow and deep rather than broad and shallow. Therefore, as you read through books and articles on your general topic, look for ways to limit the topic.

For instance, as Sarah read through materials on the general topic “divorce,” she chose to limit her paper to divorce mediation. Furthermore, she decided to limit it even more by focusing on the advantages of mediated divorce over more traditional adversarial divorce. The general topic “violence in the media” might be narrowed to instances of copycat crimes inspired by movies or TV. After doing some reading on protests against the death penalty, you might decide to limit your paper to cases in which executed people were later proved innocent. The broad subject “learning disabilities” could be reduced to the widespread use of the drug Ritalin or possible causes of dyslexia. “AIDS” might be limited to federal funding to fight the disease; “personal debt” could be narrowed to the process an individual goes through in declaring bankruptcy.

The subject headings in your library’s catalog and periodicals index will give you helpful ideas about how to limit your subject. For example, under the subject heading “Divorce” in the book file at Sarah’s library were titles suggesting many limited directions for research: helping children cope with divorce, cooperative parenting after a divorce, the financial toll of divorce, fathers and custody rights. Under the subject heading “Divorce” in the library’s periodicals index were subheadings and titles of many articles which suggested additional limited topics that a research paper might explore: how women can learn more about family finances in the event of a divorce, how parents can move past their own pain to focus on children’s welfare, becoming a divorce mediator, divorce rates in second marriages. The point is that *subject headings and*

related headings, as well as book and article titles, may be of great help to you in narrowing your topic.
Take advantage of them.

Do not expect to limit your topic and make your purpose clear all at once. You may have to do quite a bit of reading as you work out the limited focus of your paper. Note that many research papers have one of two general purposes. Your purpose might be to make and defend a point of some kind. (For example, your purpose in a paper might be to provide evidence that gambling should be legalized.) Or, depending on the course and the instructor, your purpose might simply be to present information about a particular subject. (For instance, you might be asked to write a paper describing the most recent scientific findings about what happens when we dream.)

Step 3: Gather Information on Your Limited Topic

After you have a good sense of your limited topic, you can begin gathering information that is relevant to it. A helpful way to proceed is to sign out the books that you need from your library. In addition, make copies of all relevant articles from magazines, newspapers, or journals. If your library has an online periodicals database, you may be able to print those articles out.

In other words, take the steps needed to get all your important source materials together in one place. You can then sit and work on these materials in a quiet, unhurried way in your home or some other place of study.

Step 4: Plan Your Paper and Take Notes on Your Limited Topic

Preparing a Scratch Outline

As you carefully read through the material you have gathered, think constantly about the specific content and organization of your paper. Begin making decisions about exactly what information you will present and how you will arrange it. Prepare a scratch outline for your paper that shows both its thesis and the areas of support for the thesis. It may help to try to plan at least three areas of support.

Thesis: _____

Support: 1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Here, for example, is the brief outline that Sarah Hughes prepared for her paper on divorce mediation:

Thesis:

Divorce mediation is an alternative to the painful, expensive process of a traditional divorce.

Support:

1. Saves time and money

2. Produces less hostility

3. Produces more acceptable agreement between ex-spouses

Taking Notes

With a tentative outline in mind, you can begin taking notes on the information that you expect to include in your paper. Write your notes on four- by six-inch or five- by eight-inch cards, on sheets of loose-leaf paper, or in a computer file. The notes you take should be in the form of *direct quotations*, *summaries in your own words*, or both. (At times you may also *paraphrase*—use an equal number of your own words in place of someone else’s words. Since most research involves condensing information, you will summarize much more than you will paraphrase.)

A *direct quotation* must be written *exactly* as it appears in the original work. But as long as you don’t change the meaning, you may omit words from a quotation if they are not relevant to your point. Show such an omission with three bracketed spaced periods (known as an *ellipsis*) in place of the deleted words:



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Original Passage

If you choose to follow the traditional path through this adversarial system, you will each hire lawyers who will fight on your behalf like ancient knights, charging each other with lances. Each knight, highly skilled in the intricacies of jousting but untrained in other ways to resolve conflict, will try to win by seizing for his client as much booty (children and property) as possible.

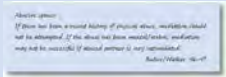
Direct Quotation with Ellipses

“[Y]ou will each hire lawyers who will fight on your behalf like ancient knights, charging each other with lances. Each knight [. . .] will try to win by seizing for his client as much booty (children and property) as possible.”

(Note that the capital letter in brackets shows that the word was capitalized by the student, but did not begin the sentence in the original source. Similarly, the brackets around the three periods indicate that the student inserted these ellipses.)

In a *summary*, you condense the original material by expressing it in your own words. Summaries may be written as lists, as brief paragraphs, or both. Following is one of Sarah Hughes’s summary note cards:

379
380



Keep in mind the following points about your research notes:

- Write on only one side of each card or sheet of paper.
- Write only one kind of information, from one source, on any one card or sheet. For example, the sample card above has information on only one idea (abusive spouse) from one source (Butler/Walker).
- At the top of each card or sheet, write a heading that summarizes its content. This will help you organize the different kinds of information that you gather.
- Identify the source and page number at the bottom.

Whether you quote or summarize, be sure to record the exact source and page from which you take each piece of information. In a research paper, you must document all information that is not common knowledge or a matter of historical record. For example, the birth and death dates of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., are established facts and do not need documenting. On the other hand, the number of adoptions granted to single people in 2006 is a specialized fact that should be documented. As you read several sources on a subject, you will develop a sense of what authors regard as generally shared or common information and what is more specialized information that must be documented.

A Note on Plagiarism



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If you do not document information that is not your own, you will be stealing. The formal term is *plagiarizing*—using someone else’s work as your own, whether you borrow a single idea, a sentence, or an entire essay. Plagiarism is a direct violation of academic ethics; if you pass someone else’s work off as your own, you risk being failed or even expelled. Equally, plagiarism deprives you of what can be a most helpful and organizational experience—researching and writing about a selected topic in detail.

380
381

One example of plagiarism is turning in a friend’s paper as if it is one’s own. Another example is copying an article found in a magazine, newspaper, journal, or on the Internet and turning it in as one’s own.

Keep in mind, too, that while the Internet has made it easier for students to plagiarize, it has also made it riskier. Teachers can easily discover that a student has taken material from an Internet source by typing a sentence or two from the student’s paper into a powerful search engine like Google; that source is then often quickly identified.

With the possibility of plagiarism in mind, then, be sure to take careful, documented notes during your research. Remember that if you use another person's material, *you must acknowledge your source*. When you cite a source properly, you give credit where it is due, you provide your readers with a way to locate the original material on their own, and you demonstrate that your work has been carefully researched.

Step 5: Write the Paper



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After you have finished reading and note-taking, you should have a fairly clear idea of the plan of your paper. Make a *final outline* and use it as a guide to write your first full draft. If your instructor requires an outline as part of your paper, you should prepare either a *topic outline*, which contains your thesis plus supporting words and phrases; or a *sentence outline*, which contains all complete sentences. In the model paper shown on [pages 390–397](#), a topic outline appears on [page 389](#). You will note that roman numerals are used for first-level headings, capital letters for second-level headings, and arabic numerals for third-level headings.

In your *introduction*, include a thesis statement expressing the purpose of your paper and indicate the plan of development that you will follow. The section on writing an introductory paragraph for an essay ([pages 331–333](#)) is also appropriate for the introductory section of a research paper.

As you move from *introduction* to *main body* to *conclusion*, strive for unity, support, and coherence so that your paper will be clear and effective. Repeatedly ask, “Does each of my supporting paragraphs develop the thesis of my paper?” Use the checklist on the inside back cover of this book to make sure that your paper touches all four bases of effective writing.

381

Step 6: Use an Acceptable Format and Method of Documentation

382

Format

The model paper on [pages 390–397](#) shows acceptable formats for a research paper, including the style recommended by the Modern Language Association (MLA). Be sure to note carefully the comments and directions set in small print in the margins of each page.

Documentation of Sources

You must tell the reader the sources (books, articles, and so on) of the borrowed material in your paper. Whether you quote directly or summarize ideas in your own words, you must acknowledge your sources. In the past, you may have used footnotes and a bibliography to cite your sources. Here you will learn a simplified and widely accepted documentation style used by the Modern Language Association.

Citations within a Paper

When citing a source, you must mention the author’s name and the relevant page number. The author’s name may be given either in the sentence you are writing or in parentheses following the sentence. Here are two examples:

Paula James, the author of The Divorce Mediation Handbook, has witnessed the divorce process from both sides—actually, three sides. First, she went through a traditional divorce herself. In her words, “we simply turned our destinies over to our two attorneys. [. . .] Many thousands of dollars later we were divorced, but with resentment and distrust and no idea of how we would jointly raise our child” (xvi).

As the authors of The Divorce Mediation Answer Book say, a mediated agreement is “future focused. In mediation, as contrasted to litigation, each of you is empowered to control your own future, and since you have shared in the negotiation process, you are more likely to abide by the agreement” (Butler and Walker 5).

There are several points to note about citations within the paper:

- When an author’s name is provided within the parentheses, only the last name is given.
 - There is no punctuation between the author’s name and the page number.
 - The parenthetical citation is placed after the borrowed material but before the period at the end of the sentence.
-
- If you are using more than one work by the same author, include a shortened version of the title within the parenthetical citation. For example, suppose you were using two books by Paula James and you included a second quotation from her book *The Divorce Mediation Handbook*. Your citation within the text would be

(James, Handbook 39).

Note that a comma separates the author’s last name from the abbreviated title and page number.

Citations at the End of a Paper

Your paper should end with a list of “Works Cited” which includes all the sources actually used in the paper. (Don’t list any other sources, no matter how many you have read.) Look at “Works Cited” in the model research paper ([page 397](#)) and note the following points:

- The list is organized alphabetically according to the authors’ last names. (If no author is given, the entry is alphabetized by title.) Entries are not numbered.
- Entries are double-spaced, with no extra space between entries.

- After the first line of each entry, there is a half-inch indentation for each additional line in the entry.
- Use the abbreviation *qtd. in* when citing a quotation from another source. For example, a quotation from Lynn Jacob on page 3 of the paper is from a work written not by her but by Ann Field. The citation is therefore handled as follows:

As pointed out by Lynn Jacob, president of the Academy of Family Mediators, “the legal system is designed so that the more the couples fight, the more money the lawyers earn” (qtd. in Field 136).

Model Entries for a List of “Works Cited”

Model entries of “Works Cited” are given below. Use these entries as a guide when you prepare your own list.

Book by One Author

Nuland, Sherwin B. How We Die: Reflections on Life’s Final Chapter. New York: Vintage, 1995.

Note that the author’s last name is written first.

In addition, when citing *any* book, always provide the full title, which you should copy from the inside title page. Include any subtitle by placing a colon after the main title and then copying the subtitle, word for word.

383

384

Two or More Entries by the Same Author

---. The Mysteries Within: A Surgeon Reflects on Medical Myths. New York: Simon & Schuster, 2000.

If you cite two or more entries by the same author (in the example above, a second book by Sherwin B. Nuland is cited), do not repeat the author’s name. Instead, begin with a line made up of three hyphens followed by a period. Then give the remaining information as usual. Arrange the works by the same author alphabetically by title. The words *A*, *An*, and *The* are ignored in alphabetizing by title.

Book by Two or More Authors

Baxandall, Rosalyn, and Elizabeth Ewen. Picture Windows: How the Suburbs Happened. New York: Basic Books, 2000.

For a book with two or more authors, give all the authors’ names but reverse only the first name.

Magazine Article

Chin, Paula. "You Were a Good Man, Charlie Brown." People 28 Feb. 2000: 52–59.

Write the date of the issue as follows: day, month (abbreviated in most cases to three or four letters), and year, followed by a colon. The final number or numbers refer to the pages of the issue on which the article appears.

Newspaper Article

Zoroya, Gregg. "A Hunger for Heroes." USA Today 28 Feb. 2000: D1–2.

The final letter and number refer to pages 1 and 2 of section D.

If the article is not printed on consecutive pages, simply list the first page, followed by a plus sign "+" (in that case, the above example would read "D1+").

In addition, when citing newspaper titles, omit the introductory *The* (for example, *Boston Globe*, not *The Boston Globe*).

Editorial

"Drugs and Preschoolers." Editorial. Philadelphia Inquirer 28 Feb. 2000: A10.

List an editorial as you would any signed or unsigned article, but indicate the nature of the piece by adding *Editorial* or *Letter* after the article's title.

384

385

Selection in an Edited Collection

Feist, Raymond E. "The Wood Boy." Legends: Short Novels by the Masters of Modern Fantasy. Ed. Robert Silverberg. New York: Tor Books, 1998. 176–211.

Revised or Later Edition

Davis, Mark H. Social Psychology. 4th ed. New York: McGraw-Hill, 2000.

Note that the abbreviations *Rev. ed.*, *2nd ed.*, *3rd ed.*, and so on, are placed right after the title.

Chapter or Section in a Book by One Author

Secunda, Victoria. "A New Sense of Family." Losing Your Parents, Finding Yourself: The Defining Turning Point of Adult Life. New York: Hyperion, 2000. 242–59.

Pamphlet

Heart and Stroke Facts. New York: American Heart Association, 2000.

Television Program

“Not As Private As You Think.” 60 Minutes. Narr. Lesley Stahl. Prod. Rome Hartman. CBS. 13 Aug. 2000.

Film

The Departed. Dir. Martin Scorsese. Warner Bros., 2006.

Sound Recording

Mayer, John. “Gravity.” Continuum. Aware Records, 2006.

DVD or Videocassette

“To the Moon.” Nova. Narr. Liev Schrieber. Videocassette. PBS Video, 1999.

Personal Interview

Anderson, Robert B. Personal interview. 17 Sept. 2000.

385

Article in a Reference Database

“Heredity.” Britannica Online. Sept. 1999. Encyclopaedia Britannica. 2 Mar. 2007
<<http://www.britannica.com/bcom/eb/article/4/0,5716,120934,00.html#Article>>.

The first date (Sept. 2006) refers to the online publication date; the second date (2 Mar. 2007) refers to the exact day when the student researcher accessed the information and should *not* be followed by a period.

386

Article in an Online Magazine

Ehrenreich, Barbara. “Will Women Still Need Men?” Time Online 21 Feb. 2000. 15 Apr. 2008
<http://www.time.com/time/reports/v21/live/men_mag.html>.

Article in Web site

“Being Chased.” *Dreams and Nightmares*. Internet Resources. 2003. 17 Mar. 2007
<<http://www.dreamnightmares.com/chasedindreams.html>>.

No author is given, so the article is cited first, followed by the title of the Web site (*Dreams and Nightmares*) and the sponsor of the Web site (Internet Resources). The first date (2003) refers to when the material was electronically published, updated, or posted; the second date (17 Mar. 2007) refers to when the student researcher accessed the source.

Electronic Mail (E-Mail) Posting

Graham, Vanessa. “Teenager Problems.” E-mail to Sonya Philips. 12 Apr. 2007.

Activity 1

On a separate sheet of paper, convert the information in each of the following references into the correct form for a list of “Works Cited.” Use the appropriate model above as a guide.

1. An article by Alex Yannis titled “In New League, Women Get Payoff and Payday” on page D5 of the April 13, 2001 issue of the *New York Times*.
2. An article by Nancy Franklin titled “Nonsense and Sensibility” on pages 96–97 of the March 6, 2000 issue of the *New Yorker*.
3. A book by Francis McInerney and Sean White called *Futurewealth: Investing in the Second Great Wave of Technology* and published in New York by St. Martin’s in 2000.
4. A book by Ellen N. Junn and Chris Boyatzis titled *Child Growth and Development* and published in a seventh edition by McGraw-Hill in New York in 2000.
5. An article by Melinda Liu and Leila Abboud titled “Generation Superpower” dated April 11, 2001 and found on April 12, 2007 at <<http://www.msnbc.com/news/557986.asp>> in the online version of *Newsweek*.



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386

387

387

Model Paper

While the *MLA Handbook* does not require a title page or an outline for a paper, your instructor may ask you to include one or both. Here is a model title page.

Option 1: Model Title Page

The title should begin about one-third of the way down the page. Center the title. Double-space between lines of the title and your name. Also center and double-space the instructor's name and the date.

Divorce Mediation: A Better Alternative
by
Sarah Hughes
English 101
Professor Martinez
8 March 2007

Papers written in MLA style use the simple format shown below. There is no title page or outline.

Option 2: Model First Page with Top Heading

Double-space between lines. Leave a one-inch margin on all sides.

1 inch
Sarah Hughes
Professor Martinez
English 101
8 March 2007

½ inch
Hughes 1

Divorce Mediation: A Better Alternative

Divorce is never easy. Even if two people both want to part, ending a marriage is a painful experience. In order to become divorced, most people go through a process that increases this pain. Starting with the lawsuit that one partner has to file against the other, the two take on the roles of enemies. . . .

Use this format if your instructor asks you to submit an outline of your paper.

389

Hughes i

Outline

Thesis: Divorce mediation offers several advantages over the traditional process of divorce.

- I. Introduction
 - A. Traditional divorce
 1. Casts divorcing couple in the role of enemies
 2. Expensive and painful
 - B. Mediation
 1. Description of mediation process
 2. Growing popularity of mediation
- II. Advantages of mediation in terms of money and time
 - A. Traditional divorce
 1. Lawyers' fees charged for every step
 2. Lawyers' and courts' involvement slows process down
 - B. Mediation
 1. Mediators' fees lower than lawyers'
 2. Couple controls costs of case
 3. Mediated divorces completed more quickly
- III. Emotional benefits of mediation
 - A. Traditional divorce
 1. Pits clients against one another
 2. Produces hostility and distrust
 - B. Mediation encourages clients to work cooperatively
- IV. Advantages of mediation in terms of divorce agreement
 - A. Traditional divorce leaves clients with attorney-negotiated agreement that may not work well for them
 - B. Mediation creates agreement that both clients can live with
- V. Who shouldn't use mediation
- VI. Conclusion

Model Outline Page

After the title page, number all pages in upper-right corner—a half-inch from the top. Place your name before the page number. Use lowercase Roman numerals on outline pages. Use arabic numbers on pages following the outline.

The word *Outline* (without underlining or quotation marks) is centered one inch from the top. Double-space between lines. Leave a one-inch margin on all sides.

Here is a full model paper. It assumes that the writer has included a title page.

389

390

Double-space between lines of the text. Leave a one-inch margin all the way around the page. Your name and the page number should be typed one-half inch from the top of the page.

Source is identified by name.

Direct quotations of five typed lines or more are indented ten spaces from the left margin. Quotation marks are not used.

The bracketed spaced periods (ellipsis) show that material from the original source has been omitted.

Only the page number is needed, as the author has already been named in the text.

Thesis, followed by plan of development.

Citation for a signed newspaper article. The letter and number refer to section B, page 7.

Hughes 1

Divorce Mediation: A Better Alternative

Divorce is never easy. Even if two people both want to break up, ending a marriage is a painful experience. In order to become divorced, most people go through a process that increases this pain. Starting with the lawsuit that one partner files against the other, the two take on the roles of enemies. As author Paula James describes it,

You will each hire lawyers who will fight on your behalf like ancient knights, charging each other with lances. Each knight [...] will try to win by seizing for his client as much booty (children and property) as possible. You will stand on the sidelines wringing your hands while you watch the battle—and, of course, pay your knight a high hourly fee. One peculiarity of this battle is that the wounds inflicted don't appear on the other warrior; they appear on you, your spouse, and your children. (3)

But there is an alternative to this traditional, ugly divorce process. It is called divorce mediation. Couples who use divorce mediation find that it saves them time and money, it produces less hostility, and it leaves them with an agreement they can respect.

What is divorce mediation? According to a 1997 article in USA Today, it is a process in which "the couple, rather than a judge, decides who gets the kids, the house, the cars, and other marital assets. The mediator serves as coach, counselor, consensus builder and occasional referee" (Valente B7). That mediator, who is usually a lawyer or a therapist, helps the couple hammer out a divorce agreement they both find acceptable. This is done in as few or as many meetings as necessary. Each spouse will probably hire a personal lawyer to review the agreement

Hughes 2

before it is made final. But the spouses, not “hired gun” lawyers, are responsible for creating it. During the process, the mediator doesn’t favor one partner over the other. Instead, the mediator maintains, in the words of the lawyer and mediator Gary Friedman, an attitude of “positive neutrality.” Friedman explains the term by saying, “While I am largely neutral as to outcome [. . .] I am not neutral as to process. On the contrary, I am actively engaged in trying to ensure that each party takes responsibility for him- or herself, and making sure that all decisions are sound for both of them” (26).

Once the couple is satisfied with the agreement, it is filed in court and approved by a judge in a brief hearing. In many states, the couple does not even need to attend that hearing. Couples can thus complete a divorce without ever seeing the inside of a courtroom.

There are no official statistics to tell how many divorcing couples use mediation, but it is definitely becoming a popular option. According to the Academy of Family Mediators in Boston, the number of mediators has jumped in recent years from just 100 to over 3,600 (Valente B7). And courts in twenty-five states now require couples involved in child-custody disputes to work with a mediator (Field 136).

One practical advantage of mediation is that it is less expensive and less time-consuming. In a traditional divorce, after each partner retains a lawyer and sets the divorce machine in motion, costs mount up quickly. A lawyer’s fee “may range from \$125 to \$500 per hour [. . .] for each spouse” (“Avoiding the War”). The lawyers bill their clients for every phone call made, every letter written, every hearing attended, every meeting held to iron out another wrinkle in the process. In addition, when people divorce,

Source is identified by name and area of expertise

This typical citation is made up of the author’s last name and the relevant page number. “Works Cited” then provides full information about the source.

Citation for an online source. No page number is given because the online document does not provide one.

Hughes 3

they must make decisions about countless details. Even if the spouses are not far apart in their thinking, those decisions take time. If the husband and wife are deeply divided, the bills can become staggering. According to Field, "An uncontested, amiable divorce may cost \$5,000 per partner and drag on for more than a year. [...] A warring duo [...] could wind up spending \$30,000 apiece, and the case might span an entire Presidential administration" (136). The couple's financial welfare is not the top concern of courts and attorneys. As pointed out by Lynn Jacob, president of the Academy of Family Mediators, "the legal system is designed so that the more the couples fight, the more money the lawyers earn" (qtd. in Field 136).

The abbreviation *qtd.* means *quoted*. The quoted material is not capitalized because the student has blended it into a sentence with an introductory phrase.

Quotation marks acknowledge that the phrase is copied from the previous citation.

By contrast, mediation costs are far more reasonable. Most mediators charge between \$100 and \$350 an hour (Friedman 19). Because both spouses are present for all mediating sessions, they are in control of how high the costs mount. Although there is no "typical" divorce, it is clear that mediated divorces tend to be much less expensive than others. In Friedman's experience, a mediated divorce in which there is "substantial disagreement" costs between \$2,000 and \$5,000 (19). Ken Waldron, a mediator with the Madison (Wisconsin) Center for Divorce Mediation, estimates that most mediated divorces end up costing one-half to one-third less than an attorney-negotiated divorce (Schuetz 10). Mediator Paula James describes mediated divorces as costing "a fraction" of attorney-negotiated ones (60).

Second, mediated divorces are finalized much more quickly than divorces fought out in the courts. Couples divorcing in the traditional way spend a long time going through the following cycle: meet with attorney,

Hughes 4

wait for attorney to talk with spouse's attorney, wait for spouse's attorney to talk with spouse, wait for spouse's attorney to return with response. Mediating couples don't have to do any of that. They also don't have the ordeal of endless hearings, court delays, and their attorneys' own schedule problems. Mediating couples can do a large part of the work of their divorce agreement outside their meetings with the mediator. Most mediating couples really want to get their agreement finished, for both financial and emotional reasons. Because they have the guidance of a professional to help them work through difficult points, they tend to work efficiently. According to an article by Meg Lundstrum in Business Week, most mediated divorces are completed in four to eight sessions, or six to twenty-four hours (228). Gary Friedman's estimate is about the same: four to six meetings spaced over a period of two to three months (18). A typical mediation center advertising online, Divorce Solutions of New York, N.Y., says, "The entire divorce process takes approximately 2–3 months, as opposed to 2–3 years in the adversarial process" ("Mediation: How It Works").

Citation for an
online source.

A third important point is that mediated divorces leave less hostility behind them. It's true that a divorce produces feelings of grief, anger, and frustration for almost everyone. But mediation can help people deal with these feelings. By contrast, an attorney-fought divorce seems designed to make the splitting partners hate each other as much as possible. Before she wrote The Divorce Mediation Handbook, Paula James had witnessed the divorce process from both sides—actually, three sides. First, she went through a traditional divorce herself. In her words, "we simply turned our destinies over to our two attorneys. [. . .] Many thousands of dollars later

Hughes 5

we were divorced, but with resentment and distrust and no idea of how we would jointly raise our child" (xvi).

Later, James became an attorney herself and represented clients in traditional divorces. She describes how she and her colleagues routinely dug for dirt about possible affairs, alcohol abuse, shady business dealings, child neglect, and any other personal weaknesses they could use as ammunition in court. By the end of such an ordeal, she writes, couples were "deeply in debt, very angry, and distrustful of one another" (10).

Finally, James began working as a divorce mediator. As a mediator she works with many clients who may no longer be the best of friends but who want to remain on decent terms with their ex-spouses, for their own sake as well as for the sake of any children. One such client, Terri, expressed the feelings of many people who want a mediated divorce. She called James after having talked with an attorney. Terri was horrified by the attorney's fee (\$5,000 to start) and what he told her. "He said that Eli and I are now adversaries, that I must do everything I can to protect myself from him and to get as much money as possible . . .," Terri said. "That's not what I want. I'm sorry that our marriage hasn't worked out, but I'm not trying to take Eli to the cleaners" (10). Terri and Eli then started working with James. By listening carefully to them both, and stepping in occasionally to help them explain their fears and priorities rather than attack one another, James helped Terri and Eli work out an agreement in a short time and for a reasonable fee. "They left my office looking more relaxed than when they had entered," she reported (15). According to the Divorce Law Information Service Center's home page, "In family law disputes, mediation is often preferred over litigation because it facilitates

Single quotation marks are used for a quotation within a quotation.

Hughes 6

future communication between the parties which is necessary when the future of the children is at stake.”

In the long run, the biggest advantage of mediated divorce is that it helps couples develop an agreement they will be willing to live with. As the authors of The Divorce Mediation Answer Book say, a mediated agreement is “future focused. In mediation, as contrasted to litigation, each of you is empowered to control your own future, and since you have shared in the negotiation process, you are more likely to abide by the agreement” (Butler and Walker 5). Attorney-negotiated agreements tend to fall into rigid, traditional patterns: she gets the house; he gets the car; the kids spend every other weekend and six weeks in the summer with him. But mediated agreements are generally more creative and in tune with the divorcing couple’s lives. One couple described in the Cosmopolitan article, Vivian and Bill, had been fighting bitterly over the mail-order business they had built together. Each insisted that he or she should take over the business entirely.

Without lawyers, judges, or formal courtroom rules to get in the way, the mediator got Vivian and Bill to agree on a general plan whereby one spouse would keep the business, buy out the other, and lend him or her enough money to start a new venture. Then he instructed them to calculate their company’s net worth. Finally, the material helped them realize on their own that Vivian, who’d had more contact with overseas suppliers, should keep the business; Bill, who was more aggressive, would do better taking the loan and launching a new product line. (Field 137)

Quoted from
an online
source. Since
the source has
been named
in the text, no
further citation
is necessary.

Hughes 7

Brackets indicate that the words inside them were supplied by the student and did not appear in the original source.

Once they are used to the idea, most couples like the idea of creating an agreement that really works for them. In the words of Paula James, “[The divorcing couple] aren’t ignorant children who must be silenced while their lawyers do the talking” (xvii).

Although mediation has clear advantages, it is not right for everyone. Most mediation experts agree with Butler and Walker, who say that mediation “would not be an appropriate way to negotiate a fair settlement” if one of the divorcing partners feels unable or too frightened to stand up to the other. Examples are situations characterized by “intimidation or fear of violence,” “a recent history of domestic violence or child abuse,” or “severe intellectual or emotional limitations” (6). In such cases, it is probably best for the weaker partner if an attorney does his or her negotiating.

The conclusion provides a summary and restates the thesis.

In conclusion, while divorce is never a pleasant experience, divorce mediation can save a couple time and money, help them keep a civil relationship, and produce an agreement that they both feel is reasonable. According to the Academy of Family Mediators, 70 to 90 percent of couples are satisfied with the terms of their mediated divorces (Lundstrum 228). This high figure shows that mediation is a more civilized and respectful way to achieve a divorce than the traditional courtroom method.

A mediating couple, Sam and Jane, said it best:

[Sam said,] “I really do appreciate your help. This was a lot easier than I thought it would be.”

Jane smiled. “We both thought we were going to end up in a huge fight. Doing it this way was so much better.” (Qtd. in James xi)

Hughes 8

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Works cited should be double-spaced. Titles of books, magazines, and the like should be underlined.

Include the date you accessed a Web source—in this case, February 18, 2007.



What is confusing about these signs? How could you change their wording or appearance to keep each one's message consistent and coherent?

[Sentence-Skills Diagnostic Test](#)

[SECTION 1: Grammar](#)

[21: Subjects and Verbs](#)

[22: Sentence Sense](#)

[23: Fragments](#)

[24: Run-Ons](#)

[25: Standard English Verbs](#)

[26: Irregular Verbs](#)

[27: Subject-Verb Agreement](#)

[28: Pronoun Agreement and Reference](#)

[29: Pronoun Types](#)

[30: Adjectives and Adverbs](#)

[31: Misplaced and Dangling Modifiers](#)

[SECTION 2: Mechanics](#)

[32: Paper Format](#)

[33: Capital Letters](#)

[34: Numbers and Abbreviations](#)

[SECTION 3: Punctuation](#)

[35: Apostrophes](#)

[36: Quotation Marks](#)

[37: Commas](#)

[38: Other Punctuation Marks](#)

[SECTION 4: Word Use](#)

[39: Using the Dictionary](#)

[40: Improving Spelling](#)

[41: Vocabulary Development](#)

[42: Commonly Confused Words](#)

[43: Effective Word Choice](#)

[44: ESL Pointers](#)

[SECTION 5: Practice](#)

[45: Combined Mastery Tests](#)

[46: Editing Tests](#)

[*Sentence-Skills Achievement Test*](#)

Sentence-Skills Diagnostic Test**Part 1**www.mhhe.com/langan

This test will help you check your knowledge of important sentence skills. Certain parts of the following word groups are underlined. Write X in the answer space if you think a mistake appears at the underlined part. Write C in the answer space if you think the underlined part is correct.

A series of headings (“Fragments,” “Run-Ons,” and so on) will give you clues to the mistakes to look for. However, you do not have to understand the label to find a mistake. What you are checking is your own sense of effective written English.

Fragments

- _____ 1. Until his mother called him twice. Barry did not get out of bed. He had stayed up too late the night before.
- _____ 2. After I slid my aching bones into the hot water of the tub, I realized there was no soap. I didn't want to get out again.
- _____ 3. Mother elephants devote much of their time to child care. Nursing their babies up to eight years.
- _____ 4. Sweating under his heavy load. Brian staggered up the stairs to his apartment. He felt as though his legs were crumbling beneath him.
- _____ 5. I love to eat and cook Italian food, especially lasagna and ravioli. I make everything from scratch.
- _____ 6. One of my greatest joys in life is eating desserts. Such as blueberry cheesecake and vanilla cream puffs. Almond fudge cake makes me want to dance.

Run-Ons

- _____ 7. He decided to stop smoking, for he didn't want to die of lung cancer.
- _____ 8. The window shade snapped up like a gunshot her cat leaped four feet off the floor.
- _____ 9. Billy is the meanest little kid on his block, he eats only the heads of animal crackers.
- _____ 10. He knew he had flunked the driver's exam, he ran over a stop sign.
- _____ 11. My first boyfriend was five years old. We met every day in the playground sandbox.

- _____ 12. The store owner watched the shopper carefully, she suspected him of stealing from her before.

400

Standard English Verbs

401

- _____ 13. Jed tows cars away for a living and is ashamed of his job.
- _____ 14. You snored like a chain saw last night.
- _____ 15. When I was about to finish work last night, a man walk into the restaurant and ordered two dozen hamburgers.
- _____ 16. Charlotte react badly whenever she gets caught in a traffic jam.

Irregular Verbs

- _____ 17. I gived a twenty-dollar bill to the cashier and waited for my change.
- _____ 18. I had eaten so much food at the buffet dinner that I went into the bathroom just to loosen my belt.
- _____ 19. When the mud slide started, the whole neighborhood began going downhill.
- _____ 20. Juan has rode the bus to school for two years while saving for a car.

Subject-Verb Agreement

- _____ 21. There is long lines at the checkout counter.
- _____ 22. The little girl have a painful ear infection.
- _____ 23. One of the crooked politicians was jailed for a month.
- _____ 24. The cockroaches behind my stove gets high on Raid.

Consistent Verb Tense

- _____ 25. My brother and I played video games for an hour before we start to do homework.
- _____ 26. The first thing Jerry does every day is weigh himself. The scale informs him what kind of meals he can eat that day.
- _____ 27. Sandy eats a nutritional breakfast, skips lunch, and then enjoys a big dinner.
- _____ 28. His parents stayed together for his sake; only after he graduates from college were they divorced.

Pronoun Agreement, Reference, and Point of View

- _____ 29. I get my hair cut by a barber who talks to you constantly.
- _____ 30. I enjoy movies, like *The Return of the Vampire*, that frighten me.

_____ 31. Every guest at the party dressed like their favorite cartoon character.

401

_____ 32. Persons camping in those woods should watch their step because of wild dogs.

402

_____ 33. Angry because he had struck out, Tony hurled the baseball bat at the fence and broke it.

_____ 34. I love hot peppers, but they do not always agree with me.

Pronoun Types

_____ 35. Alfonso and me take turns driving to work.

_____ 36. No one is a better cook than she.

Adjectives and Adverbs

_____ 37. Bonnie ran quick up the steps, taking them two at a time.

_____ 38. Larry is more better than I am at darts.

Misplaced Modifiers

_____ 39. He swatted the wasp that stung him with a newspaper.

_____ 40. Charlotte returned the hamburger that was spoiled to the supermarket.

_____ 41. Jamal test-drove a car at the dealership with power windows and a sunroof.

_____ 42. I adopted a dog from a junkyard which is very close to my heart.

Dangling Modifiers

_____ 43. Tapping a pencil on the table, Ms. Garcia asked for the students' attention.

_____ 44. Flunking out of school, my parents demanded that I get a job.

_____ 45. While I was waiting for the bus, rain began to fall.

_____ 46. Braking the car suddenly, the shopping bags tumbled onto the floor.

Faulty Parallelism

_____ 47. Jeff enjoys hunting for rabbits, socializing with friends, and to read the comics.

_____ 48. The recipe instructed me to chop onions, to peel carrots, and to boil a pot of water.

_____ 49. When I saw my roommate with my girlfriend, I felt worried, angry, and embarrassment as well.

_____ 50. Jackie enjoys shopping for new clothes, surfing the Internet, and walking her dog.

402

Capital Letters

403

- _____ 51. After being out in a cold drizzling rain, I looked forward to a bowl of campbell's soup for lunch.
- _____ 52. During july, Frank's company works a four-day week.
- _____ 53. A woman screamed, "He's stolen my purse!"
- _____ 54. On Summer days I will drink glass after glass of lemonade.

Apostrophe

- _____ 55. The Wolfman's bite is worse than his bark.
- _____ 56. Clydes quick hands reached out to break his son's fall.
- _____ 57. I'll be with you shortly if youll just wait a minute.
- _____ 58. We didn't leave the rude waiter any tip.

Quotation Marks

- _____ 59. Mark Twain once said, "The more I know about human beings, the more I like my dog."
- _____ 60. Say something tender to me, "whispered Tony to Lola."
- _____ 61. "I hate that commercial, he muttered."
- _____ 62. "If you don't leave soon," he warned, "you'll be late for work."

Comma

- _____ 63. My favorite sandwich includes turkey tomatoes lettuce and mayonnaise on whole-wheat bread.
- _____ 64. Although I have a black belt in karate I decided to go easy on the demented bully who had kicked sand in my face.
- _____ 65. All the tree branches, which were covered with ice, glittered like diamonds.
- _____ 66. We could always tell when our instructor felt disorganized for his shirt would not be tucked into his pants.
- _____ 67. Dogs, according to most cat lovers, are inferior pets.
- _____ 68. His father shouted "Why don't you go out and get a job?"

Commonly Confused Words

- _____ 69. The best way to prevent colds and flu is to wash you're hands several times a day.
- _____ 70. Since he's lost weight, most of Max's clothes are to big for him.

403

404

- _____ 71. They're planning to trade in their old car.
- _____ 72. Its important to get this job done properly.
- _____ 73. Will you except this job if it's offered to you, or keep looking for something better?
- _____ 74. Who's the culprit who left the paint can on the table?

Effective Word Choice

- _____ 75. Because the school was flooded, the dance had to be postponed until a later date.
- _____ 76. The movie was a real bomb, so we left early.
- _____ 77. The victims of the car accident were shaken but none the worse for wear.
- _____ 78. Anne is of the opinion that the death penalty should be abolished.

See [Appendix A](#) for answers.

Part 2 (Optional)

Do Part 2 at your instructor's request. This second part of the test will provide more detailed information about skills you need to know. On a separate piece of paper, number and correct all the items you have marked with an X. For example, suppose you had marked the following word groups with an X. (Note that these examples are not taken from the test.)

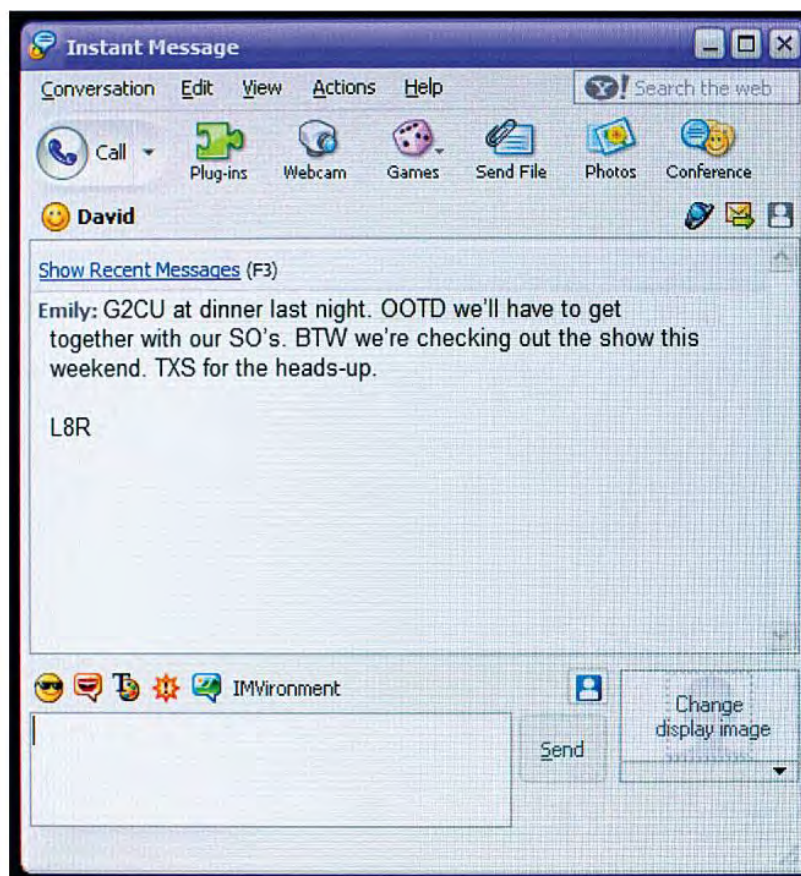
4. If football games disappeared entirely from television. I would not even miss them. Other people in my family would perish.
7. The kitten suddenly saw her reflection in the mirror, she jumped back in surprise.
15. I wanted to get close enough to see the tag on the stray dogs collar.
29. When we go out to a restaurant we always order something we would not cook for ourselves.

Here is how you should write your corrections on a separate sheet of paper.

4. television, I
7. mirror, and
15. dog's
29. restaurant, we

There are more than forty corrections to make in all.

SECTION 2: Mechanics



Abbreviations are the norm in instant messages and text messages, as shown above. But are these abbreviations appropriate in your college papers? Why or why not?

[32: Paper Format](#)

[33: Capital Letters](#)

[34: Numbers and Abbreviations](#)

SECTION 3: Punctuation



How does each of the signs above misuse punctuation, and how could you correct the errors? Have you seen similar mistakes in signs posted on campus? On the road? In a newspaper or book?

[35: Apostrophes](#)

[36: Quotation Marks](#)

[37: Commas](#)

[38: Other Punctuation Marks](#)

SECTION 4: Word Use



Can you find the error on the piece of candy above? Can you guess which chapter in this section might cover such an error?

[39: Using the Dictionary](#)

[40: Improving Spelling](#)

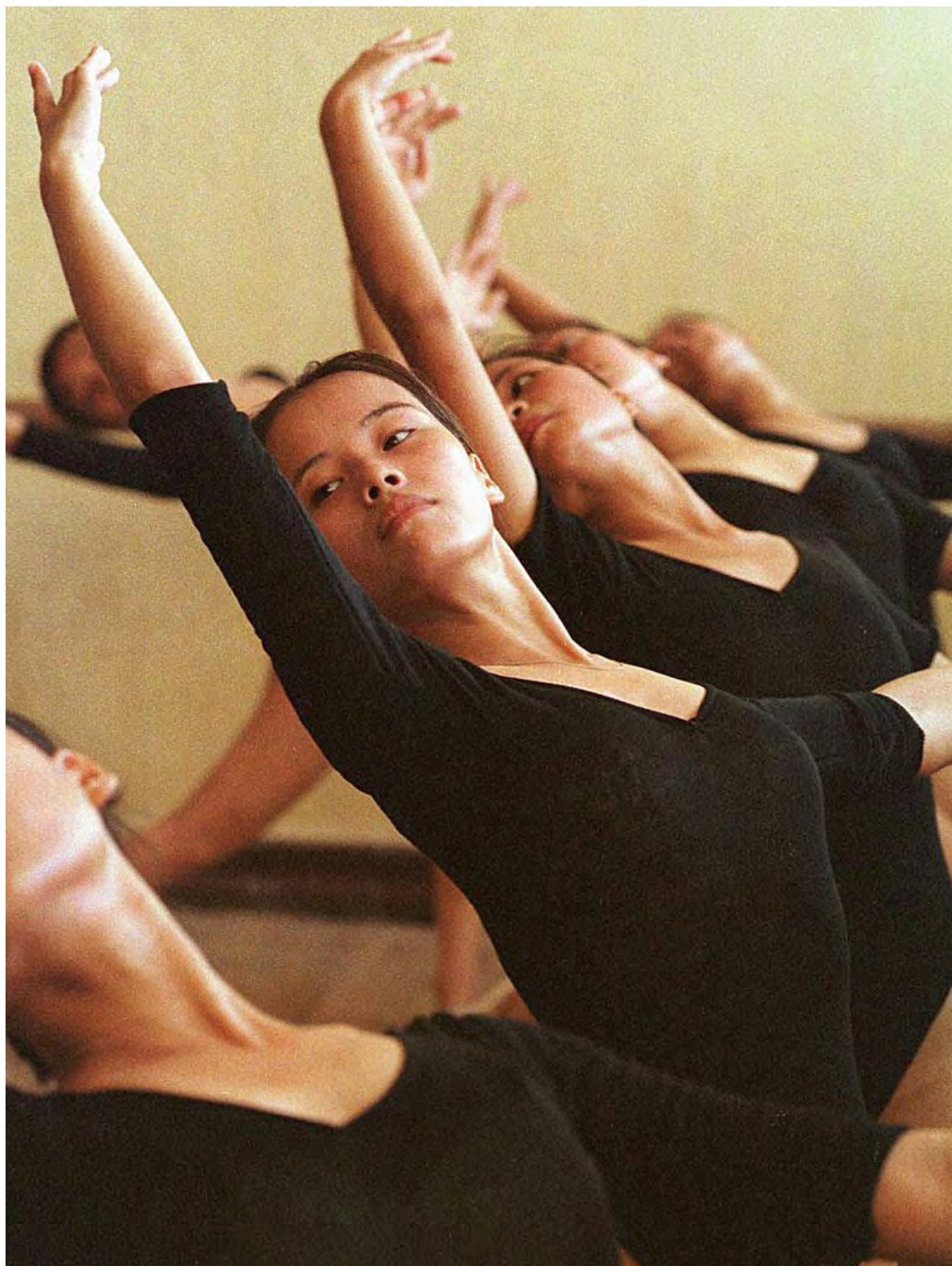
[41: Vocabulary Development](#)

[42: Commonly Confused Words](#)

[43: Effective Word Choice](#)

[44: ESL Pointers](#)

SECTION 5: Practice



Think of a time in your life when practice paid off and write a narrative paragraph about the experience. You may want to review [Chapter 15](#), “Narration.”

[45: Combined Mastery Tests](#)

[46: Editing Tests](#)

[*Sentence-Skills Achievement Test*](#)

PART 6: Readings for Writers



What do you notice about the student in the photograph above? Although surrounded by books, he seems to need only his computer. Will computers and the Internet ever replace the need for printed books? Think about this question and write a response.

[*Introduction to the Readings*](#)

[Goals and Values](#)

[Education and Self-Improvement](#)

[Human Groups and Society](#)

Introduction to the Readings

The reading selections in Part Six will help you find topics for writing. Some of the selections provide helpful practical information. For example, you’ll learn how to discuss problems openly with others and how to avoid being manipulated by clever ads. Other selections deal with thought-provoking aspects of contemporary life. One article, for instance, dramatizes in a vivid and painful way the tragedy that can result when teenagers drink and drive. Still other selections are devoted to a celebration of human goals and values; one essay, for example, reminds us of the power that praise and appreciation can have in our daily lives. The varied subjects should inspire lively class discussions as well as serious individual thought. The selections should also provide a continuing source of high-interest material for a wide range of writing assignments.

The selections serve another purpose as well. They will help you develop reading skills that will directly benefit you as a writer. First, through close reading, you will learn how to recognize the main idea or point of a selection and how to identify and evaluate the supporting material that develops the main idea. In your writing, you will aim to achieve the same essential structure: an overall point followed by detailed, valid support for that point. Second, close reading will help you explore a selection and its possibilities thoroughly. The more you understand about what is said in a piece, the more ideas and feelings you may have about writing on an assigned topic or a related topic of your own. A third benefit of close reading is becoming more aware of authors’ stylistic devices—for example, their introductions and conclusions, their ways of presenting and developing a point, their use of transitions, their choice of language to achieve a particular tone. Recognizing these devices in other people’s writing will help you enlarge your own range of writing techniques.

The Format of Each Selection

Each selection begins with a short overview that gives helpful background information. The selection is then followed by two sets of questions.

- First, there are ten reading comprehension questions to help you measure your understanding of the material. These questions involve several important reading skills: understanding vocabulary in context, recognizing a subject or topic, determining the thesis or main idea, identifying key supporting points, and making inferences. Answering the questions will enable you and your instructor to check quickly your basic understanding of a selection. More significantly, as you move from one selection to the next, you will sharpen your reading skills as well as strengthen your thinking skills—two key factors in making you a better writer.
- Following the comprehension questions are several discussion questions. In addition to dealing with content, these questions focus on structure, style, and tone.

624

625

Finally, several writing assignments accompany each selection. Many of the assignments provide guidelines on how to proceed, including suggestions for pre-writing and appropriate methods of development. When writing your responses to the readings, you will have opportunities to apply all the methods of development presented in Part Two of this book.

How to Read Well: Four General Steps

Skillful reading is an important part of becoming a skillful writer. Following are four steps that will make you a better reader—both of the selections here and in your reading at large.

1 Concentrate as You Read

To improve your concentration, follow these tips. First, read in a place where you can be quiet and alone. Don't choose a spot where a TV or stereo is on or where friends or family are talking nearby. Next, sit in an upright position when you read. If your body is in a completely relaxed position, sprawled across a bed or nestled in an easy chair, your mind is also going to be completely relaxed. The light muscular tension that comes from sitting upright in a chair promotes concentration and keeps your mind ready to work. Finally, consider using your index finger (or a pen) as a pacer while you read. Lightly underline each line of print with your index finger as you read down a page. Hold your hand slightly above the page and move your finger at a speed that is a little too fast for comfort. This pacing with your index finger, like sitting upright in a chair, creates a slight physical tension that will keep your body and mind focused and alert.

2 Skim Material before You Read it

In skimming, you spend about two minutes rapidly surveying a selection, looking for important points and skipping secondary material. Follow this sequence when skimming:

- Begin by reading the overview that precedes the selection.
- Then study the title of the selection for a few moments. A good title is the shortest possible summary of a selection; it often tells you in several words what a selection is about.
- Next, form a basic question (or questions) out of the title. Forming questions out of the title is often a key to locating a writer's main idea—your next concern in skimming.
- Read the first two or three paragraphs and the last two or three paragraphs in the selection. Very often a writer's main idea, *if* it is directly stated, will appear in one of these paragraphs and will relate to the title.
- Finally, look quickly at the rest of the selection for other clues to important points. Are there any subheads you can relate in some way to the title? Are there any words the author has decided to emphasize by setting them off in *italic* or **boldface** type? Are there any major lists of items signaled by words such as *first*, *second*, *also*, *another*, and so on?

625

626

3 Read the Selection Straight Through with a Pen Nearby

Don't slow down or turn back; just aim to understand as much as you can the first time through. Place a check or star beside answers to basic questions you formed from the title, and beside other ideas that seem important. Number lists of important points 1, 2, 3, . . . Circle words you don't understand. Put question marks in the margin next to passages that are unclear and that you will want to reread.

4 Work with the Material

Go back and reread passages that were not clear the first time through. Look up words that block your understanding of ideas, and write their meanings in the margin. Also, reread carefully the areas you identified as most important; doing so will enlarge your understanding of the material. Now that you have a sense of the whole, prepare a short outline of the selection by answering the following questions on a sheet of paper:

- What is the main idea?
- What key points support the main idea?
- What seem to be other important points in the selection?

By working with the material in this way, you will significantly increase your understanding of a selection. Effective reading, just like effective writing, does not happen all at once. Rather, it is a process. Often you begin with a general impression of what something means, and then, by working at it, you move to a deeper level of understanding of the material.

626
627

How to Answer the Comprehension Questions: Specific Hints



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Several important reading skills are involved in the ten reading comprehension questions that follow each selection. The skills are

- Understanding vocabulary in context
- Summarizing the selection by providing a title for it
- Determining the main idea
- Recognizing key supporting details
- Making inferences

The following hints will help you apply each of these reading skills:

- **Vocabulary in context.** To decide on the meaning of an unfamiliar word, consider its context. Ask yourself, “Are there any clues in the sentence that suggest what this word means?”
- **Subject or title.** Remember that the title should accurately describe the *entire* selection. It should be neither too broad nor too narrow for the material in the selection. It should answer the question “What is this about?” as specifically as possible. Note that you may at times find it easier to do the “title” question *after* the “main idea” question.

- **Main idea.** Choose the statement that you think best expresses the main idea or thesis of the entire selection. Remember that the title will often help you focus on the main idea. Then ask yourself, “Does most of the material in the selection support this statement?” If you can answer *Yes* to this question, you have found the thesis.
- **Key details.** If you were asked to give a two-minute summary of a selection, the major details are the ones you would include in that summary. To determine the key details, ask yourself, “What are the major supporting points for the thesis?”
- **Inferences.** Answer these questions by drawing on the evidence presented in the selection and on your own common sense. Ask yourself, “What reasonable judgments can I make on the basis of the information in the selection?”

On [page 773](#) is a chart on which you can keep track of your performance as you answer the ten questions for each selection. The chart will help you identify reading skills you may need to strengthen.

Goals and Values

All the Good Things: Sister Helen Mrosla

PREVIEW



Sometimes the smallest things we do have the biggest impact. A teacher's impulsive idea, designed to brighten a dull Friday-afternoon class, affected her students more than she ever dreamed. Sister Helen Mrosla's moment of classroom inspiration took on a life of its own, returning to visit her at a most unexpected time. Her account of the experience reminds us of the human heart's endless hunger for recognition and appreciation.

- 1 He was in the first third-grade class I taught at Saint Mary's School in Morris, Minnesota. All thirty-four of my students were dear to me, but Mark Eklund was one in a million. He was very neat in appearance but had that happy-to-be-alive attitude that made even his occasional mischievousness delightful.
- 2 Mark talked incessantly. I had to remind him again and again that talking without permission was not acceptable. What impressed me so much, though, was his sincere response every time I had to correct him for misbehaving—"Thank you for correcting me, Sister!" I didn't know what to make of it at first, but before long I became accustomed to hearing it many times a day.
- 3 One morning my patience was growing thin when Mark talked once too often, and then I made a novice teacher's mistake. I looked at him and said, "If you say one more word, I am going to tape your mouth shut!"

- 4 It wasn't ten seconds later when Chuck blurted out, "Mark is talking again." I hadn't asked any of the students to help me watch Mark, but since I had stated the punishment in front of the class, I had to act on it.
- 5 I remember the scene as if it had occurred this morning. I walked to my desk, very deliberately opened my drawer, and took out a roll of masking tape. Without saying a word, I proceeded to Mark's desk, tore off two pieces of tape and made a big X with them over his mouth. I then returned to the front of the room. As I glanced at Mark to see how he was doing, he winked at me.
- 6 That did it! I started laughing. The class cheered as I walked back to Mark's desk, removed the tape, and shrugged my shoulders. His first words were, "Thank you for correcting me, Sister."
- 7 At the end of the year I was asked to teach junior-high math. The years flew by, and before I knew it Mark was in my classroom again. He was more handsome than ever and just as polite. Since he had to listen carefully to my instruction in the "new math," he did not talk as much in ninth grade as he had talked in the third.
- 8 One Friday, things just didn't feel right. We had worked hard on a new concept all week, and I sensed that the students were frowning, frustrated with themselves—and edgy with one another. I had to stop this crankiness before it got out of hand. So I asked them to list the names of the other students in the room on two sheets of paper, leaving a space after each name. Then I told them to think of the nicest thing they could say about each of their classmates and write it down.
- 9 It took the remainder of the class period to finish the assignment, and as the students left the room, each one handed me the papers. Charlie smiled. Mark said, "Thank you for teaching me, Sister. Have a good weekend."
- 10 That Saturday, I wrote down the name of each student on a separate sheet of paper, and I listed what everyone else had said about that individual.
- 11 On Monday I gave each student his or her list. Before long, the entire class was smiling. "Really?" I heard whispered. "I never knew that meant anything to anyone!" "I didn't know others liked me so much!"
- 12 No one ever mentioned those papers in class again. I never knew if the students discussed them after class or with their parents, but it didn't matter. The exercise had accomplished its purpose. The students were happy with themselves and one another again.
- 13 That group of students moved on. Several years later, after I returned from a vacation, my parents met me at the airport. As we were driving home, Mother asked me the usual questions about the trip—the weather, my experiences in general. There was a slight lull in the conversation. Mother gave Dad a sideways glance and simply said, "Dad?" My father cleared his throat as he usually did before something important. "The Eklunds called last night," he began. "Really?" I said. "I haven't heard from them in years. I wonder how Mark is."

628

629

- 14 Dad responded quietly. “Mark was killed in Vietnam,” he said. “The funeral is tomorrow, and his parents would like it if you could attend.” To this day I can still point to the exact spot on I-494 where Dad told me about Mark.
- 15 I had never seen a serviceman in a military coffin before. Mark looked so handsome, so mature. All I could think at that moment was, Mark, I would give all the masking tape in the world if only you would talk to me.
- 16 The church was packed with Mark’s friends. Chuck’s sister sang “The Battle Hymn of the Republic.” Why did it have to rain on the day of the funeral? It was difficult enough at the graveside. The pastor said the usual prayers, and the bugler played Taps. One by one those who loved Mark took a last walk by the coffin and sprinkled it with holy water.
- 17 I was the last one to bless the coffin. As I stood there, one of the soldiers who had acted as pallbearer came up to me. “Were you Mark’s math teacher?” he asked. I nodded as I continued to stare at the coffin. “Mark talked about you a lot,” he said.
- 18 After the funeral, most of Mark’s former classmates headed to Chuck’s farmhouse for lunch. Mark’s mother and father were there, obviously waiting for me. “We want to show you something,” his father said, taking a wallet out of his pocket. “They found this on Mark when he was killed. We thought you might recognize it.”
- 19 Opening the billfold, he carefully removed two worn pieces of notebook paper that had obviously been taped, folded and refolded many times. I knew without looking that the papers were the ones on which I had listed all the good things each of Mark’s classmates had said about him. “Thank you so much for doing that,” Mark’s mother said. “As you can see, Mark treasured it.”
- 20 Mark’s classmates started to gather around us. Charlie smiled rather sheepishly and said, “I still have my list. it’s in the top drawer of my desk at home.” Chuck’s wife said, “Chuck asked me to put his list in our wedding album.” “I have mine too,” Marilyn said. “It’s in my diary.” Then Vicki, another classmate, reached into her pocketbook, took out her wallet, and showed her worn and frazzled list to the group. “I carry this with me at all times,” Vicki said without batting an eyelash. “I think we all saved our lists.”
- 21 That’s when I finally sat down and cried. I cried for Mark and for all his friends who would never see him again.

629

630



From looking at the photograph above, what can you tell about the relationship between the students and their instructor? What specific visual clues help you draw these conclusions?

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *incessantly* in “Mark talked incessantly. I had to remind him again and again that talking without permission was not acceptable” (paragraph 2) means
 - a. slowly.
 - b. quietly.
 - c. constantly.
 - d. pleasantly.
2. The word *edgy* in “We had worked hard on a new concept all week, and I sensed that the students were frowning, frustrated with themselves—and edgy with one another. I had to stop this crankiness before it got out of hand” (paragraph 8) means
 - a. funny.
 - b. calm.
 - c. easily annoyed.
 - d. dangerous.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. Talkative Mark
 - b. My Life as a Teacher
 - c. More Important Than I Knew
 - d. A Tragic Death
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?
 - a. Although Sister Helen sometimes scolded Mark Eklund, he appreciated her devotion to teaching.

630

631

- b. When a former student of hers died, Sister Helen discovered how important one of her assignments had been to him and his classmates.
 - c. When her students were cranky one day, Sister Helen had them write down something nice about each of their classmates.
 - d. A pupil whom Sister Helen was especially fond of was tragically killed while serving in Vietnam.
5. Upon reading their lists for the first time, Sister Helen's students
- a. were silent and embarrassed.
 - b. were disappointed.
 - c. pretended to think the lists were stupid, although they really liked them.
 - d. smiled and seemed pleased.
6. In the days after the assignment to write down something nice about one another,
- a. students didn't mention the assignment again.
 - b. students often brought their lists to school.
 - c. Sister Helen received calls from several parents complaining about the assignment.
 - d. Sister Helen decided to repeat the assignment in every one of her classes.

631

7. According to Vicki,
- a. Mark was the only student to have saved his list.
 - b. Vicki and Mark were the only students to have saved their lists.
 - c. Vicki, Mark, Charlie, Chuck, and Marilyn were the only students to have saved their lists.
 - d. all the students had saved their lists.
8. The author implies that
- a. she was surprised to learn how much the lists had meant to her students.
 - b. Mark's parents were jealous of his affection for Sister Helen.
 - c. Mark's death shattered her faith in God.
 - d. Mark's classmates had not stayed in touch with one another over the years.
9. *True or false?* _____ The author implies that Mark had gotten married.
10. We can conclude that when Sister Helen was a third-grade teacher, she

632

- a. was usually short-tempered and irritable.
- b. wasn't always sure how to discipline her students.
- c. didn't expect Mark to do well in school.
- d. had no sense of humor.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. What did Sister Helen hope to accomplish by asking her students to list nice things about one another?
- 2. At least some students were surprised by the good things others wrote about them. What does this tell us about how we see ourselves and how we communicate our views of others?
- 3. "All the Good Things" has literally traveled around the world. Not only has it been reprinted in numerous publications, but many readers have sent it out over the Internet for others to read. Why do you think so many people love this story? Why do they want to share it with others?

About Structure

- 4. This selection is organized according to time. What three separate time periods does it cover? What paragraphs are included in the first time period? The second? The third?
- 5. Paragraph 8 includes a cause-and-effect structure. What part of the paragraph is devoted to the cause? What part is devoted to the effect? What transition word signals the break between the cause and the effect?
- 6. What does the title "All the Good Things" mean? Is this a good title for the essay? Why or why not?

About Style and Tone

- 7. Sister Helen is willing to let her readers see her weaknesses as well as her strengths. Find a place in the selection in which the author shows herself as less than perfect.
- 8. What does Sister Helen accomplish by beginning her essay with the word "he"? What does that unusual beginning tell the reader?
- 9. How does Sister Helen feel about her students? Find evidence that backs up your opinion.
- 10. Sister Helen comments on Mark's "happy-to-be-alive" attitude. What support does she provide that makes us understand what Mark was like?

632
633

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Early in her story, Sister Helen refers to a “teacher’s mistake” that forced her to www.mhhe.com/langan punish a student in front of the class. Write a paragraph about a time you gave in to pressure to do something because others around you expected it. Explain what the situation was, just what happened, and how you felt afterward. Here are two sample topic sentences:

Even though I knew it was wrong, I went along with some friends who shop lifted at the mall.

Just because my friends did, I made fun of a kid in my study hall who was a slow learner.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph



Sister Helen’s students kept their lists for many years. What souvenir of the past have you kept for a long time? Why? Bring your souvenir to class and describe it to a partner. Write a paragraph describing the souvenir, how you got it, and what it means to you. Begin with a topic sentence such as this:

I’ve kept a green ribbon in one of my dresser drawers for over ten years because it reminds me of an experience I treasure.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

It’s easy to forget to let others know how much they have helped us. Only after one of the students died did Sister Helen learn how important the list of positive comments had been to her class. Write an essay about someone to whom you are grateful and explain what that person has done for you. In your thesis statement, introduce the person and describe his or her relationship to you. Also include a general statement of what that person has done for you. Your thesis statement can be similar to any of these:

My brother Roy has been an important part of my life.

My best friend Ginger helped me through a major crisis.

633

634

Mrs. Morrison, my seventh-grade English teacher, taught me a lesson for which I will always be grateful.

Use freewriting to help you find interesting details to support your thesis statement. You may find two or three separate incidents to write about, each in a paragraph of its own. Or you may find it best to use several paragraphs to give a detailed narrative of one incident or two or three related events. (Note how Sister Helen uses several separate “scenes” to tell her story.) Whatever your approach, use some dialogue to enliven key parts of your essay. (Review the reading to see how Sister Helen uses dialogue throughout her essay.)

Alternatively, write an essay about three people to whom you are grateful. In that case, each paragraph of the body of your essay would deal with one of those people. The thesis statement in such an essay might be similar to this:

There are three people who have made a big difference in my life.

Rowing the Bus: Paul Logan

PREVIEW



There is a well-known saying that goes something like this: All that is necessary in order for evil to triumph is for good people to do nothing. Even young people are forced to face cruel behavior and to decide how they will respond to it. In this essay, Paul Logan looks back at a period of schoolyard cruelty in which he was both a victim and a participant. With unflinching honesty, he describes his behavior then and how it helped to shape the person he has become.

634

- 1 When I was in elementary school, some older kids made me row the bus. Rowing meant that on the way to school I had to sit in the dirty bus aisle littered with paper, gum wads, and spitballs. Then I had to simulate the motion of rowing while the kids around me laughed and chanted, “Row, row, row the bus.” I was forced to do this by a group of bullies who spent most of their time picking on me.
- 2 I was the perfect target for them. I was small. I had no father. And my mother, though she worked hard to support me, was unable to afford clothes and sneakers that were “cool.” Instead she dressed me in outfits that we got from “the bags”—hand-me-downs given as donations to a local church.
- 3 Each Wednesday, she’d bring several bags of clothes to the house and pull out musty, wrinkled shirts and worn bell-bottom pants that other families no longer wanted. I knew that people were kind to give things to us, but I hated wearing clothes that might have been donated by my classmates. Each time I wore something from the bags, I feared that the other kids might recognize something that was once theirs.
- 4 Besides my outdated clothes, I wore thick glasses, had crossed eyes, and spoke with a persistent lisp. For whatever reason, I had never learned to say the “s” sound properly, and I pronounced words that began with “th” as if they began with a “d.” In addition, because of my severely crossed eyes, I lacked the hand and eye coordination necessary to hit or catch flying objects.
- 5 As a result, footballs, baseballs, soccer balls and basketballs became my enemies. I knew, before I stepped onto the field or court, that I would do something clumsy or foolish and that everyone would laugh at me. I feared humiliation so much that I became skillful at feigning illnesses to get out of gym class. Eventually I learned how to give myself low-grade fevers so the nurse would write me an excuse. It worked for a while, until the gym teachers caught on. When I did have to play, I was always the last one chosen to be on any team. In fact, team captains did everything in their power to make their opponents get stuck with me. When the unlucky team captain was forced to call my name, I would trudge over to the team, knowing that no one there liked or wanted me. For four years, from second through fifth grade, I prayed nightly for God to give me school days in which I would not be insulted, embarrassed, or made to feel ashamed.
- 6 I thought my prayers were answered when my mother decided to move during the summer before sixth grade. The move meant that I got to start sixth grade in a different school, a place where I had no reputation. Although the older kids laughed and snorted at me as soon as I got on my new bus—they couldn’t miss my thick glasses and strange clothes—I soon discovered that there was another kid who received the brunt of their insults. His name was George, and everyone made fun of him. The kids taunted him because he was skinny; they belittled him because he had acne that pocked and blotched his face; and they teased him because his voice was squeaky. During my first gym class at my new school, I wasn’t the last one chosen for kickball; George was.

635

- 7 George tried hard to be friends with me, coming up to me in the cafeteria on the first day of school. “Hi. My name’s George. Can I sit with you?” he asked with a peculiar squeakiness that made each word high-pitched and raspy. As I nodded for him to sit down, I noticed an uncomfortable silence in the cafeteria as many of the students who had mocked George’s clumsy gait during gym class began watching the two of us and whispering among themselves. By letting him sit with me, I had violated

636

an unspoken law of school, a sinister code of childhood that demands there must always be someone to pick on. I began to realize two things. If I befriended George, I would soon receive the same treatment that I had gotten at my old school. If I stayed away from him, I might actually have a chance to escape being at the bottom.

- 8 Within days, the kids started taunting us whenever we were together. “Who’s your new little buddy, Georgie?” In the hallways, groups of students began mumbling about me just loud enough for me to hear, “Look, it’s George’s ugly boy friend.” On the bus rides to and from school, wads of paper and wet chewing gum were tossed at me by the bigger, older kids in the back of the bus.
- 9 It became clear that my friendship with George was going to cause me several more years of misery at my new school. I decided to stop being friends with George. In class and at lunch, I spent less and less time with him. Sometimes I told him I was too busy to talk; other times I acted distracted and gave one-word responses to what ever he said. Our classmates, sensing that they had created a rift between George and me, intensified their attacks on him. Each day, George grew more desperate as he realized that the one person who could prevent him from being completely isolated was closing him off. I knew that I shouldn’t avoid him, that he was feeling the same way I felt for so long, but I was so afraid that my life would become the hell it had been in my old school that I continued to ignore him.
- 10 Then, at recess one day, the meanest kid in the school, Chris, decided he had had enough of George. He vowed that he was going to beat up George and anyone else who claimed to be his friend. A mob of kids formed and came after me. Chris led the way and cornered me near our school’s swing sets. He grabbed me by my shirt and raised his fist over my head. A huge gathering of kids surrounded us, urging him to beat me up, chanting “Go, Chris, go!”
- 11 “You’re Georgie’s new little boyfriend, aren’t you?” he yelled. The hot blast of his breath carried droplets of his spit into my face. In a complete betrayal of the only kid who was nice to me, I denied George’s friendship.
- 12 “No, I’m not George’s friend. I don’t like him. He’s stupid,” I blurted out. Several kids snickered and mumbled under their breath. Chris stared at me for a few seconds and then threw me to the ground.
- 13 “Wimp. Where’s George?” he demanded, standing over me. Someone pointed to George sitting alone on top of the monkey bars about thirty yards from where we were. He was watching me. Chris and his followers sprinted over to George and yanked him off the bars to the ground. Although the mob quickly encircled them, I could still see the two of them at the center of the crowd, looking at each other. George seemed stoic, staring straight through Chris. I heard the familiar chant of “Go, Chris, go!” and watched as his fists began slamming into George’s head and body. His face bloodied and his nose broken, George crumpled to the ground and sobbed without even throwing a punch. The mob cheered with pleasure and darted off into the playground to avoid an approaching teacher.
- 14 Chris was suspended, and after a few days, George came back to school. I wanted to talk to him, to ask him how he was, to apologize for leaving him alone and for not trying to stop him from getting hurt. But I couldn’t go near him. Filled with shame for denying George and angered by my own cowardice, I never spoke to him again.

636
637

- 15 Several months later, without telling any students, George transferred to another school. Once in a while, in those last weeks before he left, I caught him watching me as I sat with the rest of the kids in the cafeteria. He never yelled at me or expressed anger, disappointment, or even sadness. Instead he just looked at me.
- 16 In the years that followed, George’s silent stare remained with me. It was there in eighth grade when I saw a gang of popular kids beat up a sixth-grader because, they said, he was “ugly and stupid.” It was there my first year in high school, when I saw a group of older kids steal another freshman’s clothes and throw them into the showers. It was there a year later, when I watched several seniors press a wad of chewing gum into the hair of a new girl on the bus. Each time that I witnessed another awkward, uncomfortable, scared kid being tormented, I thought of George, and gradually his haunting stare began to speak to me. No longer silent, it told me that every child who is picked on and taunted deserves better, that no one—no matter how big, strong, attractive, or popular—has the right to abuse another person.
- 17 Finally, in my junior year when a loudmouthed, pink-skinned bully named Donald began picking on two freshmen on the bus, I could no longer deny George. Donald was crumpling a large wad of paper and preparing to bounce it off the back of the head of one of the young students when I interrupted him.
- 18 “Leave them alone, Don,” I said. By then I was six inches taller and, after two years of high-school wrestling, thirty pounds heavier than I had been in my freshman year. Though Donald was still two years older than me, he wasn’t much bigger. He stopped what he was doing, squinted, and stared at me.
- 19 “What’s your problem, Paul?”
- 20 I felt the way I had many years earlier on the playground when I watched the mob of kids begin to surround George.
- 21 “Just leave them alone. They aren’t bothering you,” I responded quietly.
- 22 “What’s it to you?” he challenged. A glimpse of my own past, of rowing the bus, of being mocked for my clothes, my lisp, my glasses, and my absent father flashed in my mind.
- 23 “Just don’t mess with them. That’s all I am saying, Don.” My fingertips were tingling. The bus was silent. He got up from his seat and leaned over me, and I rose from my seat to face him. For a minute, both of us just stood there, without a word, staring.
- 24 “I’m just playing with them, Paul,” he said, chuckling. “You don’t have to go psycho on me or anything.” Then he shook his head, slapped me firmly on the chest with the back of his hand, and sat down. But he never threw that wad of paper. For the rest of the year, whenever I was on the bus, Don and the other troublemakers were noticeably quiet.
- 25 Although it has been years since my days on the playground and the school bus, George’s look still haunts me. Today, I see it on the faces of a few scared kids at my sister’s school—she is in fifth grade. Or once in a while I’ll catch a glimpse of someone like George on the evening news, in a story about a child who brought a gun to school to stop the kids from picking on him, or in a feature about a

637

638

teenager who killed herself because everyone teased her. In each school, in almost every classroom, there is a George with a stricken face, hoping that someone nearby will be strong enough to be kind—despite what the crowd says—and brave enough to stand up against people who attack, tease, or hurt those who are vulnerable.

- 26 If asked about their behavior, I'm sure the bullies would say, "What's it to you? It's just a joke. It's nothing." But to George and me, and everyone else who has been humiliated or laughed at or spat on, it is everything. No one should have to row the bus.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *simulate* in "Then I had to simulate the motion of rowing while the kids around me laughed and chanted, 'Row, row, row the bus'" (paragraph 1) means
 - a. sing.
 - b. ignore.
 - c. imitate.
 - d. release.
2. The word *rift* in "I decided to stop being friends with George. . . . Our classmates, sensing that they had created a rift between George and me, intensified their attacks on him" (paragraph 9) means
 - a. friendship.
 - b. agreement.
 - c. break.
 - d. joke.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. A Sixth-Grade Adventure
 - b. Children's Fears
 - c. Dealing with Cruelty
 - d. The Trouble with Busing

4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?

638

639

- a. Although Paul Logan was the target of other students' abuse when he was a young boy, their attacks stopped as he grew taller and stronger.
 - b. When Logan moved to a different school, he discovered that another student, George, was the target of more bullying than he was.
 - c. Logan's experience of being bullied and his shame at how he treated George eventually made him speak up for someone else who was teased.
 - d. Logan is ashamed that he did not stand up for George when George was being attacked by a bully on the playground.
5. When Chris attacked George, George reacted by
- a. fighting back hard.
 - b. shouting for Logan to help him.
 - c. running away.
 - d. accepting the beating.
6. Logan finally found the courage to stand up for abused students when he saw
- a. Donald about to throw paper at a younger student.
 - b. older kids throwing a freshman's clothes into the shower.
 - c. seniors putting bubble gum in a new student's hair.
 - d. a gang beating up a sixth-grader whom they disliked.
7. *True or false?* ____ After Logan confronted Donald on the bus, Donald began picking on Logan as well.
8. *True or false?* ____ The author suggests that his mother did not care very much about him.
9. The author implies that, when he started sixth grade at a new school,
- a. he became fairly popular.
 - b. he decided to try out for athletic teams.
 - c. he was relieved to find a kid who was more unpopular than he.
 - d. he was frequently beaten up.
10. We can conclude that
- a. the kids who picked on George later regretted what they had done.
 - b. George and the author eventually talked together about their experience in sixth grade.

- c. the author thinks kids today are kinder than they were when he was in sixth grade.
- d. the author is a more compassionate person now because of his experience with George.

639
640

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. Logan describes a number of incidents involving students’ cruelty to other students. Find at least three such events. What do they seem to have in common? Judging from such incidents, what purpose does cruel teasing seem to serve?
- 2. Throughout the essay, Paul Logan talks about cruel but ordinary school behavior. But in paragraph 25, he briefly mentions two extreme and tragic consequences of such cruelty. What are those consequences, and why do you think he introduces them? What is he implying?

About Structure

- 3. Below, write three time transitions Logan uses to advance his narration.

- 4. Logan describes the gradual change within him that finally results in his standing up for a student who is being abused. Where in the narrative does Logan show how internal changes may be taking place within him? Where in the narrative does he show that his reaction to witnessing bullying has changed?
- 5. Paul Logan titled his selection “Rowing the Bus.” Yet very little of the essay actually deals with the incident the title describes. Why do you think Logan chose that title? In groups or two or three, come up with alternative titles and discuss why they would or would not be effective.



About Style and Tone

- 6. Give examples of how Logan appeals to our senses in paragraphs 1–4.
Sight _____
Smell _____
Hearing _____
- 7. What is Logan’s attitude toward himself regarding his treatment of George? Find three phrases that reveal his attitude and write them on a separate piece of paper.

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Logan writes, “In each school, in almost every classroom, there is a George with a stricken face.” Think of a person who filled the role of George in one of your classes. Then write a descriptive paragraph about that person, explaining why he or she was a target and what form the teasing took. Be sure to include a description of your own thoughts and actions regarding the student who was teased. Your topic sentence might be something like one of these:

640

641

A girl in my fifth-grade class was a lot like George in “Rowing the Bus.”

Like Paul Logan, I suffered greatly in elementary school from being bullied.

Try to include details that appeal to two or three of the senses.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Paul Logan feared that his life at his new school would be made miserable if he continued being friends with George. So he ended the friendship, even though he felt ashamed of doing so. Think of a time when you have wanted to do the right thing but felt that the price would be too high. Maybe you knew a friend was doing something dishonest and wanted him to stop but were afraid of losing his friendship. Or perhaps you pretended to forget a promise you had made because you decided it was too difficult to keep. Write a paragraph describing the choice you made and how you felt about yourself afterward.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Logan provides many vivid descriptions of incidents in which bullies attack other students. Reread these descriptions, and consider what they teach you about the nature of bullies and bullying. Then write an essay that supports the following main idea:

Bullies seem to share certain qualities.

Identify two or three qualities; then discuss each in a separate paragraph. You may use two or three of the following as the topic sentences for your supporting paragraphs, or come up with your own supporting points:

Bullies are cowardly.

Bullies make themselves feel big by making other people feel small.

- Bullies cannot feel very good about themselves.
- Bullies are feared but not respected.
- Bullies act cruelly in order to get attention.

Develop each supporting point with one or more anecdotes or ideas from any of the following: your own experience, your understanding of human nature, and “Rowing the Bus.”

641

642

The Scholarship Jacket: Marta Salinas

PREVIEW

All of us have suffered disappointments and moments when we have felt we’ve been treated unfairly. In “The Scholarship Jacket,” originally published in *Growing Up Chicana: An Anthology*, Marta Salinas writes about one such moment in her childhood in southern Texas. By focusing on an award that school authorities decided she should not receive, Salinas shows us the pain of discrimination as well as the need for inner strength.

- 1 The small Texas school that I attended carried out a tradition every year during the eighth-grade graduation: a beautiful jacket in gold and green, the school colors, was awarded to the class valedictorian, the student who had maintained the highest grades for eight years. The scholarship jacket had a big gold S on the left front side, and the winner’s name was written in gold letters on the pocket.
- 2 My oldest sister, Rosie, had won the jacket a few years back, and I fully expected to win also. I was fourteen and in the eighth grade. I had been a straight-A student since the first grade, and the last year I had looked forward to owning that jacket. My father was a farm laborer who couldn’t earn enough money to feed eight children, so when I was six I was given to my grandparents to raise. We couldn’t participate in sports at school because there were registration fees, uniform costs, and trips out of town; so even though we were quite agile and athletic, there would never be a sports school jacket for us. This one, the scholarship jacket, was our only chance.
- 3 In May, close to graduation, spring fever struck, and no one paid any attention to class; instead we stared out the windows and at each other, wanting to speed up the last few weeks of school. I despaired every time I looked in the mirror. Pencil-thin, with not a curve anywhere, I was called “Beanpole” and “String Bean,” and I knew that’s what I looked like. A flat chest, no hips, and a brain, that’s what I had. That really isn’t much for a fourteen-year-old to work with, I thought, as I absentmindedly wandered from my history class to the gym. Another hour of sweating during basketball and displaying my toothpick legs was coming up. Then I remembered my P.E. shorts were still in a bag under my desk where I’d forgotten them. I had to walk all the way back and get them. Coach Thompson was a real bear if anyone wasn’t dressed for P.E. She had said I was a good forward and once she even tried to talk Grandma into letting me join the team. Grandma, of course, said no.

642

- 4 I was almost back at my classroom door when I heard angry voices and arguing. I stopped. I didn't mean to eavesdrop; I just hesitated, not knowing what to do. I needed those shorts and I was going to be late, but I didn't want to interrupt an argument between my teachers. I recognized the voices: Mr. Schmidt, my history teacher; and Mr. Boone, my math teacher. They seemed to be arguing about me. I couldn't believe it. I still remember the shock that rooted me flat against the wall as if I were trying to blend in with the graffiti written there.
- 5 "I refuse to do it! I don't care who her father is; her grades don't even begin to compare to Martha's. I won't lie or falsify records. Martha has a straight-A-plus average and you know it." That was Mr. Schmidt, and he sounded very angry. Mr. Boone's voice sounded calm and quiet.
- 6 "Look, Joann's father is not only on the Board, he owns the only store in town; we could say it was a close tie and—"
- 7 The pounding in my ears drowned out the rest of the words, only a word here and there filtered through. "... Martha is Mexican ... resign ... won't do it. ... " Mr. Schmidt came rushing out, and luckily for me went down the opposite way toward the auditorium, so he didn't see me. Shaking, I waited a few minutes and then went in and grabbed my bag and fled from the room. Mr. Boone looked up when I came in but didn't say anything. To this day I don't remember if I got in trouble in P.E. for being late or how I made it through the rest of the afternoon. I went home very sad and cried into my pillow that night so Grandmother wouldn't hear me. It seemed a cruel coincidence that I had overheard that conversation.
- 8 The next day when the principal called me into his office, I knew what it would be about. He looked uncomfortable and unhappy. I decided I wasn't going to make it any easier for him, so I looked him straight in the eye. He looked away and fidgeted with the papers on his desk.
- 9 "Martha," he said, "there's been a change in policy this year regarding the scholarship jacket. As you know, it has always been free." He cleared his throat and continued. "This year the Board decided to charge fifteen dollars—which still won't cover the complete cost of the jacket."
- 10 I stared at him in shock and a small sound of dismay escaped my throat. I hadn't expected this. He still avoided looking in my eyes.
- 11 "So if you are unable to pay the fifteen dollars for the jacket, it will be given to the next one in line."
- 12 Standing with all the dignity I could muster, I said, "I'll speak to my grandfather about it, sir, and let you know tomorrow." I cried on the walk home from the bus stop. The dirt road was a quarter of a mile from the highway, so by the time I got home, my eyes were red and puffy.
- 13 "Where's Grandpa?" I asked Grandma, looking down at the floor so she wouldn't ask me why I'd been crying. She was sewing on a quilt and didn't look up.
- 14 "I think he's out back working in the bean field."
- 15 I went outside and looked out at the fields. There he was. I could see him walking between the rows, his body bent over the little plants, hoe in hand. I walked slowly out to him, trying to think how I

could best ask him for the money. There was a cool breeze blowing and a sweet smell of mesquite in the air, but I didn't appreciate it. I kicked at a dirt clod. I wanted that jacket so much. It was more than just being a valedictorian and giving a little thank-you speech for the jacket on graduation night. It represented eight years of hard work and expectation. I knew I had to be honest with Grandpa; it was my only chance. He saw me and looked up.

- 16 He waited for me to speak. I cleared my throat nervously and clasped my hands behind my back so he wouldn't see them shaking. "Grandpa, I have a big favor to ask you," I said in Spanish, the only language he knew. He still waited silently. I tried again. "Grandpa, this year the principal said the scholarship jacket is not going to be free. It's going to cost fifteen dollars and I have to take the money in tomorrow, otherwise it'll be given to someone else." The last words came out in an eager rush. Grandpa straightened up tiredly and leaned his chin on the hoe handle. He looked out over the field that was filled with the tiny green bean plants. I waited, desperately hoping he'd say I could have the money.
- 17 He turned to me and asked quietly, "What does a scholarship jacket mean?"
- 18 I answered quickly; maybe there was a chance. "It means you've earned it by having the highest grades for eight years and that's why they're giving it to you." Too late I realized the significance of my words. Grandpa knew that I understood it was not a matter of money. It wasn't that. He went back to hoeing the weeds that sprang up between the delicate little bean plants. It was a time-consuming job; sometimes the small shoots were right next to each other. Finally he spoke again.
- 19 "Then if you pay for it, Marta, it's not a scholarship jacket, is it? Tell your principal I will not pay the fifteen dollars."
- 20 I walked back to the house and locked myself in the bathroom for a long time. I was angry with Grandfather even though I knew he was right, and I was angry with the Board, whoever they were. Why did they have to change the rules just when it was my turn to win the jacket?
- 21 It was a very sad and withdrawn girl who dragged into the principal's office the next day. This time he did look me in the eyes.
- 22 "What did your grandfather say?"
- 23 I sat very straight in my chair.
- 24 "He said to tell you he won't pay the fifteen dollars."
- 25 The principal muttered something I couldn't understand under his breath, and walked over to the window. He stood looking out at something outside. He looked bigger than usual when he stood up; he was a tall, gaunt man with gray hair, and I watched the back of his head while I waited for him to speak.
- 26 "Why?" he finally asked. "Your grandfather has the money. Doesn't he own a small bean farm?"

27 I looked at him, forcing my eyes to stay dry. “He said if I had to pay for it, then it wouldn’t be a scholarship jacket,” I said and stood up to leave. “I guess you’ll just have to give it to Joann.” I hadn’t meant to say that; it had just slipped out. I was almost to the door when he stopped me. 644
645

28 “Martha—wait.”

29 I turned and looked at him, waiting. What did he want now? I could feel my heart pounding. Something bitter and vile-tasting was coming up in my mouth; I was afraid I was going to be sick. I didn’t need any sympathy speeches. He sighed loudly and went back to his big desk. He looked at me, biting his lip, as if thinking.

30 “OK, damn it. We’ll make an exception in your case. I’ll tell the Board, you’ll get your jacket.”

31 I could hardly believe it. I spoke in a trembling rush. “Oh, thank you, sir!” Suddenly I felt great. I didn’t know about adrenaline in those days, but I knew something was pumping through me, making me feel as tall as the sky. I wanted to yell, jump, run the mile, do something. I ran out so I could cry in the hall where there was no one to see me. At the end of the day, Mr. Schmidt winked at me and said, “I hear you’re getting a scholarship jacket this year.”

32 His face looked as happy and innocent as a baby’s, but I knew better. Without answering I gave him a quick hug and ran to the bus. I cried on the walk home again, but this time because I was so happy. I couldn’t wait to tell Grandpa and ran straight to the field. I joined him in the row where he was working and without saying anything I crouched down and started pulling up the weeds with my hands. Grandpa worked alongside me for a few minutes, but he didn’t ask what had happened. After I had a little pile of weeds between the rows, I stood up and faced him.

33 “The principal said he’s making an exception for me, Grandpa, and I’m getting the jacket after all. That’s after I told him what you said.”

34 Grandpa didn’t say anything; he just gave me a pat on the shoulder and a smile. He pulled out the crumpled red handkerchief that he always carried in his back pocket and wiped the sweat off his forehead.

35 “Better go see if your grandmother needs any help with supper.”

36 I gave him a big grin. He didn’t fool me. I skipped and ran back to the house whistling some silly tune.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *falsify* in “I won’t lie or falsify records. Martha has a straight-A-plus average and you know it” (paragraph 5) means

- a. make untrue.
- b. write down.
- c. keep track of.
- d. sort alphabetically.

645

2. The word *dismay* in “I stared at him in shock and a small sound of dismay escaped my throat. I hadn’t expected this” (paragraph 10) means

646

- a. joy.
- b. comfort.
- c. relief.
- d. disappointment.

3. Which sentence best expresses the central point of the selection?

- a. It is more important to be smart than good-looking or athletic.
- b. People who are willing to pay for an award deserve it more than people who are not.
- c. By refusing to give in to discrimination, the author finally received the award she had earned.
- d. Always do what the adults in your family say, even if you don’t agree.

4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of paragraph 2?

- a. Marta wanted to win the scholarship jacket to be like her sister Rosie.
- b. The scholarship jacket was especially important to Marta because she was unable to earn a jacket in any other way.
- c. The scholarship jacket was better than a sports school jacket.
- d. Marta resented her parents for sending her to live with her grandparents.

5. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of paragraph 7?

- a. Marta was shocked and saddened by the conversation she overheard.
- b. Marta didn’t want her grandmother to know she was crying.
- c. Mr. Schmidt didn’t see Marta when he rushed out of the room.
- d. Marta didn’t hear every word of Mr. Schmidt’s and Mr. Boone’s conversation.

6. Marta was raised by her grandparents because

- a. she wanted to learn to speak Spanish.
 - b. her father did not earn enough money to feed all his children.
 - c. she wanted to learn about farming.
 - d. her parents died when she was six.
7. *True or false?* _____ Marta was called by a different name at school.
8. We can infer from paragraph 8 that the principal was “uncomfortable and unhappy” because
- a. the students had not been paying attention in class during the last few weeks before graduation.
 - b. his office was very hot.
 - c. he was ashamed to tell Marta that she had to pay fifteen dollars for a jacket that she had earned.
 - d. Mr. Boone and Mr. Schmidt were fighting in the hallway.
-
9. The author implies that the Board members were not going to give Marta the scholarship jacket because
- a. she was late for P.E. class.
 - b. they wanted to award the jacket to the daughter of an important local citizen.
 - c. another student had better grades.
 - d. they didn’t think it was fair to have two members of the same family win the jacket.
10. *True or false?* _____ The author implies that the Board’s new policy to require a fee for the scholarship jacket was an act of discrimination.

646

647

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. Why was winning the scholarship jacket so important to Marta?
- 2. What seemed to be the meaning of the argument between Mr. Schmidt and Mr. Boone?
- 3. After Marta’s grandfather asks her what the scholarship jacket is, the author writes, “‘It means you’ve earned it by having the highest grades for eight years and that’s why they’re giving it to you.’ Too late I realized the significance of my words.” What is the significance of her words?

About Structure

- 4. Why do you think Salinas begins her essay with a detailed description of the scholarship jacket? How does her description contribute to our interest in her story?
- 5. At what point does Salinas stop providing background information and start giving a time-ordered narration of a particular event in her life?
- 6. In the course of the essay, Salinas rides an emotional roller-coaster. Find and write here three words or phrases she uses to describe her different emotional states:

About Style and Tone

- 7. As you read the essay, what impression do you form of Salinas’s grandfather? What kind of man does he seem to be? What details does Salinas provide in order to create that impression?
- 8. In paragraph 12, Salinas writes, “Standing with all the dignity I could muster, I said, ‘I’ll speak to my grandfather about it, sir, and let you know tomorrow.’” What other evidence does Salinas give us that her dignity is important to her?

647

648

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Write a paragraph about a time when you experienced or witnessed an injustice. Describe the circumstances surrounding the incident and why you think the people involved acted as they did. In your paragraph, describe how you felt at the time and any effect the incident has had on you. Your topic sentence could be something like one of the following:

I was angry when my supervisor promoted his nephew even though I was more qualified.

A friend of mine recently got into trouble with authorities even though he was innocent of any wrongdoing.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph



Marta stresses again and again how important the scholarship jacket was to her and how hard she worked to win it. In groups of two or three, discuss something you each worked hard to achieve when you were younger. Then write a paragraph about that experience. How long did you work toward that goal? How did you feel when you finally succeeded? Or write about not achieving the goal. How did you cope with the disappointment? What did you learn from the experience?

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

This story contains several examples of authority figures—specifically, the two teachers, the principal, and Marta’s grandfather. Write an essay describing three qualities that you think an authority figure should possess. Such qualities might include honesty, fairness, compassion, and knowledge.

In the body of your essay, devote each supporting paragraph to one of those qualities. Within each paragraph, give an example or examples of how an authority figure in your life has demonstrated that quality.

You may write about three different authority figures who have demonstrated those three qualities to you. Alternatively, one authority figure may have demonstrated all three.

Your thesis statement might be similar to one of these:

My older brother, my grandmother, and my football coach have been models of admirable behavior for me.

My older brother’s honesty, courage, and kindness to others have set a valuable example for me.

648

649

Joe Davis: A Cool Man: Beth Johnson

PREVIEW



Drugs and guns, crime and drugs, drugs and lies, liquor and drugs. If there was one constant in Joe Davis’s life, it was drugs, the substances that ruled his existence. Personal tragedy was not enough to turn him off the path leading to the brink of self-destruction. Finally Joe was faced with a moment of decision. The choice he made has opened doors into a world that the old Joe barely knew existed.

- 1 Joe Davis was the coolest fourteen-year-old he’d ever seen.
- 2 He went to school when he felt like it. He hung out with a wild crowd. He started drinking some wine, smoking some marijuana. “Nobody could tell me anything,” he says today. “I thought the sun rose and set on me.” There were rules at home, but Joe didn’t do rules. So he moved in with his grandmother.
- 3 Joe Davis was the coolest sixteen-year-old he’d ever seen.
- 4 Joe’s parents gave up on his schooling and signed him out of the tenth grade. Joe went to work in his dad’s body shop, but that didn’t last long. There were rules there, too, and Joe didn’t do rules. By the time he was in his mid-teens, Joe was taking pills that got him high, and he was even using cocaine. He was also smoking marijuana all the time and drinking booze all the time.
- 5 Joe Davis was the coolest twenty-five-year-old he’d ever seen.
- 6 He was living with a woman almost twice his age. The situation wasn’t great, but she paid the bills, and certainly Joe couldn’t pay them. He had his habit to support, which by now had grown to include heroin. Sometimes he’d work at a low-level job, if someone else found it for him. He might work long enough to get a paycheck and then spend it all at once. Other times he’d be caught stealing and get fired first. A more challenging job was not an option, even if he had bothered to look for one. He couldn’t put words together to form a sentence, unless the sentence was about drugs. Filling out an application was difficult. He wasn’t a strong reader. He couldn’t do much with numbers. Since his drug habit had to be paid for, he started to steal. He stole first from his parents, then from his sister. Then he stole from the families of people he knew. But eventually the people he knew wouldn’t let him into their houses, since they knew he’d steal from them. So he got a gun and began holding people up. He chose elderly people and others who weren’t likely to fight back. The holdups kept him in drug money, but things at home were getting worse. His woman’s teenage daughter was getting out of line. Joe decided it was up to him to discipline her. The girl didn’t like it. She told her boyfriend. One day, the boyfriend called Joe out of the house.
- 7 Bang.
- 8 Joe Davis was in the street, his nose in the dirt. His mind was still cloudy from his most recent high, but he knew something was terribly wrong with his legs. He couldn’t move them; he couldn’t even feel them. His mother came out of her house nearby and ran to him. As he heard her screams, he imagined what she was seeing. Her oldest child, her first baby, her bright boy who could have been and done anything, was lying in the gutter, a junkie with a .22 caliber bullet lodged in his spine.
- 9 The next time Joe’s head cleared, he was in a hospital bed, blinking up at his parents as they stared helplessly at him. The doctors had done all they could; Joe would live, to everyone’s surprise. But he was a paraplegic—paralyzed from his chest down. It was done. It was over. It was written in stone. He

would not walk again. He would not be able to control his bladder or bowels. He would not be able to make love as he did before. He would not be able to hold people up, then hurry away.

- 10 Joe spent the next eight months being moved between several Philadelphia hospitals, where he was shown the ropes of life as a paraplegic. Officially he was being “rehabilitated”—restored to a productive life. There was just one problem: Joe. “To be rehabilitated, you must have been habilitated first,” he says today. “That wasn’t me.” During his stay in the hospitals, he found ways to get high every day.
- 11 Finally Joe was released from the hospital. He returned in his wheelchair to the house he’d been living in when he was shot. He needed someone to take care of him, and his woman friend was still willing. His drug habit was as strong as ever, but his days as a stickup man were over. So he started selling drugs. Business was good. The money came in fast, and his own drug use accelerated even faster.
- 12 A wheelchair-bound junkie doesn’t pay much attention to his health or cleanliness. Eventually Joe developed his first bedsore: a deep, rotting wound that ate into his flesh, overwhelming him with its foul odor. He was admitted to Magee Rehabilitation Hospital, where he spent six months on his stomach while the ghastly wound slowly healed. Again, he spent his time in the hospital using drugs. This time his drug use did not go unnoticed. Soon before he was scheduled to be discharged, hospital officials kicked him out. He returned to his friend’s house and his business. But then the police raided the house. They took the drugs; they took the money; they took the guns.
- 13 “I really went downhill then,” says Joe. With no drugs and no money to get drugs, life held little meaning. He began fighting with the woman he was living with. “When you’re in the state I was in, you don’t know how to be nice to anybody,” he says. Finally she kicked him out of the house. When his parents took him in, Joe did a little selling from their house, trying to keep it low-key, out of sight, so they wouldn’t notice. He laughs at the notion today. “I thought I could control junkies and tell them, ‘Business only during certain hours.’” Joe got high when his monthly Social Security check came, high when he’d make a purchase for someone else and get a little something for himself, high when a visitor would share drugs with him. It wasn’t much of a life. “There I was,” he says, “a junkie with no education, no job, no friends, no means of supporting myself. And now I had a spinal cord injury.”
- 14 Then came October 25, 1988. Joe had just filled a prescription for pills to control his muscle spasms. Three hundred of the powerful muscle relaxants were there for the taking. He swallowed them all.
- 15 “It wasn’t the spinal cord injury that did it,” he says. “It was the addiction.”
- 16 Joe tried hard to die, but it didn’t work. His sister heard him choking and called for help. He was rushed to the hospital, where he lay in a coma for four days.
- 17 Joe has trouble finding the words to describe what happened next.
- 18 “I had . . . a spiritual awakening, for lack of any better term,” he says. “My soul had been cleansed. I knew my life could be better. And from that day to this, I have chosen not to get high.”
- 19 Drugs, he says, “are not even a temptation. That life is a thing that happened to someone else.”

650
651

- 20** Joe knew he wanted to turn himself around, but he needed help in knowing where to start. He enrolled in Magee Hospital's vocational rehabilitation program. For six weeks, he immersed himself in discussions, tests, and exercises to help him determine the kind of work he might be suited for. The day he finished the rehab program, a nurse at Magee told him about a receptionist's job in the spinal cord injury unit at Thomas Jefferson Hospital. He went straight to the hospital and met Lorraine Buchanan, coordinator of the unit. "I told her where I was and where I wanted to go," Joe says. "I told her, 'If you give me a job, I will never disappoint you. I'll quit first if I see I can't live up to it.'" She gave him the job. The wheelchair-bound junkie, the man who'd never been able to hold a job, the drug-dependent stickup man who "couldn't put two words together to make a sentence" was now the first face, the first voice that patients encountered when they entered the spinal cord unit. "I'd never talked to people like that," says Joe, shaking his head. "I had absolutely no background. But Lorraine and the others, they taught me to speak. Taught me to greet people. Taught me to handle the phone." How did he do in his role as a receptionist? A huge smile breaks across Joe's face as he answers, "Excellent."
- 21** Soon, his personal life also took a very positive turn. A month after Joe started his job, he was riding a city bus to work. A woman recovering from knee surgery was in another seat. The two smiled, but didn't speak.
- 22** A week later, Joe spotted the woman again. The bus driver sensed something was going on and encouraged Joe to approach her. Her name was Terri. She was a receptionist in a law office. On their first date, Joe laid his cards on the table. He told her his story. He also told her he was looking to get married. "That about scared her away," Joe recalls. "She said she wasn't interested in marriage. I asked, 'Well, suppose you did meet someone you cared about who cared about you and treated you well. Would you still be opposed to the idea of marriage?' She said no, she would consider it then. I said, 'Well, that's all I ask.'"
- 23** Four months later, as the two sat over dinner in a restaurant, Joe handed Terri a box tied with a ribbon. Inside was a smaller box. Then a smaller box, and a smaller one still. Ten boxes in all. Inside the smallest was an engagement ring. After another six months, the two were married in the law office where Terri works. Since then, she has been Joe's constant source of support, encouragement, and love.
- 24** After Joe had started work at Jefferson Hospital, he talked with his supervisor, Lorraine, about his dreams of moving on to something bigger, more challenging. She encouraged him to try college. He had taken and passed the high school general equivalency diploma (GED) exam years before, almost as a joke, when he was recovering from his bedsores at Magee. Now he enrolled in a university mathematics course. He didn't do well. "I wasn't ready," Joe says. "I'd been out of school seventeen years. I dropped out." Before he could let discouragement overwhelm him, he enrolled at Community College of Philadelphia (CCP), where he signed up for basic math and English courses. He worked hard, sharpening study skills he had never developed in his earlier school days. Next he took courses toward an associate's degree in mental health and social services, along with a certificate in addiction studies. Five years later, he graduated from CCP, the first member of his family ever to earn a college

651

652

degree. He went on to receive a bachelor’s degree in mental health from Hahnemann University in Philadelphia and then a master of social work from the University of Pennsylvania.

- 25 Today, Joe is the coordinator of “Think First,” a violence and injury prevention program operated by Magee Rehabilitation Hospital, where he also serves as a case manager for patients with spinal cord injuries. Once a month, he and two other men with such injuries speak to a group of first-time offenders who were arrested for driving under the influence of drugs or alcohol. He talks with government officials about passing stricter gun legislation and installing injury-prevention programs in public schools, and he visits local schools to describe the lessons of his life with students there. In every contact with every individual, Joe has one goal: to ensure the safety and well-being of young people.
- 26 At a presentation at a disciplinary school outside of Philadelphia, Joe gazes with quiet authority at the unruly crowd of teenagers. He begins to speak, telling them about speedballs and guns, fast money and bedsores, even about the leg bag that collects his urine. At first, the kids snort with laughter at his honesty. When they laugh, he waits patiently, then goes on. Gradually the room grows quieter as Joe tells them of his life and then asks them about theirs. “What’s important to you? What are your goals?” he says. “I’m still in school because when I was young, I chose the dead-end route many of you are on. But now I’m doing what I have to do to get where I want to go. What are you doing?”
- 27 He tells them more, about broken dreams, about his parents’ grief, about the former friends who turned away from him when he was no longer a source of drugs. He tells them of the continuing struggle to regain the trust of people he once abused. He tells them about the desire that consumes him now, the desire to make his community a better place to live. His wish is that no young man or woman should have to walk the path he’s walked in order to value the precious gift of life. The teenagers are now silent. They look at this broad-shouldered black man in his wheelchair, his head and beard close-shaven, a gold ring in his ear. His hushed words settle among them like gentle drops of cleansing rain. “What are you doing? Where are you going?” he asks them. “Think about it. Think about me.”
- 28 Joe Davis is the coolest forty-eight-year-old you’ve ever seen.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *immersed* in “For six weeks, he immersed himself in discussions, tests, and exercises to help him determine the kind of work he might be suited for” (paragraph 20) means
- a. totally ignored.
- b. greatly angered.

- c. deeply involved.
 - d. often harmed.
- 2. Which sentence best expresses the central point of the selection?
 - a. Most people cannot improve their lives once they turn to drugs and crime.
 - b. Joe Davis overcame a life of drugs and crime and a disability to lead a rich, meaningful life.
 - c. The rules set by Joe Davis’s parents caused him to leave home and continue a life of drugs and crime.
 - d. Joe Davis’s friends turned away from him once they learned he was no longer a source of drugs.
- 3. A main idea may cover more than one paragraph. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of paragraphs 21–23?
 - a. First sentence of paragraph 21
 - b. Second sentence of paragraph 21
 - c. First sentence of paragraph 22
 - d. First sentence of paragraph 23
- 4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of paragraph 24?
 - a. It was difficult for Joe to do college work after being out of school for so many years.
 - b. Lorraine Buchanan encouraged Joe to go to college.
 - c. Joe’s determination enabled him to overcome a lack of academic preparation and eventually succeed in college.
 - d. If students would stay in high school and work hard, they would not have to go to the trouble of getting a high school GED.
- 5. Joe Davis quit high school
 - a. when he was fourteen.
 - b. when he got a good job at a hospital.
 - c. when he was in the tenth grade.
 - d. after he was shot.
- 6. Joe tried to kill himself by

653
654

- a. swallowing muscle-relaxant pills.
 - b. shooting himself.
 - c. overdosing on heroin.
 - d. not eating or drinking.
7. According to the selection, Joe first met his wife
- a. in the hospital, where she was a nurse.
 - b. on a city bus, where they were both passengers.
 - c. on the job, where she was also a receptionist.
 - d. at Community College of Philadelphia, where she was also a student.
8. Joe decided to stop using drugs
- a. when he met his future wife.
 - b. right after he was shot.
 - c. when he awoke after a suicide attempt.
 - d. when he was hired as a receptionist.
9. We can conclude from paragraph 26 that
- a. Joe is willing to reveal very personal information about himself in order to reach young people with his story.
 - b. Joe was angry at the Philadelphia students who laughed at parts of his story.
 - c. Joe is glad he did not go to college directly from high school.
 - d. Joe is still trying to figure out what his life goals are.
10. When the author writes, “Joe Davis was the coolest fourteen- (or sixteen- or twenty-five-) year-old he’d ever seen,” she is actually expressing
- a. her approval of the way Joe was living then.
 - b. her envy of Joe’s status in the community.
 - c. her mistaken opinion of Joe at these stages in his life.
 - d. Joe’s mistaken opinion of himself at these stages in his life.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. When speaking of his suicide attempt, Joe said, “it wasn’t the spinal cord injury that did it. It was the addiction.” What do you think Joe meant? Why does he blame his addiction, rather than his disability, for his decision to try to end his life?
- 2. Why do you think the students Joe spoke to laughed as he shared personal details of his life? Why did they later quiet down? What effect do you think his presentation had on these students?
- 3. Joe wants young people to learn the lessons he has learned without having to experience his hardships. What lessons have you learned in your life that you would like to pass on to others?

About Structure

- 4. Paragraphs 1, 3, 5, and 28 are very similar. In what important way is paragraph 28 different from the others? What do you think Johnson is suggesting by introducing that difference?
- 5. Johnson tells the story of Joe’s shooting briefly, in paragraphs 6–8. She could have chosen to go into much more detail about that part of the story. For instance, she could have described any previous relationship between Joe and the young man who shot him, or what happened to the shooter afterward. Why do you think she chose not to concentrate on those details? How would the story have been different if she had focused on them?
- 6. In paragraphs 21–23, Johnson condenses an important year in Joe’s life into three paragraphs. Locate and write below three of the many transitions that are used as part of the time order in those paragraphs.

About Style and Tone



- 7. In paragraph 12, Johnson describes Joe’s poor physical condition. She could have simply written, “Joe developed a serious bedsore.” Instead she writes, “Eventually Joe developed his first bedsore: a deep, rotting wound that ate into his flesh, overwhelming him with its foul odor.” Why do you think she provided such graphic detail? What is the effect on the reader?
- 8. How do you think Johnson feels about Joe Davis? What hints lead you to that conclusion? Work with a partner to find and list support for it.

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Like Joe Davis, many of us have learned painful lessons from life. And like him, we wish we could pass those lessons on to young people to save them from making the same mistakes.

Write a one-paragraph letter to a young person you know. In it, use your experience to pass on a lesson you wish he or she would learn. Begin with a topic sentence in which you state the lesson you'd like to teach, as in these examples:

My own humiliating experience taught me that shoplifting is a very bad idea.

I learned the hard way that abandoning your friends for the “cool” crowd will backfire on you.

The sad experience of a friend has taught me that teenage girls should not give in to their boyfriends’ pressure for sex.

Dropping out of high school may seem like a great idea, but what happened to my brother should convince you otherwise.



Your letter should describe in detail the lesson you learned and how you learned it. Exchange letters with a partner and help each other to revise and edit.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Although Joe’s parents loved him, they weren’t able to stop him from using drugs, skipping school, and doing other self-destructive things. Think of a time that you have seen someone you cared about doing something you thought was bad for him or her. What did you do? What did you want to do?

Write a paragraph in which you describe the situation and how you responded. Make sure to answer the following questions:

What was the person doing?

Why was I concerned about him or her?

- Did I feel there was anything I could do?
- Did I take any action?
- How did the situation finally turn out?

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

- One of Joe’s goals is to regain the trust of the friends and family members he abused during his earlier life. Have you ever given a second chance to someone who treated you poorly? Write an essay about what happened. You could begin with a thesis statement something like this:
“Although my closest friend betrayed my trust, I decided to give him another chance.”

You could then go on to structure the rest of your essay in this way:

- In your first supporting paragraph, explain what the person did to lose your trust. Maybe it was an obviously hurtful action, like physically harming you or stealing from you. Or perhaps it was something more subtle, like insulting or embarrassing you.
- In your second supporting paragraph, explain why you decided to give the person another chance.
- In your third supporting paragraph, tell what happened as a result of your giving the person a second chance. Did he or she treat you better this time? Or did the bad treatment start over again?
- In your concluding paragraph, provide some final thoughts about what you learned from the experience.

Alternatively, write an essay about a time that you were given a second chance by someone whose trust you had abused. Follow the same pattern of development.

The Fist, the Clay, and the Rock: Donald Holland

PREVIEW

In this narrative, Donald Holland recalls a high school teacher’s inspiring question: *If the world were a first, would you rather be a rock or a ball of clay?* Emphasizing the power of knowledge in the classroom and beyond, Mr. Gery encouraged his students to become rocks—strong, resilient learners.

- The best teacher I ever had was Mr. Gery, who taught 12th grade English. He started his class with us by placing on the front desk a large mound of clay and, next to it, a rock about the size of a tennis ball. That got our attention quickly, and the class quieted down and waited for him to talk.”
- Mr. Gery looked at us and smiled and said, “If there were a pill I could give you that would help you learn, and help you want to learn, I would pass it out right now. But there is no magic pill. Everything is up to you.”

- 3 Then Mr. Gery held up his fist and kind of shook it at us. Some of us looked at each other. *What's going on?* we all thought. Mr. Gery continued: "I'd like you to imagine something for me. Imagine that my fist is the real world—not the sheltered world of this school but the real world. Imagine that my fist is everything that can happen to you out in the real world." 657
658
- 4 Then he reached down and pointed to the ball of clay and also the rock. He said, "Now imagine that you're either this lump of clay or you're the rock. Got that?" He smiled at us, and we waited to see what he was going to do.
- 5 He went on, "Let's say you're this ball of clay, and you're just sitting around minding your own business and then out of nowhere here's what happens." He made a fist again and he smashed his fist into the ball of clay, which quickly turned into a half-flattened lump.
- 6 He looked at us, still smiling. "If the real world comes along and takes a swing at you, you're likely to get squashed. And you know what, the real world will come along and take a swing at you. You're going to take some heavy hits. Maybe you already have taken some heavy hits. Chances are that there are more down the road. So if you don't want to get squashed, you're better off if you're not a piece of clay.
- 7 "Now let's say you're the rock and the real world comes along and takes a swing at you. What will happen if I smash my fist into this rock?" The answer was obvious. Nothing would happen to the rock. It would take the blow and not be changed.
- 8 He continued, "So what would you like to be, people, the clay or the rock? And what's my point? What am I trying to say to you?"
- 9 Someone raised their hand and said, "We should all be rocks. It's bad news to be clay." And some of us laughed, though a bit uneasily.
- 10 Mr. Gery went on. "OK, you all want to be rocks, don't you? Now my question is, 'How do you get to be a rock? How do you make yourself strong, like the rock, so that you won't be crushed and beaten up even if you take a lot of hits?'"
- 11 We didn't have an answer right away and he went on, "You know I can't be a fairy godmother. I can't pull out a wand and say, 'Thanks for wanting to be a rock. I hereby wave my wand and make you a rock.' That's not the way life works. The only way to become a rock is to go out and make yourself a rock.
- 12 "Imagine you're a fighter getting ready for a match. You go to the gym, and maybe when you start you're flabby. Your whole body is flab and it's soft like the clay. To make your body hard like a rock, you've got to train.
- 13 "Now if you want to train and become hard like the rock, I can help you. You need to develop skills, and you need to acquire knowledge. Skills will make you strong, and knowledge is power. It's my job to help you with language skills. I'll help you train to become a better reader. I'll help you train to be a better writer. But you know, I'm just a trainer. I can't make you be a fighter.

14 “All I can do is tell you that you need to make yourself a fighter. You need to become a rock. Because you don’t want to be flabby when the real world comes along and takes a crack at you. Don’t spend the semester just being Mr. Cool Man or Ms. Designer Jeans or Mr. or Ms. Sex Symbol of the class. Be someone. Be someone.”

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15 He then smashed that wad of clay one more time, and the thud of his fist broke the silence and then created more silence. He sure had our total attention.

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16 “At the end of the semester, some of you are going to leave here, and you’re still going to be clay. You’re going to be the kind of person that life can smush around, and that’s sad. But some of you, maybe a lot of you, are going to be rocks. I want you to be a rock. Go for it. And when this comes”—and he held up his fist—“you’ll be ready.”

17 And then Mr. Gery segued into talking about the course. But his demonstration stayed with most of us. And as the semester unfolded, he would call back his vivid images. When someone would not hand in a paper and make a lame excuse, he would say, “Whatever you say, Mr. Clay.” Or “whatever you say, Ms. Clay.” Or if someone would forget their book, or not study for a test, or not do a reading assignment, he would say, “Of course, Mr. Clay.” Sometimes we would get into it also and call out, “Hey, Clayman.”

18 Mr. Gery worked us very hard, but he was not a mean person. We all knew he was a kind man who wanted us to become strong. It was obvious he wanted us to do well. By the end of the semester, he had to call very few of us Mr. or Ms. Clay.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *squashed* in “If the real world comes along and takes a swing at you, you’re likely to get squashed. And you know what, the real world will come along and take a swing at you” (paragraph 6) means
 - a. upset.
 - b. ignored.
 - c. crushed.
 - d. excited.
2. The words *segued into* in “And then Mr. Gery segued into talking about the course. But his demonstration stayed with most of us” (paragraph 17) mean
 - a. stopped.

- b. transitioned.
 - c. gave up.
 - d. anticipated.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
- a. Mr. Gery's English Class
 - b. Life's Heavy Hits
 - c. Training to Be a Fighter in Life
 - d. Mr. Clayman
-
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?
- a. The students in Mr. Gery's class experienced difficulties in their lives.
 - b. Mr. Gery's job was to transform his students into fighters.
 - c. Mr. Gery's students were the only ones who could make themselves strong.
 - d. Although Mr. Gery worked his students very hard, he was a kind man.
5. The students in Mr. Gery's twelfth-grade English class wanted to be
- a. clay.
 - b. fists.
 - c. rocks.
 - d. teachers.
6. *True or false?* _____ Mr. Gery promised all his students that they would be rocks at the end of the semester.
7. When Mr. Gery smashed his fist into the mound of clay for a second time, his students
- a. remained silent.
 - b. laughed uneasily.
 - c. shouted "Mr. Clayman."
 - d. looked bored.
8. When the author writes, "The best teacher I ever had was Mr. Gery," we can conclude that Mr. Gery

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660

- a. was an easy teacher.
 - b. made English fun and exciting.
 - c. taught the author a meaningful lesson.
 - d. taught the author to be a better writer.
9. When Mr. Gery asked his students if they wanted to be the clay or the rock (paragraph 8), we can infer that
- a. he did not know what they would say.
 - b. he knew that they wanted to be the rock.
 - c. he thought that some of them wanted to be the clay.
 - d. his students already knew how to be the rock.
10. When Mr. Gery called a student “Mr. Clay” or “Ms. Clay” (paragraph 17), we can infer that
- a. he was disgusted with the student.
 - b. he hoped to embarrass the student.
 - c. he forgot the student’s name.
 - d. he wanted the student to do better.

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. Why did the author mention several times that Mr. Gery smiled at his students throughout his entire demonstration? How would his students have responded if Mr. Gery scowled?
- 2. What do you think Mr. Gery meant when he told his students, “Everything is up to you” (paragraph 2)? Do you feel this way about learning? About life?
- 3. Do you know anyone who is like a flattened lump of clay? Do you know anyone who is strong like a well-trained fighter? What factors determine a person’s fate?

About Structure

- 4. The author uses narration to illustrate his main point. Below, write three time transitions he uses to advance his narration.
- _____

- 5. The author uses dialogue to recount what Mr. Gery told his class about the fist, the clay, and the rock but does not use dialogue to tell his readers what Mr. Gery said about the course (paragraph 17). Why do you think the author chose this narrative strategy?

About Style and Tone

- 6. Is the author just telling his readers about his twelfth-grade English teacher, or is the author hoping to inspire his readers to do something?
- 7. What do you think Mr. Gery’s attitude toward those students who have “already taken some heavy hits” is (paragraph 6)? What does he offer these students?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Write a paragraph about an influential teacher in your life. Perhaps you had a very inspiring teacher who challenged you to try your best, or you had a teacher who took the time to learn about what was happening in your life outside the classroom. Provide plenty of detail to let your readers know why you consider this teacher so influential. Your topic sentence may begin like this:

The teacher who inspired me to _____.

661

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

662

Mr. Gery tells his students, “All I can do is tell you that you need to make yourself a fighter.” Do you know a person who took some “heavy hits” but remained hard like a rock, someone who didn’t want to be flabby when the real world came along and took a crack at him or her? Write a paragraph describing how this person trained and made him- or herself a fighter. Introduce that person in your topic sentence, as in these examples:

My older brother was born without the ability to hear, but through hard work and a positive attitude he did well in school, played sports, and graduated from Gallaudet University.

Although my best friend was involved in a very abusive relationship, she left her abuser, sought counseling, and today volunteers at a women’s shelter.

Then give several specific examples of the person’s efforts. Conclude by providing a prediction for this person’s future.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Mr. Gery tells his students that some of them will leave his class as lumps of clay and some will leave as rocks. Those who are clay will get smashed around, but those who are rocks will be ready for life. Write an essay in which you compare a “clay” person and a “rock” person. Perhaps you know someone who is addicted to alcohol but refuses to recognize the problem and someone who attends Alcoholics Anonymous and is living a sober life. Develop your essay by describing each person in detail. You can present your details point by point or one side at a time (see [pages 224–225](#)). Share your rough draft with a partner to get and give feedback for revision. Refer to the checklist on the inside back cover.



What Good Families Are Doing Right: Delores Curran

PREVIEW

It isn’t easy to be a successful parent these days. Pressured by the conflicting demands of home and workplace, confused by changing moral standards, and drowned out by the constant barrage of new media, today’s parents seem to be facing impossible odds in their struggle to raise healthy families. Yet some parents manage to “do it all”—and even remain on speaking terms with their children. How do they do it? Delores Curran’s survey offers some signi? cant suggestions; her article could serve as a recipe for a successful family.

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663

- 1 I have worked with families for fifteen years, conducting hundreds of seminars, workshops, and classes on parenting, and I meet good families all the time. They’re fairly easy to recognize. Good families have a kind of visible strength. They expect problems and work together to find solutions, applying common sense and trying new methods to meet new needs. And they share a common shortcoming—they can tell me in a minute what’s wrong with them, but they aren’t sure what’s right with them. Many healthy families with whom I work, in fact, protest at being called *healthy*. They don’t think they are. The professionals who work with them do.
- 2 To prepare the book on which this article is based, I asked respected workers in the fields of education, religion, health, family counseling, and voluntary organizations to identify a list of possible traits of a healthy family. Together we isolated fifty-six such traits, and I sent this list to five hundred professionals who regularly work with families—teachers, doctors, principals, members of the clergy, scout directors, YMCA leaders, family counselors, social workers—asking them to pick the fifteen qualities they most commonly found in healthy families.
- 3 While all of these traits are important, the one most often cited as central to close family life is communication: The healthy family knows how to talk—and how to listen.

- 4 “Without communication you don’t know one another,” wrote one family counselor. “If you don’t know one another, you don’t care about one another, and that’s what the family is all about.”
- 5 “The most familiar complaint I hear from wives I counsel is ‘He won’t talk to me’ and ‘He doesn’t listen to me,’” said a pastoral marriage counselor. “And when I share this complaint with their husbands, they don’t hear *me*, either.”
- 6 “We have kids in classes whose families are so robotized by television that they don’t know one another,” said a fifth-grade teacher.
- 7 Professional counselors are not the only ones to recognize the need. The phenomenal growth of communication groups such as Parent Effectiveness Training, Parent Awareness, Marriage Encounter, Couple Communication, and literally hundreds of others tells us that the need for effective communication—the sharing of deepest feelings—is felt by many.
- 8 Healthy families have also recognized this need, and they have, either instinctively or consciously, developed methods of meeting it. They know that conflicts are to be expected, that we all become angry and frustrated and discouraged. And they know how to reveal those feelings—good and bad—to each other. Honest communication isn’t always easy. But when it’s working well, there are certain recognizable signs or symptoms, what I call the hallmarks of the successfully communicating family.

The Family Exhibits a Strong Relationship between the Parents

- 9 According to Dr. Jerry M. Lewis—author of a significant work on families, *No Single Thread*—healthy spouses complement, rather than dominate, each other. 663
Either husband or wife could be the leader, depending on the circumstances. In the unhealthy families he studied, the dominant spouse had to hide feelings of weakness while the submissive spouse feared being put down if he or she exposed a weakness. 664
- 10 Children in the healthy family have no question about which parent is boss. Both parents are. If children are asked who is boss, they’re likely to respond, “Sometimes Mom, sometimes Dad.” And, in a wonderful statement, Dr. Lewis adds, “If you ask if they’re comfortable with this, they look at you as if you’re crazy—as if there’s no other way it ought to be.”
- 11 My survey respondents echo Dr. Lewis. One wrote, “The healthiest families I know are ones in which the mother and father have a strong, loving relationship. This seems to flow over to the children and even beyond the home. It seems to breed security in the children and, in turn, fosters the ability to take risks, to reach out to others, to search for their own answers, become independent and develop a good self-image.”

The Family Has Control over Television

- 12 Television has been maligned, praised, damned, cherished, and even thrown out. It has more influence on children’s values than anything else except their parents. Over and over, when I’m invited to help families mend their communication ruptures, I hear “But we have no time for this.” These families have literally turned their “family-together” time over to television. Even those who

control the quality of programs watched and set “homework-first” regulations feel reluctant to intrude upon the individual’s right to spend his or her spare time in front of the set. Many families avoid clashes over program selection by furnishing a set for each family member. One of the women who was most desperate to establish a better sense of communication in her family confided to me that they owned nine sets. Nine sets for seven people!

- 13 Whether the breakdown in family communication leads to excessive viewing or whether too much television breaks into family lives, we don’t know. But we do know that we can become out of one another’s reach when we’re in front of a TV set. The term *television widow* is not humorous to thousands whose spouses are absent even when they’re there. One woman remarked, “I can’t get worried about whether there’s life after death. I’d be satisfied with life after dinner.”
- 14 In family-communication workshops, I ask families to make a list of phrases they most commonly hear in their home. One parent was aghast to discover that his family’s most familiar comments were “What’s on?” and “Move.” In families like this one, communication isn’t hostile—it’s just missing.
- 15 But television doesn’t have to be a villain. A 1980 Gallup Poll found that the public sees great potential for television as a positive force. It can be a tremendous device for initiating discussion on subjects that may not come up elsewhere, subjects such as sexuality, corporate ethics, sportsmanship, and marital fidelity.
- 16 Even very bad programs offer material for values clarification if family members view them together. My sixteen-year-old son and his father recently watched a program in which hazardous driving was part of the hero’s characterization. At one point, my son turned to his dad and asked, “Is that possible to do with that kind of truck?”
- 17 “I don’t know,” replied my husband, “but it sure is dumb. If that load shifted. . .” With that, they launched into a discussion on the responsibility of drivers that didn’t have to originate as a parental lecture. Furthermore, as the discussion became more engrossing to them, they turned the sound down so that they could continue their conversation.
- 18 Parents frequently report similar experiences; in fact, this use of television was recommended in the widely publicized 1972 Surgeon General’s report as the most effective form of television gatekeeping by parents. Instead of turning off the set, parents should view programs with their children and make moral judgments and initiate discussion. Talking about the problems and attitudes of a TV family can be a lively, nonthreatening way to risk sharing real fears, hopes, and dreams.

664

665

The Family Listens and Responds

- 19 “My parents say they want me to come to them with problems, but when I do, either they’re busy or they only half-listen and keep on doing what they were doing—like shaving or making a grocery list. If a friend of theirs came over to talk, they’d stop, be polite, and listen,” said one of the children quoted in a *Christian Science Monitor* interview by Ann McCarroll. This child put his finger on the most difficult problem of communicating in families: the inability to listen.

- 20 It is usually easier to react than to respond. When we react, we reflect our own experiences and feelings; when we respond, we get into the other person's feelings. For example:

Tom, age seventeen: "I don't know if I want to go to college. I don't think I'd do very well there."

Father: "Nonsense. Of course you'll do well."

- 21 That's reacting. This father is cutting off communication. He's refusing either to hear the boy's fears or to consider his feelings, possibly because he can't accept the idea that his son might not attend college. Here's another way of handling the same situation:

Tom: "I don't know if I want to go to college. I don't think I'd do very well there."

Father: "Why not?"

Tom: "Because I'm not that smart."

Father: "Yeah, that's scary. I worried about that, too."

Tom: "Did you ever come close to flunking out?"

Father: "No, but I worried a lot before I went because I thought college would be full of brains. Once I got there, I found out that most of the kids were just like me."

- 22 This father has responded rather than reacted to his son's fears. First, he searched for the reason behind his son's lack of confidence and found it was fear of academic ability (it could have been fear of leaving home, of a new environment, of peer pressure, or of any of a number of things); second, he accepted the fear as legitimate; third, he empathized by admitting to having the same fear when he was Tom's age; and, finally, he explained why his, not Tom's, fears turned out to be groundless. He did all this without denigrating or lecturing.
- 23 And that's tough for parents to do. Often we don't want to hear our children's fears, because those fears frighten us; or we don't want to pay attention to their dreams because their dreams aren't what we have in mind for them. Parents who deny such feelings will allow only surface conversation. It's fine as long as a child says, "School was OK today," but when she says, "I'm scared of boys," the parents are uncomfortable. They don't want her to be afraid of boys, but since they don't quite know what to say, they react with a pleasant "Oh, you'll outgrow it." She probably will, but what she needs at the moment is someone to hear and understand her pain.
- 24 In Ann McCarroll's interviews, she talked to one fifteen-year-old boy who said he had "some mother. Each morning she sits with me while I eat breakfast. We talk about anything and everything. She isn't refined or elegant or educated. She's a terrible housekeeper. But she's interested in everything I do, and she always listens to me—even if she's busy or tired."
- 25 That's the kind of listening found in families that experience real communication. Answers to the routine question, "How was your day?" are heard with the eyes and heart as well as the ears.

665

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Nuances are picked up and questions are asked, although problems are not necessarily solved.

Members of a family who really listen to one another instinctively know that if people listen to you, they are interested in you. And that's enough for most of us.

The Family Recognizes Unspoken Messages

26 Much of our communication—especially our communication of feelings—is nonverbal. Dr. Lewis defines *empathy* as “someone responding to you in such a way that you feel deeply understood.” He says, “There is probably no more important dimension in all of human relationships than the capacity for empathy. And healthy families teach empathy.” Their members are allowed to be mad, glad, and sad. There's no crime in being in a bad mood, nor is there betrayal in being happy while someone else is feeling moody. The family recognizes that bad days and good days attack everyone at different times.

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27 Nonverbal expressions of love, too, are the best way to show children that parents love each other. A spouse reaching for the other's hand, a wink, a squeeze on the shoulder, a “How's-your-back-this-morning?” a meaningful glance across the room—all these tell children how their parents feel about each other.

667

28 The most destructive nonverbal communication in marriage is silence. Silence can mean lack of interest, hostility, denigration, boredom, or outright war. On the part of a teen or preteen, silence usually indicates pain, sometimes very deep pain. The sad irony discovered by so many family therapists is that parents who seek professional help when a teenager becomes silent have often denied the child any other way of communicating. And although they won't permit their children to become angry or to reveal doubts or to share depression, they do worry about the withdrawal that results. Rarely do they see any connection between the two.

29 Healthy families use signs, symbols, body language, smiles, and other gestures to express caring and love. They deal with silence and withdrawal in a positive, open way. Communication doesn't mean just talking or listening; it includes all the clues to a person's feelings—his bearing, her expression, their resignation. Family members don't have to say, “I'm hurting,” or, “I'm in need.” A quick glance tells that. And they have developed ways of responding that indicate caring and love, whether or not there's an immediate solution to the pain.

The Family Encourages Individual Feelings and Independent Thinking

30 Close families encourage the emergence of individual personalities through open sharing of thoughts and feelings. Unhealthy families tend to be less open, less accepting of differences among members. The family must be Republican, or Bronco supporters, or gun-control advocates, and woe to the individual who says, “Yes, but . . .”

31 Instead of finding differing opinions threatening, the healthy family finds them exhilarating. It is exciting to witness such a family discussing politics, sports, or the world. Members freely say, “I don't agree with you,” without risking ridicule or rebuke. They say, “I think it's wrong . . .” immediately after Dad says, “I think it's right . . .”; and dad listens and responds.

- 32 Give-and-take gives children practice in articulating their thoughts at home so that eventually they'll feel confident outside the home. What may seem to be verbal rambling by preteens during a family conversation is a prelude to sorting out their thinking and putting words to their thoughts.
- 33 Rigid families don't understand the dynamics of give-and-take. Some label it disrespectful and argumentative; others find it confusing. Dr. John Meeks, medical director of the Psychiatric Institute of Montgomery County, Maryland, claims that argument is a way of life with normally developing adolescents. "In early adolescence they'll argue with parents about anything at all; as they grow older, the quantity of argument decreases but the quality increases." According to Dr. Meeks, arguing is something adolescents need to do. If the argument doesn't become too bitter, they have a good chance to test their own beliefs and feelings. "Incidentally," says Meeks, "parents can expect to 'lose' most of these arguments, because adolescents are not fettered by logic or even reality." Nor are they likely to be polite. Learning how to disagree respectfully is a difficult task, but good families work at it.
- 34 Encouraging individual feelings and thoughts, of course, in no way presumes that parents permit their children to do whatever they want. There's a great difference between permitting a son to express an opinion on marijuana and allowing him to use it. That his opinion conflicts with his parents' opinion is OK as long as his parents make sure he knows their thinking on the subject. Whether he admits it or not, he's likely at least to consider their ideas if he respects them.
- 35 Permitting teenagers to sort out their feelings and thoughts in open discussions at home gives them valuable experience in dealing with a bewildering array of situations they may encounter when they leave home. Cutting off discussion of behavior unacceptable to us, on the other hand, makes our young people feel guilty for even thinking about values contrary to ours and ends up making those values more attractive to them.

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The Family Recognizes Turn-Off Words and Put-Down Phrases

- 36 Some families deliberately use hurtful language in their daily communication. "What did you do all day around here?" can be a red flag to a woman who has spent her day on household tasks that don't show unless they're not done. "If only we had enough money" can be a rebuke to a husband who is working as hard as he can to provide for the family. "Flunk any tests today, John?" only discourages a child who may be having trouble in school.
- 37 Close families seem to recognize that a comment made in jest can be insulting. A father in one of my groups confided that he could tease his wife about everything but her skiing. "I don't know why she's so sensitive about that, but I back off on it. I can say anything I want to about her cooking, her appearance, her mothering—whatever. But not her skiing."
- 38 One of my favorite exercises with families is to ask them to reflect upon phrases they most like to hear and those they least like to hear. Recently, I invited seventyfive fourth- and fifth-graders to submit the words they most like to hear from their mothers. Here are the five big winners:

"I love you."

“Yes.”

“Time to eat.”

“You can go.”

“You can stay up late.”

668

- 39 And on the children’s list of what they least like to hear from one another are the following:

669

“I’m telling.”

“Mom says!”

“I know something you don’t know.”

“You think you’re so big.”

“Just see if I ever let you use my bike again.”

- 40 It can be worthwhile for a family to list the phrases members like most and least to hear, and post them. Often parents aren’t even aware of the reaction of their children to certain routine comments. Or keep a record of the comments heard most often over a period of a week or two. It can provide good clues to the level of family sensitivity. If the list has a lot of “shut ups” and “stop its,” that family needs to pay more attention to its relationships, especially the role that communication plays in them.

The Family Interrupts, but Equally

- 41 When Dr. Jerry M. Lewis began to study the healthy family, he and his staff videotaped families in the process of problem solving. The family was given a question, such as, “What’s the main thing wrong with your family?” Answers varied, but what was most significant was what the family actually did: who took control, how individuals responded or reacted, what were the put-downs, and whether some members were entitled to speak more than others.
- 42 The researchers found that healthy families expected everyone to speak openly about feelings. Nobody was urged to hold back. In addition, these family members interrupted one another repeatedly, but no one person was interrupted more than anyone else.
- 43 Manners, particularly polite conversational techniques, are not hallmarks of the communicating family. This should make many parents feel better about their family’s dinner conversation. One father reported to me that at their table people had to take a number to finish a sentence. Finishing sentences, however, doesn’t seem all that important in the communicating family. Members aren’t sensitive to being interrupted, either. The intensity and spontaneity of the exchange are more important than propriety in conversation.

The Family Develops a Pattern of Reconciliation

- 44 “We know how to break up,” one man said, “but who ever teaches us to make up?” Survey respondents indicated that there is indeed a pattern of reconciliation in healthy families that is missing in others. “It usually isn’t a kiss-and-make-up situation,” explained one family therapist, “but there are certain rituals developed over a long period of time that indicate it’s time to get well again. Between husband and wife, it might be a concessionary phrase to which the other is expected to respond in kind. Within a family, it might be that the person who stomps off to his or her room voluntarily reenters the family circle, where something is said to make him or her welcome.” 669 670
- 45 When I asked several families how they knew a fight had ended, I got remarkably similar answers from individuals questioned separately. “We all come out of our rooms,” responded every member of one family. Three members of another family said, “Mom says, ‘Anybody want a Pepsi?’” One five-year-old scratched his head and furrowed his forehead after I asked him how he knew the family fight was over. Finally, he said, “Well, Daddy gives a great big yawn and says, ‘Well . . .’” This scene is easy to visualize, as one parent decides that the unpleasantness needs to end and it’s time to end the fighting and to pull together again as a family.
- 46 Why have we neglected the important art of reconciling? “Because we have pretended that good families don’t fight,” says one therapist. “They do. It’s essential to fight for good health in the family. It gets things out into the open. But we need to learn to put ourselves back together—and many families never learn this.”
- 47 Close families know how to time divisive and emotional issues that may cause friction. They don’t bring up potentially explosive subjects right before they go out, for example, or before bedtime. They tend to schedule discussions rather than allow a matter to explode, and thus they keep a large measure of control over the atmosphere in which they will fight and reconcile. Good families know that they need enough time to discuss issues heatedly, rationally, and completely—and enough time to reconcile. “You’ve got to solve it right there,” said one father. “Don’t let it go on and on. It just causes more problems. Then when it’s solved, let it be. No nagging, no remembering.”

The Family Fosters Table Time and Conversation

- 48 Traditionally, the dinner table has been a symbol of socialization. It’s probably the one time each day that parents and children are assured of uninterrupted time with one another.
- 49 Therapists frequently call upon a patient’s memory of the family table during childhood in order to determine the degree of communication and interaction there was in the patient’s early life. Some patients recall nothing. Mealtime was either so unpleasant or so unimpressive that they have blocked it out of their memories. Therapists say that there is a relationship between the love in a home and life around the family table. It is to the table that love or discord eventually comes.
- 50 But we are spending less table time together. Fast-food dining, even within the home, is becoming a way of life for too many of us. Work schedules, individual organized activities, and television all limit the quantity and quality of mealtime interaction. In an informal study conducted by a church 670 671

group, 68 percent of the families interviewed in three congregations saw nothing wrong with watching television while eating.

- 51 Families who do a good job of communicating tend to make the dinner meal an important part of their day. A number of respondents indicated that adults in the healthiest families refuse dinner business meetings as a matter of principle and discourage their children from sports activities that cut into mealtime hours. “We know which of our swimmers will or won’t practice at dinnertime,” said a coach, with mixed admiration. “Some parents never allow their children to miss dinners. Some don’t care at all.” These families pay close attention to the number of times they’ll be able to be together in a week, and they rearrange schedules to be sure of spending this time together.
- 52 The family that wants to improve communication should look closely at its attitudes toward the family table. Are family table time and conversation important? Is table time open and friendly or warlike and sullen? Is it conducive to sharing more than food—does it encourage the sharing of ideas, feelings, and family intimacies?
- 53 We all need to talk to one another. We need to know we’re loved and appreciated and respected. We want to share our intimacies, not just physical intimacies but all the intimacies in our lives. Communication is the most important element of family life because it is basic to loving relationships. It is the energy that fuels the caring, giving, sharing, and affirming. Without genuine sharing of ourselves, we cannot know one another’s needs and fears. Good communication is what makes all the rest of it work.



Based on the traits that Curran describes in her essay, are either of the families pictured here “successful” families? What is it about the family’s appearance and interaction with one another that lets you know this? In what ways is the “successful” family different from the other family pictured? Considering these questions and the essay you’ve just read, write a paragraph in which you contrast the two families pictured here.

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672

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



1. The word *aghast* in “One parent was aghast to discover that his family’s most familiar comments were ‘What’s on?’ and ‘Move’” (paragraph 14) means
 - a. horrified.
 - b. satisfied.
 - c. curious.
 - d. amused.
2. The word *engrossing* in “as the discussion became more engrossing to them, they turned the sound down so that they could continue their conversation” (paragraph 17) means
 - a. disgusting.
 - b. intellectual.
 - c. foolish.
 - d. interesting.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. Successful Communication
 - b. How to Solve Family Conflicts
 - c. Characteristics of Families
 - d. Hallmarks of the Communicating Family
4. Which sentence best expresses the article’s main point?
 - a. Television can and often does destroy family life.
 - b. More American families are unhappy than ever before.
 - c. A number of qualities mark the healthy and communicating family.
 - d. Strong families encourage independent thinking.
5. *True or false?* ____ According to the article, healthy families have no use for television.
6. Healthy families
 - a. never find it hard to communicate.
 - b. have no conflicts with each other.

- c. know how to reveal their feelings.
- d. permit one of the parents to make all final decisions.

672

7. The author has found that good families frequently make a point of being together

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- a. in the mornings.
- b. after school.
- c. during dinner.
- d. before bedtime.

8. *True or false?* ____ The article implies that the most troublesome nonverbal signal is silence.

9. The article implies that

- a. verbal messages are always more accurate than nonverbal ones.
- b. in strong families, parents practice tolerance of thoughts and feelings.
- c. parents must avoid arguing with their adolescent children.
- d. parents should prevent their children from watching television.

10. From the article, we can conclude that

- a. a weak marital relationship often results in a weak family.
- b. children should not witness a disagreement between parents.
- c. children who grow up in healthy families learn not to interrupt other family members.
- d. parents always find it easier to respond to their children than to react to them.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

1. What are the nine hallmarks of a successfully communicating family? Which of the nine do you feel are most important?
2. How do good parents control television? How do they make television a positive force instead of a negative one?
3. In paragraph 20, the author says, "It is usually easier to react than to respond." What is the difference between the two terms *react* and *respond*?

4. Why, according to Curran, is a “pattern of reconciliation” (paragraph 44) crucial to good family life? Besides those patterns mentioned in the essay, can you describe a reconciliation pattern you have developed with friends or family?
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About Structure

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5. What is the thesis of the selection? Write here the number of the paragraph in which it is stated:_____
6. What purpose is achieved by Curran’s introduction (paragraphs 1–2)? Why is a reader likely to feel that her article will be reliable and worthwhile?
7. Curran frequently uses dialogue or quotations from unnamed parents or children as the basis for her examples. The conversation related in paragraphs 16–17 is one instance. Find three other dialogues used to illustrate points in the essay and write the numbers below:

Paragraph(s) _____

Paragraph(s)_____

Paragraph(s)_____

About Style and Tone

8. Curran enlivens the essay by using some interesting and humorous remarks from parents, children, and counselors. One is the witty comment in paragraph 5 from a marriage counselor: “And when I share this complaint with their husbands, they don’t hear *me*, either.” Find two other places where the author keeps your interest by using humorous or enjoyable quotations, and write the numbers of the paragraphs here:

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Write a definition paragraph on the hallmarks of a *bad* family. Your topic sentence might be “A bad family is one that is _____, _____, and _____.”

To get started, you should first reread the features of a good family explained in the selection. Doing so will help you think about what qualities are found in a bad family. Prepare a list of as many bad qualities as you can think of. Then go through the list and decide on the qualities that seem most characteristic of a bad family.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Curran tells us five phrases that some children say they most like to hear from their mothers (paragraph 38). When you were younger, what statement or action of one of your parents (or another adult) would make you especially happy—or sad? Write a paragraph that begins with a topic sentence like one of the following:

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A passing comment my grandfather once made really devastated me.

When I was growing up, there were several typical ways my mother treated me that always made me sad.

A critical remark by my fifth-grade teacher was the low point of my life.

My mother has always had several lines that make her children feel very pleased.

You may want to write a narrative that describes in detail the particular time and place of a statement or action. Or you may want to provide three or so examples of statements or actions and their effect on you.

To get started, make up two long lists of childhood memories involving adults—happy memories and sad memories. Then decide which memory or memories you could most vividly describe in a paragraph. Remember that your goal is to help your readers see for themselves why a particular time was sad or happy for you.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

In light of Curran’s description of what healthy families do right, examine your own family. Which of Curran’s traits of communicative families fit your family? Write an essay pointing out three things that your family is doing right in creating a communicative climate for its members. Or, if you feel your family could work harder at communicating, write the essay about three specific ways your family could improve. In either case, choose three of Curran’s nine “hallmarks of the successfully communicating family” and show how they do or do not apply to your family.

In your introductory paragraph, include a thesis statement as well as a plan of development that lists the three traits you will talk about. Then present these traits in turn in three supporting paragraphs. Develop each paragraph by giving specific examples of conversations, arguments, behavior patterns, and so on, that illustrate how your family communicates. Finally, conclude your essay with a summarizing sentence or two and a final thought about your subject.

To get ideas flowing, draw a picture of your family, and consider what the word “family” means to you. In groups of two or three, share your pictures and definitions, discussing how your family communicates. Compare and contrast your experiences with “successful” communication.



Education and Self-Improvement

Do It Better!: Ben Carson, M.D., with Cecil Murphey

PREVIEW



If you suspect that you are now as “smart” as you’ll ever be, then read the following selection. Taken from the book *Think Big*, it is about Dr. Ben Carson, who was sure he was “the dumbest kid in the class” when he was in fifth grade. Carson tells how he turned his life totally around from what was a path of failure. Today he is a famous neurosurgeon at the Johns Hopkins University Children’s Center in Baltimore, Maryland.

- 1 “Benjamin, is this your report card?” my mother asked as she picked up the folded white card from the table.
- 2 “Uh, yeah,” I said, trying to sound casual. Too ashamed to hand it to her, I had dropped it on the table, hoping that she wouldn’t notice until after I went to bed.
- 3 It was the first report card I had received from Higgins Elementary School since we had moved back from Boston to Detroit, only a few months earlier.
- 4 I had been in the fifth grade not even two weeks before everyone considered me the dumbest kid in the class and frequently made jokes about me. Before long I too began to feel as though I really was the most stupid kid in fifth grade. Despite Mother’s frequently saying, “You’re smart, Bennie. You can do anything you want to do,” I did not believe her.
- 5 No one else in school thought I was smart, either.

- 6 Now, as Mother examined my report card, she asked, “What’s this grade in reading?” (Her tone of voice told me that I was in trouble.) Although I was embarrassed, I did not think too much about it. Mother knew that I wasn’t doing well in math, but she did not know I was doing so poorly in every subject.
- 7 While she slowly read my report card, reading everything one word at a time, I hurried into my room and started to get ready for bed. A few minutes later, Mother came into my bedroom.
- 8 “Benjamin,” she said, “are these your grades?” She held the card in front of me as if I hadn’t seen it before.
- 9 “Oh, yeah, but you know, it doesn’t mean much.”
- 10 “No, that’s not true, Bennie. It means a lot.”
- 11 “Just a report card.”
- 12 “But it’s more than that.”
- 13 Knowing I was in for it now, I prepared to listen, yet I was not all that interested. I did not like school very much and there was no reason why I should. Inasmuch as I was the dumbest kid in the class, what did I have to look forward to? The others laughed at me and made jokes about me every day.
- 14 “Education is the only way you’re ever going to escape poverty,” she said. “It’s the only way you’re ever going to get ahead in life and be successful. Do you understand that?”
- 15 “Yes, Mother,” I mumbled.
- 16 “If you keep on getting these kinds of grades you’re going to spend the rest of your life on skid row, or at best sweeping floors in a factory. That’s not the kind of life that I want for you. That’s not the kind of life that God wants for you.”
- 17 I hung my head, genuinely ashamed. My mother had been raising me and my older brother, Curtis, by herself. Having only a third-grade education herself, she knew the value of what she did not have. Daily she drummed into Curtis and me that we had to do our best in school.
- 18 “You’re just not living up to your potential,” she said. “I’ve got two mighty smart boys and I know they can do better.”
- 19 I had done my best—at least I had when I first started at Higgins Elementary School. How could I do much when I did not understand anything going on in our class?
- 20 In Boston we had attended a parochial school, but I hadn’t learned much because of a teacher who seemed more interested in talking to another female teacher than in teaching us. Possibly, this teacher was not solely to blame—perhaps I wasn’t emotionally able to learn much. My parents had separated just before we went to Boston, when I was eight years old. I loved both my mother and father and went through considerable trauma over their separating. For months afterward, I kept thinking that my parents would get back together, that my daddy would come home again the way he used to, and that

676

677

we could be the same old family again—but he never came back. Consequently, we moved to Boston and lived with Aunt Jean and Uncle William Avery in a tenement building for two years until Mother had saved enough money to bring us back to Detroit.

21 Mother kept shaking the report card at me as she sat on the side of my bed. “You have to work harder. You have to use that good brain that God gave you, Bennie. Do you understand that?”

22 “Yes, Mother.” Each time she paused, I would dutifully say those words.

23 “I work among rich people, people who are educated,” she said. “I watch how they act, and I know they can do anything they want to do. And so can you.” She put her arm on my shoulder. “Bennie, you can do anything they can do—only you can do it better!”

677

24 Mother had said those words before. Often. At the time, they did not mean much to me. Why should they? I really believed that I was the dumbest kid in fifth grade, but of course, I never told her that.

678

25 “I just don’t know what to do about you boys,” she said. “I’m going to talk to God about you and Curtis.” She paused, stared into space, then said (more to herself than to me), “I need the Lord’s guidance on what to do. You just can’t bring in any more report cards like this.”

26 As far as I was concerned, the report card matter was over.

27 The next day was like the previous ones—just another bad day in school, another day of being laughed at because I did not get a single problem right in arithmetic and couldn’t get any words right on the spelling test. As soon as I came home from school, I changed into play clothes and ran outside. Most of the boys my age played softball, or the game I liked best, “Tip the Top.”

28 We played Tip the Top by placing a bottle cap on one of the sidewalk cracks. Then taking a ball—any kind that bounced—we’d stand on a line and take turns throwing the ball at the bottle top, trying to flip it over. Whoever succeeded got two points. If anyone actually moved the cap more than a few inches, he won five points. Ten points came if he flipped it into the air and it landed on the other side.

29 When it grew dark or we got tired, Curtis and I would finally go inside and watch TV. The set stayed on until we went to bed. Because Mother worked long hours, she was never home until just before we went to bed. Sometimes I would awaken when I heard her unlocking the door.

30 Two evenings after the incident with the report card, Mother came home about an hour before our bedtime. Curtis and I were sprawled out, watching TV. She walked across the room, snapped off the set, and faced both of us. “Boys,” she said, “you’re wasting too much of your time in front of that television. You don’t get an education from staring at television all the time.”

31 Before either of us could make a protest, she told us that she had been praying for wisdom. “The Lord’s told me what to do,” she said. “So from now on, you will not watch television, except for two preselected programs each week.”

32 “Just *two* programs?” I could hardly believe she would say such a terrible thing.

- 33 “That’s not—” “And *only* after you’ve done your homework. Furthermore, you don’t play outside after school, either, until you’ve done all your homework.”
- 34 “Everybody else plays outside right after school,” I said, unable to think of anything except how bad it would be if I couldn’t play with my friends. “I won’t have any friends if I stay in the house all the time —”
- 35 “That may be,” Mother said, “but everybody else is not going to be as successful as you are—”
- 36 “But, Mother—”
- 37 “This is what we’re going to do. I asked God for wisdom, and this is the answer I got.”
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- 38 I tried to offer several other arguments, but Mother was firm. I glanced at Curtis, expecting him to speak up, but he did not say anything. He lay on the floor, staring at his feet.
- 39 “Don’t worry about everybody else. The whole world is full of ‘everybody else,’ you know that? But only a few make a significant achievement.”
- 40 The loss of TV and play time was bad enough. I got up off the floor, feeling as if everything was against me. Mother wasn’t going to let me play with my friends, and there would be no more television —almost none, anyway. She was stopping me from having any fun in life.
- 41 “And that isn’t all,” she said. “Come back, Bennie.”
- 42 I turned around, wondering what else there could be.
- 43 “In addition,” she said, “to doing your homework, you have to read two books from the library each week. Every single week.”
- 44 “Two books? Two?” Even though I was in fifth grade, I had never read a whole book in my life.
- 45 “Yes, two. When you finish reading them, you must write me a book report just like you do at school. You’re not living up to your potential, so I’m going to see that you do.”
- 46 Usually Curtis, who was two years older, was the more rebellious. But this time he seemed to grasp the wisdom of what Mother said. He did not say one word.
- 47 She stared at Curtis. “You understand?”
- 48 He nodded.
- 49 “Bennie, is it clear?”
- 50 “Yes, Mother.” I agreed to do what Mother told me—it wouldn’t have occurred to me not to obey—but I did not like it. Mother was being unfair and demanding more of us than other parents did.
- 51 The following day was Thursday. After school, Curtis and I walked to the local branch of the library. I did not like it much, but then I had not spent that much time in any library.

678

679

- 52 We both wandered around a little in the children’s section, not having any idea about how to select books or which books we wanted to check out.
- 53 The librarian came over to us and asked if she could help. We explained that both of us wanted to check out two books.
- 54 “What kind of books would you like to read?” the librarian asked.
- 55 “Animals,” I said after thinking about it. “Something about animals.”
- 56 “I’m sure we have several that you’d like.” She led me over to a section of books. She left me and guided Curtis to another section of the room. I flipped through the row of books until I found two that looked easy enough for me to read. One of them, *Chip, the Dam Builder*—about a beaver—was the first one I had ever checked out. As soon as I got home, I started to read it. It was the first book I ever read all the way through even though it took me two nights. Reluctantly I admitted afterward to Mother that I really had liked reading about Chip.

679

- 57 Within a month I could find my way around the children’s section like someone who had gone there all his life. By then the library staff knew Curtis and me and the kind of books we chose. They often made suggestions. “Here’s a delightful book about a squirrel,” I remember one of them telling me.
- 58 As she told me part of the story, I tried to appear indifferent, but as soon as she handed it to me, I opened the book and started to read.
- 59 Best of all, we became favorites of the librarians. When new books came in that they thought either of us would enjoy, they held them for us. Soon I became fascinated as I realized that the library had so many books—and about so many different subjects.
- 60 After the book about the beaver, I chose others about animals—all types of animals. I read every animal story I could get my hands on. I read books about wolves, wild dogs, several about squirrels, and a variety of animals that lived in other countries. Once I had gone through the animal books, I started reading about plants, then minerals, and finally rocks.
- 61 My reading books about rocks was the first time the information ever became practical to me. We lived near the railroad tracks, and when Curtis and I took the route to school that crossed by the tracks, I began paying attention to the crushed rock that I noticed between the ties.
- 62 As I continued to read more about rocks, I would walk along the tracks, searching for different kinds of stones, and then see if I could identify them.
- 63 Often I would take a book with me to make sure that I had labeled each stone correctly.
- 64 “Agate,” I said as I threw the stone. Curtis got tired of my picking up stones and identifying them, but I did not care because I kept finding new stones all the time. Soon it became my favorite game to walk along the tracks and identify the varieties of stones. Although I did not realize it, within a very short period of time, I was actually becoming an expert on rocks.

680

- 65 Two things happened in the second half of fifth grade that convinced me of the importance of reading books.
- 66 First, our teacher, Mrs. Williamson, had a spelling bee every Friday afternoon. We’d go through all the words we’d had so far that year. Sometimes she also called out words that we were supposed to have learned in fourth grade. Without fail, I always went down on the first word.
- 67 One Friday, though, Bobby Farmer, whom everyone acknowledged as the smartest kid in our class, had to spell “agriculture” as his final word. As soon as the teacher pronounced his word, I thought, *I can spell that word*. Just the day before, I had learned it from reading one of my library books. I spelled it under my breath, and it was just the way Bobby spelled it.
- 68 *If I can spell “agriculture,” I’ll bet I can learn to spell any other word in the world. I’ll bet I can learn to spell better than Bobby Farmer.*
- 69 Just that single word, “agriculture,” was enough to give me hope.
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- 70 The following week, a second thing happened that forever changed my life. When Mr. Jaeck, the science teacher, was teaching us about volcanoes, he held up an object that looked like a piece of black, glass-like rock. “Does anybody know what this is? What does it have to do with volcanoes?”
- 71 Immediately, because of my reading, I recognized the stone. I waited, but none of my classmates raised their hands. I thought, *This is strange. Not even the smart kids are raising their hands*. I raised my hand.
- 72 “Yes, Benjamin,” he said.
- 73 I heard snickers around me. The other kids probably thought it was a joke, or that I was going to say something stupid.
- 74 “Obsidian,” I said.
- 75 “That’s right!” He tried not to look startled, but it was obvious he hadn’t expected me to give the correct answer.
- 76 “That’s obsidian,” I said, “and it’s formed by the supercooling of lava when it hits the water.” Once I had their attention and realized I knew information no other student had learned, I began to tell them everything I knew about the subject of obsidian, lava, lava flow, supercooling, and compacting of the elements.
- 77 When I finally paused, a voice behind me whispered, “Is that Bennie Carson?”
- 78 “You’re absolutely correct,” Mr. Jaeck said and he smiled at me. If he had announced that I’d won a million-dollar lottery, I couldn’t have been more pleased and excited.
- 79 “Benjamin, that’s absolutely, absolutely right,” he repeated with enthusiasm in his voice. He turned to the others and said, “That is wonderful! Class, this is a tremendous piece of information Benjamin has just given us. I’m very proud to hear him say this.”

680

681

- 80 For a few moments, I tasted the thrill of achievement. I recall thinking, *Wow, look at them. They're all looking at me with admiration. Me, the dummy! The one everybody thinks is stupid. They're looking at me to see if this is really me speaking.*
- 81 Maybe, though, it was I who was the most astonished one in the class. Although I had been reading two books a week because Mother told me to, I had not realized how much knowledge I was accumulating. True, I had learned to enjoy reading, but until then I hadn't realized how it connected with my schoolwork. That day—for the first time—I realized that Mother had been right. Reading is the way out of ignorance, and the road to achievement. I did not have to be the class dummy anymore.
- 82 For the next few days, I felt like a hero at school. The jokes about me stopped. The kids started to listen to me. *I'm starting to have fun with this stuff.*
- 83 As my grades improved in every subject, I asked myself, "Ben, is there any reason you can't be the smartest kid in the class? If you can learn about obsidian, you can learn about social studies and geography and math and science and everything."
- 84 That single moment of triumph pushed me to want to read more. From then on, it was as though I could not read enough books. Whenever anyone looked for me after school, they could usually find me in my bedroom—curled up, reading a library book—for a long time, the only thing I wanted to do. I had stopped caring about the TV programs I was missing; I no longer cared about playing Tip the Top or baseball anymore. I just wanted to read. 681
682
- 85 In a year and a half—by the middle of sixth grade—I had moved to the top of the class.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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- The word *trauma* in "I loved both my mother and father and went through considerable trauma over their separating. For months afterward, I kept thinking that my parents would get back together, . . . but he never came back" (paragraph 20) means
 - love.
 - knowledge.
 - distance.
 - suffering.
- The word *acknowledged* in "One Friday, though, Bobby Farmer, whom everyone acknowledged as the smartest kid in our class, had to spell 'agriculture' as his final word" (paragraph 67) means

- a. denied.
 - b. recognized.
 - c. forgot.
 - d. interrupted.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
- a. The Importance of Fifth Grade
 - b. The Role of Parents in Education
 - c. The Day I Surprised My Science Teacher
 - d. Reading Changed My Life
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of this selection?
- a. Children who grow up in single-parent homes may spend large amounts of time home alone.
 - b. Because of parental guidance that led to a love of reading, the author was able to go from academic failure to success.
 - c. Most children do not take school very seriously, and they suffer as a result.
 - d. Today’s young people watch too much television.
5. Bennie’s mother
- a. was not a religious person.
 - b. spoke to Bennie’s teacher about Bennie’s poor report card.
 - c. had only a third-grade education.
 - d. had little contact with educated people.
6. To get her sons to do better in school, Mrs. Carson insisted that they
- a. stop watching TV.
 - b. finish their homework before playing.
 - c. read one library book every month.
 - d. all of the above.
7. *True or false?* _____ Bennie’s first experience with a library book was discouraging.

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- 8. We can conclude that Bennie Carson believed he was dumb because
 - a. in Boston he had not learned much.
 - b. other students laughed at him.
 - c. he had done his best when he first started at Higgins Elementary School, but still got poor grades.
 - d. all of the above.
- 9. We can conclude that the author’s mother believed
 - a. education leads to success.
 - b. her sons needed to be forced to live up to their potential.
 - c. socializing was less important for her sons than a good education.
 - d. all of the above.
- 10. From paragraphs 70–80, we can infer that
 - a. Bennie thought his classmates were stupid because they did not know about obsidian.
 - b. Mr. Jaeck knew less about rocks than Bennie did.
 - c. this was the first time Bennie had answered a difficult question correctly in class.
 - d. Mr. Jaeck thought that Bennie had taken too much class time explaining about obsidian.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. How do you think considering himself the “dumbest kid in class” affected Bennie’s schoolwork?
- 2. The author recalls his failure in the classroom as an eight-year-old child by writing, “Perhaps I wasn’t emotionally able to learn much.” Why does he make this statement? What do you think parents and schools can do to help children through difficult times? 683
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- 3. How did Mrs. Carson encourage Bennie to make school—particularly reading—a priority in his life? What effect did her efforts have on Bennie’s academic performance and self-esteem?
- 4. As a child, Carson began to feel confident about his own abilities when he followed his mother’s guidelines. How might Mrs. Carson’s methods help adult students build up their own self-confidence and motivation?

About Structure

- 5. What is the main order in which the details of this selection are organized—time order or listing order? Locate and write below three of the many transitions that are used as part of that time order or listing order.

- 6. In paragraph 65, Carson states, “Two things happened in the second half of fifth grade that convinced me of the importance of reading books.” What two transitions does Carson use in later paragraphs to help readers recognize those two events? Write those two transitions here:

About Style and Tone

- 7. Instead of describing his mother, Carson reveals her character through specific details of her actions and words. Find one paragraph in which this technique is used, and write its number here: _____. What does this paragraph tell us about Mrs. Carson?
- 8. Why do you suppose Carson italicizes sentences in paragraphs 67, 68, 71, 80, and 82? What purpose do the italicized sentences serve?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

The reading tells about some of Carson’s most important school experiences, both positive and negative. Write a paragraph about one of your most important experiences in school. To select an event to write about, consider the following questions and discuss them in groups of two or three:



Which teachers or events in school influenced how I felt about myself?

684

What specific incidents stand out in my mind as I think back to elementary school?

685

To get started, you might use freewriting to help you remember and record the details. Then begin your draft with a topic sentence similar to one of the following:

A seemingly small experience in elementary school encouraged me greatly.

If not for my sixth-grade teacher, I would not be where I am today.

My tenth-grade English class was a turning point in my life.

Use concrete details—actions, comments, reactions, and so on—to help your readers see what happened.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Reading helped Bennie, and it can do a lot for adults, too. Most of us, however, don't have someone around to make us do a certain amount of personal reading every week. In addition, many of us don't have as much free time as Bennie and Curtis had. How can adults find time to read more? Write a paragraph listing several ways adults can add more reading to their lives.

To get started, simply write down as many ways as you can think of—in any order. Here is an example of a prewriting list for this paper:

Situations in which adults can find extra time to read:

Riding to and from work or school

In bed at night before turning off the light

While eating breakfast or lunch

Instead of watching some TV

In the library

Feel free to use items from the list above, but see if you can add at least one or two of your own points as well. Use descriptions and examples to emphasize and dramatize your supporting details.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Mrs. Carson discovered an effective way to boost her children's achievement and self-confidence. There are other ways as well. Write an essay whose thesis statement is "There are several ways parents can help children live up to their potential." Then, in the following paragraphs, explain and illustrate two or three methods parents can use. In choosing material for your supporting paragraphs, you might consider some of these areas, or think of others on your own:

Assigning regular household "chores" and rewarding a good job

Encouraging kids to join an organization that fosters achievement: Scouts, Little League, religious group, or neighborhood service club

685

Going to parent-teacher conferences at school and then working more closely with children’s teachers—knowing when assignments are due, and so on

686

Giving a child some responsibility for an enjoyable family activity, such as choosing decorations or food for a birthday party

Setting up a “Wall of Fame” in the home where children’s artwork, successful schoolwork, and so on, can be displayed

Setting guidelines (as Mrs. Carson did) for use of leisure time, homework time, and the like

Draw on examples from your own experiences or from someone else’s—including those of a classmate or Bennie Carson, if you like.



Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name: James Lincoln Collier

PREVIEW



What is your basis for making personal decisions? Do you aim to rock the boat as little as possible, choosing the easy, familiar path? There is comfort in sticking with what is safe and well-known, just as there is

comfort in eating bland mashed potatoes. But James Lincoln Collier, author of numerous articles and books, decided soon after leaving college not to live a mashed-potato sort of life. In this essay, first published in *Reader's Digest*, he tells how he learned to recognize the marks of a potentially exciting, growth-inducing experience, to set aside his anxiety, and to dive in.

- 1 Between my sophomore and junior years at college, a chance came up for me to spend the summer vacation working on a ranch in Argentina. My roommate's father was in the cattle business, and he wanted Ted to see something of it. Ted said he would go if he could take a friend, and he chose me.
- 2 The idea of spending two months on the fabled Argentine pampas was exciting. Then I began having second thoughts. I had never been very far from New England, and I had been homesick my first weeks at college. What would it be like in a strange country? What about the language? And besides, I had promised to teach my younger brother to sail that summer. The more I thought about it, the more the prospect daunted me. I began waking up nights in a sweat.
- 3 In the end I turned down the proposition. As soon as Ted asked somebody else to go, I began kicking myself. A couple of weeks later I went home to my old summer job, unpacking cartons at the local supermarket, feeling very low. I had turned down something I wanted to do because I was scared, and I had ended up feeling depressed. I stayed that way for a long time. And it didn't help when I went back to college in the fall to discover that Ted and his friend had had a terrific time.
- 4 In the long run that unhappy summer taught me a valuable lesson out of which I developed a rule for myself: *do what makes you anxious, don't do what makes you depressed*.
- 5 I am not, of course, talking about severe states of anxiety or depression, which require medical attention. What I mean is that kind of anxiety we call stage fright, butterflies in the stomach, a case of nerves—the feelings we have at a job interview, when we're giving a big party, when we have to make an important presentation at the office. And the kind of depression I am referring to is that downhearted feeling of the blues, when we don't seem to be interested in anything, when we can't get going and seem to have no energy.
- 6 I was confronted by this sort of situation toward the end of my senior year. As graduation approached, I began to think about taking a crack at making my living as a writer. But one of my professors was urging me to apply to graduate school and aim at a teaching career.
- 7 I wavered. The idea of trying to live by writing was scary—a lot more scary than spending a summer on the pampas, I thought. Back and forth I went, making my decision, unmaking it. Suddenly, I realized that every time I gave up the idea of writing, that sinking feeling went through me; it gave me the blues.
- 8 The thought of graduate school wasn't what depressed me. It was giving up on what deep in my gut I really wanted to do. Right then I learned another lesson. To avoid that kind of depression meant, inevitably, having to endure a certain amount of worry and concern.
- 9 The great Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard believed that anxiety always arises when we confront the possibility of our own development. It seems to be a rule of life that you can't advance without getting that old, familiar, jittery feeling.

686
687

- 10 Even as children we discover this when we try to expand ourselves by, say, learning to ride a bike or going out for the school play. Later in life we get butterflies when we think about having that first child, or uprooting the family from the old hometown to find a better opportunity halfway across the country. Any time, it seems, that we set out aggressively to get something we want, we meet up with anxiety. And it's going to be our traveling companion, at least part of the way, in any new venture.
- 11 When I first began writing magazine articles, I was frequently required to interview big names—687
people like Richard Burton, Joan Rivers, sex authority William Masters, baseball great Dizzy Dean. 688
Before each interview I would get butterflies and my hands would shake.
- 12 At the time, I was doing some writing about music. And one person I particularly admired was the great composer Duke Ellington. On stage and on television, he seemed the very model of the confident, sophisticated man of the world. Then I learned that Ellington still got stage fright. If the highly honored Duke Ellington, who had appeared on the bandstand some ten thousand times over thirty years, had anxiety attacks, who was I to think I could avoid them?
- 13 I went on doing those frightening interviews, and one day, as I was getting onto a plane for Washington to interview columnist Joseph Alsop, I suddenly realized to my astonishment that I was looking forward to the meeting. What had happened to those butterflies?
- 14 Well, in truth, they were still there, but there were fewer of them. I had benefited, I discovered, from a process psychologists call “extinction.” If you put an individual in an anxiety-provoking situation often enough, he will eventually learn that there isn't anything to be worried about.
- 15 Which brings us to a corollary to my basic rule: *you'll never eliminate anxiety by avoiding the things that caused it*. I remember how my son Jeff was when I first began to teach him to swim at the lake cottage where we spent our summer vacations. He resisted, and when I got him into the water he sank and sputtered and wanted to quit. But I was insistent. And by summer's end he was splashing around like a puppy. He had “extinguished” his anxiety the only way he could—by confronting it.
- 16 The problem, of course, is that it is one thing to urge somebody else to take on those anxiety-producing challenges; it is quite another to get ourselves to do it.
- 17 Some years ago I was offered a writing assignment that would require three months of travel through Europe. I had been abroad a couple of times on the usual “If it's Tuesday this must be Belgium”,* trips, but I hardly could claim to know my way around the continent. Moreover, my knowledge of foreign languages was limited to a little college French.
- 18 I hesitated. How would I, unable to speak the language, totally unfamiliar with local geography or transportation systems, set up interviews and do research? It seemed impossible, and with considerable regret I sat down to write a letter begging off. Halfway through, a thought—which I subsequently made into another corollary to my basic rule—ran through my mind: *you can't learn if you don't try*. So I accepted the assignment.

19 There were some bad moments. But by the time I had finished the trip I was an experienced traveler. And ever since, I have never hesitated to head for even the most exotic of places, without guides or even advance bookings, confident that somehow I will manage.

688

20 The point is that the new, the different, is almost by definition scary. But each time you try something, you learn, and as the learning piles up, the world opens to you.

689

21 I've made parachute jumps, learned to ski at forty, flown up the Rhine in a balloon. And I know I'm going to go on doing such things. It's not because I'm braver or more daring than others. I'm not. But I don't let the butterflies stop me from doing what I want. Accept anxiety as another name for challenge, and you can accomplish wonders.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *daunted* in “The more I thought about [going to Argentina], the more the prospect daunted me. I began waking up nights in a sweat” (paragraph 2)
 - a. encouraged.
 - b. interested.
 - c. discouraged.
 - d. amused.
2. The word *corollary* in “Which brings us to a corollary to my basic rule: *you'll never eliminate anxiety by avoiding the things that caused it*” (paragraph 15) means
 - a. an idea that follows from another idea.
 - b. an idea based on a falsehood.
 - c. an idea that creates anxiety.
 - d. an idea passed on from one generation to another.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. A Poor Decision
 - b. Don't Let Anxiety Stop You
 - c. Becoming a Writer

- d. The Courage to Travel
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?
- a. The butterflies-in-the-stomach type of anxiety differs greatly from severe states of anxiety or depression.
 - b. Taking on a job assignment that required traveling helped the author get over his anxiety.
 - c. People learn and grow by confronting, not backing away from, situations that make them anxious.
 - d. Anxiety is a predictable part of life that can be dealt with in positive ways.
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5. When a college friend invited the writer to go with him to Argentina, the writer
- a. turned down the invitation.
 - b. accepted eagerly.
 - c. was very anxious about the idea but went anyway.
 - d. did not believe his friend was serious.
6. *True or false?* ____ As graduation approached, Collier's professor urged him to try to make his living as a writer.
7. *True or false?* ____ The philosopher Søren Kierkegaard believed that anxiety occurs when we face the possibility of our own development.
8. *Extinction* is the term psychologists use for
- a. the inborn tendency to avoid situations that make one feel very anxious.
 - b. a person's gradual loss of confidence.
 - c. the natural development of a child's abilities.
 - d. the process of losing one's fear by continuing to face the anxiety-inspiring situation.
9. The author implies that
- a. it was lucky he didn't take the summer job in Argentina.
 - b. his son never got over his fear of the water.
 - c. Duke Ellington's facing stage fright inspired him.
 - d. one has to be more daring than most people to overcome anxiety.
10. The author implies that

689

690

- a. anxiety may be a signal that one has an opportunity to grow.
- b. he considers his three-month trip to Europe a failure.
- c. facing what makes him anxious has eliminated all depression from his life.
- d. he no longer has anxiety about new experiences.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. Collier developed the rule “Do what makes you anxious; don’t do what makes you depressed.” How does he distinguish between feeling anxious and feeling depressed?
- 2. With a partner, discuss the following questions, and then share your ideas with the whole class: In what way does Collier believe that anxiety is positive? How, according to him, can we eventually overcome our fears? Have you ever gone ahead and done something that made you anxious? How did it turn out?



690
691

About Structure

- 3. Collier provides a rule and two corollary rules that describe his attitude toward challenge and anxiety. Below, write the location of that rule and its corollaries.

Collier’s rule: paragraph _____

First corollary: paragraph _____

Second corollary: paragraph _____

How does Collier emphasize the rule and its corollaries?
- 4. Collier uses several personal examples in his essay. Find three instances of these examples and explain how each helps Collier develop his main point.

About Style and Tone

- 5. In paragraph 3, Collier describes the aftermath of his decision not to go to Argentina. He could have just written, “I worked that summer.” Instead he writes, “I went home to my old summer job, unpacking cartons at the local supermarket.” Why do you think he provides that bit of detail about his job? What is the effect on the reader?

- 6. Authors often use testimony by authorities to support their points. Where in Collier’s essay does he use such support? What do you think it adds to his piece?
- 7. In the last sentence of paragraph 10, Collier refers to anxiety as a “traveling companion.” Why do you think he uses that image? What does it convey about his view of anxiety?
- 8. Is Collier just telling about a lesson he has learned for himself, or is he encouraging his readers to do something? How can you tell?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Collier explains how his life experiences made him view the term *anxiety* in a new way. Write a paragraph in which you explain how a personal experience of yours has given new meaning to a particular term. Following are some terms you might consider for this assignment:

Failure	Homesickness
Friendship	Maturity
Goals	Success

Here are two sample topic sentences for this assignment:

I used to think of failure as something terrible, but thanks to a helpful boss, I now think of it as an opportunity to learn.

The word *creativity* has taken on a new meaning for me ever since I became interested in dancing.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

The second corollary to Collier’s rule is “you can’t learn if you don’t try.” Write a paragraph using this idea as your main idea. Support it with your own experience, someone else’s experience, or both. One way of developing this point is to compare two approaches to a challenge: One person may have backed away from a frightening opportunity while another person decided to take on the challenge. Or you could write about a time when you learned something useful by daring to give a new experience a try. In that case, you might discuss your reluctance to take on the new experience, the difficulties you encountered, and your eventual success. In your conclusion, include a final thought about the value of what was learned.

Listing a few skills you have learned will help you decide on the experience you wish to write about. To get you started, below is a list of things adults often need to go to some trouble to learn.

- Driving with a stick shift
- Taking useful lecture notes
- Knowing how to do well on a job interview
- Asking someone out on a date
- Making a speech
- Standing up for your rights

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Collier describes three rules he follows when facing anxiety. In an essay, write about one or more rules, or guidelines, that you have developed for yourself through experience. If you decide to discuss two or three such guidelines, mention or refer to them in your introductory paragraph. Then go on to discuss each in one or more paragraphs of its own. Include at least one experience that led you to develop a given guideline, and tell how it has helped you at other times in your life. You might end with a brief summary and an explanation of how the guidelines as a group have helped. If you decide to focus on one rule, include at least two or three experiences that help to illustrate your point.

To prepare for this assignment, spend some time freewriting about the rules or guidelines you have set up for yourself. Continue writing until you feel you have a central idea for which you have plenty of interesting support. Then organize that support into a scratch outline, such as this one:

Thesis: I have one rule that keeps me from staying in a rut—Don’t let the size of a challenge deter you; instead, aim for it by making plans and taking steps.

Topic sentence 1: I began to think about my rule one summer in high school when a friend got the type of summer job that I had only been thinking about.

Topic sentence 2: After high school, I began to live up to my rule when I aimed for a business career and entered college.

Topic sentence 3: My rule is also responsible for my having the wonderful boyfriend (or girlfriend or spouse or job) I now have.

Let’s Really Reform Our Schools: Anita Garland

PREVIEW

A few years ago, a National Commission on Excellence in Education published *A Nation at Risk*, in which the commission reported on a “rising tide of mediocrity” in our schools. Other studies have pointed to students’ poor achievement in science, math, communication, and critical thinking. What can our schools do to improve students’ performance? Anita Garland has several radical ideas, which she explains in this selection. As you read it, think about whether or not you agree with her points.

- 1 American high schools are in trouble. No, that’s not strong enough. American high schools are disasters. “Good” schools today are only a rite of passage for American kids, where the pressure to look fashionable and act cool outweighs any concern for learning. And “bad” schools—heaven help us—are havens for the vicious and corrupt. There, metal detectors and security guards wage a losing battle against the criminals that prowl the halls.
- 2 Desperate illnesses require desperate remedies. And our public schools are desperately ill. What is needed is no meek, fainthearted attempt at “curriculum revision” or “student-centered learning.” We need to completely restructure our thinking about what schools are and what we expect of the students who attend them.

693

- 3 The first change needed to save our schools is the most fundamental one. Not only must we stop *forcing* everyone to attend school; we must stop *allowing* the attendance of so-called students who are not interested in studying. Mandatory school attendance is based upon the idea that every American has a right to basic education. But as the old saying goes, your rights stop where the next guy’s begin. A student who sincerely wants an education, regardless of his or her mental or physical ability, should be welcome in any school in this country. But “students” who deliberately interfere with other students’ ability to learn, teachers’ ability to teach, and administrators’ ability to maintain order should be denied a place in the classroom. They do not want an education. And they should not be allowed to mark time within school walls, waiting to be handed their meaningless diplomas while they make it harder for everyone around them to either provide or receive a quality education.

694

- 4 By requiring troublemakers to attend school, we have made it impossible to deal with them in any effective way. They have little to fear in terms of punishment. Suspension from school for a few days doesn’t improve their behavior. After all, they don’t want to be in school anyway. For that matter, mandatory attendance is, in many cases, nothing but a bad joke. Many chronic troublemakers are absent so often that it is virtually impossible for them to learn anything. And when they *are* in school, they are busy shaking down other students for their lunch money or jewelry. If we permanently banned such punks from school, educators could turn their attention away from the troublemakers and toward those students who realize that school is a serious place for serious learning.
- 5 You may ask, “What will become of these young people who aren’t in school?” But consider this: What is becoming of them now? They are not being educated. They are merely names on the school records. They are passed from grade to grade, learning nothing, making teachers and fellow students miserable. Finally they are bumped off the conveyor belt at the end of twelfth grade, oftentimes barely literate, and passed into society as “high school graduates.” Yes, there would be a need for alternative solutions for these young people. Let the best thinkers of our country come up with some ideas. But in the meanwhile, don’t allow our schools to serve as a holding tank for people who don’t want to be there.

- 6 Once our schools have been returned to the control of teachers and genuine students, we could concentrate on smaller but equally meaningful reforms. A good place to start would be requiring students to wear school uniforms. There would be cries of horror from the fashion slaves, but the change would benefit everyone. If students wore uniforms, think of the mental energy that could be redirected into more productive channels. No longer would young girls feel the need to spend their evenings laying out coordinated clothing, anxiously trying to create just the right look. The daily fashion show that currently absorbs so much of students' attention would come to a halt. Kids from modest backgrounds could stand out because of their personalities and intelligence, rather than being tagged as losers because they can't wear the season's hottest sneakers or jeans. Affluent kids might learn they have something to offer the world other than a fashion statement. Parents would be relieved of the pressure to deal with their offspring's constant demands for wardrobe additions. 694
- 7 Next, let's move to the cafeteria. What's for lunch today? How about a Milky Way bar, a bag of Fritos, a Coke, and just to round out the meal with a vegetable, maybe some french fries. And then back to the classroom for a few hours of intense mental activity, fueled on fat, salt, and sugar. What a joke! School is an institution of education, and that education should be continued as students sit down to eat. Here's a perfect opportunity to teach a whole generation of Americans about nutrition, and we are blowing it. School cafeterias, of all places, should demonstrate how a healthful, low-fat, well-balanced diet produces healthy, energetic, mentally alert people. Instead, we allow school cafeterias to dispense the same junk food that kids could buy in any mall. Overhaul the cafeterias! Out with the candy, soda, chips, and fries! In with the salads, whole grains, fruits, and vegetables! 695
- 8 Turning our attention away from what goes on during school hours, let's consider what happens after the final bell rings. Some school-sponsored activities are all to the good. Bands and choirs, foreign-language field trips, chess or skiing or drama clubs are sensible parts of an extracurricular plan. They bring together kids with similar interests to develop their talents and leadership ability. But other common school activities are not the business of education. The prime example of inappropriate school activity is in competitive sports between schools.
- 9 Intramural sports are great. Students need an outlet for their energies, and friendly competition against one's classmates on the basketball court or baseball diamond is fun and physically beneficial. But the wholesome fun of sports is quickly ruined by the competitive team system. School athletes quickly become the campus idols, encouraged to look down on classmates with less physical ability. Schools concentrate enormous amounts of time, money, and attention upon their teams, driving home the point that competitive sports are the *really* important part of school. Students are herded into gymnasiums for "pep rallies" that whip up adoration of the chosen few and encourage hatred of rival schools. Boys' teams are supplied with squads of cheerleading girls . . . let's not even get into what the subliminal message is *there*. If communities feel they must have competitive sports, let local businesses or even professional teams organize and fund the programs. But school budgets and time should be spent on programs that benefit more than an elite few.
- 10 Another school-related activity that should get the ax is the fluff-headed, moneyeating, misery-inducing event known as the prom. How in the world did the schools of America get involved in this showcase of excess? Proms have to be the epitome of everything that is wrong, tasteless,

misdirected, inappropriate, and just plain sad about the way we bring up our young people. Instead of simply letting the kids put on a dance, we've turned the prom into a bloated nightmare that ruins young people's budgets, their self-image, and even their lives. The pressure to show up at the prom with the best-looking date, in the most expensive clothes, wearing the most exotic flowers, riding in the most extravagant form of transportation, dominates the thinking of many students for months before the prom itself. Students cling to doomed, even abusive romantic relationships rather than risk being dateless for this night of nights. They lose any concept of meaningful values as they implore their parents for more, more, more money to throw into the jaws of the prom god. The adult trappings of the prom—the slinky dresses, emphasis on romance, slow dancing, nightclub atmosphere—all encourage kids to engage in behavior that can have tragic consequences. Who knows how many unplanned pregnancies and alcohol-related accidents can be directly attributed to the pressures of prom night? And yet, not going to the prom seems a fate worse than death to many young people—because of all the hype about the “wonder” and “romance” of it all. Schools are not in the business of providing wonder and romance, and it's high time we remembered that.

695

696

- 11 We have lost track of the purpose of our schools. They are not intended to be centers for fun, entertainment, and social climbing. They are supposed to be institutions for learning and hard work. Let's institute the changes suggested here—plus dozens more—without apology, and get American schools back to business.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *affluent* in “Kids from modest backgrounds could stand out because of their personalities and intelligence. . . . Affluent kids might learn they have something to offer the world other than a fashion statement” (paragraph 6) means
 - a. intelligent.
 - b. troubled.
 - c. wealthy.
 - d. poor.
2. The word *implore* in “They lose any concept of meaningful values as they implore their parents for more, more, more money to throw into the jaws of the prom god” (paragraph 10) means
 - a. beg.
 - b. ignore.
 - c. pay.

- d. obey.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
- a. America's Youth
 - b. Education of the Future
 - c. Social Problems of Today's Students
 - d. Changes Needed in the American School System
-
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?
- a. Excesses such as the prom and competitive sports should be eliminated from school budgets.
 - b. Major changes are needed to make American schools real centers of learning.
 - c. Attendance must be voluntary in our schools.
 - d. The best thinkers of our country must come up with ideas on how to improve our schools.
5. Garland believes that mandatory attendance at school
- a. gives all students an equal chance at getting an education.
 - b. allows troublemakers to disrupt learning.
 - c. is cruel to those who don't really want to be there.
 - d. helps teachers maintain control of their classes.
6. Garland is against school-sponsored competitive sports because she believes that
- a. exercise and teamwork should not have a role in school.
 - b. they overemphasize the importance of sports and athletes.
 - c. school property should not be used in any way after school hours.
 - d. they take away from professional sports.
7. We can infer that Garland believes
- a. teens should not have dances.
 - b. proms promote unwholesome values.
 - c. teens should avoid romantic relationships.
 - d. proms are even worse than mandatory education.

696

697

- 8. The author clearly implies that troublemakers
 - a. are not intelligent.
 - b. really do want to be in school.
 - c. should be placed in separate classes.
 - d. don't mind being suspended from school.
- 9. *True or false?* _____ We can conclude that the author feels that teachers and genuine students have lost control of our schools.
- 10. The essay suggests that the author would also oppose
 - a. school plays.
 - b. serving milk products in school cafeterias.
 - c. the selection of homecoming queens.
 - d. stylish school uniforms.

697
698

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. What reforms does Garland suggest in her essay? Think back to your high school days. Which of the reforms that Garland suggests do you think might have been most useful at your high school?
- 2. Garland's idea of voluntary school attendance directly contradicts the "stay in school" campaigns. Do you agree with her idea? What do you think might become of students who choose not to attend school?
- 3. At the end of her essay, Garland writes, "Let's institute the changes suggested here—plus dozens more." What other changes do you think Garland may have in mind? What are some reforms you think might improve schools?

About Structure

- 4. The thesis of this essay can be found in the introduction, which is made up of the first two paragraphs. Find the thesis statement and write it here:

- 5. The first point on Garland's list of reforms is the elimination of mandatory (that is, required) education. Then she goes on to discuss other reforms. Find the transition sentence which

signals that she is leaving the discussion about mandatory education and going on to other needed changes. Write that sentence here:

6. What are two transitional words that Garland uses to introduce two of the other reforms?

About Style and Tone

7. Garland uses some colorful images to communicate her ideas. For instance, in paragraph 5 she writes, “Finally [the troublemakers] are bumped off the conveyor belt at the end of twelfth grade, oftentimes barely literate, and passed into society as ‘high school graduates.’” What does the image of a conveyor belt imply about schools and about the troublemakers? What do the quotation marks around *high school graduates* imply?
8. On the following page there are three other colorful images from the essay. What do the italicized words imply about today’s schools and students?

698

. . . don’t allow our schools to serve as a *holding tank* for people who don’t want to be there. (paragraph 5)

699

A good place to start would be requiring students to wear school uniforms. There would be cries of horror from the *fashion slaves* . . . (paragraph 6)

Students are *herded* into gymnasiums for “pep rallies” that whip up adoration of the chosen few . . . (paragraph 9)

9. To convey her points, does the author use a formal, straightforward tone or an informal, impassioned tone? Give examples from the essay to support your answer.

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Write a persuasive paragraph in which you agree or disagree with one of Garland’s suggested reforms. Your topic sentence may be something simple and direct, like these:

I strongly agree with Garland’s point that attendance should be voluntary in our high schools.

I disagree with Garland’s point that high school students should be required to wear uniforms.

Alternatively, you may want to develop your own paragraph calling for reform in some other area of American life. Your topic sentence might be like one of the following:

We need to make radical changes in our treatment of homeless people.

Strong new steps must be taken to control the sale of guns in our country.

Major changes are needed to keep television from dominating the lives of our children.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

If troublemakers were excluded from schools, what would become of them? Write a paragraph in which you suggest two or three types of programs that troublemakers could be assigned to. Explain why each program would be beneficial to the troublemakers themselves and society in general. You might want to include in your paragraph one or more of the following:

Apprentice programs

Special neighborhood schools for troublemakers

Reform schools

Work-placement programs

Community service programs

699

700

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Garland suggests ways to make schools “institutions for learning and hard work.” She wants to get rid of anything that greatly distracts students from their education, such as having to deal with troublemakers, overemphasis on fashion, and interschool athletics. When you were in high school, what tended most to divert your attention from learning? Write an essay explaining in full detail the three things that interfered most with your high school education. You may include any of Garland’s points, but present details that apply specifically to you. Organize your essay by using emphatic order—in other words, save whatever interfered most with your education for the last supporting paragraph.

It is helpful to write a sentence outline for this kind of essay. Here, for example, is one writer’s outline for an essay titled “Obstacles to My High School Education.”

Thesis: There were three main things that interfered with my high school education.

Topic sentence 1: Concern about my appearance took up too much of my time and energy.

- a. Since I was concerned about my looking good, I spent too much time shopping for clothes.

- b. In order to afford the clothes, I worked twenty hours a week, drastically reducing my study time.
- c. Spending even more time on clothes, I fussed every evening over what I would wear to school the next day.

Topic sentence 2: Cheerleading was another major obstacle to my academic progress in high school.

- a. I spent many hours practicing in order to make the cheerleading squad.
- b. Once I made the squad, I had to spend even more time practicing and then attending games.
- c. Once when I didn’t make the squad, I was so depressed for a while that I couldn’t study, and this had serious consequences.

Topic sentence 3: The main thing that interfered with my high school education was my family situation.

- a. Even when I had time to study, I often found it impossible to do so at home, since my parents often had fights that were noisy and upsetting.
- b. My parents showed little interest in my schoolwork, giving me little reason to work hard for my classes.
- c. When I was in eleventh grade, my parents divorced; this was a major distraction for me for a long time.

700
701

To round off your essay with a conclusion, you may simply want to restate your thesis and main supporting points. After you finish a first draft, swap essays with a classmate and share revision advice; use the checklist on the inside back cover to guide your critique.



How They Get You to Do That: Janny Scott

PREVIEW



So you think you’re sailing along in life, making decisions based on your own preferences? Not likely! Janny Scott brings together the findings of several researchers to show how advertisers, charitable organizations, politicians, employers, and even your friends get you to say “yes” when you should have said “no”—or, at least, “Let me think about that.”

- 1 The woman in the supermarket in a white coat tenders a free sample of “lite” cheese. A car salesman suggests that prices won’t stay low for long. Even a penny will help, pleads the door-to-door solicitor. Sale ends Sunday! Will work for food.
- 2 The average American exists amid a perpetual torrent of propaganda. Everyone, it sometimes seems, is trying to make up someone else’s mind. If it isn’t an athletic shoe company, it’s a politician, a panhandler, a pitchman, a boss, a billboard company, a spouse.
- 3 The weapons of influence they are wielding are more sophisticated than ever, researchers say. And they are aimed at a vulnerable target—people with less and less time to consider increasingly complex issues.
- 4 As a result, some experts in the field have begun warning the public, tipping people off to precisely how “the art of compliance” works. Some critics have taken to arguing for new government controls on one pervasive form of persuasion—political advertising.

701

- 5 The persuasion problem is “the essential dilemma of modern democracy,” argue social psychologists Anthony Pratkanis and Elliot Aronson, the authors of *Age of Propaganda: The Everyday Use and Abuse of Persuasion*.
- 6 As the two psychologists see it, American society values free speech and public discussion, but people no longer have the time or inclination to pay attention. Mindless propaganda flourishes, they say; thoughtful persuasion fades away.
- 7 The problem stems from what Pratkanis and Aronson call our “message-dense environment.” The average television viewer sees nearly 38,000 commercials a year, they say. “The average home receives . . . [numerous] pieces of junk mail annually and . . . [countless calls] from telemarketing firms.”
- 8 Bumper stickers, billboards and posters litter the public consciousness. Athletic events and jazz festivals carry corporate labels. As direct selling proliferates, workers patrol their offices during lunch breaks, peddling chocolate and Tupperware to friends.
- 9 Meanwhile, information of other sorts multiplies exponentially. Technology serves up ever-increasing quantities of data on every imaginable subject, from home security to health. With more and more information available, people have less and less time to digest it.
- 10 “It’s becoming harder and harder to think in a considered way about anything,” said Robert Cialdini, a persuasion researcher at Arizona State University in Tempe. “More and more, we are going to be deciding on the basis of less and less information.”

702

- 11 Persuasion is a democratic society's chosen method for decision making and dispute resolution. But the flood of persuasive messages in recent years has changed the nature of persuasion. Lengthy arguments have been supplanted by slogans and logos. In a world teeming with propaganda, those in the business of influencing others put a premium on effective shortcuts.
- 12 Most people, psychologists say, are easily seduced by such shortcuts. Humans are "cognitive misers," always looking to conserve attention and mental energy—leaving themselves at the mercy of anyone who has figured out which shortcuts work.
- 13 The task of figuring out shortcuts has been embraced by advertising agencies, market researchers, and millions of salespeople. The public, meanwhile, remains in the dark, ignorant of even the simplest principles of social influence.
- 14 As a result, laypeople underestimate their susceptibility to persuasion, psychologists say. They imagine their actions are dictated simply by personal preferences. Unaware of the techniques being used against them, they are often unwittingly outgunned.
- 15 As Cialdini tells it, the most powerful tactics work like jujitsu: They draw their strength from deep-seated, unconscious psychological rules. The clever "compliance professional" deliberately triggers these "hidden stores of influence" to elicit a predictable response.
- 16 One such rule, for example, is that people are more likely to comply with a request if a reason—no matter how silly—is given. To prove that point, one researcher tested different ways of asking people in line at a copying machine to let her cut the line.
- 17 When the researcher asked simply, "Excuse me, I have five pages. May I use the Xerox machine?" only 60 percent of those asked complied. But when she added nothing more than, "because I have to make some copies," nearly every one agreed.
- 18 The simple addition of "because" unleashed an automatic response, even though "because" was followed by an irrelevant reason, Cialdini said. By asking the favor in that way, the researcher dramatically increased the likelihood of getting what she wanted.
- 19 Cialdini and others say much of human behavior is mechanical. Automatic responses are efficient when time and attention are short. For that reason, many techniques of persuasion are designed and tested for their ability to trigger those automatic responses.
- 20 "These appeals persuade not through the give-and-take of argument and debate," Pratkanis and Aronson have written. ". . . They often appeal to our deepest fears and most irrational hopes, while they make use of our most simplistic beliefs."
- 21 Life insurance agents use fear to sell policies, Pratkanis and Aronson say. Parents use fear to convince their children to come home on time. Political leaders use fear to build support for going to war—for example, comparing a foreign leader to Adolf Hitler.

702

703

- 22 As many researchers see it, people respond to persuasion in one of two ways: If an issue they care about is involved, they may pay close attention to the arguments; if they don't care, they pay less attention and are more likely to be influenced by simple cues.
- 23 Their level of attention depends on motivation and the time available. As David Boninger, a UCLA psychologist, puts it, "If you don't have the time or motivation, or both, you will pay attention to more peripheral cues, like how nice somebody looks."
- 24 Cialdini, a dapper man with a flat Midwestern accent, describes himself as an inveterate sucker. From an early age, he said recently, he had wondered what made him say yes in many cases when the answer, had he thought about it, should have been no.
- 25 So in the early 1980s, he became "a spy in the wars of influence." He took a sabbatical and, over a three-year period, enrolled in dozens of sales training programs, learning firsthand the tricks of selling insurance, cars, vacuum cleaners, encyclopedias, and more.
- 26 He learned how to sell portrait photography over the telephone. He took a job as a busboy in a restaurant, observing the waiters. He worked in fund-raising, advertising, and public relations. And he interviewed cult recruiters and members of bunco squads.
- 27 By the time it was over, Cialdini had witnessed hundreds of tactics. But he found that the most effective ones were rooted in six principles. Most are not new, but they are being used today with greater sophistication on people whose fast-paced lifestyle has lowered their defenses.

703

- 28 *Reciprocity*. People have been trained to believe that a favor must be repaid in kind, even if the original favor was not requested. The cultural pressure to return a favor is so intense that people go along rather than suffer the feeling of being indebted.
- 29 Politicians have learned that favors are repaid with votes. Stores offer free samples—not just to show off a product. Charity organizations ship personalized address labels to potential contributors. Others accost pedestrians, planting paper flowers in their lapels.
- 30 *Commitment and Consistency*. People tend to feel they should be consistent—even when being consistent no longer makes sense. While consistency is easy, comfortable, and generally advantageous, Cialdini says, "mindless consistency" can be exploited.
- 31 Take the "foot in the door technique." One person gets another to agree to a small commitment, like a down payment or signing a petition. Studies show that it then becomes much easier to get the person to comply with a much larger request.
- 32 Another example Cialdini cites is the "lowball tactic" in car sales. Offered a low price for a car, the potential customer agrees. Then at the last minute, the sales manager finds a supposed error. The price is increased. But customers tend to go along nevertheless.
- 33 *Social Validation*. People often decide what is correct on the basis of what other people think. Studies show that is true for behavior. Hence, sitcom laugh tracks, tip jars "salted" with a bartender's cash, long lines outside nightclubs, testimonials, and "man on the street" ads.

704

- 34 Tapping the power of social validation is especially effective under certain conditions: When people are in doubt, they will look to others as a guide; and when they view those others as similar to themselves, they are more likely to follow their lead.
- 35 *Liking*. People prefer to comply with requests from people they know and like. Charities recruit people to canvass their friends and neighbors. Colleges get alumni to raise money from classmates. Sales training programs include grooming tips.
- 36 According to Cialdini, liking can be based on any of a number of factors. Good-looking people tend to be credited with traits like talent and intelligence. People also tend to like people who are similar to themselves in personality, background, and lifestyle.
- 37 *Authority*. People defer to authority. Society trains them to do so, and in many situations deference is beneficial. Unfortunately, obedience is often automatic, leaving people vulnerable to exploitation by compliance professionals, Cialdini says.
- 38 As an example, he cites the famous ad campaign that capitalized on actor Robert Young's role as Dr. Marcus Welby, Jr., to tout the alleged health benefits of Sanka decaffeinated coffee.
- 39 An authority, according to Cialdini, need not be a true authority. The trappings of authority may suffice. Con artists have long recognized the persuasive power of titles like doctor or judge, fancy business suits, and expensive cars.
- 40 *Scarcity*. Products and opportunities seem more valuable when the supply is limited.
- 41 As a result, professional persuaders emphasize that "supplies are limited." Sales end Sunday and movies have limited engagements—diverting attention from whether the item is desirable to the threat of losing the chance to experience it at all.
- 42 The use of influence, Cialdini says, is ubiquitous.
- 43 Take the classic appeal by a child of a parent's sense of consistency: "But you said . . ." And the parent's resort to authority: "Because I said so." In addition, nearly everyone invokes the opinions of like-minded others—for social validation—in vying to win a point.
- 44 One area in which persuasive tactics are especially controversial is political advertising—particularly negative advertising. Alarmed that attack ads might be alienating voters, some critics have begun calling for stricter limits on political ads.
- 45 In Washington, legislation pending in Congress would, among other things, force candidates to identify themselves at the end of their commercials. In that way, they might be forced to take responsibility for the ads' contents and be unable to hide behind campaign committees.
- 46 "In general, people accept the notion that for the sale of products at least, there are socially accepted norms of advertising," said Lloyd Morrisett, president of the Markle Foundation, which supports research in communications and information technology.

704

705

47 “But when those same techniques are applied to the political process—where we are judging not a product but a person, and where there is ample room for distortion of the record or falsification in some cases—there begins to be more concern,” he said.

48 On an individual level, some psychologists offer tips for self-protection.

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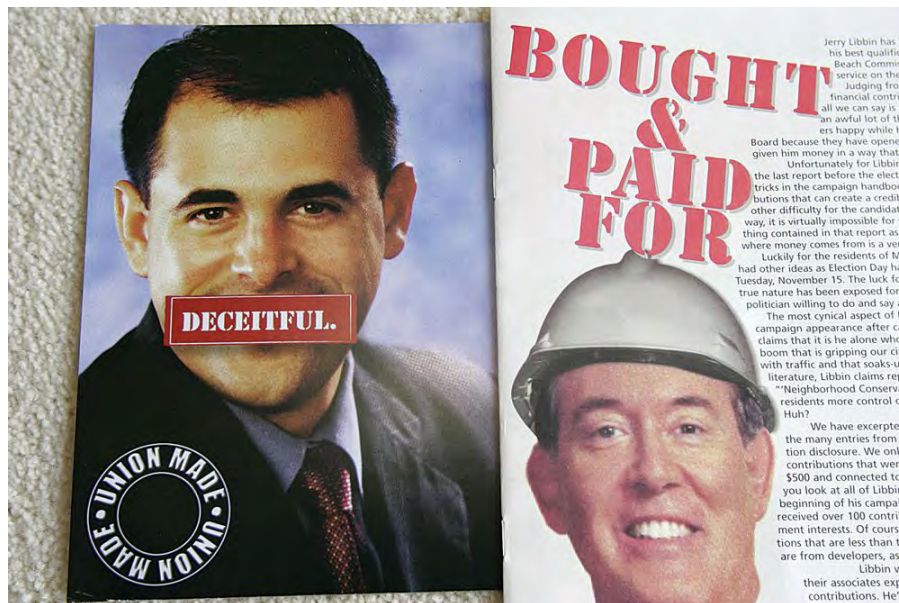
- Pay attention to your emotions, says Pratkanis, an associate professor of psychology at UC Santa Cruz: “If you start to feel guilty or patriotic, try to figure out why.” In consumer transactions, beware of feelings of inferiority and the sense that you don’t measure up unless you have a certain product.

50

- Be on the lookout for automatic responses, Cialdini says. Beware foolish consistency. Check other people’s responses against objective facts. Be skeptical of authority, and look out for unwarranted liking for any “compliance professionals.”

51 Since the publication of his most recent book, *Influence: The New Psychology of Modern Persuasion*, Cialdini has begun researching a new book on ethical uses of influence in business—addressing, among other things, how to instruct salespeople and other “influence agents” to use persuasion in ways that help, rather than hurt, society.

52 “If influence agents don’t police themselves, society will have to step in to regulate. . . the way information is presented in commercial and political settings,” Cialdini said. “And that’s a can of worms that I don’t think anybody wants to get into.”



Have you ever been persuaded by negative advertising? Why do you think attack ads, like the one pictured here, are so effective?

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *wielding* in “The weapons of influence they are wielding are more sophisticated than ever” (paragraph 3) means
 - a. handling effectively.
 - b. giving up.
 - c. looking for.
 - d. demanding.

706

2. The word *peripheral* in “As David Boninger . . . puts it, ‘If you don’t have the time or motivation, or both, you will pay attention to more peripheral cues, like how nice somebody looks’” (paragraph 23) means
 - a. important.
 - b. dependable.
 - c. minor.
 - d. attractive.

707

3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. Automatic Human Responses
 - b. Our Deepest Fears
 - c. The Loss of Thoughtful Discussion
 - d. Compliance Techniques
4. Which sentence best expresses the selection’s main point?
 - a. Americans are bombarded by various compliance techniques, the dangers of which can be overcome through understanding and legislation.
 - b. Fearful of the effects of political attack ads, critics are calling for strict limits on such ads.
 - c. With more and more messages demanding our attention, we find it harder and harder to consider any one subject really thoughtfully.

- d. The persuasion researcher Robert Cialdini spent a three-year sabbatical learning the tricks taught in dozens of sales training programs.
5. *True or false?* ____ According to the article, most laypeople think they are more susceptible to persuasion than they really are.
6. According to the article, parents persuade their children to come home on time by appealing to the children's sense of
- a. fair play.
 - b. guilt.
 - c. humor.
 - d. fear.
7. When a visitor walks out of a hotel and a young man runs up, helps the visitor with his luggage, hails a cab, and then expects a tip, the young man is depending on which principle of persuasion?
- a. reciprocity
 - b. commitment and consistency
 - c. social validation
 - d. liking
-
8. An inference that can be drawn from paragraph 49 is that
- a. Anthony Pratkanis is not a patriotic person.
 - b. one compliance technique involves appealing to the consumer's patriotism.
 - c. people using compliance techniques never want consumers to feel inferior.
 - d. consumers pay too much attention to their own emotions.
9. One can infer from the selection that
- a. the actor Robert Young was well-known for his love of coffee.
 - b. Sanka is demonstrably better for one's health than other coffees.
 - c. the actor Robert Young was also a physician in real life.
 - d. the TV character Marcus Welby, Jr., was trustworthy and authoritative.
10. We can conclude that to resist persuasive tactics, a person must
- a. buy fewer products.

707

708

- b. take time to question and analyze.
- c. remain patriotic.
- d. avoid propaganda.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. What unusual method did Robert Cialdini apply to learn more about compliance techniques? Were you surprised by any of the ways he used his time during that three-year period? Have you ever been employed in a position in which you used one or more compliance techniques?
- 2. What are the six principles that Cialdini identifies as being behind many persuasion tactics? Describe an incident in which you were subjected to persuasion based on one or more of these principles.
- 3. In paragraph 16, we learn that “people are more likely to comply with a request if a reason—no matter how silly—is given.” Do you find that to be true? Have you complied with requests that, when you thought about them later, were backed up with silly or weak reasons? Describe such an incident. Why do you think such requests work?
- 4. In paragraphs 44–47, the author discusses persuasive tactics in political advertising. Why might researchers view the use of such tactics in this area as “especially controversial”? Discuss this issue in groups of two or three, taking into consideration the question of “attack ads” (see page 706).



708

709

About Structure

- 5. What is the effect of Janny Scott’s introduction to the essay (paragraphs 1–2)? On the basis of that introduction, why is a reader likely to feel that the selection will be worth his or her time?
- 6. Which of the following best describes the conclusion of the selection?
 - a. It just stops.
 - b. It restates the main point of the selection.
 - c. It focuses on possible future occurrences.
 - d. It presents a point of view that is the opposite of views in the body of the selection.

Is this conclusion effective? Why or why not?

About Style and Tone

- 7. Why might Robert Cialdini have identified himself to the author as an “inveterate sucker”? How does that self-description affect how you regard Cialdini and what he has to say?
- 8. The author writes, “People defer to authority. Society trains them to do so; and in many situations deference is beneficial.” Where does the author himself use the power of authority to support his own points? In what situations would you consider authority to be beneficial?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

According to the article, “laypeople underestimate their susceptibility to persuasion. . . . They imagine their actions are dictated simply by personal preferences. Unaware of the techniques being used against them, they are often unwittingly outgunned.” After having read the selection, do you believe that statement is true of you? Write a paragraph in which you either agree with or argue against the statement. Provide clear, specific examples of ways in which you are or are not influenced by persuasion.

Your topic sentence might be like either of these:

- After reading “How They Get You to Do That,” I recognize that I am more influenced by forms of persuasion than I previously thought.
- Many people may “underestimate their susceptibility to persuasion,” but I am not one of those people.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Think of an advertisement—on TV, or on the Internet, in print, or on a billboard—that you have found especially memorable. Write a paragraph in which you describe it. Provide specific details that make your reader understand why you remember it so vividly. Conclude your paragraph by indicating whether or not the advertisement persuaded you to buy or do what it was promoting.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Robert Cialdini identifies “social validation” as a strong persuasion technique. Social validation involves people’s need to do what they hope will get approval from the crowd, rather than thinking for themselves. The essay provides several examples of social validation, such as laughing along with a laugh track and getting in a long line to go to a nightclub.

709
710

Choose a person you know for whom the need for social validation is very strong. Write an essay about that person and how the need for social validation has impacted several areas of his or her life. Develop each paragraph with colorful, persuasive examples of the person’s behavior. (You may wish to write about an invented person, in which case, feel free to use humorous exaggeration to make your points.)

Here is a possible outline for such an essay:

Thesis statement: My cousin Nina has a very strong need for social validation.

Topic sentence 1: Instead of choosing friends because of their inner qualities, Nina chooses them on the basis of their popularity.

Topic sentence 2: Nina’s wardrobe has to be made up of the newest and most popular styles.

Topic sentence 3: Instead of having any real opinions of her own, Nina adopts her most popular friend’s point of view as her own.

End your essay with a look into the future of a person whose life is ruled by the need for social validation.

Alternatively, write about the most independent thinker you know, someone who tends to do things his or her way without worrying much about what others say.

710
711

Dealing with Feelings: Rudolph F. Verderber

PREVIEW

Do you hide your feelings, no matter how strong they are, letting them fester inside? Or do you lash out angrily at people who irritate you? If either of these descriptions fits you, you may be unhappy with the results of your actions. Read the following excerpt from the college textbook *Communicate!* Sixth Edition (Wadsworth), to discover what the author recommends as a better approach to dealing with your emotions.

- 1 An extremely important aspect of self-disclosure is the sharing of feelings. We all experience feelings such as happiness at receiving an unexpected gift, sadness about the breakup of a relationship, or anger when we believe we have been taken advantage of. The question is whether to disclose such feelings, and if so, how. Self-disclosure of feelings usually will be most successful not when feelings are withheld or displayed but when they are described. Let’s consider each of these forms of dealing with feelings.

Withholding Feelings

- 2 Withholding feelings—that is, keeping them inside and not giving any verbal or nonverbal clues to their existence—is generally an inappropriate means of dealing with feelings. Withholding feelings is best exemplified by the good poker player who develops a “poker face,” a neutral look that is

impossible to decipher. The look is the same whether the player's cards are good or bad.

Unfortunately, many people use poker faces in their interpersonal relationships, so that no one knows whether they hurt inside, are extremely excited, and so on. For instance, Doris feels very nervous when Candy stands over her while Doris is working on her report. And when Candy says, "That first paragraph isn't very well written," Doris begins to seethe, yet she says nothing—she withholds her feelings.

- 3 Psychologists believe that when people withhold feelings, they can develop physical problems such as ulcers, high blood pressure, and heart disease, as well as psychological problems such as stress-related neuroses and psychoses. Moreover, people who withhold feelings are often perceived as cold, undemonstrative, and not much fun to be around.

711

- 4 Is withholding ever appropriate? When a situation is inconsequential, you may well choose to withhold your feelings. For instance, a stranger's inconsiderate behavior at a party may bother you, but because you can move to another part of the room, withholding may not be detrimental. In the example of Doris seething at Candy's behavior, however, withholding could be costly to Doris.

712

Displaying Feelings

- 5 Displaying feelings means expressing those feelings through a facial reaction, body response, or spoken reaction. Cheering over a great play at a sporting event, booing the umpire at a perceived bad call, patting a person on the back when the person does something well, or saying, "What are you doing?" in a nasty tone of voice are all displays of feelings.
- 6 Displays are especially appropriate when the feelings you are experiencing are positive. For instance, when Gloria does something nice for you, and you experience a feeling of joy, giving her a big hug is appropriate; when Don gives you something you've wanted, and you experience a feeling of appreciation, a big smile or an "Oh, thank you, Don" is appropriate. In fact, many people need to be even more demonstrative of good feelings. You've probably seen the bumper sticker "Have you hugged your kid today?" It reinforces the point that you need to display love and affection constantly to show another person that you really care.
- 7 Displays become detrimental to communication when the feelings you are experiencing are negative—especially when the display of a negative feeling appears to be an overreaction. For instance, when Candy stands over Doris while she is working on her report and says, "That first paragraph isn't very well written," Doris may well experience resentment. If Doris lashes out at Candy by screaming, "Who the hell asked you for your opinion?" Doris's display no doubt will hurt Candy's feelings and short-circuit their communication. Although displays of negative feelings may be good for you psychologically, they are likely to be bad for you interpersonally.

Describing Feelings

- 8 Describing feelings—putting your feelings into words in a calm, nonjudgmental way—tends to be the best method of disclosing feelings. Describing feelings not only increases chances for positive communication and decreases chances for short-circuiting lines of communication; it also teaches people how to treat you. When you describe your feelings, people are made aware of the effect of

their behavior. This knowledge gives them the information needed to determine whether they should continue or repeat that behavior. If you tell Paul that you really feel flattered when he visits you, such a statement should encourage Paul to visit you again; likewise, when you tell Cliff that you feel very angry when he borrows your jacket without asking, he is more likely to ask the next time he borrows a jacket. Describing your feelings allows you to exercise a measure of control over others' behavior toward you.

712

- 9 Describing and displaying feelings are not the same. Many times people think they are describing when in fact they are displaying feelings or evaluating.

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- 10 If describing feelings is so important to communicating effectively, why don't more people do it regularly? There seem to be at least four reasons why many people don't describe feelings.

11

1. Many people have a poor vocabulary of words for describing the various feelings they are experiencing. People can sense that they are angry; however, they may not know whether what they are feeling might best be described as annoyed, betrayed, cheated, crushed, disturbed, furious, outraged, or shocked. Each of these words describes a slightly different aspect of what many people lump together as anger.

12

2. Many people believe that describing their true feelings reveals too much about themselves. If you tell people when their behavior hurts you, you risk their using the information against you when they want to hurt you on purpose. Even so, the potential benefits of describing your feelings far outweigh the risks. For instance, if Pete has a nickname for you that you don't like and you tell Pete that calling you by that nickname really makes you nervous and tense, Pete may use the nickname when he wants to hurt you, but he is more likely to stop calling you by that name. If, on the other hand, you don't describe your feelings to Pete, he is probably going to call you by that name all the time because he doesn't know any better. When you say nothing, you reinforce his behavior. The level of risk varies with each situation, but you will more often improve a relationship than be hurt by describing feelings.

13

3. Many people believe that if they describe feelings, others will make them feel guilty about having such feelings. At a very tender age we all learned about "tactful" behavior. Under the premise that "the truth sometimes hurts" we learned to avoid the truth by not saying anything or by telling "little" lies. Perhaps when you were young your mother said, "Don't forget to give Grandma a great big kiss." At that time you may have blurted out, "Ugh—it makes me feel yucky to kiss Grandma. She's got a mustache." If your mother responded, "That's terrible—your grandma loves you. Now you give her a kiss and never let me hear you talk like that again!" then you probably felt guilty for having this "wrong" feeling. But the point is that the thought of kissing your grandma made you feel "yucky" whether it should have or not. In this case what was at issue was the way you talked about the feelings—not your having the feelings.

14

4. Many people believe that describing feelings causes harm to others or to a relationship. If it really bothers Max when his girlfriend, Dora, bites her fingernails, Max may believe that describing his feelings to Dora will hurt her so much that the knowledge will drive a wedge into their relationship. So it's better for Max to say nothing, right? Wrong! If Max says nothing, he's still going to be bothered by Dora's behavior. In fact, as time goes on, Max will probably lash out at Dora for other things because he can't bring himself to talk about the behavior that really bothers him. The net result is that not only will Dora be hurt by Max's behavior, but she won't understand the true source of his feelings. By not describing his feelings, Max may well drive a wedge into their relationship anyway.

15

If Max does describe his feelings to Dora, she might quit or at least try to quit biting her nails; they might get into a discussion in which he finds out that she doesn't want to bite them but just can't seem to stop, and he can help her in her efforts to stop; or they might discuss the problem and Max may see that it is a small thing really and not let it bother him as much. The point is that in describing feelings the chances of a successful outcome are greater than they are in not describing them.

- 16 To describe your feelings, first put the emotion you are feeling into words. Be specific. Second, state what triggered the feeling. Finally, make sure you indicate that the feeling is yours. For example, suppose your roommate borrows your jacket without asking. When he returns, you describe your feelings by saying, "Cliff, I [indication that the feeling is yours] get really angry [the feeling] when you borrow my jacket without asking [trigger]." Or suppose that Carl has just reminded you of the very first time he brought you a rose. You describe your feelings by saying, "Carl, I [indication that the feeling is yours] get really tickled [the feeling] when you remind me about that first time you brought me a rose [trigger]."
- 17 You may find it easiest to begin by describing positive feelings: "I really feel elated knowing that you were the one who nominated me for the position" or "I'm delighted that you offered to help me with the housework." As you gain success with positive descriptions, you can try negative feelings attributable to environmental factors: "It's so cloudy; I feel gloomy" or "When the wind howls through the cracks, I really get jumpy." Finally, you can move to negative descriptions resulting from what people have said or done: "Your stepping in front of me like that really annoys me" or "The tone of your voice confuses me."

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *detrimental* in “For instance, a stranger’s inconsiderate behavior at a party may bother you, but because you can move to another part of the room, withholding may not be detrimental” (paragraph 4) means
 - a. useful.
 - b. private.
 - c. helpless.
 - d. harmful.
2. The word *wedge* in “Max may believe that describing his feelings to Dora will hurt her so much that the knowledge will drive a wedge into their relationship” (paragraph 14) means
 - a. something that divides.
 - b. loyalty.
 - c. friendship.
 - d. many years.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. Effective Communication
 - b. Negative Feelings
 - c. The Consequences of Withholding Feelings
 - d. Emotions: When and How to Express Them
4. Which sentence best expresses the article’s main point?
 - a. Everyone has feelings.
 - b. There are three ways to deal with feelings; describing them is most useful for educating others about how you want to be treated.
 - c. Withholding feelings means not giving verbal or nonverbal clues that might reveal those feelings to others.
 - d. Psychologists have studied the manner in which people deal with their feelings.
5. You are most likely to create physical problems for yourself by
 - a. withholding your feelings.
 - b. displaying your positive feelings.
 - c. describing your positive feelings.

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- d. describing your negative feelings.
6. The author uses the term “describing your feelings” to refer to
- a. keeping your feelings inside.
 - b. giving a nonverbal response to feelings.
 - c. putting your feelings into words calmly.
 - d. telling “little” lies.
7. Shouting angrily at a person who has stepped in front of you in line is an example of
- a. withholding feelings.
 - b. displaying feelings.
 - c. describing feelings.
 - d. self-disclosing.
-
8. From the reading, we can conclude that describing feelings
- a. is usually easy for people.
 - b. is often a good way to solve problems.
 - c. should be done only for positive feelings.
 - d. should make you feel guilty.
9. Which sentence can we infer is an example of describing a feeling?
- a. Although Mrs. Henderson hates going to the mountains, she says nothing as her husband plans to go there for their vacation.
 - b. Neil calls Joanna the day after their date and says, “I want you to know how much I enjoyed our evening together. You’re a lot of fun.”
 - c. Raoul jumps out of his seat and yells joyfully as the Packers make a touchdown.
 - d. Peggy’s office-mate chews gum noisily, cracking and snapping it. Peggy shrieks, “How inconsiderate can you be? You’re driving me crazy with that noise!”
10. *True or false?* _____ We can infer that people who describe their feelings tend to be physically healthier than those who withhold feelings.

715

716

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. Discuss this and the following two questions with a partner. What is the difference between describing feelings and expressing them? How might Doris describe her feelings to Candy after Candy says, “That first paragraph isn’t very well written” (paragraph 2)?
- 2. Why do you think Verderber emphasizes describing feelings over the other two methods of dealing with feelings?
- 3. What are some examples from your own experience of withholding, expressing or displaying, and describing feelings? How useful was each?



About Structure

- 4. What method of introduction does Verderber use in this selection?
 - a. Broad to narrow
 - b. Anecdote
 - c. Beginning with a situation opposite to the one he will describe
 - d. Question Is his introduction effective? Why or why not?
- 5. Verderber divides the body of his essay into three parts: first about withholding feelings, second about displaying feelings, and finally about describing feelings. He further divides the third part by introducing a list. What is that list about? How many items does he include in it?
- 6. What devices does the author use to emphasize the organization of his essay?
- 7. How many examples does Verderber provide for withholding feelings? Displaying feelings? Describing feelings?

About Style and Tone

- 8. What type of evidence does the author use to back up his points throughout the selection? What other types of support might he have used?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Write a paragraph about a time when you withheld or displayed feelings, but describing them would have been a better idea. Your topic sentence might be something like either of these:

An argument I had with my boyfriend recently made me wish that I had described my feelings rather than displaying them.

Withholding my feelings at work recently left me feeling frustrated and angry.

Then narrate the event, showing how feelings were withheld or displayed and what the result was. Conclude your paragraph by contrasting what really happened with what *might* have happened if feelings had been described.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

“Dealing with Feelings” lists and discusses several ways to cope with emotions. Write a paragraph in which you present three ways to do something else. Your tone may be serious or humorous. You might write about three ways to do one of the following:

Cut expenses

Meet people

Get along with a difficult coworker

Ruin a party

Embarrass your friends

Lose a job

Here is a possible topic sentence for this assignment:

To ruin a party, you must follow three simple steps.

717

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

At one time or another, you have probably used all three methods of communicating described by Verderber: withholding, displaying, and describing. Write an essay that describes a situation in which you have used each of those methods. In each case, narrate the event that occurred. Then explain why you responded as you did and how you ended up feeling about your response. Finish your essay with some conclusion of your own about dealing with feelings.

Here’s a sample outline for such an essay:

Thesis statement: At different times, I have withheld my feelings, displayed my feelings, and described my feelings.

Topic sentence 1: Dealing with a rude store clerk, I withheld my feelings.

Topic sentence 2: When another driver cut me off in traffic, I displayed my feelings.

Topic sentence 3: When my mother angered me by reading a letter I’d left lying on the dining-room table, I described my feelings.

Conclusion: When it comes to dealing with people I care about, describing my feelings works better than withholding or displaying them.

“Extra Large,” Please: Diane Urbina

PREVIEW

Why are so many kids today overweight or even obese? According to Diane Urbina, the number-one culprit is junk food, which is available anytime, anywhere—and in ever-increasing portion sizes. Urbina argues that schools, fast-food restaurants, and the media have a responsibility to raise awareness about nutrition and save people of all ages from a public-health disaster.

- 1 School lunches have always come in for criticism. When I was a kid, we complained about “mystery meat” and “leftover surprise casserole.” Half a canned pear in a shaky nest of Jell-O didn’t do much to excite our tastebuds. I hid my share of limp green beans under my napkin, the better to escape the eagle eye of lunchroom monitors who encouraged us to eat our soggy, overcooked vegetables.
- 2 But the cafeteria lunches were there, and so we ate them. (Most of them. OK, I hid the gooey tapioca pudding, too.) I think we accepted the idea that being delicious was not the point. The meals were reasonably nutritious and they fueled our young bodies for the mental and physical demands of the day. In my case, that demand included walking a quarter-mile to and from school, enjoying three recesses a day, and taking part in gym class a couple of times a week. After-school hours, at least when the weather was good, were spent outdoors playing kickball or tag with neighbor kids.

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- 3 I can imagine you wondering, “Who cares?” I don’t blame you. My memories of schooldays in northern Indiana thirty-some years ago aren’t all that fascinating even to me. And yet I think you should care, because of one fact I haven’t mentioned yet. When I was a kid and looked around at other kids my age, I saw all kinds of differences. There were tall ones and short ones and black and white and brown ones, rude ones and polite ones, popular ones and geeky ones, athletic ones and uncoordinated ones. But you know what? There weren’t many heavy ones. The few there were stood out because they were unusual. I think that if you had asked me at the time, I would have told you that kids are just naturally skinny.
- 4 Flash forward to the present. Walk down any city street in America. Sit in a mall and watch the people stream by. You don’t need to be a rocket scientist to notice something’s changed. Whether you call them big-boned, chubby, husky, or plus-sized, kids are heavy, lots of them. If your own eyes don’t convince you, here are the statistics: Since 1980, the number of American kids who are dangerously overweight has tripled. More than 16 percent of our children—that’s 1 in 6—qualify as “obese.” Hordes of them are developing diet-related diabetes, a disease that used to be seen almost always in adults. When California’s students grades 5 through 12 were given a basic fitness test, almost 8 out of 10 failed.
- 5 Part of the problem is that many kids don’t have good opportunities to exercise. They live in neighborhoods without sidewalks or paths where they can walk, bike, or skate safely. Drug activity and violent crime may make playing outside dangerous. They can reach their schools only by car or bus. Many of those schools are so short of money they’ve scrapped their physical-fitness classes. Too few communities have athletic programs in place.
- 6 Electronic entertainment also plays a role in the current state of affairs. Kids used to go outside to play with other kids because it was more fun than sitting around the house. Today, kids who sit around the house have access to dozens of cable TV channels, the Internet, DVD players, and a dizzying assortment of video games.
- 7 Still another cause is the lack of parental supervision. When I was a kid, most of us had a mom or an older sibling at home telling us to get off our butts and go outside. (The alternative was often to stay inside and do chores. We chose to go out and play.) Now, most American families have two working parents. For most of the daylight hours, those parents just aren’t around to encourage their kids to get some exercise. A related problem is that parents who can’t be home much may feel guilty about it. One way of relieving that guilt is to buy Junior the game system of his dreams and a nice wide-screen TV to play it on.
- 8 These are all complicated problems whose solutions are equally complicated. But there is one cause of the fattening of America’s kids that can be dealt with more easily. And that cause is the enormous influence that fast-food restaurants and other sources of calorie-laden junk have gained over America’s kids.
- 9 I’m no health nut. I like an occasional Quarter Pounder as well as the next mom. There is no quicker way to my kids’ hearts than to bring home a newly released DVD, a large pepperoni pie and a bag of

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Chicken McNuggets. But in our home, an evening featuring extra mozzarella and bottles of 7-Up is a once-in-a-while treat—sort of a guilty pleasure.

- 10 To many of today’s kids, fast food is not a treat—it’s their daily diet. Their normal dinnertime equals McDonald’s, Pizza Hut, Domino’s, Burger King, Taco Bell or Kentucky Fried Chicken, all washed down with Pepsi. And increasingly, lunchtime at school means those foods too. About 20 percent of our nation’s schools have sold chain restaurants the right to put their food items on the lunch line. Many schools also allow candy and soft-drink vending machines on their campuses. The National Soft Drink Association reports that 60 percent of public and private middle schools and high schools make sodas available for purchase.
- 11 Believe me, when I was a kid, if the lunchline had offered me a couple of slices of double-crust stuffed pepperoni-sausage pizza instead of a Turkey Submarine, I would have said yes before you could say the words “clogged arteries.” And when I needed a mid-afternoon pick-me-up, I would have gladly traded a handful of change for a Coke and a Snickers bar.
- 12 And then I would have gone back into algebra class and spent the hour bouncing between a sugar high and a fat-induced coma.
- 13 Stopping off at Taco Bell for an occasional Seven-Layer Burrito is one thing. But when fast foods become the staple of young people’s diets, it’s the kids who become Whoppers. And it has become the staple for many. According to researchers at Children’s Hospital Boston, during any given week, three out of four children eat a fast-food meal one or more times a day. The beverages they chug down are a problem, too. The U.S. Department of Agriculture says that every day, the average adolescent drinks enough soda and fruit beverages to equal the sugar content of 50 chocolate-chip cookies.
- 14 The problem isn’t only that burgers, fries, and sodas aren’t nutritious to begin with—although they aren’t. What has made the situation much worse is the increasingly huge portions sold by fast-food restaurants. Back when McDonald’s began business, its standard meal consisted of a hamburger, two ounces of French fries, and a 12-ounce Coke. That meal provided 590 calories. But today’s customers don’t have to be satisfied with such modest portions. For very little more money, diners can end up with a quarter-pound burger, extra-large fries, and extra-large cup of Coke that add up to 1,550 calories. A whole generation of kids is growing up believing that this massive shot of fat, sugar, and sodium equals a “normal portion.” As a result, they’re becoming extra large themselves.
- 15 As kids sit down to watch the after-school and Saturday-morning shows designed for them, they aren’t just taking in the programs themselves. They’re seeing at least an hour of commercials for every five hours of programming. On Saturday mornings, nine out of 10 of those commercials are for sugary cereals, fast foods, and other non-nutritious junk. Many of the commercials are tied in with popular toys or beloved cartoon characters or movies aimed at children. Watching those commercials makes the kids hungry—or at least they think they’re hungry. (Thanks to all the factors mentioned here, many children can no longer tell if they’re genuinely hungry or not. They’ve been programmed to eat for many reasons other than hunger.) So they snack as they sit in front of the TV set. Then at mealtime, they beg to go out for more junk food. And they get bigger, and bigger, and bigger.

720
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- 16 There is no overnight solution to the problem of American children's increasing weight and decreasing level of physical fitness. But can anything be done? To begin with, fast-food meals and junk-food vending machines should be banned from schools. Our education system should be helping children acquire good nutritional habits, not assisting them in committing slow nutritional suicide.
- 17 In addition, commercials for junk food should be banned from TV during children's viewing time, specifically Saturday mornings.
- 18 And finally, fast-food restaurants should be required to do what tobacco companies—another manufacturer of products known to harm people's health—have to do. They should display in their restaurants, and in their TV and print ads as well, clear nutritional information about their products. For instance, a young woman at Burger King who was considering ordering a Double Whopper with Cheese, a king-size order of fries and a king-size Dr. Pepper could read something like this:



Who is the intended audience of this advertisement? How do you know? The ad may be effective, but considering Urbina's point in her essay, is it socially responsible? Why or why not?

- 19 *Your meal will provide 2030 calories, 860 of those calories from fat.*
- 20 *Your recommended daily intake is 2000 calories, with no more than 600 of those calories coming from fat.*
- 21 At a glance, then, the customer could see that in one fast-food meal, she was taking in more calories and fat than she should consume in an entire day.
- 22 Overweight kids today become overweight adults tomorrow. Overweight adults are at increased risk for heart disease, diabetes, stroke, and cancer. Schools, fast-food restaurants, and the media are contributing to a public-health disaster in the making. Anything that can be done to decrease the role junk food plays in kids' lives needs to be done, and done quickly.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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- The word *hordes* in “More than 16 percent of our children—that’s 1 in 6—qualify as ‘obese.’ Hordes of them are developing diet-related diabetes, a disease that used to be seen almost always in adults” (paragraph 4) means
 - few.
 - many.
 - hardly any.
 - a handful.
- The word *complicated* in “These are all complicated problems whose solutions are equally complicated” (paragraph 8) means
 - simple.
 - interesting.
 - complex.
 - easy.
- Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - Healthy School Lunches
 - Solving Childhood Obesity

- c. The Dangers of Childhood Obesity
 - d. Too Much of a Junk Thing
4. Which sentence best expresses the central idea of the selection?
- a. Electronic entertainment is responsible for childhood obesity.
 - b. More physical-fitness classes are needed to solve childhood obesity.
 - c. We need to reduce the role that junk food plays in children's lives and help them acquire good nutritional habits.
 - d. School lunches are much more nutritious than junk food.
-
5. According to the author, which of the following does *not* contribute to childhood obesity?
- a. Electronic entertainment
 - b. Fewer opportunities to exercise
 - c. Occasional fast-food treats
 - d. Lack of parental supervision
6. *True or false?* _____ Today, 1 in 6 children in America qualify as "obese."
7. The author argues that fast-food restaurant chains should be required to
- a. provide nutritional information about their products.
 - b. reduce the portion sizes of their products.
 - c. use healthier ingredients in their products.
 - d. reduce the amount of saturated fats contained in their products.
8. Many public and private middle schools and high schools
- a. provide students with healthy lunch options.
 - b. refuse to allow candy vending machines on their campuses.
 - c. make soft drinks available for purchase.
 - d. refuse to offer items from fast-food restaurant chains.
9. From the article, we can infer that the author
- a. believes her readers are genuinely concerned about her topic.
 - b. is trying to convince her readers about the importance of her topic.

722

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- c. is trying to encourage her readers to lobby for school lunch reform.
 - d. believes that the solution to childhood obesity is simple.
10. When the author suggests that fast-food restaurants should be required to display nutritional information about their products, she is assuming that
- a. many of the items will exceed the recommended daily intake of calories.
 - b. the tobacco companies will also display information about their products.
 - c. fast-food restaurants will feel pressured to offer healthier menu items.
 - d. people will then choose to eat more wisely.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. In paragraph 3, the author tells her readers, “I can imagine you wondering, ‘Who cares?’” Does she blame her readers? Why does she think they should care?
- 2. Do you feel that the author’s solutions in paragraphs 16–18 will solve “the problem of American children’s increasing weight and decreasing level of physical fitness”? With a partner, discuss what other solutions are needed to counteract this problem.

723
724



- 3. How might the author revise her essay to appeal directly to children and teenagers? What might she say to them? What might convince them to change their eating habits?

About Structure

- 4. What patterns of development does the author use in her essay? Explain.
- 5. The author uses *addition words* to signal added ideas. Locate and write three of these words:

- 6. The author uses the first-person approach, which relies on her own experiences. Do you feel that she is credible? What details does she include in her essay to convince us of her trustworthiness?

About Style and Tone

- 7. In paragraph 1, the author recounts her experiences eating school lunches. She could have simply written, “I ate casseroles, canned fruits, and cooked vegetables.” Instead she writes, “Half a canned pear in a shaky nest of Jell-O didn’t do much to excite our tastebuds. I hid my share of limp green beans under my napkin, the better to escape the eagle eye of lunchroom monitors who encouraged us to eat our soggy, overcooked vegetables.” Why do you think she provides such vivid details? What is the effect on her readers?
- 8. The author uses statistics as well as personal experiences. Find three places in the selection where statistics are cited:

Paragraph _____

Paragraph _____

Paragraph _____

What do statistics accomplish that anecdotes cannot?

- 9. What are a few words that the author would probably use to describe the people who are responsible for fast-food marketing? Find evidence in the selection to support your opinion.

724

725

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Diane Urbina discusses why 1 in 6 children in our country are considered obese. Choose one of the problems she identifies, such as lack of opportunities for children to exercise, and write a paragraph in which you discuss what could be done to help solve the problem. Following are a few possible topic sentences for this assignment:

Children would have more opportunities to exercise if the government would allocate funds to build playgrounds, fields, and basketball courts.

Parents should spend time with their children doing physical activities, such as riding their bikes, going for hikes, or swimming at the neighborhood pool.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

What did you learn from the selection, or what do you already know, about obesity that might influence your own future? Write a paragraph in which you list three or four ways in which you could minimize or avoid some of the problems often faced by those struggling with their weight. For instance, you may decide to do whatever you can to remain as healthy as possible throughout your life. That might involve taking daily walks, eating less junk food, and cooking more nutritious meals. Your topic sentence might simply be “There are three important ways in which I hope to avoid some of the problems often faced by those struggling with obesity.”

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay Using Internet Research

As Diane Urbina discovered while doing her research, when California’s students grades 5 through 12 were given a basic fitness test, almost 80 percent failed (paragraph 4). What can people—students, parents, teachers, administrators, and community members—do to change these statistics and help produce more physically active students? Use the Internet to see what some experts have suggested. Then write an essay on three ways that can promote physical fitness.

To start your research, use the very helpful search engine Google (www.google.com). Try one of the following phrases or some related phrase:

physical fitness and children

exercise and children

Human Groups and Society

The Most Hateful Words: Amy Tan

PREVIEW



For years, a painful exchange with her mother lay like a heavy stone on Amy Tan's heart. In the following essay, Tan, author of best-selling novels including *The Joy Luck Club* and *The Kitchen God's Wife*, tells the story of how that weight was finally lifted. This essay is from her memoir, *The Opposite of Fate*.

- 1 The most hateful words I have ever said to another human being were to my mother. I was sixteen at the time. They rose from the storm in my chest and I let them fall in a fury of hailstones: "I hate you. I wish I were dead. . . ."
- 2 I waited for her to collapse, stricken by what I had just said. She was still standing upright, her chin tilted, her lips stretched in a crazy smile. "Okay, maybe I die too," she said between huffs. "Then I no longer be your mother!" We had many similar exchanges. Sometimes she actually tried to kill herself by running into the street, holding a knife to her throat. She too had storms in her chest. And what she aimed at me was as fast and deadly as a lightning bolt.
- 3 For days after our arguments, she would not speak to me. She tormented me, acted as if she had no feelings for me whatsoever. I was lost to her. And because of that, I lost, battle after battle, all of them: the times she criticized me, humiliated me in front of others, forbade me to do this or that without even listening to one good reason why it should be the other way. I swore to myself I would never forget these injustices. I would store them, harden my heart, make myself as impenetrable as she was.

- 4 I remember this now, because I am also remembering another time, just a few years ago. I was forty-seven, had become a different person by then, had become a fiction writer, someone who uses memory and imagination. In fact, I was writing a story about a girl and her mother, when the phone rang.
- 5 It was my mother, and this surprised me. Had someone helped her make the call? For a few years now, she had been losing her mind through Alzheimer's disease. Early on, she forgot to lock her door. Then she forgot where she lived. She forgot who many people were and what they had meant to her. Lately, she could no longer remember many of her worries and sorrows. 726
727
- 6 "Amy-ah," she said, and she began to speak quickly in Chinese. "Something is wrong with my mind. I think I'm going crazy."
- 7 I caught my breath. Usually she could barely speak more than two words at a time. "Don't worry," I started to say.
- 8 "It's true," she went on. "I feel like I can't remember many things. I can't remember what I did yesterday. I can't remember what happened a long time ago, what I did to you. . . ." She spoke as a drowning person might if she had bobbed to the surface with the force of will to live, only to see how far she had already drifted, how impossibly far she was from the shore.
- 9 She spoke frantically: "I know I did something to hurt you."
- 10 "You didn't," I said. "Don't worry."
- 11 "I did terrible things. But now I can't remember what. . . . And I just want to tell you . . . I hope you can forget, just as I've forgotten."
- 12 I tried to laugh so she would not notice the cracks in my voice. "Really, don't worry."
- 13 "Okay, I just wanted you to know."
- 14 After we hung up, I cried, both happy and sad. I was again that sixteen-year-old, but the storm in my chest was gone.
- 15 My mother died six months later. By then she had bequeathed to me her most healing words, as open and eternal as a clear blue sky. Together we knew in our hearts what we should remember, what we can forget.

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *stricken* in “I waited for her to collapse, *stricken* by what I had just said” (paragraph 2) means
 - a. wounded.
 - b. amused.
 - c. annoyed.
 - d. bored.
2. The word *bequeathed* in “By then she had *bequeathed* to me her most healing words, those that are as open and eternal as a clear blue sky” (paragraph 15) means
 - a. denied.
 - b. sold.
 - c. given.
 - d. cursed.

727

3. Which sentence best expresses the central idea of the selection?
 - a. Because of Alzheimer’s disease, the author’s mother forgot harsh words the two of them had said to each other.
 - b. Amy Tan had a difficult relationship with her mother that worsened over the years.
 - c. Years after a painful childhood with her mother, Amy Tan was able to realize peace and forgiveness.
 - d. Despite her Alzheimer’s disease, Amy Tan’s mother was able to apologize to her daughter for hurting her.
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of paragraphs 1–2?
 - a. Amy Tan’s mother was sometimes suicidal.
 - b. Amy Tan wanted to use words to hurt her mother.
 - c. It is not unusual for teenagers and their parents to argue.
 - d. Amy Tan and her mother had a very hurtful relationship.
5. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of paragraphs 8–9?
 - a. The author’s mother was deeply disturbed by the thought that she had hurt her daughter.
 - b. Alzheimer’s disease causes people to become confused and unable to remember things clearly.

728

- c. The author's mother could not even remember what she had done the day before.
 - d. The author's mother had changed very little from what she was like when Tan was a child.
6. After arguing with her daughter, the author's mother
- a. would say nice things about her to others.
 - b. would immediately forget they had argued.
 - c. would refuse to speak to her.
 - d. would apologize.
7. When she was a girl, the author swore that she
- a. would never forget her mother's harsh words.
 - b. would never be like her mother.
 - c. would publicly embarrass her mother by writing about her.
 - d. would never have children.
-
8. The first sign that the author's mother had Alzheimer's disease was
- a. forgetting where she lived.
 - b. being able to speak only two or three words at a time.
 - c. forgetting people's identities.
 - d. forgetting to lock her door.
9. We can infer from paragraph 2 that
- a. the author wished her mother were dead.
 - b. the author immediately felt guilty for the way she had spoken to her mother.
 - c. the author's mother was emotionally unstable.
 - d. the author's mother was physically abusive.
10. The author implies, in paragraphs 9–15, that
- a. she was pleased by her mother's sense of guilt.
 - b. her love and pity for her mother were stronger than her anger.
 - c. she did not recall what her mother was talking about.
 - d. she was annoyed by her mother's confusion.

728

729

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. How would you describe Amy Tan’s mother? What kind of mother does she appear to have been?
- 2. In the discussion at the end of the essay, Tan chooses to keep her emotions hidden from her mother. Why do you think she does this?
- 3. What does Tan mean by her last line, “Together we knew in our hearts what we should remember, what we can forget.”

About Structure

- 4. Tan makes effective use of parallel structure in writing her story. What are two examples of parallelism that help make her sentences clear and easy to read?
- 5. Tan begins her essay from the point of view of a sixteen-year-old girl but finishes it from the perspective of a woman in her late forties. Where in the essay does Tan make the transition between those two perspectives? What words does she use to signal the change?
- 6. Paragraph 5 describes a sequence of events, and the writer uses several transition words to signal time relationships. Locate three of those transitions and write them here:

About Style and Tone

- 7. What effect does Tan achieve by using so many direct quotations?
- 8. Tan uses images of the weather throughout her essay. Find three instances in which Tan mentions weather and list them below. What does she accomplish with this technique?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Despite being an adult, Tan recalls feeling like a sixteen-year-old girl again when she speaks to her mother. Think about something in your life that has the power to reconnect you to a vivid memory.

Write a paragraph in which you describe your memory and the trigger which “takes you back” to it. Begin your paragraph with a topic sentence that makes it clear what you are going to discuss. Then provide specific details so that readers can understand your memory. Here are sample topic sentences.

Whenever I see swings, I remember the day in second grade when I got into my first fistfight.

The smell of cotton candy takes me back to the day my grandfather took me to my first baseball game.

I can’t pass St. Joseph’s Hospital without remembering the day, ten years ago, when my brother was shot.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

In this essay, we see that Tan’s relationship with her mother was very complicated. Who is a person with whom you have a complex relationship—maybe a relationship you’d describe as “love-hate” or “difficult”? Write a paragraph about that relationship. Be sure to give examples or details to show readers why you have such difficulties with this person.

Your topic sentence should introduce the person you plan to discuss. For example:

730

731

To me, my mother in-law is one of the most difficult people in the world. (*Or, My mother-in-law and I have contrasting points of view on several issues.*)

While I respect my boss, he is simply a very difficult person.

Even though I love my sister, I can’t stand to be around her.

Be sure to provide specific examples or details to help your reader understand why the relationship is so difficult for you. For example, if you decide to write about your boss, you will want to describe specific behaviors that show just why you consider him or her difficult.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Like Tan’s mother, most of us have at some time done something we wish we could undo. If you had a chance to revisit your past and change one of your actions, what would it be? Write an essay describing something you would like to undo.

In your first paragraph, introduce exactly what you did. Here are three thesis statements that students might have written:

I wish I could undo the night I decided to drive my car while I was drunk.

If I could undo any moment in my life, it would be the day I decided to drop out of high school.

One moment from my life I would like to change is the time I picked on an unpopular kid in sixth grade.

Be sure to provide details and, if appropriate, actual words that were spoken, so that your readers can “see and hear” what happened. Once you’ve described the moment that you wish to take back, write three reasons why you feel the way you do. Below is a scratch outline for the first topic.

I wish I could undo the night I decided to drive my car while I was drunk.

- 1. Caused an accident that hurt others.
- 2. Lost my license, my car, and my job.
- 3. Affected the way others treat me.

To write an effective essay, you will need to provide specific details explaining each reason you identify. For instance, to support the third reason above, you might describe new feelings of guilt and anger you have about yourself as well as provide examples of how individual people now treat you differently. To end your essay, you might describe what you would do today if you could replay what happened.



Share a draft of your essay with a classmate, and offer to critique his or her paper as well. Use the Four Bases checklist on the inside back cover to help you revise.

731

732

The Storyteller: Adapted from H. H. Munro (“Saki”)

PREVIEW



What is a good story for children: one that teaches them a lesson—or one that they enjoy? In the timeless and beloved tale that follows, an aunt learns a lesson herself about storytelling.

- 1 It was a hot afternoon, and inside the train it was steamy. The next stop was Templecombe, which was almost an hour ahead. In one car of the train there were a little girl, an even younger girl, and a little boy. Their aunt sat in a seat in the corner. In the opposite corner of the car was a bachelor who didn't know them. The girls and the boy were running all over the train car. Their conversation with their aunt reminded the bachelor of the irritating buzzing of a housefly. Everything the aunt said to the children began with "Don't," while everything the children said to her began with "Why?" The bachelor said nothing.
- 2 "Don't, Cyril, don't!" exclaimed the aunt, as the boy began hitting the seat cushions, making clouds of dust fly up. "Come over here and look out the window."
- 3 Reluctantly, the boy went over to the window. "Why are they driving those sheep out of that field?" he asked.
- 4 "I guess they are being taken to another field that has more grass," said the aunt weakly.
- 5 "But there's lots of grass in that field," protested the boy. "There's nothing but grass there. Aunt, there's lots of grass in that field."
- 6 "Maybe the grass in the other field is better," the aunt suggested foolishly.
- 7 "Why is it better?" came the quick, obvious question.
- 8 "Oh, look at those cows!" exclaimed the aunt. Almost every field they passed was full of cows, but she sounded as if this was an amazing surprise.
- 9 "Why is the grass in the other field better?" Cyril kept at her.
- 10 The frown on the bachelor's face was deepening into a scowl. The aunt noticed, and decided he was a mean, unfriendly man. And she couldn't come up with any good explanation for the little boy about the grass in the field.
- 11 The younger girl began to entertain herself by reciting a poem. She knew only the first line, but she put that one line to good use, repeating it over and over again in a loud, dreamy voice. The bachelor wondered if someone had bet her she couldn't say that same line two thousand times without stopping. Unfortunately for him, it seemed she was going to win the bet.
- 12 "Come over here and listen to a story," said the aunt, who had noticed the bachelor glaring at her. He looked as if he might complain to the train conductor.
- 13 The children moved over toward the aunt without any enthusiasm. It was clear she didn't have a very good reputation as a storyteller.
- 14 In a quiet voice that was often interrupted by loud questions from the children, the aunt started a dreadfully boring story about a little girl who was good. Because she was so good, she made a lot of friends, and was finally saved from a wild bull by people who admired how good she was.

732

733

- 15 “Wouldn’t they have saved her if she hadn’t been good?” demanded the older of the little girls. That was exactly the question the bachelor had wanted to ask.
- 16 “Well, yes,” answered the aunt lamely, “but I don’t think they would have run so fast to help her if they hadn’t liked her so much.”
- 17 “It’s the stupidest story I’ve ever heard,” said the older of the little girls.
- 18 “I didn’t even listen after the first part because it was so stupid,” said Cyril.
- 19 The younger girl didn’t comment on the story. Minutes earlier she had stopped listening and started repeating the line from the poem.
- 20 “You don’t seem to be a very successful storyteller,” said the bachelor suddenly.
- 21 The aunt became defensive at this unexpected attack. “It’s very difficult to tell stories that children will understand and enjoy,” she said stiffly.
- 22 “I don’t agree with you,” said the bachelor.
- 23 “Maybe you’d like to tell them a story,” the aunt shot back.
- 24 “Tell us a story!” demanded the older of the little girls.
- 25 “Once upon a time,” began the bachelor, “there was a little girl called Bertha, who was very, very good.”
- 26 The children’s temporary interest started fading immediately. To them, all stories seemed boring and the same, no matter who told them.
- 27 “She did everything she was told to do. She always told the truth and kept her clothes neat and clean. She ate food that was good for her instead of junk food and sweets, got good grades in school, and was polite to everyone.”
- 28 “Was she pretty?” asked the older little girl.
- 29 “Not as pretty as any of you,” said the bachelor, “but she was horribly good.”
- 30 The children became more enthusiastic. The word *horrible* in connection with goodness was something new, and they liked it. It seemed real and true, unlike the aunt’s stories about children.
- 31 “She was so good,” continued the bachelor, “that she won several medals for goodness, which she always wore pinned to her dress. There was a medal for following rules, one for being on time, and one for general good behavior. They were large metal medals and they clinked against each other when she walked. No other child in her town had three medals, so everyone knew that she must be an extra good child.”
- 32 “Horribly good,” repeated Cyril.

- 33 “Everybody talked about how good she was, and the prince of the country heard about it. He decided she was so good that he would let her walk once a week in his park just outside the town. It was a beautiful park, and no children had ever been allowed in it before. So it was a great honor for Bertha to be allowed to go there.” 733
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- 34 “Were there any sheep in the park?” demanded Cyril.
- 35 “No,” said the bachelor, “there were no sheep.”
- 36 “Why weren’t there any sheep?” came the unavoidable question.
- 37 The aunt grinned, looking forward to seeing the bachelor trapped.
- 38 “There were no sheep in the park,” said the bachelor, “because the prince’s mother had once had a dream that her son would be killed either by a sheep or by a clock falling on him. So the prince never kept sheep in his park or a clock in his palace.”
- 39 The aunt gasped in admiration at how well the bachelor had answered the question.
- 40 “Was the prince killed by a sheep or a clock?” asked Cyril.
- 41 “He is still alive, so we don’t know if the dream will come true,” said the bachelor. “Anyway, there were no sheep in the park, but there were lots of little pigs running all over the place.”
- 42 “What color were they?”
- 43 “Black with white faces, white with black spots, black all over, gray with white patches, and some were white all over.”
- 44 The storyteller stopped to let the children imagine all of the wonderful things about the park, and then started again: “Bertha was sad to find that there were no flowers in the park. She had promised her aunts, with tears in her eyes, that she wouldn’t pick any of the flowers. She wanted to keep her promise, so it made her feel silly that there weren’t any flowers to pick.”
- 45 “Why weren’t there any flowers?”
- 46 “Because the pigs had eaten all of them,” said the bachelor. “The gardeners told the prince he couldn’t have both pigs and flowers, so he decided to keep the pigs and forget the flowers.”
- 47 The children looked pleased with the prince’s choice; so many people would have chosen the flowers instead of the pigs.
- 48 “There were lots of other delightful things in the park. There were ponds with gold, blue, and green fish in them; and trees with beautiful talking parrots; and hummingbirds that could hum popular music. Bertha walked around, enjoying herself greatly. She thought, ‘If I weren’t so very good, they wouldn’t have let me come to this beautiful park and enjoy everything in it.’ Her three medals clinked against each other as she walked and again reminded her how good she was. But just then, a very big wolf came prowling into the park to hunt for a fat little pig for its supper.”

- 49 “What color was it?” asked the children, who were now very interested in the story.
- 50 “Mud-colored all over, with a black tongue and pale gray eyes that gleamed fiercely. The first thing it saw in the park was Bertha. Her dress was so spotlessly white and clean that you could see it from far away. Bertha saw the wolf creeping toward her, and she wished she had never been invited to the park. She ran as fast as she could, but the wolf came after her with huge leaps and bounds. She managed to reach some bushes, and she hid in them. As the wolf sniffed the bushes, she could see its black tongue hanging out of its mouth and its cold gray eyes. Bertha was very frightened, and thought, ‘If I had not been so very good, I would be safe back in town right now.’” 734
735
- 51 “However, the smell of the bushes was so strong and the branches were so thick that the wolf couldn’t smell or see Bertha, so it decided to give up and go catch a pig instead. Bertha was so scared of the wolf that she was shaking, and her medals for goodness started clinking together. The wolf was just moving away when it heard the medals clinking and stopped to listen. When they clinked again, it dived into the bush with its gray eyes shining fiercely. It dragged Bertha out and ate her all up. All that was left were her shoes, scraps of clothing, and the three medals for goodness.”
- 52 “Were any of the pigs killed?”
- 53 “No, they all escaped.”
- 54 “The story started badly,” said the younger girl, “but it had a beautiful ending.”
- 55 “It is the most beautiful story I have ever heard,” said the older little girl seriously.
- 56 “It is the *only* beautiful story I have ever heard,” said Cyril.
- 57 The aunt disagreed. “That is a most inappropriate story to tell young children! You may have ruined years of careful teaching!”
- 58 “Anyway,” said the bachelor, gathering his belongings together so he could get off the train, “I kept them quiet for ten minutes, which was more than you could do.”
- 59 “Poor woman!” he thought to himself as he walked down the platform of Templecombe station. “For the next six months those children will beg her in public for an inappropriate story!”



In one or more paragraphs, retell a classic children's story such as Little Red Riding Hood, in your own words. Imagine your audience is a group of disinterested children, and your job is to make them interested in the story.

735

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *glaring* in “‘Come over here and listen to a story,’ said the aunt, who had noticed the bachelor glaring at her. He looked as if he might complain to the train conductor” (paragraph 12) means
 - a. staring angrily.
 - b. smiling.
 - c. yelling.
 - d. laughing.
2. The word *defensive* in “The aunt became defensive at this unexpected attack. ‘It’s very difficult to tell stories that children will understand and enjoy,’ she said stiffly” (paragraph 21) means
 - a. amused.
 - b. self-protecting.
 - c. sad.
 - d. confused.
3. Which sentence best expresses the central point of the selection?
 - a. An aunt traveling with nieces and a nephew tells them a story that taught a lesson.
 - b. A bachelor on a train ride tells a story to three children he doesn’t know.
 - c. Children bored by an aunt’s story about goodness listen happily to a bachelor’s awful and surprising tale.
 - d. It is not right to tell stories to children in which the good character ends up being eaten up by a wolf.
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of paragraph 51?
 - a. The bush had such thick branches and a strong smell that the wolf couldn’t find Bertha.
 - b. Bertha was so frightened by the wolf that she was shaking.
 - c. By the time the wolf left, only scraps of clothing, shoes, and the medals remained.

- d. Though Bertha hid in thick bushes, the wolf found her when her medals clinked, and then ate her up.
5. The aunt offered to tell the children a story when the
- a. little girl began reciting poetry.
 - b. children began running around the train car.
 - c. children asked the bachelor for a story.
 - d. bachelor glared at the aunt.
-
6. The children first began to show real interest in the bachelor's story when he
- a. referred to Bertha as "horribly good."
 - b. mentioned the wolf.
 - c. explained why there were no sheep in the park.
 - d. told about Bertha's medals.
7. As Bertha was hiding in the bushes, she thought
- a. of a plan for escaping from the wolf.
 - b. that the prince should not have allowed a wolf in his park.
 - c. that if she had not been so good, she would be safe.
 - d. that the wolf would probably go away and eat a little pig.
8. When Bertha discovered that there were no flowers in the park, she felt
- a. relieved, because she would not be tempted to pick them.
 - b. sad, because she had made a promise that was now useless.
 - c. angry, because she thought the prince should have provided flowers.
 - d. happy, because she did not like flowers.
9. The author implies that the bachelor
- a. wanted something bad to happen to the children on the train.
 - b. understood children better than the aunt did.
 - c. actually was acquainted with the children and their aunt.
 - d. told a true story.

736

737

10. The author implies that
- a. the children had very good manners.
 - b. the aunt had not spent much time with the children before.
 - c. the aunt would not be taking the children on any more trips.
 - d. the children were tired of their aunt’s stories about perfect children.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. Why do you think the children preferred the bachelor’s story to the aunt’s?
- 2. When you were little, who was your favorite storyteller? Was it an adult in your life such as a parent or teacher, or was it a friend of yours, or was it a TV personality? What stories do you remember him or her telling or reading?
- 3. Did your parents (or other adults in your life) ever hold up other children as examples to you? What qualities did they admire in the other children? How did you respond to being compared with other kids?

737

About Structure

738

- 4. Saki describes the aunt’s story in just one paragraph (14). He spends many paragraphs on the bachelor’s story, providing every word that the bachelor and the children said. Why do you think he gives the two stories such unequal treatment?
- 5. The bachelor makes his story very specific. Name three details he provides that you feel are especially effective.
- 6. Find an example of how the aunt responds to a question from the children; then find an example of how the bachelor responds to one. How do the two contrast with each other?

About Style and Tone

- 7. What are a few words you think the author would probably use to describe the aunt? Find evidence in the story to support your opinion.
- 8. As the bachelor’s story goes on, how can you tell that the children are becoming increasingly enthusiastic about it? What hints does the author give you?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

The children in “The Storyteller” will probably never forget their meeting with the bachelor on the train. Write a paragraph about a brief but memorable encounter you’ve had with a stranger. Include some direct quotations as well as descriptive details that appeal to several senses (sight, hearing, smell, touch) so that the reader can clearly “see” the stranger as you did. Begin your paper with a main point like this:

I’ll never forget a conversation I had with a homeless man last winter.

I had a brief but interesting encounter with a woman I met in a doctor’s waiting room.

Standing in line to buy tickets for a concert, I met a girl whom I’ve remembered ever since.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

The aunt in “The Storyteller” probably means well, but she doesn’t seem to understand children or how to relate to them. Think of a person you’ve observed who didn’t seem to understand how to relate to someone else. Maybe it was an adult with a child, a parent with a teenager, or a teacher with a student. Write a paragraph about the lack of connection between those two people. Begin with a sentence that sums up your observations. Here are some examples:

738

Watching my grandfather and my sister’s little boy makes it clear that Grandpa doesn’t know much about babies.

739

A mother I saw in a toy store didn’t seem to understand how to relate to her little girl.

A waitress at the diner I go to doesn’t seem to understand how to deal with customers.

In your paper, include direct quotations and specific details that illustrate the poor communication you observed.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Favorite stories help families and friends form strong bonds. When people get together, familiar stories are often told. Even though everyone present may already know a story, we enjoy retelling and rehearing it.

Write an essay in which you tell three stories that involve your family or friends, or both. Your thesis statement might be something like one of these:

Of all the stories my relatives tell when they get together, my favorite three involve my dad, my aunt Rosa, and my cousin José.

When I think about my high school friends, I remember three special stories. Two of them were funny, and one was sad.

In the body of your essay, devote one paragraph to telling each of your stories. Remember to explain briefly who each character is and provide any background information your reader will need in order to understand what is happening. Be sure to include the elements that make each story memorable. If one involves a funny conversation, for instance, be sure to quote that conversation directly. If one focuses on something physical, be sure to describe what happened in enough detail so that your reader can clearly envision it. In your concluding paragraph, make a few final remarks about why the three stories are memorable to you.

Alternatively, tell one long story that naturally divides itself into two or three parts. Each of those parts can be one of the supporting paragraphs in your essay.



Exchange essays with a partner and help each other to make revisions; use the Four Bases checklist on the inside back cover as a guide.

739

740

Rudeness at the Movies: Bill Wine

PREVIEW



When you're at a movie theater, do loud conversations, the crinkling of candy wrappers, and the wailing of children make you wish you'd gone bowling instead? Do you cringe when your fellow viewers announce plot twists moments before they happen? If so, you'll find a comrade in suffering in the film critic and columnist Bill Wine, who thinks people have come to feel far too at home in theaters. In the following essay, which first appeared as a newspaper feature story, Wine wittily describes what the moviegoing experience all too often is like these days.

- 1 Is this actually happening or am I dreaming?
- 2 I am at the movies, settling into my seat, eager with anticipation at the prospect of seeing a long-awaited film of obvious quality. The theater is absolutely full for the late show on this weekend evening, as the reviews have been ecstatic for this cinema masterpiece.
- 3 Directly in front of me sits a man an inch or two taller than the Jolly Green Giant. His wife, sitting on his left, sports the very latest in fashionable hairdos, a gathering of her locks into a shape that resembles a drawbridge when it's open.
- 4 On his right, a woman spritzes herself liberally with perfume that her popcornmunching husband got her for Valentine's Day, a scent that should be renamed "Essence of Elk."
- 5 The row in which I am sitting quickly fills up with members of Cub Scout Troop 432, on an outing to the movies because rain has canceled their overnight hike. One of the boys, demonstrating the competitive spirit for which Scouts are renowned worldwide, announces to the rest of the troop the rules in the Best Sound Made from an Empty Good-n-Plenty's Box contest, about to begin.
- 6 Directly behind me, a man and his wife are ushering three other couples into their seats. I hear the woman say to the couple next to her: "You'll love it. You'll just love it. This is our fourth time and we

enjoy it more and more each time. Don't we, Harry? Tell them about the pie-fight scene, Harry. Wait'll you see it. It comes just before you find out that the daughter killed her boyfriend. It's great."

- 7

The woman has more to say—much more—but she is drowned out at the moment by the wailing of a six-month-old infant in the row behind her. The baby is crying because his mother, who has brought her twins to the theater to save on babysitting costs, can change only one diaper at a time.

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Suddenly, the lights dim. The music starts. The credits roll. And I panic.

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I plead with everyone around me to let me enjoy the movie. All I ask, I wail, is to be able to see the images and hear the dialogue and not find out in advance what is about to happen. Is that so much to expect for six bucks, I ask, now engulfed by a cloud of self-pity. I begin weeping unashamedly.
- 10

Then, as if on cue, the Jolly Green Giant slumps down in his seat, his wife removes her wig, the Elk lady changes her seat, the Scouts drop their candy boxes on the floor, the play-by-play commentator takes out her teeth, and the young mother takes her two bawling babies home.
- 11

Of course I am dreaming, I realize, as I gain a certain but shaky consciousness. I notice that I am in a cold sweat. Not because the dream is scary, but from the shock of people being that cooperative.
- 12

I realize that I have awakened to protect my system from having to handle a jolt like that. For never—NEVER—would that happen in real life. Not on this planet.
- 13

I used to wonder whether I was the only one who feared bad audience behavior more than bad moviemaking. But I know now that I am not. Not by a long shot. The most frequent complaint I have heard in the last few months about the moviegoing experience has had nothing to do with the films themselves.
- 14

No. What folks have been complaining about is the audience. Indeed, there seems to be an epidemic of galling inconsiderateness and outrageous rudeness.
- 15

It is not that difficult to forgive a person's excessive height, or malodorous perfume, or perhaps even an inadvisable but understandable need to bring very young children to adult movies.
- 16

But the talking: that is not easy to forgive. It is inexcusable. Talking—loud, constant, and invariably superfluous—seems to be standard operating procedure on the part of many movie patrons these days.
- 17

It is true, I admit, that after a movie critic has seen several hundred movies in the ideal setting of an almost-empty screening room with no one but other politely silent movie critics around him, it does tend to spoil him for the packed-theater experience.
- 18

And something is lost viewing a movie in almost total isolation—a fact that movie distributors acknowledge with their reluctance to screen certain audience-pleasing movies for small groups of critics. Especially with comedies, the infectiousness of laughter is an important ingredient of movie-watching pleasure.

- 19 But it is a decidedly uphill battle to enjoy a movie—no matter how suspenseful or hilarious or moving—with nonstop gabbers sitting within earshot. And they come in sizes, ages, sexes, colors, and motivations of every kind.
- 20 Some chat as if there is no movie playing. Some greet friends as if at a picnic. Some alert those around them to what is going to happen, either because they have seen the film before, or because they are self-proclaimed experts on the predictability of plotting and want to be seen as prescient geniuses.
-
- 21 Some describe in graphic terms exactly what is happening as if they were doing the commentary for a sporting event on radio. (“Ooh, look, he’s sitting down. Now he’s looking at that green car. A banana—she’s eating a banana.”) Some audition for film critic Gene Shalit’s job by waxing witty as they critique the movie right before your very ears.
- 22 And all act as if it is their constitutional or God-given right. As if their admission price allows them to ruin the experience for anyone and everyone else in the building. But why?
- 23 Good question. I wish I knew. Maybe rock concerts and ball games—both environments which condone or even encourage hootin’ and hollerin’—have conditioned us to voice our approval and disapproval and just about anything else we can spit out of our mouths at the slightest provocation when we are part of an audience.
- 24 But my guess lies elsewhere. The villain, I’m afraid, is the tube. We have seen the enemy and it is television.
- 25 We have gotten conditioned over the last few decades to spending most of our screen-viewing time in front of a little box in our living rooms and bedrooms. And when we watch that piece of furniture, regardless of what is on it—be it commercial, Super Bowl, soap opera, funeral procession, prime-time sitcom, Shakespeare play—we chat. Boy, do we chat. Because TV viewing tends to be an informal, gregarious, friendly, casually interruptible experience, we talk whenever the spirit moves us. Which is often.
- 26 All of this is fine. But we have carried behavior that is perfectly acceptable in the living room right to our neighborhood movie theater. And that *isn’t* fine. In fact, it is turning lots of people off to what used to be a truly pleasurable experience: sitting in a jammed movie theater and watching a crowd-pleasing movie. And that’s a first-class shame.
- 27 Nobody wants Fascist-like ushers, yet that may be where we’re headed of necessity. Let’s hope not. But something’s got to give.
- 28 Movies during this Age of Television may or may not be better than ever. About audiences, however, there is no question.
- 29 They are worse.

741

742

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *ecstatic* in “The theater is absolutely full . . . as the reviews have been ecstatic for this cinema masterpiece” (paragraph 2) means
 - a. clever.
 - b. disappointing.
 - c. a little confusing.
 - d. very enthusiastic.
2. The word *malodorous* in “It is not that difficult to forgive a person’s . . . malodorous perfume” (paragraph 15) means
 - a. pleasant.
 - b. expensive.
 - c. bad-smelling.
 - d. hard-to-smell.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. Television-Watching Behavior
 - b. Today’s Movie Audiences
 - c. Modern Films
 - d. The Life of a Movie Critic
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?
 - a. Ushers should now make movie audiences keep quiet.
 - b. People talk while they watch television or sports.
 - c. Rude audiences are ruining movies for many.
 - d. Films have changed in recent years.
5. The author states that in his dream

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743

- a. he had come to the movies with a friend.
 - b. he wore a tall hat and sat in front of a person shorter than he is.
 - c. the Cub Scouts stopped making noises with empty candy boxes.
 - d. the popcorn was too salty.
6. *True or false?* _____ The experience that Wine describes in the first eight paragraphs of this article is typical of what really happens at the movies today.
7. The most frequent complaint the author has heard about movies is that
- a. they are too long.
 - b. they are too expensive.
 - c. the audiences are too noisy.
 - d. the audiences arrive too late.
8. The author suggests that watching television
- a. has affected the behavior of movie audiences.
 - b. should be done in silence.
 - c. is more fun than seeing movies in a theater.
 - d. is a good model for watching movies in theaters.
-
9. From the selection, we can conclude that the author feels
- a. films aren't as good as they used to be.
 - b. teenagers are the rudest members of movie audiences.
 - c. talking during a movie is much more common now than it used to be.
 - d. tall people should be seated in the back of a theater.
10. In paragraph 27, the author implies that unless audiences become quieter,
- a. movie theaters will be closed.
 - b. everyone will watch less television.
 - c. movies will get worse.
 - d. ushers will have to force talkers to be quiet or leave.

743

744

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. According to Wine, what are some possible causes for people’s rude behavior at movies? Of these, which does Wine consider the most likely cause?
- 2. Do you agree with Wine’s theory about why some people are rude at the movies? Why or why not? What might theater operators and other audience members do to control the problem?
- 3. Have you noticed the problem of noisy audiences in a movie theater? If so, what exactly have you experienced? What, if anything, was done about the problems you encountered?

About Structure

- 4. Wine writes about a problem. Write here the paragraphs in which Wine presents details that explain and illustrate what that problem is: paragraphs _____ to _____.
- 5. Wine discusses reasons for the problem he writes about. Write here the paragraphs in which he discusses those reasons: paragraphs _____ to _____.
- 6. Wine suggests one possible but unwelcome solution for the problem he writes about. Write here the number of the paragraph in which he mentions that solution: _____.

About Style and Tone

- 7. Wine provides exaggerated descriptions of audience members—for example, he refers to the tall man sitting in front of him as “an inch or two taller than the Jolly Green Giant.” Find two other examples of this humorous exaggeration.

744
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Besides making readers smile, why might Wine have described the audience in this way?

- 8. Wine tends to use informal wording and sentence structure. In paragraphs 22–26, for instance, find two examples of his informal wording.

In the same paragraphs, find an example of his informal sentence structure.

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Which do you prefer—watching a movie at home or seeing it in a movie theater? Drawing on your own experiences, write a paragraph in which you explain why you prefer one viewing location over the other. Provide a strong example or two for each of your reasons. For instance, below is one reason with a specific example to support it.

Reason: One reason I prefer going to a movie theater is that it is definitely more peaceful than watching a film at home.

Supporting example: For instance, when I tried watching *Titanic* at home the other night, I had to check on a crying baby or a fussy toddler every ten minutes. Can you imagine what it is like just as two pairs of lips on the screen are getting close enough to meet, to hear, “Mommy, my tummy hurts.” If I go out to the movies, I leave my kids and their diapers in the care of my husband or mother.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Using exaggeration and humor, Wine gives his impressions of people’s looks and behavior at a movie theater. Write a paragraph describing your impressions of people’s looks and behavior at a specific event or place. For instance, you might describe how people look and act at a rock concert, in an elevator, in a singles’ hangout, or in a library. Like Wine, use colorful descriptions and quotations. Your topic sentence might be similar to the following:

How people behave on an elevator reveals some key personal qualities.

Try listing ideas to develop your supporting details. Brainstorm ideas with a partner. Below is a list of possible supporting points for the topic sentence above.



Shy people tend to avoid eye contact.

Very friendly people smile and may say something.

Helpful people will keep the elevator from leaving when they see someone rushing toward it.

745

746

A romantic couple won't notice anyone else on the elevator.

Impatient people may push the number of their floor more than once.

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Rudeness, unfortunately, is not limited to the movie theater. We have all observed rude behavior in various places we often go to. Write an essay on this topic. You might use one of the following thesis statements:

Rude behavior is all too common in several places I often go to.

A common part of life at my neighborhood supermarket is the rude behavior of other shoppers.

In an essay with the first central point, you could write about three places where you have seen rude behavior. Develop each paragraph with one or more vivid examples.

In an essay on the second central point, you would need to come up with two or three general types of rude behavior to write about. Below is one student's outline for an essay with that topic sentence.

Central idea: A common part of life at my neighborhood supermarket is the rude behavior of other shoppers.

(1) Getting in the way of other shoppers

Blocking the aisle with a cart

Knocking things down and not picking them up

"Parking" in front of all the free samples

(2) Misplacing items

Putting unwanted frozen food on a shelf instead of back in a freezer

Putting unwanted meat on a shelf instead of in a refrigerated section

(3) Unreasonably making others wait at the checkout line

Bringing a bulging cartload to the express line

Keeping a line waiting while running to get "just one more thing" (instead of stepping out of line)

Keeping a line waiting while deciding what not to buy to keep the total price down (instead of keeping track while shopping)

From Father to Son, Last Words to Live by: Dana Canedy

PREVIEW

On October 14, 2006, Dana Canedy’s fiancé, First Sgt. Charles Monroe King, died in combat in Baghdad; their son Jordan was only seven months old. Before Charles was deployed to Iraq, he began recording a journal—a blend of stories from his life and pieces of advice—for Jordan. In this essay, Canedy, a *New York Times* editor, describes the acute pain of losing her son’s father and seeks comfort in the words he left behind.

- 1 He drew pictures of himself with angel wings. He left a set of his dog tags on a nightstand in my Manhattan apartment. He bought a tiny blue sweat suit for our baby to wear home from the hospital.
- 2 Then he began to write what would become a 200-page journal for our son, in case he did not make it back from the desert in Iraq.
- 3 For months before my fiancé, First Sgt. Charles Monroe King, kissed my swollen stomach and said goodbye, he had been preparing for the beginning of the life we had created and for the end of his own.
- 4 He boarded a plane in December 2005 with two missions, really—to lead his young soldiers in combat and to prepare our boy for a life without him.
- 5 Dear son, Charles wrote on the last page of the journal, “I hope this book is somewhat helpful to you. Please forgive me for the poor handwriting and grammar. I tried to finish this book before I was deployed to Iraq. It has to be something special to you. I’ve been writing it in the states, Kuwait and Iraq.”
- 6 The journal will have to speak for Charles now. He was killed Oct. 14 when an improvised explosive device detonated near his armored vehicle in Baghdad. Charles, 48, had been assigned to the Army’s First Battalion, 67th Armored Regiment, Fourth Infantry Division, based in Fort Hood, Tex. He was a month from completing his tour of duty.
- 7 For our son’s first Christmas, Charles had hoped to take him on a carriage ride through Central Park. Instead, Jordan, now 9 months old, and I snuggled under a blanket in a horse-drawn buggy. The driver seemed puzzled about why I was riding alone with a baby and crying on Christmas Day. I told him.
- 8 “No charge,” he said at the end of the ride, an act of kindness in a city that can magnify loneliness.
- 9 On paper, Charles revealed himself in a way he rarely did in person. He thought hard about what to say to a son who would have no memory of him. Even if Jordan will never hear the cadence of his father’s voice, he will know the wisdom of his words.
- 10 Never be ashamed to cry. No man is too good to get on his knee and humble himself to God. Follow your heart and look for the strength of a woman.

- 11 Charles tried to anticipate questions in the years to come. Favorite team? I am a diehard Cleveland Browns fan. Favorite meal? Chicken, fried or baked, candied yams, collard greens and cornbread. Childhood chores? Shoveling snow and cutting grass. First kiss? Eighth grade.
- 12 In neat block letters, he wrote about faith and failure, heartache and hope. He offered tips on how to behave on a date and where to hide money on vacation. Rainy days have their pleasures, he noted: Every now and then you get lucky and catch a rainbow.
- 13 Charles mailed the book to me in July, after one of his soldiers was killed and he had recovered the body from a tank. The journal was incomplete, but the horror of the young man’s death shook Charles so deeply that he wanted to send it even though he had more to say. He finished it when he came home on a two-week leave in August to meet Jordan, then 5 months old. He was so intoxicated by love for his son that he barely slept, instead keeping vigil over the baby.
- 14 I can fill in some of the blanks left for Jordan about his father. When we met in my hometown of Radcliff, Ky., near Fort Knox, I did not consider Charles my type at first. He was bashful, a homebody and got his news from television rather than newspapers (heresy, since I’m a *New York Times* editor).
- 15 But he won me over. One day a couple of years ago, I pulled out a list of the traits I wanted in a husband and realized that Charles had almost all of them. He rose early to begin each day with prayers and a list of goals that he ticked off as he accomplished them. He was meticulous, even insisting on doing my ironing because he deemed my wrinkle-removing skills deficient. His rock-hard warrior’s body made him appear tough, but he had a tender heart.
- 16 He doted on Christina, now 16, his daughter from a marriage that ended in divorce. He made her blush when he showed her a tattoo with her name on his arm. Toward women, he displayed an old-fashioned chivalry, something he expected of our son. Remember who taught you to speak, to walk and to be a gentleman, he wrote to Jordan in his journal. These are your first teachers, my little prince. Protect them, embrace them and always treat them like a queen.
- 17 Though as a black man he sometimes felt the sting of discrimination, Charles betrayed no bitterness. It’s not fair to judge someone by the color of their skin, where they’re raised or their religious beliefs, he wrote. Appreciate people for who they are and learn from their differences.
- 18 He had his faults, of course. Charles could be moody, easily wounded and infuriatingly quiet, especially during an argument. And at times, I felt, he put the military ahead of family.
- 19 He had enlisted in 1987, drawn by the discipline and challenges. Charles had other options—he was a gifted artist who had trained at the *Art Institute of Chicago*—but felt fulfilled as a soldier, something I respected but never really understood. He had a chest full of medals and a fierce devotion to his men.
- 20 He taught the youngest, barely out of high school, to balance their checkbooks, counseled them about girlfriends and sometimes bailed them out of jail. When he was home in August, I had a baby shower for him. One guest recently reminded me that he had spent much of the evening worrying about his troops back in Iraq.

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- 21 Charles knew the perils of war. During the months before he went away and the days he returned on leave, we talked often about what might happen. In his journal, he wrote about the loss of fellow soldiers. Still, I could not bear to answer when Charles turned to me one day and asked, “You don’t think I’m coming back, do you?” We never said aloud that the fear that he might not return was why we decided to have a child before we planned a wedding, rather than risk never having the chance.
- 22 But Charles missed Jordan’s birth because he refused to take a leave from Iraq until all of his soldiers had gone home first, a decision that hurt me at first. And he volunteered for the mission on which he died, a military official told his sister, Gail T. King. Although he was not required to join the resupply convoy in Baghdad, he believed that his soldiers needed someone experienced with them. “He would say, ‘My boys are out there, I’ve got to go check on my boys,’” said First Sgt. Arenteanis A. Jenkins, Charles’s roommate in Iraq.
- 23 In my grief, that decision haunts me. Charles’s father faults himself for not begging his son to avoid taking unnecessary risks. But he acknowledges that it would not have made a difference. “He was a born leader,” said his father, Charlie J. King.
- 24 “And he believed what he was doing was right.” Back in April, after a roadside bombing remarkably similar to that which would claim him, Charles wrote about death and duty.
- 25 The 18th was a long, solemn night, he wrote in Jordan’s journal. We had a memorial for two soldiers who were killed by an improvised explosive device. None of my soldiers went to the memorial. Their excuse was that they didn’t want to go because it was depressing. I told them it was selfish of them not to pay their respects to two men who were selfless in giving their lives for their country.
- 26 Things may not always be easy or pleasant for you, that’s life, but always pay your respects for the way people lived and what they stood for. It’s the honorable thing to do.
- 27 When Jordan is old enough to ask how his father died, I will tell him of Charles’s courage and assure him of Charles’s love. And I will try to comfort him with his father’s words.
- 28 God blessed me above all I could imagine, Charles wrote in the journal. I have no regrets, serving your country is great.
- 29 He had tucked a message to me in the front of Jordan’s journal. This is the letter every soldier should write, he said. For us, life will move on through Jordan. He will be an extension of us and hopefully everything that we stand for. . . . I would like to see him grow up to be a man, but only God knows what the future holds.

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READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *meticulous* in “He was meticulous, even insisting on doing my ironing because he deemed my wrinkle-removing skills deficient” (paragraph 15) means
 - a. sloppy.
 - b. careful and precise.
 - c. generous and warm.
 - d. careless.
2. The word *chivalry* in “Toward women, he displayed an old-fashioned chivalry, something he expected of our son. Remember who taught you to speak, to walk and to be a gentleman, he wrote to Jordan in his journal” (paragraph 16) means
 - a. politeness.
 - b. outlook.
 - c. rudeness.
 - d. attitude.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
 - a. A Soldier’s Letter
 - b. Jordan’s Early Years
 - c. A Father’s Gift to His Son
 - d. Charles’s Military Experience
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?
 - a. Charles Monroe King writes about his experiences as a soldier in Iraq.
 - b. Charles Monroe King provides his son Jordan with personal proverbs.
 - c. Both Jordan’s father, Charles Monroe King, and Jordan’s mother, Dana Canedy, provide their son with words to live by.
 - d. Dana Canedy writes an article for the *New York Times* about her fiancé’s love for their son, Jordan.
5. Charles Monroe King was killed
 - a. a month after starting his tour of duty in Iraq.
 - b. a month before taking leave to visit Jordan for the first time.
 - c. a month before completing his tour of duty in Iraq.

d. a month after witnessing a roadside bombing that killed two of his soldiers.

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6. *True or false?* _____ Charles's father begged his son to avoid taking unnecessary risks by joining a resupply convoy in Baghdad.

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7. Charles and his fiancé first met in

a. Radcliff, KY

b. New York, NY

c. Cleveland, OH

d. Chicago, IL

8. Which of the following did Charles *not* write in his journal?

a. Always be ashamed to cry.

b. It's not fair to judge someone by the color of their skin.

c. Every now and then you get lucky and catch a rainbow.

d. Always pay your respects for the way people lived and what they stood for.

9. Charles wrote in his journal, "Follow your heart and look for the strength of a woman" (paragraph 10). From this passage, we can infer that he

a. did not trust his mind.

b. felt that women were stronger than men.

c. felt that men were stronger than women.

d. was sincere and respected women.

10. The author writes, "And at times, I felt, he put the military ahead of family" (paragraph 18). After reading the entire selection, we can infer that she

a. never forgave Charles for putting the military ahead of his family.

b. should have begged Charles not to sign up for the dangerous convoy mission.

c. understood Charles's duty to his country.

d. did not understand why Charles could not put his family ahead of the military.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. What did Charles hope to accomplish by writing the journal? Do you feel that he was successful? What does the author, Charles’s fiancée, hope to accomplish by writing her article and publishing it in the *New York Times*?
- 2. The author writes that “on paper, Charles revealed himself in a way he rarely did in person” (paragraph 9). Why do you think this occurred?
- 3. What are some words of wisdom that you received from your parents or family members? What words do you have to inspire others?

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About Structure

- 4. What patterns of development does the author use in her essay? Explain.
- 5. The author uses several time transition words to signal time relationships. Find three of these time words, and write them here:

- 6. In paragraphs 22 and 23, the author includes information told to her by people other than Charles, such as his sister and his roommate in Iraq. Why do you think she chose this narrative strategy?

About Style and Tone

- 7. In paragraphs 1 and 2, the author does not indicate whom the pronoun “he” refers to: “He drew pictures of himself with angel wings. He left a set of his dog tags on a nightstand in my Manhattan apartment. He bought a tiny blue sweat suit for our baby to wear home from the hospital. Then he began to write what would become a 200-page journal for our son, in case he did not make it back from the desert in Iraq.” Why do you think she waited until the third paragraph to provide a pronoun reference?
- 8. How do you think the author feels about America’s military involvement in Iraq? Find evidence in the selection to support your opinion.

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

Author Dana Canedy weaves excerpts from her fiancé Charles’s journal into her own essay about him. Write a paragraph about a person in your life toward whom you care about—such as a relative, a spouse, or a close friend—but whom you recognize has “faults, of course” (paragraph 18). Perhaps you enjoy this person’s company but are annoyed by her grumbling. Or you admire the person’s work ethic but find his flirting uncomfortable. In your topic sentence, state both sides of your feelings, as in the following sample topic statement:

While Jim is a terrific supervisor, he sometimes flirts too much with the office staff.

Then fully describe one side of your subject’s personality before you begin describing the other. Throughout the paragraph, illustrate your point with specific revealing comments and incidents.



Before you begin writing, describe your subject to a partner. Ask which supporting details seem most interesting and most relevant to the topic.

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Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Describe a person you know who has managed to positively touch the lives of nearly everyone around him or her. Divide your paragraph into three sections. These sections could be about *individuals* the person has impacted, such as any of these:

- A grandchild
- A former student
- A coworker

Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

Charles Monroe King was a person who did not judge someone by the color of his or her skin, where they were raised, or their religious beliefs, perhaps because, as his fiancé pointed out, he “sometimes felt the sting of discrimination” (paragraph 17). Write an essay about how it feels to be discriminated against. Select several specific instances in your life when you felt that someone was judging you unfairly. In your essay, devote each supporting paragraph to one such anecdote, describing what happened and how you responded.

A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath: Theresa Conroy and Christine M. Johnson

PREVIEW

Have you ever sat behind the wheel of your car after drinking? Have you ever assured yourself, “I haven’t had too much. I’m still in control”? If you have, you’re not alone. The large number of arrests for drunk driving proves that plenty of drivers who have been drinking thought they were capable of getting home safely. After all, who would get into a car with the intention of killing himself or herself or others? Yet killing is exactly what many drunk drivers do. If all drivers could read the following selection—a newspaper report on one tragic accident—perhaps the frequent cautions about drinking and driving would have some impact. Read the article and see if you agree.

- 1 When Tyson Baxter awoke after that drunken, tragic night—with a bloodied head, broken arm, and battered face—he knew that he had killed his friends.
- 2 “I knew everyone had died,” Baxter, eighteen, recalled. “I knew it before anybody told me. Somehow, I knew.”
- 3 Baxter was talking about the night of Friday, September 13, the night he and seven friends piled into his Chevrolet Blazer after a beer-drinking party. On Street Road in Upper Southampton, he lost control, rear-ended a car, and smashed into two telephone poles. The Blazer’s cab top shattered, and the truck spun several times, ejecting all but one passenger.
- 4 Four young men were killed.
- 5 Tests would show that Baxter and the four youths who died were legally intoxicated.
- 6 Baxter says he thinks about his dead friends on many sleepless nights at the Abraxas Drug and Alcohol Rehabilitation Center near Pittsburgh, where, on December 20, he was sentenced to be held after being found delinquent on charges of vehicular homicide.
- 7 “I drove them where they wanted to go, and I was responsible for their lives,” Baxter said recently from the center, where he is undergoing psychological treatment. “I had the keys in my hand, and I blew it.”
- 8 The story of September 13 is a story about the kind of horrors that drinking and driving is spawning among high school students almost everywhere, . . . about parents who lost their children in a flash and have filled the emptiness with hatred, . . . about a youth whose life is burdened with grief and guilt because he happened to be behind the wheel.
- 9 It is a story that the Baxter family and the dead boys’ parents agreed to tell in the hope that it would inspire high school students to remain sober during this week of graduation festivities—a week that customarily includes a ritual night of drunkenness.
- 10 It is a story of the times.

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- 11 The evening of September 13 began in high spirits as Baxter, behind the wheel of his gold Blazer, picked up seven high school chums for a drinking party for William Tennent High School students and graduates at the home of a classmate. Using false identification, according to police, the boys purchased one six-pack of beer each from a Warminster Township bar.
- 12 The unchaperoned party, attended by about fifty teenagers, ended about 10:30 P.M. when someone knocked over and broke a glass china cabinet. Baxter and his friends decided to head for a fast-food restaurant. As Baxter turned onto Street Road, he was trailed by a line of cars carrying other partygoers.
- 13 Baxter recalled that several passengers were swaying and rocking the high-suspension vehicle. Police were unable to determine the vehicle's exact speed, but, on the basis of the accounts of witnesses, they estimated it at fifty-five miles per hour—ten miles per hour over the limit.
- 14 "I thought I was in control," Baxter said. "I wasn't driving like a nut; I was just . . . driving. There was a bunch of noise, just a bunch of noise. The truck was really bouncing."
- 15 "I remember passing two [cars]. That's the last I remember. I remember a big flash, and that's it."
- 16 Killed in that flash were: Morris "Marty" Freedenberg, sixteen, who landed near a telephone pole about thirty feet from the truck, his face ripped from his skull; Robert Schweiss, eighteen, a Bucks County Community College student, whose internal organs were crushed when he hit the pavement about thirty feet from the truck; Brian Ball, seventeen, who landed near Schweiss, his six-foot-seven-inch frame stretched three inches when his spine was severed; and Christopher Avram, seventeen, a premedical student at Temple University, who landed near the curb about ten feet from the truck.
- 17 Michael Serratore, eighteen, was thrown fifteen feet from the truck and landed on the lawn of the CHI Institute with his right leg shattered. Baxter, who sailed about ten feet after crashing through the windshield of the Blazer, lost consciousness after hitting the street near the center lane. About five yards away, Paul Gee Jr., eighteen, lapsed into a coma from severe head injuries.
- 18 John Gahan, seventeen, the only passenger left in the Blazer, suffered a broken ankle.
- 19 Brett Walker, seventeen, one of several Tennent students who saw the carnage after the accident, would recall later in a speech to fellow students: "I ran over [to the scene]. These were the kids I would go out with every weekend."
- 20 "My one friend [Freedenberg], I couldn't even tell it was him except for his eyes. He had real big, blue eyes. He was torn apart so bad"
- 21 Francis Schweiss was waiting up for his son, Robert, when he received a telephone call from his daughter, Lisa. She was already at Warminster General Hospital.
- 22 "She said Robbie and his friends were in a bad accident and Robbie was not here" at the hospital, Schweiss said. "I got in my car with my wife; we went to the scene of the accident."

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- 23 There, police officers told Francis and Frances Schweiss that several boys had been killed and that the bodies, as well as survivors, had been taken to Warminster General Hospital.
- 24 “My head was frying by then,” Francis Schweiss said. “I can’t even describe it. I almost knew the worst was to be. I felt as though I were living a nightmare. I thought, ‘I’ll wake up. This just can’t be.’”
- 25 In the emergency room, Francis Schweiss recalled, nurses and doctors were scrambling to aid the injured and identify the dead—a difficult task because some bodies were disfigured and because all the boys had been carrying fake drivers’ licenses.
- 26 A police officer from Upper Southampton was trying to question friends of the dead and injured—many of whom were sobbing and screaming—in an attempt to match clothing with identities.
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- 27 When the phone rang in the Freedenberg home, Robert Sr. and his wife, Bobbi, had just gone upstairs to bed; their son Robert Jr. was downstairs watching a movie on television.
- 28 Bobbi Freedenberg and her son picked up the receiver at the same time. It was from Warminster General. . . . There had been a bad accident. . . . The family should get to the hospital quickly.
- 29 Outside the morgue about twenty minutes later, a deputy county coroner told Rob Jr., twenty-two, that his brother was dead and severely disfigured; Rob decided to spare his parents additional grief by identifying the body himself.
- 30 Freedenberg was led into a cinder-block room containing large drawers resembling filing cabinets. In one of the drawers was his brother, Marty, identifiable only by his new high-top sneakers.
- 31 “It was kind of like being taken through a nightmare,” Rob Jr. said. “That’s something I think about every night before I go to sleep. That’s hell. . . . That whole night is what hell is all about for me.”
- 32 As was his custom, Morris Ball started calling the parents of his son’s friends after Brian missed his 11:00 P.M. curfew.
- 33 The first call was to the Baxters’ house, where the Baxters’ sixteen-year-old daughter, Amber, told him about the accident.
- 34 At the hospital, Morris Ball demanded that doctors and nurses take him to his son. The hospital staff had been unable to identify Brian—until Ball told them that his son wore size fourteen shoes.
- 35 Brian Ball was in the morgue. Lower left drawer.
- 36 “He was six foot seven, but after the accident he measured six foot ten, because of what happened to him,” Ball said. “He had a severed spinal cord at the neck. His buttocks were practically ripped off, but he was lying down and we couldn’t see that. He was peaceful and asleep.
- 37 “He was my son and my baby. I just can’t believe it sometimes. I still can’t believe it. I still wait for him to come home.”

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- 38 Lynne Pancoast had just finished watching the 11:00 P.M. news and was curled up in her bed dozing with a book in her lap when the doorbell rang. She assumed that one of her sons had forgotten his key, and she went downstairs to let him in.
- 39 A police light was flashing through the window and reflecting against her living room wall; Pancoast thought that there must be a fire in the neighborhood and that the police were evacuating homes.
- 40 Instead, police officers told her there had been a serious accident involving her son, Christopher Avram, and that she should go to the emergency room at Warminster General.
- 41 At the hospital she was taken to an empty room and told that her son was dead.
- 42 Patricia Baxter was asleep when a Warminster police officer came to the house and informed her that her son had been in an accident.
- 43 At the hospital, she could not immediately recognize her own son lying on a bed in the emergency room. His brown eyes were swollen shut, and his straight brown hair was matted with blood that had poured from a deep gash in his forehead.
- 44 While she was staring at his battered face, a police officer rushed into the room and pushed her onto the floor—protection against the hysterical father of a dead youth who was racing through the halls, proclaiming that he had a gun and shouting, “Where is she? I’m going to kill her. I’m going to kill him. I’m going to kill his mother.”
- 45 The man, who did not have a gun, was subdued by a Warminster police officer and was not charged.
- 46 Amid the commotion, Robert Baxter, a Lower Southampton highway patrol officer, arrived at the hospital and found his wife and son.
- 47 “When he came into the room, he kept going like this,” Patricia Baxter said, holding up four fingers. At first, she said, she did not understand that her husband was signaling that four boys had been killed in the accident.
- 48 After Tyson regained consciousness, his father told him about the deaths.
- 49 “All I can remember is just tensing up and just saying something,” Tyson Baxter said. “I can remember saying, ‘I know.’”
- 50 “I can remember going nuts.”
- 51 In the days after the accident, as the dead were buried in services that Tyson Baxter was barred by the parents of the victims from attending, Baxter’s parents waited for him to react to the tragedy and release his grief.
- 52 “In the hospital he was nonresponsive,” Patricia Baxter said. “He was home for a month, and he was nonresponsive.”

756

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- 53 “We never used to do this, but we would be upstairs and listen to see if Ty responded when his friends came to visit,” she said. “But the boy would be silent. That’s the grief that I felt. The other kids showed a reaction. My son didn’t.”
- 54 Baxter said, however, that he felt grief from the first, that he would cry in the quiet darkness of his hospital room and, later, alone in the darkness of his bedroom. During the day, he said, he blocked his emotions.
- 55 “It was *just* at night. I thought about it all the time. It’s still like that.”
- 56 At his parents’ urging, Baxter returned to school on September 30.
- 57 “I don’t remember a thing,” he said of his return. “I just remember walking around. I didn’t say anything to anybody. It didn’t really sink in.”
- 58 Lynne Pancoast, the mother of Chris Avram, thought it was wrong for Baxter to be in school, and wrong that her other son, Joel, a junior at William Tennent, had to walk through the school halls and pass the boy who “killed his brother.”
- 59 Morris Ball said he was appalled that Baxter “went to a football game while my son lay buried in a grave.”
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- 60 Some William Tennent students said they were uncertain about how they should treat Baxter. Several said they went out of their way to treat him normally, others said they tried to avoid him, and others declined to be interviewed on the subject.
- 61 The tragedy unified the senior class, according to the school principal, Kenneth Kastle. He said that after the accident, many students who were friends of the victims joined the school’s Students Against Driving Drunk chapter.
- 62 Matthew Weintraub, seventeen, a basketball player who witnessed the bloody accident scene, wrote to President Reagan and detailed the grief among the student body. He said, however, that he experienced a catharsis after reading the letter at a student assembly and, as a result, did not mail it.
- 63 “And after we got over the initial shock of the news, we felt as though we owed somebody something,” Weintraub wrote. “It could have been us and maybe we could have stopped it, and now it’s too late. . . .
- 64 “We took these impressions with us as we then visited our friends who had been lucky enough to live. One of them was responsible for the accident; he was the driver. He would forever hold the deaths of four young men on his conscience. Compared with our own feelings of guilt, [we] could not begin to fathom this boy’s emotions. He looked as if he had a heavy weight upon his head and it would remain there forever.”
- 65 About three weeks after the accident, Senator H. Craig Lewis (D., Bucks) launched a series of public forums to formulate bills targeting underage drinking. Proposals developed through the meetings

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include outlawing alcohol ads on radio and television, requiring police to notify parents of underage drinkers, and creating a tamperproof driver’s license.

- 66 The parents of players on William Tennent’s 1985–1986 boys’ basketball team, which lost Ball and Baxter because of the accident, formed the Caring Parents of William Tennent High School Students to help dissuade students from drinking.
- 67 Several William Tennent students, interviewed on the condition that their names not be published, said that, because of the accident, they would not drive after drinking during senior week, which will be held in Wildwood, N.J., after graduation June 13.
- 68 But they scoffed at the suggestion that they curtail their drinking during the celebrations.
- 69 “We just walk [after driving to Wildwood],” said one youth. “Stagger is more like it.”
- 70 “What else are we going to do, go out roller skating?” an eighteen-year-old student asked.
- 71 “You telling us we’re not going to drink?” one boy asked. “We’re going to drink very heavily. I want to come home retarded. That’s senior week. I’m going to drink every day. Everybody’s going to drink every day.”
- 72 Tyson Baxter sat at the front table of the Bucks County courtroom on December 20, his arm in a sling, his head lowered, and his eyes dry. He faced twenty counts of vehicular homicide, four counts of involuntary manslaughter, and two counts of driving under the influence of alcohol.
- 73 Patricia Ball said she told the closed hearing that “it was Tyson Baxter who killed our son. They used the car as a weapon. We know they killed our children as if it were a gun. They killed our son.
- 74 “I really could have felt justice [was served] if Tyson Baxter was the only one who died in that car,” she said in an interview, “because he didn’t take care of our boys.”
- 75 Police officers testified before Bucks County President Judge Isaac S. Garb that tests revealed that the blood-alcohol levels of Baxter and the four dead boys were above the 0.10 percent limit used in Pennsylvania to establish intoxication.
- 76 Baxter’s blood-alcohol level was 0.14 percent, Ball’s 0.19 percent, Schweiss’s 0.11 percent, Avram’s 0.12 percent, and Freedenberg’s 0.38 percent. Baxter’s level indicated that he had had eight or nine drinks—enough to cause abnormal bodily functions such as exaggerated gestures and to impair his mental faculties, according to the police report.
- 77 After the case was presented, Garb invited family members of the dead teens to speak.
- 78 In a nine-page statement, Bobbi Freedenberg urged Garb to render a decision that would “punish, rehabilitate, and deter others from this act.”
- 79 The parents asked Garb to give Baxter the maximum sentence, to prohibit him from graduating, and to incarcerate him before Christmas Day. (Although he will not attend formal ceremonies, Baxter will receive a diploma from William Tennent this week.)

758
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- 80 After hearing from the parents, Garb called Baxter to the stand.
- 81 “I just said that all I could say was, ‘I’m sorry; I know I’m totally responsible for what happened,’” Baxter recalled. “It wasn’t long, but it was to the point.”
- 82 Garb found Baxter delinquent and sentenced him to a stay at Abraxas Rehabilitation Center—for an unspecified period beginning December 23—and community service upon his return. Baxter’s driver’s license was suspended by the judge for an unspecified period, and he was placed under Garb’s jurisdiction until age twenty-one.
- 83 Baxter is one of fifty-two Pennsylvania youths found responsible for fatal drunken-driving accidents in the state in 1985.
- 84 Reflecting on the hearing, Morris Ball said there was no legal punishment that would have satisfied his longings.
- 85 “They can’t bring my son back,” he said, “and they can’t kill Tyson Baxter.”
- 86 Grief has forged friendships among the dead boys’ parents, all of whom blame Tyson Baxter for their sons’ deaths. Every month they meet at each other’s homes, but they seldom talk about the accident.
- 87 Several have joined support groups to help them deal with their losses. Some said they feel comfortable only with other parents whose children are dead.
- 88 Bobbi Freedenberg said her attitude had worsened with the passage of time. “It seems as if it just gets harder,” she said. “It seems to get worse.”
- 89 Freedenberg, Schweiss, and Pancoast said they talk publicly about their sons’ deaths in hopes that the experience will help deter other teenagers from drunken driving.
- 90 Schweiss speaks each month to the Warminster Youth Aid Panel—a group of teenagers who, through drug use, alcohol abuse, or minor offenses, have run afoul of the law.
- 91 “When I talk to the teens, I bring a picture of Robbie and pass it along to everyone,” Schweiss said, wiping the tears from his cheeks. “I say, ‘He was with us last year.’ I get emotional and I cry. . . .
- 92 “But I know that my son helps me. I firmly believe that every time I speak, he’s right on my shoulder.”
- 93 When Pancoast speaks to a group of area high school students, she drapes her son’s football jersey over the podium and displays his graduation picture.
- 94 “Every time I speak to a group, I make them go through the whole thing vicariously,” Pancoast said. “It’s helpful to get out and talk to kids. It sort of helps keep Chris alive. . . . When you talk, you don’t think.”
- 95 At Abraxas, Baxter attended high school classes until Friday. He is one of three youths there who supervise fellow residents, who keep track of residents’ whereabouts, attendance at programs, and adherence to the center’s rules and regulations.

759

760

- 96 Established in Pittsburgh in 1973, the Abraxas Foundation provides an alternative to imprisonment for offenders between sixteen and twenty-five years old whose drug and alcohol use has led them to commit crimes.
- 97 Licensed and partially subsidized by the Pennsylvania Department of Health, the program includes work experience, high school education, and prevocational training. Counselors conduct individual therapy sessions, and the residents engage in peer-group confrontational therapy sessions.
- 98 Baxter said his personality had changed from an “egotistical, arrogant” teenager to someone who is “mellow” and mature.
- 99 “I don’t have quite the chip on my shoulder. I don’t really have a right to be cocky anymore,” he said.
- 100 Baxter said not a day went by that he didn’t remember his dead friends.
- 101 “I don’t get sad. I just get thinking about them,” he said. “Pictures pop into my mind. A tree or something reminds me of the time. . . . Sometimes I laugh. . . . Then I go to my room and reevaluate it like a nut,” he said.
- 102 Baxter said his deepest longing was to stand beside the graves of his four friends.
- 103 More than anything, Baxter said, he wants to say good-bye.
- 104 “I just feel it’s something I *have* to do, . . . just to talk,” Baxter said, averting his eyes to hide welling tears. “Deep down I think I’ll be hit with it when I see the graves. I know they’re gone, but they’re not gone.”

760

761

READING COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS



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1. The word *fathom* in “Compared with our own feelings of guilt, [we] could not begin to fathom this boy’s emotions” (paragraph 64) means
 - a. choose.
 - b. understand.
 - c. mistake.
 - d. protest.
2. The word *dissuade* in “The parents . . . formed the Caring Parents of William Tennent High School Students to help dissuade students from drinking” (paragraph 66) means

- a. discourage.
 - b. delay.
 - c. organize.
 - d. frighten.
3. Which of the following would be the best alternative title for this selection?
- a. The Night of September 13
 - b. A Fatal Mistake: Teenage Drinking and Driving
 - c. The Agony of Parents
 - d. High School Drinking Problems
4. Which sentence best expresses the main idea of the selection?
- a. Teenagers must understand the dangers and consequences of drinking and driving.
 - b. Tyson Baxter was too drunk to drive that night.
 - c. The Abraxas Foundation is a model alternative program to imprisonment for teenagers.
 - d. Teenagers are drinking more than ever before.
5. The hospital had trouble identifying the boys because
- a. officials could not find their families.
 - b. the boys all had false licenses and some of their bodies were mutilated.
 - c. there weren't enough staff members on duty at the hospital that night.
 - d. everyone was withholding information.
6. Tyson Baxter feels that
- a. the judge's sentence was unfair.
 - b. he will never graduate from high school.
 - c. he is responsible for the whole accident.
 - d. he should not be blamed for the accident.
7. *True or false?* _____ Because of the accident, all the seniors promised that they would not drink during senior week.
8. The authors imply that the parents of the dead boys felt that

761

762

- a. Tyson should not be punished.
 - b. their boys shared no blame for the accident.
 - c. Tyson should have come to the boys' funerals.
 - d. Tyson should be allowed to attend graduation.
9. The authors imply that most of the parents' anger has been toward
- a. school officials.
 - b. Senator H. Craig Lewis.
 - c. their local police.
 - d. Tyson Baxter.
10. The authors imply that Tyson
- a. behaved normally after the accident.
 - b. will always have a problem with alcohol.
 - c. no longer thinks about his dead friends.
 - d. is benefiting from his time at Abraxas.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

About Content

- 1. Why do the authors call their narrative "a story of the times"?
- 2. Exactly why did four teenagers die in the accident? To what extent were their deaths the driver's fault? Their own fault? Society's fault?
- 3. What effect has the accident had on other Tennent students? In view of the tragedy, can you explain the reluctance of the Tennent students to give up drinking during "senior week"?
- 4. How would you describe the attitude of Tyson Baxter after the accident? How would you characterize the attitude of the parents? Whose attitude, if any, seems more appropriate under the circumstances?

About Structure

- 5. The lead paragraphs in a newspaper article such as this one are supposed to answer questions known as the *five W's*: who, what, where, when, and why.

Which paragraphs in the article answer these questions? _____

- 6. The authors *do not* use transitional words to move from one section of their article to the next. How, then, do they manage to keep their narrative organized and clear?

About Style and Tone

- 7. Why do the authors use so many direct quotations in their account of the accident? How do these quotations add to the effectiveness of the article?
- 8. What seems to be the authors’ attitude toward Tyson Baxter at the end of the piece? Why do you think they end with Tyson’s desire to visit his dead friends’ graves? What would have been the effect of ending with Lynne Pancoast’s words in paragraph 94?

WRITING ASSIGNMENTS



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Assignment 1: Writing a Paragraph

While drunk drivers are of all ages, a large percentage of them are young. Write a paragraph explaining what you think would be one or more *effective* ways of dramatizing to young people the dangers of drunk driving. Keep in mind that the young are being cautioned all the time, and that some of the warnings are so familiar that they probably don’t have any impact.

What kind of caution or cautions would make young people take notice? Develop one approach in great detail or suggest several approaches for demonstrating the dangers of drunk driving to the young.

Assignment 2: Writing a Paragraph

Tyson Baxter’s friends might still be alive if he had not been drunk when he drove. But there is another way their deaths could have been avoided—they might have refused to get into the car. Such a refusal would not have been easy; one does not, after all, want to embarrass a person who has given you a ride to some event. At the same time, it may be absolutely necessary to make such a refusal. In groups of two or three, discuss various ways to turn down a ride from a driver who may be drunk. Then write a paragraph suggesting one or more strategies.



Assignment 3: Writing an Essay

A number of letters to the editor followed the appearance of “A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath.” Here are some of them:

To the Editor:

I am deeply concerned by the June 8 article, “A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath,” not because of the tragedy it unfolds, but because of the tragedy that is occurring as a result.

It is an injustice on the part of the parents whose children died to blame Tyson Baxter so vehemently for those deaths. (I lost my best friend in a similar accident eight years ago, and I haven’t forgotten the pain or the need to blame.) All the youths were legally intoxicated. None of them refused to go with Mr. Baxter, and I submit that he did not force them to ride with him.

Yes, Mr. Baxter is guilty of drunk driving, but I would like the other parents to replace Mr. Baxter with their sons and their cars and ask themselves again where the blame lies.

Tyson Baxter did not have the intent to kill, and his car was not the weapon. All these boys were Mr. Baxter’s friends. The weapon used to kill them was alcohol, and in a way each boy used it on himself.

If we are to assign blame, it goes far beyond one drunk eighteen-year-old.

The answer lies in our society and its laws—laws about drinking and driving, and laws of parenting, friendship, and responsibility. Why, for instance, didn’t the other youths call someone to come get them, or call a taxi, rather than choose to take that fatal ride?

These parents should be angry and they should fight against drunk driving by making people aware. But they shouldn’t continue to destroy the life of one boy whose punishment is the fact that he survived.

Elizabeth Bowen
Philadelphia

To the Editor:

I could not believe the attitude of the parents of the boys who were killed in the accident described in the June 8 article “A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath.” Would they really feel that justice was done if Tyson Baxter were dead, too?

Tyson Baxter is not the only guilty person. All the boys who got into the vehicle were guilty, as well as all the kids at the party who let them go. Did any of the parents question their children earlier that fateful night as to who would be the “designated driver” (or did they think their sons would never go out drinking)?

How would those parents feel if their son happened to be the one behind the wheel?

I do not want to lessen the fact that Tyson Baxter was guilty (a guilt he readily admits to and will carry with him for a lifetime). However, should he have to carry his own guilt and be burdened with everyone else's guilt as well?

Andrea D. Colanti

Philadelphia 764

To the Editor:

Reading the June 8 article about the tragic aftermath of the drunken-driving accident in which high school students were killed and injured, I was aware of a major missing element. That element is the role of individual responsibility.

While we cannot control everything that happens to us, we can still manage many of the events of our lives. Individual responsibility operates at two levels. First is the accountability each person has for his own actions. To drink, or not to drink. To drink to excess, or to remain sober. To ride with someone who has been drinking, or to find another ride.

Second is the responsibility to confront those who are drinking or using drugs and planning to drive. To talk to them about their alcohol or drug consumption, to take their keys, call a cab, or do whatever else a friend would do.

The toughest, most punitive laws will not prevent people from drinking and driving, nor will they rectify the results of an accident. The only things we can actually control are our personal choices and our responses.

Don't drink and drive. Don't ride with those that do. Use your resources to stop those who try.

Gregory A. Gast

Willow Grove

To the Editor:

After reading the June 8 article about the tragic accident involving the students from William Tennent High School, my heart goes out to the parents of the boys who lost their lives. I know I can't begin to understand the loss they feel. However, even more so, my heart goes out to them for their inability to forgive the driver and their ability to wish him dead.

I certainly am not condoning drunk driving; in fact, I feel the law should be tougher.

But how can they be so quick to judge and hate this boy, when all their sons were also legally drunk, some more so than the driver, and any one of them could have easily been the driver himself? They all got into the car knowingly drunk and were noisily rocking the vehicle. They were all teenagers, out for a night of fun, never thinking of the consequences of drunk driving.

I would view this differently had the four dead boys been in another car, sober, and hit by a drunk driver. However, when you knowingly enter a car driven by someone who is drunk and are drunk yourself, you are responsible for what happens to you.

Tyson Baxter, the driver, needs rehabilitation and counseling. He will live with this for the rest of his life. The parents of the four boys who died need to learn about God, who is forgiving, and apply that forgiveness to a boy who desperately needs it. He could have easily been one of their sons.

Debbie Jones

Wilmington 765
766

These letters make apparent a difference of opinion about how severely Tyson Baxter should be punished. Write an essay in which, in an introductory paragraph, you advance your judgment about the appropriate punishment for Tyson Baxter. Then provide three supporting paragraphs in which you argue and defend your opinion. You may use or add to ideas stated in the article or the letters, but think through the ideas yourself and put them into your own words.

Assignment 4: Writing an Essay Using Internet Research

The tragic deaths of Tyson Baxter’s four friends highlight the problem of drinking and driving. What can be done to get drunken drivers off the road? Use the Internet to research the topic. Then write an essay that explains three ways to get intoxicated drivers off the road. These could include ways to prevent people from drinking and driving in the first place, or ways to keep a person convicted of drunken driving from doing it again.

To begin your research, use the very helpful search engine Google (www.google.com). Try one of the following phrases or some related phrase:

- keeping drunk drivers off the road
- drunk drivers and prevention
- successful prevention programs for drunk driving

As you proceed, you’ll develop a sense of how to “track down” and focus a topic by adding more information to your search words and phrases.

* Reference to a film comedy about a group of American tourists who visited too many European countries in too little time.

Back Matter

[APPENDIXES](#)

[Appendix A: Answers and Charts](#)

[Appendix B: A Writer's Journal](#)

[Credits](#)

[INDEX](#)

APPENDIXES

[Appendix A: Answers and Charts](#)

[Appendix B: A Writer's Journal](#)

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INDEX

A

- A/an*, 571
 with count nouns, 583
 ESL tips for using, 581–584
- Abbreviations, rules for using, 511–512
- Accent marks in dictionaries, 550
- Accept/except*, 571
- Accepting tone, 167–168
- Active thinking, 11
- Active verbs, revising for, 29
- Added-detail fragments, 422–424
- Addition words, identifying, 98–99, 101–102
- Addresses, commas with, 537
- Adequate details, importance of, 60–62
- Adjectives. *See also* Adverbs
 for comparisons, 483–485
 defined, 483
 diagnostic test, 402
 ESL tips, 589–591
 mistakes with, 486
 as noun markers, 581
 series, placing in, 120–122, 590
- Advanced writing assignments, 314–323
- Adverbial conjunctions, 437–438
- Adverbs
 defined, 485
 diagnostic test, 402
 mistakes with, 486
- Advice/advise*, 571
- Affect/effect*, 571
- Agreement. *See* Pronoun agreement;
 Subject-verb agreement
- “All Good Things” (Mrosła), 628–634
- All ready/already*, 566
- Amazon.com, 366
- The American Heritage Dictionary*, 546
- Among/between*, 571
- Anecdotes in introductions, 331–332
- Announcement in topic sentence, 63
- Another*, 87
- Antecedent of pronoun, 471
- Antonyms in dictionaries, 548
- “Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name” (Collier), 686–693
- Anyone*, 109
- AOL (America OnLine), 366
- Apostrophes, 514–522
 in contractions, 515–516
 diagnostic test, 402
 editing sentences for, 122
 introductory activity, 514
 ownership or possession, showing, 516–521
 plurals *versus*, 518–521
 possessive pronouns and, 480, 518
 -s, plural words ending in, 520–521
 sentence-skills achievement test, 619
- Archaic usage, 553
- Argument, 174, 298–312
 prewriting argument paragraph, 303–304, 306–307, 309–310
 revising argument paragraph, 304–305, 307–309, 310–311
 tips on, 175
 writing guide for, 305–312
- Articles
 capital letters for titles of, 504
 with count/noncount nouns, 582–583
 ESL tips for using, 581–584
 omitting articles, 583
 quotation marks for titles of, 527
- As, subject pronouns after, 478
- Associations. *See* Organizations and associations
- Attitudes on writing, 5, 11–13
- Audience
 for argument paragraph, 312

Audience—*Cont.*

- for cause-and-effect paragraph, 220, 241
 for definition paragraph, 253
 for descriptive paragraph, 283
 development of paragraph and, 167–168
 for division and classification paragraph, 267
 for examples paragraph, 188
 for narrative paragraph, 297
 for process paragraph, 206
 tone and, 168–169
- Authors, finding books by, 360

B

- Backing up computer work, 169–170
- Balanced sentences, 106–107
- Barnes and Noble books, 366
- Bases for writing. *See also* Coherence; Sentence skills; Support; Unity
 all bases, evaluating paragraph for, 161–163
 for essays, 345–347
 summary of, 148
- Basic word list, 557–561
- Beside/besides*, 572
- Between/among*, 571
- Be* verbs, 450
 subject pronouns with, 478
- Bibliography entries, 383–386
- Bitter tone, 167–168
- body* words, 472
 singular verbs with, 467
- Books. *See also* Libraries
 capital letters for titles of, 504
 Internet, finding books on, 366–368
 italicizing titles, 528
 numerals for parts of, 510
 underlining titles of, 527
- Book stacks, 362–363
- Brainstorming, 22–23
- Break/brake*, 566

- Broad statements
 in introductions, 331
 in topic sentences, 63
 Browsing Internet, 367
- C**
- Call numbers, 360, 362
 Canedy, Dana, "From Father to Son, Last Words to Live by," 747–753
 Capital letters
 combined mastery tests, 599–600
 diagnostic test, 402
 editing sentences for, 122
 ellipsis with, 379
 introductory activity, 501
 main uses of, 502
 run-ons, correcting, 432–434
 sentence-skills achievement test, 619
 unnecessary uses of, 508
 Carson, Ben, "Do It Better!" 676–686
 Cartoons, point and support in, 6–8
 Catalogs, 359–360
 of Library of Congress, 367
 periodicals, lists of, 363
 Cause and effect, 174, 207–220
 prewriting, development through, 210–212, 214–215, 216–217, 230–232, 233–235, 237–238
 revising paragraph, 212–213, 215, 218, 232, 235, 238–240
 Change-of-direction transitions
 identifying, 99–102
 signals, 90, 91
 Childhood place writing
 assignment, 319
 Classification. *See* Division and classification
 Clichés, 577–578
 editing sentences for, 122
 list of, 577
 revising for, 29
 Closed stacks, libraries with, 362–363
 Club names, capital letters for, 503
 Clustering
 in freewriting, 23–24
 student model, 24
Coarse/course, 566
 Coherence, 138
 in argument paragraph, 302, 308, 310
 in cause-and-effect paragraph, 210, 215, 218, 230, 236, 239
 definition and, 245, 249, 251
 in descriptive paragraph, 272
 in division and classification paragraph, 257, 263, 265
 essays, revising, 345–347
 evaluating paragraphs for, 156–161
 examples and, 179–180, 188
 in narrative paragraph, 288, 294
 in process paragraph, 194, 201
 summary of, 148
 understanding, 142–144
 Collier, James Lincoln, "Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name," 686–693
 Colons, 541
 editing sentences for, 122
 in formal letters, 537
 Combined mastery tests, 595–602
 Comfort writing assignment, 319
 Commas, 531–539
 between complete thoughts, 535–536
 in coordinating sentences, 116–117
 with dependent-word groups, 417
 diagnostic test, 402
 with direct quotations, 536–537
 double verb and one subject, sentences with, 535
 editing sentences for, 122
 with everyday material, 537–538
 final comma in series, use of, 532
 flow of thought, words interrupting, 534–535
 introductory activity, 531
 after introductory material, 533
 with persons spoken to, 537
 with quotation marks, 524
 run-ons, correcting, 435–436
 sentence-skills achievement test, 620
 series, separating items in, 532–533
 in subordinating sentences, 118
 Comma splices, 431
 periods/capital letters, correcting with, 433–434
 Comments in peer review, 173
 Commercial product names, capital letters for, 503
 Commonly confused words, 565–574
 diagnostic test, 402–404
 homonyms, 566–570
 introductory activity, 565
 mastering, 557
 sentence-skills achievement test, 620
 Community dialects. *See* Dialects
 Company names, capital letters for, 503
 Compare and contrast, 174, 221–241
 adjectives for comparisons, 483–485
 agreement with, 484–485
 in introductions, 331
 methods for development, 224–227
 one-side-at-a-time development, 224–225
 point-by-point development, 225
 Complete thoughts, commas between, 535–536
 Complex sentences, subordination in, 117–119
 Compound sentences, coordination in, 116–117
 Compound subjects
 subject pronouns and, 478
 subject-verb agreement and, 466
 Computers. *See also* Internet
 editing computer work, 171–172
 first drafts, writing, 171
 prewriting on, 170
 proofreading work on, 171–172
 revising on, 171
 tips on using, 167–172
 Concentration and reading, 625
 Concise words, 113–115
 review tests, 130–131
 Conclusions
 in essays, 334
 for research papers, 381

- Conclusion transitions
 identifying, 101–102
 signals, 90, 91–92
- Connecting words. *See also* Transitions
 identifying, 102–104
 pronouns as, 93
 repeated words, 92
 synonyms as, 93
- Conroy, Theresa, “A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath,” 753–766
- Consistency
 diagnostic test, 401
 editing sentences for, 122
 with number series, 510
 with pronouns, 109–111
 sentence skills achievement test, 617
 with verbs, 108–109
- Consonants, doubling final, 556–557
- Content, revising for, 28–29
- Contractions, apostrophes in, 515–516
- Coordination, 116–117
 review tests, 132–136
- Coping writing assignment, 320
- Correspondence. *See* Letters and correspondence
- Count/noncount nouns, 582–583
 a/an with, 583
 list of, 582
- Curran, Delores, “What Good Families Are Doing Right,” 662–675
- D**
- Dangling modifiers
 defined, 490–493
 diagnostic test, 402
 introductory project, 488
 sentence-skills achievement test, 618
- Dashes, 542
 editing sentences for, 122
- Dates
 commas with, 537
 numerals for, 510
- Dead-end statements, 63
- “Dealing with Feelings” (Verderber), 711–718
- Decision essay assignment, 350–351
- Definition, 242–253
 prewriting for developing, 245–247, 248–249, 250–251
 revising and, 247–248, 249–250, 251–253
- Demonstrative pronouns, 480–481
- Dependent clauses, 117
 in run-ons, 431
- Dependent statements, 415–416
- Dependent words
 correcting fragments, 416–418
 fragments, 415–419
 lists of, 117, 415, 439
- Description, 174, 268–283
 prewriting descriptive paragraph, 272–274, 275–277, 279–280
 revising descriptive paragraph, 274–275, 278–279, 280–283
 spatial order organization, 277
 writing guide for, 275–283
- Desert/dessert*, 572
- Details, 6, 8, 50–51
 adequate details, importance of, 60–62
 in list-making, 22–23
 logical support with, 75–76
 paragraphs, adding to, 78–79
 in readings, 627
 specific details, 73–75
 importance of, 56–59
 recognizing, 71–75
 supporting points, 6, 8, 50–51
 unity of, 140
- Development
 of essay, 328
 paragraph development, 167–175
- Dewey decimal system, 363
- Diagramming, 23–24
- Dialects, 446
 irregular verbs and, 449–453
- Dialog*, 365
- Dialog writing assignment, 316–317
- Dictionaries
 benefits of owning, 546–547
 computer dictionaries, 547–548
 for editing help, 123
 entries, understanding, 548–554
- Dictionaries—*Cont.*
 full pronunciation
 information, 551
 improving spelling with, 555
 irregular verbs, information on, 551–552
 meanings in, 552–553
 parts of speech information, 551
 personal spelling lists, 555–556
 pronunciation information, 549–550
 spelling information, 548–549
 syllabication information, 549
 synonyms in, 548, 553–554
 usage labels, 553
- Dictionary.com, 547
- Direct quotations, 379
 commas with, 536–537
- Discovery and writing, 13–14
- Division and classification, 254–267
 prewriting for, 259–260, 262–263, 264–265
 revising paragraphs, 260–261, 263–264, 265–267
 single principle of division, 255, 264
- Documentation of sources, 382–387
- “Do It Better!” (Carson, with Murphey), 676–686
- Don't/doesn't*, 451
- Double-spacing papers, 496
- Doubling final consonant, 556–557
- Do* verbs, 451
- “A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath” (Conroy and Johnson), 753–766
- E**
- E*, final silent, 556
- Earthlink, 366
- EBSCOhost*, 365, 368, 375
- Edited collections, citing selections in, 385
- Editing, 31–32
 computer work, 171–172
 sentences, 122–124
 student model, 31–32

- Editing—*Cont.*
 tests, 603–615
 tips for, 123, 603
- Editorial sources, citing, 384
- ed words as openers, 119
- Effect. *See* Cause and effect
- Effect/affect*, 571
- Effective word choice, 575–580
 diagnostic test, 402–404
 sentence-skills achievement test, 620
- Elibrary, 368
- Ellipsis with direct quotations, 379
- E-mail postings, citing, 386
- Emotions in narrative
 paragraph, 290
- Emphatic order, 84–86
 and coherence, 144
 practice with, 96–97
 time and emphatic order, combination of, 97–98
- English as a second language (ESL)
 tips, 581–593
- Entertainment, development of
 paragraph for, 167
- ESL (English as a second language)
 adjectives, 589–591
 gerunds and infinitives, 586–589
 prepositions, 592
 subject and verb tips, 585–589
 tips, 581–593
- Essays, 324–354. *See also*
 Introductions; Thesis sentences
 bases of writing, revising for, 345–347
 concluding paragraphs, 334
 diagram of form of, 327–328
 forms for planning, 340
 model essay, 329–330
 outlines for, 339–340
 paragraphs compared, 327
 revising for bases of writing, 345–347
 scratch outlines for, 339–340
 supporting paragraphs, 333
 transitional sentences, 333–334
 writing assignments, 347–354
- Evidence. *See also* Organization
 adequate evidence, identifying, 76–78
 for Internet resources, 370
 logical support, evidence providing, 73–75
 points, supporting, 49–51
 thesis sentences, support for, 342–343
- Examples, 174, 176–190
 in paragraphs, 9
 prewriting, development through, 180–181, 184
 revising, developing in, 182–183, 185–186
 support requiring, 142–143
 writing paragraphs using, 183–190
- Except/accept*, 571
- Exemplification. *See* Examples
- Explanations, colons in, 541
- Exposition, 174. *See also* Cause and effect; Examples; Process
- “‘Extra Large,’ Please” (Urbina), 718–725
- F**
- Family relationship names, capital letters for, 505–506
- Fewer/less*, 572
- Films. *See* Movies
- Final silent *e*, 556
- First drafts, 26–27
 computers, working on, 171
 revising, 28–29
 student model, 26–27
- First-person pronouns, 109
- First sentences of papers, 497
- “The Fist, the Clay, and the Rock” (Holland), 657–662
- Flow of thought, commas around words interrupting, 534–535
- Format for paper, 496–500
- Fragments
 added-detail fragments, 422–424
 checking for, 426
 combined mastery tests, 595–596
- Fragments—*Cont.*
 defined, 415
 dependent-word fragments, 415–419
 diagnostic test, 400
 editing sentences for, 122
 -ing words and, 419–422
 introductory activity, 414
 missing-subject fragments, 424–426
 sentence-skills achievement test, 616–617
 with *to* words, 419–422
- Freewriting, 19–21
 clustering, 23–24
 list-making, 22–23
 questioning, 21–22
 scratch outlines, 24–26
 student model of, 19–21
- “From Father to Son, Last Words to Live by” (Canedy), 747–753
- Fused sentences, 431
 periods/capital letters, correcting with, 432–433
- G**
- Garland, Anita, “Let’s Really Reform Our Schools,” 693–701
- Geographic locations, capital letters for, 506
- Gerunds. *See also* -ing words
 ESL tips, 586–589
- Good*, 486–487
- Google, 368–369, 376
- Grammar
 editing for, 31
 in freewriting, 19–21
 handbook for editing help, 123
- H**
- Handwritten papers, 496
- Have* verbs, 450
- Hear/here*, 566
 ESL tips, 585
- Heroes essay assignment, 354
- High school memory essay assignment, 352

Historical periods/events, capital letters for, 506
Hole/whole, 567
 Holidays, capital letters for, 503
 Holland, Donald, "The Fist, the Clay, and the Rock," 657–662
 Homonyms, 566–570
 Hopeful tone, 167–168
 House/apartment essay
 assignment, 348
 "How They Get You to Do That" (Scott), 701–710
 Humorous tone, 167–168
 Hyphens, 542–543
 editing sentences for, 122
 words, hyphenating, 497

I
 Identification for peer review, 172
 Illustration transitions
 identifying, 101–102
 signals, 90, 91
 Important person writing
 assignment, 319
In addition, 87
 Indefinite pronouns
 agreement with, 472–473
 verbs with, 467
 Indentation in papers, 496
 Independent clauses, 117
 in run-ons, 431
 Indirect quotations, 526–527
 Inferences in readings, 627
 Infinitives
 ESL tips for, 586–589
 verbs plus, 587–588
 Influences essay assignment, 350
 Influential people essay
 assignment, 354
 Informal usage, 553
 Information, development of
 paragraph for, 167
InfoTrac, 365, 368
 -ing words
 ESL tips, 586–589
 fragments with, 419–422
 as openers, 119
 as verbs, 409

Internet
 articles, finding, 368–369
 bookmarks, 369
 books on topic, finding, 366–368
 browsing, 367
 citing articles on, 386
 e-mail postings, citing, 386
 evaluating sources on, 369–371
 favorite places on, 369
 Library of Congress Web site, 367
 practice in using, 371–373
 printing information from, 368
 reliability of resources, 370
 search box, using, 367
 search engines, 368–369
 topics, researching, 375–377
 Web addresses, 370
 working with, 366–371
 Internet Explorer, 369
 Interview writing assignment, 315–316
 Introductions, 328, 330–333
 common methods, 331–333
 identifying, 343–344
 to research papers, 381
 Introductory material, commas
 after, 533
 Irregular verbs
 diagnostic test, 401
 dialect forms of, 449–453
 dictionary information, 551–552
 introductory project, 454
 list of, 455–458
 Italicizing titles, 528
Its/it's, 567

J
 "Joe Davis: A Cool Man" (Johnson), 649–657
 Johnson, Beth, "Joe Davis: A Cool Man," 649–657
 Johnson, Christine M., "A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath," 753–766
 Joining words
 in coordinating sentences, 116–117
 run-ons, correcting, 435–436
 Journals, 14–15
 writing assignment, 316–317

K
 Keywords
 in essays, 333–334
 in topic sentences, 65–66
 King, Charles Monroe, 747
Knew/new, 567
Know/no, 567
L
 Language, capital letters for, 506
Less/fewer, 572
Less/least comparisons, 484
 "Let's Really Reform Our Schools" (Garland), 693–701
 Letters and correspondence
 capital letters for openings/closings, 507
 commas with openings/closings, 537
 Libraries. *See also* Catalogs
 authors, finding books by, 360
 book stacks, 362–363
 call numbers, 360, 362
 with closed stacks, 362–363
 Dewey decimal system, 363
 Library of Congress
 system, 363
 main desk of, 359
 periodicals in, 363–365
 practice in using, 371–373
 subject headings, using, 361–362
 subjects, finding books by, 360
 titles, finding books by, 360
 Library of Congress
 system, 363
 Web site, 367
 Line spacing for papers, 496
 Linking verbs, ESL tips for, 585
 Links, 366
 Lists
 colons in, 541
 in freewriting, 22–23
 Logan, Paul, "Rowing the Bus," 634–641
Loose/lose, 572
 -ly words. *See also* Adverbs
 as openers, 119

M

Magazines and periodicals
 capital letters for titles of, 504
 indexes, periodical, 363
 italicizing titles, 528
 in libraries, 363–365
 online magazines, 368, 386
 quotation marks for titles of
 articles in, 527
 underlining titles of, 527
 vocabulary, development of, 562
 Works Cited entries for articles
 in, 384, 386

Main desk of library, 359

Main ideas in readings, 627

Mapping, 23–24

Margins, 496

Matter-of-fact tone, 167–168

Merriam-Webster Collegiate Dictionary, 546

merriam-webster.com, 547

Misplaced modifiers
 defined, 489–490
 diagnostic test, 402
 introductory activity, 488
 sentence-skills achievement
 test, 618

Missing-subject fragments, 424–426

Mistake essay assignment, 348

Modems, 366

Modern Language Association
 (MLA) style, 382–387

Modifiers. *See also* Dangling
 modifiers; Misplaced modifiers
 defined, 489–490
 editing sentences for, 122

Month names, capital letters
 for, 503

More with adjectives, 483–484

“The Most Hateful Words” (Tan),
 726–731

Most with adjectives, 483–484

Movies
 capital letters for titles of, 504
 quotation marks for titles of, 527

Mroska, Helen, “All Good Things,”
 628–634

Munro, H. H. (“Saki”), “The
 Storyteller,” 732–739

Murphey, Cecil, “Do It Better!”,
 676–686

N

Names. *See* Proper nouns

Narration, 174, 284–297
 prewriting narrative paragraph,
 288–289, 291, 293
 rewriting narrative paragraph,
 290, 292–293, 294–296
 writing guide, 290–297

Narrow statements in topic
 sentences, 63

Nations/nationalities, capital letters
 for, 507

New/knew, 567

Newspapers
 capital letters for titles of, 504
 italicizing titles, 528
 online articles, 368
 quotation marks for titles of
 articles in, 527
 underlining titles of, 527
 vocabulary, development of, 562
 Works Cited entries for articles
 in, 384

Newsweek magazine, 562

No/know, 567

Noncount nouns. *See* Count/
 noncount nouns

Nonessential information, commas
 around, 534

Nonstandard usage, 553

Notes for research papers, 379–380

Noun markers, 581

Nouns. *See also* Proper nouns
 count/noncount nouns, 582–583
 and infinitives, 588
 proper nouns, 584

Numbers and numerals
 commas in, 537
 noun markers, numerals as, 581
 rules for using, 510–511

O

Object pronouns, 477, 479–480

Obsolete usage, 553

One, 109

One-side-at-a-time development,
 224–225

-one words, 472

singular verbs with, 467

Optimistic tone, 167–168

Organization, 28–29. *See also*
 Emphatic order; Time order;
 Transitions
 outlining for, 36
 personal review for, 174

Organizations and associations
 abbreviations for, 511
 names, capital letters for, 503

Outlines
 activities, 36–43
 for essays, 339–340
 research papers, final outlines
 for, 381
 scratch outlines, 24–26

Ownership, apostrophes showing,
 516–521

P

Pair/pear, 567

Paper format, 496–500

Paragraphs. *See also* Support
 all four bases, evaluating for,
 161–163
 benefits of writing, 10
 coherence, evaluating and
 revising for, 156–161
 defined, 8
 details, adding, 78–79
 development of, 167–175
 essays compared, 327
 pattern of development, 174–175
 points in, 8–10
 simple paragraph assignment,
 80–82
 specific details in, 73–75
 tone in, 168–169
 unity, evaluating for, 150–153

Parallelism, 106–107
 diagnostic test, 402
 review tests, 125–128
 revising for, 29
 sentence-skills achievement
 test, 619

Paraphrasing in research papers, 379

- Parentheses, 543–544
 editing sentences for, 122
- Parents/children essay
 assignment, 353
- Passed/past*, 568
- Past participles
 as adjectives, 590–591
 irregular verbs, 455–458
 regular verbs, 455
- Past tense
 endings, 448–449
 irregular verbs, 455–458
 regular verbs, 455
- Patterns of development, 174–175
- Peace/piece*, 568
- Pear/pair*, 567
- Peer review, 172–173
- People* magazine, 562
- Percentages, numerals for, 510
- Periodicals. *See* Magazines and periodicals
- Periods
 with quotation marks, 524
 run-ons, correcting, 432–434
- Personal spelling lists, 555–556
- Persons' titles, capital letters
 for, 506
- Persuasion, development of
 paragraph for, 167
- Pet peeves writing assignment, 318
- Piece/peace*, 568
- Place names, capital letters for, 502–503
- Plagiarism, avoiding, 380–381
- Plain/plane*, 568
- Plays, quotation marks for titles
 of, 527
- Plurals
 apostrophes and, 518–521
 dictionary information
 on, 552
 subjects, plural, 464
- Poems, capital letters for titles
 of, 504
- Point-by-point development, 225
- Point of view
 diagnostic test, 401–402
 revising for, 29
 sentence-skills achievement
 test, 618
- Points, 5–10, 28–29. *See also*
 Details; Evidence; Support
 in cartoons, 6–8
 examples of, 53–56
 outlining for, 36
 in paragraphs, 8–10
 practice in making, 62–81
 reinforcing, 53–56
 specific evidence, support with,
 49–51
 starting with, 47–49
 umbrella idea, point as, 51–53
- Political group names, capital letters
 for, 503
- Possession, apostrophes showing,
 516–521
- Possessive nouns, 581
- Possessive pronouns, 480–481
 apostrophes *versus*, 518
- Prepositional phrases, 408
 as openers, 119
- Prepositions
 common prepositions, 408
 ESL tips, 592
 gerunds with, 587
 object pronouns with,
 479–480
- Present participles
 as adjectives, 590–591
 regular verbs, 455
- Present tense
 endings, 447–448
 irregular verbs, 455–458
 regular verbs, 455
- Pretentious words, 578–579
 editing sentences for, 122
 revising for, 29
- Prewriting, 18–26
 activity, 34–36
 argument paragraph, 303–304,
 306–307, 309–310
 for cause-and-effect paragraph,
 210–212, 214–215, 216–217,
 230–232, 233–235,
 237–238
 computers, working on, 170
 for definition, 245–247, 248–249,
 250–251
 descriptive paragraph, 272–274,
 275–277, 279–280
- Prewriting—*Cont.*
 for division and classification
 paragraph, 259–260,
 262–263, 264–265
 examples in, 180–181, 184
 freewriting, 19–21
 narrative paragraph, 288–289,
 291, 293, 294–296
 for process paragraph, 195–197,
 202–203
- Principle/principle*, 568
- Printing computer work, 169–170
- Process, 191–206
 assignments, 198–206
 developing process paragraph,
 195–198
 prewriting process paragraph,
 195–197, 202–203
 revising process paragraph,
 197–198, 204
- Procrastination, 11–12
- Product names, capital letters
 for, 503
- Progressive tense, tips for
 using, 586
- Pronoun agreement, 470–476
 diagnostic test for, 401–402
 introductory project, 470
 sentence-skills achievement
 test, 618
- Pronouns, 407. *See also* Indefinite
 pronouns; Possessive pronouns
 apostrophes and possessive
 pronouns, 518
 as connecting words, 93
 consistency with, 109–111
 defined, 471
 demonstrative pronouns,
 480–481
 diagnostic test, 401–402
 editing sentences for, 122
 ESL tips, 585
 identifying, 104
 object pronouns, 477, 479–480
 reference, 473–474
 sentence-skills achievement
 test, 618
 subject pronouns, 477–479
- Pronunciation information in
 dictionaries, 549–550

Proofreading, 31, 123–124
 computer work, 171–172
 symbols, 123

Proper nouns
 capital letters for, 502
the with, 584

Punctuation
 combined mastery tests, 599–600
 editing for, 31, 122
 introductory activity, 540

Purpose
 argument paragraph for, 312
 for cause-and-effect paragraph, 220, 241
 definition paragraph for, 253
 descriptive paragraph for, 283
 and development of paragraph, 167–169
 division and classification paragraph for, 267
 in examples paragraph, 188
 narrative paragraph for, 297
 in process paragraph, 206
 research paper purpose, limiting, 377–378

Q

Qualifiers, 582

Quality/habits writing
 assignment, 320

Quantity words, 581

Questions
 in introductions, 332
 in prewriting, 21–22

Quite/quite, 573

Quotation marks, 523–530
 diagnostic test, 402
 editing sentences for, 122
 for exact words of speaker/writer, 524–527
 indirect quotations and, 526–527
 introductory activity, 523
 sentence-skills achievement test, 619
 short works, titles of, 527–528
 single quotation marks, use of, 529
 special words/phrases, setting off, 529

Quotations. *See also* Direct quotations
 capital letters in, 502
 colons in, 541
 in introductions, 332–333
 in research papers, 379

R

Races, capital letters for, 507

The Random House Dictionary, 546

Rare usage, 553

Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature, 363–365, 375

Reading aloud
 fragments, checking for, 426
 for run-ons, 440
 for sentence sense, 411, 413

Readings
 “All Good Things” (Mroska), 628–634
 “Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name” (Collier), 686–693
 comprehension questions, hints for answering, 627
 concentration and, 625
 “Dealing with Feelings” (Verderber), 711–718
 “Do It Better!” (Carson, with Murphey), 676–686
 “A Drunken Ride, a Tragic Aftermath” (Conroy and Johnson), 753–766
 “‘Extra Large,’ Please” (Urbina), 718–725
 “The Fist, the Clay, and the Rock” (Holland), 657–662
 format for, 624–625
 “From Father to Son, Last Words to Live by” (Canedy), 747–753
 “How They Get You to Do That” (Scott), 701–710
 introduction to, 624–627
 “Joe Davis: A Cool Man” (Johnson), 649–657
 “Let’s Really Reform Our Schools” (Garland), 693–701

Readings—*Cont.*
 “The Most Hateful Words” (Tan), 726–731
 “Rowing the Bus” (Logan), 634–641
 “Rudeness at the Movies” (Wine), 740–746
 “The Scholarship Jacket” (Salinas), 642–648
 skimming material, 625–626
 steps for reading well, 625–626
 “The Storyteller” (Munro [“Saki”]), 732–739
 straight through reading, 626
 “What Good Families Are Doing Right” (Curran), 662–675
 working with materials, 626

Record albums, quotation marks for titles of, 527

Reference
 diagnostic test, 401–402
 pronoun reference, 473–474
 sentence-skills achievement test, 618

Reference database, citing article in, 386

Regular verbs. *See* Verbs

Reinforcing points and support, 53–56

Relevance in introductions, 331

Religious organization names, capital letters for, 503

Repeated words, 92
 identifying, 103

Repetition, undersupported points and, 60

Research papers, 374–397. *See also* Internet; Libraries
 acknowledging sources in, 381
 bibliography entries, 383–386
 documentation of sources, 382–387
 end-of-paper citations, 383
 final outlines for, 381
 gathering information for, 378
 in-paper citations, 382–383
 limiting topics, 377–378
 model paper, 388–397
 note-taking for, 379–380
 plagiarism, avoiding, 380–381

- Research papers—*Cont.*
 planning, 378–381
 purpose, limiting, 377–378
 scratch outlines for, 378–379
 specific terms,
 researching, 376
 topics for, 375–377
 Works Cited entries, 383–386
- Revising, 28–31
 activities for, 43–45
 argument paragraph, 304–305,
 307–309, 310–311
 cause-and-effect paragraph,
 212–213, 215, 218, 232, 235,
 238–240
 computers, working on, 171
 content, 28–29
 definition and, 247–248,
 249–250, 251–253
 descriptive paragraph, 274–275,
 278–279, 280–283
 division and classification
 paragraph, 260–261,
 263–264, 265–267
 examples, development of,
 182–183, 185–186
 process paragraph, 197–198, 204
 sentences, 29, 106–122
 student model for, 29–31
- Right/write*, 569
- RoadRunner, 366
- Rough drafts. *See* First drafts
- “Rowing the Bus” (Logan),
 634–641
- “Rudeness at the Movies” (Wine),
 740–746
- Run-ons, 430–444
 checking for, 440
 combined mastery tests, 595–596
 commas, correcting with,
 435–436
 correcting, 432–440
 defined, 431
 diagnostic test, 400
 editing sentences for, 122
 introductory project, 430
 joining words, correcting with,
 435–436
 semicolons, correcting with,
 436–438
- Run-ons—*Cont.*
 subordination, correcting with,
 439–440
 words leading to, 431
- S**
- Safari, 369
- Saki, (H. H. Munro) “The
 Storyteller,” 732–739
- Salinas, Marta, “The Scholarship
 Jacket,” 642–648
- Saving work on computers, 169
- “The Scholarship Jacket” (Salinas),
 642–648
- School courses, capital letters
 for, 506
- Schwa (ə) symbol, 550
- Scott, Janny, “How They Get You to
 Do That,” 701–710
- Scratch outlines, 24–26
 for descriptive paragraph, 277
 for essays, 339–340
 peer review of, 172–173
 for research papers, 378–379
 student model, 25–26
 unity, evaluating for, 149–150
- Search engines, 368–369
- Second-person pronouns, 109
- Semicolons, 541–542
 editing sentences for, 122
 run-ons, correcting, 436–438
- Sentences. *See also* Fragments; Run-
 ons; Thesis sentences; Topic
 sentences; Variety in sentences
 capital letters in, 502
 coordination in, 116–117
 editing, 122–124
 openers for, 119–120
 parallelism in, 106–107
 revising, 29, 106–122
 series, adjectives and verbs in,
 120–122
 special openers for, 119–120
 subordination in, 117–119
- Sentence sense, 411–413
- Sentence skills, 122, 138
 achievement test, 616–621
 in argument paragraph,
 308, 310
- Sentence skills—*Cont.*
 in cause-and-effect paragraph,
 215, 218, 236, 239
 definition and, 249, 251
 diagnostic test, 400–404
 in division and classification
 paragraph, 263, 265
 essays, revising, 345–347
 examples and, 188
 in narrative paragraph, 294
 personal review for, 174
 in process paragraph, 201
 summary of, 148
 understanding, 145–147
- Sentimental tone, 167–168
- Series
 adjectives and verbs in,
 120–122, 590
 commas separating items in,
 532–533
 numbers, consistency in series
 of, 510
- Sexual bias in pronouns, 473
- Short works, quotation marks for
 titles of, 527–528
- Simple paragraph assignment, 80–82
- Single life essay assignment, 349–350
- Single quotation marks, use of, 529
- Singular subjects, 464
- Skimming material, 625–626
- Slang, 576–577
 dictionary information, 553
 editing sentences for, 122
 revising for, 29
- Smile*, forms of, 408–409, 446
- Someone*, 109
- Songs, capital letters for titles of, 504
- Sophisticated sentences, creating, 115
- Sorting. *See* Division and
 classification
- Space signals, 90
- Spacing
 in computer work, 170
 line spacing for papers, 496
- Special openers for sentences,
 119–120
- Specific details. *See* Details
- Specific words, 111–113
 review tests, 128–130
 revising for, 29

- Spelling. *See also* Commonly confused words
 basic rules of, 556–557
 basic word list, 557–561
 computer work, spell-checking, 172
 dictionary entries, 548–549
 editing for, 31, 122
 student model of, 19–21
- Standard verbs. *See* Verbs
- Stories, capital letters for titles of, 504
- “The Storyteller” (Munro [“Saki”]), 732–739
- Strong commas, 436
- Subject matter
 finding books by, 360
 in readings, 627
- Subject pronouns, 477–479
- Subjects, 406. *See also* Subject-verb agreement
 and added-detail fragments, 422–424
 dangling modifiers and, 491
 double verb and one subject, sentences with, 535
 ESL tips, 585–589
 identifying, 406
 missing-subject fragments, 424–426
 repeated subjects, avoiding, 585
- Subject-verb agreement
 for compound subjects, 466
 diagnostic test, 401
 editing sentences for, 122
 with indefinite pronouns, 467
 introductory project, 463
 sentence-skills achievement test, 617
 before subject, verbs coming, 465
 words between subject and verb, 464–465
- Subordination
 with dangling modifiers, 491
 review tests, 132–136
 run-ons, correcting, 439–440
 in sentences, 117–119
- Summary of research paper notes, 380
- Support, 5–10, 138. *See also* Points in argument paragraph, 308, 310
- Support—*Cont.*
 in cause-and-effect paragraph, 210, 215, 218, 229, 236, 239
 definition and, 245, 249, 251
 in descriptive paragraph, 271
 in division and classification paragraph, 257, 263, 265
 essays, revising, 345–347
 evaluating paragraphs for, 153–156
 examples and, 179, 188
 in narrative paragraph, 288, 294
 personal review for, 174
 in process paragraph, 194, 201
 summary of, 148
 for thesis sentences, 342–343
 understanding, 140–142
- Syllables
 dictionaries, information in, 549
 doubling final consonant and, 556–557
 spelling and, 555
- Symbols in proofreading, 123
- Synonyms
 as connecting words, 93
 in dictionaries, 548, 553–554
 identifying, 103
- T**
- Talking and writing, 9
- Tan, Amy, “The Most Hateful Words,” 726–731
- Television shows
 capital letters for titles of, 504
 quotation marks for titles of, 527
 review essay assignment, 351–352
 writing assignment, 321
- Tenses. *See* Verbs
- Tests
 combined mastery tests, 595–602
 editing tests, 603–615
 sentence-skills achievement test, 616–621
- Than
 subject pronouns after, 478
 and *then*, 569
- The*, 583–584
- Then/than*, 569
- There/their*
 ESL tips, 585–586
 and *they’re*, 569
- Thesis sentences, 327
 in introduction, 330
 supporting, 342–343
 two parts of, 341–342
- thing* words, singular verbs with, 467
- Thinking
 active thinking, 11
 paragraph writing and, 10
- Third-person pronouns, 109
- Though/thought*, 573
- Threw/through*, 569
- Time* magazine, 562
- Time order, 84–86
 emphatic and time order, combination of, 97–98
 identifying time transitions, 99
 practice with, 95–96
- Times
 abbreviation rules, 511
 numerals for, 510
 transitions, identifying, 101–102
 words showing, 87–90
- Titles
 centering titles on papers, 496
 finding books by, 360
 persons, capital letters for titles of, 506
 quotation marks for, 527–528
 tips for titling papers, 497
- To*
 fragments with, 419–422
 verbs preceded by, 409
- Tolerant tone, 167–168
- Tone in paragraph, 168–169
- Topics
 for research papers, 375–377
 subject headings, using, 361–362
- Topic sentences, 8
 activities for writing, 64–65
 broad statements in, 63
 in cause-and-effect paragraphs, 213–214, 226, 227
 common errors, identifying, 62–65
 discovery and, 14
 effective sentences, 63

Topic sentences—*Cont.*

- keywords in, 65–66
- in narrative paragraph, 295
- narrow statements in, 63
- parts of sentence, understanding, 65–66
- selecting, 66–67
- specific details in, 71–73
- writing practice, 67–70

To/too/two, 570*To* words

- homonyms, 570
- as openers, 119

Transitions, 86–90. *See also*

- Emphatic order; time order
- addition, words showing, 86–90
- change-of-direction signals, 90, 91
- conclusion signals, 90, 91–92
- defined, 86
- in essays, 333–334
- identifying, 98–104
- illustration signals, 90, 91
- list of transitional words, 438
- semicolons with, 437–438
- space signals, 90

Two/to/too, 570**U**

Umbrella idea, point as, 51–53

Underlining titles, 527

Union names, capital letters for, 503

Unity, 28–29, 138

- in argument paragraph, 301–302, 308, 310
- in cause-and-effect paragraph, 210, 215, 218, 229, 236, 239
- definition and, 245, 249, 251
- in descriptive paragraph, 271
- in division and classification paragraph, 257, 263, 265
- essays, revising, 345–347
- examples and, 179, 188
- in narrative paragraph, 287, 294
- outlining for, 36
- paragraphs, evaluating, 150–153
- personal review for, 174
- in process paragraph, 194, 201

Unity—*Cont.*

- scratch outlines, evaluating, 149–150
- summary of, 148
- understanding, 138–140
- Urbina, Diane, “‘Extra Large,’ Please,” 718–725
- Usage
 - dictionaries, labels in, 553
 - editing for, 31

V

Valued possession essay assignment, 349

Variety in sentences, 115–122

- review tests, 132–136
- revising for, 29
- semicolons adding, 437

Verbs, 408, 445–453. *See also*

- Adverbs; Irregular verbs;
- Subject-verb agreement
- active verbs, revising for, 29
- and added-detail fragments, 422–424
- combined mastery tests, 597–598
- consistency with, 108–109
- diagnostic test, 401
- double verb and one subject, sentences with, 535
- editing sentences for, 122
- ESL tips, 585–589
- gerunds plus, 587–588
- identifying, 406–407
- and infinitives, 588
- nonstandard usage, 446
- object pronouns with, 479–480
- past tense endings, 448–449
- present tense endings, 447–448
- progressive tense, tips for using, 586
- review of tenses, 455
- sentence-skills achievement test, 616–617
- series, placing in, 120–122
- Verderber, Rudolph F., “Dealing with Feelings,” 711–718
- Vocabulary
 - development of, 562–564
 - in readings, 627

Vocabulary—*Cont.*

- study books, 564
- worksheets for, 563–564
- Vowels
 - dictionaries, vowel sounds in, 549–550
 - doubling final consonant and, 556–557
- Vulgar usage, 553

W*Wear/where*, 570*Weather/whether*, 570

Web sites

- citing articles from, 386
- for dictionaries, 547
- Library of Congress Web site, 367

*Webster's New World**Dictionary*, 546

Weekday names, capital letters for, 503

Well, 486–487

“What Good Families Are Doing Right” (Curran), 662–675

Where/wear, 570*Whether/weather*, 570*Whole/hole*, 567*Whose/who's*, 570

Wine, Bill, “Rudeness at the Movies,” 740–746

Wordiness

- avoiding, 113–115
- list of wordy expressions, 114
- revising for, 29
- undersupported points and, 62

Word processing programs. *See* ComputersWords. *See also* Commonly

- confused words; Effective word choice; Pretentious words; Spelling; Transitions; Vocabulary
- basic word list, 557–561
- combined mastery tests, 600–601
- concise wording, using, 113–115
- effective word choice, 575–580
- parallelism in, 106–107
- run-ons, words leading to, 431
- specific words, using, 111–113

Works Cited entries, 383–386
 chapters/sections in
 books, 385
 edited collections, selections
 in, 385
 editorials, 384
 magazine articles, 384
 newspaper articles, 384
 one author, books by, 383
 online magazines, citing articles
 in, 386

Works Cited entries—*Cont.*
 reference database, articles
 in, 386
 two entries by same author, 384
 Web site articles, 386
Worst enemy essay assignment,
 352–353
Writing
 as discovery process, 13–14
 inventory of, 33–34
 as skill, 11–13

Y

Yahoo.com, 369
Yourdictionary.com, 547
Your/you're, 570
Y to *i*, changing, 556

Z

Zip codes, commas with, 537